The M.A.K. Halliday Library Functional Linguistics Series

Chenguang Chang
Hui Yu *Editors*

Explorations in Systemic Functional Linguistics

Essays in Honor of Professor Huang Guowen

Springer

The M.A.K. Halliday Library Functional Linguistics Series

Series Editors

Chenguang Chang, Sun Yat-sen University, Guangzhou, China

Guowen Huang, Sun Yat-sen University, Guangzhou, China

This series focuses on studies concerning the theory and application of Systemic Functional Linguistics. It bears the name of Professor M.A.K. Halliday, as he is generally regarded as the founder of this school of linguistic thought. The series covers studies on language and context, functional grammar, semantic variation, discourse analysis, multimodality, register and genre analysis, educational linguistics and other areas. Systemic Functional Linguistics is a functional model of language inspired by the work of linguists such as Saussure, Hjelmslev, Whorf, and Firth. The theory was initially developed by Professor M.A.K. Halliday and his colleagues in London during the 1960s, and since 1974 it has held an international congress every year at various continents around the world. It is well-known for its application in a variety of fields, including education, translation, computational linguistics, multimodal studies, and healthcare, and scholars are always exploring new areas of application.

Chenguang Chang · Hui Yu
Editors

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Contents

1 Introduction 1
Chenguang Chang and Hui Yu

Part I SFL: The Theory

2 Verbal Play: The Coupling of Interpersonal and Experiential Meanings 17
Chenguang Chang

3 A Systemic Functional Approach to the Categorial Status of Disyllabic Localizers in Mandarin Chinese 41
Wei He

4 Transitivity, Ergativity, and Their Complementarity: The Case of Chinese 69
Yong Wang

5 Grammatical Metaphor across Disciplines: A Corpus-Based Study 101
Bingjun Yang

6 A Cardiff Grammar's Syntactico-Semantic Analysis of the Existential Enhanced Theme Construction in English 133
Renhua Deng

Part II SFL and Ecolinguistics

7 Self-Realization in Ancient Chinese Poetry: Toward an Inclination-Oriented Eco-Civilization 167
Ruihua Zhao

8 Huang's Studies on Ecological Discourse Analysis 187
Xiaochun Tan

9 The Discursive Construction of Ecological Image for Chinese Oil and Gas Corporations in Climate Change Representation: A Corpus-Based Study of Sustainability Reports 201
Lin Zhang

10 Sociality, Communicativeness, Functionality: The Consonance Between Systemic Functional Linguistics and Landsenses Ecology 221
Lan Zhang

Part III SFL: Applications

11 The Court Interpreter's Impossible Task: From a Linguist's Perspective 237
Jonathan Webster

12 A Genre-Based Approach to Academic Literacy in an EFL Context 269
Hui Yu

13 Storytelling, Cohesion and EFL Teaching 289
Fan Dai

14 Communicating Crises During the Pandemic: A Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study of CSR Reports by Top Corporations of China and the US 303
Ming Liu and Yang Yang

15 An Ideational Analysis of Different Versions of *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* 325
Zhenzhen Zhang

Part IV SFL and Translation

16 Systemic Functional Linguistics in Translation Studies: From Linguistic Shifts to Social Accountability 351
Meifang Zhang and Hanting Pan

17 Researching Translation Quality Assessment: A Systemic-Functional Linguistics Perspective 367
Xianzhu Si

18 A Systemic Functional Study of the AI-Aided English Translation of a Significant Concept in the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture 383
Manliang Li

19 Translation as Textual Titration: The Origin of Translation and a Typology of Titration Patterns 399
Guoxiang Wu

Appendix I: Students supervised by Professor Huang Guowen 417

Appendix II: List of Publications by Professor Huang Guowen 427

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List of Figures

Fig. 3.1 The occurrences of typical monosyllabic and disyllabic localizers following the common noun *qiáng* (墙 "wall") in the BCC corpus 54
Fig. 3.2 The occurrences of typical monosyllabic and disyllabic localizers following the common noun *zhuōzi* (桌子 "table") in the BCC corpus 55
Fig. 3.3 The occurrences of typical monosyllabic and disyllabic localizers following the common noun bīngxiāng (冰箱 "fridge") in the BCC corpus 55
Fig. 5.1 Congruent and metaphorical realizations (Adapted from Halliday 2004[1998b]: 83) 105
Fig. 5.2 Typology of grammatical metaphors (Halliday 2004[1998a]: 41–42) 106
Fig. 5.3 The use of GMs across LOB, FLOB, and CLOB 121
Fig. 5.4 The use of GMs across disciplines in textbooks 122
Fig. 5.5 The use of GMs across disciplines in the Baw corpus 123
Fig. 5.6 Comparing the use of GMs in textbook and FLOB 126
Fig. 5.7 Comparing the use of GMs in Baw and FLOB 127
Fig. 6.1 Four types of enhanced theme constructions (adapted from Fawcett 2003) 134
Fig. 6.2 The transitivity analysis of a locational EET construction in the Hallidayan approach 134
Fig. 6.3 Halliday's transitivity analysis of a locational EET construction with a locating clause (Halliday 1994/2000: 143; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 259; 2014: 309) 135
Fig. 6.4 Halliday's transitivity analysis of attributive, directional and possessive EET constructions 140
Fig. 6.5 Matthiessen's classification of processes (adapted from Matthiessen 1995: 223, 297) 141
Fig. 6.6 Thompson's (1996/2000: 138) thematic analysis 145

Fig. 6.7 Huang's (1997: 114; 1999: 142) thematic analysis (original in Chinese) . . . 145
Fig. 6.8 Halliday's (supposed) thematic analysis of the attributive, directional, and possessive EET constructions . . . 145
Fig. 6.9 The system network for the relational process in the Cardiff Grammar (Neale 2002: 164) . . . 146
Fig. 6.10 A comparison between SG and CG in the transitivity analysis . . . 147
Fig. 6.11 Huang's (2003: 11) syntactic-thematic analysis of a locational EET construction . . . 147
Fig. 6.12 Fawcett's (2003: 21) system network of EET (Network C) . . . 148
Fig. 6.13 Fawcett's (2003: 55) syntactic and semantic analysis of a locational EET construction . . . 148
Fig. 6.14 Huang's (1997: 112; 1999: 140) existential enhanced theme analysis (original in Chinese) . . . 149
Fig. 6.15 Huang's modified existential enhanced theme analysis (Deng 2003: 148; 2019: 115) . . . 149
Fig. 6.16 The syntactic analysis of an attributive EET construction . . . 149
Fig. 6.17 The syntactico-semantic analysis of some assessed locational EET constructions . . . 150
Fig. 6.18 The syntactico-semantic analysis of EET constructions with Attribute as EET . . . 151
Fig. 6.19 The syntactic analysis of a directional EET construction . . . 151
Fig. 6.20 The syntactic analysis of a possessive EET construction with Possessed as EET . . . 152
Fig. 6.21 The syntactic analysis of a possessive EET construction with the Process and the Affected-Carrier as EET . . . 152
Fig. 6.22 Four types of existential enhanced theme constructions . . . 152
Fig. 6.23 Network C^{+}: Deng's (2005) expanded network of EET (original in Chinese) . . . 153
Fig. 6.24 Network C^{++}A further expanded network of existential enhanced theme . . . 154
Fig. 7.1 Qualitative diversity in four aspects and their key factors . . . 173
Fig. 9.1 Trend in Chinese oil and gas companies' focus on climate change . . . 207
Fig. 11.1 Delivery speed in words per minute . . . 247
Fig. 11.2 Lexical density and grammatical complexity for the period between 10:24 and 10:30 am . . . 249
Fig. 12.1 The learning cycle . . . 274
Fig. 12.2 Five phases of a learning activity (Rose and Martin 2012: 306) . . . 276
Fig. 12.3 Lexical relations in the text . . . 279
Fig. 12.4 Learning activity as a cycle (Rose and Martin 2012: 307) . . . 282
Fig. 16.1 Bilingual public notice in use . . . 358
Fig. 17.1 Translation quality assessment model . . . 371

Fig. 17.2 Revised translation quality assessment model 374
Fig. 17.3 Translation quality assessment model 378
Fig. 17.4 Translation quality assessment model 380
Fig. 17.5 Overview of translation quality assessment model process 381
Fig. 18.1 Basic system (Eggins 2004: 194) 386
Fig. 18.2 Word system networks for the English translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* 390
Fig. 18.3 Structure system of the English translation of cǎoyuán míngzhū 392
Fig. 19.1 A 3D view of the DR equation: The OT and the eight directions 403
Fig. 19.2 Four curved surfaces and five types of Chinese-English textual titrations 409

List of Tables

Table 4.1 Transitivity analysis of (3a, b) 75
Table 4.2 Ergativity analysis of (4a, b) 75
Table 4.3 Ergativity Analysis of (9) and (10) 75
Table 4.4 Ergativity Analysis of (16a,b) 79
Table 5.1 Speech functions and responses (Halliday & Matthiessen 2014: 137) 108
Table 5.2 Some typical metaphors of mood in Halliday (1994: 365) 108
Table 5.3 Types of modality metaphors based on Halliday (1994: 358) 109
Table 5.4 The selected Baw corpus 110
Table 5.5 The textbook corpus 110
Table 5.6 The LOB family corpora and category J 111
Table 5.7 Type token ratio comparison 111
Table 5.8 Occurrences of 13 types of GM in the corpora 115
Table 5.9 Occurrences of modality metaphors in the corpora 116
Table 5.10 GM as the main variable 117
Table 5.11 Rounded correlation matrix 118
Table 5.12 Corpus as the main variable 120
Table 7.1 *Spring Morning* and its translation 174
Table 7.2 Participants, processes, and circumstances in *Spring Morning* 176
Table 7.3 *The Dale of Singing Birds* and its translation 178
Table 7.4 Participants, processes, and circumstances in *The Dale of Singing Birds* 179
Table 7.5 Type and number of agents and processes 180
Table 7.6 *Early Departure* and its translation 182
Table 9.1 The sustainability report corpus 206
Table 9.2 Verbs collocating with ‘climate change’ or ‘global warming’ 208
Table 9.3 Semantic classification of collocating verbs with ‘climate change’ in clauses 209

Table 9.4 Sample of concordances of the importance of 'climate change' issue . . . 211
Table 9.5 Sample of concordances of the response to climate change . . . 211
Table 9.6 Classification of collocating nominal groups of 'climate change' or 'global warming' . . . 212
Table 9.7 Sample of concordances of 'climate change' (or 'global warming') and energy . . . 213
Table 9.8 Sample of concordances of 'climate change' and environment . . . 214
Table 9.9 Sample of concordances of 'climate-related risk(s)' . . . 215
Table 11.1 Speaking rate by section in words per minute . . . 246
Table 11.2 Speaking rate on second day of summing-up . . . 246
Table 11.3 Speaking rate: words per hour by day . . . 246
Table 14.1 Top 100 corporations in China and the US (30 selected) . . . 308
Table 14.2 Top 20 key SMCs of the two corpora . . . 312
Table 14.3 Top 20 strong co-occurring adjectives of "Danger" (A15-) . . . 314
Table 14.4 Top 20 strong co-occurring verbs of "Danger" (A15-) . . . 316
Table 14.5 Top 20 strong co-occurring adverbs of "Danger" (A15-) . . . 317
Table 14.6 Top 20 strong co-occurring nouns of "Danger" (A15-) . . . 319
Table 15.1 Level 1 analysis . . . 337
Table 15.2 Level 2 analysis . . . 337
Table 15.3 Level 3 analysis . . . 337
Table 15.4 Analysis of SVC3 . . . 339
Table 15.5 Analysis of SVC4 . . . 340
Table 15.6 Differences in the number of material process . . . 342
Table 16.1 Selected key publications employing the Hallidayan model in translation research . . . 353
Table 16.2 Summary of Zhang Peiji et al.'s Model (1980) . . . 356
Table 16.3 A comparison of the differences between ST and TT . . . 359
Table 18.1 Systemic functional analysis of a Chinese nominal group . . . 388
Table 18.2 Systemic functional analysis of *cǎoyuán míngzhū and its English translation* . . . 394

Chapter 1
Introduction



Chenguang Chang and Hui Yu

It is with great honor and profound respect that we present this festschrift in celebration of Professor Huang Guowen's 70th birthday. This volume brings together contributions from scholars across China, reflecting the breadth and depth of Professor Huang's intellectual legacy. As one of China's most distinguished linguists, Professor Huang has not only shaped academic discourse in several linguistic fields but has also nurtured a new generation of scholars through his mentorship, leadership, and unwavering commitment to linguistic inquiry. The chapters herein reflect the breadth of his intellectual pursuits—spanning systemic functional linguistics (SFL), ecolinguistics, translation studies, and applied linguistics—while also highlighting the depth of his theoretical innovations and practical applications.

Professor Huang's academic journey is nothing short of remarkable. From his early days as a typist in Raoping County to his dual doctoral degrees from the University of Edinburgh and the University of Wales at Cardiff, his career embodies the transformative power of dedication and intellectual curiosity.

1.1 A Life of Scholarship and Leadership

Before we introduce Professor Huang Guowen's academic contributions, a brief biography is in order here. Professor Huang was born on February 25, 1956, in Qiandong Town, Raoping County, Chaozhou City, Guangdong Province, P.R. China.

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He has two brothers and two sisters: one elder sister, two younger brothers, and one younger sister, and he is married and has a son, a daughter-in-law and two grandsons.

Huang Guowen attended his primary school and junior middle school in Qiandong Town from 1962–1971. Before entering university in 1974, Huang worked as a Chinese typist at the Raoping County Committee for over three years. In September 1974, he enrolled as one of "students of worker-peasant-soldier background" in the English Department at the Guangzhou Institute of Foreign Languages (later merged with Guangzhou Institute of Foreign Trade and renamed "Guangdong University of Foreign Studies") and graduated in July 1977. Then he began working as a teacher of English at this university. He subsequently earned a Master's degree in "Linguistics and Applied Linguistics" from the Guangzhou Institute of Foreign Languages (1986). Huang's early work in English studies and discourse analysis laid the foundation for his later groundbreaking contributions to systemic functional linguistics, a field he helped establish and popularize in China.

In September 1988, he was sent by the Chinese Government to pursue a PhD in the UK, where he earned a PhD in "Applied Linguistics" from the University of Edinburgh in 1992, and another PhD in "Functional Linguistics" from the University of Wales (College of Cardiff) (now Cardiff University) in 1996.

In February 1996, he returned to China and became a professor of functional linguistics at Sun Yat-sen University, where he worked until 2016. His exceptional promotion from lecturer to full professor—bypassing the associate professorship—underscored the academic community's recognition of his extraordinary contributions. Over the next two decades, he built a strong research team, transforming Sun Yat-sen University into a hub for SFL scholarship.

In 2016, at the age of 60, Professor Huang embarked on yet another intellectual adventure by shifting his focus to ecolinguistics. His move to South China Agricultural University marked the beginning of a new phase in his career, one that would see him develop the framework of Harmonious Discourse Analysis (HDA), a model that integrates ecological ethics with linguistic analysis. His work in this area has been widely acclaimed, influencing scholars globally and fostering a deeper understanding of how language shapes our relationship with the environment. He retired from South China Agricultural University in January2024. Since then, he has been working as a professor of applied linguistics at the City University of Macau.

Since his teaching career started in 1977, Huang Guowen has taught undergraduate and postgraduate courses and supervised over 50 doctoral students and more than 100 master's students in English studies, functional linguistics, ecolinguistics, applied linguistics, and translation studies (for a full list see Appendix I).

The distinguished honors he has received include:

1. Outstanding Teacher in South China (1999),
2. Baogang Education Award (2005),
3. Special Government Allowance recipient from the State Council (2009),
4. "Changjiang Scholar" Distinguished Professor (Ministry of Education, 2012), and
5. Outstanding Social Scientist of Guangdong Province (2021).

As far as social service is concerned, Professor Huang served as Dean of the School of Foreign Languages and Dean of the School of International studies at Sun Yat-sen University for a number of years during 2000–2015, and then as Dean of the School of Foreign Languages at South China Agricultural University during 2016–2024. Over the past 30 years, he has actively participated in academic activities both domestically and internationally. He has held prominent leadership positions in scholarly associations while serving on the editorial boards of more than 20 domestic and international academic journals as either member or advisor. He was President of the China Functional Linguistics Association (2003–2015) and President of the China Discourse Analysis Association (2007–2024). From 2011 to 2014, he was Chair of the Executive Committee of the International Systemic Functional Linguistics Association (ISFLA), the only Asian scholar to hold this position in the association's 40-year history. In July 2013, he and Professor Chang Chenguang hosted the 40th International Systemic Functional Congress (as co-convenors) at Sun Yat-sen University, Guangzhou.

Huang Guowen also initiated several academic forums, including (1) the "Symposium on Functional Linguistics and Discourse Analysis", which has been held 30 times in different parts of China, and (2) the "International Conference on Ecolinguistics". The latter was first held at South China Agricultural University in 2016, followed by subsequent conferences at Beijing Foreign Studies University (2017), Guizhou Normal University (2018), the University of Southern Denmark (Syddansk Universitet, Denmark) (2019), the University of Liverpool (UK) (2021), the University of Graz (Universität Graz, Austria) (2022), and Beijing Normal University (2024). The next conference is scheduled for July 2026 at the University of Rennes (Université Rennes) in France.

1.2 Focus of Academic Research and Publications

Professor Huang's academic journey is a testament to perseverance, innovation, and the transformative power of education. In this section, we move on to introduce his academic research in some detail.

Broadly speaking, his academic career has four key turning points, and they demonstrate his research foci at different stages in his career.

1. 1988–1996: Studying at the University of Edinburgh and the University of Wales at Cardiff, where he earned two doctorates in different linguistics fields. During this period, he also worked as a Research Associate with Professor Lesley Milroy at the University of Newcastle Upon Tyne on sociolinguistics and bilingualism. In Chinese academia, few scholars hold two doctorates from Western countries.
2. 1996: After returning from the UK, he joined Sun Yat-sen University to pioneer the teaching and research of systemic functional linguistics. At the time, systemic functional linguistics was scarcely studied in southern China, but under his academic leadership, Sun Yat-sen University developed a strong research team in this field. He worked as a full professor at this university for 20 years.

3. 2016: At the age of 60, he moved from Sun Yat-sen University to South China Agricultural University, where he initiated research in ecolinguistics and ecological discourse analysis. He has since published over 40 papers in this area, co-authored *Shenme Shi Shengtai Yuyanxue* (*What Is Ecolinguistics*) (Huang & Zhao 2019), and gained international recognition for the paper entitled "Harmonious discourse analysis: approaching peoples' problems in a Chinese context" (Huang & Zhao 2021). He is currently working on two new monographs: *Shengtai Yuyanxue de Lilun yu Shijian* (*The Theory and Practice of Ecolinguistics*) (Huang et al. 2026) and *Introducing Ecolinguistics* (Huang et al. forthcoming). He also contributed to the Chinese translation of Arran Stibbe's *Ecolinguistics: Language, Ecology and the Stories We Live By* (Stibbe 2015) (Chen et al. 2019).
4. 2024: After retiring from South China Agricultural University, he was appointed Vice Dean (research), and Professor at the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences, City University of Macau, where he focuses on training PhD students in applied linguistics, systemic functional linguistics, and ecolinguistics. Recently, he published "Yingyong Yuyanxue Jiaoxue yu Yanjiu zhong de Lunli Wenti" (Ethical Issues in Teaching and Researching Applied Linguistics) (Huang 2024a) and "Xueshu Yanjiu zhong de Lunli Sikao" (Ethical Considerations in Academic Research) (Huang 2024b). These works address ethical concerns in teaching and research, a topic rarely explored in Chinese institutions of linguistics and applied linguistics.

Huang Guowen has published more than 300 academic papers and authored over 10 monographs (see complete list in Appendix II). He began publishing articles on English studies in 1979 and his research spans six areas: (1) English grammar, (2) English discourse analysis, (3) systemic functional linguistics, (4) ecolinguistics, (5) translation studies, and (6) applied linguistics.

Together with his mentor Professor Robin Fawcett, they proposed the concept of "enhanced theme", which was later included in the functional linguistics textbook published by Edward Arnold in the UK (Thompson 2004, 2014). His monograph *Fanyi Yanjiu de Yuyanxue Tansuo* (*Linguistic Explorations in Translation Studies*) (Huang 2006) was translated into English (by B. Wang and Y.Y. Ma) and published by the University of Toronto Press (Huang 2024c). Early in his career, he authored China's first book on English text analysis, *Yupian Fenxi Gaiyao* (*Essentials of Text Analysis*) (Huang 1988), and years later, he co-authored, with one of his students, Dr. ZHAO Ruihua, China's first ecolinguistics book, *Shenme Shi Shengtai Yuyanxue* (*What Is Ecolinguistics*) (Huang & Zhao 2019). Professor Huang pioneered the Harmonious Discourse Analysis (HDA) framework, which has gained significant scholarly recognition in the field of ecolinguistics both in China and abroad (see Stibbe 2021, Poole 2022; Zhao and Huang 2026). The framework's interdisciplinary nature and practical applicability have made it particularly valuable for analyzing the complex relationship between language, ecology, and sustainable development.

His academic journey and impact over the decades are detailed in "Rensheng Chuchu Jie Xuanze" (Life Is Full of Choices) (Huang 2016b) and "Ba Nian Gengyun

Yuan Xin Meng" (Eight Years of Dedication, Realizing a New Vision) (Huang 2024d).

Of his more than 300 published academic papers, most were written for Chinese readers, with over 40 in English. Those written in English have appeared in internationally renowned journals (e.g., *Language Sciences*, *Social Semiotics*, *World Englishes*, *Linguistics and the Human Sciences*, *Journal of World Languages, Pragmatics and Society*) and influential edited volumes (e.g., Berry et al. 1996; Webster & Peng 2017; Bartlett & O'Grady 2017; Tucker et al. 2020). One of his papers in English (Huang 2016a) was translated into Chinese (Huang 2018) and later into Portuguese (Huang 2021).

1.3 Thematic Contributions of this Volume

This festschrift is structured into four thematic sections, consisting of a total of 18 papers contributed by his close associates, most of whom are his former PhD students. Each section corresponds to a major pillar of Professor Huang's scholarly legacy. Below, we elaborate on these themes, underscoring their significance and the ways in which his work has reshaped linguistic inquiry.

1.3.1 Part I: SFL—The Theory

Systemic functional linguistics, as developed by M.A.K. Halliday, has found one of its most ardent and creative proponents in Professor Huang. His work has not only disseminated SFL within China but has also expanded its theoretical and methodological boundaries. Over the past 30 years, Huang Guowen dedicated himself to exploring the theory and practice of systemic functional linguistics, publishing over 60 papers and monographs, including *Enhanced Theme in English: Its Structures and Functions* (Huang 2003), *Fanyi Yanjiu de Yuyanxue Tansuo* (*Linguistic Explorations in Translation Studies*) (Huang 2006, 2024c), *Xitong Gongneng Yufa Rumen: Jiadifu Moshi* (*An Introduction to Systemic Functional Grammar: The Cardiff Model*) (Huang et al. 2008), *Shenme Shi Gongneng Yufa* (*What Is Functional Grammar*) (Huang & Xin 2014), and *Xitong Gongneng Yuyanxue Shi Jiang* (*Ten Lectures on Systemic Functional Linguistics*) (Huang & Chen 2021). With Wang Hongyang, he also translated *Systemic Functional Grammar: A First Step into the Theory* (by C.M.I.M. Matthiessen & M.A.K. Halliday) into Chinese (Huang & Wang 2009); and he co-edited two volumes in honor of M.A.K. Halliday and Robin Fawcett respectively, published in the US and the UK: *Meaning and Form: Systemic Functional Interpretations — Studies for Michael Halliday* (Berry et al. 1996) and *Approaches to Systemic Functional Grammar: Convergence and Divergence* (Tucker et al. 2020).

The chapters in this section build upon these foundations. In Chap. 2, **Chenguang CHANG** explores verbal play as dynamic interplay between interpersonal

and experiential meanings, illustrating how creativity in language emerges from the tension between formulaic structures and novel expressions. The paper analyzes how creative verbal play builds on the foundation of formulaicity but twists or combines existing language elements in novel ways. It is shown that verbal play often makes use of the experiential frames of existing patterns but adds new interpersonal and experiential dimensions which fit the new context. This coupling of experiential and interpersonal meanings in verbal play enhances communication by making it more relevant, engaging, memorable, and contextually appropriate.

Wei HE's study in Chap. 3 employs SFL to analyze the categorial status of disyllabic localizers (e.g., *shàngmian* "above", *lǐbian* "inside") in Mandarin Chinese, arguing that their classification depends on syntactic context. The paper concludes that disyllabic localizers are typically used alone as nouns, expressing the relative positions of things and performing similar syntactic functions to nouns. Even those exceptions, including *yǐnèi* (以内 "within"), *yǐwài* (以外 "outside, beyond"), *zhīshàng* (之上 "above, on top of"), *zhīxià* (之下 "under"), *zhīzhōng* (之中 "in, among, in the midst of"), *zhīnèi* (之内 "within, in") and *zhīwài* (之外 "outside, beyond"), should be viewed as place nouns when used alone. In most cases, these exceptions serve as postpositions. When following nominals directly, typical disyllabic localizers have undergone grammaticalization; in other words, they emphasize positional relationships between things over relative positions. In certain situations—specifically, when their preceding nominals can be deleted, when the insertion of *de* (的 "REL") sounds natural, and when they can be replaced by corresponding monosyllabic localizers—they should be considered both postpositions and nouns. If the insertion of *de* (的 "REL") renders the new nominal groups unacceptable, they should primarily be regarded as postpositions. The study challenges the uniform noun classification, proposing a gradient model that accounts for their dual noun-postposition status in specific contexts.

In Chap. 4, **Yong WANG**'s contribution extends the ergativity framework to Chinese, challenging traditional transitivity analyses and offering a more nuanced understanding of clause structures in Mandarin Chinese. It is shown that Chinese illustrates a language type in which ergativity is expressed all the way along the lexico-grammar continuum, in which the ergative and the transitive models may be combined such that both of their nuclei may co-occur, and they may be interwoven and in co-operation with each other in expressing experiential meaning. This is different both from split ergative languages discussed in linguistic typology, and from the complementarity between transitivity and ergativity as presented in the orthodox SFL literature with English as the major illustrating language.

Bingjun YANG's contribution in Chap. 5 is a corpus-based study that examines the disciplinary variations of grammatical metaphor (GM) across linguistics, law, medicine, and physics, using textbook corpora, the British Academic Written English (BAWE) corpus, and the LOB family corpora (LOB, FLOB, CLOB). Results reveal that nominalizations (Types 1–4) and adjectivizations (Types 6&13) are most frequent in law and medicine, reflecting a preference for abstract entities in human-centric disciplines, while physics and linguistics use fewer GMs. Modality metaphors vary significantly, with law favoring explicit subjective expressions and medicine

avoiding them, while physics minimizes both verbalizations and modality metaphors. Compared to FLOB-academic standards, student writing shows overuse of nominalizations in law and underuse in physics. The study concludes that while GM is a persistent feature of academic discourse, its usage is discipline-specific, time-constrained, and proficiency-dependent, with implications for teaching academic writing across disciplines.

In Chap. 6, **Renhua DENG** conducts the syntactico-semantic analysis of locational, attributive, directional and possessive existential enhanced theme (EET) constructions in English. In transitivity analysis, the participant role (PR) common in the four types of EET constructions is Carrier, and it is the second PR in each—Location, Attribute, Direction, or Possessed—that distinguishes one from another. Thematically, what is common in the four types of EET constructions is that there is the "thematic build-up" usually composed of "there" and "be" in the clause-initial position, followed by the existential enhanced theme enhanced by it. The elements which can be enhanced are the Process and the two basic PRs in each, one being Carrier and the other being Location, Attribute, Direction or Possessed, respectively. Among the Carriers, Simple Carrier is the element that is most frequently thematized compared to Agent-Carrier and Affected-Carrier. When Carrier is not EET, the other basic PR in the locational, attributive and possessive EET constructions(Location, Attribute or Possessed) can also be enhanced. Alternatively, the Process and its dependent roles in the locational, directional, and possessive types of EET constructions (Location, Direction and Affected-Carrier) can also be enhanced. And all these thematic options are captured in an EET system network. By reconciling the Sydney and the Cardiff approaches, this chapter underscores Professor Huang's belief that SFL must evolve through cross-linguistic and interdisciplinary dialogue—a principle that has guided his own research and mentorship.

1.3.2 Part II: SFL and Ecolinguistics

Professor Huang's pioneering work in ecolinguistics is celebrated in this section, with four papers which examines the intersection of language, ecology, and social responsibility. His Harmonious Discourse Analysis framework emphasizes the ethical dimensions of discourse, urging scholars to "think and act ecolinguistically". The chapters in this part reflect Professor Huang's conviction that linguistics must engage with real-world issues, from environmental crises to corporate accountability.

In Chap. 7, **Ruihua ZHAO**'s study explores the concept of self-realization in Tang Dynasty pastoral and nostalgic poetry through an eco-discourse analysis framework, drawing on Naess's (1989) inclination-oriented approach rather than moral obligation. Analyzing three poems—*Spring Morning* (Meng Haoran), *The Dale of Singing Birds* (Wang Wei), and *Early Departure* (Wen Tingyun)—the paper examines how bodily-mental, interpersonal, and interspecies integrations foster ecological consciousness. Using transitivity analysis, it identifies linguistic patterns that reflect diversity, complexity, and symbiosis in human-nature relationships, emphasizing

synesthesia (sensory blending) as a key mechanism for empathy and identification. Findings reveal that self-realization unfolds through ontological (T1), social (T2), and ecological (T3) unities, with poets integrating personal emotions into natural settings. Unlike critical eco-discourse studies that critique anthropocentrism, this research highlights beneficial discourse that promotes life sustainability by blurring boundaries between humans and nature. The study concludes that ancient Chinese poetry, regardless of emotional tone (joyful or melancholic), exemplifies harmonious human-nature coexistence, offering a model for contemporary ecological discourse.

Xiaochun TAN's paper in Chap. 8 examines Professor Huang Guowen's contributions to ecolinguistics, particularly his development of Harmonious Discourse Analysis (HDA), which integrates Halliday's systemic functional linguistics (SFL) and Stibbe's ecolinguistic theory with Confucian philosophy. The study analyzes DeepSeek's AI-generated summary of Huang's work, highlighting its strengths—such as recognizing HDA's interdisciplinary approach—while critiquing omissions, including Huang's human-orientedness assumption and three key principles (conscience, proximity, regulation) proposed for doing ecological discourse analysis. The paper underscores AI's limitations in accurately representing academic research, noting fabricated references and exaggerated evaluations. Ultimately, it affirms Huang's impact on ecological discourse analysis while advocating critical engagement with AI-generated content in scholarly work.

In Chap. 9, **Lin ZHANG** employs SFL and corpus-based methods to analyze Chinese oil and gas companies' sustainability reports (2012–2023), focusing on their discursive construction of climate change. Findings reveal that these companies increasingly frame climate change as both a challenge and an opportunity, emphasizing energy transition, emission reduction, and risk management. Key terms like climate change, global warming, and climate-related risks show rising frequency, reflecting corporate engagement with low-carbon policies and international climate agreements. The ecological image constructed aligns with China's environmental policies and GRI disclosure standards, portraying proactive corporate responsibility. The study highlights how linguistic patterns in sustainability reports shape perceptions of corporate environmental commitment.

Lan ZHANG's contribution in the next chapter explores the conceptual synergy between SFL and Landsenses Ecology, highlighting their shared focus on sociality, communicativeness, and functionality. SFL examines language as a social semiotic system, while Landsenses Ecology studies human-environment interaction through sensory perception and behavioral norms. Both theories emphasize symbolic meaning-making, whether through linguistic choices (SFL) or environmental design (Landsenses Ecology). The study identifies interdisciplinary convergence in their approaches to meaning construction, social interaction, and functional application, proposing linguistic landsenses as a bridge between discourse analysis and ecological design. This integration offers new insights for sustainable communication and environmental behavior studies.

1.3.3 Part III: SFL—Applications

Professor Huang's work has always emphasized the *appliability* of SFL theory. Demonstrating the practical reach of the theory, this section showcases its applications in legal, educational, and technological contexts.

Jonathan WEBSTER's contribution in Chap. 11 examines the failed court interpretation in *HKSAR v. Moala Alipate* (2019), where a Tongan defendant's drug trafficking conviction was overturned due to inadequate translation. The interpreter struggled with the judge's fast-paced, dense, and jargon-laden summary, which included complex grammar and high lexical density. The case highlights systemic flaws in court interpretation standards, emphasizing the need for qualified interpreters and judicial awareness of linguistic challenges in legal proceedings.

In the next two chapters, **Hui YU** and **Fan DAI** demonstrate how SFL-based pedagogy enhances academic literacy and creative writing, reflecting Professor Huang's lifelong dedication to teaching. **Hui YU**'s paper proposes a genre-based pedagogy model rooted in SFL to enhance academic literacy in EFL tertiary education. Drawing on the Sydney School's teaching/learning cycle—deconstruction, joint construction, and independent construction—the model systematically scaffolds students' mastery of academic genres, particularly abstracts of academic writings. By integrating explicit instruction, collaborative writing, and guided practice, students develop proficiency in generic structures, lexico-grammatical features, and communicative functions of scholarly texts. The study highlights how this structured approach enhances students' ability to analyze and produce discipline-specific writing, ultimately fostering independent academic communication. The findings advocate for broader adoption in EFL contexts to bridge gaps in literacy instruction.

In Chap. 13, **Fan DAI** explores the role of cohesive devices in EFL creative writing, arguing that effective use of cohesion reflects language proficiency and enhances narrative coherence. Analyzing works by both published authors and EFL students, it demonstrates how devices such as reference, lexical cohesion, substitution, and conjunction contribute to storytelling. The study highlights creative writing as a pedagogical tool for improving EFL learners' textual coherence and linguistic awareness, while also identifying common errors in cohesion usage. By integrating SFL with creative writing instruction, the paper advocates for craft-based approaches to EFL teaching in the process of fostering meaningful language learning.

The next chapter by **Ming LIU** and **Yang YANG** compares crisis communication strategies in CSR reports from top Chinese and US corporations during the COVID-19 pandemic, using corpus-assisted discourse analysis and SFL. Findings reveal cultural differences: Chinese firms emphasize collective, hidden dangers requiring proactive elimination, reflecting state-driven, long-term planning, while US firms focus on individual/corporate risks, adopting flexible mitigation strategies aligned with market-driven, short-term solutions. The research highlights cross-cultural CSR communication patterns and advocates integrating text mining with discourse analysis for deeper insights.

Zhenzhen Zhang's study in Chap. 15 analyzes Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* and its simplified versions using SFL to examine experiential and logical meanings. Findings reveal that simplification strategies vary—some versions retain semantic complexity while others reduce lexico-grammatical structures. The research highlights textual adaptation challenges and advocates for graded reading materials in language teaching, particularly for young learners.

1.3.4 Part IV: SFL and Translation

As a leading figure in functional translation studies, Professor Huang has argued that translation is not merely a linguistic shift but a socially accountable practice. This section begins with **Meifang ZHANG** and **Hanting PAN**'s paper which explores the application of SFL in Translation Studies, tracing its evolution from linguistic shifts to social accountability. It reviews key SFL-based translation models (e.g., Catford's shift theory, Halliday's context analysis) and examines translator attitudinal positioning using Martin & White's Appraisal Framework. Findings highlight SFL's role in broadening translation studies from textual analysis to sociocultural and ideological considerations, offering insights for translation teaching and practice. The study advocates for discourse analysis in future translation studies.

In Chap. 17, **Xianzhu SI** explores translation quality assessment models based on SFL, analyzing House's model and its limitations. The paper proposes a revised framework incorporating genre analysis and macro-level equivalence to address issues like "faithful but not smooth" translations. The study emphasizes ideational and interpersonal meaning equivalence while integrating cultural context for comprehensive evaluation. The refined model enhances operability and accuracy in assessing translation quality, balancing micro-level precision with macro-level coherence.

In Chap. 18, **Manliang LI** analyzes the AI-assisted English translation of the Chinese phrase *cǎoyuán míngzhū* ("grassland pearl") using SFL. The study compares Chinese and English nominal group structures, evaluates AI-generated translations, and selects the optimal version based on context, syntactic analysis, and lexical precision. Findings highlight the importance of functional grammar and cultural context in AI-aided translation, offering insights for localizing SFL in translation studies.

Finally, **Guoxiang WU**'s paper proposes a textual titration model for translation, analyzing Chinese-English translations through density rate (DR)—a ratio of lexical (RWC) and grammatical (RCC) parameters. It identifies the origin of translation (OT) as a reference point and categorizes translations into five titration patterns (T1-T5) based on DR fluctuations. The study illustrates typological transformations between patterns, offering a quantitative framework to assess dynamic equivalence in translation.

1.4 Conclusion: A Legacy of Integration and Innovation

Professor Huang's career defies narrow categorization. Whether pioneering SFL in China, championing ecolinguistics, or mentoring future scholars, he has consistently bridged theory and practice, East and West, tradition and innovation. His mottos—"Form is the realization of meaning", "Think and act ecolinguistically", and "Live and let live"—capture a philosophy that values both rigor and openness.

As this festschrift illustrates, his influence extends far beyond his publications. Through conferences, translations, and mentorship, he has cultivated a vigorous academic community committed to *appliable*, *ethical*, and *ecologically conscious* linguistics. On his 70th birthday and the 50th anniversary of his teaching career, we celebrate not just a scholar, but a visionary whose work continues to inspire new generations to explore language as a force for understanding, harmony, and change.

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Part I
SFL: The Theory

Chapter 2
Verbal Play: The Coupling of Interpersonal and Experiential Meanings



Chenguang Chang

Abstract This chapter explores verbal play from a systemic functional perspective, focusing on the semiotic resources involved in verbal creativity and the coupling of interpersonal and experiential meanings in these instances of language use. It will be shown that creative verbal play builds on the foundation of formulaicity but twists or combines existing language elements in novel ways. Particularly, verbal play often makes use of the experiential frames of existing patterns but adds new interpersonal and experiential dimensions which fit the new context. The coupling of experiential and interpersonal meanings in verbal play enhances communication by making it more relevant, engaging, memorable, and contextually appropriate.

Keywords Verbal play · Appraisal · Interpersonal meaning · Experiential meaning · Coupling

2.1 Introduction

Verbal play constitutes a ubiquitous phenomenon in everyday language use and has clear interpersonal functions. We forge, maintain, and deepen interpersonal relationships through playful, adaptive, and idiosyncratic use of language, which allows us to infuse our interactions with appeal, authenticity, and emotional resonance. Such personalized creativity operates as a relational glue, enabling us to signal belonging, navigate social dynamics, express attitudes, and co-construct shared identities. In this paper, I intend to explore verbal play from a systemic functional perspective, which offers a cohesive framework for exploring the semiotic resources involved in verbal creativity, and to focus on the coupling of interpersonal and experiential meanings in these creative instances of language use. I will begin by discussing some common types of verbal play, based on my own collection of examples from the media and

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everyday discourses. Then I will analyze how creative verbal play builds on the foundation of formulaicity but twists or combines existing language elements in novel ways. It will be shown that verbal play often makes use of the experiential frames of existing patterns but adds new experiential and interpersonal dimensions which fit the new context. This coupling of experiential and interpersonal meanings in verbal play enhances communication by making it more relevant, engaging, memorable, and contextually appropriate.

2.2 Verbal Play: Innovative Use of Language Resources

Previous studies on verbal play have focused on different aspects of this prevalent and complex phenomenon. Halliday (1978: 160), in his discussio+n on language in urban society, for example, points out that "language lends itself to play", and that it is associated with all kinds of verbal games and contests, from storytelling, the swapping of insults to highly elaborate forms. Crystal (1998) distinguishes between amateur and professional users and uses of playful language, and argues that language play is central to human lives, and it is rooted in a human enjoyment of language which is built on bending and breaking the rules of the language. Crystal further argues that greater attention should be paid to language play and linguistic creativity in reading books in schools to support the development of creativity in naturalistic child language development. Cook (2000) maintains that language play exists at different linguistic levels from the phonological to the discoursal and the textual, and cites examples of language play from child to adult discourse extending from children' playground rhymes and chants to tabloid puns, riddles, magical incantations, religious liturgy, verbal dueling, fiction, poetry, and songs. Cook's study is significant in its discussion of the sociocultural contexts and social and educational functions of language play, as well as its consideration of the biological aspects. Carter (2004) discusses creative language use in common everyday speech and finds that there are many motivating factors for linguistic creativity, including offering new perspectives of "seeing the content of the message", creating humor, expressing attitudes, "making the speaker's identity more manifest", entertaining others, "or simply oiling the wheels of the conversation" (Carter 2004: 148). Munat (2007) includes studies by different researchers which together provide a multi-faceted investigation of lexical creativity viewed in relation to a variety of textual and contextual constraints, in which nonce words and other new coinages are analyzed in relation to context, speaker/writer intention and the wider environment.

Idiomatic creativity is an important topic of research on verbal play. A significant contribution in this area is Fernando (1996), who considers the functions of idioms in contexts of communication and demonstrates the "bipolar nature of idiomaticity in the balance between routinized expression and linguistic creativity" (Carter 1996). Moon (1998) is a corpus-driven study of fixed expressions and idioms in English, and includes discussion of instances of creative manipulations. Chang (2004) focuses on the interpersonal meanings of English idioms, including creative manipulations, and

concludes that the use and creative manipulation of idioms and proverbs can serve as "a membershipping device", provide interest and novelty to the discourse and express personal attitudes and evaluation. Langlotz (2006) provides a detailed exploration of idiomatic creativity from a cognitive linguistic perspective, claiming that idiom variation reflects "intelligent creative behavior that exploits basic knowledge-resources and the information processing capacities of the human mind" (Langlotz 2006: 10).

In systemic functional linguistics (hereafter SFL), language is taken as social semiotic, a meaning-making resource (Halliday 1978, 1994, 2004; Halliday & Matthiessen 2014; Thompson 2014). This meaning-making potential gets expanded through actual instances of language use in real contexts. Halliday often uses the weather and climate analogy to discuss the relationship between system and instance (e.g., Halliday 2008). The influence between the two is bi-directional. On the one hand, every instance of language use is derived from this potential. The system provides the resources that constrain the choices available to the speaker or writer. On the other hand, each instance of language use is unique and variable, shaped by specific contexts and communicative purposes. Analyzing multiple instances of language use helps us understand and describe the system itself. Over time, the accumulation of instances can also lead to changes or refinements of the system. This dynamic interaction allows language to be flexible, context-sensitive, and yet systematically structured, enabling effective communication and understanding.

Verbal play encompasses a variety of techniques that exploit the resources in language and manipulate them for humor, emotional resonance, or social bonding. As Halliday (1978: 160) points out,

> Verbal play involves all elements in the linguistic system, from rhyme and rhythm to vocabulary and structure. But the essence of verbal play is playing with meaning; including… playing with the meaning that is inherent in the social structure.

Indeed, verbal creativity can be found at different ranks and strata of language, and is not limited to the lexis. For example, the playful use of rhyme and rhythm that Halliday mentions is not uncommon in newspaper headlines that serve to attract attention. Here are two examples of tabloid headlines about a policy that requires employees to be vaccinated against COVID-19 in order to keep their jobs:

(1) No Jab, No Job.

(2) Get the vacc or risk the sack.

Rhymes are commonly found in poetry, songs, nursery rhymes, and limericks. They add a musical and rhythmic quality to language and can make it more memorable and enjoyable.

Then there are other types of verbal creativity that involve different aspects of language, from neologisms, metaphoric extensions, manipulations of idioms and proverbs, to parody and mimicry, and so on.

2.2.1 Neologisms and Portmanteaus

The most basic verbal creativity is probably the invention of new words or the blending of existing ones. Recent examples include *trikini 2020* (bikini plus a facemask: a swimsuit during the COVID-19 pandemic), *Megxit* (Meghan Markle, Duchess of Sussex, and Prince Harry, Duke of Sussex, leaving the British royal family), *Henterprise* (name of a company that provides hen-renting service during the egg shortage at the beginning of Trump's second presidency), *Signalgate* (the scandal involving a group of senior national security officials in the Trump administration discussing sensitive military plans to attack the Houthis in Yemen in the chat app Signal), and "The *Gingerific* Soft Drink!" (an advertisement slogan for a ginger beer).

Sometimes such play can be very ingenious and humorous, for example:

(3) Colbert: People have gotten so desperate that since January, customs agents have stopped at least 90 people from smuggling eggs into the country. The head of the smuggling operation? Pablo *Eggscobar*!

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

The name *Eggscobar* in (3) is a portmanteau, blending "egg" with "Escobar" (the surname of the infamous Colombian drug lord). This portmanteau exploits auditory similarity, creating a playful distortion that primes the listener to connect the name to *eggs* while retaining the cadence of the original name. This fusion humorously recontextualizes Escobar's infamy into a new, ludicrous role (egg smuggler), making use of morphological creativity to refresh a familiar name. Similar examples can also be found in the following:

(4) Stewart: *Panican*? The genius who gave us classics like Sleepy Joe, and Crooked Hillary just shits out: You are a *Panican!* How about *Hysterocrats? Repussicans?* How about *Cryontologists?*

(*The Daily Show* with Jon Stewart)

Here in (4), Stewart is mocking Trump, who tweets: "Don't be Weak! Don't be Stupid! Don't be a PANICAN [a new party based on weak and stupid people]…", in response to people who criticize his tariffs policy and trade war. As can be seen, the morphological creativity in nicknames like *Panican*, *Hysterocrats*, *Repussicans*, and *Cryontologists* all rely on morphemes such as *-can, -crat, -ist*, used to form nouns, indicating a person or group. These morphemes are added on to bases such as *panic, hysteria, cry on* and so on. The host is implying that Trump's use of such nicknames is a childish and unproductive way of engaging in political discourse, rather than addressing real issues.

Another example is the nickname Elon Musk gave Peter Navarro in their recent dispute.

(5) Lightick: … Peter Navarro thinks Elon Musk is taking advantage of unfair trade policies at the risk of American prosperity. Elon, what's your response?

Video clips from MSNBC: Musk calling him a moron and dumber than a sack of bricks.

Video clips from CNBC: And there is the latest, calling him Peter *Retarrdo*.

(The *Daily Show* with Debbie Lightick)

Here, "Retarrdo" is clearly a play on the surname "Navarro", by altering Navarro's name to sound similar but with a clear negative and mocking connotation.

2.2.2 Puns and Wordplay

Verbal play frequently involves puns and wordplay, which exploit homophones, polysemy, or double entendre to create humorous ambiguity. As a common form of humor and language play, puns are often used to create a sense of surprise and amusement.

Partington (2009) examines word play in British newspaper headlines and argues that the overriding of polysemous primings in puns often forces the reader to shift between an idiomatic mode of reading (i.e., single, automatic choice) and an open choice mode of reading (i.e., manual interpretation of novel constructions). Here are recent examples from our data:

(6) Colbert: Wall Street clearly wants the President to *change his mind*, but *he doesn't have one*.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

(7) Will Smith has released his first album in 20 years, and ironically the album doesn't *slap*.

(NBC *Weekend Update* with Colin Jost and Michael Che)

In (6), the phrase "change his mind" here is twisted to imply Trump lacks a coherent mind (or policy) to begin with. Then by suggesting Trump "doesn't have one" (a mind), Colbert mocks his lack of strategic thinking or intelligence. This double entendre frames Trump's leadership as a paradox (a president who "doesn't have a mind" to change and an economy drowning in "uncertainty") and thus reduces Trumpism to its essence: a spectacle of incompetence.

The humor in (7) arises from a pun that cleverly merges slang, pop culture context, and ironic wordplay. The word *slap*, in modern slang, particularly in music and youth culture, means something is "excellent, energetic, or impactful" (e.g., "This beat slaps!"). By saying an album "doesn't slap", the host critiques it as unimpressive or unsuccessful. Literally, the word also evokes Will Smith's real-life physical slap of Chris Rock at the 2022 Oscars. As a double entendre, the word *slap* acts as a pivot point, bridging two unrelated ideas (music quality vs. physical action) to create a surprising, witty connection.

In the next example, the humor arises from a similar wordplay, which is used to mock the US Secretary of Defense, Pete Hegseth's flimsy excuse for the Signalgate scandal.

(8) Colbert: (commenting on Hegseth's excuse for mistakenly including a reporter in the sensitive group chat) The number just *got sucked in?* Well, something *sucks*, but I don't think it's the numbers.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

In (8), the host is roasting the Signal group chat leak, and is mocking Hegseth's claim that the reporter Jeffrey Goldberg's phone number was accidentally "sucked in" the sensitive messaging chain. Colbert pivots to the colloquial meaning of "sucks" (something is terrible, dishonest or incompetent), and suggests that the real issue is Hegseth's excuse itself, not the telephone number's inclusion. Colbert exploits this duality of meaning to shift the blame from the "numbers" to Hegseth's excuse.

Sometimes, the puns may involve proper names and hinge on near-homophony, as in the following examples:

(9) I don't *Truss Liz*!

(10) Too *Hastie* a judgement.

(11) While the president can name his son *Barron*, he can't make him a *baron.*

In (9), a protest slogan against former British Prime Minister Liz Truss when she was to be appointed by the Queen, the pun hinges on the near-homophony between "trust" and "Truss". While not perfect homophones, the auditory similarity in casual speech, especially in protest slogans meant to be chanted, creates a seamless substitution. The slogan morphs the phrase "I don't trust Liz" into a direct critique of Liz Truss herself by repurposing the surname "Truss" as a verb. The substitution personalizes distrust, tying it explicitly to the politician's name.

Similarly, in (10), the title of an article from an Australian newspaper criticizing Andrew Hastie, a Liberal backbencher, who caused a diplomatic rift between Australia and China by supporting a self-declared Chinese "spy", the homophony between the surname *Hastie* and the adjective "hasty" is cleverly exploited. This play on dual meaning also amplifies the bite of columnist's critique of Andrew Hastie.

Example (11) is a remark made by pro-impeachment Professor Pamela Karlan in her testimony during the House Judiciary Committee's first public hearing on the impeachment inquiry against Trump in December 2019. The pun is another sharp example of phonological play on near-homophony and semantic subversion. The joke lies in the near-identical pronunciation of *Barron* (the name of Trump's son) and *Baron* (a noble title), which contrasts Trump's power to name his child (a personal, symbolic act) with his inability to grant a noble title (a legal impossibility in the U.S., where titles of nobility are constitutionally banned). The joke frames Trump's leadership style as quasi-monarchical, contrasting it with America's foundational rejection of aristocracy. The use of antithesis ("can name" vs. "can't make") amplifies the irony, and functions as a direct rebuke of Trump's perceived authoritarian impulses.

2.2.3 Metaphors and Similes

Verbal play involving metaphors and similes frames one concept in terms of another to highlight similarities. Metaphors and similes are highly formulaic in terms of their syntactic structure, yet they offer greater creativity in terms of lexical items that can be used to fill the slots.

(12) Colbert: In the first Trump term, it took a disease to destroy the economy. This time, *he is the disease*.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

Colbert equates Trump to a "disease", a metaphor that casts him as a destructive, uncontrollable force. In Trump's first term as president, COVID-19 (the literal disease) disrupted the economy, and now in his second term, Trump himself becomes the metaphorical "disease", suggesting his policies or persona are the root cause of harm. This antithesis highlights an unexpected shift from uncontrollable misfortune to self-sabotage, framing Trump's leadership as worse than a pandemic.

(13) Lightick: 104% tariffs? OK, this is getting really serious. We'll know exactly how serious once we ask China to do the maths for us. But the point is, Trump is out of control right now. I'd say he's *like a bull in a China shop*. But at 104%, I can't afford to say that.

(The *Daily Show* with Debbie Lightick)

If we focus on the simile in (13) first, Lightick's quip frames Trump's leadership as reckless, impulsive, and destructive by likening him to a "bull in a China shop". The simile used here also involves a pun on "China shop", playing with its dual meaning (china as porcelain vs. China the country), turning a clichéd idiom into a geopolitical punchline. Trump isn't just someone who causes reckless destruction in a delicate situation; he's actively destabilizing U.S.-China relations.

Of course, the verbal play in this excerpt also creates irony and sarcasm. When the host says, "…We'll know exactly how serious once we ask China to do the maths for us", the absurdity of the situation lies on the play on the stereotype that China excels in STEM fields, often used in Western humor. By repurposing it, the host mocks U.S. reliance on Chinese manufacturing and Trump's hypocrisy in attacking a nation the U.S. economically depends on.

(14) Lightick: The tariffs aren't just tearing apart our economy, and tearing apart our trade with China. OK, this is getting really serious. They are also tearing apart Donald Trump's friends.

Video clips from MSNBC: An internal battle over Trump's tariffs between top advisor Peter Navarro and Elon Musk.

Lightick: Ooh! I'll have to pick between Elon Musk and Peter Navarro? This is *like the trolley problem*, and *the problem is that you only have one trolley*.

(The *Daily Show* with Debbie Lightick)

This segment here critiques the chaos of Trump's tariff policies and the infighting among his inner circle. Picking sides in the political conflict between Elon Musk and Peter Navarro over tariffs is likened to the "trolley problem", a classic ethical dilemma (i.e., whether to divert a runaway trolley to kill one person instead of five). Lightick feigns distress over a "choice" here, but then ironically subverts the trolley problem simile and suggests there is "only one trolley", mocking the absurdity of having to "choose" between two controversial figures, neither of whom the audience are likely to sympathize with.

2.2.4 Proverbs and Idioms

Proverbs and idioms are often manipulated to reflect personal or modern contexts. Twisting proverbs and idioms often updates traditional wisdom to resonate with contemporary context. Sometimes they are subverted simply to comment on a situation and to create humor. For example, "A watched pot never boils… but a watched inbox somehow fills up faster". The twist on the classic proverb cleverly captures the paradox of modern life in the digital age.

Here are more examples of twists on proverbs and sayings, where familiar sayings are exploited to deliver biting political or economic commentary, leveraging the audience's recognition for satirical impact.

(15) A Wikileak a day keeps tyranny at bay.

(16) An APPLE a day may, judiciously munched in Tokyo, keep the US sanctions away.

(17) If you can't defeat them, discredit them.

Both (15) and (16) play on the proverb "An apple a day keeps the doctor away". In (15), a protest sign during Julian Assange's trial, the words "apple" and "doctor" are replaced by "Wikileak" and "tyranny" respectively, referencing the organization founded by Assange, which publishes classified leaks to expose government secrecy and corruption. The sign shows support for Assange, portraying his trial as an attack on press freedom and the public's right to know, framing transparency as a safeguard against authoritarian overreach. The verbal humor in (16) relies on the rhetorical device of punning ("Apple" as fruit vs. company or electronic product), suggesting that aligning with U.S. corporate interests could shield Japan from punitive U.S. trade measures.

Example (17) highlights the irony of U.S. high-tech firms, often accused of data exploitation themselves, moralizing against foreign rivals like DeepSeek. It subverts the message of cooperation in the original proverb (*If you can't beat them, join them*) into one of sabotage. The substitution of "join" with "discredit", implying smear campaigns or hypocrisy (e.g., accusing rivals of data misuse while engaging in similar practices), critiques tactics used by dominant U.S. tech firms to undermine competitors by weaponizing public scrutiny or regulatory frameworks.

Here is another example in which a proverb is manipulated:

(18) Colbert: Some MAGA voters also don't like how Trump is letting Elon slice through the Federal government like a drunk raccoon with a samurai sword, with one of them telling the pollster: "*There's a lot of babies being tossed out with the bathwater*." Well, that's not surprising, that's how Trump raised Eric.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

The humor in this piece combines absurdist metaphor (*like a drunk raccoon with a samurai sword*), idiomatic subversion, and personal ridicule (*that's how Trump raised Eric*) to critique Trump's governance and parenting. If we focus on the subversion of the proverb, the original proverb (*Don't throw the baby out with the bathwater*) warns against discarding valuable things while eliminating waste, but the MAGA voter's complaint inverts this, accusing the Trump administration of recklessly jettisoning essential institutions (*babies*) in their zeal to dismantle bureaucracy (*bathwater*).

Similarly, idioms are also frequently manipulated. Here is an example:

(19) Kimmel: …but the story that is unfolding in Washington right now is a hard one to beat – The "Oops! who did I add to this text chain?" around the world. It's not even a complicated story. It's a simple story. There is a high level government text chain. They were using an app that the government specifically warned them not to use. They shared specific times they would be attacking another country hours before the attack, and they accidentally put a reporter on the chain to witness the whole thing. That's it. That's the plot. *The chat is out of the bag*, but what makes a Donald Trump Presidency more spasmodically volatile than other presidencies is that their first instinct when something like this happens is to bury something that embarrasses them under a steaming pile of… (turning to an aid) of what, Guillermo?

Guillermo: of bullshit.

Kimmel: of bullshit!

(*Jimmy Kimmel Live*)

The phrase "the chat is out of the bag" is a clever play on the original idiom, "the cat is out of the bag" (a secret is revealed), replacing "cat" with "chat". This substitution hinges on phonological similarity and creates a pun that ties directly to the context of a security breach involving digital communication. By adapting a well-known idiom, the host creates intertextuality—invoking shared cultural knowledge while recontextualizing it for the current event. A similar kind of idiomatic play can be found in the following:

(20) Colbert: (commenting on layoffs by DOGE in federal departments) …and that's *the tip of the cutberg*. Over at the weather service, they're expected to drop at least 300 more employees as severe storm season ramps up.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

This play on the idiomatic phrase "the tip of the iceberg" implies that the visible layoffs are just the beginning of deeper, systemic cuts by DOGE, the Department of Government Efficiency, headed by Elon Musk. The new form blends these concepts into a single term and critiques Musk's management tactics—rapid layoffs, chaotic restructuring, and prioritizing "efficiency" over stability, framing his efficiency drives as an impending disaster lurking beneath the surface.

2.2.5 Parody and Mimicry

Parody is based on a deep understanding of the original work and accurately captures its characteristics, style, narrative structure, language, and other important elements. Parody also exaggerates or distorts these elements to make them more prominent, while still retaining the recognizability of the original work. The purpose is to make people laugh through humorous, funny, or satirical means, and at the same time convey criticism or reflection on the original work, social phenomena, cultural trends, etc.

(21) Colbert: Give me liberty or charge me an extra $10,000 for a Hyundai Elantra.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

This statement is clearly a playful twist on the iconic Revolutionary War declaration "Give me liberty, or give me death!" attributed to Patrick Henry, which symbolizes an unyielding demand for freedom at any cost. By replacing "death" with "charge me an extra $10,000 for a Hyundai Elantra", the host humorously diminishes the gravity of the original sentiment, substituting a mundane and relatable consumer concern (the cost of a car) for a life-or-death struggle. The juxtaposition of a profound, historical rallying cry—the grandiose language of revolution, with a trivial, everyday issue creates absurdist contrast, and serves to mock Trump's bragging on "Liberation Day" at a time when the country is facing severe economic crisis.

Parody often plays with the audience's expectations. In fact, a key feature of parody is the subversion of expectation. For example:

(22) Stewart: Our economy is in midst of a beautiful metamorphosis, *turning from a simple caterpillar into a … dead caterpillar*.

(*Daily Show* with Jon Stewart)

The ironic effect in (22) comes from the twisting of a well-known story line to defy expectations. The phrase "beautiful metamorphosis" evokes the natural process of a caterpillar transforming into a butterfly, symbolizing growth, renewal, or progress. Here, the audience is led to think of a positive economic transformation, but instead of a "beautiful butterfly", the economy becomes a "dead caterpillar"—a jarring, absurd outcome that negates the promise of transformation. This twist mocks the failure of Trump's economic policies to deliver meaningful improvement. The juxtaposition between the poetic "metamorphosis" and the grim "dead caterpillar" amplifies the negative comment.

Manipulations of idioms often involve parody and mimicry as well. "The tip of the cutburg" in (20) is apparently based on phonetic mimicry, where the rhythm and menace of "iceberg" is retained, evoking both the original idiom and Musk's disruptive actions.

Parodies can also work with longer stretches of text. The following example, taken from Martin & Rose (2008: 248), parodies the idea of a recipe, which is a common and familiar form, to critique the historical act of claiming land as terra nullius.

(23) **Terra Nullius Pie**

> INGREDIENTS…
>
> 1 * "Empty" continent (a wide brown one will do nicely)
>
> 10 * Point Plan, OR
>
> 100 Litres "Sorry Tears"
>
> Some live Cultures
>
> Plenty of re-written history to garnish
>
> METHOD
>
> Take the land and thoroughly clean of any people. Remove as much of the forest and minerals as you can. Next liberally pour wastes into waterways until nicely blue-green. At this point you'll be tempted to carve the pie up into 10 big slices, but this may cause heartburn or even armed insurrection later!
>
> ALTERNATIVELY, sprinkle well with sorry tears and leave to reconcile for a while. When cool, share it out—if no one is too greedy there'll be plenty to go round…
>
> (cited in Martin & Rose 2008: 248)

By presenting the process of colonizing a land as if it were a cooking recipe, it subverts the normal expectations of what a recipe should be about, and instead this form is used to make a serious point about the historical injustices. Martin & Rose (2008: 248) cite this as an example of "contextual metaphor", which may be regarded as a type of priming of genre expectations, if we can stretch Hoey's (2005) lexical priming theory a bit further. In this case, counterexpectancy creates the satire.

2.3 Verbal Play: Interpersonal Meanings

The above categorization of different forms of verbal play is by no means exhaustive (we might also include other types, for example, hyperbole and understatement), and the categories obviously overlap sometimes. More often than not, an instance of verbal play may involve several rhetorical devices, as exemplified in the previous section. Whatever forms deployed, verbal play essentially plays with meaning (Halliday 1978: 160).

SFL, as a theory of "text-in-context", takes a multifunctional approach to the study of meaning (Halliday 1978, 1994, 2004; Halliday & Matthiessen 2014). One of the most important aspects of meaning at stake here is interpersonal meaning. Halliday & Matthiessen (2014: 30) explain the interpersonal metafunction as follows:

> While construing, language is always also enacting: enacting our personal and social relationships with the other people around us. The clause of the grammar is not only a figure …; it is also a proposition, or a proposal, whereby we inform or question, give an order or make an offer, and express our appraisal of and attitude towards whoever we are addressing and what we are talking about. This kind of meaning is more active: if the ideational function of the grammar is "language as reflection", this is "language as action". We call it the interpersonal metafunction, to suggest that it is both interactive and personal.

We can explore interpersonal meaning across all strata of language, but reference to appraisal means we are approaching evaluation from the stratum of discourse semantics (Martin & White 2005). Whereas the system of NEGOTIATION models the *inter-* of *interpersonal* meaning, APPRAISAL models the *-personal* in *interpersonal*. In this section, I will focus particularly on how different forms of verbal play express evaluation based on the Appraisal framework developed by Martin and his colleagues (Martin 2000; Martin & White 2005; Hood 2019).

Due to lack of space, I will be assuming knowledge of the Appraisal framework for the most part. But very broadly, the system of appraisal consists of three sub-systems: ATTITUDE, GRADUATION and ENGAGEMENT. ATTITUDE models the general categories of values that can be expressed: AFFECT (the emotional dimension), JUDGMENT (the ethical dimension) and APPRECIATION (the aesthetic dimension). Attitudinal meanings can be either positive or negative, and they can be expressed either explicitly as *inscribed* ATTITUDE or implicitly as *invoked* ATTITUDE (Martin & White 2005). The sub-system of GRADUATION concerns the potential available in language for "meaning by degree" (Martin 1992), which can be adjusted along dimensions of FORCE (grading according to intensity or amount) or FOCUS (grading according to prototypicality). The sub-system of ENGAGEMENT maps options for negotiating intersubjective stance, distinguishing between monoglossia (single-voiced) and heteroglossia (multi-voiced). Speakers/writers can choose to expand or contract space for alternative voices in text.

2.3.1 Heightening the Force of Evaluation

Verbal play often brings with it an additional layer of evaluative meaning. To begin with, many neologisms and portmanteaus created through verbal play are evaluative. For example, the word *gingerific* in the advertisement "The Gingerific Soft Drink!" does not merely state that it is a ginger beer, the suffix *-ific* indicates that it is a terrific soft drink people should try. Similarly, the morpheme *-gate* in *Signalgate* has now come to indicate some kind of scandal (with its origin in *Watergate*). In Example (4), morphemes such as *-can, -crat*, and *-ist* added on bases such as *panic*, *hysteria*, *cry on* and so on, also create nouns with negative meanings.

A more recent example is *Ukrainesplain*, a term coined by the U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio to criticize Zelensky, the president of Ukraine.

(24) Rubio: He (Zelensky) found every opportunity to Ukrainesplain on every issue, then he confronted the Vice President.

(ABC *This week*)

The term *Ukrainesplain* is a parody of the internet buzzwords such as *mansplain* (a portmanteau of *man* and *explain*, referring to men condescendingly lecturing women) and *whitesplain* (a white person explaining something to people of color, often in a condescending or patronizing manner, especially when it comes to issues related to

race, social justice, or minority culture). Because of this connection, *Ukrainesplain* has taken on a negative meaning. Similarly, in the following example,

(25) Lightick: I'm ready to Foxsplain this insignificant oopsie-daisy that will never happen again.

(*The Daily Show* with Debbie Lightick)

The word *Foxsplain* in (25) is formed through the same mechanism, meaning to explain away, dismiss, or spin a controversial issue in a manner characteristic of Fox News' perceived tactics—downplaying scandals such as Signalgate, deflecting blame, or reframing narratives to align with partisan agendas. In this context, the diminutive "oopsie-daisy" (a playful term for a minor mistake) contrasts sharply with the severity of a national security breach, which is the topic under discussion, highlighting the absurdity of downplaying such an event. Here, the host frames Fox News' narrative strategies on Signalgate as similarly patronizing or manipulative, employing infantilizing language to trivialize wrongdoing.

These examples containing "*-splain*" show how parody or analogy can be used to produce new words/compound terms (see also Veale 2007). Such a mechanism can become so persuasive that even fallacious conclusions that can be drawn may seem even very natural (Trask 1996). Intertextually, the morpheme "*-splain*" in the examples above evokes a broader lexicon of critique. In (25), the term *Foxsplain,* for example, aligns Fox News' rhetoric with other forms of patronizing or oppressive discourse. The word condenses complex critiques of media bias into a single, instantly recognizable concept, bypassing the need for lengthy explanation.

Beyond word formation, verbal play allows speakers to encode their attitudes creatively, often blending personal flair with shared linguistic conventions. In (9) and (10), punning on surnames, such as *Truss* and *Hastie,* can express clear negative judgment. Then the use of metaphors and similes, which frames one concept in terms of another, often implicitly invokes an attitudinal stance. In (18), Elon Musk is likened to "a drunk raccoon with a samurai sword", invoking a negative judgment of Musk's behavior as reckless, uncoordinated and disruptive.

In cases of idiom or proverb manipulation, the value of intensification is often fused with an experiential element, as in the following examples, where the intensification is entailed by an experiential value.

(26) The paper's editorial described the section as "a nasty piece of work" which gave the police "a considerable measure of arbitrary and unchallengeable judgment". Using it against the hippies was like relying on "*an earthmover to crack a nut*".

(OHPC data, cited in Moon 1998: 170)

The phrase "an earthmover to crack a nut" in (26) is a playful variation of the idiom "using a sledgehammer to crack a nut", which conveys the idea of using excessive force or resources to accomplish a simple task. In this context, the editorial criticizes the police's approach as overly heavy-handed and disproportionate. By substituting "earthmover" for "sledgehammer", the author amplifies the absurdity of the situation, suggesting that the tools or methods employed are not just excessive but comically so. This exaggeration underscores the editorial's negative judgment of the police's

actions as both unnecessary and unjustified, particularly when applied to a group like the hippies, a relatively minor or non-threatening target.

The exaggeration of the images or vehicles in the original idioms and proverbs is a common feature in verbal play, often generating a heightened authorial force. In (18), "There's a lot of babies being tossed out with the bathwater" modifies the proverb (Don't throw the baby out with the bathwater), where the grading of FORCE is adjusted along the dimension of quantification: amount (*a lot of babies*). Here is a similar example:

(27) He works 18 hours a day. He rings people up at 4am his time. He burns the candle at five ends. He might look like this huge heavyweight boxer but his family and friends have worried about his health for years.

(OHPC data, cited in Moon 1998: 170)

Here the play with the idiom *burn the candle at five ends* involves exaggeration of the image in the original *burning the candle at both ends*, and also belongs to the same dimension of quantification: amount.

The infused values can also involve interpersonal intensification in manipulated idioms. For example, a common form of manipulation is the modification of idioms by the insertion of adjectives as well as other intensifiers or evaluatives.

(28) Titmuss is contemptuous, hooded-eyed, vindictive; he staggers visibly under the weight of *a **giant** chip on the shoulder*.

(*The Times*, 4 September 1991)

(29) Economic reform, political stability and close ties with Washington are *the **biggest** feathers in Mr. Menem's cap.*

(*Financial Times*, 13 November 1991)

In these examples, the two modifiers *giant* and *biggest* are added to the manipulated idioms (*have a chip on one's shoulder, a feather in one's cap*) respectively and can serve to entail evaluations of double intensity.

The evaluative force can also be enhanced through the use of irony and sarcasm. For example:

(30) Lightick: It's been one week since Donald Trump announced his bold vision for destroying the economy. And guess what? His plan is working…

(*The Daily Show* with Debbie Lightick)

(31) Colbert: … So it's no secret how I feel about this Trump reboot. I was not looking forward to it. I knew he'd take the opportunity of his second presidency to do every terrible thing I could imagine, but I just never imagined he'd do all of them at once.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

The use of "bold vision" in (30) is clearly sarcastic, considering the juxtaposition with "destroying the economy". It is a way to ironically describe Trump's economic plans as if they were ambitious and forward-looking, when in fact, the speaker believes they are having negative consequences ("destroying the economy"). The phrase "his plan is working" is also ironic, suggesting that the supposed negative effects on the economy that the speaker anticipates are coming to fruition. In (31), by hyperbolizing Trump's actions as an exhaustive checklist of "terrible things", Colbert satirizes the chaos and norm-breaking of Trump's presidency. This negative judgment is further intensified in "he'd do all of them at once". Then the word "reboot" sarcastically sneers at Trump's repetitive, destructive tactics. The irony and sarcasm in these examples work together to realize negative appraisal prosodically.

Martin & White (2005: 19-23) interpret the ways in which appraisal operates as an ongoing cumulative motif. They quote Halliday's comments on the prosodic nature of interpersonal structure and point out that this is of particular relevance to appraisal analysis. According to Halliday (1979: 66–7), interpersonal meanings tend to be "strung throughout the clause as a continuous motif or colouring" and "the effect is cumulative". We can see the prosodic nature of realization of appraisal meaning in many instances of verbal play as they combine different forms and devices. Example (18), reproduced below, can be seen as another example of such prosodic realization of appraisal meaning.

> Colbert: Some MAGA voters also don't like how Trump is letting Elon slice through the Federal government like a drunk raccoon with a samurai sword, with one of them telling the pollster: "There's a lot of babies being tossed out with the bathwater." Well, that's not surprising, that's how Trump raised Eric.

The verbal play here combines absurdist metaphor (*like a drunk raccoon with a samurai sword*), hyperbolic idiomatic subversion (*a lot of babies being tossed out with the bathwater*) and personal ridicule (*that's how Trump raised Eric*), which work together to build an ongoing cumulative motif of negative judgment of the Trump administration and its wanton destruction and imprudent reform. Such prosodic realization of appraisal meaning clearly serves to enhance the evaluative impact.

2.3.2 Building Rapport and Strengthening Social Bonds

Apart from construing new experiences and expressing appraisal in innovative ways, verbal play can be used to build rapport and strengthen social bonds. Innovative uses of language often blend formulaic structures (shared linguistic conventions) with personal creativity, enabling speakers to convey individualistic meaning while signaling group cohesion and affiliation. Neologisms like *Eggscobar*, *Henterprise*, and *Foxsplain* are able to trigger laughter because they signal shared experiences or subcultural identity. To take the portmanteau *Eggscobar* as an example, the name relies on shared cultural knowledge of Pablo Escobar as a notorious figure. By invoking this reference, the host creates an instant, recognizable framework, and

then subverts it with the egg-themed twist. The humor depends on the audience's ability to recognize both the original name and the absurdity of its adaptation. Similarly, the blend *Foxsplain* also relies on the audience's familiarity with Fox News' ideological leanings and controversies, making the negative critique accessible and shareable.

Puns and wordplay invite shared laughter and intellectual collaboration, as listeners "solve" the wordplay. They signal wit and creativity, fostering camaraderie or membership. For example, the joke in (7) involving the punning of the word "slap" relies on the audience's familiarity with the 2022 Oscars incident. The setup ("first album in 20 years") primes the audience to anticipate praise or positive appreciation, making the critique ("doesn't slap") both unexpected and funny due to its dual meaning and creating a punchline that feels timely and biting. For the participants in the interaction, this shared decoding process reinforces in-group solidarity.

Similarly, play on audience anticipation is also at work in verbal play that involves parody and mimicry. In (22), for instance, the joke relies on the audience familiarity with both the butterfly metaphor and the current economic reality in the U.S. The host builds anticipation with the lofty metaphor of *a beautiful metamorphosis*, only to ironically deflate it with a punchline that is both bathetic and bleak, an anticlimax that is counter-expectant. The dark humor offers comic relief through absurdity, channeling audience frustration into laughter. Likewise, in (14), the joke taps into knowledge of the trolley problem. It makes the critique accessible to audiences familiar with its ethical quandaries, reinforcing in-group solidarity.

We may also discuss this from an intertextuality perspective. Intertextuality—the concept that all texts (or utterances) are interconnected, referencing and reshaping prior cultural, linguistic, and social discourses—provides a rich framework for understanding verbal play. From this perspective, language is inherently relational, built on a web of preexisting meanings. According to Bakhtin's concept of "dialogism" (Bakhtin 1981), meaning emerges through the interaction between the speaker, listener, and the cultural "voices" embedded in language. Verbal play thrives on this interconnectedness, repurposing familiar texts, tropes, cultural codes and so on to create humor, irony, or social resonance. For audiences who lack familiarity with these "voices", the verbal play will fall flat or may even alienate.

As far as idioms and proverbs are concerned, the intertextuality factor is quite obvious, as these expressions often represent institutionalized sociocultural values. As Chang (2004) points out, in using an idiom or proverb, a speaker is often invoking an ideology, locating a concept within it, and appealing to it as authority, thus making the evaluation more forceful and harder to challenge. Accordingly, the use of proverbs and metaphorical idioms can be seen as part of a discourse of familiarity, enforcing an acknowledgment of common ground between the discourse participants by appealing to shared sociocultural schemas and evaluation. By capitalizing on the receiver's knowledge of idioms and proverbs, the manipulated forms serve to amplify the evaluative force. The subversion of idioms and proverbs is not a counter argument against the institutionalized nature of such expressions. It can be argued that verbal play involving idioms and proverbs can function at all only because the audience have knowledge of the canonical forms in the first place. When language is used

in such a way as to position the audience as "in the know" or as part of the same community, it creates a sense of shared understanding and belonging.

When proverbs, idioms, and other routine expressions are creatively modified, as they are often done in the talk show programs in our data, the hosts assume that their audience are familiar with the original forms and can appreciate the clever alteration. This shared appreciation of the verbal play helps to build rapport because it creates a positive interaction based on a common cultural knowledge. It can make the audience feel included and engaged, which in turn strengthens social bonds. With this feeling of a connection with the host, the audience find they are part of the group that "gets it", and they are able to laugh it off together. Such "inside jokes" act as relational shorthand, instantly invoking shared history and strengthening group cohesion. This aligns with Bell & Skalicky's (2019) study which demonstrates that both the construction and appreciation of much humor relies on knowledge of formulaic conventions and cultural norms.

In a sense, it can be argued that such humorous verbal creativity serves as a coded language within relationships, distinguishing insiders from outsiders. Humor and linguistic play evolve as social bonding mechanisms, and they remain central to human interaction. Knight's study of affiliation (Knight, 2010a, 2010b) is highly relevant here. For Knight, affiliation is seen as the formation and management of communities of shared values. It is concerned with how semiotic resources are deployed to commune (Martin 2011). Drawing on the concept of "coupling" (Martin 2000), Knight (2010b) shows how recurring instances of the kinds of [ATTITUDE + IDEATION] couplings constitute the basis for negotiating solidarity and community. To the extent that couplings are shared between participants, they constitute "bonds" of affiliation, and complexes of shared bonds form bond networks. Knight develops this idea in the context of conversational humor, which she argues is characterized by the tendency of participants to "laugh off" couplings that cause "wrinkles" in their network of values.

Inspired by the concept of affiliation, Zappavigna (2011) explores how language is used to build community with the microblogging service, Twitter. Based on a corpus of 45,000 tweets collected in the 24 hours after the announcement of Barak Obama's victory in the 2008 US presidential elections, she tried to show how tweets function to invite a digital audience of "followers" to share in evaluative bonds. Zappavigna's study shows that Twitter offers a medium for expressing personal evaluation to a large body of listeners with which one can affiliate ambiently, and argues that by presenting couplings of evaluative and ideational meanings, a tweet invites the follower or searcher to share in the values presented.

Another study by Logi & Zappavigna (2019) provides a social semiotic analysis of a stand-up comedy text. Their study treats laughter as a marker for the deferral of social values that create non-threatening tension with interactants' shared community affiliation. Dialogic resources such as projected speech are shown to play an important role in positioning the comedian's alignment to social values, and function to amplify the tension created.

As Knight (2010a: 184) observes, "ENGAGEMENT resources are used in humorous phases to afford attitudes that couple and to enhance the humorous play". As we have

tried to show in this study, instances of verbal play seem to indicate that by appealing to "cultural voices", institutionalized sociocultural values and the discourse of familiarity, common ground can be established between the discourse participants. As we illustrated earlier, twists and manipulations in the talk show examples often distort these voices, creating dark humor, but the dark humor offers comic relief through absurdity, which channels audience frustration into laughter. Thus by deviating from formulaic norms, individuals signal trust and familiarity, as such deviation assumes the listener's ability to decode personalized meaning. In this sense, such verbal play also acts as a barometer of bonding. Communication is not just about exchanging information, but also about creating worlds of shared values, building rapport, and strengthening bonds.

2.4 Formulaicity and Creativity: A Reflection

In this concluding section, I will reflect on how verbal play thrives on the tension between formulaicity (communal norms) and creativity (personal innovation). Formulaicity and creativity are clearly two interconnected aspects of language use. Formulaicity serves as the foundation for efficient and socially appropriate communication. By bending formulaic language (e.g., idioms, clichés, conversational routines) through creativity, speakers navigate complex social relationships with agility.

Previous studies have underscored the pivotal role of prefabricated linguistic units in both first-language (L1) and second-language (L2) production and comprehension. For instance, Hymes (1962) observes that a substantial portion of verbal behavior is composed of established linguistic routines. Bolinger (1976) further posits that speakers do at least as much remembering as they do putting together. The formulaic nature of language use has also been studied by Fillmore (1976), Pawley & Syder (1983) and Cowie (1998), who argue all languages have particular ways of putting words together.

Corpus research further testifies to the prevalence and importance of formulaic expressions in language use. Sinclair's (1991) idiom principle argues that the use of prefabricated chunks may illustrate a natural tendency to economy of effort. Formulaic expressions ease the processing overload not only because they are ready-made but also because their salient meanings are easily accessible in online production and processing. Wray's (2002) work on formulaic language also highlights its role in reducing cognitive load and enabling fluent communication. Kecskes (2007, 2013, 2019) maintains that preferred ways of saying things and preferred ways of organizing thoughts in a language are best reflected in the use of formulaic language.

Pragmatics research on formulaic language has primarily considered the social function of formulaic language, maintaining that use of specific formulaic sequences mark speakers' membership within specific communities (Bardovi-Harlig 2019).

Creativity in language, on the other hand, involves breaking free from traditional patterns to express unique ideas or perspectives. In fact, corpus researchers from the Sinclairian perspective have shown that creative language, such as humor and

irony, is the result of deviations from typified language patterns. In a series of corpus studies, Partington (2007, 2009, 2011a, 2011b) demonstrates how both irony and humorous word play subvert formulaic patterns at the levels of collocation, colligation, and semantic association. Partington (2007) describes irony as a "reversal of evaluation", which exploits readers' expectations for the evaluation of entities through the purposeful contrasting of unexpected collocations.

Hoey's (2005) theory of Lexical Priming argues that language patterns, such as collocations, colligation, and semantic associations are psychologically reinforced in the mental lexicon as language users are exposed to language input. Hoey refers to these mental associations as primings, arguing that lexical items are primed to occur with certain other lexical items, in certain grammatical roles, and in certain semantic and pragmatic categories. Hoey maintains that humor, ambiguity, and other types of linguistic creativity are the result of subversions or conflicts among primings associated with different senses of polysemous words.

Goatly (2012, 2017) explores jokes and other examples of humor from the perspective of Lexical Priming. His work reveals that key phrases in his examples exploit primings at the levels of collocation, colligation, or semantic preference when compared to usage in generalized corpora. Goatly also identifies an additional type of priming found in an example of humorous news satire: primings of genre or register expectations.

All these studies show that creativity is not a departure from formulaicity but an extension of it, as speakers manipulate entrenched forms to meet expressive needs. From an SFL perspective, we argue that verbal play emerges as the coupling of the interpersonal and experiential (Martin 2008a, 2008b, 2010). Verbal creativity thrives on blending these dimensions, allowing speakers to convey information while simultaneously signaling individuality, fostering connection, expressing attitudes, or subverting expectations. This interplay transforms mundane exchanges into dynamic social acts.

As we illustrated in the previous sections, creative verbal play builds on the experiential base but twists or combines existing language elements in novel ways. Whether in neologisms (e.g., *Ukrainesplain, Foxsplain, Eggscobar*), punning on proper names (e.g., I don't *Truss* Liz, Too *Hastie* a judgment), the twisting of idioms and proverbs (e.g., *the chat is out of the bag, burn the candle at five ends*), or the use of parody (e.g., *Give me liberty or charge me an extra $10,000 for a Hyundai Elantra*), we see a clear coupling of experiential and interpersonal meanings in verbal play, where evaluative meaning is enhanced by making it more engaging, individualistic, and contextually more relevant.

Indeed, creativity depends on formulaic foundations. Many jokes, for instance, often riff on universally recognized templates (e.g., twisting an idiom, proverb, or pop culture reference). Then such creative verbal play often triggers further verbal play. Here is an example:

(32) Colbert: Of course before the full transcript was released, Hegseth had denied that any sensitive attack plans were shared, He said this: "Nobody was texting war plans, and that's all I have to say about that." Oh "that's all I have to say about that." Why does that sound familiar?

(Clip from the movie *Forrest Gump*) Gump: "And that's all I have to say about that."

Colbert: Oh man, he went full Gump. Except for Hegseth, life is more like a box of wine.

(CBS *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert)

The humor in this excerpt relies on using lines from the iconic film *Forrest Gump* to mock Pete Hegseth's evasive denial. The line "And that's all I have to say about that" embodies Forrest's simplistic, earnest, and avoidant communication style. By echoing this line verbatim, Hegseth unwittingly mirrors Forrest's childlike refusal to engage with nuance. The comparison frames Hegseth's denial as similarly simplistic, dismissive, and intellectually shallow. The phrase "going full Gump" implies adopting Forrest's naiveté to an absurd degree. Then the twisted metaphor "Life is more like a box of wine" subverts the original line from Forrest's mother ("Life is like a box of chocolates – you never know what you're gonna get"), and subtly mocks Hegseth's worldview as reckless or morally blurry. By adapting well-known lines from an iconic movie, the host creates intertextuality—invoking shared cultural knowledge while recontextualizing it for current events.

Such intertextual mechanics also help explain the creative play on many idioms, where the image in the original becomes an experiential template for infinite recontextualizations. Take the idiom *fiddle while Rome burns* as an example. The experiential reference in the original of the Roman emperor Nero playing a musical instrument in his palace and watching Rome burning later becomes a metaphor implying "a lack of awareness or responsibility in the face of a major crisis". I would suggest re-appropriating the concept of "iconization" to describe this metaphorical process, where the meaning is experientially discharged and interpersonally charged. Once the idiomatic meaning of the expression is developed through "iconization", it can be recontextualized in examples like "*Fiddle while the world burns"* or "*The President is accused of fiddling while US industry burns*", where part of the original image is de-metaphorized, to make it experientially recharged to fit the context. In "*Fiddle while the world burns"*, the title of an article from *The Amicus Journal*, the word "burns" extends the experiential meaning in the original and refers to global warming, the topic of the article. Similarly, in the second example, "*while US industry burns*" literally refers to the burning of fossil fuel. However, in both cases, the iconization is still in effect as the evaluative meaning of the idiom is retained, though experientially the meaning is recharged to fit different contexts.

The experiential template of the idiom is further stretched in "*Netflix while the deadline looms*", where "fiddle" is replaced by "Netflix", representing the act of watching streaming content, and "Rome burns" is transformed into "the deadline looms", depicting how students often procrastinate on their assignments by indulging in entertainment while deadlines become more and more pressing. Such creative play may become formulaic over time within a specific context (at least among small groups or communities), demonstrating complex coupling and re-coupling of the experiential and interpersonal. The same processes of coupling and re-coupling are at work in the proverb manipulation in (15), *A Wikileak a day keeps tyranny at bay.*

To conclude, the two forces of creativity and formulaicity exist in a symbiotic relationship, each enabling and constraining the other. Formulaic expressions serve as

the building blocks of language, offering speakers a shared repertoire of predictable frames, while creativity drives linguistic adaptation. Thus, formulaicity does not stifle creativity but anchors it in communal understanding. The dynamic interaction between the two forces ensures that language remains both stable and vibrant. From an SFL perspective, it can be argued that creative verbal play often makes use of the experiential frame of existing patterns but adds new experiential and interpersonal dimensions which fit the new context. The coupling and re-coupling of experiential and interpersonal meanings in verbal play enriches the resources that can be deployed in communication.

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Chapter 3
A Systemic Functional Approach to the Categorial Status of Disyllabic Localizers in Mandarin Chinese



Wei He

3.1 Introduction

This study examines the categorial status of disyllabic "localizers" (*fāngwèicí*, 方位词) in Mandarin Chinese by exploring their semantic and syntactic functions within the framework of Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL). Disyllabic localizers refer to those that take on disyllabic forms, formed by adding an affix to their monosyllabic counterparts.[1] The involved affixes include suffixes like *miàn* (面 "surface"), *biān* (边 "edge"), and *tóu* (头 "head, end"), or prefixes like *yǐ* (以 "to") and *zhī* (之 "of, between") (e.g., Huang & Liao 1991; Peyraube 2003; Liu 2003 and cf. Cheung 2016; also Nie & Liu 2021).[2] Although there is no consensus yet about the categorial status

[1] Monosyllabic localizers include sixteen items, including *shàng* (上 "up, on, in, above, top"), *xià* (下 "down, under, below, bottom"), *qián* (前 "front, before, ahead"), *hòu* (后 "back, behind, after"), *lǐ* (里 "in, inside"), *wài* (外 "out, outside"), *zuǒ* (左 "left"), *yòu* (右 "right"), *dōng* (东 "east"), *xī* (西 "west"), *nán* (南 "south"), *běi* (北 "north"), *zhōng* (中 "middle, in"), *jiān* (间 "between, in"), *páng* (旁 "side"), and *nèi* (内 "within, in").

[2] For all localizers, this study provides English glosses. Notably, some localizers may have a few glosses out of context. In such situations, this study presents all the glosses, while in specific contexts, it presents a particular gloss. For those with more than one gloss, the primary gloss appears first in the brackets. Regarding which gloss is primary, this article consulted *Modern Chinese dictionary* (seventh edition) (2016) and Xu (2008).

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of monosyllabic localizers in Mandarin Chinese,[3] there is a relatively consistent view regarding disyllabic localizers. It is generally accepted that most disyllabic localizers used alone or following nominals[4] function as place words (a subtype of nouns), while a few exceptions—those formed by adding *yǐ* (以 "at, on") and *zhī* (之 "of, between") to the monosyllable, act as postpositions (e.g., Liu et al. 2001; Liu 2003; Kuo 2022). This viewpoint finds support in Zhang (2010), where the exceptions, comprising *yǐ* (以 "at, on") and *zhī* (之 "of, between"), do not group with those including *miàn* (面 "face"), *biān* (边 "side") or *tóu* (头 "head"). The ordinary disyllabic localizers are referred to as place words, while the exceptions are considered disyllabic localizers. In this context, it should be noted that although the research of a few scholars makes this viewpoint somewhat controversial, they are fundamentally still consistent with it. According to Huang et al. (2009), Liu & Oakden (2014), Li (2019), and Nie & Liu (2021), despite the varied functions disyllabic localizers have in different contexts, they are essentially nominal. Based on the research of Djamouri, Paul & Whitman (2013), some disyllabic localizers are postpositions, including those *yǐ*-localizers (*yǐhòu* [以后 "after"—temporal], *yǐnèi* [以内 "inside, within], *yǐqián* [以前 "before, ago"], *yǐshàng* [以上 "above, over"], *yǐwài* [以外 "outside, beyond"] and *yǐxià* [以下 "under, below"]), *zhī*-localizers (*zhījiān* [之间 "between"]) and parallel localizers (*qiánhòu* [前后 "around"], *zuǒyòu* [左右 "around, about"], *shàngxià* [上下 "around, about"]); however, among these disyllabic localizers, the parallel localizers notably exhibit properties of nouns (Kuo 2022). Generally, it is agreed that most disyllabic localizers function as nouns, while a few exceptions have been transitioning from content words to functional ones or have already become postpositions.

[3] There are six perspectives on the categorial status of post-nominal monosyllabic localizers in the literature. These include locative particles (Li & Thompson 1981; Hsiung 2023); nouns (Li 1985, 1990; McCawley 1992; Huang et al. 2009; Huang 2010; Zhang 2010; Kuo 2022), or a subclass of nominals (Chu 2006; Chappell & Peyraube 2008, 2013; Li 2009); clitics, defined as phrasal affixes (Liu 1998; Sun 2008; Wu et al. 2018); spatial enclitics or particles (Sun 2008); postpositions (Tai 1973; Ernst 1988; Djamouri et al. 2013; Takahashi 2020); and postpositions in circumpositions (Liu 2003, 2008). A detailed review is available in He (2025).

[4] In the literature, scholars typically use "nouns" or "nominals" instead of "nominal groups" to refer to the category of linguistic units occurring before localizers. For convenience, this study primarily follows the convention of using "nouns" and "nominals" in academia. However, it is important to note that when addressing such phenomena within the framework of Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), this study refers to "nominal groups" instead of "nouns" or "nominals," even if only the head element is present in the unit. This is because the nominal group in SFL encompasses all linguistic phenomena that denote things, regardless of how many elements are involved.

The prevailing view regarding the categorial status of disyllabic localizers stems from a lack of understanding and random observations of their semantic and syntactic functions. When discussing post-nominal monosyllabic localizers, He (2025) notes that in certain contexts, these monosyllabic localizers can be substituted with disyllabic ones. Given that post-nominal monosyllabic localizers are classified as postpositions, the disyllabic localizers in similar contexts cannot merely function as nouns. This perspective is somewhat reflected in Wu's research (2015), which contends that certain common post-nominal disyllabic localizers possess properties of both nouns and postpositions, positioning them between these two categories. However, Wu's research is limited to a few disyllabic localizers such as *lǐmiàn* (里面 "inside"), *hòutóu* (后头 "back") and *wàibiān* (外边 "outside"). This study further states that post-nominal disyllabic localizers are either postpositions, postpositions as well as nouns, or primarily considered postpositions.

In a similar vein to He (2025), this study investigates the categorial status of disyllabic localizers within the framework of SFL. It aims to answer two questions: a) What are the semantic and syntactic functions of disyllabic localizers in Mandarin Chinese? b) What kind of categorial status do disyllabic localizers in Mandarin Chinese hold? Overall, by examining the semantic and syntactic functions of disyllabic localizers, this study aims to highlight the complex categorial status of post-nominal disyllabic localizers, emphasizing positional relationships between entities rather than their relative positions. They are on the verge of becoming postpositions.

3.2 Theoretical Framework

Currently, SFL comprises two major versions (cf. Huang 2023)—the Sydney Grammar (SG) with Halliday's *An Introduction to Functional Grammar* (1985, 1994, 2004, 2014) as the seminal work, and the Cardiff Grammar (CG) with Fawcett's *A Theory of Syntax for Systemic Functional Linguistics* (2000) as the most representative work. While they differ in some respects, both adhere to key principles of language description, such as the primacy of meaning over form and the idea that form is a realization of meaning.

This study integrates SG and CG in analyzing and describing disyllabic localizers along with their preceding nominals and prepositions. It classifies groups and phrases into six categories: the nominal group, the quality group, the quantity group, the preposition group, the conjunction group, and the prepositional phrase, with detailed descriptions provided in He et al. (2015a, b). Since the analysis and description mainly focus on disyllabic localizers and their preceding elements, specifically, nominal groups and prepositional phrases, a brief review of these two units is provided below.

The nominal group is a grammatical unit that expresses cultural classifications of things. It mainly consists of the determiner, modifier, head, and qualifier elements in its syntactic structure. The "head" element is crucial for expressing a cultural classification of things, answering the question, "What class of things does the nominal group refer to?" The "modifier" element conveys qualities of things, answering the question, "What sort of things does the nominal group refer to?" The "determiner" element specifies the item, answering the question, "Which (or whose) thing does the nominal group refer to?" The "qualifier" element functions similarly to the modifier in classifying or depicting things but comes after the head. For example, in *wǒ de liǎng zhī dà shǒu, zhàopiàn shang de* (我的两只大手, 照片上的 "my two big hands in the picture"), *wǒ de* (我的 "my") is the deictic determiner, *liǎng zhī* (两只 "two") is the quantifying determiner, *dà* (大 "big") is the modifier, *shǒu* (手 "hand") is the head, and *zhàopiàn shang de* (照片上的 "in the picture") is the qualifier.

The prepositional phrase is a grammatical unit that encodes minor relationships between elements and typically consists of two components: the preposition and the completive. The preposition connects the referent indicated by a grammatical unit occupying the completive element to the referent indicated by another grammatical unit in the local context. For example, in *zài xiào shítáng* (在校食堂 "at the school cafeteria"), *zài* (在 "at") is the preposition, and *xiào shítáng* (校食堂 "school cafeteria") as a nominal group fills the completive. In *Zhào Míng zài xiào shítáng gōngzuò* (赵明在校食堂工作 "Zhao Ming works at the school cafeteria"), the preposition expresses the spatial relationship between the school cafeteria and *Zhào Míng*.

By closely observing the key principles of language description and referencing the explanations of nominal groups and prepositional phrases within the SFL framework, the ensuing section analyzes and describes disyllabic localizers in various contexts. The aim is to highlight the complex nature of their categorical status.

3.3 Analysis and Description

Unlike monosyllabic localizers, disyllabic ones provide greater flexibility in usage. In other words, they can function as nouns in certain contexts, serve as postpositions in others, or act as both nouns and postpositions in various situations. Below is a detailed analysis and description of disyllabic localizers across different contexts.

3.3.1 Disyllabic Localizers Used Alone as Nouns

Disyllabic localizers can function independently as place words. As a subclass of nouns, they share similar usages and syntactic functions with common nouns. They can take the subordinating particle *de* (的, "REL") and can be modified by adjectives. In terms of syntactic functions, they can serve as the subject, the Complement ("object"[5] beyond SFL), and the Adjunct within a clause. They can also act as the head and the modifier of a nominal group, serve as the finisher of quality and quantity groups, and function as the completive of a prepositional phrase. Given the clear categorical status of disyllabic localizers when used independently, we present the usages of one disyllabic localizer, *shàngmiàn* (上面 "top, up, above, surface"), as follows.[6,7]

[5] The technical terms used in other schools of linguistics differ from those addressed within the framework of SFL, are quoted. For example, the "objects" of verbs are the Complements of clauses in SFL, and the "objects" of prepositions are the completives of prepositional phrases in SFL.

[6] All Chinese examples in this study without specific sources are from one of the two corpora: the CCL Corpus (the corpus of Chinese at the Center for Chinese Linguistics PKU, 673,576,532 characters, available at http://ccl.pku.edu.cn/), and the BCC Chinese corpus (developed by the Institute of Big Data and Educational Technology, School of Information Science, Beijing Language and Culture University, has a total number of about 9.5 billion words, including multi-domain corpora such as newspapers [2 billion], literature [3 billion], dialogue/microblog and film subtitles [0.6 billion], comprehensive [1.9 billion], and ancient Chinese [2 billion]. It is a large-scale corpus that fully reflects the language use of today's society.) Note that some examples have been shortened for convenience. The reason for using two corpora instead of just one is that access to either website may sometimes be unavailable. Therefore, during the research process, whichever corpus can be accessed will be used. Since both corpora are large-scale, there are no significantly different search results, which does not affect the research findings of this study.

[7] The examples referenced from the literature are all accompanied by their exact sources; for these examples, the glosses are also sourced from the same references. If the glossing of aspects, classifiers, relatives, and so on does not adhere to the Leipzig Glossing abbreviation conventions, this study replaces them with standard glosses. In this study, ASP denotes "aspect"; CLF refers to "classifier"; GEN signifies "genitive"; MP indicates "mood particle"; PREP stands for "preposition" (used when there is no corresponding preposition); and REL represents "relative." Note that for the subordinating particle or the modifying structural marker *de* (的), Halliday & McDonald (2004) gloss it as SUB, but this article continues to use REL, adhering to the Leipzig Glossing abbreviation conventions.

(1) a.

上面	少	了	一	支	枪。
shàngmiàn	*shǎo*	*le*	*yī*	*zhī*	*qiāng.*
top	lose	ASP	a	CLF	gun

“A gun is missing from it.”

b.

请	看	上面。
qǐng	*kàn*	*shàngmiàn.*
please	look	up

“Please look up.”

c.

我	上面	提到	了	这	一	点。
wǒ	*shàngmiàn*	*tídào*	*le*	*zhè*	*yī*	*diǎn.*
I	above	mention	ASP	this	a	point

“I mentioned this point above.”

d.

门	的	上面	写	着	两	个	字。
mén	*de*	*shàngmiàn*	*xiě*	*zhe*	*liǎng*	*gè*	*zì.*
door	REL	surface	write	ASP	two	CLF	character

“There are two characters written on the door.”

e.

这	一	点	由	上面	的	例证	可以	知道。
zhè	*yī*	*diǎn*	*yǒu*	*shàngmiàn*	*de*	*lìzhèng*	*kéyǐ*	*zhīdào.*
this	a	point	via	above	REL	example	can	know

“This can be seen from the above example.”

f.

上面	最	显眼	的	是	一	只	和平鸽。
shàngmiàn	*zuì*	*xiányǎn*	*de*	*shì*	*yī*	*zhī*	*hépínggē.*
above	most	conspicuous	REL	be	one	CLF	dove of peace

“The most conspicuous thing above is a dove of peace.”

g.

上面	很多	讲	了	元旦	晚会。
shàngmiàn	*hěnduō*	*jiǎng*	*le*	*yuándàn*	*wǎnhuì.*
above	many	talk	ASP	new year	evening party

“There are many talks about the new year’s party above.”

h.

侧面	比	上面	大。
cèmiàn	*bǐ*	*shàngmiàn*	*dà.*
side	than	top	large

“The side is larger than the top.”

In (1a), the disyllabic localizer functions as the Subject of the clause; in (1b), it acts as the Complement; in (1c), it serves as the Adjunct; in (1d), it is the head of the nominal group *mén de shàngmiàn* (门的上面 "the surface of the door"); in (1e), it is the modifier of the nominal group *shàngmiàn de lìzhèng* (上面的例证 "the above example"); in (1f), it is the finisher of the quality group *shàngmiàn zuì xiányǎn* (上面最显眼 "the most conspicuous above"); in (1g), it is the finisher of the quantity group *shàngmiàn hěnduō* (上面很多 "many above"); in (1h), it is the completive of the prepositional phrase *bǐ shàngmiàn* (比上面 "than the top").

Notably, even the exceptional disyllabic localizers mentioned by Liu (2003) and Liu et al. (2001) can be considered nouns when used in isolation, although they are rarely used independently. They include *yǐnèi* (以内 "within"), *yǐwài* (以外 "outside, beyond"), *zhīshàng* (之上 "above, on top of") and *zhīxià* (之下 "under") according to Liu (2003: 112, 310–311), and *zhījiān* (之间 "between, among"), *zhīzhōng* (之中 "in, among, in the midst of"), *zhīnèi* (之内 "within, in") and *zhīwài* (之外 "outside, beyond") according to Liu et al. (2001: 57). They are regarded as postpositions by Liu (2003) and Liu et al. (2001). This study agrees with them on one point—further explanations are provided in sect. 4, but highlights that when used alone, they remain nouns. For example,

(2)

距离	采场	200	米	以外	是	安全	区，	以内	是	危险	区。
jùlí	*cáichǎng*	*200*	*mǐ*	*yǐwài*	*shì*	*ānquán*	*qū,*	*yǐnèi*	*shì*	*wēixiǎn*	*qū.*
from	stope	200	meter	outside	be	safe	area,	within	be	dangerous	area

“200 meters away from the stope is the safe zone, and within is the dangerous zone.”

(3)

翠	岩	环	拥	出	草地…	以外	是	图案	似	的	田亩。
cuì	*yán*	*huán*	*yōng*	*chū*	*cǎodì…*	*yǐwài*	*shì*	*tú'àn*	*sì*	*de*	*tiánmǔ.*
green	rock	ring	embrace	out	grassland…	outside	be	pattern	like	REL	field

“The green rocks embrace the grassland... Outside are patterned fields.”

(4)

烟波	尽处	是	瓦灰	的	一	线，	之上	就	是
yānbō	*jìnchù*	*shìī*	*wǎhuī*	*de*	*yī*	*xiàn,*	*zhīshàng*	*jiù*	*shì*
smoke wave	end	be	tile ash	REL	a	line,	above	exactly	be
白朗朗	的	长	天	了。					
báilángláng	*de*	*cháng*	*tiān*	*le.*					
white	REL	long	sky	MP					

“At the end of the smoke wave is a line of tile ash, and above it is the long white sky.”

(5)

每	科	分	列	项目，	之下	再	分	列	条目。
měi	*kē*	*fēn*	*liè*	*xiàngmù,*	*zhīxià*	*zài*	*fēn*	*liè*	*tiáomù.*
each	subject	separately	list	item,	below	then	separately	list	entry

“Each subject is divided into items, and then each item is divided into entries.”

3.3.2 Post-Nominal Disyllabic Localizers as Postpositions

As mentioned above, these exceptional disyllabic localizers are rarely used alone and typically occur after nominals. They seldom serve a syntactic function independently at the clause level. To support this perspective, we searched the CCL Corpus and found that most exceptions under discussion are infrequently used independently. There are only two cases concerning *yǐnèi* (以内 "within"), four cases concerning *yǐwài* (以外 "outside"), two cases concerning *zhīshàng* (之上 "above, on top of"), two cases concerning *zhīnèi* (之内 "within, in"), three cases concerning *zhīzhōng* (之中 "in, among, in the midst of"), four cases concerning *zhīxià* (之下 "under"), and nine cases concerning *zhīwài* (之外 "outside, beyond"). However, there are fifty-one cases concerning *zhījiān* (之间 "between, among").

The search results indicate that, except for *zhījiān* (之间 "between, among"), the other exceptions are rarely used in isolation. Therefore, it is reasonable for Liu (2003) and Liu et al. (2001) to classify them as postpositions. As previously noted, this study aligns with their views in some respects but diverges in others, suggesting that their perspective needs adjustment here. Specifically, when used independently—though very infrequently—they still function as nouns, as illustrated by examples (2) through (5). Conversely, when they follow nominals, they act as postpositions. Clearly, their preceding nominals cannot be omitted; they do not accept the subordinating particle *de* (的 "REL"), and they can be replaced by corresponding monosyllabic localizers. In terms of semantic functions, when positioned directly after nominals, they link one referent to another. Regarding syntactic functions, the phrases formed by them and their preceding nominals perform similar roles to prepositional phrases. They can serve as the Adjunct, Complement, or Subject of the clause, the head and modifier of the nominal group, the finisher of the quality and quantity group, and the completive of the prepositional phrase. Below, we provide examples concerning one such exceptional disyllabic localizer, *yǐnèi* (以内 "within").

(6) a.

五	年	以内,	发展	速度	只能	增长	百分之四。
wǔ	*nián*	*yǐnèi,*	*fāzhǎn*	*sùdù*	*zhǐnéng*	*zēngzhǎng*	*bǎifēnzhīsì.*
five	year	within,	development	speed	only	increase	four percent

"Within five years, the growth rate can only increase by 4%."

b.

标题	一般	在	20	字	以内。
biāotí	*yībān*	*zài*	*20*	*zì*	*yǐnèi.*
title	generally	at	20	character	within

"The title is generally within 20 characters."

c.

2	米	以内	是	较为	紧凑	和谐	的	私人	空间。
2	*mǐ*	*yǐnèi*	*shì*	*jiàowéi*	*jǐncòu*	*héxié*	*de*	*sīrén*	*kōngjiān.*
2	meter	within	be	relatively	compact	harmonious	REL	private	space

"Within 2 meters is a relatively compact and harmonious private space."

d.

北极	地区	是	指	北极圈	以内	的	区域。
běijí	*dìqū*	*shì*	*zhǐ*	*běijíquān*	*yǐnèi*	*de*	*qūyù.*
Arctic	region	be	refer to	Arctic circle	within	REL	region

"The Arctic region refers to the region within the Arctic circle."

e.

它	是	北京	二环	以内	最	高	的	建筑物。
tā	*shì*	*Běijīng*	*èrhuán*	*yǐnèi*	*zuì*	*gāo*	*de*	jiànzhūwù.
it	be	Beijing	Ring Road No. 2	within	most	tall	REL	building

"It is the tallest building within ring road no. 2 of Beijing."

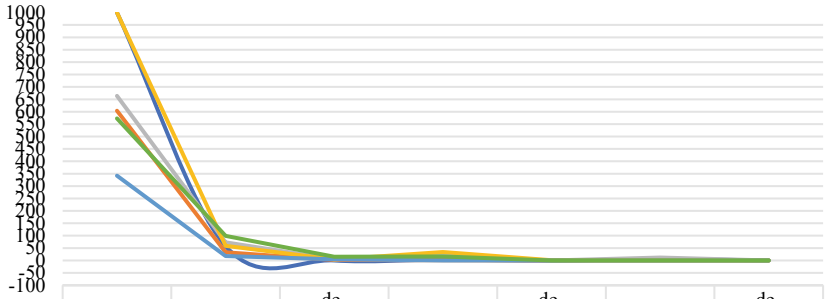
i	500	分钟	以内	最	高	只	收	30	元。		
	500	*fēnzhōng*	*yǐnèi*	*zuì*	*gāo*	*zhǐ*	*shōu*	*30*	*yuán.*		
	500	minute	within	most	high	only	charge	30	*yuan.*		
	“The maximum charge within 500 minutes is only 30 *yuan*.”										
j	在	一	分钟	以内,	顾客	可	获得	一	张	彩色	照片。
	zài	*yī*	*fēnzhōng*	*yǐnèi,*	*gùkè*	*kě*	*huòdé*	*yī*	*zhāng*	*cǎisè*	*zhàopiān.*
	at	one	minute	within,	customer	can	get	one	CLF	color	photo
	“Within one minute, customers can get a color photo.”										

3.3.3 *Post-Nominal Disyllabic Localizers as Postpositions as Well as Nouns or Primarily as Postpositions*

The search results concerning the uses of those exceptional items presented above also indicate that when used directly after nominals, disyllabic localizers emphasize positional relationships between entities, and their categorial status is complex. In some instances, they function as both postpositions and nouns—that is, they are neither purely postpositions nor solely nouns; in other instances, they are primarily postpositions.

According to Liu et al. (2001: 58), only two groups of disyllabic localizers can be considered postpositions as well as nouns, which are the combinations of monosyllabic localizers *shàng* (上 "up, on, in, above, top") and *lǐ* (里 "in, inside") and morphemes *tóu* (头 "head"), *biān* (边 "side") and *miàn* (面 "surface"). However, this study argues that in certain situations, all typical post-nominal disyllabic localizers can be described as both postpositions and nouns (place words). In other words, from one perspective, they function as postpositions, while from another, they act as nouns. To confirm this, we have searched the BCC Corpus for instances of all typical post-nominal disyllabic localizers.[8] Those disyllabic localizers include the combinations of monosyllabic localizers *shàng* (上 "up, on, in, above, top"), *xià* (下 "down, under, below, bottom"), *lǐ* (里 "in, inside"), *wài* (外 "out, outside"), *qián* (前 "front, before, ahead"), and *hòu* (后 "back, behind, after") and morphemes *tóu* (头 "head"), *biān* (边 "side"), and *miàn* (面 "surface"), and they are: *shàngmiàn* (上面 "on, up, above, top"), *shàngbiān* (上边 "on, up, above, top"), and *shàngtóu* (上头 "on, up, above, top"); *xiàmiàn* (下面 "down, under, below, bottom"), *xiàbiān* (下边 "down, under, below, bottom"), and *xiàtóu* (下头 "down, under, below, bottom"); *lǐmiàn* (里面 "in, inside, interior"), *lǐbiān* (里边 "in, inside, interior") and *lǐtóu* (里头 "in, inside, interior"); *wàimiàn* (外面 "out, outside, exterior"), *wàibiān* (外边 "out, outside, exterior"), and *wàitóu* (外头 "out, outside, exterior"); *qiánmiàn* (前面 "front, before, ahead, anterior"), *qiánbiān* (前边 "front, before, ahead, anterior"), and *qiántóu* (前头 "front, before, ahead, anterior"); *hòumiàn* (后面 "back, behind, after, rear"), *hòubiān* (后边 "back, behind, after, rear"), and *hòutóu* (后头 "back, behind, after, rear"). Before considering the uses of these disyllabic localizers, we highlight the difference between the occurrences of these disyllabic localizers and their corresponding monosyllabic localizers in the same contexts to specify why monosyllabic localizers can be viewed as postpositions while disyllabic ones typically function as place words. Due to the difficulty of counting all the nouns followed by the localizers in question, we focus on three standard common nouns: *qiáng* (墙 "wall" –142,205 cases in BCC), *zhuōzi* (桌子 "table"—31,467 cases in BCC) and *bīngxiāng* (冰箱 "fridge"—17,230 cases in BCC). While they may not cover all

[8] This study examined the BCC corpus for occurrences of typical monosyllabic and disyllabic localizers following the three common nouns: *qiáng* (墙 "wall"), *zhuōzi* (桌子 "table") and *bīngxiāng* (冰箱 "fridge") on July 29th-31st, 2021.



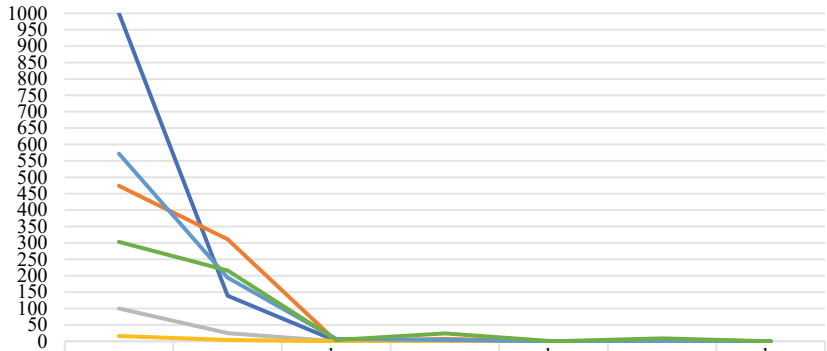
	MonoLoc	MonoLoc-miàn	de-MonoLoc-miàn	MonoLoc-biān	de-MonoLoc-biān	MonoLoc-tóu	de-MonoLoc-tóu
shàng	1000	58	0	3	0	5	0
xià	604	33	2	1	0	0	0
lǐ	664	73	5	22	0	12	0
wài	1000	59	4	34	1	1	0
qián	342	18	5	0	0	0	0
hòu	573	99	15	16	0	0	0

Fig. 3.1 The occurrences of typical monosyllabic and disyllabic localizers following the common noun *qiáng* (墙 "wall") in the BCC corpus

nouns because they refer to various shapes commonly found in daily life, they can illustrate this perspective to some extent. The findings are described below.[9]

For comparisons with corresponding monosyllabic localizers, as shown in Figs. 3.1, 3.2, and 3.3, disyllabic localizers rarely occur after nominals and are primarily used independently. This indicates that they are referential rather than indicative of positional relationships between things in most cases. In contrast, monosyllabic localizers are typically used after nominals.

[9] Note that in Figs 3.1, 3.2, and 3.3, MonoLoc is the abbreviation for monosyllabic localizer. Also, in the Chinese *pinyin* of all the monosyllabic localizers, the morphemes added to these localizers in these three figures are not italicized, as the format of such figures is fixed and does not permit this.



	MonoLoc	MonoLoc-miàn	de-MonoLoc-miàn	MonoLoc-biān	de-MonoLoc-biān	MonoLoc-tóu	de-MonoLoc-tóu
shàng	1000	139	1	3	0	3	0
xià	474	311	0	7	0	0	0
lǐ	100	25	0	0	0	0	0
wài	16	4	0	0	0	0	0
qián	572	194	7	4	0	1	0
hòu	303	216	4	24	0	9	0

Fig. 3.2 The occurrences of typical monosyllabic and disyllabic localizers following the common noun *zhuōzi* (桌子 "table") in the BCC corpus



	MonoLoc	MonoLoc-miàn	de-MonoLoc-miàn	MonoLoc-biān	de-MonoLoc-biān	MonoLoc-tóu	de-MonoLoc-tóu
shàng	182	15	0	1	0	1	0
xià	4	2	0	0	0	0	0
lǐ	2309	79	0	0	0	0	0
wài	4	0	0	0	0	0	0
qián	62	8	0	0	0	0	0
hòu	14	5	0	0	0	0	0

Fig. 3.3 The occurrences of typical monosyllabic and disyllabic localizers following the common noun bīngxiāng (冰箱 "fridge") in the BCC corpus

To further clarify the uses of disyllabic localizers following nominals, we observe that they are primarily added directly to their preceding nominals instead of being separated by the subordinating particle *de* (的 "REL"). For example, *shàngmiàn* (上面 "on, above, top") directly follows *qiáng* (墙 "wall") in all of the 58 cases whereas there is no case with *de* (的 "REL") intervening them. Regarding *zhuōzi* (桌子 "table"), there are totally 139 cases with *shàngmiàn* (上面 "on, above, top") directly following the nominal whereas there is only one case involving *de* (的 "REL"). Regarding *bīngxiāng* (冰箱 "fridge"), there are 15 cases with *shàngmiàn* (上面 "on, above, top") directly following the nominal whereas there is no case involving *de* (的 "REL"). This situation is not confined to the disyllabic localizers formed by *shàng* (上 "on, up, above") and *lǐ* (里 "in, inside") and morphemes *tóu* (头 "head"), *biān* (边 "side"), and *miàn* (面 "surface"). As shown by the figures, all typical disyllabic localizers exhibit similar behavior, indicating that they have undergone grammaticalization. From one perspective, they can be considered place nouns that express the relative positions of things in most cases. One argument for this is that the noun preceding them can be omitted. In other words, they can function independently as the Adjunct, Complement, and Subject of the clause, as the modifier of the nominal group, and as the finisher of the quality and the quantity group, as well as the completive of the prepositional phrase. For example,[10]

[10] In examples (7a) to (7c), the underlined parts serve as the Adjunct, Complement, and Subject of the clauses in question, respectively; in (7d) to (7 g), they act as the modifier of the nominal group, the finisher of the quality group, the finisher of the quantity group, and the completive of the prepositional phrase, respectively. Thus, the notations "(Adjunct)," "(Complement)," "(Subject)," "(modifier)," "(finisher)," "(finisher)," and "(completive)" are presented at the end of the first line of the examples in question, respectively.

(7) a. 桌子, 上面, 眼睛 看 着 对面 的 那 个 男人。 (adjunct)
zhuōzi shàngmiàn, yǎnjīng kàn zhe duìmiàn de nà gè nánrén.
table on, eye look ASP opposite REL that CLF man
"On the table, his eyes were fixed on the man sitting opposite."

b. 它 就 在 桌子 上面。 (complement)
tā jìu zài zhuōzi shàngmiàn.
it just exist table on
"It is just on the table."

c. 桌子 上面 放 着 奶瓶。 (subject)
zhuōzi shàngmiàn fàng zhe nǎipíng.
table on put ASP milk bottle
"There are milk bottles on the table."

d. 他 看到 了 桌子 上面 的 菜。 (modifier of the nominal group)
tā kàndào le zhuōzi shàngmiàn de cài.
he see ASP table on REL dish
"He saw the dishes on the table."

e. 这 是 火星 上面 最 重要 的 特征。 (finisher of the quality group)
zhè shì huǒxīng shàngmiàn zuì zhòngyào de tèzhēng.
this be Mars on most important REL feature
"This is the most important feature on Mars."

f.	刚刚	微博	上面	大多	有	了	新	进展。	(finisher of the quantity group)		
	gānggāng	*wēibó*	*shàngmiàn*	*dàduō*	*yǒu*	*le*	*xīn*	*jìnzhǎn.*			
	just now	weibo	on	most	have	ASP	new	progress			
	"Just now, most (things) on Weibo have made new progress."										
g.	我	的	两	只	手	在	桌子	上面	哆嗦	着。	(completive of the prepositional phrase)
	wǒ	*de*	*liǎng*	*zhī*	*shǒu*	*zài*	*zhuōzi*	*shàngmiàn*	*duōsuo*	*zhe*	
	I	GEN	two	CLF	hand	at	table	on	tremble	ASP	
	"My hands were trembling on the table."										

From another perspective, post-nominal disyllabic localizers can be regarded as postpositions if they can be substituted with corresponding monosyllabic localizers. This indicates that they imply positional relationships between things. The following arguments support this view. Firstly, the complete absence of *de* (的 "REL") before these localizers suggests that such usages feel very natural. Secondly, in certain instances, inserting *de* (的 "REL") between the localizers and their preceding nominals emphasizes a specific, concrete location rather than a relative position, much less a positional relationship. This is illustrated in example (7c) and its adaptation.

(7)	c.	桌子	上面	放	着	奶瓶。	
		zhuōzi	*shàngmiàn*	*fàng*	*zhe*	*nǎipíng.*	
		table	on	put	ASP	milk bottle	
		"There are milk bottles on the table."					
	c'.	桌子	的	上面	放	着	奶瓶。
		zhuōzi	*de*	*shàngmiàn*	*fàng*	*zhe*	*nǎipíng.*
		table	REL	surface	put	ASP	milk bottle
		"There are milk bottles on the table."					

From the analysis of the translation lines, it is clear that *zhuōzi shàngmiàn* (桌子上面 "on the table") is better interpreted as indicating a positional relationship between things, whereas *zhuōzi de shàngmiàn* (桌子的上面 "the surface of the table") refers to a specific reference. In conclusion, in certain contexts, post-nominal disyllabic localizers, like those in examples (7a-g), function both as postpositions and as nouns.

In other situations, post-nominal disyllabic localizers should primarily be regarded as postpositions, particularly if adding *de* (的 "REL") renders the new nominal group unacceptable. For example,

(8) a.

报纸	上	有	一	个	关于	克隆牛	的	消息。	
bàozhǐ	*shàng*	*yǒu*	*yī*	*gè*	*guānyú*	*kèlóngniú*	*de*	*xiāoxī.*	
paper	on	have	one	CLF	about	cloned cattle	REL	message	

"There is a message about cloned cattle in the newspaper."

b.

报纸	上面	有	一	个	关于	克隆牛	的	消息。	(adapted in this study)
bàozhǐ	*shàngmiàn*	*yǒu*	*yī*	*gè*	*guānyú*	*kèlóngniú*	*de*	*xiāoxī.*	
paper	on	have	one	CLF	about	cloned cattle	REL	message	

"There is a message about cloned cattle in the newspaper."

c.

*报纸	的	上面	有	一	个	关于	克隆牛	的	消息。	(adapted in this study)
bàozhǐ	*de*	*shàngmiàn*	*yǒu*	*yī*	*gè*	*guānyú*	*kèlóngniú*	*de*	*xiāoxī.*	
paper	REL	top	have	one	CLF	about	cloned cattle	REL	message	

(9) a.

大家	都	把	自己	号码	发	到	我	手机	上。
dàjiā	*dōu*	*bǎ*	*zìjǐ*	*hàomǎ*	*fā*	*dào*	*wǒ*	*shǒujī*	*shàng.*
everyone	all	PREP	self	number	send	to	I	mobile phone	on

"Everyone sends the numbers to my mobile phone."

b.	大家	都	把	自己	号码	发	到	我	手机	上面。	(adapted in this study)	
	dàjiā	*dōu*	*bǎ*	*zìjǐ*	*hàomǎ*	*fā*	*dào*	*wǒ*	*shǒujī*	*shàngmiàn.*		
	everyone	all	PREP	self	number	send	to	I	mobile phone	on		
	“Everyone sends the numbers to my mobile phone.”											
c.	*大家	都	把	自己	号码	发	到	机	我手	的	上面。	(adapted in this study)
	dàjiā	*dōu*	*bǎ*	*zìjǐ*	*hàomǎ*	*fā*	*dào*	*wǒ*	*shǒujī*	*de*	*shàngmiàn.*	
	everyone	all	PREP	self	number	to	I	mobile	phone	REL	top	

The search of the BCC corpus shows that there are 6535 cases concerning *bàozhǐ shang* (报纸上 “in the newspaper”) and 4833 cases concerning *shǒujī shang* (手机上 “on the mobile phone”), and there are 33 cases concerning *bàozhǐ shàngmiàn* (报纸上面 “in the newspaper”) and 49 cases concerning *shǒujī shàngmiàn* (手机上面 “on the mobile phone”); however, there is no case concerning *bàozhǐ de shàngmiàn* (报纸的上面 “on the top of the newspaper”) or *shǒujī de shàngmiàn* (手机的上面 “on the top of the mobile phone”). This confirms the search result about the co-occurrences of the typical disyllabic localizers and their preceding nominals *zhuōzi* (桌子 “table”), *qiáng* (墙 “wall”) and *bīngxiāng* (冰箱 “fridge”), implying that post-nominal disyllabic localizers are undergoing grammaticalization, and peculiarly denote positional relationships between things. However, the degree of grammaticalization of post-nominal disyllabic localizers varies across different contexts. In instances such as examples (7a-g), preceding nominals can be omitted, the subordinating particle *de* (的 “REL”) may appear, and corresponding monosyllabic localizers can serve as substitutes; in these scenarios, the degree of grammaticalization of post-nominal disyllabic localizers tends to be moderate, and thus, they should be regarded as both postpositions and nouns. In cases like examples (8b) and (9b), the subordinating particle *de* (的 “REL”) cannot appear, yet their preceding nominals can be omitted; in these instances, the degree of grammaticalization of post-nominal disyllabic localizers is comparatively high, and therefore, they should primarily be viewed as postpositions.

As explained above, post-nominal disyllabic localizers can function as postpositions as well as nouns or primarily as postpositions. Based on this, a question arises. As demonstrated in example (10), it is evident that the disyllabic localizer acts as a pure noun, since the presence of *de* (的 “REL”) between it and the preceding nominal sounds very natural, and they cannot be replaced with corresponding monosyllabic localizers. In this context, whether with *de* (的 “REL”) or without it, the emphasis of the nominal group is placed on the disyllabic localizer.

(10) 墙 下面 宽。
qiáng *xiàmiàn* *kuān.*
wall bottom wide
“The bottom of the wall is wide.”

This study agrees that disyllabic localizers, like those in example (10), are indeed pure nouns. This usage indicates that they are not genuinely post-nominal disyllabic localizers but are instead similar to those used independently. The absence of the subordinating particle *de* (的 “REL”) represents a form of ellipsis, as confirmed by the pause between the preceding nominals and these disyllabic localizers.

3.4 Discussion

As mentioned in the introduction, disyllabic localizers are typically regarded as nouns in the literature. This study concurs that, in principle, all disyllabic localizers can be classified as nouns when used on their own. This position is further supported by Chappell & Peyraube (2008, 2013). By tracing the developmental trajectory of disyllabic localizers, they found that these forms appeared in the Pre-Medieval period and were utilized independently as both subjects and objects. In Early Medieval Chinese, a few instances of post-nominal disyllabic localizers emerged, functioning as place words. By the Late Medieval Chinese era, disyllabic localizers had become increasingly prevalent (Chappell & Peyraube 2008: 31). Unlike monosyllabic localizers, which were initially used independently but have tended to follow nominals throughout their evolution, disyllabic localizers have primarily been used alone since their introduction into Chinese. Consequently, in academia, scholars generally categorize disyllabic localizers as place nouns, whereas there is ongoing debate regarding the categorical status of monosyllabic localizers.

In sect. 3, this study argues that the exceptional localizers function as postpositions when they follow nominals directly—indeed, they are typically utilized in such contexts. Besides the exceptions noted by Liu (2003) and Liu et al. (2001), Djamouri et al. (2013) even classify yǐqián (以前 "before") and yǐwài (以外 "outside, beyond") as postpositions. From one perspective, this study disagrees with Djamouri et al. regarding the categorical status of these two words, as they are often employed independently. An examination of the CCL corpus shows that yǐqián (以前 "before") is used alone in at least 31,395 cases, while yǐwài (以外 "outside, beyond") appears alone in at least 925 cases. However, from another perspective, this study finds support in Djamouri et al. (2013). Specifically, although yǐqián (以前 "before") and yǐwài (以外 "outside, beyond") cannot be classified as postpositions, Djamouri et al.'s approach to disyllabic localizers suggests that a few exceptional disyllabic localizers should be regarded as postpositions when they are placed directly after nominals.

This study contends that the categorical status of typical post-nominal disyllabic localizers is complex. In certain scenarios—specifically, when the preceding nominals can be omitted, when the use of de (的 "REL") feels natural, and when they can also be substituted with corresponding monosyllabic localizers, they can be considered both postpositions and nouns. In other words, under these conditions, they are neither pure nouns nor pure postpositions. Conversely, in scenarios where the use of de (的 "REL") does not appear natural or renders the new nominal groups unacceptable, they should primarily be viewed as postpositions. This view implies that disyllabic localizers are undergoing grammaticalization. Given this developmental trend, one of the most effective principles for analyzing and describing disyllabic localizers is to acknowledge linguistic facts (He 2021).

At this point, Kuo's concern regarding the postpositional approach to post-nominal disyllabic localizers can be resolved. Kuo (2022) suggests that since de (的 "REL") can be inserted between preceding nominals and post-nominal disyllabic localizers,

as illustrated in the example below, the post-nominal disyllabic localizers should be regarded as nouns. This viewpoint excludes the other two possibilities, including their consideration as postpositions in some situations and primarily as postpositions in others.

(11) 张 三 在 房间 (的) 里面。
Zhāng *Sān* *zài* fángjiān (de) *lǐmiàn.*
Zhang San at room REL inside
"Zhang San is inside the room."

As previously described, disyllabic localizers, like the example in (11), should be regarded as both postpositions and nouns. This is evident since the preceding nominals can be deleted, the particle *de* (的 "REL") can be inserted between them, and they can be replaced by their corresponding monosyllabic localizers. However, it is noteworthy that although *de* (的 "REL") can be inserted in some cases, as seen in examples (7c') and (11), what these new nominal groups emphasize is a specific, concrete place rather than a relative position. This suggests that the two units, those without and those with *de* (的 "REL"), do not convey precisely the same meaning, which is consistent with Wu's (2015) analysis of disyllabic localizers.

In other situations, as illustrated by examples (8c) and (9c), *de* (的 "REL") cannot be inserted in between, as this raises grammatical concerns. This indicates that in these cases, post-nominal disyllabic localizers should primarily be viewed as postpositions.

Before concluding the discussion, another crucial issue should be addressed regarding the presence of postpositions in modern Chinese, which primarily follows the SVO word order. According to Dryer (2002), very few languages that have transitioned from SOV to SVO are found to contain postpositions. Otherwise, this goes against the principle of head proximity (Rijkhoff 1986, 1987). Two reasons can be drawn from the literature. First, Chinese has gradually evolved from SOV to SVO over time (Tai 1988; LaPolla 1994), and this shift is not radical, suggesting that modern Chinese still retains some characteristics of SOV. This argument aligns with the view that disyllabic localizers have been undergoing grammaticalization. Some disyllabic localizers are nearly postpositions, and typical ones can function as both postpositions and nouns when appearing immediately after nominals. Secondly, this phenomenon may be attributed to the areal influence of languages to the north (Dryer 2002). Moreover, it could be rooted in the fundamental mode of Chinese philosophical thinking. Detailed explanations are provided in He (2025).

3.5 Conclusion

The following conclusions can be drawn from the analysis, description, and discussion above.

Disyllabic localizers are typically used alone as nouns, expressing the relative positions of things and performing similar syntactic functions to nouns. Even those exceptions, including *yǐnèi* (以内 "within"), *yǐwài* (以外 "outside, beyond"), *zhīshàng* (之上 "above, on top of"), *zhīxià* (之下 "under"), *zhīzhōng* (之中 "in, among, in the midst of"), *zhīnèi* (之内 "within, in"), and *zhīwài* (之外 "outside, beyond"), should be viewed as place nouns when used alone, though they are rarely used in this manner. In most cases, these exceptions serve as postpositions. When following nominals directly, typical disyllabic localizers have undergone grammaticalization; in other words, they emphasize positional relationships between things over relative positions. In certain situations—specifically, when their preceding nominals can be deleted, when the insertion of de (的 "REL") sounds natural, and when they can be replaced by corresponding monosyllabic localizers—they should be considered both postpositions and nouns. In other situations, namely, if the insertion of *de* (的 "REL") renders the new nominal groups unacceptable, they should primarily be regarded as postpositions.

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Chapter 4
Transitivity, Ergativity, and Their Complementarity: The Case of Chinese



Yong Wang

Abstract Systemic functional linguistics (SFL) sees transitivity and ergativity as two complementary systems for construing experiential meaning. The former is concerned with the deed-&-extension aspect of experience, with 'Actor ^ Process' as the nucleus, and the latter the cause-&-effect aspect, with 'Medium ^ Process' as the nucleus. Under this rationale, we probe into the less-studied domain of ergativity in Chinese, by examining how it is expressed along the lexico-grammar continuum. At the lexical end, ergative verbs are those that may occur in the two agnate patterns, 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and 'NG2 ^ V.' These can also serve as the reference frames for checking the ergative meaning expressed by verb-resultative groups, which are abundant in the language due to its productivity and flexibility. Toward the end of grammar, we recognize event-existentials as the ergative construction, for they typically express the result and state meaning, and the only direct participant occurs post-verbally in the clause. Another syntactic pattern which are typically employed for expressing ergativity is the bǎ-construction with verb-resultative groups occurring clause-finally. Thus Chinese illustrates a language type in which ergativity is expressed all the way along the lexico-grammar continuum, in which the ergative and the transitive models may be combined such that both of their nuclei may co-occur, and they may be interwoven and in cooperation with each other in expressing experiential meaning. This is different both from split ergative languages discussed in linguistic typology, and from the complementarity between transitivity and ergativity as presented in the orthodox SFL literature with English as the major illustrating language.

Keywords Transitivity · Ergativity · Lexico-grammar · Cause · Effect

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4.1 Ergativity in Systemic Functional Grammar

In linguistic typology, three basic participant roles are recognized in the clause, i.e., A, S, and O, standing respectively for **Agent** of transitive clauses, **Subject** and the only participant in intransitive clauses, and **Object** in transitive clauses, to distinguish ergative languages from accusative ones. If A and S are marked similarly in case, agreement, and word order, and O is marked differently, the language is accusative. If O and S are marked similarly in these aspects, and A is marked differently, the language is ergative. There are borderline cases between these two types; these are called split ergative languages (see, e.g., Dixon 1979, 1994; Plank 1979, see Sect. 4.1).

The functional model of transitivity vs. ergativity is different from (though related to) the typological distinction of accusativity vs. ergativity, the former being more oriented to semantics and function in association with the formal features and the latter based on formal features, e.g., case marking, agreement, word order, etc.[1] In Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL, e.g., Halliday 1985, 1994), **ergativity** and the **transitivity** are seen as two complementary systems for construing experiential meaning. They may be found existing in all languages, figuring differently in different contexts. The following is a brief sketch of the functional model of transitivity and ergativity (see Halliday 1967a, b, 1968, 1985, 1994; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004, 2014).

Ergativity and transitivity are both concerned with experiential meaning.[2] According to Halliday and Matthiessen (2014: 334, 339), the transitive model is based on the configuration of 'Actor ^ Process.' Actor brings about the unfolding of the Process through time; and this unfolding is either confined in its outcome to Actor or extended to another participant, Goal. Process and Actor are obligatory and essential for an action to occur, e.g., *they are reading*. This may be extended to a Goal, as in *they are reading the guidelines*. According to the ergative model, every process is structured in the same way, on the basis of just one variable, which relates to the source of the process: what it is that brings it about. The question at issue is: is the process brought about from within, or from outside? Looked at from this point of view, the variable is not one of extension but one of causation (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 339, 340). That is, the ergative model is concerned with instigation of process (Davidse 1992: 109). The most essential elements for a process to occur is Process and **Medium** (through which the process takes place). Thus, a process can be construed as self-instigated, e.g., *the vase dropped*, or as externally instigated, e.g., *the careless man dropped the vase*). These are called non-ergative

[1] Hopper and Thompson (1980: 252) list the prototypical features of transitivity, including the number of participants, activity, agentivity/controllability, intentionality, affectedness of the patient. We use the term **intentional/actional meaning** to cover these features.

[2] In Halliday (e.g., 1985, 1994) and Halliday and Matthiessen (e.g., 2004, 2014), transitivity is taken as the major system realizing experiential meaning, which consists of the transitive model and the ergative model. To us, there is a disproportionality of transitivity as the major system and the transitive model as an alternative to the ergative model. Thus, we see experiential meaning as expressed through the two systems of transitivity and ergativity via the two models respectively (e.g., Wang 2016; Wang and Zhou 2014a).

and ergative clauses respectively (Davidse 1998: 102). The former does not make the distinction whether the event is self-engendered or externally initiated (Davidse 1998: 104). Thus *the vase dropped* can be interpreted as: it dropped by itself, or it was dropped. The question *Who dropped it*? can be raised in the latter case. In each model, three voices can be differentiated (Davidse 1998: 102; cf., Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 349–350):

(1)	Transitivity:		
	a. Middle:	intransitive:	*The* (Actor) *horse ran*
	b. Pseudo-Effective:	with Range:	*The horse* (Actor) *ran a race* (Range)
	c. Effective:	transitive:	*They* (Actor) *hunted the rabbit* (Goal)
(2)	Ergativity:		
	a. Middle:	non-ergative:	*The glass* (Medium) *broke*
	b. Pseudo-Effective:	with setting:	*The car* (Setting) *broke an axle* (Medium)
	c. Effective:	ergative:	*The cat* (Instigator) *broke the glass* (Medium)

We focus on the ergative model in this study (though reference is often made to the transitive model), which is recognized mainly on semantic grounds, with regard to the semantic relation between the process and its participants. The semantic role of Medium remains constant in middle and effective voice of the clause. The agnate relation between the different voice forms, then, can be used as a diagnostic criterion, for making judgment whether a lexical item or a clause pattern is ergative or not.

The pseudo-effective voice (2b) is different from the other two in that it does not necessarily relate to others through the agnate relation. It can be taken as a syntactic construction of ergativity, that is, if the sole direct participant may fill in the post-verbal position, the whole pattern expresses ergative meaning. Lexical items falling into this position may express ergative meaning, though they do not necessarily express this meaning when they occur elsewhere. Therefore we argue that it is the pattern as such that are ergative. This point will be further developed in Sect. 4.2.3.

The ergative model emphasizes the *cause-&-effect* aspect of processes in contrast to the *deed-&-extension* one in the transitive model (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 340). The two models complement one another, and they are favored and foregrounded variedly across registers. For example, in English the transitive model is favored in daily narrative texts while the ergative one is preferred in scientific registers. They embody different generalizations about the flux of experience, in accordance with different situation types (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 337, 347).

Though the terms and approaches adopted are different, there is no unsurpassable divide between the typological approach and the functional approach to ergativity (cf. Davidse 1998). For one thing, the morphological distinction between ergative and accusative languages is to be associated with semantics and function (e.g., Dixon

1979, 1994; Larson 1981), and semantic/functional differentiation is significant only when it finds support in morphological and structural distinctions. For another, when confronting those languages that do not show much morphological change, it will be more feasible to start from semantics and function to recognize the ergative/transitive patterns and find out how they are realized in form. What's more, as Dixon admits, there are no pure ergative languages; most are mixed. In such cases, different semantic factors, including animacy, definiteness, person, etc., are believed to be functional in motivating the choice of the ergative or the accusative paradigm (see Sect. 4.4 for further discussion).

In SFL, lexis and grammar are posited as constituting the two ends of a continuum of delicacy: lexis is the most delicate grammar (Halliday 1961, 2008; Hasan 1987). Ergativity may be expressed in lexis and/or grammar. For example, in English, the choice between the intransitive and transitive usage of such lexical items as *break*, *open*, *wake*, illustrates the alternation between non-ergative and ergative patterns (Halliday 1967a, b, 1968; Davidse 1992, 1998; cf. Dixon 1979: 68). On the other hand, the choice between intransitive and transitive usage of such lexical items as *fight*, *eat*, *follow*, *answer*, revolves around the actor-action relation, typical of the transitive model. That is, we can tell whether a lexical item can be used in the transitive or ergative model by testing it against the middle and effective patterns in these two systems ((1) and (2)). At the syntactic end, the pseudo-effective pattern is typically ergative for reasons that will be set out in the following section.

Studies on ergativity in Chinese are mainly inspired and influenced by the Unaccusative Hypothesis (Perlmutter 1978) and Dixon's typological studies. Zhou (1990) discusses ergativity in Chinese syntax in terms of government and binding, claiming that Chinese has both unergative (accusative) and ergative-type structures. Huang (2007) extends the unaccusative–unergative distinction from intransitive, through transitive, to ditransitive verbs. Jin and Wang (2014) recognize four types of verbs, i.e., absolutive vs. ergative, intransitive vs. transitive, and four types of argument accordingly, i.e., absolutive, ergative, subject, and object. The advantage of such a classification, they argue, is that they can better account for the existence of the VO and OV orders in the language. There are also studies concentrating on ergativity in Chinese as manifest in the verb-complement construction (see Sect. 4.2.2), e.g., Liu (2006), Liu and Wang (2009), Wang et al. (2009), Shen and Sybesma (2012), and on the mixed nature of Chinese syntax, thus depicting Chinese as a split ergative language (Ye and Pan 2017). Zeng (2009) is a monograph focusing on ergative verbs in Chinese by proposing three criteria to make judgment whether a verb is ergative or not. She also discusses the patterns that ergative verbs typically fall in. However, she does not explore the semantic features of these verbs and their patterns though she works within the SFL framework. She does not cover other lexico-grammatical means which may be employed to realize the ergative function. All in all, most of these studies are interested in how ergativity is exhibited in Chinese with reference to typological studies, without presenting a holistic picture in relation to other features or patterns within the language. What's more, few explore the semantic features of ergativity, not to say how they can be related to the formal/structural features and how these are related to the system of transitivity.

In this study, we will investigate the ergative features of the Chinese language within the SFL framework. This framework posits a natural relation between meaning/function and form and offers two alternative routes of investigation: We can start from form to explore what meaning is expressed, thus offering a functional explanation for the form. Otherwise, we can start from meaning to investigate how it is realized through form, thus explicating the natural relationship between them. We adopt the second route in this study on the following counts: First, there is an established definition of ergativity in the SFL literature, which can be used as a convenient and workable starting point. Second, being semantic and functional, this starting point will facilitate cross-linguistic comparison (which will be made, e.g., to English at least, explicitly or implicitly throughout) (Song 2001, 2018). Third, as mentioned above, Chinese is a language which does not show much morphological change. For example, among the major syntactic means are word order and syntactic patterns, to which too many meanings and functions are associated. Thus, it is impracticable and unworthwhile to start from formal features. Indeed, researchers are often at a loss as to which are the worthwhile formal features to work with.

Thus, our investigation will be more oriented to semantics and function and how these may find expression in form, e.g., in syntactic pattern, word order, etc. Halliday's formulation of transitivity and ergativity is mainly based on English. His description shows that ergativity is mainly expressed through lexical means. That is, it is the idiosyncratic features of individual words which condition the choice of (1) vs. (2) above, which in turn give rise to the transitive or the ergative interpretation. There are no syntactic patterns that are uniquely ergative (Halliday 1967a, b, 1968, 1985, 1994; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004, 2014). In SFL, transitivity and ergativity are seen as alternative perspectives to and different interpretations of the same state of affairs. However, as our analysis will show, Chinese illustrates a language type in which ergativity is expressed all the way along the lexico-grammar continuum. The ergative and the transitive models may be combined such that both of their nuclei may co-occur, and they may be interwoven into and in cooperation with each other in expressing the experiential meaning.

In Sect. 4.2, we first examine how ergativity is expressed in the lexico-grammar of Chinese, by starting with the lexical items, through groups, to syntactic constructions. Throughout, reference will be made to the transitivity system, both for explication purposes and because of the fact that the two systems are often interwoven into each other and are in cooperation with each other. In addition to the general semantic feature of *cause-&-effect*, there may be other semantic features that are shared by the ergative expressions. We will probe into such semantic features in Sect. 4.3. Section 4.4 will show how the two systems of transitivity and ergativity interact with and complement each other. We conclude the whole study in Sect. 4.5, by summing up its major findings and by discussing its implications.

4.2 Ergativity in Chinese Grammar

As mentioned above, our orientation is from meaning to form. That is, we start from the established definition of the ergative meaning to explore its formal realizations in Chinese. We will first set out the reference frames and criteria to recognize and describe those ergative expressions. These include ergative verbs, verb-resultative groups, and syntactic patterns, which will be surveyed in turn in the following subsections.

4.2.1 Ergative Verbs

Lü (1987) raises the issue of ergativity in Chinese by giving the following well-known examples:

(3)	a	*zhōngguó*	*nǚlán*	***dà-shèng***	*náncháoxiānduì*
		China	woman basket-ball team	great-win	South Korea team

'Chinese Women's Basket-ball Team won a great victory over South Korean Team.' (中国女篮大胜南朝鲜队。)

b	*zhōngguó*	*nǚlán*	***dà-shèng***	
	China	woman basket-ball team	great-win	

'Chinese Women's Basket-ball Team won a great victory.' (中国女篮大胜。)

(4)	a	*zhōngguó*	*nǚlán*	***dà-bài***	*náncháoxiānduì*
		China	woman basket-ball team	great-defeat	South Korea team

'Chinese Women's Basket-ball Team defeated South Korean Team utterly.' (中国女篮 大败南朝鲜队。)

b		*náncháoxiānduì*	***dà-bài***
		South Korea team	great-defeat

'South Korea team was defeated utterly.' (南朝鲜队大败。)

(3a) and (4a) are both of the linear sequence: NG1 + V + NG2. However, the two nominal groups are related to the verbs, *shèng* and *bài* differently. In the former, *shèng* is oriented to NG1, i.e., *zhōngguó nǚlán*, while in the latter *bài* is oriented to *náncháoxiānduì*, as explicated in (3b) and (4b) respectively. Such differences can be attributed to the two verbs. *Shèng* fits in well with transitive model, while *bài* is suited to the ergative model. To bring out such differences, we apply transitivity analysis to (3a, b, Table 4.1), and ergativity analysis to (4a, b, Table 4.2, cf. Halliday 1994: 164):

Table 4.1 Transitivity analysis of (3a, b)

Actor	Process	Goal	Actor	Process
zhōngguó nǚlán	*dà shèng*	*náncháoxiānduì*	*zhōngguó nǚlán*	*dà shèng*

Table 4.2 Ergativity analysis of (4a, b)

Agent	Process	Medium	Medium	Process
zhōngguó nǚlán	*dà bài*	*náncháoxiānduì*	*náncháoxiānduì*	*dà bài*

Table 4.3 Ergativity Analysis of (9) and (10)

Agent	Process	Medium	Medium	Process
tā	*kū-hóng-le*	*yǎnjīng*	*yǎnjīng*	*kū-hóng-le*
tā	*róu-zhǒng-le*	*yǎnjīng*	*yǎnjīng*	*róu-zhǒng-le*

Table 4.1 shows that the semantic role of *zhōngguó nǚlán* remains Actor in both the transitive and the intransitive clauses. In both, Actor and Process constitute the nucleus, which may or may not extend to a Goal (i.e., the *deed-&-extension* model). Table 4.2 shows that Medium is the essential participant role which combines with the Process to construe the event. This may or may not be brought about by an external force (i.e., the *cause-&-effect* model). Verbs of the former type are called **transitive verbs**, and those of the latter type are called **ergative verbs**.

In order to tell whether a verb is ergative or not, there should be some criteria. We follow and modify Zeng (2009: 115–116), who proposes the following three diagnostic patterns, though the way we interpret and apply them is different from hers:

(5) a. There exists an agnate relation between 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and 'NG2 ^ V.'[3]

b. The verb may occur in the pattern 'NG1 ^ *shǐ* (使) ^ NG2 ^ V.'

c. The verb in the pattern 'NG2 ^ V' may take reflexives as its adjunct, that is, 'NG2 ^ *zìjǐ* (自己) ^ V-le(了)' ('NG2 V by itself') is acceptable

Zeng (2009: 117) takes (5a) as obligatory, and (5b) and (5c) as optional conditions, for they are mutually exclusive. We find that (5b) is oriented to the ergative pattern 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2,' to explicate the causative meaning of V, while (5c) is oriented to the non-ergative pattern 'NG2 ^ V,' to express the meaning that the event denoted by 'NG2 ^ V' may happen by itself (see (1) and (2) in Sect. 4.1). It seems logical to say that (5b) and (5c) are mutually exclusive, on the grounds that an event is either caused by some external agent or it happens by itself. However, if we study the ergative model as elaborated in SFL (see Sect. 4.1), and be mindful of the basic nature of ergativity,

[3] List of abbreviations: A = agent, BA = *ba* (把), CLS = classifier, DE = *de*, NG = nominal group, O = object, PEF = perfective, PL = plural, PRG = progressive, S = subject, VG = verbal group.

we will find these three criteria should be considered simultaneously, to secure the ergative status of a verb. This is because: (1) the ergative pattern 'NG1 + V + NG2' coincides with the transitive pattern, and the non-ergative pattern of 'NG2 + V' coincides with the intransitive pattern. The agnate shift between them guarantees that the semantic role of NG2 remains the same in the two patterns; and (2) 'NG2 + V' is ambiguous, open to two interpretations. That is, the event may be caused by some external cause (i.e., an agent), or it may happen by itself. (5b) exhibits the first interpretation, and (5c) the second. For example, the clause *mén kāi-le* (门开了, door open-PEF, 'the door opened.'), may mean that some external agent caused the door to open, e.g., somebody opened the door; or it opened by itself. Thus, (5b) and (5c) help explicate the two interpretations of 'NG2 + V' respectively. Particularly, (5c) is necessary because it helps to tell 'NG2 + V' from such clauses as *jī bù chī-le* (鸡不吃了, chicken NEG-eat-PEF, 'somebody would not eat chicken anymore.'),[4] which is easy to be confused with *mén kāi-le*, for both share the 'NG ^ V' pattern. Thus, all the three criteria should be considered in recognizing ergative verbs.

With respect to these three criteria, we examine all the 1223 entries listed in *Dictionary of Verbs and Their Usages* (Meng et al. 1999) and yield 122 ergative verbs. (See Appendix.)

It should be noted that 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and 'NG2 ^ V' are agnate and that the fact it is possible to change one into the other does not mean that they are synonymous. Indeed, they are different in meaning, as shown by (6a) and (6b):

(6)	a	*tā*	***kāi-le***	*mén.* (他开了门)	b	*mén*	***kāi-le.*** (门开了)
		he	open-PEF	door		door	open-PEF
		'He opened the door.'				'The door opened.'	

(6b) is more oriented to result and state, i.e., the door is open, without being concerned with what/who caused it to open. It does not take any expressions of intention. Compare (6c) with (6b):

(6)	c	**mén*	***gùyì/zhèng zhǔnbèi***	*kāi*
		door	intentional/is about to	open
		'The door is about to open/has the intention to open.'(*门故意/正准备开。)		

Apart from expressing the result and state meaning (i.e., the door is open), (6a) also expresses the causative meaning, that is, *tā* is the causer/agent of the state of

[4] This represents one of the most common topic-comment patterns in Chinese, with the goal of the process occurs clause-initially, functioning as the topic.

the door's being open. In addition, 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' may express action, especially when NG1 is human. Thus, (6a) also denotes his action of opening the door, and expressions of intention can be added to it:

(6) d *tā* ***gùyì/zhèng zhǔnbèi*** *kāi* *mén*
he intentional/is about to open door
'He deliberately/is about to open(ed) the door.' (他故意/正准备开门。)

However, intentional/actional meaning is not inherent to 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2,' as can be seen when NG1 is not human:

(7) *sīyǒuhuà* ***suōxiǎo****-le* *gōnggòng* *jīgòu-de* *guīmó*
privatization decrease-PEF public institution-DE scale
zēngqiáng*-le* *huólì*
strengthen-LE vitality
'Privatization decreased the scale of public institutions and increased its vitality.'
(私有化缩小了公共机构的规模,增强了活力。)

There are two ergative verbs in (7), i.e., *suōxiǎo* (缩小) and *zēngqiáng* (增强). They are used in the 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' pattern, to express the causative meaning. That is, privatization caused the scale of public institutions to decrease and vitality to increase. They do not express intention in the present case, because *sīyǒuhuà* (私有化) is non-human. This shows that the causative meaning is inherent to the 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' pattern, though the intentional/actional meaning is not. Both the transitive model and the ergative model share the patterns of 'NG1 + V + NG2' and 'NG + V.' It is the verb that is responsible for the ergative or transitive reading. If a verb occurs in these two patterns and expresses causation, it is an ergative verb.

Some verbs are not ergative by themselves. However, when they combine with another resultative element, the combination may be ergative. This will be discussed below.

4.2.2 Verb-Resultative Groups

In Chinese, as in English (Halliday 1985, 1994), phrases and groups belong to the rank intermediate between words and clauses. At this rank, ergativity is typically expressed by verb-resultative groups (VRGs).[5] These belong to the verb-complement groups, in which the complement, typically realized by verbal groups, adjectival groups, and

[5] It is found, in typological studies (Comrie 1989: 119), that resultative constructions, which typically denotes a change of state, are usually ergatively encoded, in that the change is necessarily attributed to the S when the predicate is intransitive, and typically to O when the predicate is transitive (see Sect. 4.1).

prepositional phrases, denotes the result and state of the action expressed by the verbal head before it (Zhu 1982: 125; Xing 1997: 97; Shi 2003: 77, 85–86). As with all kinds of phrases and groups in Chinese, verb-resultative groups are open-ended.

It should be noted that neither the verb nor the resultative is ergative by itself. It is the VRG as such that expresses this meaning. Indeed, the verb is typically actional, and it may be transitive or intransitive. For example, the verb *xǐ* (洗, wash, 'wash') is transitive; it can be followed by many different resultatives. Apart from *xǐ-gānjìng* (洗干净, wash-clean, 'wash … clean'), we may have *xǐ-zāng* (洗脏, wash-dirty, 'be dirty as a result of washing'), *xǐ-pò* (洗破, wash-worn out, 'be worn out as a result of washing'), *xǐ-diū* (洗丢, wash-lost, 'be lost after washing'). We can even say:

(8) a *bǎ* *wǒ* ***xǐ-hútú-le***
BA I wash-confused- PEF
'I was confused as a result of washing.'(把我洗糊涂了)

b *bǎ* *tā* ***xǐ-kū-le***
BA he wash-cry- PEF
'He was made to cry because of the washing.' (把他洗哭了)

Both *xǐ-hútú* and *xǐ-kū* in (8) are ergative; they can be used in both 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and 'NG2 ^ V.' As another example, *kū* (哭, cry) is intransitive. However, it may combine with *yǎ* (哑, hoarse) to form the ergative VRG *kūyǎ*, as in *kū-yǎ-le sǎngzǐ* (哭哑了嗓子, cry-hoarse-PEF throat, 'cry one's throat hoarse').

As with ergative verbs, we can use the patterns 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and 'NG2 ^ V' as the diagnostic device to explicate the ergative meaning. For example, the two VRGs *kū-hóng* and *róu-zhǒng* may be used in both patterns:

(9) a *tā* ***kū-hóng-le*** *yǎnjīng* →
she cry-red- PEF eye
'She cried her eyes red.'(她哭红了眼睛。)

b *yǎnjīng* ***kū-hóng-le***
eye cry-red- PEF
'(Her) eyes were red as a result of crying.' (眼睛哭红了。)

(10) a *tā* ***róu-zhǒng-le*** *yǎnjīng* →
she rub-swollen- PEF eye
'She rubbed her eyes swollen.' (她 揉 肿了眼睛。)

b *yǎnjīng* ***róu-zhǒng-le***
eye rub-swollen-PEF
'(Her) eyes are swollen as a result of rubbing.' (眼睛揉 肿了。)

Table 4.4 Ergativity Analysis of (16a,b)

Circumstance	Process	Medium	Medium	Process	Circumstance
the car	*broke*	*an axle*	*an axle*	*broke*	*in the car*

These can be analyzed in terms of ergativity as (Table 4.3):

Different from ergative verbs, ergative VRGs allow the causative interpretation both when it occurs in the 'NG1 ^ VRG ^ NG2' and in the 'NG2 ^ VRG' pattern.[6] In the former, the cause/agent (which is also the actor of the verb, e.g., *kū* and *róu* in 9 and 10) of the result (e.g., *hóng* and *zhǒng* in 9 and 10) is explicitly expressed, while in the latter it is implied due to the presence of the actional verb, which is indicative of the cause of the result. (9b) expresses the meaning of '(her) eyes were red as a result of crying,' and (10b) the meaning of '(her) eyes are swollen as a result of rubbing,' though the actor of crying or rubbing is not expressed. In this sense, the so-called non-ergative pattern is basically ergative when VRGs occur in it.

Thus, causative meaning and resultative meaning are both expressed by ergative VRGs due to the presence of the verb and the resultative and their different semantic orientations (Lu 1997). The verb mainly contributes to the former and it is oriented to NG1 (the Agent, though it may be implied and not expressed), e.g., *kū* and *róu* in (9) and (10), which are oriented to *tā* in both cases. The resultative contributes to the latter and it is oriented to NG2, e.g., *hóng* and *zhǒng* in (9) and (10), which are oriented to *yǎnjīng*. As is explicated in Sect. 4.1, the basic meaning of the ergative model is the *cause-&-effect* relation. This semantic feature is even more evident in the case of VRGs: that is, 'NG1 ^ Verb' is responsible for the cause, and 'NG2 ^ Resultative' for the effect. Thus the 'NG1 + VRG + NG2' pattern expresses both cause and effect, and the causative relation between them. For example, (9c) and (10c) can be derived from (9a) and (10a):

(9) c *tā kū* ('she cried') causes *yǎnjīng hóng-le* ('her eyes turned red')

(10) c *tā róu* ('she rubbed') causes *yǎnjīng zhǒng-le* ('her eyes were swollen')

The 'NG2 + VRG' pattern focuses on the result and effect, though cause is still present due to the presence of the verb in VRG, as illustrated by (9b) and (10b).

If the resultative is not oriented to NG2, VRG cannot enter the 'NG2 ^ VRG' pattern, then it does not express ergative meaning, e.g.,

(11) a *tā* ***hèn-tòu-le*** *zhànzhēng.* →

he hate-extremely-PEF war

[6] Please note that when ergative verbs occur in the 'NG2 ^ V' pattern, it is open to two interpretations. See Sect. 4.1.

‘He hates wars extremely.’ (他恨透了战争。)

b **zhànzhēng* ***hèn-tòu-le***
war hate-extremely-PEF
(*战争恨透了。)

In (11), the verb-complement group *hèn-tòu* cannot enter the ‘NG2 ^ VRG’ pattern as illustrated by (11b), because the complement is not oriented to NG2, *zhànzhēng* in the present case. Rather it is oriented to the verb. The whole group behaves like a single transitive verb.

Similar to ergative verbs, VRGs may express both actional and causative meaning at the same time. The former meaning is typically present when NG1 is human. This is not inherent to the ergative meaning of VRG, though the causative meaning is. Different from ergative verbs, these two meanings are attributable to different elements within VRG. The verb and its Actor (i.e., NG1) are responsible for the action and the cause, and the resultative and the Medium (i.e., NG2) are responsible for the effect/result. For example, intentional expressions such as *gùyì* (故意, ‘intentional/deliberate’) can be added to (9a) and (10a) to have *tā gùyì kū-hóng-le yǎnjīng* (她故意哭红了眼睛, ‘she intentionally cried her eyes red.’) and *tā gùyì róu-zhǒng-le yǎnjīng* (她故意揉肿了眼睛, ‘she deliberately rubbed her eyes swollen.’), but not to (9b) and (10b) to have **yǎnjīng gùyì kū-hóng-le* and **yǎnjīng gùyì róu-zhǒng-le.* If NG1 is non-human, actional and deliberate meaning will be absent, as in

(12)

zhè-gè	*chéngshì-de*	*měi-jǐng*	*céng*	***zuì-dǎo**-le*
this-CLS	city-DE	beautiful-scenery	once	be drunk-fallen-LE
wúshù-de	*guanguāng*	*yóukè*	*hé*	*láifǎngzhě*
countless-DE	sight-see	tourist	and	visitors

‘Many tourists and visitors were carried away by the beauty of the city.’ (这个城市的美景曾醉倒了无数的观光游客和来访者。)

In (12), the whole clause does not express the intentional/actional meaning, though the causative meaning is present. Such intentional words as *gùyì* cannot be added to the clause.

Sybesma (1992, 1999), Sybesma and Shen (2006), and Shen and Sybesma (2010) analyze VRGs in terms of small clause. Essentially, their position is that the verb in VRGs expresses an event that is atelic, which is followed by a complement clause consisting of a subject (i.e., NG2) and a predicate (i.e., the resultative). The small clause defines the scope and end point of the event as denoted by the verb, thus rendering the whole VRG telic. To put it simply, the verb expresses event, and the resultative defines its result and end point. The whole VRG expresses a complete event, containing both an event and its result. It follows naturally, that, of the two

elements, the resultative is the more salient meaning of the construction, because the verb expresses the presuppositional meaning and the resultative the asserted meaning. That is, the endpoint of an action/event presupposes its occurrence and duration. Similarly, Li (1984, 1992) shows that, semantically, the verb in VRGs is more like the modifying and subordinate element, with the resultative as its head. This is evident in the 'NG2 ^ VRG' pattern, where the verb is backgrounded, and the assertive focus falls on the resultative, e.g., *yīfú (lín)-shī-le* (衣服(淋)湿了, clothes (drench)-wet- PEF, 'the clothes were drenched.'), *háizǐ (xià)-kū-le* (孩子(吓)哭了, child (frighten)-cry- PEF, 'the child was frightened to cry'). In both examples, the semantic weight falls on the resultative, i.e., *shī* and *kū*, rather than on the verb, i.e., *lín* and *xià*.

In the above VRGs, the verb and the resultative are both mono-syllabic, and they combine to form disyllabic groups. This conforms to the general disyllabic pattern of Chinese words.Thus they behave like single words and verbs (Lü 1963; Feng 1997; Dong 2002, 2016). Further away from the lexical end along the lexico-grammar cline are those VRGs, whose inner structure are more flexible. The resultative may be realized by more complex elements than just verbs or adjectives; and the VRG may be used discontinuously. The following are three examples:

(13) a

tā	***xià-le***	***wǒ***	***yī***	***tiào***
he	scare-PEF	I	one	jump

'He scared me and I jumped.'/ 'He scared me and I was taken aback.' (他吓了我一跳。)

b

wǒ	***xià-le***	***yī***	***tiào***
I	scare-PEF	one	jump

'I was scared to jump.'/ 'I was taken aback.' (我吓了一跳。)

(14) a

nà	*chǎng*	*jiēlìsài*	***pǎo-de***	***háizǐ-men***	***shàngqìbújiēxiàqì***
that	CLS	relay	run-DE	child-PL	be out of breath

'The children ran so hard in the relay that they were out of breath.' (那场接力赛跑得孩子们上气不接下气。)

b

háizi-men	***pǎo-de***	***shàngqìbújiēxiàqì***
child-PL	run-DE	be out of breath

'The children ran so hard that they were out of breath.' (孩子们跑得上气不接下气。)

(15) a

nà-tàng	*chē*	***děng-de***	***yī-jiā***	***rén***	***xīnjíhuǒliáo***
that-CLS	bus	wait-DE	one-family	people	burnt with anxiety

'The family were burnt with anxiety when waiting for the bus.' (那趟车等得一家人心急火燎。)

b

yī-jiā	***rén***	***děng-de***	***xīnjíhuǒliáo***
one-family	people	wait-DE	burnt with anxiety

'The family were burnt with anxiety when waiting.' (一家人等得心急火燎。)

All the VRGs (in bold) in the above examples conform to the syntactic and semantic features discussed above. They can occur both in the ergative and non-ergative pattern, and the verb and the resultative are responsible for the cause and the effect meaning respectively. They are different from disyllabic VRG in that the structure of the resultative is more complex and weightier. In the ergative pattern, the causative relation is more evident, with NG2 occurring between the verb and the resultative within the VRG, as shown by (13a), (14a), and (15a) above, thus rendering the cause and the effect more recognizable than when they are not separated. The former is realized by *xià*, *pǎo*, and *děng* (and their agents), and the latter by *(wǒ) yī tiào*, (*háizǐ-men) shàngqìbújiēxiàqì, (yī-jiā rén) xīnjíhuǒliáo*, respectively, with NG2s in the brackets. The verb and the resultative are separated because the latter is more complex and weightier and carries more new information than NG2, and it occurs after NG2. That is, the agent of *xià* is expressed as *tā* in (13a):

(13) c *tā* ***xià*** ('he frightened (me)') causes ***wǒ yī tiào*** ('I was taken aback.')

(14a) and (15a) are different from (13a) in that an additional layer of cause and effect is involved. At the innermost layer are the nuclei, (*háizǐ-men*) *shàngqìbújiēxiàqì* (14a) and *yī-jiā rén xīnjíhuǒliáo* (15a); in the middle layer are *háizǐ-men pǎo* and *yī-jiā rén děng* these are the causes of nuclear events and effects of the outmost layer causes, that is, *nà-chǎng jiēlìsài* and *nà-tàng chē* in (14a) and (15a) respectively:

(14c)	*nà chǎng jiēlìsài*	causes	*háizǐ-men pǎo*	causes	*háizǐ-men shàngqìbújiēxiàqì*
(15c)	*nà-tàng chē*	causes	*yī-jiā rén děng*	causes	*yī-jiā rén xīnjíhuǒliáo*

In the non-ergative pattern, NG2 occurs before the VRG, as in (13b), (14b), and (15b) above, with the cause of the resultative presupposed, though the agent is not explicitly expressed. For example, from (13b), it can be known that (*wǒ*) *yī tiào* ((我)一跳) is the result of my being scared; from (14b) it can be known that (*háizǐ-men*) *shàngqìbújiēxiàqì* ((孩子们)上气不接下气) is the result of their running; and from (15b) it can be known that *(yī jiā rén) xīn jíhuǒliáo* ((一家人)心急火燎) is the result of their waiting.

Thus, despite the structural differences between ergative verbs, disyllabic VRGs, and the more flexible and extended VRGs, VRGs are ergative, because they occur in both the ergative and non-ergative patterns, and the causative meaning is invariably expressed, irrespective of the presence/absence of NG1.

4.2.3 Ergative Syntactic Patterns

4.2.3.1 The Pseudo-Effective Pattern

In the above discussion, we examine verbs and VRGs by considering whether and how they fit in with the two agnate patterns: 'NG2 + V' and 'NG1 + V + NG2.' If a verb or a VRG can enter these two patterns, it is ergative. These two patterns correspond to (2a) and (2c) respectively. From the perspective of ergativity, NG2 is the more central participant, which combines with the process to express the event. NG1 denotes the agent/instigator of the event; it is optional. The nucleus of the ergativity pattern is effect, or rather, the event denoting effect. This is expressed by the configuration of 'NG2 ^ V.' Since both transitivity and ergativity share the pattern 'NG + V + (NG),' it is the individual verb/VRG that gives rise to different interpretations. Thus we take individual verbs, the VRG construction, rather than the pattern 'NG + V + (NG),' as being ergative.

Davidse (1998: 102) calls (2c) and (2a) ergative and non-ergative respectively, depending on whether the agent/instigator of the event is explicitly expressed. Here, then, arises the question: how is the pattern of (2b) (pseudo-effective in Davidse's terms) related to ergativity. On the surface, (2b) resembles (2c) in that both share the configuration of 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2.' However, they are different in that NG1 in (2b) is neither a direct participant nor the instigator of the process. Rather, it is more like a circumstantial element, denoting the setting of the process, as illustrated by the English example *the car broke an axle* in (2b). In this case, *the car* is more like a possessor, the whole to which the part *an axle* belongs. There exists an agnate relation between:

(16) a. *The car broke an axle* b. *An axle broke in the car*

These can be analyzed as Table 4.4.

Unlike NG1 in (2c), which denotes the agent/instigator of the event, NG1 in (2b) does not express this meaning. For example, (16) does not express the meaning 'the car causes the axle to break.' The change from (16a) to (16b) explicates the circumstantial nature of NG1. Thus Davidse (1998: 102) terms it **setting**. The following are comparable Chinese examples:

(17) a *gébì* *diàn-lǐ* ***zǒu-le*** *yī-bāng* *kè*
next door guesthouse-in leave-PEF one-CLS guest
'A group of guests left the guesthouse next door.' (隔壁店里走了一帮客。)

b *lù-biān* *yòu* ***fān-le*** *yī-liàng* *chē*
road-side again overturn-PEF one-CLS vehicle
'There is another vehicle overturned on the roadside.' (路边又翻了一辆车。)

c *dì-shàng* *yòu* ***suì-le*** *yī-gè* *wǎn*
ground-on again break-PEF one-CLS bowl
'There is another bowl broken on the ground.' (地上又碎了一个碗。)

d *Wáng Miǎn* ***sǐ-le*** *fùqīn*
Wang Mian die-PEF father
'Wang Mian's father died.' (王冕死了父亲。)

e *shān-shàng* ***zhù-zhe*** *yī-hù* *rénjiā*
mountain-on live-PRG one-CLS family
'There is a family living in the mountain.'(山上住着一户人家。)

f *hēibǎn-shàng* ***xiě-zhe*** *jǐ-gè* *zì*
blackboard-onwrite-PRG write-PRG several-CLS character
'There are several characters written on the blackboard.' (黑板上写着几个字。)

g *qiángtóu-shàng* ***chā-zhe*** *yī-miàn* *hóngqí*
wall-on plant-PRG one-CLS red flag
'There is a red flag planted on the wall.' (墙头上插着一面红旗。)

What the clauses in (17) have in common is that the clause-initial NG1 (underlined) is locational, as the indicated by the locational words *lǐ* (里, in 17a), *biān* (边, in 17b), and *shàng* (上, in 17c, e, f, g).[7] This makes their circumstantial nature more evident. The verbal group (in bold) is followed by the perfective marker *-le* or the progressive marker *-zhe,* indicating that they express results/states. The clause-final NG2 (wave-underlined) is the sole direct participant and the Medium of the process. It combines with the process to form the nucleus of the event. In typological terms (e.g., Dixon 1979), it may be S (the sole participant of intransitive verbs) as in (17a–e), or O (the object of transitive verbs) as in (17f, g). It configures with the process (realized by the verbal group) to express the event, and NG1 denotes the circumstance where the event takes place.

We recognize this pattern as ergative not only because it allows the agnate shift as shown in (16), but also because S and O are the sole participant in the process. They occur as the Medium after the verbal group, which is the position for O.

In Chinese, word order is one of the major means to encode grammatical relations. The basic word order is AVO/SO. This is the order characteristic of accusative languages. If the VS/O order is adopted, ergativity will emerge (Dixon 1994: 91). Chinese existentials, which can be schematized as 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and which are exemplified by (17), belong to this pattern (Zeng 2009: 297). Wang and Zhou (2014a, b) propose the notion of event-existential to account for such clauses, with ergativity as one of its central meanings (cf., Wang 2016, 2021). Both transitive and intransitive verbs may enter this pattern, though they only keep the Medium as its sole participant in this construction. The former include: *fàng* (放, 'place'), *guà* (挂, 'hang'), *xiě* (写, 'write'), *tiē* (贴, 'paste'), *diào* (吊, 'hang'), *lā* (拉, 'pull'), *jià* (架, 'erect'), etc., and the latter include: *zhù* (住, 'live'), *zuò* (坐, 'sit'), *tǎng* (躺, 'lie'), *piāo* (漂, 'float'), *fēi* (飞, 'fly'), *lì* (立, 'stand'), *piāo* (飘, 'flutter'), etc.

When they occur in the pseudo-effective pattern (i.e., 2b), the verbal group expresses state or result meaning, but not intentional actions (Li 1984; Nie 1987; Song 1991). Intentionality is inherently associated with action verbs; it is incompatible with this pattern. And the distinction between transitive and intransitive and that between S and O is blurred. The state and result meaning as denoted by 'V + NG2' (in this order) become centralized. The post-verb particle *-le*, which otherwise denotes completion of dynamic actions, denotes states as a result of the completion of the action. For example, (17a) is concerned with the result of guests' having left the guesthouse; (17b) that of the vehicle being overturned, etc. The post-verb particle *-zhe*, which otherwise denotes dynamic going-on actions, denotes states. For example, (17e) describes the states of a family living in the mountain, (17f) that of the characters' being written on the blackboard, and (17 g) a red flag being planted on the wall. Thus, the (2b) pattern in Chinese, as exemplified by (17) describes result and state, without being concerned with their causes.

It is interesting to note that when the above transitive and intransitive verbs occur in the 'NG1 + V + NG2' and 'NG ^ V' pattern respectively, they do not express

[7] In this sense, (17d) is different from others. (17d) is more like (16a) in that NG1, *Wáng Miǎn* is related to NG2, *fùqīn*, as its possessor. Thus it is also circumstantial.

ergativity, but transitivity. This shows that such verbs are not ergative. It is the pseudo-effective pattern that gives rise to ergativity. Thus, we call it the ergative syntactic pattern, in contrast to individual lexical items, i.e., verbs and VRGs that express this meaning. For example,

(18)	a	*tā*	*zài*	*hēibǎn-shàng*	***xiě-le***	*jǐ-gè*	*zì*.(cf., 17f)
		he	at	blackboard-onwrite-PEF	write-PEF	several-CLS	character
		'He wrote several characters on the blackboard.' (他在黑板上写了几个字。)					
	b	*kèrén*	***zǒu-chū-le***	*gébì*	*nà-jiā*	*diàn.* (cf., 17a)	
		guest	walk-out-PEF	next door	that-CLS	shop	
		'The guest walked out the shop next door.'(客人走出了隔壁那家店。)					

When the transitive verb *xiě* is used in the 'NG1 + V + NG2' pattern as in (18a), it denotes an action; and intentional words such as *gùyì* (故意, 'deliberate, intentional') can be added before it. It does not express the *cause-&-effect* meaning typically associated with (2c) where the verb is ergative. That is, (18a) does not mean that he caused the characters to be written on the blackboard. Please note that the intentional/actional meaning is absent if *xiě* occurs in the pseudo-effective pattern of (2b) as exemplified by (17f). Similarly, when the intransitive verb *zǒu* occurs in the 'NG + V' pattern as in (18b), *kèrén* is the actor. Intentional words such as *gùyì* (故意, 'intentional') can be added. It does not express the effect meaning typically expressed by (2c) when the verb is ergative. However, when *zǒu* occurs in pseudo-effective pattern of (2b) as exemplified by (17a), it expresses an effect (i.e., a result/a state) without being concerned with its cause (cf. Zeng 2009: 304; Gu 1994). Neither *xiě* (transitive) nor *zǒu* (intransitive) takes any intentional words when they occur in the pseudo-effective pattern. This shows that, though both are typical actional verbs, they express ergative meaning when they occur in the pseudo-effective pattern of (2b). It can be said that it is the pattern that brings about this meaning (Goldberg 1995). Thus, it can be called an ergative syntactic pattern.[8]

4.2.3.2 The *Bǎ*-Construction

Generally, the *bǎ*-construction is described as a construction for introducing O of transitive verbs, though cases where *bǎ* introduces S of intransitive verbs are also attested (Zhu 1982: 185, 187). This syntactic pattern also expresses ergativity (Frei 1957; Li and Yip 1979), especially when it co-occurs with VRGs (see above), as in:

[8] Another feature showing the ergative nature of this pattern is that the NG occurring after the verb is characteristically indefinite (Chao 1968/2004: 252; Zhu 1982: 97), e.g., (17). This bears cross-linguistic evidence as described by Dixon 1994: 91–92). See Sect. 4.1.

(19) a *tā* ***bǎ*** ***guānzhòng*** *chàng-pǎo-le*
he BA audience sing-run-PEF
'He caused the audience to leave by singing'/ 'His singing drove the audience away.' (他把观众唱跑了。)

(20) a *wǒ* ***bǎ*** ***xiézi*** *zǒu-pò-le*
I BA shoe walk-worn out-PEF
'My shoes are worn out as a result of walking.' (我把鞋子走破了。)

(21) ***bǎ*** ***gè*** ***Qíngwén*** *jiě-jie* *méi-le*
BA CLS Qingwen sister-REP disappear-PEF
'Sister Qingwen passed away.' (把个晴雯姐姐没了。)

(22) ***bǎ*** ***gè*** ***fànrén*** *pǎo-le*
BA CLS prisoner run-PEF
'A prisoner ran away.' (把个犯人跑了。)

We describe the *bǎ*-construction as ergative, on the grounds that it conforms to the ergative features both in syntax and in meaning. In syntactic terms, the element introduced by *bǎ* (in bold) is either O as in (19a) and (20a) or S as in (21) and (22) (in bold). Actor does not occur in this position. That is, this is the position for Medium (i.e., O and S). We call the former Type I and the latter Type II *bǎ*-constructions.

Semantically, Type I *bǎ*-construction is one in which the *cause-&-effect* meaning is explicitly expressed.[9] Specifically, NG1 before *bǎ* denotes the agent, and 'NG2 ^ Resultative' the effect. For example, *tā* in (19a) is the agent, and *tā chàng* (他唱, 'he sang') is the cause of ***guānzhòng*** *pǎo-le* (观众跑了, 'the audience ran away'); the latter is the effect (see 9c and 10c). (19a) and (20a) stand in an agnate relation with (19b, c) and (20b, c) respectively.

(19) b *tā* *chàng-pǎo-le* ***guānzhòng***
he sing-run-PEF audience
'He drove the audience away by singing.' (他唱跑了观众。)

c ***guānzhòng*** *chàng-pǎo-le*
audience sing-run-PEF
'The audience left because of the singing.' (观众唱跑了。)

(20) b *wǒ* *zǒu-pò-le* ***xiézi***
I walk-worn out-PEF shoe
'I wore out my shoes by walking.' (我走破了鞋子。)

c ***xiézi*** *zǒu-pò-le*

[9] Indeed, some scholars (e.g., Sybesma 1992; Shen and Sybesma 2012) view the *bǎ*-construction as causative.

shoe walk-worn out-PEF

'The shoes are worn out as a result of walking.' (鞋子走破了。)

This shows that the *bǎ*-construction with VRGs is cognately related to 'NG1 ^ VRG ^ NG2' and 'NG2 ^ VRG.' Thus (9a, b) and (9d), (10a, b) and (10d) are agnate as are (19a), (19b), (20a), (20b), and (19c), (20c).

(9) d *tā* *bǎ* *yǎnjīng* ***kū-hóng-le***

she BA eye cry-red-LE

'She cried her eyes red.'(她把眼睛哭红了。)

(10) d *tā* *bǎ* *yǎnjīng* ***róu-zhǒng-le***

she BA eye rub-swollen-LE

'She rubbed her eyes swollen.' (她把眼睛 揉肿了。)

The differences between the *bǎ*-construction and the 'NG1 ^ VRG ^ NG2' construction lie in: (1) the former expresses the causative relation more explicitly and (2) the focus of the former is on the VRG, particularly the resultative, e.g., *kū-hóng-le* in (9d)[10]; while the latter focuses on NG2, e.g., *yǎnjīng* in (9a). Both the *bǎ*-construction and the 'NG2 ^ VRG' construction lay focus on the clause-final VRG; their difference is that in the former the agent is explicitly expressed, while in the latter it is only implied.

Different from Type I, Type II *bǎ*-construction exclusively expresses the resultative meaning, i.e., the effect in the *cause-&-effect* relation; it is not concerned with its cause. It is incongruent with intentional/actional meaning. For example, intentional expressions such as *gùyì* (故意, 'intentional') cannot be added to before the VRG in (21) and (22). (21) is only to state the fact *Qíngwén jiě-jie méi-le* ('Sister Qingwen passed away.'), and (22) the fact that *fànrén pǎo-le* ('A prisoner ran away.'). They do not indicate or imply the cause of these facts.

In a word, these two types of *bǎ*-construction can be recognized as ergative because they are particularly devoted either to the *cause-&-effect* meaning (Type I) or to the effect (Type II). It should be noted that, as described in Sect. 4.2.2, VRGs are ergative by nature. What is special about the *bǎ*-construction is that the causative meaning is more explicit, with the agent being promoted to the clause-initial position and separated from the verb, and the VRG being highlighted by occupying the clause-final focal position.

[10] Many scholars agree that bare verbs are not informative enough to occupy the clause-final position; they have to take some additional elements, e.g., complements, aspect markers, etc., in order to qualify for this position (Zhu 1982: 185–186; Shi 2003).

4.2.4 Summary

In this section, we first set out two agnate patterns: 1) NG1 ^ VRG ^ NG2 (ergative) and 2) NG2 ^ VRG (non-ergative) and three criteria (see (5)) in order to identify the different kinds of ergativity expressions in Chinese. 122 verbs are yielded from *Dictionary of Verbs and Their Usages* (Meng et al. 1999), which may occur both in the ergative and non-ergative pattern. In the former case, where NG1 is present, causative meaning is explicitly expressed, whereas the cause is unstated in the latter case though the resultative state is expressed. Verb-resultative groups (VRGs) are also recognized as expressive of ergativity. They allow the causative interpretation both when they occur in the ergative and non-ergative patterns, due to the presence of the verb and the resultative.

Since both transitivity and ergativity share the pattern 'NG + V + (NG),' it is the individual verb/VRG that gives rise to different interpretations. Thus we take as ergative the individual verbs, the VRG construction, rather than the pattern 'NG + V + (NG).' When ergative verbs and VRGs occur in the ergative pattern, intentionality is allowed, which shows that the ergative and transitive models may co-occur in the same clause.

We recognize two syntactic patterns expressive of ergativity: 1) The pseudo-effective pattern (2b) with NG1 realizing the circumstance and NG2 the Medium. This pattern expresses result/state meaning, and it is incompatible with intentionality. 2) The *bǎ*-construction, which conforms to the ergative features both in syntax and in meaning. In syntactic terms, the element introduced by *bǎ* is either O or S. The *cause-&-effect* meaning may be expressed explicitly when this construction takes VRGs into clause-final position.

Though lexical verbs are not large in number (accounting for about 10% of the total number of common verbs in the dictionary), VRG is a productive and flexible construction, into which different kinds of words (e.g., verbs, adjectives), groups and phrases, or even clauses can enter. Many verbs (both transitive and intransitive) can enter the two syntactic patterns. These constitute the ergativity resources in the lexico-grammar of Chinese.

4.3 Meaning of Ergativity: A Further Probe

As is explicated in Sect. 4.1, ergativity revolves around the nucleus of 'Process ^ Medium,' which denotes the effect in the chain of *cause-&-effect* (in contrast to that of *deed-&-extension*). Presence or absence of cause constitutes the variable in the ergative model. Thus the effect may be construed as being brought about from within, or from outside, which gives rise to the non-ergative and ergative patterns respectively. This is the basic meaning of ergativity, presumably shared between Chinese and English (if not among most languages). Starting from this basic and general meaning, we would like to probe: what is the more specific meaning of ergativity?

On the other hand, there are a lot of typological studies on the causative construction (roughly equivalent to the ergative model, see Shibatani 1976; Comrie 1989). One of the semantic parameters in such studies is the temporal and spatial distance between cause and effect. In some cases, cause and effect are so close to one another temporally that it is difficult to factor the macro-situation in causative terms. In others, the relation between them may be much more distant. These are called direct and indirect causatives respectively. The second semantic parameter is the degree of control exercised by the causee over the effect. Where the causee is an inanimate entity, it has no potential of exercising any control over the macro-situation, so that the question of control does not arise. Where, however, the causee is animate, there is the potential for a continuum of degree of control retained by that causee (Comrie 1989: 172–174; Song 2001: 276–281). Scholars, e.g., Shibatani (1976: 14), also notice a correlation between direct/indirect causation and control exercised by the causee. That is, other things being equal, the causee exerts more control over the effect in direct causation, and vice versa. With respect to such studies, we ask: how is intentionality/controllability related to the ergative model in Chinese?

Wang et al. (2009) posit that ergativity is necessarily composed of the three meanings of action, causation, and result/state. Here action typically implies intentionality/controllability. According to this view, these are all present in (2c) with the result/state meaning oriented to NG2; whereas only the result/state meaning is present in (2a), with the other two implied or completely absent. We find that the action meaning is characteristically associated with transitivity with humans as the intentional actor (Halliday 1994; cf., Hopper and Thompson 1980). It is true that, when ergative words or groups are used in the 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' pattern, action meaning may be available, as shown by *deliberately* and *to block the levee breach* in (23a):

(23) a *The crew sank the ship* ***deliberately to block the levee breach***

b *The ship sank (*to block the levee breach). /The ship sank (*deliberately)*

c *As they coasted home, darkness (****deliberately****) sank the city into starlight and the quiet towering brilliance of Boston's Back Bay*

The intentional/actional meaning is neither necessary nor inherent to ergativity. (23a) expresses this meaning because 1) 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and 'NG ^ V' are accidently shared between the transitivity model and the ergativity model. The condition for ergative verbs to be able to express this meaning is that NG1 is human and the ergative verb denotes action at the same time, as in (23a). If this is not the case, the action meaning will be ruled off, as shown by (23b, c).

In Chinese, as in English, action meaning is not inherent to ergativity, as we have shown in Sects. 4.2.1 and 4.2.2 (particularly examples 6 and 7). When ergative verbs or VRGs are employed to express the cause in the *cause-&-effect* relation in the 'NG1 ^ V/VRG ^ NG2' pattern, they may be involved in expressing this meaning. This is accidental. For example, in (6a) above, the action of *tā kāi-le mén* (他开了门, 'he opened the door.') is the cause of *mén kāi-le* (门开了, 'the door opened.'). That is, his action of opening the door is the cause of the door's being open. Comparatively,

the 'NG2 ^ V/VRG'[11] pattern is a specialized pattern for ergativity, particularly for expressing the effect meaning. It is resistant to actional meaning as shown by (6c) and (23b). The pseudo-effective construction as described in Sect. 4.2.3, is also resistant to intentional/actional meaning (see examples therein). This construction is exclusively ergative, in that it is devoted to the effect meaning, without being concerned with what brings it about and how. Such facts show that, in Chinese at least, action meaning/controllability is not a necessary component of ergativity, as different from what is observed in the literature, e.g., Shibatani (1976: 14), Comrie (1989: 172–174), Wang et al. (2009), etc.

Indeed, action meaning is one of the things that distinguish transitivity from ergativity.[12] It is prototypically associated with the *deed-&-extension* model, in which the nucleus is the action, with the extension being optional. Whereas in the ergativity model, which revolves around the *cause-&-effect* meaning, the effect (expressed by 'NG2 ^ V/VRG') is the nucleus, with the cause (expressed by 'NG1 ^ V') being optional. This is the common semantic feature shared by the lexical items and syntactic patterns surveyed in Sect. 4.2. As we have seen, the cause may be mixed with action meaning, but the effect is necessarily resistant to this meaning.

Then, what is effect? Basically, effect is some result or state as a result of some action or event. This is typically expressed by the perfective marker *-le* in Chinese, as is the case above (except examples 14a, 15a, and 17e, f, g, see below). This is so because the resultative meaning and the ergative verbs or VRGs are congruent with each other (cf. Comrie 1989: 119). Even in those cases where *-le* is not used, the perfective meaning is present, and *-le* can be added to explicate the resultative meaning, e.g., (4a, b). In those cases where the progressive marker *-zhe* is used, i.e., (17e, f, g), it is to express a state, instead of the progressive meaning. For example, (17e) is to describe the state that a family is living in the mountain; (17f) the state that some characters are written on the blackboard (not the progressive action that someone is writing the characters); and (17g) the state of a red flag being planted on the wall (not the action of someone planting the flag on the wall) (cf., Jin and Wang 2014). The marker *-zhe* in these examples can be changed into *-le*, with the state meaning retained, as a result of perfective meaning (Cheng and Huang 1994). Neither of the aspect marker is used in (14) and (15). This is possible because the resultative explicitly expresses a state as a result of the action/event denoted by the verb in VRG.

In a word, in the ergative model of *cause-&-effect*, the cause may be mixed with actional meaning, involving intentionality and controllability, but the effect is necessarily resistant to this meaning. As the nucleus in this model, effect denotes the result or state as a result of the action or event expressed in the cause part of this relation.

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[11] This is to be distinguished from the 'NG1 ^ V' pattern, which is the intransitive pattern in the transitive model.

[12] The fact that action meaning is involved in the 'NG1 ^ V/VRG ^ NG2' pattern, which also expresses ergativity, shows that these two meanings are mixed in this pattern. We will explore this in the following sub-section.

4.4 Complementarity of Ergativity and Transitivity in Chinese

According to Halliday (e.g., 1985, 1994), the transitive and ergative models are two different interpretations of and alternative perspectives to experiential meaning. In the transitive model, different process types are recognized, each with their different configurations of process and participant roles. The ergative model is more abstract and generalized, 'turning up in all process types' (Halliday 1994: 164). Experiential meaning can be seen as some blend of these semantic models (Halliday 1994: 167). On the one hand, they complement each other, such that different process types can be analyzed in ergative terms (Halliday 1994: 165–167). On the other hand, they are strong in bringing out either the transitive or ergative/causative meanings respectively, due to the ways each is oriented and centered (Halliday 1994: 169 Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 348, see Sect. 4.1).

English is used as the illustrative language for the exposition of SFL in Halliday (1985, 1994, etc.). It is open to question how the observations reviewed above fare in other languages. Our discussion in previous sections indicates that, though it is not a necessary component of it, intentional/actional meaning may be involved in ergativity in Chinese. For example, some verbs are suited to the transitivity model and others to the ergativity model. All verbs can be used in one of the models, and some can express both ergativity and transitivity at the same time. In the latter case, transitive and ergative meanings co-occur, as shown in (6a–d). Of the non-ergative (e.g., 2a) and ergative (e.g., 2c) patterns, the former is resistant to intentionality and the latter is open to it as shown by (6c) and (6d) respectively. Specifically, (6d) expresses both the transitive meaning of 'he is doing the action of opening the door,' and the ergative meaning of 'he causes the door to open.' The transitive meaning is prototypically present when NG1 in (2c) is a human agent.

At the rank of group, VRG, as a typical, productive, flexible group pattern, provides a rich resource for expressing ergativity. It is interesting to note that neither the V nor the R is ergative, though their combination is. Indeed V (transitive or intransitive) is typically actional. This meaning may be explicated when VRGs occur in (2c), in which case the V is oriented to NG1, and R to NG2 (Lu 1997). Thus the configuration of 'NG1 ^ V' may express actional meaning (and the meaning of cause in the *cause-&-effect* relation), especially when NG1 is human, and that of 'R ^ NG2' are responsible for the nuclear meaning of effect. The whole clause expresses transitivity and ergativity at the same time. See examples 8, 9, and 10, and the discussion therein.

In Sect. 4.2, we recognized two syntactic patterns that are expressive of ergativity: the event-existential construction (conforming to the pseudo-effective construction of (2b)) and the *bǎ*-construction. The latter, which is also called dispositive construction (Wang 1944/1985: 82–86, 1989: 266ff), is available for expressing transitivity. Indeed, it is originally a transitive pattern, taking only transitive verbs to express transitive (dispositive) meaning. The agent is typically human, and is intentionally engaged in a transitive and controllable process. Thus non-human agent with

uncontrollable process is unlikely to occur in this construction. Compare (24a) and (24b)[13]:

(24) a *yù* *bǎ* *qīngtiān* *mō.* (Wang 1989: 268)
want BA blue sky touch
'… want to touch the blue sky' (欲把青天摸。)

b **táoshù* *bǎ* *huā* *kāi.* (Wang 1944/1985: 83)
peach tree BA blossom open
'Peach blossoms come out.' (*桃树把花开。)

According to Wang (1944/1985: 85), the difference between the dispositive construction (i.e., the *bǎ*-construction) and its non-dispositive agnate is textual, that is, the former fulfills the textual function of bringing the process (realized by the verbal group) into the focal position, i.e., to the end of the clause, while the latter retains the normal focus of the goal. Compare (24a) with *yù mō qīngtiān* (欲摸青天, '… want to touch the sky'). Later on, as VRGs find their way into the construction, ergative meaning appears (Wang 1989: 269). In this process, transitive meaning persists both when the ergative meaning is present and when it is absent. In the former case, *gùyì* (故意, 'intentional/deliberate') can be added to Type I, e.g., (19a) and (20a), to the front of *bǎ*, to explicate the actional meaning. In the latter case, transitive meaning is the sole meaning expressed, as in,

(25) *yīdìng* *yào* *bǎ* *gǎigé* *jìnxíng* *dàod*
definitely should BA reform carry on to end
'(We) should carry on the reform to its end.' (一定要把改革进行到底。)

Thus, transitivity and ergativity in Chinese, are not so much different interpretations of or alternative perspectives to the same experiential meaning, as different models of construing this meaning, each being suited to different domains. What's more, the two models may co-occur in the same clause, such that they are combined and interwoven into each other, and they complement each other and are in cooperation with each other in construing experience.

The division of labor between the two models may be motivated by different semantic factors, including animacy of the participant, its definiteness, and controllability of the process. Dixon (1994: 91, 116–119, 125, 212) notes that inanimate participants often occur in the ergative pattern, while animate and intentional participants are often associated the transitivity model (Lemmens 1998: 118, 163). In Chinese, as is shown above, when NG1 is human, the 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' pattern typically involves action meaning even when the verb is ergative (see example 6). Another factor that may interact with the choice between ergativity and transitivity is definiteness. Dixon (1994: 91, 212) finds that definite participants are often involved

[13] Though absent, the agent of (24a) is understood to be human.

in the transitivity system, while indefinite participants are more likely to be used in the ergativity model (cf., Du Bois 1987). In the pseudo-effective pattern in Chinese, the NG that occurs after the verb is typically indefinite (Chao 1968/2004: 99; Zhu 1982: 97). If it is definite, the 'NG ^ V' order will be preferred as in (18b) in contrast to (17a), and the action meaning will be expressed instead of the result and state meaning that are typically associated with ergativity (Jin and Wang 2014: 50).

The third factor that may be relevant is the controllability of the process. Generally, the more controllable a process is, the more likely it will be modeled transitively, and vice versa (Dixon 1979, 1994: 73–83). Chinese is also in accord with this tendency. Ergative verbs that express action meaning are those that denote controllable processes. Obviously, this is closely related to the animacy of the participant. Only humans or highly animate beings can be described as in control of a process. Those processes that involve inanimate agents are typically uncontrollable. This also explains Halliday and Matthiessen's (2014: 337, 347) observation that the ergativity model is favored in scientific registers, which are concerned with the causative relation between different entities and states of affairs. On the other hand, the transitivity model is more commonly adopted in such registers as personal accounts and fictions, in which the *deed-&-extension* relation figures more prominently.

All in all, it can be said that, the transitive and ergative models in the grammar of Chinese are both indispensable ways of construing experience. It is through the division of labor, cooperation and complementation of the two models that our experience of the world is construed in a fitting and effective manner.

4.5 Conclusion

We have provided an overview of the ergativity system as a sub-system of experiential meaning in Chinese. By following the SFL rationale, we take *cause-&-effect* as the basic meaning (with effect being central) of ergativity, from which we start to examine how it is expressed in lexico-grammar. At the lexical end, there are ergative verbs that may occur in the two agnate patterns, 'NG1 ^ V ^ NG2' and 'NG2 ^ V,' with the causative meaning being explicit in the former and implicit in the latter. There are 122 verbs that fit in with these two patterns. Similarly, VRGs are identified as ergative, in that they conform to the semantic features and behave as ergative verbs do in the two patterns, except that causative meaning is more explicit, due to the fact the cause-denoting verb and the resultative are obviously analyzable and are oriented to NG1 and NG2 respectively. Toward the end of grammar, we recognize event-existentials as the pseudo-effective construction, for they typically express result and state meaning, and the only direct participant occurs post-verbally in the clause. Another syntactic pattern which is typically employed to express ergativity is the *bǎ*-construction with VRG in it. This construction and VRGs cooperate with each other to make explicit the cause and to focalize the effect.

Transitivity is inherently associated with the actional meaning of intentionality and controllability, and ergativity focuses on the effective meaning of result and state.

Although, ergativity is not the dominant meaning resource in Chinese, it accounts for an indispensable part. More importantly, the two systems are often co-existent and interwoven into each other. Thus, they complement and are in cooperation with each other at different levels and in different ways. It can be said most texts in actual use are mixtures of both systems, though different registers may show different preferences.

This study may have a number of implications for SFL and for typological studies of ergativity and causation. First, it may complement SFL in two ways: For one thing, the transitive and ergative models are not so much different interpretations of and alternative perspectives to experiential meaning, as different ways of construing experience, each suited to a different domain. For another, the two models do not alternate when functioning. Rather, they co-occur, are interwoven into, and in cooperation with each other, such that actional and causative meanings are mixed. This, we believe, is true to the nature of our experience, which does not show clear-cut divides between different domains. There is no doubt that Halliday's SFL theory is seminal and inspirational, due to its functional orientation, comprehensiveness, typological awareness, etc. (Wang and Xu 2011). However, it is also true that his exposition of the theory (e.g., Halliday 1985, 1994, etc.) is mainly based on English. New observations and questions are likely to arise when this theory is applied to the description of different languages. Indeed, this is one of the ways through which the theory can be enriched and enhanced.

Second, we may propose a new (sub-)type of split ergative on the basis of data in Chinese in which a clause may be both ergative and transitive at the same time, as different from the current opinion that a construction in a split ergative language is either ergative or accusative (≈transitive), and it cannot be both. Thus transitivity and ergativity may not only be mixed in a text, but also in a clause. There are also methodological implications, both for SFL and typology: Being semantically/functionally oriented, SFL may offer a rich source of functional parameters, along which cross-linguistic comparisons may be conducted, and generalizations made. On the other hand, for those languages which do not show much morphological variation, functional parameters are both convenient and worthwhile to start from and to work with.

Appendix: Ergative Verbs in Chinese (122 Verbs in Total)

āndìng (安定, ‘stabilize’)	*bàihuài* (败坏, ‘undermine’)	*bàofā* (爆发, ‘erupt’)
bàolù (暴露, ‘expose’)	*biàn* (变, ‘change’)	*biànlì* (便利, ‘facilitate’)
chénglì (成立, ‘establish’)	*chéngqīng* (澄清, ‘clarify’)	*chōngshí* (充实, ‘enrich’)
chūdòng (出动, ‘dispatch’)	*chúnjié* (纯洁, ‘purify’)	*chúnjìng* (纯净, ‘purify’)
dànhuà (淡化, ‘desalinate’)	*dòngyáo* (动摇, ‘shake’)	*duànjué* (断绝, ‘break off’)
duānzhèng (端正, ‘correct’)	*è* (饿, ‘become/make hungry’)	*èhuà* (恶化, ‘worsen’)
fánróng (繁荣, ‘make prosperous’)	*fāzhǎn* (发展, ‘develop’)	*fēngfù* (丰富, ‘enrich’)
fēnliè (分裂, ‘break up’)	*fēnsàn* (分散, ‘scatter’)	*fǔhuà* (腐化, ‘decay’)
gǎibiàn (改变, ‘transform’)	*gǎijìn* (改进, ‘improve’)	*gǎishàn* (改善, ‘make better’)
gǎndòng (感动, ‘touch/move’)	*gǒnggù* (巩固, ‘consolidate’)	*guān* (关, ‘close’)
guànchè (贯彻, ‘implement’)	*guànchuān* (贯穿, ‘perforate’)	*gùdìng* (固定, ‘fasten’)
guīfàn (规范, ‘standardize’)	*gūlì* (孤立, ‘isolate’)	*hōngdòng* (轰动, ‘stir’)
huà (化, ‘turn’)	*huāngfèi* (荒废, ‘waste’)	*huāngshū* (荒疏, ‘neglect’)
huǎnhé (缓和, ‘alleviate’)	*huǎnjiě* (缓解, ‘ease’)	*huànsàn* (涣散, ‘scatter’)
huīfù (恢复, ‘restore’)	*huǐmiè* (毁灭, ‘destroy’)	*huódòng* (活动, ‘exercise’)
huóyuè (活跃, ‘enliven’)	*jiādà* (加大, ‘increase’)	*jiāgù* (加固, ‘reinforce’)
jiākuài (加快, ‘accelerate’)	*jiàngdī* (降低, ‘lower’)	*jiǎnqīng* (减轻, ‘mitigate’)
jiànquán (健全, ‘improve’)	*jiǎnshǎo* (减少, ‘reduce’)	*jiāqiáng* (加强, ‘strengthen’)
jiāshēn (加深, ‘deepen’)	*jiāsù* (加速, ‘accelerate’)	*jiāzhòng* (加重, ‘aggravate’)
jīdàng (激荡, ‘agitate’)	*jiějué* (解决, ‘solve’)	*jiéshù* (结束, ‘end’)
jíhé (集合, ‘assemble’)	*jīhuà* (激化, ‘intensify’)	*jīngdòng* (惊动, ‘disturb’)

jīngxǐng (惊醒, ‘rouse’)
jízhōng (集中, ‘focus’)
kāi (开, ‘open’)
kāitōng (开通, ‘dredge’)
kuādà (夸大, ‘exaggerate’)
kuòchōng (扩充, ‘expand’)
kuòdà (扩大, ‘enlarge’)
mábì (麻 痹, ‘benumb’)
mǎnzú (满足, ‘satisfy’)
miè (灭, ‘extinguish’)
míhuò (迷惑, ‘confuse’)
míngquè (明确, ‘pinpoint’)
mìqiè (密切, ‘endear’)
móhu (模糊, ‘blur’)
píngdìng (平定, ‘quell’)
píngxī (平息, ‘pacify’)
píngzhěng (平整, ‘flatten’)
pǔjí (普及, ‘popularize’)
qǐdòng (启动, ‘start’)
qīngxǐng (清醒, ‘wake’)
rónghuà (融化, ‘thaw’)
róngjiě (溶解, ‘dissolve’)
ruǎnhuà (软化, ‘soften’)
shíxiàn (实现, ‘realize’)
shūsàn (疏散, ‘disperse’)
suōxiǎo (缩小, ‘decrease’)
tígāo (提高, ‘raise’)
tōngguò (通过, ‘pass through’)
tǒngyī (统一, ‘unify’)
tòulòu (透露, ‘divulge’)
tūchū (突出, ‘protrude’)
wǎjiě (瓦解, ‘disintegrate)
wánchéng (完成, ‘complete)
wéinán (为难, ‘embarrass’)
wěndìng (稳定, ‘stabilize’)
wěngù (稳固, ‘stabilize’)
wēnnuǎn (温暖, ‘warm’)
xiāochú (消除, ‘eliminate’)
xiāomiè (消灭, ‘eradicate’)
xīmiè (熄灭, ‘extinguish’)
xíngchéng (形成, ‘take shape’)
xuēruò (削弱, ‘weaken’)
yáncháng (延长, ‘prolong’)
yáohuàng (摇晃, ‘sway’)
yáodòng (摇动, ‘shake’)
zēngchǎn (增产, ‘increase production’)
zēngjiā (增加, ‘increase’)
zēngqiáng (增强, ‘strengthen’)
zēngzhǎng (增长, ‘grow’)
zhǎnkāi (展开, ‘expand’)
zhèndìng (镇定, ‘calm down’)
zhuǎnbiàn (转变, ‘change into’)
zhèndòng (震动, ‘tremor’)
zhènfèn (振奋, ‘stimulate’)
zhènjīng (震惊, ‘shock’)
zhènzuò (振作, ‘cheer up’)
zhuàndòng (转动, ‘revolve’)
zhuàngdà (壮大, ‘strengthen’)
zīrùn (滋润, ‘moisten’)

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Chapter 5
Grammatical Metaphor across Disciplines: A Corpus-Based Study

Bingjun Yang

Abstract The use of grammatical metaphor (GM) has been found to be a typical feature of academic writing, but few studies focused on the variations of GM across disciplines. In order to find out how GMs vary across disciplines, we selected four textbooks (linguistics, law, medicine and physics respectively representing arts and humanities, social sciences, life sciences, and physical sciences) which were published by prestigious publishers, each being the sixth edition at least, and then with these textbook contents we built a corpus of 1.1 million tokens. Other corpora used include the British Academic Written English Corpus (BAWE) and the LOB family (LOB, FLOB and CLOB). With Lancsbox 6.0 as the corpus tool, we observed the occurrences of ideational GMs and modality metaphors in the data. Then with Scholar GPT, correlation analyses have been performed. The results show that the use of GM is discipline common, time constrained, and proficiency dependent. The strategy of using GMs varies in texts compiled in different disciplines but GM is a persistent feature in general and there is a trend of increasing GM usages in academic writings.

Keywords Disciplines · Textbook · BAWE · LOB · Grammatical metaphor

5.1 Introduction

In a recent study, McGrath and Liardét find that the overall frequency of grammatical metaphor (hereafter GM) across disciplines (arts and humanities, life sciences, social sciences, and physical sciences) was very similar, and variation between arts & humanities and life sciences was statistically significant but also small (McGrath and Liardét 2023). They acknowledge that, "[g]iven the central role GM has been found to play in the language valued in academic and professional discourse, it is important to empirically describe its use and to account for any variation of its deployment

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across disciplines" (McGrath and Liardét 2023). As an important contribution to studies concerning GM and academic discourse, a limitation of this research lies in its GM typology which only includes "shift to thing" and "shift to quality", with six sub-types in total. GM includes ideational grammatical metaphor (13 sub-types) and interpersonal metaphor (4 sub-types of modality metaphor and 4 sub-types of mood metaphor), and the six types used in the study by McGrath & Liardét all belong to ideational GM, four of which are nominalizations and two are adjectivizations. Thus, it is significant to move forward and observe the other types as well. A taxonomy to observe the full range of GMs in academic texts should include the 13 types of ideational GM and the modality metaphors of interpersonal GM.[1]

In order to observe the 13 types of GM and modality metaphors across disciplines, we focus on three research questions as follows: (1) How does the use of ideational GM vary between disciplines? (2) How are modality metaphors used in different disciplines? (3) What are the general features of GM usages across disciplines? First, we will review the relevant studies. Then, research methods and corpora used in this research will be introduced, followed by results and discussions.

5.2 Disciplinary English and Grammatical Metaphor

Multidisciplinary, interdisciplinary, and transdisciplinary researchers all try to address "common problems" (Rosenfield 1992: 1351), and it is found that disciplinary English as "a way of meaning which has become associated with objective authority" "has shaped our disciplinary knowledge and spread across to registers of bureaucratic and political subject matter" (Butt 2019: 4).

Disciplinary English has in fact been much discussed in the field of English for Academic Purposes (EAP) for decades. For example, it is found that "markers of epistemic modality as well as hedging phenomena in general constitute an important rhetorical means for writers of research articles" (Vold 2006: 225). A number of people condemn students to conformity in EAP and passive acceptance of norms and ideologies. They also condemn EAP teachers for spoon-feeding students with conformity, but "EAP is not a monolithic approach and exemplars are used in many different ways" (Hyland 2018: 394). In recent analyses of academic English, corpus-based methodologies "have been favored" because of reliability and generalizability (Römer et al. 2020: 1). Research topics vary, but the following are very popular in recent years: metadiscourse and metaphor.

Many people claim that metadiscourse is a term coined by Zellig Harris in 1959 (Harris 1959) and it is reasonable to say so because it is Zellig Harris who first published an article entitled *Discourse Analysis* (Harris 1952). In an article published in 1931, Tarski said "the language about which we speak and the language in which we speak" are different, and "[t]he names of the expressions of the first language, and

[1] Since mood metaphor as the other sub-type of interpersonal GM occurs in conversations, which is uncommon in academic written texts, it needs to be excluded here.

of the relations between them, belong to the second language, called the metalanguage" (Tarski 1956: 167). In other words, "signs of signs constitute a language of a higher level, which we call metalanguage" (Reichenbach 1947: 9). Closely related to metalanguage, "metadiscourse analysis has largely focused on specialised varieties of language" (Hyland 2017: 17). Metadiscourse refers to "the ways in which writers and speakers interact through their use of language with readers and listeners" or "how we use language out of consideration for our readers or hearers based on our estimation of how best we can help them process and comprehend what we are saying" (Hyland 2017: 16–17).

Thus, the model of metadiscourse proposed by Hyland includes two major categories: interactive resources which help to guide readers through the text; interactional resources which involve the readers in the text. The former consists of transitions (e.g. *in addition, but*), frame markers (e.g. *finally, my purpose is*), endophoric markers (e.g. *noted above, see Fig*), evidentials (e.g. *according to, Z states*), and code glosses (e.g. *namely, in other words*). The latter consists of hedges (e.g. *might, perhaps*), boosters (e.g. *in fact, it is clear that*), attitude markers (e.g. *unfortunately, I agree*), self mentions (e.g. *I, we, our*), and engagement markers (e.g. *consider, note that*) (Hyland 2005, 2019). There has been a significant increase in interactive features and a significant decrease in interactional types; interactional metadiscourse shows a marked decline in the discursive soft knowledge fields and a substantial increase in the science subjects (Hyland & Jiang 2018). Metadiscursive nouns have been observed diachronically and increased use of quality nouns are found in hard sciences to promote the value of research outcome while evidential nouns for factual support are more preferred in soft sciences (Jiang and Hyland 2021).

Besides metadiscourse, metaphor has always been a focal area of interest, particularly since the inception of conceptual metaphor theory in 1980 (Lakoff and Johnson 1980). For example, metaphor as a key cognitive and sociolinguistic mechanism for building up schemas involved in architecture discourse needs to be taught so that students may know and use it as part of their future jargon; and during the teaching of metaphor in the ESP classroom an effective approach should require teachers to explicitly present and explain a few metaphor "basics" and to ask the learners to use metaphors in specific genres (Rodriguez 2003). It is also widely believed that challenges that students may face when they begin schooling in universities include a command of metaphors in different disciplines. For example, a study of metaphor comprehension in engineering texts by first-year university students finds that English first-language (L1) students outperformed English second (L2) language students in comprehending metaphors, and students who performed poorly on the diagnostic assessment could not comprehend metaphors satisfactorily (Beynen 2020).

The first mention of "grammatical metaphor" as a technical term was in 1976 (Halliday 1976) but it is not until recently that GM is studied in academic writing. In general, academic discourse is generally "vertical" and "vertical discourse is all bound up with grammatical metaphor" because the verticality can be achieved through using new forms to construe meanings (Martin 2007: 55). There has been a consensus that GM plays a critical role in academic discourse, and many studies found that students should be taught in the use of GM. An observation of Disciplinary

English (DE) used in technical subjects shows that GM plays an important role in DE (Butt 2019). By a profile of GMs used in the British Academic Written English Corpus (BAWE), an introductory list of 2702 experiential GMs was compiled and it can be used to inform teachers during the teaching of GM (McGrath and Liardét 2022). Another study carried out an analysis of GM use in a corpus across four disciplines and found that the disciplinary variation was small and a generalized approach to teaching GM should be feasible, which is beneficial to both ESP and EAP classes (McGrath and Liardét 2023).

The majority of extant studies focuses on ideational GM. For example, it is found that grade nine students may intuitively use ideational GM, but there is a lack of consistency (Gonzalez 2019), this may be due to the pervasive nominalizations used in textbooks for technical terms (Hao and Humphrey 2019). The pervasiveness of GM, nominalizations in particular can be found in general academic writings (Liardet, Black, and Bardetta 2019), agnation patterns in economic texts, field-oriented conceptual frameworks (Liu and Irwin 2020), applied linguistics (Kaidan, Jalilifar, and Don 2021), and ESL writings (Hu and Perez 2022). Studies on interpersonal GM find that by using "As we all know" frequently learners tend to foreground certainty and negotiability (Liardet 2018). Textual metaphor has not been accepted widely because a lot of issues need to be clarified, though it is found that textual metaphor tends to be used more in soft sciences (He 2022), and students may be taught to use textual metaphor for the improvement of academic writing (Liardet and Black 2020).

5.3 Types of Grammatical Metaphor

The language system in systemic functional linguistics (SFL) is stratified into semantics, lexicogrammar, phonology, and phonetics, in which the semantic stratum is the core. The semantic stratum consists of such units as sequence, figure, and element while the units at the lexicogrammar stratum include clause, phrase/group, word, and morpheme (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014). The semantic stratum can be realized at the lexicogrammar stratum either congruently or metaphorically (Fig. 5.1), and thus GM is the stratal realignment (Halliday 2004[1998b]), or stratal tension (Martin 2020), between semantics and lexicogrammar.

Let's take an example to illustrate GM. In (1a) a sequence is realized by a clause complex and it is direct and natural, which suggests that (1a) is a congruent form. The same meaning is metaphorically realized by a clause in (1b), or by a nominal group in (1c).

(1)	a.	He resigned because they had departed
	b.	Their departure caused his resignation
	c.	his resignation because of their departure. (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 720)

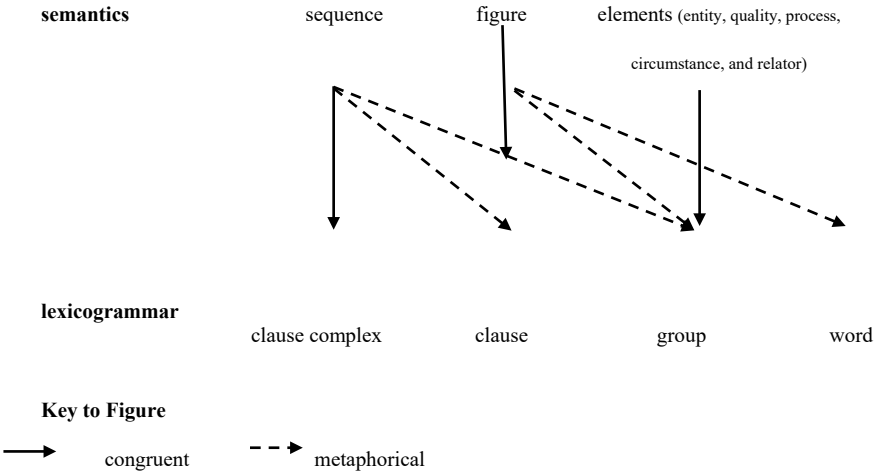


Fig. 5.1 Congruent and metaphorical realizations (Adapted from Halliday 2004[1998b]: 83)

GM usages trigger textual effects. Semantically these examples tell readers the same meaning but textually they bring different effects, in which the metaphorical expressions read more academic. Based on semantic junctions, GM can be classified into 13 types (Halliday 2004[1998a]: 41–42). See Figure 5.2.

GM includes ideational and interpersonal types, and interpersonal metaphor is categorized into metaphors of mood and metaphors of modality in SFL. In terms of SFL, the most fundamental types of speech role are "giving" and "demanding". See Table 5.1.

The four variables (giving, demanding, goods-&-services, and information) in Table 5.1 "when taken together, define the four primary speech functions of offer, command, statement and question" (Halliday, 1994: 69). These speech functions correspond with three mood types (declarative, interrogative and imperative). When the mood types realize the speech functions as shown in Table 5.1, they are direct and natural. These realizations are called the congruent forms. By contrast, mismatches will result in different speech functions. For example, when a command functioning as warning is realized by a declarative mood (e.g. *I wouldn't…if I were you*), it is unnatural and indirect and it is called the metaphorical form. Likewise, when an offer functioning as threat (e.g. *Maybe I'll…*) is realized by a declarative mood (e.g. *I've a good mind to…*), the metaphorical form occurs. See Table 5.2.

Truly, "it is by no means easy to decide what are metaphorical and what are congruent forms" and the "specific rhetorical function is made manifest by any or all of a variety of other factors" (Halliday, 1994: 365). This is particularly true to mood metaphors.

In language exchanges, there are various possibilities between "do" and "do not" when giving or demanding goods-&-services, and there are also various possibilities between "yes" and "no" when giving or demanding information. These possibilities

semantic element	**grammatical class**
grammatical function	Example
1. quality => entity	adjective =>noun
Epithet = Thing	unstable = instability[1]
2. process =>entity	verb => noun
(i) Event = Thing	transform = transformation
(ii) Auxiliary = Thing:	
(tense)	will/going to = prospect
(phase)	try to = attempt
(modality)	can/could = possibility/potential
3. circumstances => entity	preposition => noun
Minor Process = Thing	with = accompaniment
	to = destination
4. relator => entity	conjunction => noun
Conjunctive = Thing	so = cause/proof; if = condition
5. process => quality	verb => adjective

[1] It should not be misunderstood as a kind of conversion. One meaning may be realized by a higher unit (a clause like "The bridge is unstable" for example) or a lower unit (a group like "the instability of the bridge" for example), and here "instability" is the metaphorical expression of "unstable". Examples in Figure 5.2 should be put into context for proper understanding.

Fig. 5.2 Typology of grammatical metaphors (Halliday 2004[1998a]: 41–42)

are ways of modality, and speakers use them to make judgment on the validity of a proposition, ask addressees to be responsible to an order, or to express willingness in a proposal. Four types of modality are distinguished in GM: probability, usuality, obligation, and inclination. Each type of modality can be realized in four semantic domains: subjective, objective, implicit, and explicit.

(i) Event = Epithet	[property] is increasing = increasing [property]
(ii) Auxiliary =	
(tense)	was/used to = previous
(phase)	begin to = initial
(modality)	must/will[always] = constant

6. circumstance => quality	adverb / prepositional phrase => adjective*
(i) Manner => Epithet	[decided] hastily = hasty [decision]
(ii) other => Epithet	[argued] for a long time = lengthy [argument]
(iii) other => Classifier	[cracked] on the surface = surface [cracks]

7. relator => quality	conjunction => adjective
Conjunctive = Epithet	then = subsequent; so = resulting

8. circumstance => process	*be/go*+ preposition => (verb)
Minor Process = Process	be about = concern; be instead of = replace

9. relator => process	conjunction => verb)
Conjunctive = Event	then = follow; so = cause; and = complement

10. relator => circumstance	conjunction => preposition/-al group
Conjunctive = Minor Process	when = in times of / in … times
	if = under condition of / under… conditions

11. zero => entity	= the phenomenon of
12. zero => process	= … occurs / ensures
13. entity => expansion	noun => [various] (in env. 1, 2 above)

Fig. 5.2 (continued)

Head = Modifier	the government [decided] = the government's [decision], [a/the decision] of/by the government, [a] government(al) [decision] the government [couldn't decide/was indecisive] = the government's [indecision], [the indecision] of the government, government(al) [indecision]

* or noun; cf. mammal [cells]/mammalian [cells]

Fig. 5.2 (continued)

Table 5.1 Speech functions and responses (Halliday & Matthiessen 2014: 137)

		Initiation	Response	
			expected	discretionary
Give	Goods-&-services	(a) Offer *shall I give you this teapot?*	Acceptance *yes, please, do!*	Rejection *no, thanks*
Demand		(b) Command *give me that teapot!*	Undertaking *here you are*	Refusal *I won't*
Give	Information	(c) Statement *he's giving her the teapot*	Acknowledgement *is he?*	Contradiction *no, he isn't*
Demand		(d) Question *what is he giving her?*	Answer a teapot	Disclaimer *I don't know*

Table 5.2 Some typical metaphors of mood in Halliday (1994: 365)

Type	Functioning as	Congruent	Metaphorical
Command	Warning	*Don't…*	*I wouldn't…if I was you*
Modalized offer	Threat	*Maybe I'll…*	*I've a good mind to…*
Modulated command	Advice	*She should…*	*She'd better…*

Metaphor of modality occurs when "the speaker's opinion regarding the probability that his observation is valid is coded not as a modal element within the clause, which would be its congruent realization, but as a separate, projecting clause in a hypotactic clause complex" (Halliday, 1994: 354). The explicit subjective and the explicit objective expressions are modality metaphors. See Table 5.3.

Thus, the 13 types of ideational GM and the four types of modality metaphors were observed in the data. As mentioned in Footnote 1, mood metaphors were excluded for two reasons: they are produced because of variation in mood in conversations and they are seldom used in written texts; they can only be identified with contexts to inform communicative purposes.

Table 5.3 Types of modality metaphors based on Halliday (1994: 358)

	Type	Congruent	Metaphorical
Proposition	Probability	*Mary probably knows*	*I think that Mary knows*
	Usuality	*Fred usually sits quite quiet*	*It's usual for Fred to sit quite quiet*
Proposal	Obligation	*John is supposed to go*	*It's expected that John goes*
	Inclination	*Jane'll help*	*Jane wishes that she could help*

5.4 Methods

5.4.1 Instruments

LancsBox 6.0 was used as the software and regular expression (Regex) was used to search for GMs. Microsoft Excel was used for initial groupings of the types. Scholar GPT[2] was used for data analysis.

5.4.2 The Corpus

The general practice in discipline classification is to distinguish four general disciplinary areas: arts and humanities, social sciences, life sciences, and physical sciences. Since the workload would be enormous if we consider all disciplines in these broad areas, we decided to choose linguistics, law, medicine, and physics as the representatives. These disciplines were observed in the following corpora: The British Academic Written English (BAWE) corpus; the self-compiled Textbook Corpus; the LOB corpora (i.e. LOB, FLOB, and CLOB).

BAWE corpus was developed at the University of Warwick and it contains 2761 pieces of assessed student writing (6,506,995 words). The average length is 2357 words for each text, which were all written between 2000 and 2007 (Table 5.4). The writing is evenly distributed across four levels of study. BAWE covers 35 academic disciplines within four general disciplinary areas: Arts and Humanities, Social Sciences, Life Sciences, and Physical Sciences. The texts are evenly distributed among the four disciplinary areas. Except for a few cases marked as "unknown", the texts in the corpus are texts graded at the level of "merit" or "distinction", which means they are all successful writings by students. The four disciplines representing the disciplinary areas (law, linguistics, physics, and medicine) were selected and re-organized into the Baw[3] Corpus (See Table 5.4).

The Textbook Corpus is a self-compiled collection of four popular textbooks published by the leading publishers. Each of the textbooks has more than six editions, indicating good acceptability and wide popularity. The figures and symbols which are

[2] Scholar GPT is the recent tool launched by openai.com, and it is part of ChatGPT applications.

[3] Note that Baw is used to differentiate from BAWE.

Table 5.4 The selected Baw corpus

Corpus	Period	Texts	Tokens
Law	2000–2007	17	22,359
Linguistics	2000–2007	38	55,283
Physics	2000–2007	25	27,763
Medicine	2000–2007	16	21,905

Table 5.5 The textbook corpus

Textbook	Discipline	Publisher	Year	Edition	Token	Type
The study of language	Linguistics	Cambridge University Press	2017	6th	94,286	9662
International law	Law	Oxford University Press	2013	7th	164,899	8074
Textbook of critical care	Medicine	Elsevier	2023	8th	500,987	29,158
Fundamentals of physics	Physics	John Wiley & Sons	2022	12th	379,600	16,203

not relevant for observation were deleted and txt files were created. Then a textbook corpus[4] was built (See Table 5.5).

The Lancaster-Oslo/Bergen (LOB) Corpus is a collection of British English texts published in 1961 by British authors. It consists of 500 samples each comprising about 2000 words in the genres of newspapers, fiction, academic writing, and general prose. In 1991 with the involvement of Freiburg University, a similar corpus called FLOB was compiled and it contains the early 1990s texts of similar genres, matching the original LOB corpus as closely as possible. The CLOB[5] corpus released in 2012 is a collection of British English texts written during 2008 and 2011, being a matched compilation of 500 hundred samples (each about 2000 words) as well. The J categories in the three corpora are all about academic writing. See Table 5.6.

In order to test the comparability, we observed the type-token ratio (TTR), standardized type-token ratio (STTR), and moving average type-token ratio (MATTR) (Table 5.7). The MATTR shows that the corpora under study are comparable.

5.4.3 Data Processing

All types of ideational GM and modality metaphors were observed in the data. The Regex for searching all nominalizations may be completed simply by inputting [word

[4] The corpus is used for research only and no contents can be shared or distributed.

[5] Note that CLOB is more recent but the time span of the data in CLOB is not 30 years while that between LOB and FLOB is 30 years. This is a disadvantage of the corpus and it may affect the results, so we used FLOB as the reference corpus.

Table 5.6 The LOB family corpora and category J

Corpus	Release Year	Period	Genres/Category	Category J
LOB	1961	1960s	Press/ABC General prose/DEFG Learned/HJ Fiction/KLMNPR	Science (academic writing)
FLOB	1992	1990s	Press/ABC General prose/DEFG Learned/HJ Fiction/KLMNPR	Science (academic writing)
CLOB	2012	2008–2011	Press/ABC General prose/DEFG Learned/HJ Fiction/KLMNPR	Science (academic writing)

Table 5.7 Type token ratio comparison

Corpus Name	Type	Token	TTR	STTR	MATTR
Textbooklinguistics	9662	94,286	0.10	0.69	0.69
BAWElinguistics	5847	55,283	0.11	0.69	0.69
Textbooklaw	8074	164,899	0.05	0.67	0.67
BAWElaw	3908	22,359	0.17	0.71	0.71
Textbookmedicine	29,158	500,987	0.06	0.72	0.72
BAWEmedicine	4519	21,905	0.21	0.72	0.72
Textbookphysics	16,203	379,600	0.04	0.63	0.63
BAWEphysics	3995	27,763	0.14	0.68	0.68
LOB-academic	18,012	162,254	0.11	0.71	0.71
FLOB-academic	16,548	160,936	0.10	0.70	0.70
CLOB-academic	16,655	160,919	0.10	0.71	0.71

= "{3,}(tion|tions|ment|ments|ness|nesses|ity|ities)"] or NOMINALIZATION in LancsBox 6.0. The words such as "question(s), business(es), element(s), university(-ties)" were excluded from the counts manually. Nominalizations ended with "-er, -ant, -al, -ance, -ery, and -age" may not be very typical GMs and they were excluded in the observations in this study.

In order to identify Types 5 and 7 (adjectivalization), the Regex as follows was used, and altogether 50 typical adjectives were considered:

[increasing|previous|initial|subsequent|resulting|preceding|consequent|ensuing|accelerative|acceleratory|accretionary|accretive|augmentative|decreasing|ever-increasing|diminishing|reducing|growing|doubling|declining|lowering|expanding|earlier|recent|preceding|prior|current|intermediate|preliminary|eventual|tentative|invariable|continual|steadfast|unswerving|unfailing|unflagging|sporadic|inconstant|discontinuous|noncontinuous|consequent|ensuant|resultant|sequent|antecedent|successive|consequent|prolonged|antecedent|ensuing|culminating|constant]

Note that "constant" may be a typical adjectivalization or a noun in physics, and only the adjectival usages were counted.

Types 6 & 13 (i.e. Adj + Nominalization) were searched via the following Regex:

[pos="J. *" & word!="(increasing|previous|initial|subsequent|resulting|accelerative|acceleratory|accretionary|accretive|augmentative|decreasing|ever-increasing|diminishing|reducing|growing|doubling|declining|lowering|expanding|earlier|recent|preceding|prior|current|intermediate|preliminary|eventual|tentative|invariable|continual|steadfast|unswerving|unfailing|unflagging|variable|sporadic|inconstant|discontinuous|noncontinuous|consequent|ensuant|resultant|sequent|antecedent|successive|consequent|prolonged|antecedent|ensuing|culminating|constant|such|other|weak|strong|vital|young|younger|new|old|older|red|white|black|green|blue|purple|yellow|such|different|same|many|much|more|most|good|better|best|short|long|little|few|small|large|big|huge|vast|great|high|tall|slow|fast|quick|only|open|first|second|third|fourth|fine|else|heavy|light|main|major|local|global|wide|narrow|own|past|above|below|close|cold|cool|warm|hot|right|wrong|clear|early|low|lowest|lower|key|less|male|female|real|full|last|next|very|late|total|later|down|up|left)"]

In the results, only adjectives were counted. Since typical nominalizations found by the automatic search query NOMINALIZATION have been counted and included in Types 1–4, they were no longer counted as instances of Types 6 & 13.

Types 8 and 9 (verbalization) were searched by the following Regex:

[cause|causes|caused|concerns|concerned|replaces|replaced|follows|followed|follow|complements|complemented|involves|involved|restores|restored|renews|renewed|displaces|displaced]

Since the expression may result in nominals such as "cause" and "concern", the nominal usages were excluded manually.

Type 10 (Adverbialization) is complicated because many choices are possible. In order to find as many cases as possible, four Regexes as follows were used:

[pos = "I.*"][hw = "(circumstance|basis||time|absence|presence|contrast|purpose|reason|account|case|term|time|condition|result|consequence|course|context|event|view|sake|face)"][pos = "I.*"].

[word = "(long|because|spite|regard|regardless)"] [pos = "I.*"]

[pos = "I.*"][pos = "N.*"& word! =.*.{3,}(tion|tions|ment|ments|ness|nesses|ity|ities)][pos = "I.*"]

[pos = "I.*"][word = "(the|a|an)"][pos = "N.*"& word!=. *.{3,}(tion|tions|ment|ments|ness|nesses|ity|ities)][pos = "I.*"]

These Regexes helped find usages such as "in times of, at the time of, because of, as a result, in consequence", etc.

Type 11 represented by typical shell nouns (zero-entity) could be searched by using "the NOUN that", "the NOUN of", and "the NOUN to" in LancsBox. But many nouns which do not belong to Type 11 should be included. So the following Regex was used:

[hw = "the"][word = "(facts|fact|phenomenon|phenomena|absence|presence|altitudes|attitudes|amounts|amount|ideas|idea|amplitude|analysis|analyses|atmosphere|balance|basis|bases|circumference|concept|concepts|danger|dangers|effect|effects|forms|form|hallmark|hallmarks|laws|law|principle|principles|magnitude|mass|masses|moments|moment|momentum|onset|openning|openning|beginnings|beginning|orders|order|origins|origin|passages|passage|patterns|pattern|periods|period|points|point|views|view|viewpoints|viewpoint|problems|problem|purposes|purpose|results|result|rules|rule|senses|sense|signs|sign|systems|system|subjects|subject|tendency|tendencies|trends|trend|needs|need|belief|beliefs|pledge|faith|dreams|dream|promises|promise|consequences|consequence|whole|range|influences|influence|structures|structure|roles|role|basis|bases|base|choice|choices)"][word = "(of|that|to)"].

To find Type 12 (zero to process) in the data, the following Regex was used:

[pos = "P.*"][word = "(occur|occurs|occurred|happens|happened|rises|rose|arises|arose|ensure|ensures|ensured|enable|enabled)"].

As to modality metaphors, two search queries were used in LancsBox to identify the usuality type and the obligation type:

It VERB ADJECTIVE that

It VERB ADVERB ADJECTIVE that

As to the probability type and the inclination type, a search query which helps sort out all possible verbs was used:

NOUN VERB that

Then verbs which mean "think", "believe", etc., were selected. For example, "arbitrator denied that…" contains a strong sense of "arbitrator didn't think that…". Again, "his view of law was that it…" is another way of saying "he thinks that". Thus, these instances were manually identified and counted as modality metaphors.

In order to understand the subjective and objective tendencies in expressing indeterminacy, we put modality metaphors into three groups: explicit subjective, explicit objective, and intermediate. Explicit subjective (ModalSub) refers to those which use I/we or other personal nouns to express probability and inclination. Examples from the data are as follows:

(2) Let us suppose that…
Fitton also realized that…
Many of you will no doubt think that…

Explicit objective (ModalObj) refers to those which use various ways of expressing usuality or obligation. See (3) below:

(3) It was universally accepted that…
It is possible that…
There is little wonder that
No wonder that…
Both theories under discussion assume that…

Non-finite verbs are also used to express modality meanings. They also carry metaphorical senses when used in many cases. In order to differentiate them, we named them the intermediate type (ModalInte). See (4) below:

(4) Arguing that huge waves have been quite common
To suggest that an appeal was possible

Sometimes, the first type of modality metaphor (explicit subjective) and the second type of modality metaphor (explicit objective) or the intermediate type (non-finite expressions) may co-occur in academic texts. See (5) below:

(5) And **I think** that **it is this fact** that…
However **it is probably wise to assume** that…
However, **there is a real tendency to believe** that…

These instances were counted twice, one count being explicit subjective (ModalSub) and the other explicit objective (ModalObj).

5.5 Results and Discussion

5.5.1 Results

The occurrences of 13 types of GM in the corpora can be seen in Table 5.8. Since Types 1–4 are all about nominalization, they are grouped into one. Types 5 & 7 and Types 6 & 13 are about adjectivization but they are different. Types 5 & 7 are either "from process to quality" or "from relator to quality" while types 6 & 13 are either "from circumstance to quality" or "from entity to expansion". The four types are similar in that an adjectival word is used before a nominal. Types 8 & 9 result from verbalization. Type 11 is realized by typical shell nouns (SN). Type 12 refers to entities from nothing (e.g. *the phenomenon of*). Type 10 refers to cases where relator shifts to circumstance (e.g. *when = in times of / in … times*).

Mood metaphors can only be found in dialogues where intentions behind messages are ostensively shown, which is not usual in academic writing, so we only considered modality metaphors. As was mentioned in Sect. 5.4.2 (data processing), three types of modality metaphors were identified and the results can be seen in Table 5.9.

Table 5.8 Occurrences of 13 types of GM in the corpora

	Nominal (Types 1–4)	Adjectivization (Types 5&7)	Adjectivization (Types 6&13)	Verbalization (Types 8&9)	Typical SNs (Type 11)	Zero to Pro (Type 12)	Adverbial (Type 10)
TextBook-law	8266 (501.27)	276 (16.74)	2017 (122.32)	258 (15.65)	723 (43.85)	9 (0.55)	159 (9.64)
TextBook-linguistics	2161 (229.19)	123 (13.05)	535 (56.74)	131 (13.89)	240 (25.45)	6 (0.63)	83 (8.80)
TextBook-medicine	26,073 (520.43)	2171 (43.33)	7948 (158.65)	1117 (22.30)	987 (19.70)	12 (0.24)	658 (13.13)
TextBook-physics	9047 (238.33)	1546 (40.73)	2413 (63.57)	292 (7.69)	1046 (27.56)	2 (0.05)	247 (6.51)
BAWE-law	1087 (486.15)	33 (14.76)	244 (109.13)	34 (15.21)	79 (35.33)	1 (0.45)	11 (4.92)
BAWE-linguistics	1425 (257.76)	58 (10.49)	287 (51.91)	55 (9.95)	171 (30.93)	4 (0.72)	31 (5.61)
BAWE-medicine	805 (367.50)	53 (24.20)	173 (78.98)	48 (21.91)	19 (8.67)	0 0	13 (5.93)
BAWE-physics	676 (243.49)	106 (38.18)	153 (55.11)	44 (15.85)	103 (37.10)	1 (0.36)	16 (5.76)
FLOB-academic	6297 (391.27)	386 (23.98)	1412 (87.74)	266 (16.53)	419 (26.04)	11 (0.68)	137 (8.51)
LOB-academic	5468 (337.00)	375 (23.11)	1311 (80.80)	211 (13.00)	423 (26.07)	6 (0.37)	92 (5.67)
CLOB-academic	6456 (401.19)	382 (23.74)	1626 (101.04)	199 (12.37)	314 (21.19)	4 (0.25)	114 (7.08)

Note The numbers in the brackets are occurrences per 10k tokens
Key "Nomina" refers to "nominalization", SN refers to "shell noun", "Pro" refers to "process", and "Adverbial" refers to "adverbialization"

Table 5.9 Occurrences of modality metaphors in the corpora

	Modality (explicit subjective)	Modality (explicit objective)	Modality (intermediate)	Total
Textbook-law	243 (14.74)	596 (36.14)	64 (3.88)	903 (54.76)
Textbook -linguistics	157 (16.65)	134 (14.21)	23 (2.44)	314 (33.30)
Textbook - medicine	39 (0.78)	308 (6.15)	75 (1.50)	422 (8.42)
Textbook - physics	538 (14.17)	96 (2.53)	48 (1.26)	682 (17.97)
BAWE-law	48 (21.47)	79 (35.33)	14 (6.26)	141 (63.06)
BAWE-linguistics	101 (18.27)	221 (39.98)	31 (5.61)	353 (63.85)
BAWE- medicine	33 (15.07)	18 (8.22)	1 (0.46)	52 (23.74)
BAWE- physics	49 (17.65)	67 (24.13)	3 (1.08)	119 (42.86)
LOB-academic	134 (8.26)	378 (23.30)	41 (2.53)	553 (34.08)
FLOB-academic	257 (15.97)	361 (22.43)	36 (2.24)	654 (40.64)
CLOB-academic	123 (7.64)	323 (20.13)	40 (2.49)	487 (30.26)

Note The numbers in the brackets are occurrences per 10 k tokens

5.5.2 Variations across GMs Informed by Scholar GPT

We used Scholar GPT for in-depth statistic analysis. Before telling Scholar GPT the prompts, excel files were prepared with clear indications of variables and data. See Table 5.10.

We uploaded an excel file (Table 5.10) for Scholar GPT and used the following prompts (Do a statistic analysis of the data I upload. Please note that the top row and the left column are the variables. Generate correlation matrix for these variables. Keep two numbers after the decimal please.) Table 5.11 shows the correlations between the specific types of GM produced by Scholar GPT.

The following insights were revealed after analysis. The average values for each "Type" vary widely, with **Type1234** and **Type613** having the highest mean values (361.23 and 87.82, respectively). This suggests that these metrics capture relatively prominent characteristics within the data. Metrics such as **Type1234** and **Type613** also have high standard deviations (109.91 and 32.98), indicating significant variability across text categories. Conversely, **Type12** has a lower mean (0.39) and standard deviation (0.24), suggesting that it represents a less prevalent characteristic. Values across all "Type" metrics span a wide range, with minimum values as low as 4.92 (Type10) and maximums reaching 520.43 (Type1234). This indicates the presence of diverse features within the text categories.

ModalSub has a mean of 13.70, with values ranging from 0.78 to 21.47, reflecting moderate variability in its occurrence across the categories. **ModalObj** has a higher spread (mean of 21.14 and a standard deviation of 12.58), suggesting a wider distribution in its frequency or value across the dataset. **ModalInte** has the lowest mean

Table 5.10 GM as the main variable

	Type1234	Type57	Type613	Type89	Type10	Type11	Type12	ModalSub	ModalObj	ModalInte
TxTLaw	501.27	16.74	122.32	15.65	9.64	43.85	0.55	14.74	36.14	3.88
TxtLing	229.19	13.05	56.74	13.89	8.80	25.45	0.63	16.65	14.21	2.44
TxtMed	520.43	43.33	158.65	22.30	13.13	19.70	0.24	0.78	6.15	1.50
TxtPhys	238.33	40.73	63.57	7.69	6.51	27.56	0.05	14.17	2.53	1.26
BawLaw	486.15	14.76	109.13	15.21	4.92	35.33	0.45	21.47	35.33	6.26
BawLing	257.76	10.49	51.91	9.95	5.61	30.93	0.72	18.27	39.98	5.61
BawMed	367.50	24.20	78.98	21.91	5.93	8.67	0.00	15.07	8.22	0.46
BawPhys	243.49	38.18	55.11	15.85	5.76	37.10	0.36	17.65	24.13	1.08
LOB	337.00	23.11	80.80	13.00	5.67	26.07	0.37	8.26	23.30	2.53
FLOB	391.27	23.98	87.74	16.53	7.08	26.04	0.68	15.97	22.43	2.24
CLOB	401.19	23.74	101.04	12.37	7.08	21.19	0.25	7.64	20.13	2.49

Key Type1234 = Types 1–4; Type57 = Types 5&7; Type613 = Types 6&13; Type89 = Types 8 & 9; ModalSub = modality metaphor (explicit subjective); ModalObj = modality metaphor (explicit objective); ModalInte = modality metaphor (non-finiteness); TxTLaw = law texts in the Textbook Corpus; TxtLing = linguistics texts in the Textbook Corpus; TxtMed = medicine texts in the Textbook corpus; TxtPhys = physics texts in the Textbook corpus; BawLaw = law texts in the BAWE corpus; BawLing = linguistics texts in the BAWE corpus; BawMed = medicine texts in the BAWE corpus; BawPhys = physics texts in the BAWE corpus

Table 5.11 Rounded correlation matrix

	Type1234	Type57	Type613	Type89	Type10	Type11	Type12	ModalSub	ModalObj	ModalInte
Type1234	1	0	0.94	0.57	0.46	0.04	−0.05	−0.36	0.16	0.24
Type57	0	1	0.23	0.22	0.33	−0.21	−0.65	−0.53	−0.69	−0.71
Type613	0.94	0.23	1	0.57	0.69	−0.03	−0.15	−0.6	−0.06	0.07
Type89	0.57	0.22	0.57	1	0.46	−0.39	−0.21	−0.3	−0.24	−0.34
Type10	0.46	0.33	0.69	0.46	1	−0.09	0	−0.66	−0.34	−0.25
Type11	0.04	−0.21	−0.03	−0.39	−0.09	1	0.54	0.44	0.69	0.55
Type12	−0.05	−0.65	−0.15	−0.21	0	0.54	1	0.39	0.71	0.62
ModalSub	−0.36	−0.53	−0.6	−0.3	−0.66	0.44	0.39	1	0.5	0.44
ModalObj	0.16	−0.69	−0.06	−0.24	−0.34	0.69	0.71	0.5	1	0.83
ModalInte	0.24	−0.71	0.07	−0.34	−0.25	0.55	0.62	0.44	0.83	1

(2.70) and standard deviation (1.85), indicating more consistent values in comparison to the other modal metrics.

There is a very strong positive correlation (0.94) between **Type1234 and Type613**, indicating that as one increases, the other tends to increase similarly. **Type613 and Type10 [adverbialization]** also show a relatively strong positive correlation (0.69), suggesting a moderate positive relationship. This implies that adjectivizations usually co-occur with adverbialization as well. **Type57 [adjectivization] and ModalObj/ ModalSub are negatively correlated** ($r = -0.69$ and -0.65), which suggests that **ModalObj and ModalSub** tend to decrease as **Type57** increases. Type57 also shows a strong negative correlation with ModalInte ($r = -0.71$).

ModalObj and ModalInte have a high correlation ($r = 0.83$), indicating they tend to co-occur. ModalSub and ModalObj ($r = 0.5$) show a moderate positive correlation. ModalSub and ModalInte ($r = 0.44$) are also moderately correlated. ModalObj and ModalInte may provide similar information in predictive modeling or analysis due to their strong relationship.

5.5.3 Variations across Disciplines Informed by Scholar GPT

To observe variations across disciplines, we used corpora as the main variable and rebuilt the dataset (Table 5.12). Then we asked Scholar GPT to compare the trends of GMs in LOB, FLOB, and CLOB, and the results can be seen in Fig. 5.3.

It can be seen from Fig. 5.3 that Type1234 (typically nominalizations) are used far more often than other types in the academic texts of LOB family corpora. CLOB also shows much more uses of Type613 (Adjectivization co-occurring with Nominalization) but this can be ignored because of the time frame disadvantages in CLOB (See Footnote 4). FLOB uses slightly more ModalSub. The general trend is that the use of GMs is increasing from LOB to FLOB, particularly with Type1234 and Type613. The time span is 30 years (1960s for LOB and 1990s for FLOB). Other metaphors distribute almost evenly and no significant differences can be found. This result suggests that GM, nominalization and adjectivization in particular, can be an indicator of how academic corpora can be balanced, at least with disciplines of law, linguistics, medicine, and physics. This in general echoes the results in a recent study (i.e. McGrath and Liardét 2023). It also suggests that the GM distribution across the disciplines is a typical feature with persistent trend.

Next, we compared the GMs across the disciplines in the Textbook Corpus. It shows that law and medicine texts use far more nominalizations (Type1234) and adjectivization plus nominalization (Types 6 and 13). The law (but not medicine) textbook also uses more Type 11 (Zero to Entity) and ModalObj. See Fig. 5.4.

The general trend of GMs across the disciplines in the Baw Corpus is similar to that from the Textbook Corpus: law and medicine texts use far more nominalizations (Type1234) and adjectivization plus nominalization (Type613); and the law (but not medicine) textbook also uses more Type 11 (Zero to Entity) and ModalObj (Fig. 5.5). This finding echoes the conclusion that metadiscursive nouns are needed

Table 5.12 Corpus as the main variable

	TxTLaw	TxtLing	TxtMed	TxtPhys	BawLaw	BawLing	BawMed	BawPhys	LOB	**FLOB**	**CLOB**
Type1234	501.27	229.19	520.43	238.33	486.15	257.76	367.5	243.49	337	391.27	401.19
Type57	16.74	13.05	43.33	40.73	14.76	10.49	24.2	38.18	23.11	23.98	23.74
Type613	122.32	56.74	158.65	63.57	109.13	51.91	78.98	55.11	80.8	87.74	101.04
Type89	15.65	13.89	22.3	7.69	15.21	9.95	21.91	15.85	13	16.53	12.37
Type10	9.64	8.8	13.13	6.51	4.92	5.61	5.93	5.76	5.67	7.08	7.08
Type11	43.85	25.45	19.7	27.56	35.33	30.93	8.67	37.1	26.07	26.04	21.19
Type12	0.55	0.63	0.24	0.05	0.45	0.72	0	0.36	0.37	0.68	0.25
ModalSub	14.74	16.65	0.78	14.17	21.47	18.27	15.07	17.65	8.26	15.97	7.64
ModalObj	36.14	14.21	6.15	2.53	35.33	39.98	8.22	24.13	23.3	22.43	20.13
ModalInte	3.88	2.44	1.5	1.26	6.26	5.61	0.46	1.08	2.53	2.24	2.49

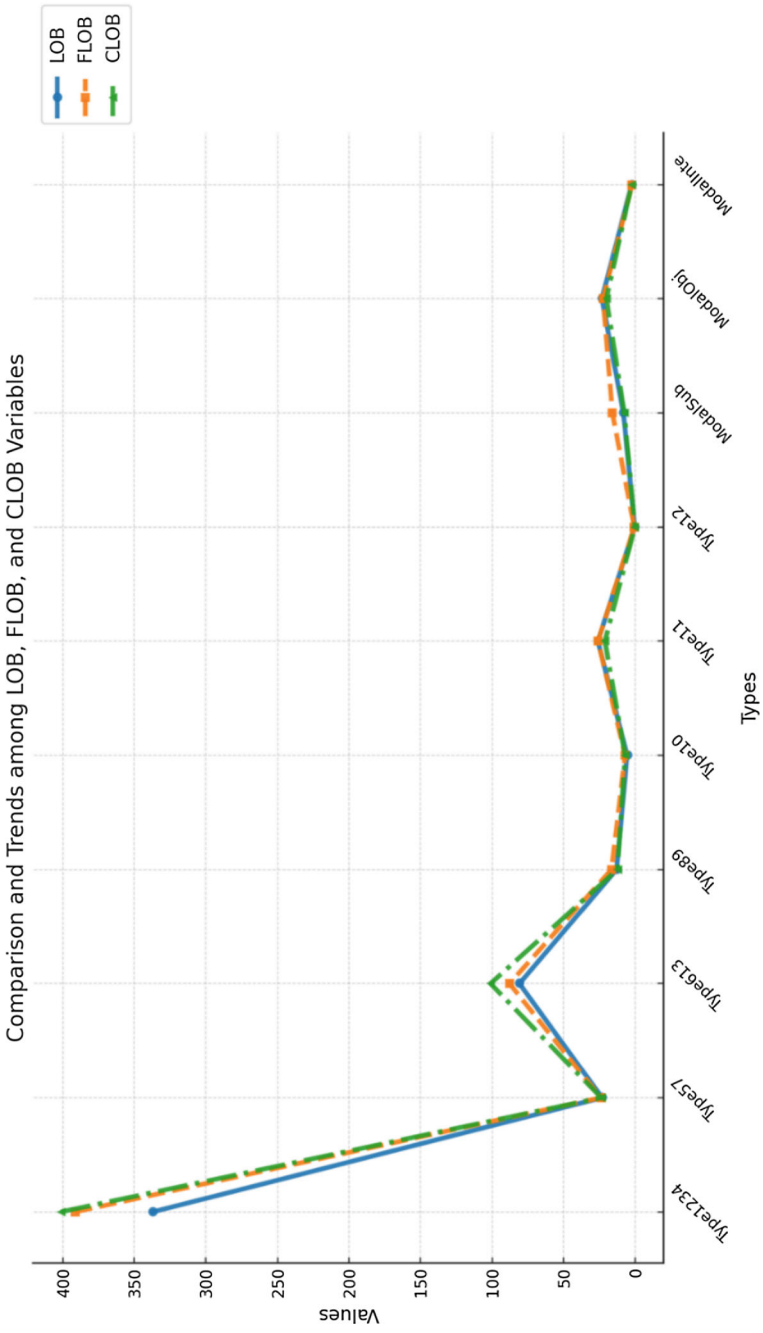


Fig. 5.3 The use of GMs across LOB, FLOB, and CLOB

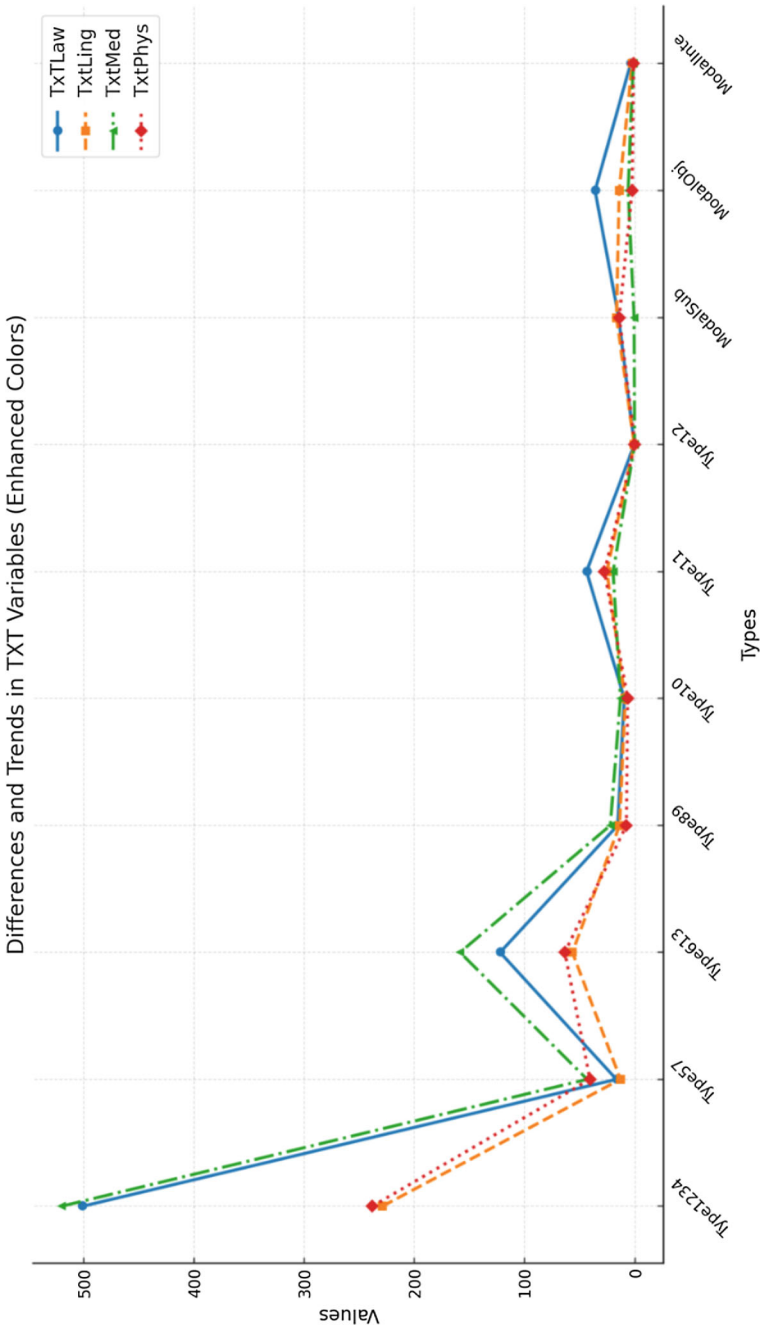


Fig. 5.4 The use of GMs across disciplines in textbooks

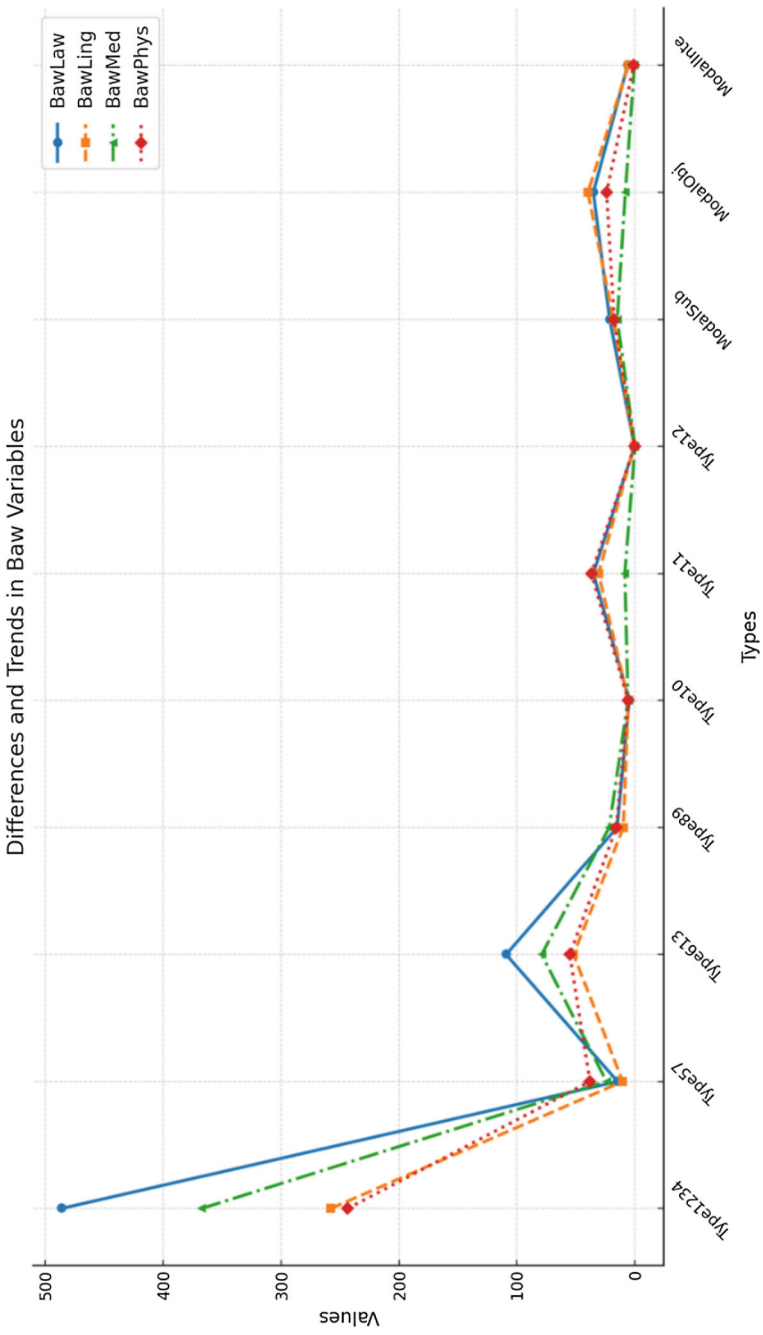


Fig. 5.5 The use of GMs across disciplines in the Baw corpus

for the rhetorical repertoire (Jiang and Hyland 2021), but it also reveals that the differentiation of hard sciences and soft sciences may be supplemented by a division of sciences related more/less to human society. Metadiscursive nouns, a type of unspecific abstract nouns closely related to GM, have increased in hard sciences while evidential nouns for factual support are more preferred in soft sciences (Jiang and Hyland 2021). By contrast, it seems that more human-relevant (law and medicine) disciplines prefer more nominalizations as well.

To be specific, nominalizations (Type1234) and adjectivization (Type613) occur more in TxtLaw and TxtMed, about twice as much as those in TxtLing or TxtPhys. The fact that nominalizations are used more often in law (a typical discipline of social science) and medicine (a discipline of life science which is directly linked to human being and society) may show that, disciplines connected with direct human concerns prefer entities (usually abstract meanings compressed out of events, states, or activities). Linguistics which is language about language, and physics which is typical hard science, are not found in using nominalizations so often. This is different from the findings on hard/soft sciences in Jiang and Hyland (2021) because GMs may not necessarily be quality nouns or evidential nouns.

This is also true to nominalizations in BawLaw and BawMed, but the difference is not so significant to adjectivizations (Type613) in BawMed. In the Baw Corpus, only law is the discipline in which Type 6 & 13 occur most. Types 6 & 13 occur twice as much in TxtMed as in BawMed (158.65: 78.98). Compared with FLOB-academic (87.74), it may be said that Types 6 & 13 are underused by medicine students who write distinct/merit academic papers.

Types 5 & 7 (e.g. *is increasing = increasing; begin to = initial*) occur much more in medicine and physics than in law and linguistics for both the Textbook Corpus and the Baw Corpus. This means that typical adjectivizations are more preferrable in life/hard sciences than in humanities and social sciences. In other words, a process or a relator is more likely to be replaced by a quality in life/hard sciences than in humanities and social sciences.

Types 8 & 9 as verbalization (e.g. *be about = concern; be instead of = replace; then = follow; so = cause; and = complement*) do not occur much, particularly in TxtPhys. This indicates that hard sciences like physics do not tend to change circumstance into process, or relator into process. This is also true to BawLing, containing only about half occurrences of the other disciplines. Since BAWE is a corpus of academic texts written by students, it may as well mean that students in linguistics still need improvement in using verbalizations in their writings.

Type 11 (Zero to Entity) occurs most in TxtLaw while least in BawMed. This type is composed of typical shell nouns which may be understood to capsulate "complex, proposition-like pieces of information" (Schmid 2000: 4). The discipline of law tends to use shell nouns more often and it seems that much more information have been encapsulated in law texts. By contrast, the discipline of medicine prefers not to use shell nouns.

Only a few cases can be found for Type 12 (Zero to Process) in the disciplines, and no such case was found in BawMed. It seems that in the academic writings in general, constructions such as "it occurs (happens, rises, arises, ensures, enables)"

are seldom used. This also indicates that academic writings tend to be grounded in specific entities and it is not usual to start "from nothing to process".

The distribution of modality metaphors is quite different in some aspects. ModalSub occurs most in BawLaw (21.47 per 10 k) while least in TxtMed (0.78 per 10 k). In the Textbook Corpus, the disciplines of law, linguistics and physics contain almost the similar occurrences of explicit subjective expressions (around 14 per 10 k) while the discipline of medicine contains only 0.78 occurrences per 10 k. This means that the textbook of medicine avoids using explicit subjective expressions. In the Baw Corpus, the disciplines contain around 15–21 occurrences per 10 k of this type (15.97), and this is very close to FLOB-academic.

Within the Textbook corpus, explicit objective expressions occur most in law (far more than those in FLOB-academic, 36.14:22.43), and least in physics (2.53), and second to least in medicine (6.15). In other words, both physics and medicine do not use explicit objective expressions much. By contrast, the Baw Corpus shows that linguistics contains most uses of explicit objectives (39.98), a little higher than law (35.33). The occurrences for physics are very close to FLOB-academic. However, medicine only contains 8.22 occurrences per 10 k. This means both law and linguistics students prefer explicit objective expressions while students in medicine do not. This imbalance may suggest that proficiency in academic writing plays a part.

As to the intermediate type (non-finite usages), the FLOB-academic contains 2.24 per 10 k, and only TxtLing (2.44) is very close to it. TxtLaw contains 3.88 occurrences per 10 k which is higher, TxtMed and TxtPhys contain far less. By contrast, BawLaw and BawLing contain more than twice (6.26 and 5.61) as much as that in FLOB-academic while BawMed (0.46) and BawPhys (1.08) contain much less than FLOB-academic. This may suggest that it is problematic for students to use the intermediate type: either too many in law and linguistics or too few in medicine and physics.

Since FLOB-academic is widely acknowledged as the representative of academic writings, it is useful to compare the corpora under study with LOB-academic. We uploaded the data (See Table 5.12) and used the prompt (Compare Type and Modal variables in different Txt, and then visualize the results) in Scholar GPT. The results can be seen in Fig. 5.6.

Compared with FLOB-academic, TxtLaw and TxtMed use more nominalizations (Type1234) and adjectivizations (Type613) while TxtLing and TxtPhys use less (Fig. 5.7); TxtLaw also uses more instances of Zero to Entity (Type11) and less explicit objective expressions (ModalObj) than FLOB-academic.

Compared with FLOB-academic, only BawLaw uses more nominalizations (Type1234) and adjectivizations (Type613) while BawLing and BawPhys use less (Fig. 5.7). BawMed uses almost the same amount of Type1234 and Type613 with FLOB-academic, but it uses fewer instances of Zero to Entity (Type11) and fewer explicit objective expressions (ModalObj) than FLOB-academic. This suggests that proficiency in academic writing influences the use of GMs.

Overall, the results supports the view in the literature that some disciplinary variations are significant (Hyland 2006), and it also supports the view that the ideational GM across disciplines is very similar and it plays a central role in academic discourse

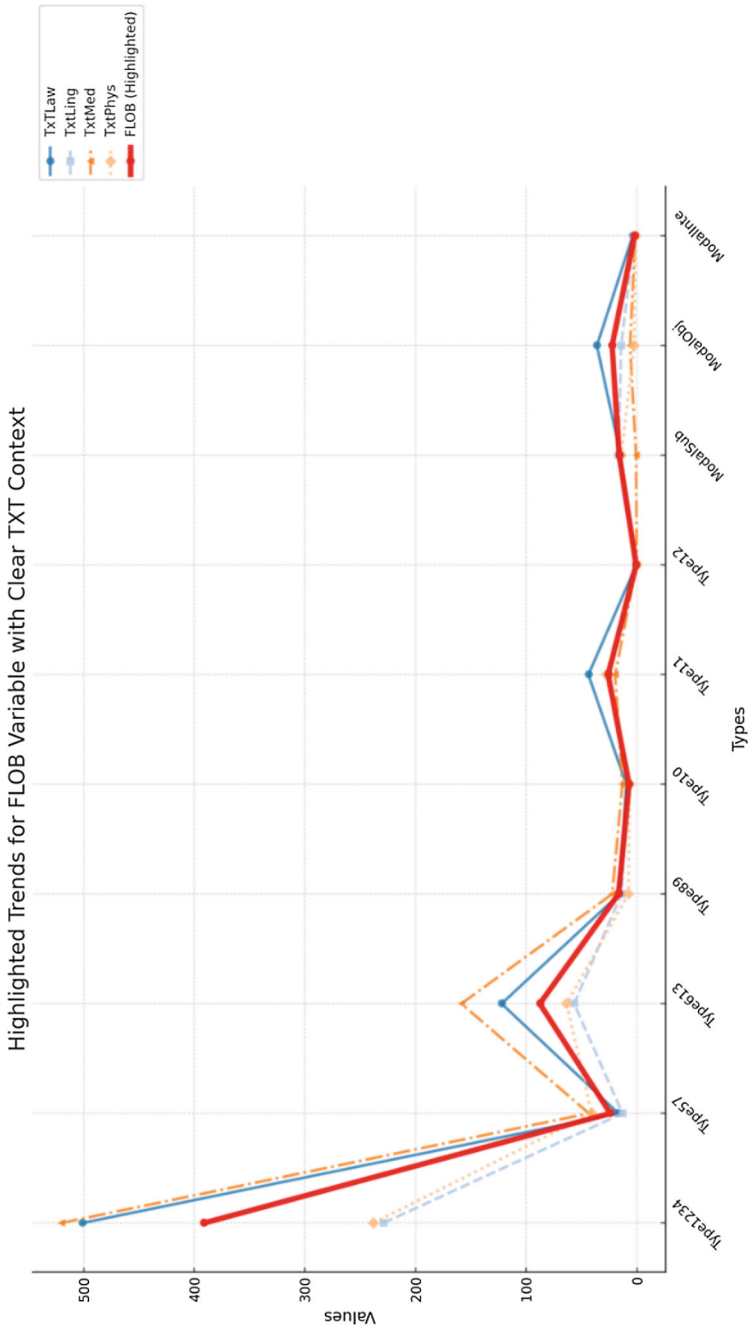


Fig. 5.6 Comparing the use of GMs in textbook and FLOB

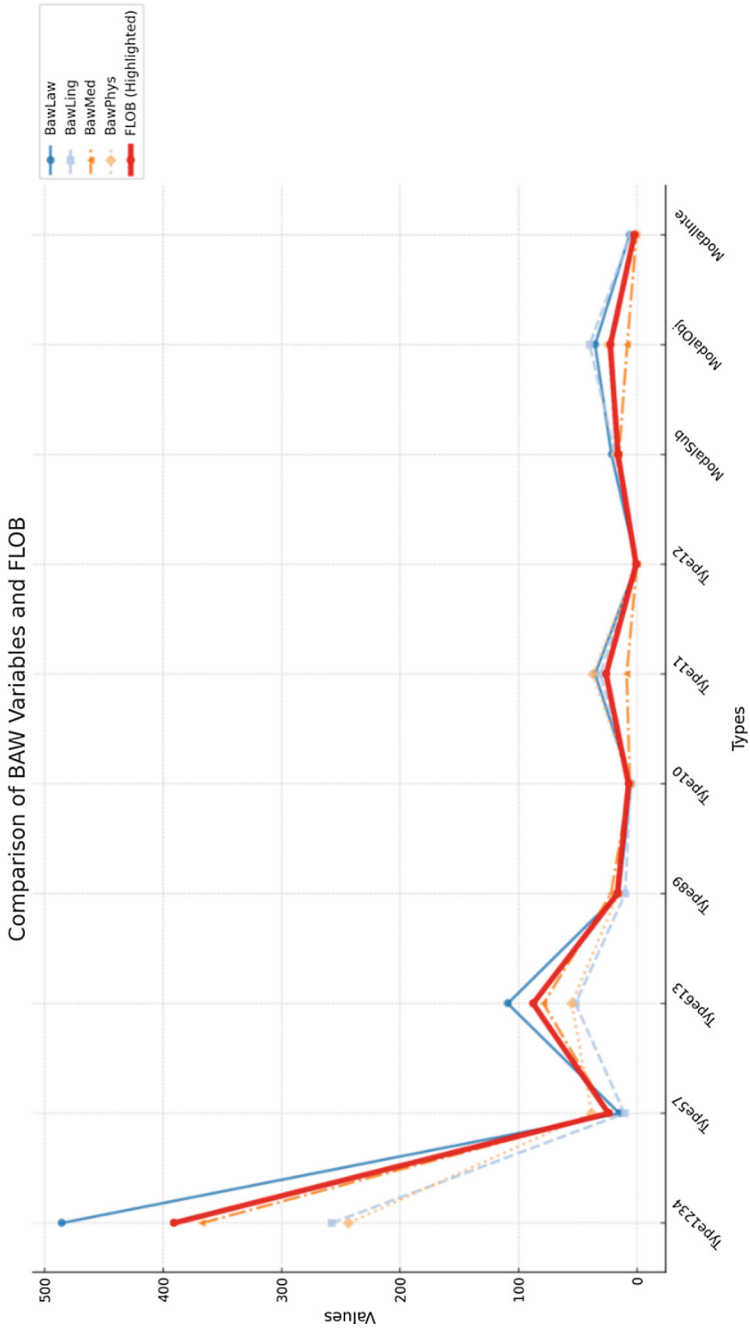


Fig. 5.7 Comparing the use of GMs in Baw and FLOB

(McGrath and Liardét 2023). Moreover, the use of modality metaphors, though not many in general, is also an important feature of academic discourse. Still, significant variations do occur between disciplines.

5.6 Conclusion

It is important for instructors across disciplines to help students write well (Adler-Kassner and Wardle 2022). The analysis highlights that the distribution of grammatical metaphors (GM) across disciplines like law (social science), linguistics (arts & humanities), medicine (life science), and physics (hard science) reflects distinctive academic writing styles and trends. Nominalization and adjectivization are prevalent across disciplines, emphasizing abstract entities over processes. Disciplines linked to human concerns (life science and social science) favor compressed abstract entities.

Adjectivization is more common in hard sciences, though its overuse among students in academic papers is noted. Meanwhile, "Zero to Process" constructions, such as "it happens" or "it arises", are rare across disciplines, emphasizing a preference for grounding writings in specific entities. Physics and linguistics texts written by students exhibit minimal use of verbalizations, implying the impact of proficiency on the use of GMs and also the need for improvement in transforming relational or circumstantial meanings into processes.

Modality metaphors (subjective and objective) also vary significantly. Explicit subjective expressions occur most in law texts and least in medicine, with medicine avoiding subjective language in favor of direct factual reporting. Explicit objective expressions are highest in law texts and lowest in physics and medicine. Intermediate modality types (non-finite forms) are overused in law and linguistics while underused in medicine and physics. These trends highlight inconsistencies in student writing compared to established academic standards, as represented by FLOB-academic.

Again, the use of modality metaphors is much influenced by proficiency. Law and medicine textbooks use more nominalizations and adjectivizations compared to FLOB-academic, while linguistics and physics use less. Law textbooks contain more instances of "Zero to Entity" constructions but fewer explicit objective expressions, aligning with their encapsulation of complex information. In contrast, BawLaw texts exhibit higher nominalization and adjectivization frequencies, suggesting that student writings may exaggerate these features compared to professional standards. Physics and medicine show distinct trends. Medicine, being tied to human concerns, prefers direct factual language, avoiding encapsulation or explicit subjectivity, whereas physics, as a hard science, minimizes verbalizations and modality metaphors, grounding its discourse in precise factual descriptions. Linguistics, a meta-disciplinary field, balances tendencies toward encapsulation and modality but shows discrepancies in the use of verbalization and intermediate modality types, indicating areas for refinement in academic writing.

The findings suggest that GM distribution reflects disciplinary preferences and can serve as a benchmark for balancing academic writing. Overuse or underuse

of certain types, especially by students, highlights potential areas for improvement in writing instruction. Disciplines like law, linguistics, and medicine, tied closely to human concerns, prefer nominalization and adjectivization, while hard sciences like physics lean toward explicit, process-based constructions. Understanding these trends can help guide academic writing practices, ensuring discipline-appropriate and balanced use of grammatical metaphors. The general trend is that there is an increasing use of GMs and GM is a persistent feature. The use of GMs also depends on the proficiency in academic language. In a word, the use of GMs is discipline common, time constrained, and proficiency dependent. In the future, disciplines which cover other subjects in social sciences, hard sciences, and humanities may be examined, yet the prediction is that variations may exist but GM will still be prevalent and serves as a useful tool for evaluating purposes.

5.7 Declaration of Generative AI in Scientific Writing

During the preparation of this work the author used Scholar GPT by Openai.com for statistic analysis. No other AI tools/services were used during the writing of the paper.

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Chapter 6
A Cardiff Grammar's Syntactico-Semantic Analysis of the Existential Enhanced Theme Construction in English

Renhua Deng

Abstract The present research explores the syntactico-semantic analysis of locational, attributive, directional, and possessive existential enhanced theme (EET) constructions in English, in particular, their transitivity and thematic analyses. In transitivity analysis, the participant role (PR) common in the four types of EET constructions is Carrier, it is the second PR in each—Location, Attribute, Direction, or Possessed—that distinguishes one from another. Thematically, what is common in the four types of EET constructions is that there is the 'thematic build-up' usually composed of 'there' and 'be' in the clause-initial position, followed by the existential enhanced theme enhanced by it. The element which can be enhanced are the Process and the two basic PRs in each, one being Carrier and the other being Location, Attribute, Direction, or Possessed, respectively. Among the Carriers, Simple Carrier is the element that is most frequently thematized compared to Agent-Carrier and Affected-Carrier. When Carrier is not EET, the other basic PR in the locational, attributive, and possessive EET constructions (Location, Attribute, or Possessed) can also be enhanced. Alternatively, the Process and its dependent roles in the locational, directional, and possessive types of EET constructions (Location, Direction, and Affected-Carrier) can also be enhanced: And all these thematic options are captured in an EET system network. It is hoped that this research can contribute to a deeper understanding of the 4 types of EET constructions in English from an alternative systemic functional perspective.

Keywords Cardiff Grammar · Syntactico-semantic analysis · Existential enhanced theme constructions

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(1a)	It was	an old man	that I saw.
(1b)	It is	likely	that ivy had a margarita.
(1c)	There's	a bee	in ivy's hair.
(1d)	It implies	a lack of genuine confidence	that he fails to put the issue to the voters
	thematic build-up	Enhanced Theme	

Fig. 6.1 Four types of enhanced theme constructions (adapted from Fawcett 2003)

(2)	There	will be	a meeting	in Room 305	tomorrow morning.
		Process	Existent: entity	Circumstance: place	Circumstance: time

Fig. 6.2 The transitivity analysis of a locational EET construction in the Hallidayan approach

6.1 Introduction

The research object of this article is the existential enhanced theme (EET) construction in English, which figures prominently in much linguistic literature under the aliases of the existentials (Freeze 1992; Hannay 1985; Wang, 2024; Ziv 1982), the existential clause (Downing and Locke 1992; Eggins 1994, 2004; Halliday, 1985, 1994/2000; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004 2014; Thompson 1996/2000, 2004; van Ek and Robat 1984), the existential sentence (Zhang and Ni 2012; Ziv 1982), the existential *there*-sentence (Ward and Birner 1995), the *there*-construction (Ungerer et al. 1984), the existential construction (Huddleston, 1988), the existential *there*-clause (Winter 1982), or the existential *there*-construction (Gómez-González, 2001). The EET construction is one of the four enhanced theme constructions in the Cardiff model of systemic functional grammar (the Cardiff Grammar, CG)[1] (Fawcett, 1980, 1995, 2000, 2003; in preparation a; in preparation b). The four types of enhanced theme constructions in English (Fig. 6.1) are: (1) the **experiential** enhanced theme construction (*it*-cleft sentence), as in (1a); (2) the **evaluative** enhanced theme construction (*it* extraposition), as in (1b); (3) the **existential** enhanced theme construction, as in (1c); and (4) the **event-relating** enhanced theme construction, as in (1d).

[1] According to Fawcett (2000: 6), there are at least four models of systemic functional theories of language: (1) the 'Sydney Grammar', (2) the 'Cardiff Grammar', (3) the 'Nottinghan Grammar', and (4) the 'Leuven Grammar'.

(3)	there	was	an old woman		tossed up	in a basket.
		Process	Existent: Entity		Process: material	Circumstance
	α: Extended				β: Extending	

Fig. 6.3 Halliday's transitivity analysis of a locational EET construction with a locating clause (Halliday 1994/2000: 143; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 259; 2014: 309)

As can be seen from Fig. 6.1, the **Enhanced Theme**[2] is the underlined portion of each construction. What is common in the four types of enhanced theme constructions is that 'there is the phenomenon of **thematic build-up**, through which the Performer signals to the Addressee that an Enhanced Theme is about to be presented' (Fawcett 2003: 87) Fig 6.2. The enhancement of the Enhanced Theme is achieved by 'a means that involves placing the element further from the start of the clause than it might otherwise be (e.g. if it were made a Marked PR [Participant Role] Theme)' (Fawcett 2003: 87; in preparation a: 113). In other words, it is through thematic build-up in the clause-initial position that the element which is to be enhanced is placed further from the start of the clause than it might otherwise be. As is noted by Fawcett (2003, in preparation a), the displacement of the element creates a special effect—'It is as if the delay between announcing that the Theme is coming and its actual presentation builds up the Addressee's expectations, so enhancing the effect when finally–but only milliseconds later–the Performers presents the Enhanced Theme itself' (Fawcett 2003: 87).

The EET construction will be approached from the perspective of the Cardiff Grammar Fig 6.4, since the innovative research of the enhanced theme constructions, including the EET construction, has been done by Robin Fawcett and Huang Guowen Fig 6.3, two leading scholars in the Cardiff Grammar.

The overall aim of the research is to propose an alternative systemic functional analysis of the EET construction in English from the perspective of the Cardiff Grammar Fig 6.5. To achieve this aim, the present study is intended to answer the following three questions: (1) Why is it necessary to undertake an investigation of the EET construction from an alternative systemic functional perspective? (2) What is the syntactic and semantic configuration of EET constructions from the perspective the Cardiff Grammar? (3) What are the elements that can serve as EET and what is the network of EET like?

In order to pave the way for the description of the EET construction from the Cardiff Grammar Fig 6.6, it is necessary to identify the different types of EET constructions and review how they are treated in the Sydney model of systemic functional grammar (the Sydney Grammar, SG) first.

[2] It is so called because the strength of its thematic value has been increased or enhanced by the preceding 'thematic build-up'.

6.2 Types of EET Constructions

According to our collected samples, EET constructions are largely relational in their transitivity analysis (to be discussed in detail in Sect. 5). Or rather they fall into the four types of the relational process in the Cardiff Grammar:

(i) the locational EET construction.

However, there is one big problem here. (BNC ADF936).
There is an unwritten rule in their crowd. (BNC CAH1246).

(ii) the attributive EET construction.

There are only some of our patients really mad. (Hannay 1985: 150).
There's no doubt that computers have an application for us. (Collins 1992).

(iii) the directional EET construction.

There was slowly making its way toward us a figure in black. (Bolinger 1977: 102).
There walked into the courtroom two people I had thought were dead. (Kuno and Takami 2004: 35).

(iv) the possessive EET construction.

There was presented to me a papaya. (www.unification.net/ws/theme140.htm).
There was presented (to the winner) by the mayor a gold medal. (Quirk et al. 1985:1409).

There is evidence that suggests there may be another type of EET construction, the actional type.

(v) the actional EET construction.

At this point, there hit the embankment a shell from our line. (Kuno and Takami 2004: 41).

Huddleston and Pullum (2002, 1393, 1395) argue that the participial 'extensions' in such EET constructions as *There were some boys playing cricket* and *There were several people killed* should not be treated as part (Postmodifier) of the postverbal nominal group, but as elements independent of the nominal group. Since such EET constructions usually have their non-enhanced counterparts (*Some boys were playing cricket* and *Several people were killed*, for example), which are clauses of the action process, such EET constructions may as well be treated as clauses of the action process. Since in our samples the number of the actional EET construction is relatively small compared to the other 4 types, this paper will mainly focus on the first four types of EET constructions except in the thematic choices in such construction in order to give a full picture of the EET network.

6.3 Sydney Grammar's Studies of the EET Construction

In this sect. I shall mainly examine the transitivity analysis of the locational EET constructions in Halliday's tradition and discuss the thematic approaches of Halliday, Thompson, and Huang to this construction and the inadequacies in their thematic analyses.

6.3.1 Halliday's Analysis of the Locational EET Construction

Halliday (1985, 1994/2000) and Halliday and Matthiessen (2004, 2014) only give functional analysis of the locational EET construction, but do not touch upon the other three types of EET constructions. So I shall first introduce briefly Halliday and Matthiessen's transitivity and thematic analyses of the locational EET construction, and then try to follow their approach and probe into the transitivity and thematic analyses of the other three types of EET constructions.

In *An Introduction to Functional Grammar* (Halliday 1985: 130–131, 1994/2000: 142–143; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 256–259; Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 307–310) the locational EET construction is treated as the clause of the existential process, one of the six types of processes that construe the world of experience. In the existential process, 'Existent' (Carrier in CG), the object or event which is said to exist, is the only participant. The 'Existent' is frequently located by a circumstantial element of time or place:

'Another very common way of "locating" the process in space-time is to follow it with a nonfinite clause' (Halliday 1994/2000: 142; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 258; Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 309):

The analysis of Halliday (and Matthiessen) indicates that (3) is a clause complex, in which *tossed up in a basket* is treated as a clause dependent on the dominant clause *there was an old woman*, and the dependent clause extends the dominant clause in logico-semantic relation. And *there's someone waiting at the door* and *there's a patient to see you* can also be treated in a similar vein.

Although the existential *there* is 'neither a participant nor a circumstance' (Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 257; 2014: 308) and therefore has 'no representational function' in transitivity (Halliday 1985: 130; 1994/2000: 142; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 257; 2014: 308), Halliday (1985: 45; 1994/2000: 44) and Halliday and Matthiessen (2004: 73) claim that 'the impersonal pronoun' *there* is the Theme in the EET construction because 'textually, the Theme is just the feature of existence (*there*), allowing the addressee to prepare for something to be introduced (Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 257)'. Eggins (1994: 157, 255, 290; 2004: 238, 313) and Hu et al. (1989) adopt the same approach to the construction.

According to a personal face-to-face consultation with Halliday,[3] his transitivity analysis of the attributive (4, 5a–5b), directional (6), and possessive (7) EET constructions are relational, material, and material in process types, as is illustrated by the following examples:

6.3.2 *Matthiessen's (1995) Analysis of the Locational EET Construction*

Matthiessen's (1995) classification of the processes (Fig. 5.9) is different from that of Halliday (1985, 1994/2000) and Halliday and Matthiessen (2004, 2014). He identifies only four types of processes—material, mental, relational, and verbal, and Halliday's existential process is classified as 'a limiting case of being–a mode of being with only one participant' (Matthiessen 1995: 299).

Matthiessen's transitivity analysis of the locational EET construction also differs slightly from that of Halliday. The slight difference is that Halliday's (1985, 1994/2000) 'circumstance' has been replaced by 'Location', though it still remains to be a circumstantial element:

(8) [Location:] On that side there [Process:] is [Existent:] a big house. (Matthiessen 1995: 299)

Despite the different classifications of the processes in the Transitivity system and the slight difference in the transitivity analysis, Matthiessen's thematic analysis of the EET construction is exactly the same as that of Halliday. He claims that *there* is still the unmarked topical Theme although it is not a participant role. He even puts forward three reasons in support of Halliday's analysis. And his third reason seems to be forceful to some extent, but it can be easily turned into a strong argument for taking *There* as Textual Theme, as in one of Huang's proposed thematic analyses of the locational EET construction (see Sect. 3.3).

> Third, at least in the case of existential clauses, the unmarked thematic organization of the clause is arguably such that its existential nature is thematic. That is, **while the Theme is not an ideational element, it still serves to indicate that the clause is existential in its transitivity selection.** This is related to its typical **textual** use. The "point of departure" is the anticipation that an Existent will be presented as a potentially new discourse referent (the so-called "presentative" function of existential clauses)… (Matthiessen 1995: 547, my emphasis)

[3] I'd like to extend my heartfelt thanks to Professor Halliday for discussing those examples with me during his visit (September 20–24, 2005) to Sun Yat-sen University.

6.3.3 Thompson's (1996/2000) And Huang's (1997, 1999) Analyses of the Locational EET Construction

The fact that Halliday takes an element without experiential meaning (the existential *there*) as the Theme of the locational EET construction has evoked queries from some scholars in the systemic functional grammar. They have endeavored to search for alternative thematic analyses. In this sect. I shall present the thematic approaches of Thompson (1996/2000) and Huang (1997, 1999) to the locational EET construction and discuss the remaining issues in their thematic analyses.

Halliday's thematic analysis of the locational EET construction obviously violates his own principle relevant to thematic analysis—The Theme (always)[4] contains one, and only one of these experiential elements (Halliday 1994/2000: 52; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 79). And it is exactly because of this inadequacy that has evoked the queries of some scholars, including Thompson (1996/2000), Huang (1997, 1999). Thompson (1996/2000) and Huang (1997, 1999) have come up with alternative thematic analyses of the EET construction.

Thompson (1996/2000: 138; 2004: 161) argues that locational EET constructions 'typically take as their starting-point the simple fact that some entity exists' and that 'The existence is signaled not just by "there" but "there" plus the existential process (typically realized by the verb "be")'. Therefore, he proposes that the Theme of the locational EET construction should be 'there' plus the existential process instead of 'there' alone. Thompson's thematic analysis of the locational EET construction is illustrated as follows:

Drawing on Halliday's (1985, 1994/2000) thematic analysis of the imperative clauses (directives in CG), Huang (1997: 113–114; 1999: 141–149) puts forward a thematic approach similar to that of Thompson. He suggests that the 'Operator/Predicator' (Operator/Main Verb in CG) in the locational EET construction, like the Operator/Main Verb in the imperative clauses, can also serve as the Theme. He also proposes that *There* can be taken as 'Textual Theme'. Huang's thematic analysis of the locational EET construction is exemplified in Fig. 6.7.

Although Thompson and Huang do not jointly propose the practice of taking '*there*' plus the process as the Theme, their thematic approaches are virtually the same. Thus they will be treated as one approach in the subsequent discussion.

[4] The word 'always' is dropped in Halliday and Matthiessen (2004: 79).

(4)	There	are	only some of our patients	really mad.
		Process: intensive	Carrier	Attribute

(5a)	There	's	a friend of mine	captain of the local football team.
		Process: intensive	Identified	Identifier

(5b)	…there	's	one of them	John's.
		Process: possessive	Possessed/Identified	Possessor/Identifier

(6)	There	was	slowly	making its way	toward us	a figure in black.
		Process	Circ	material	Circ	Actor

(7)	There	was presented	(to the winner)	by the mayor	a gold medal.
		Pr: material	Beneficiary	Actor	Goal

Fig. 6.4 Halliday's transitivity analysis of attributive, directional and possessive EET constructions

6.3.4 Remaining Issues in Sydney Grammar's Studies of EET Constructions

6.3.4.1 Remaining Issues in the Analyses of EET Constructions in Hallidayan Approach

It is not clear what Halliday's thematic analysis of the attributive, directional, and possessive EET constructions is like. But what is clear is that it is not appropriate to take *there* in those three types of constructions as the unmarked Theme, since the reason that Halliday and Matthiessen come up with for taking *there* as the unmarked Theme in the locational EET construction—'textually, the Theme is just the feature of existence (*there*), allowing the addressee to prepare for something to be introduced' (Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 257; 2014: 308)—is inappropriate, now that the other types of EET constructions are not treated as clauses of the existential process. We cannot decide that an EET construction is existential merely by searching for the

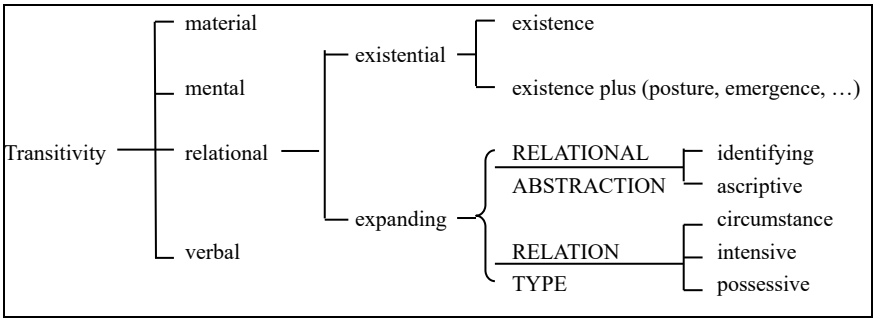


Fig. 6.5 Matthiessen's classification of processes (adapted from Matthiessen 1995: 223, 297)

existential *there* in the clause initial position, and sometimes we cannot decide the process type of an EET construction until we come to the end of the construction.

According to the principle of thematic analysis proposed by Halliday (1994/2000: 52) and Halliday and Matthiessen (2004: 79; 2014: 105)—The Theme (always)[5] contains one, and only one of the experiential elements of the process, the participants and any circumstantial elements, it may be a reasonable supposition that Halliday will take the Process (usually realized by the Main Verb *be*) as the unmarked Theme in the attributive, directive, and possessive constructions, as illustrated in Fig. 6.8.

Nevertheless, it is also a moot point how Halliday will capture the role of *there* in this (supposed) thematic analysis of the attributive, directional, and possessive EET constructions—whether it is Textual Theme, Interpersonal Theme, or the conflation of Textual Theme and Interpersonal Theme. As will be found in the subsequent discussion of Huang's (1997, 1999) thematic analysis of the locational EET construction, the practice of taking the Process as the unmarked (Topical) Theme is problematic in some way.

6.3.4.2 Remaining Issues in Thompson and Huang's Thematic Analysis of Locational EET Constructions

Since the Theme in Thompson and Huang's thematic analysis of the locational EET construction contains an experiential element (the process), their analysis complies with Halliday's thematic principle. However, it will be revealed in the following discussion that in their analysis there remain three issues to be resolved. The first issue involves the markedness of the Topical Theme in their analysis. The second issue is about the thematic status of the simple past or the simple present forms of the verb *be* in the 'polar interrogative' (polarity seeker in CG) EET construction. And the third concerns whether *there* should be treated as part of the Theme in the polar interrogative locational EET construction.

[5] The word 'always' is dropped in Halliday and Matthiessen (2004: 79).

It is not clear whether the Topical Theme (realized by the Process) in the thematic analysis of Thompson and Huang is unmarked or marked Theme. But what is clear is that it cannot be the unmarked Theme if Halliday's thematic approach is followed, since the unmarked Theme of a 'declarative clause' (information giver in CG), according to Halliday (1994/2000: 43), is 'the mapping of Theme on to Subject'. However, the Process is the element with the highest probability of being as Topical Theme in this type of construction, since the Process is the element which is always present in Halliday's 'existential clauses' (locational EET constructions in CG) whereas they may not have the existential *there* or the 'circumstantial elements' (Location in CG), as is illustrated by (11) and (12), respectively.

(11) all around (there) grew a thick hedge. (Halliday, 1994/2000: 142)
(12) there was a storm. (Halliday, 1994/2000: 143)

Since the Process is the element with the highest probability of serving as 'Topical Theme' in the locational EET construction, it can be argued that it should be the unmarked Theme. So I propose that probability should serve as a more reliable criterion for judging whether an element is marked or unmarked Theme, not only in information givers (declarative clauses in SG) but also in information seekers (interrogative clauses in SG).

The function of the simple past or simple present forms of the verb *be* is not fully represented in (Thompson and) Huang's thematic analysis of the 'polar interrogative' locational EET construction. Huang (1997, 117; 1999: 145) presents the thematic analysis of such an EET construction, as in (13a):

(13a) Is (Topical Theme) there (Textual Theme) (Theme)||any more soup (Rheme)? (Huang, 1997: 117; 1999: 145, original in Chinese)
(13b) Is (**Interpersonal/**Topical Theme) there (Textual Theme) (Theme) ||any more soup (Rheme)?

Huang's analysis shows that *Is* in (13a) is merely the 'Topical Theme'. But actually it should be **both** the Interpersonal Theme **and** the Topical Theme (the conflation of Interpersonal Theme and Topical Theme), as indicated in (13b), since the Interpersonal meaning of 'Mood' in the EET construction is realized by the configuration of *is* (Operator) and *there* (Subject). Therefore, Deng (2003, 132; 2019: 101) proposes that the verb *be* in its simple past or simple present forms in the 'polar interrogative' EET construction realizes the Interpersonal Theme **and** the Topical Theme, rather than the Topical Theme alone, as is indicated in (13a).

Another point worthy of note is that *there*, which occurs after the Topical Theme, is treated as Textual Theme. If Halliday's principle on thematic analysis were strictly followed, it should not have been taken as part of Theme. However, Huang (1997, 1999) doesn't account for this anomaly.

The contradiction between the thematic analysis of Huang (and Thompson) and Halliday's principle in thematic analysis—'in any case, the experiential element (the Topical Theme) comes last – anything following this is part of the Rheme' (Halliday 1994/2000: 53)—obviously demands an explanation. One possible account for including '*there*' in the Theme lies in the dependency of thematic system on

the choices in the Transitivity and Mood systems: the thematic system is not an autonomous one and has to depend on the choices in the systems of Transitivity and Mood. That is, the function of Theme is to enable the expression of experiential and interpersonal meanings—the so-called 'enabling' function of Theme. Since '*is*' alone is not adequate in realizing the interpersonal meaning of Mood, the Subject '*there*' should be included in the Theme, as in (13b).

6.4 Previous Cardiff Grammar's Studies of the Locational EET Construction

Due to the remaining problems mentioned above in the transitivity and thematic analyses of EET constructions in the Sydney Grammar, in this sect. I shall introduce an alternative approach to the construction from the perspective of the Cardiff Grammar, which is drastically different from those in the Sydney Grammar. The syntactic and semantic configuration of the four types of EET constructions will be analyzed in line with the Cardiff Grammar. In particular, this section will investigate the transitivity analysis and explore the thematic options in the construction. And a comparison will be made between the Sydney Grammar and the Cardiff Grammar in the transitivity analysis of the clauses denoting the existential meaning, and Huang's (1997, 1999) existential enhanced theme analysis will be compared with that of Fawcett (2003; in preparation a) and with Halliday's thematic analysis of the locational EET construction.

6.4.1 The Transitivity Analysis of the Locational EET Construction

Since EET constructions in our collected samples are predominantly relational in transitivity analysis in the Cardiff Grammar, it will be necessary to ascertain how the relational process is classified in the Cardiff Grammar.

6.4.1.1 The Relational Process in the Cardiff Grammar

In the Cardiff Grammar 5 subprocesses are identified in its relational process—locational, attributive, directional, possessive, and matching. The five subprocesses are further divided into four categories, largely depending on the different statuses of the Carrier: **simple Carrier**, **agent-Carrier**, **affected-Carrier,** or **third party Agent**. The classification of the relational process in the Cardiff Grammar can be represented in Fig. 5.9.

In the system network of the relational process in the Cardiff Grammar no distinction has been made between the 'identifying' and the 'attributive' types as in the relational process in the Sydney Grammar. Rather, the 'identifying' type of relational process is treated as a limiting case of the 'attributive' type, 'as involving Attributes of consisting of a one-member class' (Fawcett 1987: 139). Unlike Matthiessen, the terms in Fawcett's transitivity analysis of the simple carrier type of the 'locational' process (i.e. existential process in the Sydney Grammar) are aligned with those in the other types in the relational process. So 'Carrier' has replaced 'Existent' and another role is assigned to 'Carrier' so that it acquires a '**compound role**'[6] as in 'Agent-Carrier' and 'Affected-Carrier'. Although 'Location' remains unchanged in the name as in Matthiessen's analysis, it has acquired the status of a participant role.

6.4.1.2 A Comparison between SG and CG in the Transitivity Analysis of Clauses Denoting the Existential Meaning

The above examples show that in SG's analysis such verbs as 'be' and 'exist', which express the notion of 'existence', can realize different processes: relational in (14) and (17), but existential in (15) and material in (16). And the element denoting 'place' is sometimes treated as a participant role, as in (14), but in other cases as a circumstantial role, as in (15) and (16). By contrast, in Fawcett's analysis it is always 'Location', an inherent role in the 'locational' type of relational process, since when people say something exists, it is always implied that it exists somewhere though that somewhere may not be realized in form (i.e. without an overt Location). Fawcett (1987: 140) also points out that 'Location, of course, includes location in time [as in (17)], as well as in space'.

The difference between (14) and (15) is not in their representational meaning, since CG's analysis shows that they are virtually the same in transitivity analysis. Fawcett points out that the difference lies in their different thematic organizations:

> The *There* makes no difference to the transitivity … **It is in fact a thematic device** that announces that the substantive theme in the process of 'being' is coming shortly; **it is a type of what we might term 'thematic build-up'**. (Fawcett 1987: 156) (my emphasis)

6.4.1.3 The Syntactico-Semantic Analysis of the Locational EET Construction

Although he mentions the term, 'thematic build-up', Fawcett (1987) does not make any syntactic and thematic analysis of the EET construction. Such an analysis can be found in Huang (1995/2003), as represented in Fig. 6.11. In the notation 'S^{th}' denotes 'empty Subject *there*', 'O' is the 'Operator', 'M' is the 'Main Verb', '/'

[6] 'Compound role' is different from 'conflation' in that the former refers to the cases where an element of a clause plays two different roles in the same strand of meaning, whereas the latter the cases where an element plays different roles in different strands of meaning.

means 'conflated with', 'C' is 'Complement', 'Ca' is 'Carrier', 'ETh' is (existential) 'Enhanced Theme', and 'Loc' is 'Location'.

Fawcett (2003: 52–56) provides a more detailed study of the locational EET construction Fig 6.10. In addition to a network of the existential enhanced theme (Fig. 6.12), he also presents the syntactic and semantic analyses of the construction (Fig. 6.13).

In Fig. 6.13 the upper part of the diagram is the functional syntactic analysis of the clause Fig 6.14, which is a richly labeled tree diagram representation of the clause. The tree diagram in the functional syntactic analysis of the clause in the Cardiff Grammar differs from that in the generative grammar in that it not only contains information about the syntactic roles that different elements serve, but functional roles that they play Fig 6.16. For example, '*s* in Fig. 6.13 is the Main Verb in syntactic analysis and Operator (hence O/M) in the transitivity analysis. The nominal group, *a bee*, is the conflation of Complement, Carrier, and EET (C/Ca/ETh). And

(9)	There was	no question of Kate's marrying Ted.
	Theme	Rheme

Fig. 6.6 Thompson's (1996/2000: 138) thematic analysis

(10)	There	is	a young man	in your office.
	Subject	Operator/ Predicator	Complement	Adjunct
		Process: Existential	Existent	Circumstantial：place
	Mood		Residue	
	Textual Theme	Topical Theme		
	Theme		Rheme	

Fig. 6.7 Huang's (1997: 114; 1999: 142) thematic analysis (original in Chinese)

There	are	only some of our patients really mad.
There	was	slowly making its way toward us a figure in black.
There	was	a gold medal presented (to the winner) by the mayor.
?	Topical Theme	
Theme		Rheme

Fig. 6.8 Halliday's (supposed) thematic analysis of the attributive, directional, and possessive EET constructions

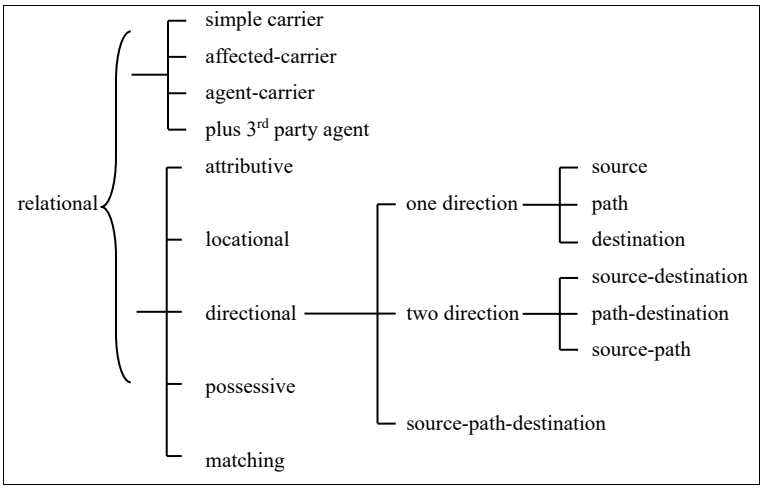


Fig. 6.9 The system network for the relational process in the Cardiff Grammar (Neale 2002: 164)

in Ivy's hair is both Complement in the syntactic analysis and Location (C/Loc) in the representation of the experiential strand of meaning.

The lower part of the diagram is the semantic analysis, which usually consists of eight categories of meanings, corresponding to the eight strands of meanings that Fawcett (1980: 26-38) identifies in the clause—the experiential, interpersonal, polarity, validity, thematic, informational, logical, and affective meanings. The validity and affective meanings demand some explanations as they are not so obvious as the others. The validity strand of meaning is concerned with the expression of the Performer's attitude toward the likelihood that a proposition is true, i.e. the validity of the proposition. The affective component reflects the 'personal' side of Halliday's interpersonal meaning (Fawcett 1980: 29)—it expresses the Performer's 'emotional attitude' toward the situation or thing to which he is referring.

Fawcett (in preparation a: 67) points out that a variant of the locational EET construction is one with Location being made a marked Participant Role theme, as in *Under the carpet [C/Loc] there ['empty Subject'] was/lay a thick sheet of plastic [C/Ca/ETh]*.

6.4.2 *Huang's EET Analysis of the Locational EET Construction*

Huang (1997, 1999) tries to combine Halliday's thematic analysis of the locational EET construction with Fawcett's existential enhanced theme analysis and proposes another existential enhanced theme analysis. This section will compare Huang's proposed thematic analysis with those of Fawcett and Halliday. It will also discuss

(14)	A sheep	was	in the garden	(this morning).
SG	Carrier	Pr: relational-circumstantial	Attribute	Circumstantial: time
CG	Carrier	Pr: relational-locational	Location	Time

(15)	There	was	a sheep	in the garden	(this morning).
SG		Pr: existential	Existent	Circ: place	Circumstantial: time
CG		Pr: rel-locational	Carrier	Location	Time

(16)	Unicorns	don't exist	(anywhere in the world).
SG	Actor	Pr: material[1]	Circumstantial: place
CG	Carrier	Pr: relational-locational	Location

(17)	Phoeb's party	will be	on Tuesday.
SG	Carrier	Pr: relational-circumstantial	Attribute
CG	Carrier	Pr: relational-locational	Location

[1] The transitivity analysis is made with reference to Thompson's (1996/2000: 101) transitivity analysis of a similar clause, *Maybe some other darker pattern exists*.

Fig. 6.10 A comparison between SG and CG in the transitivity analysis

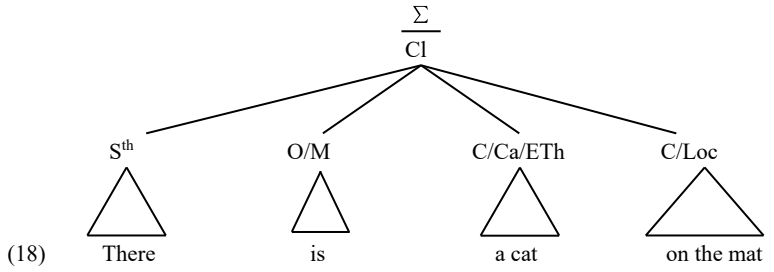


Fig. 6.11 Huang's (2003: 11) syntactic-thematic analysis of a locational EET construction

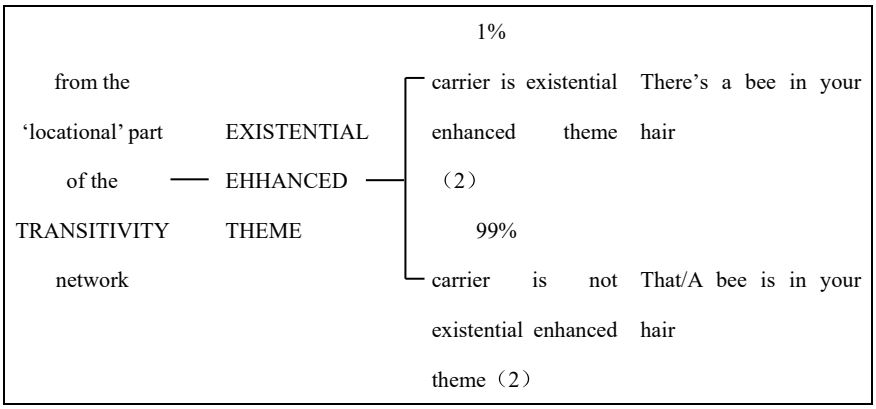


Fig. 6.12 Fawcett's (2003: 21) system network of EET (Network C)

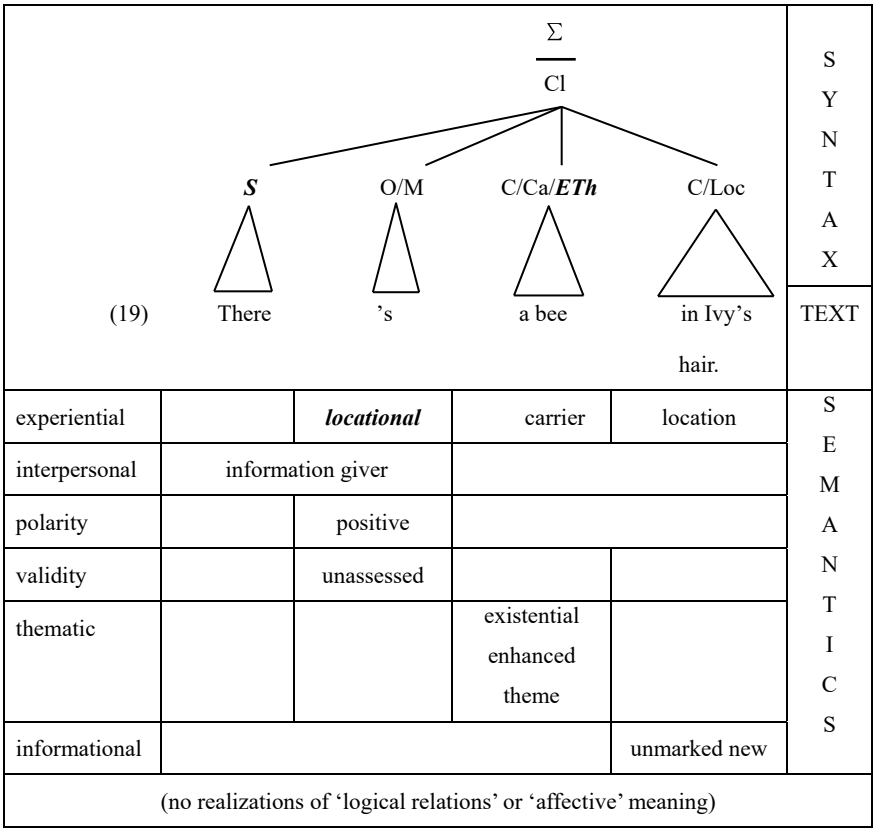


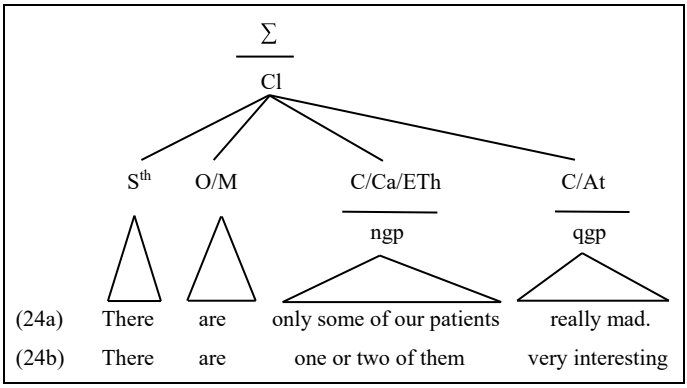
Fig. 6.13 Fawcett's (2003: 55) syntactic and semantic analysis of a locational EET construction

(20)	There	was	a cat	on the mat.
	Subject	Operator/Predicator	Complement	Adjunct
		Pr: existential	Existent	Circumstantial：place
	Mood		Residue	
			Topical Theme	
	Thematic build-up		(enhanced) Theme	Rheme

Fig. 6.14 Huang's (1997: 112; 1999: 140) existential enhanced theme analysis (original in Chinese)

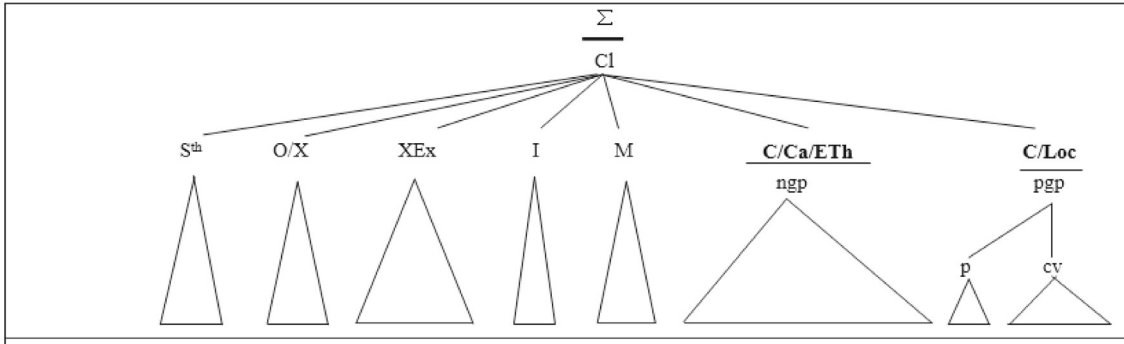
(21)	There	was	a cat	on the mat
(a)	Subject	Operator/Predicator	Complement	Adjunct
(b)		Process: existential	Carrier	Circumstance：Place
(c)	Mood		Residue	
(d)	Textual/**Interpersonal Theme**		Topical Theme	
	thematic build-up		(enhanced) theme	
	Theme			Rheme

Fig. 6.15 Huang's modified existential enhanced theme analysis (Deng 2003: 148; 2019: 115)



Additional key: qgp = quality group

Fig. 6.16 The syntactic analysis of an attributive EET construction



(22a)	There	's	certain	to	be	a trouble of crossroad.		TEXT
(22b)	There	's	undoubted	to	be	an earthquake magnitude 7.1.		
(22c)	There	is	said	to	be	a Medusa	in Greek Myths.	
experiential					locational	Carrier	Location	SEMANTICS
interpersonal	information giver							
polarity		positive						
validity			**assessed**					
thematic						existential enhanced theme		
informational						unmarked new (22a, 22b)	(unmarked new, 22c)	
No realization of 'logical relationship' or 'affective' meaning								

Fig. 6.17 The syntactico-semantic analysis of some assessed locational EET constructions

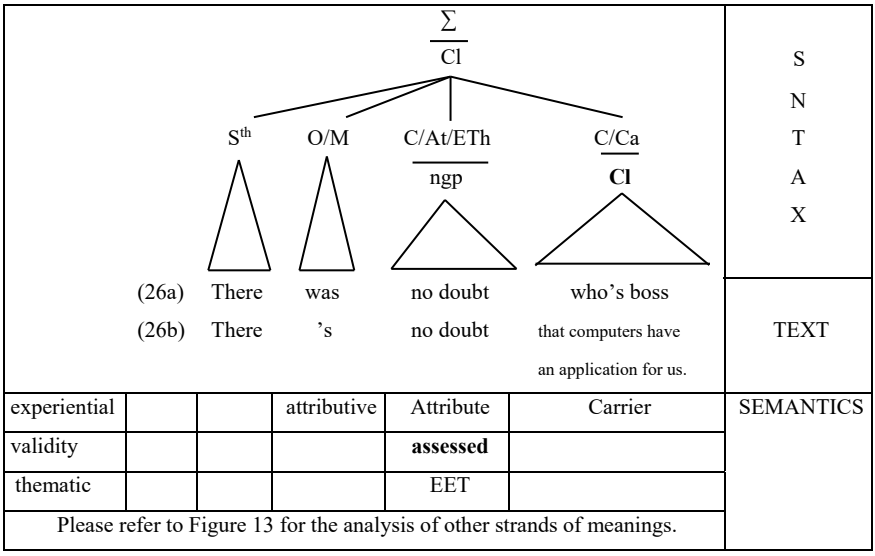


Fig. 6.18 The syntactico-semantic analysis of EET constructions with Attribute as EET

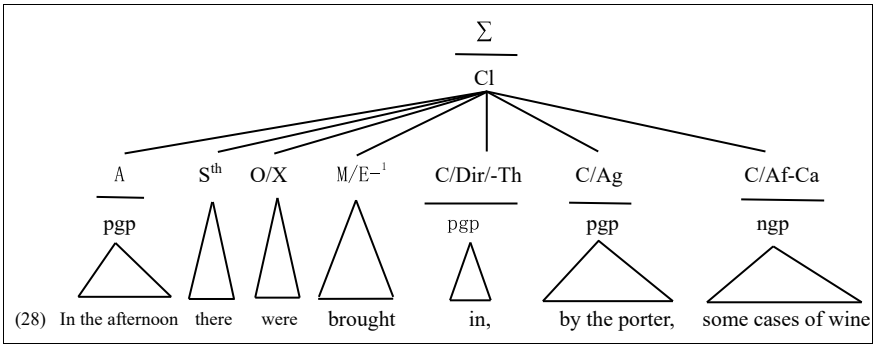


Fig. 6.19 The syntactic analysis of a directional EET construction

a problem in his analysis and presents an alternative existential enhanced theme analysis of the construction.

Huang (1997: 112; 1999: 139–141) makes admirable efforts to combine the different thematic approaches to the EET construction in the Sydney Grammar and the Cardiff Grammar. However, it can be revealed by a comparison of Fig. 7 and Fig. 14 that his second proposed approach (Fig. 5.14) follows basically the Sydney Grammar tradition, though he borrows the terms, 'thematic build-up' and 'enhanced theme', from the Cardiff Grammar (see Deng 2003: 144–146; 2019: 112–115 for a detailed discussion of the differences between Huang's EET analysis of the locational EET construction with those of Halliday and Fawcett).

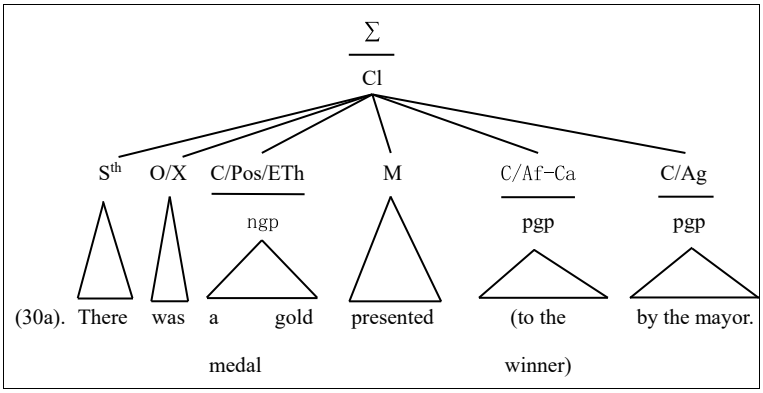


Fig. 6.20 The syntactic analysis of a possessive EET construction with Possessed as EET

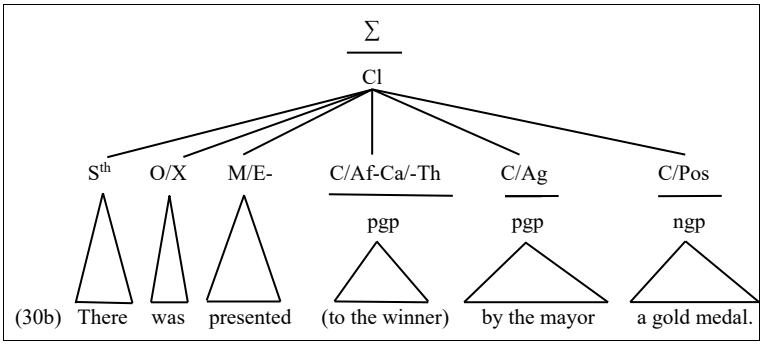


Fig. 6.21 The syntactic analysis of a possessive EET construction with the Process and the Affected-Carrier as EET

(30)	There was	a cat	on the mat.
(31a)	There was	one of the women	a Russian refugee.
(32a)	There was	(slowly) making its way towards us	a figure in black.
(33b)	There was	presented (to the winner)	by the mayor a gold medal.
	thematic build-up	**existential enhanced theme**	

Fig. 6.22 Four types of existential enhanced theme constructions

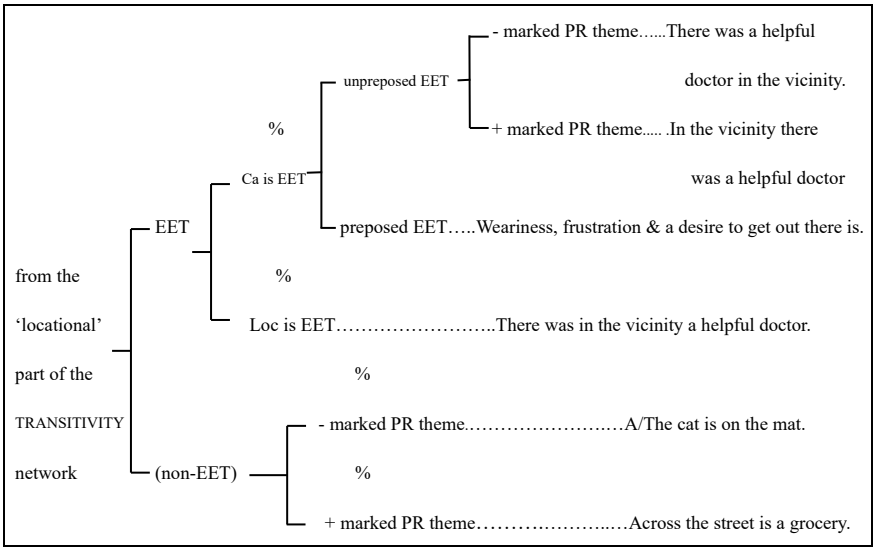


Fig. 6.23 Network C+: Deng's (2005) expanded network of EET (original in Chinese)

Apart from the apparent difference in notation, there is another noticeable difference between Huang's approach and that of Fawcett—in transitivity analysis the EET construction is treated as an existential process in Huang's analysis instead of a relational-locational process in Fawcett's approach. Thus, different terms are assigned to the participant roles or circumstantial roles in their analyses.

The above comparison clearly shows that in his existential enhanced theme analysis, Huang tries to incorporate Fawcett's existential enhanced theme analysis into Halliday's thematic analysis. And his syntactic and semantic analysis of the locational EET construction basically follows that of Halliday except for the two terms, 'thematic build-up' and 'enhanced theme', which he borrows from the Cardiff Grammar.

Huang's laudable attempt to incorporate Fawcett's existential enhanced theme analysis of locational EET constructions into Halliday thematic analysis of such constructions has not been completely achieved. There is one remaining issue in his analysis—the role of the 'thematic build-up' is not appropriately represented.

Huang's analysis seems to suggest that the 'existential enhanced theme' is Simple Theme that consists of 'Topical Theme' alone, so 'thematic build-up' is not an element of the Theme. If Halliday's thematic analysis is followed, it cannot be an element of the 'Rheme', either, since in Halliday's thematic analysis a Rhematic element cannot precede the 'Theme'. If Fawcett's analysis were followed, there should not be such an element as 'Rheme' (or 'Topical Theme') in his analysis. And 'thematic build-up' and the 'Rheme' in Huang's analysis do not constitute one single larger element in Fawcett's analysis, which is precisely why Fawcett adopts the term,

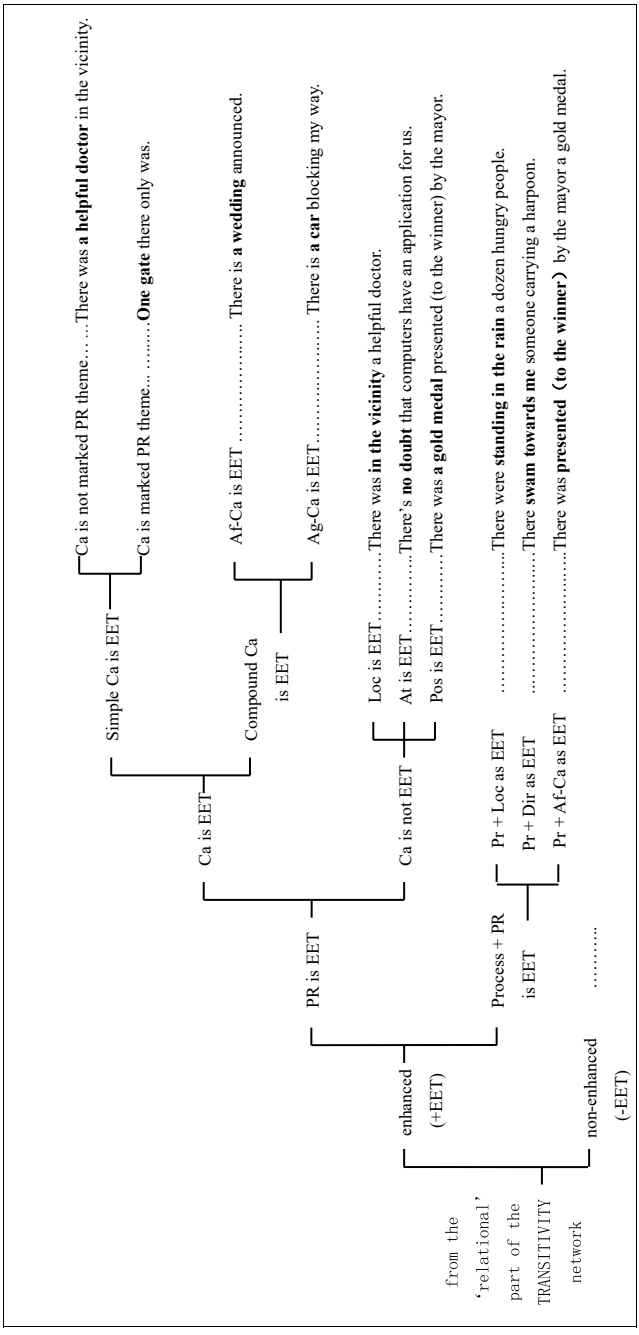


Fig. 6.24 Network C++ A further expanded network of existential enhanced theme

non-theme elements, for those elements other than (different types of) themes. So 'thematic build-up' cannot be part of (the larger) 'Rheme' of the whole clause, either.

In Fawcett's analysis, 'thematic build-up' is a non-theme element which enhances the thematic value of the existential enhanced theme, whereas in Huang's analysis it seems to be an element beyond the Theme-Rheme Structure. That is, it is a third element besides the 'Theme' and the 'Rheme'. This reveals that Huang's existential enhanced theme analysis is different from Halliday and Fawcett's thematic analyses, since in Halliday's thematic analysis there is not a third element beyond the Theme-Rheme Structure, whereas in Fawcett's thematic analysis there is no such an element besides (the different types of) themes and non-theme elements.

Huang's position on the status of the 'thematic build-up' in his analysis (personal communication) is that it is part of the 'Theme'. But what is its role in the 'Theme'? Since the 'Theme' in his existential enhanced theme analysis has already consisted of a 'Topical Theme' (and existential enhanced theme as well) realized by Carrier, the 'thematic build-up' can only be 'Textual Theme' or 'Interpersonal Theme'. Since 'thematic build-up' helps to introduce the existential enhanced theme and enhances its thematic value, it can serve as 'Textual Theme'. Furthermore, since the interpersonal meaning of Mood is realized by the configuration of the elements (*there* and *be*) of the 'thematic build-up', it can also act as 'Interpersonal Theme'. Therefore, Deng (2003: 148; 2019: 115) proposes that the 'thematic build-up' in Huang's existential enhanced theme analysis should be both 'Textual Theme' and 'Interpersonal Theme', as shown in Fig. 6.15.

The proposed alternative thematic analysis has solved the problem of the 'thematic build-up' as an element dangling beyond the Theme-Rheme Structure in Huang's analysis, and therefore, is perhaps more compatible with Halliday's thematic approach.

6.5 Syntactico-Semantic Analysis of EET Constructions from the Perspective of the Cardiff Grammar

In this sect. I shall, following the Cardiff Grammar's approach, make a detailed syntactico-semantic analysis of different types of EET constructions, including some under-studied ones. When we make the analysis, sometimes different possible analyses of an EET construction will be proposed. Then they will be compared and deliberated in order to find the analysis that best implements the systemic functional principle that 'the form is the realization of the meaning'.

6.5.1 The Locational EET Construction

An instance of the syntactico-semantic analysis of the locational EET construction has been presented in Fig. 6.13. We should now turn to some more complicated locational EET constructions. The structure of a locational EET construction can be complicated by adding the Performer's evaluation of the likelihood of the existence of a given entity, as illustrated by the following examples:

(22a) There's certain to be a trouble of the crossroad.
(22b) There's undoubted to be an earthquake of magnitude 7.1.
(22c) There is said to be a Medusa in Greek Myths. (Hu 1988: 87–88)

As is evident in the examples, 'certain' in (22a) and 'undoubted' in (22b) reinforce the likelihood of the existence of the entity concerned, where 'said' in (22c) distances or even exempts the Performer from the responsibility for the validity of the proposition.

According to Fawcett's (2003: 82) analysis in (23a) and (23b) below, 'certain', 'undoubted' and 'said', like 'considered/thought' and 'able', can also be treated as auxiliary extension (XEx). Therefore, the syntactico-semantic analysis of the three examples can be demonstrated in Fig. 6.17.

(23a) It was **considered/thought** (by the authority [C/Cog] (to be) impossible for anyone to. escape [C/Ph].
(23b) Are [O/X] you [S] **able** [XEx] to [I] swim [M] 500 miles [C]? (Fawcett 2003: 82)

6.5.2 The Attributive EET Construction

The attributive EET construction can be classified into two types according to the position of EET. The first type includes those EET constructions with EET in the position after the 'thematic build-up', as in the following:

(24a) There are only some of our patients really mad. (Hannay 1985: 150)
(24b) No, there are one or two of them very interesting. (Hannay 1985: 160)

The syntactic (and semantic) analysis of the attributive EET construction with Carrier as EET is represented as follows.

Observe an EET construction which is similar to (24a) and (24b):

(25a) There were about fifty persons present (=there). (Bolinger 1977: 104.)

Bolinger's interpretation of the clause-final quality group seems to suggest that (25a) is a locational EET construction:

(? 25b) There [S] were [O/M] about fifty persons [C/Ca/ETh] present [C/Loc].

It would seem quite odd that the quality groups were used to denote Location. Given that quality groups typically express the quality of a Thing or Situation, we first

propose to take the quality groups in (25a) as the realization of Attribute. However, we note that 'be…present' in (25b), like 'be located', denotes the existence of a given person, and should be treated as part of the Main Verb. It is the Main Verb extension (MEx). Thus (25a) is actually a locational EET construction with an unrealized Location ('at the meeting' or 'at the ceremony', for example). The syntactic analysis of (25a) should be as follows:

(25c) There [S] were [O/M] about fifty persons [C/Car/ETh] present [MEx] (at the meeting) ([C/Loc]).

The second type of attributive EET constructions consists of those with Attribute occurring in the position after the 'thematic build-up' (as EET) and the Carrier in the clause-final position. The syntactic and semantic analysis of such EET constructions is represented in Fig. 6.18.

One thing that needs to be pointed out is that the 'Attribute/EET' is also the element that expresses the Performer's validity of the proposition, which is realized by the Carrier, which is, in turn, filled by an embedded relative clause.

Sometimes the 'Attribute/EET' is not loaded with the Performer's evaluation of the validity of the proposition, and is simply filled by a nominal group. The syntactic analysis of such EET construction is illustrated as follows:

(27a) There [S^{th}] was [O/M] one man [C/At/ETh] that kept interrupting [C/Ca].
(27b) There [S^{th}] was [O/M] John [C/At/ETh] you could try [C/Ca].

6.5.3 The Directional EET Construction

Directional EET constructions usually take as EET the Process and Direction that is dependent on it, and Carrier is placed in the clause-final position. The syntactic (and semantic) analysis of such EET constructions is exemplified in Fig. 6.19.

Queries may arise as to whether 'in' in 'were brought in' can be treated as 'Main Verb extension'. However, we are not inclined for this analysis. According to the Functional Constraint on EET constructions refined from Kuno and Takami (2004: 58), the string to the left of the postverbal nominal group represents the locomotion of 'some dozen cases of wine', which is observable to the speaker or narrator, who is assumed to be among one of those people in the room or hotel. Hence, 'in' actually denotes 'into the room' or 'into the hotel', and should be treated as Direction, accordingly.

The locomotive act in (29) is engendered by an Agent, but such an act may be self-engendered. And the syntactic analysis of a self-engendered locomotive act is shown as follows:

6.5.4 *The Possessive EET Construction*

Possessive EET constructions are of two types: one is those with 'Possessed/EET' occurring in the position after the 'thematic build-up' and the Agent in the clause-final position; the other includes those with the Process and the Affected-Carrier occurring after the 'thematic build-up' (as EET) and the Possessed in the clause-final position. The analysis of the two types of directional EET constructions are illustrated in Fig. 6.20 and Fig. 6.21, respectively.

6.6 The Thematic Options in EET Constructions

A canonical EET construction is a locational EET construction as in (30). Besides the canonical EET construction, there are three other types of EET constructions, as in (31a-33b), with their 'thematic build-up' underlined, their EET in bold and the analysis of their experiential strand of meaning in square brackets.

(30) There was [Process] **a cat** [Carrier] on the mat [*Loc*].
(31a) There was [Process] **one of the women** [Carrier] a Russian refugee [*Attribute*].
(31b) There are [Process] **only some of our patients** [Carrier] really mad [*Attribute*].
(32a) There were slowly **making its way** [Process] **toward us** [*Direction*] a figure in black [Carrier].
(32b) There **walked** [Process] **into the courtroom** [*Direction*] two people I had thought were.dead [Carrier].
(33a) There was **presented** [Process] **to me** [Carrier] a papaya [*Possessed*].
(33b) There was **presented** [Process] (**to the winner**) [Carrier] by the mayor [Agent] a gold.medal [*Possessed*].

As is shown in Fig. 6.22, what is common in the four types of EET constructions is that in the thematic strand of meaning, there is the 'thematic build-up' in the clause-initial position, followed by the (existential enhanced) theme enhanced by it.

In the experiential strand of meaning, the participant role (PR) common to the four types of EET construction is Carrier, and it is the second PR in each type (Location, Attribute, Direction, or Possessed) that distinguishes one from another, which is why they are termed as the locational, attributive, directional, and possessive EET construction, respectively.

The previous discussion reveals that there are at least four types of EET constructions in English—locational, attributive, directional, and possessive. Fawcett's (2003: 21; in preparation a) network of existential enhanced theme (Network C) is actually a network of EET in the locational EET construction. As Deng (2005) points out, Fawcett's Network C should be expanded to accommodate the options where Location serves as EET (34) and where Carrier functions as EET and the marked Participant Role theme (35a–35b).

(34) There was **in vicinity** a helpful doctor. (Quirk et al. 1985: 1404)
(35a) **One gate** there only was. (Jespersen 1937/1984: 130)
(35b) **Two further points** there are that I must make before we leave this topic. (Huddleston and Pullum 2002: 1392)

The expanded network of the locational EET is presented in Fig. 6.23.

There are three points about Network C^+ that require explanations. The first point is about the status of Location when it is put in the clause-initial position, as in *In the vicinity there was a helpful doctor*. Unlike Carrier in (35a–35b), which is regarded as the conflation of EET and marked PR theme, it is treated merely as the marked PR theme rather than the conflation of the two types of themes. This is because in the locational EET construction, Location most frequently occurs in the final position, and the second most frequent position where it occurs is in the clause-initial position, whereas it rarely occurs immediately after the 'thematic build-up'. By contrast, in the locational EET construction Carrier usually takes the position immediately after the 'thematic build-up'. It sometimes occurs in the final position when it is the Focus of the information unit, but very rarely occurs in the initial position.

The second point is that the option 'Carrier is not EET' can also be expanded into a system where both Carrier and Location can be thematized. The third point is about Network C^+ as a whole. It should be noted that Network C^+ is only a network of the locational type of existential enhanced theme, a complete network of EET should include the thematic choices in the other three types of EET constructions.

In the four types of EET constructions, the element which can be enhanced are the Process and the two basic Participant Roles in each type of EET constructions, one being Carrier and the other being Location, Attribute, Direction, or Possessed, respectively. Among the Carriers, Simple Carrier is the element that is most frequently thematized, as exemplified in the following:

(36a) There's a man at the door. (Halliday 1994/2000: 143)
(36b) There was one of the women a Russian refugee. (Hannay 1985: 13)
(36c) There are some pages blank. (Downing and Locke 1992: 139)

But very rarely, a Simple Carrier can be both the enhanced theme and the marked Participant Role theme, as in (35a) and (35b) above. Sometimes Agent-Carrier (37a–37b) or Affected-Carrier (38a–38b) can also serve as the enhanced theme:

(37a) There is **a car** blocking my way. (Quirk et al. 1985: 1402)
(37b) There were **some boys** playing cricket. (Huddleston and Pullum: 2002: 1395)
(38a) There were **some people** killed. (ibid.)
(38b) There is a **wedding** announced. (Downing and Locke 1992: 139)

When Carrier is not the enhanced theme, the other basic PR in the locational, attributive and possessive types of EET constructions (i.e. Location, Attribute, or Possessed) can also be enhanced, as illustrated by the following examples:

(39a) There was **in the vicinity** a helpful doctor. (Quirk et al. 1985: 1404)
(39b) There were **in his in-tray** no fewer than thirty unpaid bills. (Huddleston and Pullum 2002:1392)

(40a) There's **no doubt** that computers have an application for us. (Collins 1992)
(40b) There's **no doubt** he's one hot commodity. (From boston.com/sports, on baseball, By Nick Cafardo, Globe Staff, May 5, 2005)
(41) There was **a gold medal** presented (to the winner) by the mayor. (Quirk et al. 1985: 1409)

The elements that can be enhanced in the EET construction may not necessarily be PRs. Alternatively, the Process and its dependent roles (Location in (42a), Direction in (42b) and Affected-Carrier in (42c)) in the locational, directional, and possessive types of EET constructions can also be enhanced:

(42a) There were **standing in the rain** a dozen hungry people. (Quirk et al. 1985: 1404)
(42b) There was slowly **making its way toward us** a figure in black. (Bolinger 1977: 102)
(42c) There was **presented(to the winner)**by the mayor a gold medal. (Quirk et al. 1985: 1409)

It seems that the choice of the Process and its dependent roles as the EET is motivated by presenting the Carrier (or Possessed in the case of possessive EET construction) as new information—it is a by-product of such a choice.

Based on the foregoing discussion, a further expanded network of EET is represented in Fig. 6.24.

6.7 Conclusion

The present study has discussed some of the problems in the transitivity and thematic analyses of the locational, attributive, directional, and possessive EET constructions from the perspective of the Sydney Grammar. In SG's transitivity analysis, verbs denoting the existential meaning may be analyzed as the existential, material, or relational processes, which lacks consistency in its transitivity analysis. In its thematic analysis of EET constructions, especially the locational EET construction, there still remain several issues to be resolved. The practice for taking *there* as the 'Theme in locational EET constructions is inappropriate, because even though the existential *there* still allows the addressee to prepare for something to be introduced, it may not herald that a clause with the existential *there* in the initial position is existential (process) in nature. Such a clause can be relational or even material in the Hallidayan tradition as well. Besides, this thematic analysis also violates Halliday's thematic analysis principle that the 'Theme' should include one and only one experiential element.

Alternatively, the four types of EET constructions have been approached from the perspective of the Cardiff Grammar. The locational, attributive, directional, and possessive EET constructions are treated as locational, attributive, directional, and possessive relational processes—four sub-types of its relational process. *There* and *be*

are taken as 'thematic build-up', a non-theme element which enhances the thematic value of the existential enhanced theme, which occurs after the 'thematic build-up' and which is usually realized by Carrier.

Apart from a detailed syntactic-semantic analysis of different types of EET constructions, this paper has also explored the thematic options in such constructions. It has been revealed that Fawcett's network of EET (Network C) concerns only the locational type of EET and does not include the thematic choices in the attributive, directional and possessive EET constructions. Thus his network has been expanded considerably. In EET constructions both Participant Roles and the Process can serve as EET. Among these elements Carrier is most frequently taken as EET. When Carrier is not EET, Location, Attribute, or Possessed can also function as EET. Even the Process and its dependent roles (Location, Direction, or Affected-Carrier) can also play such a role. On the basis of these facts, an extended network of EET (Network C^{++}) is proposed to accommodate these options.

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Part II
SFL and Ecolinguistics

Chapter 7
Self-Realization in Ancient Chinese Poetry: Toward an Inclination-Oriented Eco-Civilization



Ruihua Zhao

Abstract In examining the relationships between humans, nonhuman species, and nature, discourse studies conducted from both critical and other perspectives attempt to enhance the visibility of nonhuman life forms and make salient the moral obligations that humanity should uphold to protect the ecosystem. However, effectiveness varies with individuals who harbor divergent views on what and how they *should* do toward a more unified human-nature relationship. Enlightened by the *inclination*-oriented notion of self-realization (Naess, 1989), this article investigates how self-realization unfolds in identification by reference to a modified formulation, which systemizes the abstract concept of self-realization, its semantic interpretations, and the linguistic realizations by examining three Tang poems. It is found that self-realization unfolds in a discourse characterized by a high degree of bodily-mental, interpersonal, and interspecies integrations, where human beings play an active role in identification through synesthesia. This research is significant not only in helping alleviate negative emotions toward moral restraints and fostering a willingness to engage in ecological protection but also in introducing an applicable paradigm of analyzing discourse ecologically.

Keywords Self-realization · Identification · Synesthesia · Eco-discourse studies · Inclination · Ancient Chinese poetry

7.1 Introduction

Examining the discourses that are detrimental to ecosystems from a critical perspective has been a dominant approach to eco-discourse studies. However, as Stibbe (2018) suggests, critique is only the first step, which cannot be more useful without a following exploration of alternative discourse for the benefit of nature. Therefore,

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vital importance should be attached to discovering the linguistic features of beneficial discourse that helps boost life sustainability, yet studies adopting a positive perspective to seek out alternative discourse (see Lamb 2020; Molek-Kozakowska and Szymańska-Czaplak 2022; Plastina 2022; Sokół 2022; Stibbe 2018; Virdis 2022 for important exceptions) remain underexplored. Poetry, as "one of the crucial modes of proper letting be or unhindered disclosure of being" (Garrard's (2012: 34) account of Heidegger's view, cited from Stibbe 2015: 158), is one of the main sources for beneficial discourse. It has been discussed in different contexts from a critical perspective, such as English romantic poetry (Goatly 2000, 2017) and Japanese Haiku nature poetry (Stibbe 2007). This article investigates Chinese pastoral poetry and nostalgic poetry of the Tang Dynasty to explore the role of humanity in achieving self-realization (Naess 1989).

Views on human roles in the human-nature relationship within the era of the Anthropocene vary. A large body of literature criticizes the adverse effects of human cognition and actions on the current environmental problems, with particular attention being paid to the relationship between humans and other life forms, as it is considered "a key conceptual terrain for applied linguists to intervene in emerging interdisciplinary debates on how to address problematic human–environment relations in a time of growing ecological degradation" (Lamb 2020: 922). The widely discussed linguistic issues include the lexicogrammatical realizations of participants and processes in transitivity, such as passivization, nominalization, and anthropomorphization. In contrast, discourse studies conducted from a harmonious perspective, or harmonious discourse analysis (HDA), are human-oriented. HDA proposes three principles—conscience, proximity, and regulation—to regulate human behaviors (Huang and Zhao 2021). Both of the two approaches center on *moral obligation*, whereas related concepts like responsibility, morality, and accountability may not resonate equally with everyone. People with distinct backgrounds are likely to hold divergent views on what, how, and to what extent they should be responsible for the ecosystem, and some may even perceive it as moral blackmail if they believe the authors and analysts are asserting moral superiority to sway public opinion in their favor. A more feasible way to promote human-nature harmony can be found in the *inclination*-oriented notion "self-realization" (Naess 1989). It is realized in the process of identification, a natural self-development in seeing self in others, where intense empathy is aroused to help human beings understand themselves and other life and non-life forms in the world. Empathy is a powerful tool for bridging individual separateness by expanding the psychological representation of self to include others (Singer et al. 2004). It is investigated in a variety of domains, such as social psychology (Aron and Aron 1996) and neurobiology (Beckes et al. 2013). Empathy occurs when "…(i) one is in an affective state; (ii) this state is isomorphic to another person's affective state; (iii) this state is elicited by the observation or imagination of another person's affective state; (iv) one knows that the other person is the source of one's own affective state" (De Vignement and Singer 2006: 435). Although this definition is confined to interpersonal relationships, it parallels Naess's (1989) concept of identification in taking a relative perspective of seeing oneself in others. Moreover, it offers methods for eliciting empathy, i.e., through observation—encompassing

seeing, hearing, tasting, smelling, and feeling—and through imagination. Empathy involves self-other (other can be other persons, other life forms, and other non-life forms) overlap in visual, auditory, olfactory, gustatory, and tactile senses. This is one of the prominent features of Chinese pastoral poetry and nostalgic poetry.

Discourse, on the one hand, "has the power to legitimize relationships in which one group causes immense suffering to the other" (Stibbe 2003: 390), and on the other, "can be used imaginatively to resist dominant discourses and open up new alternatives" (ibid.). To explore the way to construct alternative discourse, this article makes a transitivity analysis (Halliday 1994) of Tang poetry on the basis of a modified formulation of T-ecosophy (Naess 1987, 1989) that systemizes the abstract concept of self-realization, its semantic interpretations, and the linguistic realizations from a top-down perspective. It is applied to demonstrate how ancient Chinese poets who were exempt from ecological obligations achieved self-realization in the process of identification by answering the three questions below:

1. What are the dimensions of self-realization achieved in these poems?
2. How are they embodied in diversity, complexity, and symbiosis, which are further realized in the linguistic choices of participants and processes?
3. What role do humans play in these poems in blurring the boundaries between the participants of qualitative differences?

7.2 Debate Over the Role of Human Beings

The ecological deterioration has "provoked changes in how humans experience and perceive their relationship to nature" (Gjesdal and Gisle 2023: 429). Goatly (2022) outlines a continuum of views on the role of human beings in the ecosystem. At the anthropocentric extreme lies the Anthropic Principle, and at the opposite end is the Gaia which regards human beings as "marginal aspects of nature" (Goatly 2022: 635). Situated between these two extremes is Taoism, a Chinese philosophy advocating harmony with nature through no-interference. Different approaches to eco-discourse studies reflect diverse engagements with these philosophical views and their linguistic realizations.

Holding a biocentric view, eco-critical discourse analysts unveil the "linguistic anthropocentrism" (Kompatscher and Heuberger 2021: 261), which is "usually identified as the most problematic issue" in ecolinguistic studies (ibid.). It is constructed through grammatical, semantic and discursive strategies, such as the choices of pronouns/relative pronouns, connectives, *to*-infinitive forms, modal verbs, process types, metaphors, lexical collocations, noun types, frame and doublespeak, to criticize the dominion of human beings, the unequal relationships between humans and other life forms, the erasure and blurring of human responsibilities, the emphasis on the inactivity, in/de-animation, and imperceptibility of nonhuman life forms, the erasure of the intrinsic value of other species, etc. (e.g., Arcari 2017; Dahl 2022; Drury et al. 2022; Fusari 2018; Gilquin and George 2006; Glenn 2004; Goatly 2006; Kompatscher & Heuberger 2021; Sealey and Oakley 2013, 2014). Among the various

linguistic devices, the passive voice and nominalization have drawn extensive attention, because they are seen as powerful tools to reinforce anthropocentrism. Relevant studies have been undertaken in the realms of technology, industry, scientific and technical literature, and corporate and political discourses (see Kahn 2001; Kompatscher and Heuberger 2021; Poole 2022). Rarely acting as actors or initiators, nonhuman animals are constructed as inactive and inanimate. Likewise, Stibbe (2015, 2021) argues that the use of passive voice and nominalization are common erasure patterns that obscure human responsibility and diminish the perceptibility and autonomy of nonhuman animals, framing them as subordinate to humans.

Goatly (1996), the proponent of Green Grammar, argues that passivization and nominalization can avoid those problems by integrating participants into processes, which helps downplay anthropocentrism in blurring the boundary between humans and other life forms. To further illustrate his point, Goatly (2017) analyzes the poems of William Wordsworth, Edward Thomas, and Alice Oswald to show how language uses in such discourses differ from those in the present-day environmental discourses and media discourses in their promotion of the alignment between humanity and nature. Apart from nominalization, he also advocates using ergative verbs in material processes to demonstrate the intrinsic value of nature, constructing nonhuman life forms in relational processes as Token and activating nonhuman Existents in existential processes to be Actor to endow them with proactivity, constructing nonhuman life forms in verbal processes as Sayer and those in mental processes as Senser to endow them with consciousness and perceptibility.

Positive and harmonious discourse studies investigate the language features and discourse patterns beneficial to the coexistence between humans and other life beings, with the aim of modifying or replacing the current dominant discourses, such as Lamb's (2020) proposal of a green applied linguistics, Molek-Kozakowska and Szymańska-Czaplak's (2022) examination of the sustainability discourses of prominent environmental charities, and Sokół's (2022) study of the interdiscursive construction of sustainable lifestyle vlogs on YouTube. In addition to modern popular discourses, scholarship (Virdis 2022) also draws on the Victorian-era lectures The Storm-Cloud of the Nineteenth Century to explore the metaphors and frames evoked by "storm" and "cloud", by which the agent is "empathetically connected to" (Virdis 2022: 614) the affected and "happiness of humanity" (ibid.), and consequently "mutual understanding in our interpersonal and social interactions" (Virdis 2022: 617) is achieved. HDA, proposed in the Chinese context (Huang and Zhao 2021; Zhao and Huang 2025), is built on the assumption of human-orientedness, laying focus on human problems and responsibilities.

Views on the role of human beings in relation to other life forms, non-life entities, and natural environment are typically categorized as positive and negative, yet both revolve around *moral obligation* by showing what humans should and should not do in the critique and praise of human cognition and actions. Except for Goatly's endorsement of utilizing passivization and nominalization, a consensus has been reached on the way to express experiential meanings ecologically, including making human participants visible in processes to highlight their responsibilities, constructing nonhuman participants as Actor, Senser, and Sayer to endow them

with animation, consciousness, and proactivity, and avoiding presenting nonhuman participants as the affected that are subject to humans.

7.3 Self-Realization and the Modified Systematic Formulation

It is widely acknowledged that eco-discourse analysis is guided by researchers' ecosophy. Naess proposed his ecosophy, ecosophy T (T representing his mountain cabin, Tvergastein, in Norway), which emphasizes deep ecological harmony, where humans recognize their interconnectedness with nature and adopt a lifestyle that respects the intrinsic value of all living beings. As the essence of ecosophy T, self-realization diverges from the literature reviewed in the previous section in its perspective on human beings. It underscores the natural unfolding of self rather than obligation; in other words, it prioritizes "inclination" over "morality" (Naess 1987). Self-realization entails integrating all life and non-life forms in the world while remaining connected to human interests. This is especially true of Tang poetry, when the poets were not morally bounded to ecological protection.

According to the classification of "self" into ego self, social self, and ecological self, three dimensions of self-realization—ego-realization (T_1), self-realization (T_2), and Self-realization (T_3)—are identified. Denoting exclusivity and isolation, T_1 is featured by individuality. It conveys the "incompatibility" (Naess 1989: 85) of individual interests, which is realized by the ontological unity of mind and body. In contrast, T_2 and T_3 involve inclusion and connection, but on different scales. T_2 is achieved in one's connections to other people in society, which is based on the social unity of self and other people. T_3 is achieved in one's integration with all the life forms in the universe, which encapsulates ontological, social, and ecological unities. It is T_3 that elicits the most intense empathy. Naess did not give a rigid definition of "Self-realization", but Rothenberg explains it as "all life is fundamentally one with our individual needs and desires" (Naess 1989: 9). It conveys three implications. First, the capitalized "S" indicates ecological self, while the ego self is subsumed within the ecological self. In establishing and maintaining the connections to the ecological self, diverse individuals contribute. In this sense, oneness means unity with diversity. Second, if "self" is extended to include other people and species, everything in the universe will become part of one's interests as they are all involved in the ecological self, and hence the ecological self and ego self are inseparable from each other. Third, no one can truly achieve T_3. T_3 is a process, an endeavor, an ultimate goal, or an ideal state, but it cannot be completely achieved. The pastoral poetry and nostalgic poetry of the Tang Dynasty typically embodies T_1, T_2, and T_3 simultaneously, irrespective of the poets' emotional state, whether joyful or melancholic; what they did was synthesizing individual, society, and nature into a unified whole. The ontological dimension (T_1) is embodied in the poets' mental unification with their bodily presence in the setting. The social dimension (T_2) is reflected in three

aspects: the poets' engagement with readers to elicit their empathy, the dynamics between human participants in the poems, and the connections to the broader social background. The ecological dimension (T_3) manifests through the poets' interactions with other species and the natural environment.

Humanity "is capable of understanding and appreciating its relations with all other life forms and to the Earth as a whole" (Naess 1989: 166). This capability is the basis of examining how the poets understand other life forms and the surroundings and connect them with nature in the process of identification, where one "sees oneself in the other" (Naess 1989: 171). "The other" can be the self in one's mental world, other people in society, other animals and plants, and the natural environment. Naess (1987) illustrates this point through his painfulness in seeing a flea dying in acid chemicals, owing to the identification of seeing himself in the flea. Identification is the cognitive basis for an emotion evoked toward other life and non-life forms. The deeper and broader the identification, the greater the empathy one demonstrates, while lack of identification will lead to indifference. For example, the poets' certain emotion is evoked in a situation when they see some flowers, nonhuman animals, mountains, rivers, etc., because they see themselves in these forms, and they would like to share their experience and feelings with readers. This involves two identification processes: poets projecting themselves onto other forms in the setting, and readers mirroring themselves in the poets. In doing so, poets, the environment, and readers are interrelated. Identification is reciprocal. It can be integrating the ego self into the world, enabling one to share the magnificence of nature with others by recognizing oneself as a nondetachable part of nature. It can also be engaging others within the ecological self by internalizing their abilities, actions, and attributes, thereby making them part of one's own identity.

The depth and breadth of identification is assessed from three variables, including diversity, complexity, and symbiosis (Naess 1989). Diversity is not equal with plurality; it is interpreted, on the one hand, in terms of variety through the lens of the number of participants involved, i.e., quantitative diversity, and on the other hand, in terms of variety through the lens of the distinguishable distinctions between participants, i.e., qualitative diversity. The differences are crystallized in the properties of participants, their spatial and temporal distribution, and the emotional response they trigger. In this article, it is qualitative diversity that functions as the basis of examining complexity and symbiosis, and it will be assessed from four aspects—PROPERTY, TEMPORAL, SPATIAL, and EMOTIONAL—with their distinctive key factors, as shown in Fig. 7.1.

Complexity refers to the various ways of connecting intimate and interdependent participants. They may be connected by shared properties, proximity in time and space, or their capacity to evoke similar emotions. For example, a, b, and c may be connected in the forms of ab, ac, bc, ba, ca, cb, abc, acb, bac, bca, cab, and cba under different conditions. These are the possible forms of symbiosis, which provides "*a cognitive basis for* a sense of belonging" (Naess 1989: 168, italics as in the original). T_1, T_2, and T_3 are gradable in symbiosis. T_1 is marked by the exclusion of others, with a low degree of symbiosis except the bodily-mental unity. Featured by relating oneself to others in society, T_2 has symbiosis as a cognitive basis of *social* belonging

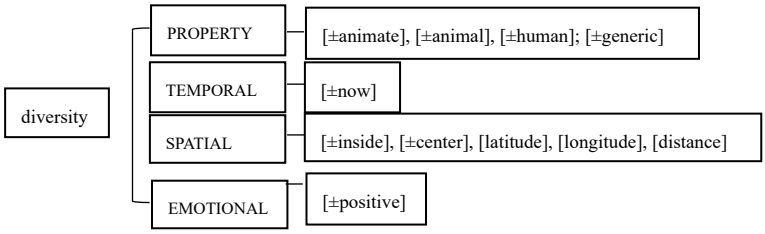


Fig. 7.1 Qualitative diversity in four aspects and their key factors

within a community based on kinship, friendship, politics, etc. T_3 exhibits the highest degree of symbiosis, serving as a cognitive basis of "*ecospheric* belonging" (Naess 1989: 168) to include every life form (and some non-life forms) in the universe. However, "'maximum diversity!' does not make sense, because many differences may not involve Self-realization and may be inconsistent with symbiosis" (Naess 1989: 201). This leads to the possibilities of ab/ba without c, ac/ca without b, and bc/cb without a, due to the potential conflicts between certain participants. In the framework of experiential analysis, diversity is typically realized in the number and roles of participants, and complexity and symbiosis are embodied in the relationships of and interactions between the agent, affected, and circumstantial elements, and between participants and the processes they are involved in.

Bringing the concept of self-realization, its interpretations, and their linguistic realizations together, this article proposes a modified formulation (based on Naess 1989: 196–198) below to systemize the three strata into a coherent whole. The basic norm (N) is on the most abstract, theoretical stratum. It is realized in the Hypothesis of its relation to empathy (H1) and in the Hypothesis of its relation to diversity, complexity, and symbiosis (H2). These three variables are in turn realized in the lexicogrammatical choices (H3), the most concrete, discoursal stratum as a form of social praxis.

N: Self-realization!
H1: The stronger the identification, the greater the empathy.
H2: The higher the self-realization attained, the weaker the dominance of the ego self; the broader and deeper the identification with others, the higher the degree of diversity, complexity, and symbiosis.
H3: The higher degree of diversity, complexity, and symbiosis, the more varied and integrated relationships and interactions between participants, and the more diverse activities across time and space of participants.

Table 7.1 *Spring Morning* and its translation

春					晓				
Chun					*Xiao*				
Spring					*Morning*				
Line 1	春	眠	不	觉	晓,	Line 2	处处	闻	啼	鸟。
	chun	*mian*	*bu*	*jue*	*xiao*		*chu chu*	*wen*	*ti*	*niao*
	spring	*sleeps*	*not*	*is aware of*	*(it [the sky] is) daybreak*		*everywhere*	*hears*	*cry*	*birds*
Line 3	夜	来	风雨		声,	Line 4	花	落	知	多少。
	ye	*lai*	*feng yu*		*sheng*		*hua*	*luo*	*zhi*	*duo shao*
	night	*-lai*	*wind and showers*		*sounds*		*flowers*	*fall*	*knows*	*how many*

7.4 Self-Realization in Pastoral and Nostalgic Poetry of the Tang Dynasty

This article chose three Tang poems: Spring Morning[1] (春晓, *Chun Xiao*) by Meng Haoran (孟浩然), The Dale of Singing Birds (鸟鸣涧, *Niao Ming Jian*) by Wang Wei (王维) and Early Departure (商山早行, *Shang Shan Zao Xing*) by Wen Tingyun (温庭筠). The first two are pastoral poetry and the third is nostalgic poetry, but all of them merge nature imagery with emotional articulation. Such poems are particularly outstanding in helping readers see themselves in others through poets' experience. The aim of choosing these three poems is twofold: to explore self-realization in ancient Chinese poetry by reference to the modified systematic formulation; and to make a comparison and contrast among them, thereby addressing the three questions raised in the introduction.

Spring Morning

Spring Morning portrays birds singing and flowers falling on a spring morning, capturing nature's vitality and the transient flow of time. The poem and its translation are presented in Table 7.1.

The explicit participants—the agent and affected—in the poem include *niao* (鸟, *birds*), *feng yu*(风雨, *wind and showers*), and *hua* (花, *flowers*); the explicit processes include *mian* (眠, *sleep*), *jue* (觉, *is aware of*), *xiao* (晓, *is daybreak*),[2] *wen* (闻, *hears*), *ti* (啼, *cry*), *luo* (落, *fall*), and *zhi* (知, *knows*); and the two circumstantial

[1] The English translations of the three poem titles are sourced from Xu (2000), who is renowned as the one translating Chinese poetry into both English and French. The Chinese annotations of the poems are from Nie (2015).

[2] It is also possible to take "daybreak" (xiao 晓) as the Phenomenon of the process "is aware of". This article interprets "daybreak" as a relational process by reference to Nie's (2015) annotation: "it is daybreak" (tian yi po xiao 天已破晓).

elements are *chun* (春, *spring*) and *ye* (夜, *night*). To identify the agents of the processes, one can observe the Behaver *niao* directly shown in the behavioral process realized by *ti*, and the Actor *hua* in the material process realized by *luo*. However, the agents of the remaining five processes cannot be inferred literally. Hiding participants is a common practice in ancient Chinese poetry, either for assumed reader knowledge or for sparking imagination. In this poem, the hidden agents are the poet,[3] as the Behaver in the behavioral process realized by *mian*, and the Senser in the three mental processes realized by *jue*, *wen,* and *zhi*, respectively. The behavioral process of birds crying and the mental processes of the poet being aware of, hearing, and knowing demonstrate what the poet sees and hears on a spring morning, presenting the scenery to readers and guiding them into the context via his perception. Another hidden agent in this poem is the sky, which is the Carrier of the relational process realized by *xiao*. The two circumstantial elements, *chun* and *ye*, indicate time. Notably, there is no explicit verb indicating the process type in the third line, as -lai (来, *lai*) is not a verb but a directional particle. However, the underlying mental process of hearing can be easily inferred from "*feng yu sheng*" (风雨声, *wind and showers sounds*), indicating that the poet heard the sounds of wind and showers last night. The participants, processes, and circumstances in this poem are shown in Table 7.2.

In the eight processes (both explicit and implicit), five of them—one behavioral process (*mian*) and four mental processes (*jue*, *wen*, (heard) and *zhi*)—have humans (i.e., the poet) as the hidden agent. The omission of the specified agent allows readers to immerse themselves in the scene, making them see, hear, and feel the same way as the poet. The two nonhuman life agents *niao* and *hua* in the behavioral process (*ti*) and material process (*luo*) also function as the Phenomenon of the two mental processes having the poet as the Senser, specifically, "the poet *wen ti niao*" and "the poet *zhi (hua luo) duoshao*". Additionally, the non-life form "the sky", which is the Carrier of the relational process *xiao*, also serves as the Phenomenon of the mental process "the poet *bu jue xiao*". In the implicit process, another non-life form *feng yu* acts as the Phenomenon of the mental process "heard", with the poet as the Senser. While this poem predominantly frames nonhuman entities as the affected, a linguistic device often associated with constructing destructive or ambivalent narratives, a reevaluation through the lens of self-realization yields different interpretations.

The qualitative diversity of these participants is examined from four aspects. In respect of PROPERTY, the four types of participants—the poet, nonhuman animals, plants, and non-life forms—are distinguishable in terms of [±animate], [±animal], and [±human]. The poet is interpreted as [+animate], [+animal], and [+human]; *niao* as [+animate], [+animal], and [-human]; *hua* as [+animate], [-animal], and [-human]; and *feng yu* and the sky as [-animate], [-animal], and [-human]. The participants show different forms of symbiosis according to their shared properties. In terms of [±animate], participants are categorized as {the poet, *niao*, *hua*} vs. {the sky, *feng yu*}; in terms of [±animal], they are categorized as {the poet, *niao*} vs. {*hua*, the sky, *feng yu*}; in terms of [±human], they are classified as {the poet} vs. {*niao*, *hua*,

[3] The explicit participants and processes represented through Chinese Pinyin, and the implicit ones are conveyed via English.

Table 7.2 Participants, processes, and circumstances in *Spring Morning*

Line	Process	Explicit agent	Implicit agent	Explicit process	Implicit process	Affected	Circumstance
1	1		the poet: Behaver	*mian*:behavioral			*chun*: time
	2		the poet: Senser	*jue*: mental–cognition			
	3		it (the sky): Carrier	*xiao*: relational–attributive			
2	4		the poet: Senser	*wen*: mental–perception		*ti niao*	*chu chu*: space
	5	*niao*		*ti*: behavioral			
3	6		the poet: Senser		heard: mental–perception	*feng yu sheng*	*ye*: time
4	7	*hua*		*luo*: material			
	8		the poet: Senser	*zhi*: mental–cognition		*[hua luo] duoshao*	

the sky, *feng yu*}. Through circumstantial elements, the participants are spatially and temporally extended. The spatial extension is first reflected in the extension from indoors to outdoors. The processes of the poet sleeping, being aware of, hearing, and knowing take place indoors, while the processes of daybreak, birds crying, wind and showers, and flowers falling take place outdoors. The outdoor participants create a layered image: the sky at the top, wind, showers, and birds in the middle, and the poet and fallen flowers at the bottom. Furthermore, the circumstantial element "everywhere" (处处, *chu chu*) disperses the sounds of birds crying to extend outward from one point in all directions. From the SPATIAL aspect, the participants are categorized as: {the poet} vs. {*niao*, *hua*, the sky, *feng yu*} in terms of [±inside], {the sky} vs. {*niao*, *feng yu*} vs. {the poet, *hua*} in terms of [latitude], and {the poet, *hua*} vs. {the sky, *niao*, *feng yu*} in terms of [±center]. The temporal extension is directly conveyed by the circumstantial element *ye*, which transports readers from the immediate scene (the poet sleeping, daybreak, fallen flowers, and birds crying) to the wind and showers and flowers falling in the wind and showers in the preceding night. From the TEMPORAL aspect, the participants are categorized as: {the poet, the sky, *niao*, *hua*} vs. {the poet, *feng yu*, *hua*} in terms of [±now]. From the aspect of EMOTION, daybreak and birds crying in the first two lines highlight the vibrancy of a spring morning, mirroring the poet's joyfulness. Conversely, the fallen flowers in the wind and showers in the last two lines illustrate the emphemerality of life, expressing the poet's regret for its fleeting nature. Through the contrast between {the sky, *niao*} and {*feng yu*, *hua*} in terms of [±positive], the poem naturally realizes an emotional shift from joyfulness to regret. The four aspects of qualitative diversity provide the participants with a variety of ways to connect to one another, characterized by interspecies, cross-spatial, and cross-temporal features. The extensions are facilitated by the poet's perceptual and cognitive engagement with the other three types of participants, who participate directly or indirectly in each process. In conclusion, *Spring Morning* contains five participants, eight processes, and three circumstances. They have eight possible combinations according to shared properties, spatial distributions, temporal distributions, and emotional shifts.

Spring Morning reveals the poet's capacity for empathy, whereby he not only exhibits his perception and understanding of spring by integrating himself into it but also facilitate readers' engagement with his experience to draw them into the unity of the poet, the scenery, and the moment.

The Dale of Singing Birds

The Dale of Singing Birds depicts the serenity and vitality of a spring night in the mountain stream. With a technique of plain sketching, the poet presents a rich Zen-like landscape, embodying his unique style of "painting within poetry". The poem and its translation are demonstrated in Table 7.3.

There are seven participants in this poem, including human *ren* (人, *noise/the poet*), *gui hua* (桂花, *laurel blooms*), *ye* (夜, *night*), *chun shan* (春山, *hills*), *yue* (

Table 7.3 *The Dale of Singing Birds* and its translation

鸟			鸣				涧		
Niao			Ming				Jian		
Birds			Singing				Dale		
Line 1	人	闲[4]	桂花	落,	Line 2	夜	静	春山	空。
	ren	xian	gui hua	luo		ye	jing	chun shan	kong
	human noise/the poet	is quiet/ is relaxed	laurel blooms	fall		night	is quiet	hills	are void
Line 3	月	出	惊	山鸟,	Line 4	时	鸣	春涧	中。
	yue	chu	jing	shan niao		shi	ming	chun jian	zhong
	the moon	has risen	startles	birds		from time to time	sing	dale	in the middle of

月, *the moon*),[5] *shan niao* (山鸟, *birds*), and *chun jian* (春涧, *dale*), and they are all explicitly present. The participants, processes, and circumstances in this poem are shown in Table 7.4.

First, *ren xian* will be discussed further. Literally, *ren* means the noise made by humans, and *ren xian* denotes a place free from human noise. This creates a tranquil and relaxed atmosphere, which lends itself to an alternative interpretation of *ren xian* as the poet's peaceful inner world. In respect of PROPERTY, the participants are categorized as: {*ren*, *gui hua*, *shan niao*} vs. {*ye*, *chun shan*, *yue*, *chun jian*} in terms of [±animate], {*ren*, *shan niao*} vs. {*gui hua*, *ye*, *chun shan*, *yue*, *chun jian*} in terms of [±animal], and {*ren*} vs. {*gui hua*, *ye*, *chun shan*, *yue*, *shan niao*, *chun jian*} in terms of [±human]. The moonrise initiating changes implies temporal extension, as it startles birds and prompts them to sing in the dale. Accordingly, from the TEMPORAL aspect the participants can be connected by reference to [±now]: {*ren*, *gui hua*, *ye*, *chun shan*} vs. {*yue*, *shan niao*, *chun jian*}. Spatially, the visible, smellable, and touchable laurel blooms near the poet, the moon, birds, and dale at a medium distance, and the hills and night as the background, realize a spatial shift

[4] In Chinese, a relational process can be realized by an adjective group. For example, in "她漂亮" (*ta piao liang*, she is beautiful), *ta* (she) is the Carrier, and the adjective *piao liang* realizes Process · Attribute. This also applies to "人闲" (*ren xian*), "夜静" *(ye jing*), and "春山空" (*chun shan kong*). They employ adjectives (*xian*, *jing,* and *kong*, respectively) instead of verbs to realize relational processes.

[5] "月出" can also be translated as a nominal group "the moonrise". However, in Nie's (2015) annotation, it is interpreted as "月亮从山谷中升起" (the moon has risen from the valley), a material process realized by "has risen". This article agrees with Nie in the framework of self-realization, as it infuses energy to the moon through a material process, demonstrating a dynamic change that a nominal group inherently obscures.

Table 7.4 Participants, processes, and circumstances in *The Dale of Singing Birds*

Line	Process	Explicit agent	Implicit agent	Process	Affected	Circumstance
1	1	*ren*: Carrier		*xian:* relational–attributive		
	2	*gui hua:* Actor		*luo:* material		
2	3	*ye:* Carrier		*jing:* relational–attributive		
	4	*chun shan:* Carrier		*kong:* relational–attributive		
3	5	*yue:* Actor		*chu:* material		
	6		the moonrise: Actor	*jing:* material	*shan niao*	
4	7		birds: Behaver	*ming:* behavioral		*shi:* time
	8					*chun jian:* place

between distant and close-up views. Besides, the moon and birds in the upper part of the scene, the hills and dale in the middle, and the poet and laurel blooms in the lower part constitute a multi-layered composition. Lastly, the poet, laurel blooms, dale, the moon, and birds are all enveloped by night and hills. From the SPATIAL aspect, it is possible to categorize the participants from [distance] into {*ren*, *gui hua*} vs. {*yue*, *shan niao*, *chun jian*} vs. {*chun shan*, *ye*}, [latitude] into {*ren*, *gui hua*} vs. {*chun shan*, *chun jian*} vs. {*yue*, *shan niao*}, and [±center] into {*ren*, *gui hua*, *chun jian*, *yue*, *shan niao*} vs. {*ye*, *chun shan*}. Seen from an EMOTIONAL standpoint, these participants do not demonstrate shifts between positive and negative emotions; instead, they collectively sustain a serene and tranquil atmosphere. In comparison with *Spring Morning*, this poem, though rich in diversity across PROPERTY, TEMPORAL, and SPATIAL dimensions, falls short of the complexity found in *Spring Morning* due to the absence of EMOTIONAL variation. The realizations of the agents and processes in this poem also differ significantly from *Spring Morning*, as illustrated in Table 7.5.

The Dale of Singing Birds differs significantly from *Spring Morning* in the type and number of explicit agents, implicit agents, and processes. Apart from the two nonhuman explicit agents *hua* and *niao*, *Spring Morning* is dominated by six implicit agents, five of which are human (the poet). In contrast, in *The Dale of Singing Birds,* five out of the seven agents are explicit, four of which are nonhuman. In respect of processes, in *Spring Morning,* the dominant type is mental processes having the poet as the Senser; another process with the human agent is the behavioral process. The remaining processes have nonhuman participants as agents, including a relational process indicating the state of the sky, a behavioral process indicating the birds' behavior of singing, and a material process indicating the flowers' action of falling. In *The Dale of Singing Birds,* there are two dominant types, one being the relational

Table 7.5 Type and number of agents and processes

	Type and number of explicit agents	Type and number of implicit agents	Type and number of processes
Spring Morning	*hua*/*niao*: [+animate] [-human] (2)	the poet: [+animate] [+animal] [+human] (5)	human agent (5): mental (4)–*jue*, *wen*, heard, *zhi*; behavioral (1)–*mian*
		the sky: [-animate] [-animal] [-human] (1)	nonhuman agent(3): relational (1)–the sky *xiao*; behavioral (1)–*niao ti*; material (1)–*hua luo*
The Dale of Singing Birds	*ren*: [+animate] [+animal] [+human] (1)	the moon (moonrise)/ birds: [-human] (2)	human agent(1): relational–*xian*
	gui hua/*ye*/*chun shan*/*yue*: [-animal] [-human] (4)		nonhuman agent(6): material (3)–*gui hua luo*, *yue chu*, the moonrise *jing*; relational (2)–*ye jing*, *chun shan kong*; behavioral (1)–birds *ming*

processes that describe the state of the poet, the night, and the hills, and the other being the material processes that depict the actions of the flowers and the moon. Moreover, there is a behavioral process indicating the birds' behavior of singing. *The Dale of Singing Birds* is predominantly defined by the processes having nonhuman agents, highlighting their states, actions, and behaviors.

In the literature, numerous studies advocate constructing nonhuman participants as the agent, particularly as Actor and Senser, to underscore their consciousness and proactivity. These partially feature beneficial discourses, but it is not wise to rush to a conclusion that *The Dale of Singing Birds* attains a higher self-realization than *Spring Morning*, without considering complexity and symbiosis. The theme of *Spring Morning* is to express love and pity for spring. This is achieved by constructing daybreak, birds crying, wind and showers, and flowers falling as the Phenomenon in the mental processes having the poet as the Senser. It shows, on the one hand, the integration of the human Senser with the four nonhuman Phenomenon, and on the other hand, the interconnectedness of the four nonhuman participants within the context of spring. *The Dale of Singing Birds* emphasizes the tranquility of the hills at night, with all participants and processes employed to make salient the serenity. The relational processes in the first two lines depict the quietness. Even the material process of laurel blooms falling is contingent upon the absence of human noise, because only when the poet is in a tranquil, undisturbed state can the flowers falling be detected. The ways the poet detects the falling of flowers can be by seeing them (sight), by feeling the petals that land on his clothes (touch), by hearing the subtle sound of the petals falling on the ground (hearing), or by smelling their floral fragrance (smell). *Ren xian*, introduced at the outset of the poem, serves not only as the prerequisite for perceiving flowers falling but also as the foundation for perceiving all subsequent movements,

including the moonrise startling birds (material process) and birds singing (behavioral process). Startling birds means not that the moonrise frightens the birds and makes them uneasy but that the moonrise initiates the birds' occasional calls. It is the interplay between external quietness (bodily presence) and inner peace (mental state) that enables the poet to derive tranquility from the movements. Neither of these two poems is detached or detachable from humans. While *Spring Morning* directly connects humans with nature by the mental verbs such as *jue*, *wen,* and *zhi*, *The Dale of Singing Birds* starts with the quietness of the environment and a relaxed state of the poet, establishing a basis for incorporating human feelings into the scenery. Both of these two poems achieve the ontological unity of body and mind (T_1) and the ecological unity of humanity and nature (T_3). Seen from this perspective, it is hard to draw a conclusion that *The Dale of Singing Birds* gains a higher self-realization than *Spring Morning*, although the former includes more nonhuman participants and agents.

Early Departure

Self-realization is not restricted to individuals coexisting *happily* with nature. It is expressed through diverse natural sentiments, provided that individuals unite themselves with nature as one, as illustrated by Naess's painful feeling in seeing a dying flea. In other words, seeking beneficial discourses is not equal to seeking discourses that convey only positive or happy emotions toward nature; rather, it involves discourses rich in diversity, complexity, and symbiosis. This is illustrated by *Early Departure*, which succinctly captures the solitary feelings of ancient travelers through typical scenes of dawn journey scenes. The poem and its translation are presented in Table 7.6.

In depicting a cold and desolate morning journey, this poem expresses the loneliness and homesickness experienced by the poet and travelers alike. Unlike the previous two poems, which focus solely on the feelings of the poet, this poem integrates the poet with a specific group—travelers in general—creating a shared emotional experience, which adds a social dimension to the ontological and ecological unities. The poet's experience, as reflected in the processes of *qi* (起, *rises*), *bei* (悲, *is sad*), and *thinks of* (思, *si*), resonates with the shared sentiments of travelers at that time. Meanwhile, the description of travelers through *zheng duo* (征铎, *horse bells*) and *ren ji* (人迹, *footprint*) captures what the poet sees and feels in that instant.

The first two lines delineate the actions and feelings of the poet and travelers alike in the morning. The material processes realized by *qi* and *xing* (行, *travels*) signify the poet's actions, the material process realized by *dong* (动, *move/ring*) denotes the movement of the carriage, and the mental process realized by *bei* reflects the poet's emotional state. *Dong zheng duo* implies a series of actions of travelers, such as harnessing the horse and driving the carriage. In the second line, the agent of the mental process, *ke*, is interpreted either as the poet when sadness is understood as the poet's nostalgia for being uprooted in a foreign land, or as travelers in general when sadness is seen as a shared feeling of those hastening on their journeys. In doing so, the poet's personal feelings expand into the shared emotions of a group with similar experiences. The third and fourth lines show what the poet saw and heard when he

Table 7.6 *Early Departure* and its translation

商山				早				行	
Shang Shan				Zao				Xing	
Shang Mountain				Early				Departure	
Line 1	晨	起	动	征铎,	Line 2	客	行	悲	故乡。
	chen	qi	dong	zheng duo		ke	xing	bei	gu xiang
	dawn	rises	move (ring)	horse bells		poet	travels	is sad	hometown
Line 3	鸡声		茅店	月,	Line 4	人迹		板桥	霜。
	ji sheng		mao dian	yue		ren ji		ban qiao	shuang
	cockcrow		thatched inn	moon		footprints		wood bridge	frost
Line 5	槲叶		落	山路,	Line 6	枳花		明	驿墙。
	hu ye		luo	shan lu		zhi hua		ming	yi qiang
	oak leaves		fall	mountain path		Zhi flowers (gardenia jasminoides)		brighten	wall of the posthouse
Line 7	因	思	杜陵梦,		Line 8	凫雁		满	回塘。
	yin	si	Duling meng			fu yan		man	hui tang
	hence	thinks of	Duling dream (the dream of homeland)			wild geese and mallards		are full of	meandering pool

woke up and came out of the inn. The scene is constituted by the participants that imply an early morning journey, including *ji ming* (鸡鸣, *cockcrow*), *yue* (月, *the moon*), and *shuang* (霜, *frost*) that indicate an early morning, and *mao dian* (茅店, *the thatched inn*), *ren ji,* and *ban qiao* (板桥, *wood bridge*) that indicate journey. The poet adds an auditory dimension to the picture through cockcrow, and an imaginary dimension through the footprints on the yet-to-melt frost of the wood bridge left behind by earlier travelers, thereby realizing a spatial and temporal extension. The fifth and sixth lines revolve around the poet's departure. The setting is constructed by two material processes that convey the actions of two nonhuman agents, i.e., *hu ye* (槲叶, *oak leaves*) *luo* (落, *fall*) and *zhi hua* (枳花, *Zhi flowers*) *ming* (明, *brighten*). In the former material process, the sounds of travelers stepping on fallen oak leaves along the mountain path introduce an auditory dimension to the action. In the latter material process, set against the backdrop of the early dawn, the blooming Zhi flowers, which paint the posthouse wall white, create a visual effect that amplifies the action. The last two lines construct the poet as the Senser and Actor. The current scene prompts the poet, the Senser in the mental process *si*, to recall his dream of his homeland (杜陵梦, *du ling meng*) from the previous night. The dream vividly presents an image of his hometown, where the back-to-the-warmth pool is filled of *fu yan* (凫雁, *mallards and wild geese*), as constructed in the relational process realized by *man* (满, *are full of*). This temporal shift (from the present to last night) and spatial leap (from a foreign land to his hometown) deepen the poet's sadness and loneliness, echoing the theme expressed in the first two lines. When displaced, one often realizes that their homeland has become an inseparable part of their identity (Naess 1987). Here, the contrast between the imagery of the foreign land and the poet's homeland serves to unify the poet's dual identity: as a stranger in a foreign land and as someone longing for home, both intensifying his loneliness.

This poem involves more participants than the previous two poems, including *ke* (the poet), travelers, *zheng duo*, *ji*, *mao dian*, *yue*, *ban qiao*, *shuang*, *hu ye*, *shan lu*, *zhi hua*, *yi qiang*, *fu yan,* and *hui tang*. It shares six key factors with *Spring Morning* and *The Dale of Singing Birds* in qualitative diversity: [±animate], [±animal], [±human], [±now], [distance], and [latitude]. But differing from those two poems, the participants in this poem are not characterized by [±center]. In addition, differing from the *The Dale of Singing Birds* but similar to *Spring Morning*, the participants in this poem are distinguishable from [±inside]. Conversely, unlike *Spring Morning* but similar to *The Dale of Singing Birds*, this poem lacks the interplay between opposing sentiments. More importantly, it needs another key factor [±generic] to make a distinction between the poet and travelers in general. Secondly, this poem is featured by the use of grammatical metaphor, typical cases being *ji sheng*, *ren ji,* and *ming*. The first two nominal groups express the actions that are supposed to be realized by verbal groups in material processes. They are the consequences of "cocks crow" and "travelers walk across the wood bridge". These congruent interpretations once again highlight the auditory, visual, and imaginary dimensions added to the actions, as previously discussed. *Ming*, an adjective in Chinese, is congruently used to indicate an Attribute, but in this poem it realizes a material process, which not only makes salient the initiativity of Zhi flowers but also adorns the flowers and posthouse

with a bright hue at dawn. Third, this poem is distinctive in its use of familiarization. It blurs the boundaries between the poet, travelers, and readers by using familiar elements or events within a shared context as stimuli for empathy. Examples include horse bells and the posthouse symbolizing a journey, the cockcrow, moon, and frost signifying the morning, Zhi flowers representing separation and sorrow, oak leaves conveying good luck on the journey, and the Duling dream revoking homesickness.

Spring Morning, *The Dale of Singing Birds,* and *Early Departure* all blend personal feelings with natural settings. The first two express joyfulness and pity and tranquility and peacefulness, respectively, and the third delivers sorrow and loneliness. This difference aligns with the context in which the poets composed their poems. *Spring Morning* and *The Dale of Singing Birds* were created in the High Tang era. *Spring Morning* was written during the poet's time of seclusion; he was enjoying a quiet idyllic life in Lumen Mountain (鹿门山) in his youth. The poet not only pictured a beautiful spring morning, but also expressed his joyfulness and his attitude of cherishing life. Similarly, *The Dale of Singing Birds* was written in the stable and unified High Tang era, which made it possible to incorporate the poet's Zen (meditation in Buddhism) of tranquility and peacefulness into the poem. However, *Early Departure* was completed during the turbulent Late Tang, a time when the poet was long ensnared in the imperial examination system and compelled to serve as a county lieutenant for livelihood. Consequently, the poet's sadness and nostalgia are readily apparent. In short, the three poems outline bodily-mental integration and human-nature integration, and meanwhile present the connections between the poets and their social backgrounds. Particularly, *Early Departure* realizes the integration of an individual with a particular group by unifying the poet and travelers alike. Therefore, while the three poems illustrate a high degree of ontological, social, and ecological self-realization, the third one excels in its portrayal of social unity.

7.5 Conclusion

"The central issue" discussed by "natural scientists, philosophers and discourse analysts" of "the linguistic choices" in the studies on nonhuman life forms is "anthropomorphism, and the extent to which imputing human thoughts or emotions to animals is either desirable or inevitable" (Sealey and Oakley 2014: 20). Particularly, anthropomorphism is linguistically constructed as Actor, Senser, Sayer, and Behaver. However, the concept of anthropomorphism itself is biased. It humanizes nonhuman forms or attributes human characteristics to them, grounded in the assumption that the values of nonhuman forms are assessed with humans as the reference point. In this sense, it is argued in this article that beneficial discourse is not necessarily anthropomorphic. Instead, the focus should be on broadening and deepening self-realization via diversity, complexity, and symbiosis.

This article follows the assumption that encouraging inclination is equally significant as establishing moral frameworks for advancing eco-civilization. The analysis of the three Tang poems answers the three questions raised in the introduction and,

meanwhile, sheds light on some debatable issues around beneficial and alternative discourses. Beneficial and alternative discourses do not necessarily convey *positive* or *happy* emotions, nor is the construction of nonhuman participants as agents the sole or primary criterion for evaluating their beneficiality. Instead, such discourses are characterized by a profound sense of self-realization. It is embedded in a spectrum of natural emotions that encompass bodily-mental, interpersonal, and human-nature integration. This can be achieved through the sharing of perceptions and emotions across species, time, and space, as well as fostering familiarization.

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Chapter 8
Huang's Studies on Ecological Discourse Analysis



Xiaochun Tan

8.1 Introduction

As the present collection is edited in honor of Professor Huang Guowen and this paper is written to express my gratitude to Professor Huang for his guidance, encouragement, help, and support, I would focus the discussion on his "ecological turn" (Huang 2022) in linguistics studies, beginning from January 2016, when he changed his job, from Sun Yat-sen University to South China Agricultural University, where he started the Chinese movement of ecolinguistics studies and began to enroll Ph.D. students majoring in ecological linguistics and linguistic ecology. I was the first of his five Ph.D. students who completed the Ph.D. studies at SCAU, gaining a degree in linguistic ecology.

As the literature to date shows, for the past four decades, Professor Huang's academic research has covered areas of English studies, stylistics, discourse analysis, systemic functional linguistics, translation studies, applied linguistics, and ecolinguistics. I decided to write a chapter for this collection, which can demonstrate my academic connections with Professor Huang. The paper is concerned with one of his major research areas, ecological discourse analysis. The aim of the paper is to explore his research in this field, and the methodology is concerned with textual analysis, a method that Professor Huang is strongly in favor of.

Professor Huang's ecolinguistics studies can be identified as an exercise of applicable linguistics (Halliday 2008), as exemplified in Halliday (1990/2003). For a comprehensive account of Professor Huang's academic ideas and achievements in ecolinguistics studies, see Zhao and Huang (2017), Zhou (2017), Chen and Huang, 2022, Huang (2022), Zhou and Zhai (2022).

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8.2 DeepSeek's Reply as Input

The present chapter first elicited information from DeepSeek and treated the result from the search as the input for discussion. On April 27th, 2025 (14:38) I turned to DeepSeek (https://www.deepseek.com/) for help. The prompt given was as follows:

> Please write an essay based on the following statement: Huang Guowen employs M.A.K. Halliday's Systemic Functional Linguistics theory and Arran Stibbe's ecolinguistic theory to conduct ecological discourse analysis, proposing the framework of "Harmonious Discourse Analysis".

The reasons for writing the above prompt are as follows: (1) Professor Huang's theoretical support is mainly from Halliday's Systemic Functional Linguistics (e.g., Halliday 1985, 1994; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004, 2014) and from Arran Stibbe's (e.g., Stibbe 2015, 2021) ecolinguistic theory; (2) Most of Professor Huang's writings on ecolinguistics are concerned with ecological discourse analysis, as he was one of the pioneers in China who introduced discourse analysis to the Chinese community; and (3) it was he who proposed Harmonious Discourse Analysis, which has been further developed by a number of Chinese scholars, especially Zhao Ruihua (e.g., Zhao 2022, 2023; Zhao and Huang 2017, 2021).

In the following discussion, the whole reply from DeepSeek is broken into different parts in Sect. 8.3, each of which will be analyzed and commented on where necessary.

8.3 Analysis

The following discussion is grouped under the different headings in the passage provided by DeepSeek. The different sections will be presented first, and this is followed by discussion, explanation, and/or evaluation.

8.3.1 The Title

The title of DeepSeek's reply is "Harmonizing Ecological Discourse: Huang Guowen's Synthesis of Systemic Functional Linguistics and Ecolinguistics". This title emphasizes the concept of "harmony" on the one hand and "synthesis" of Professor Huang's effort in drawing different theoretical supports in his ecolinguistics studies on the other hand. This would suggest that ecological discourse analysis is a problem-oriented approach to studies of "ecological analysis of discourse" (Alexander and Stibbe 2014).

8.3.2 The "Introduction"

The "Introduction" in DeepSeek's reply mentions a number of important points concerning Professor Huang's research:

> **Introduction**
>
> In the evolving field of ecological linguistics, Professor Huang Guowen has made significant theoretical contributions by innovatively combining M.A.K. Halliday's Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL) with Arran Stibbe's ecolinguistic theory to establish his "Harmonious Discourse Analysis" (HDA) framework. This interdisciplinary approach represents a groundbreaking effort to bridge Western linguistic theories with Eastern philosophical traditions, offering new perspectives for analyzing ecological discourse in the Chinese context and beyond.

DeepSeek's use of "the evolving field of ecological linguistics" is important in that it defines ecolinguistics as an evolving theme, which is like "applied linguistics" and "applied mathematics" (Halliday 2002/2007: 3). DeepSeek also emphasizes Professor Huang's contribution to the studies, and the use of "significant theoretical contributions by innovatively combining …" clearly expresses the appreciation of his work. From DeepSeek's answer we can see that the aim of innovatively combining Halliday's SFL with Stibbe's ecolinguistic theory is to establish Huang's "Harmonious Discourse Analysis" (HDA) framework. This may suggest that Huang's approach to ecological discourse analysis is a problem-oriented one, which is in line with Halliday's SFL (Halliday 2009: 61).

DeepSeek's use of "this interdisciplinary approach" can be interpreted to mean that ecological discourse analysis is interdisciplinary, since it involved disciplines such as linguistics, ecology, and others. More importantly, the study "represents a groundbreaking effort to bridge Western linguistic theories with Eastern philosophical traditions", thus "offering new perspectives for analyzing ecological discourse in the Chinese context and beyond" (Zhou and Huang 2017). Here there are three important points that cannot be missed: (1) Huang's "groundbreaking effort to bridge Western linguistic theories with Eastern philosophical traditions", (2) "new perspectives", which come from combining Halliday work with Stibbe's work, and (3) ecological discourse analysis "in the Chinese context", which is in line with Professor Huang's reiteration of scholars' social responsibility (Huang and Wen 2018; Huang and Xiao 2019).

8.3.3 The "Theoretical Foundations"

As was stated in the prompt, Professor Huang employs Halliday's SFL and Stibbe's ecolinguistic theory in his ecological discourse analysis, and DeepSeek's describes these two theoretical foundations as follows:

> ** Theoretical Foundations **

> Huang's framework is built upon two robust theoretical pillars. From Halliday's SFL, he adopts the three metafunctions of language - the ideational (constructing experience), interpersonal (enacting social relationships), and textual (creating coherent discourse). Particularly significant is his application of transitivity analysis to examine how different process types (material, mental, relational) construct human-nature relationships in discourse.
>
> Simultaneously, Huang incorporates Stibbe's ecolinguistic perspective, which examines how language shapes ecological worldviews. However, Huang extends beyond Stibbe's framework by introducing the crucial dimension of "harmony" as an evaluative criterion for ecological discourse, rooted in Confucian concepts of "天人合一" (unity of heaven and humanity) and "和而不同" (harmony in diversity).

DeepSeek assumes that Halliday's SFL and Stibbe's theory are "two robust theoretical pillars". As there are many aspects/components in SFL, and as different theoretical ideas can be put into the practice of ecological discourse analysis, DeepSeek only mentions Huang's use of the metafunctional analysis, especially transitivity analysis. DeepSeek also points out that the focus of transitivity analysis is "to examine how different process types…construct human-nature relationships in discourse". This important point cannot be ignored as the linguistic analysis is problem-oriented (i.e., how can human-nature relationships in discourse be constructed?).

In the second part of DeepSeek's answer, it is stated that the analyst's perspective leads to the examination of "how language shapes ecological worldviews", a point that Professor Huang emphasizes in a number of places (e.g., Huang and Chen 2016).

DeepSeek further emphasizes Professor Huang's study by saying that he "extends beyond Stibbe's framework by introducing the crucial dimension of 'harmony' as an evaluative criterion for ecological discourse, rooted in Confucian concepts of '天人合一' (unity of heaven and humanity) and '和而不同' (harmony in diversity)". Huang's effort in this respect can be seen as his characteristic approach to the study of academic issues which are culturally loaded.

The discussion here suggests (1) that in doing ecological discourse (which is problem-oriented), theoretical support is important because theories can solve problems in practice, (2) different theories can be combined and utilized as long as they can help solve the problem, and (3) cultural factors should be taken into consideration as the nature of the problem is ideationally oriented.

8.3.4 The "Methodological Innovation"

The answer under "Methodological Innovation" given by DeepSeek is grouped under three headings:

> **Methodological Innovation**
>
> The HDA framework introduces several methodological advances:
>
> 1. A tripartite classification of ecological discourse into "harmonious", "neutral", and "conflict" types
> 2. Three analytical principles:

- Systematicity Principle (examining discourse through SFL's context theory)
- Moral Principle (evaluating ecological ethics through appraisal resources)
- Proximity Principle (emphasizing cultural adaptation to Chinese contexts)

3. Multidimensional analysis incorporating:

- Transitivity patterns revealing anthropocentric or ecocentric orientation
- Nominalization strategies that obscure ecological agency
- Metaphorical constructions of nature (e.g., "mother earth" vs. "natural resources")

Here DeepSeek first says that the HDA framework introduces several methodological advances, giving a positive evaluation of the proposal of HDA. Then it gives "a tripartite classification of ecological discourse", which are "harmonious", "neutral", and "conflict" types. In fact, these three types of discourse are in line with Stibbe's classification of stories/discourses: beneficial stories/discourses, ambivalent stories/discourse, and destructive stories/discourses (Stibbe 2015, 2021). Here, "harmonious" refers to those discourses/stories that strengthen, enhance, or create harmony between human and nature, "neutral" refers to those discourses/stories that have pros and cons in terms of human-nature relationship, and "conflict" refers to those discourses/stories that destroy the ecosystems that life depends on. The distinction between "harmonious", "neutral", and "conflict" is largely based on the ecosophy of the analyst (Stibbe 2015; see also Naess 1989, 1995).

As was stated in Huang and Zhao (2021a, b) and other places (e.g., Huang 2017), in the HDA framework, there are three principles that serve as the descriptive principles followed in carrying out ecological discourse analysis as well as "norms guiding human thinking and activities". The three principles are: (1) the principle of conscience, (2) the principle of proximity, and (3) the principle of regulation. However, although DeepSeek also gives three principles to describe Huang's work, these three principles are not exactly the same as what was proposed earlier (e.g., Huang 2017; Huang and Zhao 2021a). If we examine the three principles given by DeepSeek with no reference to Huang's work, these principles are fine, and they are very good analytical principles: by adopting the Systematicity Principle, the focus is on examining discourse through SFL's context theory, by looking at the Moral Principle, ecological ethics can be evaluated through appraisal resources, and by applying the Proximity Principle, cultural adaptation to Chinese contexts can be emphasized. Since the topic of discussion is Huang's ecolinguistic ideas, DeepSeek's description is not adequate and truthful.

The third aspect concerning methodological innovation given by DeepSeek is the multidimensional analysis which incorporates (1) the transitivity patterns in discourse which reveal anthropocentric or ecocentric orientations, (2) the nominalization strategies in the choice of linguistic expressions that obscure ecological agency, and (3) the use of grammatical metaphor and metaphorical constructions of nature.

8.3.5 The "Applications and Case Studies"

Under this section, DeepSeek outlines four examples of application in relation to Huang's studies:

> **Applications and Case Studies**
>
> Huang's framework has been productively applied to:
>
> 1. Policy discourse analysis, revealing how Chinese environmental policies employ relational processes and high-modality expressions to construct ecological civilization narratives
> 2. Comparative media studies, contrasting Western "crisis framing" with Chinese "harmony framing" in climate change reporting
> 3. Educational materials analysis, examining how textbooks construct children's ecological consciousness
> 4. Critical discourse analysis of greenwashing in commercial advertising

The first example is related to the implication of HDA to the ecological discourse analysis, which is concerned with decision-making and policy-making and is context-based. The second area of application is comparative media studies, which may emphasize the importance of contrasting Western "crisis framing" with Chinese "harmony framing" in climate change reporting. The third area is concerned with educational linguistics studies (Halliday 2002/2007), with special reference to textbook and teaching materials analysis, focusing on how textbooks help shape children's ideology and construct their ecological consciousness.

Although there are many other areas of studies that ecological discourse analysis can be applied to, what DeepSeek gives here is good enough for the evolving field of ecological linguistics at this stage.

8.3.6 The "Theoretical Contributions"

After describing Huang's work, DeepSeek states that Huang's HDA makes three significant contributions to ecolinguistics:

> **Theoretical Contributions**
>
> Huang's HDA makes three significant contributions to ecolinguistics:
>
> 1. It provides a culturally-situated alternative to Western-centric ecolinguistic theories;
> 2. It operationalizes abstract ecological ethics through concrete linguistic analysis;
> 3. It demonstrates how traditional Chinese philosophy can inform contemporary linguistic research.

The first and the third points in DeepSeek's answer show that scholars have their own social and cultural identities in their academic research, which suggests that researchers in the same research area may give different contributions as they have different social and cultural identities. And this highlights the importance of the researcher's ecosophy and worldview (Huang and Chen 2016).

8.3.7 The "Conclusion"

In the conclusion, DeepSeek states that Huang's HDA is "an important development in ecological linguistics", because it is "successfully integrating Hallidayan linguistics with critical ecolinguistics while grounding the analysis in Chinese cultural philosophy":

> **Conclusion**
>
> Huang Guowen's Harmonious Discourse Analysis represents an important development in ecological linguistics, successfully integrating Hallidayan linguistics with critical ecolinguistics while grounding the analysis in Chinese cultural philosophy. By providing both theoretical innovation and practical analytical tools, the HDA framework offers valuable insights for researchers examining the crucial relationship between language, ecology, and cultural values in an era of environmental crisis. Future research could further develop quantitative applications of the framework and explore its relevance to other cultural contexts beyond China.

DeepSeek also mentions the general contributions of Huang's HDA as it "offers valuable insights for researchers" who are interested in studying "the crucial relationship between language, ecology, and cultural values in an era of environmental crisis".

By saying that "future research could further develop quantitative applications of the framework", DeepSeek states the weakness of not using quantitative methods in HDA. And the suggestion that further research could "explore its relevance to other cultural contexts beyond China" is an expectation of the general value of HDA.

8.3.8 The "References"

The last part of DeepSeek's answer is the "References", which are in fact "hypothetical examples". Of the three references listed, No. 2 and No. 3 are good examples, but No. 1 (i.e., Huang 2017) is a contrived example, which does not exist in the literature.

> **References** (Hypothetical examples)
>
> - Huang, G. (2017). Ecolinguistics Research and Harmonious Discourse Analysis. Beijing: Higher Education Press.
> - Halliday, M.A.K. (2001). New Ways of Meaning: The Challenge to Applied Linguistics. In A. Fill & P. Mühlhäusler (eds.), The Ecolinguistics Reader. London: Continuum.
> - Stibbe (2015). Ecolinguistics: Language, Ecology and the Stories We Live By. London: Routledge.

It can be assumed that DeepSeek knows that the reference list is not adequate or correct, because it states clearly that the references given are "hypothetical examples". The inadequate list of references given by DeepSeek suggests that what is retrieved from DeepSeek or any other similar AI models may not be adequate, correct,

or true in terms of both ideas and references. In other words, AI mechanisms such as DeepSeek can fabricate ideas, examples, and references that are in fact not from the authors or organizations concerned; they can be simply invented without being based on existing data. Therefore, we must understand that AI models can mislead us in our understanding of the world.

8.4 Discussion

Section 8.3 is the detailed analysis of the reply given by DeepSeek based on the researcher's prompt, the keywords of which include: Huang Guowen, Halliday's SFL, Stibbe's ecolinguistic theory, ecological discourse analysis, and Huang's "Harmonious Discourse Analysis". These keywords serve as the guidelines for DeepSeek's description and summary.

On the one hand, DeepSeek's answer is reasonable and adequate as it outlines Huang's ecolinguistic studies from a number of perspectives (i.e., theoretical foundations, methodological innovation, applications and case studies, and theoretical contributions). On the other hand, the description and evaluation leave room for improvement. This will be illustrated in the following discussion.

8.4.1 The General Assumption (Human-Orientedness) in HDA

In researching ecological discourse analysis, Huang (e.g., 2017) agrees with Stibbe's (2015) assertion that the analyst's ecosophy plays a vital role in determining whether a story/discourse is beneficial, ambivalent, or destructive. Thus, the same story/discourse can be identified differently if the two analysts have totally different ecosophies (Huang and Chen 2016).

Huang expresses his interpretation of the elements in ecosophy proposed by Stibbe (2015: 14–15):

> From the perspective of the seven elements of ecological philosophy as proposed by Stibbe (2015), we believe that the starting point remains human-centered – first and foremost, it emphasizes human life ("Valuing living") and welfare ("Wellbeing"). It then considers both the present and the future ("Now and the future"), extends concern to others ("Care", "Social justice"), and ultimately recognizes that the Earth's resources available to humanity are finite ("Environmental limits"). Therefore, it is essential to enhance our "adaptive" capacity toward the environment.
>
> (translated from Huang 2017: 882)

Huang's understanding of the factors involved in ecosophy helped form his worldview in ecological analysis of discourse, and this led to the proposal of the general assumption in HDA, which is "human-orientedness".

This general assumption of "human-orientedness" (yi ren wei ben 以人为本) (Huang 2017; Huang and Zhao 2021a) is culturally bound. The concept is concerned with the Chinese understanding of the relationship between human and nature. As Huang and Zhao (2021a: 9) argue:

> In the context of China, "human" has the specialized meaning of the people of a country (renmin人民). In terms of the political philosophy of Confucianism, humans, in the sense of "the people", are in contrast with the sovereign, as in "The people are the most important element in a nation; the spirits of the land and grain are the next; the sovereign is the lightest" (min wei gui, sheji ci zhi, jun wei qing 民为贵, 社稷次之, 君为轻) (The Works of Mencius Tsin Sin (Part II); Legge, 2014). This implication of human has been made explicit in terms of the idea of people-orientedness in modern China's green development (see Wang, 2014: 33), in which human refers not to humans in the abstract sense but to the people.

Huang and Zhao (2021a: 9) also argue that "harmonizing relations between economic growth and ecological protection guarantees the sustainability of the people's lives" and that "providing the people with ecological products and developing ecological industries will be beneficial for developing the green economy, promoting ecological protection, and enhancing the people's eco-awareness". This is also in line with the concept of "Harmonious coexistence" (Tan 2018).

It is a pity that this important concept of "human-orientedness" is ignored in DeepSeek's description.

8.4.2 The Three Principles in HDA

In HDA, there are three principles that govern the ecological analysis of discourse: (1) the principle of conscience, (2) the principle of proximity, and (3) the principle of regulation.

The concept of "conscience" (良知) in the principle of conscience originates from Confucian thought. Huang and Zhao (2019: 103) point out that the principle of conscience was proposed under the influence of Wang Yangming's philosophy of "extending innate knowledge" (致良知); that is, according to Wang Yangming's idea, conscience is the self-awareness of one's being, the foundation of ethical morality, and the basis for factual and value judgments.

The principle of proximity refers to the relationship between a human being and other living forms or the environment. Humans share varying degrees of closeness with other life forms in nature (including family, friends, strangers, birds, beasts, plants, etc.), forming a continuum from intimate to distant. As the most intelligent species on Earth, humans center their thoughts and actions on the "self", and interpret all relationships from their own perspective. According to Huang and Zhao (2019: 104–105), proximity can be defined across multiple dimensions—temporal, spatial, cognitive, emotional, and socio-structural. In ecological discourse analysis, examining how discourse constructs relationships between subjects and other life forms helps us evaluate events and language use.

The principle of regulation refers to the rules, regulations, and the limitations humans face in daily activities, whether internal or external. Internal constraints stem from conscience, self-cultivation, and education, while external constraints may come from community norms (e.g., local conventions), national laws (social or institutional regulations), or international governance (e.g., United Nations frameworks).

These three principles in HDA are premised on a "human-oriented" approach, because it is argued that without the human subject, there would be no basis to discuss the three principles (Huang 2017; Huang and Zhao 2019).

The three principles outlined above and the general assumption of human-orientedness in HDA are the key elements in the HDA framework, but this is not recognized by DeepSeek, which instead summarizes three related but different analytical principles: the Systematicity Principle (which is concerned with examining discourse through SFL's context theory), the Moral Principle (which is concerned with evaluating ecological ethics through appraisal resources), and the Proximity Principle (which emphasizes cultural adaptation to Chinese contexts). Although these three principles can be good principles, they are not the three principles proposed by Huang (2017) and Huang and Zhao (2019, 2021a, b).

8.4.3 The Validity of AI-Generated Information

Although AI such as DeepSeek can provide massive amounts of information on any topic, which cannot be manually retrieved in any way. However, due to the fact that all AI models learn from vast amounts of text data, which contain both accurate and inaccurate information, users should treat the information with caution, especially when the information is to be used in academic research. In the process of using AI models to help us retrieve and generate data, we should be fully aware that AI systems do not know facts in the way humans do, although the latter often judge the accuracies of information according to their subjective interpretation.

While it is acknowledged that the data (i.e., the essay provided by DeepSeek) in the present study basically provide relevant, accurate, important information concerning Professor Huang's ecolinguistics studies for the past 10 years, it should be pointed out that the essay also contains insufficient and/or inaccurate information. As was already pointed out in Sect. 8.4.1, in Huang's proposed HDA, the general assumption (human-orientedness), the very basic element in the framework, is ignored completely. This shows that the information given by DeepSeek is insufficient. Like the human-orientedness assumption, the three principles of conscience, proximity, and regulation in HDA are not accurately represented by DeepSeek, as was indicated in Sect. 8.4.2. Furthermore, the references provided are not entirely accurate, although it did warn us that the references are "hypothetical examples".

As AI models (such as DeepSeek) learn from vast amounts of text data, which contain both accurate and inaccurate information (with biases, outdated facts, or misinformation), it is difficult to ensure the accuracy and sufficiency of information

provided by AI models. Therefore, customers should use the service provided by AI models with caution.

8.4.4 Attitudes to AI's Information

In the passage given by DeepSeek in relation to Professor Huang's work in the field of ecolinguistics studies, there are a number of words and expressions which are used to express very positive evaluations: "significant" and "innovatively" in "significant theoretical contributions by innovatively combining…", "groundbreaking" in "a groundbreaking effort to bridge…", "particularly significant" in "particularly significant is his application…", "significant contributions" in "three significant contributions to ecolinguistics", and "valuable insights" in "valuable insights for researchers…". The aim of using these positive words and expressions of evaluation is to give a positive (and expected) answer, as the user is understood as a person who has a positive attitude to Huang's work.

However, to a certain extent, the evaluation given by AI models (such as DeepSeek) is likely to exaggerate or overstate the achievements made by the person concerned, and one may say that, to some extent, it is true of the case of Professor Huang's achievements described in the passage by DeepSeek. In saying this, I must make it clear that I am not downgrading Professor Huang's research and his contribution in any way, as we will be fully aware of the problems and limitations of any AI models in this respect. The main motivation for me to point this out is to remind us of the fact that AI models can give insufficient and/or inaccurate information and their evaluation should be treated with caution, and this will help us raise our self-awareness and develop a way of critical thinking and reading, which is an appropriate way of growing up in the academic community.

By writing this paper, I have come to realize the importance of making good use of AI models such as DeepSeek, and at the same time I have also noticed some weaknesses of AI models such as DeepSeek.

8.5 Concluding Remarks

Professor Huang began to conduct academic research from the early 1980s, and he has published extensively both in China and abroad, with over 200 academic papers and over 10 monographs, covering the areas of English grammar, discourse analysis, systemic functional linguistics, translation studies, ecolinguistics, and applied linguistics. A brief survey of his academic research was first given in Huang (1996), and this is supplemented by another survey by Huang (2024).

Professor Huang's research on ecolinguistics has been acknowledged by scholars at home and abroad. International ecolinguistics scholars have noticed and spoken highly of his work and contributions. For example, Arran Stibbe, who is the Convener

of the International Ecolinguistics Association, writes in the second edition of his monograph entitled *Ecolinguistics* (Stibbe 2021: 212):

> More recently, in China, scholars have developed Harmonious Discourse Analysis (Huang and Zhao 2019). This approach is unique because it is strongly rooted in traditional Chinese philosophies of harmony, particularly the three Confucian principles of conscience, proximity and regulation (Huang 2017, p. 880). Huang and Zhao (2021a, b) describe how in Harmonious Discourse Analysis, 'by examining language-related ecological problems in discourse, we aim to present the various relations of humans with other ecological participants and to promote harmonious relations via language'. The importance of Harmonious Discourse Analysis is that it provides an example of ecolinguistics travelling across the world and being reinvented in line with the culture, philosophy and ecology of the place it has arrived in.

Stibbe discusses Huang's proposal of HDA in other places as well (e.g., Stibbe 2023). Like Stibbe (e.g., 2021, 2023), Poole (2022: 10) states:

> Chinese ecolinguists have forwarded an approach to ecolinguistics titled Harmonious Discourse Analysis (Huang and Zhao 2021a). Harmonious Discourse Analysis integrates the theoretical framework of systemic functional linguistics with traditional Chinese philosophy in order to develop a context-sensitive, locally informed framework for application in non-Western settings.

I was one of the over 60 Ph.D. students Professor Huang supervised, and in 2021 I obtained my Ph.D. in Ecology, majoring in linguistic ecology, from South China Agricultural University. It was because of him that I began my academic research in ecolinguistics, and it was with great gratitude that I chose to write the present topic.

Professor Huang is my academic mentor, and he also sets a role model in life for me. Let me complete this chapter by quoting what Professor Huang said in 2024, when he retired from South China Agricultural University as a professor of ecolinguistics:

> Upon reflection, there are only a few truly important things in life. The value of life, or rather its beauty, lies in love: love for oneself, for family, for others; love for one's hometown, for community, for country; love for the environment, for nature, for the choices we make, and for every task we undertake. Cherishing life, revering nature, living well, and seizing the present moment—these are principles we must always remember. To live healthily and happily, surrounded by those who love and appreciate you—this is what truly matters in life. Life, after all, is a journey of self-improvement. Live each day with purpose, free from regret, resentment, or remorse, and that will suffice.

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Chapter 9
The Discursive Construction of Ecological Image for Chinese Oil and Gas Corporations in Climate Change Representation: A Corpus-Based Study of Sustainability Reports



Lin Zhang

Abstract Drawing upon the integrated theoretical framework of Systemic Functional Linguistics and Fairclough's three-dimensional discourse analysis model, the article uses corpus-linguistic methods to investigate the ecological image constructed in major Chinese oil and gas companies' sustainability reports (2012–2023) through the representation of climate change. It analyses the frequencies and the collocations of the terms 'climate change', 'global warming', and 'climate-related risks'. The findings show that the ecological image of Chinese oil and gas companies is characterized by their growing concern over climate change. Initially, these companies regarded climate change as a challenge, but recently they prefer to represent it as an opportunity for development. They acknowledge the crises caused by climate change while emphasizing its global significance. The companies focus on the measures to manage climate change and its related risks. Moreover, they highlight the significance of energy efficiency and transition, ecological protection, and emission reduction in the context of climate change. Finally, it can be argued that the ecological image of these oil and gas companies is influenced by various sociocultural factors, including international and domestic climate policies, corporate strategic measures, and GRI disclosure standards.

Keywords Discursive construction · Ecological image · Chinese oil and gas companies · Climate change · Sustainability reports

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9.1 Introduction

In recent years, as global environmental pollution and the energy crisis has intensified, climate change has emerged as a central topic for all of humanity in addressing environmental issues. Scholars in linguistics have long been aware of the discursive construction and representation of climate change in media discourse (e.g., Carvalho and Burgess 2005; Grundmann and Krishnamurthy 2010; Grundmann and Scott 2014; Yu et al. 2024), corporate discourse (e.g., Jaworska and Nanda 2016), and political discourse (Napolitano and Aiezza 2019). Among them, as the leading force in combating climate change, enterprises release sustainability reports and view climate change as the critical element of environmental disclosure. Existing research has investigated key themes and linguistic strategies in foreign enterprises' sustainability reporting on climate change. Yet, few studies have explored how climate change is discursively constructed and represented in Chinese corporate sustainability reports.

Corporate image refers to the overall perception, evaluation, and impression that diverse social groups form of an enterprise (Martineau 1958). While earlier studies on corporate image focused mainly on economic or social aspects, recent studies have shifted to examining the relationship between corporate image and its environmental behavior. However, most of these investigations adopted a management perspective, with relatively few employing a discourse analysis approach.

Considering the above factors, the present study first proposes the concept of corporate ecological image and defines it as the stable impression and perception formed by the public about corporate environmental performance, ecological stance, and social responsibility. Moreover, we argue that research on ecological image not only reflects corporate's environmental consideration and accountability but promotes the overall corporate image in competition. Given the different image-building entities, corporate ecological image can be classified into the other-shaped and self-shaped ones. Based on the theoretical framework of critical discourse analysis (CDA) and systemic functional linguistics (SFL), this study adopts the corpus linguistics methodology and focuses on the overall distribution of climate change-related terms like 'climate change', 'global warming' and 'climate-related risk(s)' and their collocative verbal and nominal groups in sustainability reports of Chinese oil companies (2012–2023) in order to examine corporate perception, measures, and related topics in response to climate changes and to discuss the self-shaped ecological image of the enterprises. A broad aim is to reveal the strategies and performance of leading Chinese enterprises in pollution control when tackling environmental issues, thereby providing discursive support for the global dissemination of their eco-values.

9.2 Corporate Image and Corporate Sustainability Reports

The study of corporate image started in the early twentieth century. Martineau (1958: 53) first introduced the concept and defined it as the comprehensive perception of a company from distinct social groups. Furman (2010: 68) argued that corporate image is the overall perception of people's knowledge, beliefs, emotions, impressions, and perceptions related to a company.

Most of studies of corporate image were conducted within the field of management. Recently some researchers have noted the impact of ecological protection on corporate image (e.g., Motilewa et al. 2019). The concept of corporate image and reputation is further expanded through the study of green corporate image (e.g., Martínez 2015; Bathmanathan and Hironaka 2016). In China, some research on corporate image has been approached from a linguistic perspective, exploring how news media shape the image of Chinese corporations (e.g., Wang 2019; Gong 2020; Zhao 2021) and how companies construct their own image in corporate sustainability reports (e.g., Hu and Sheng 2020).

Corporate sustainability reports stem from corporate environmental reports. They disclose the positive or negative impacts of corporate activities on the economy, environment, and society within the framework of sustainability. In recent years, environmental reports have evolved into various types of reports, including Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) Reports, Sustainability Reports, and Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) Reports (e.g., Zhong and Gan 2006; Li et al. 2010). As environmental issues become increasingly severe, climate change has emerged as a central theme in corporate environmental disclosure. Some scholars investigated the content, mechanisms, and corporate stances adopted in sustainability reports when companies addressing climate change (e.g., Kolk et al. 2008; van Halderen et al. 2014). However, Tregidga et al. (2007) indicated that the discursive analysis of environmental reports provided insights into the way how corporate environmental philosophy is constructed, conveyed and how it exerts societal influence. Some studies employed rhetorical and sociological theories, examined the topics and linguistic strategies in climate change narratives of the reports (e.g., Ihlen 2009; Ferguson et al. 2016; Pollach 2018). Jaworska & Nanda (2016) combined corpus-based methods, cyclic theory, and topic modeling to investigate a large number of reports and found climate change is gradually becoming a representative topic in recent environmental reports. Centered on the discursive construction of climate change, Jaworska (2018) analyzed the environmental reports of the major global oil companies, and the finding indicated that climate change was initially described as a manageable phenomenon, but it has recently been viewed as an unpredictable risk. This shift reflects the uncertainty in corporate response to environmental issues. However, no studies have yet been conducted on Chinese environmental reports.

In summary, the connection between corporate image and its green image has already been noted in management studies. But from the perspective of discourse analysis, there has been limited research on how corporate discourse relates to environment and corporate image. While researchers have explored the themes and

linguistic strategies used in environmental reports to construct climate change narratives, there is a lack of studies that focus on how climate change is represented in Chinese environmental reports.

To address this gap, this article investigates the linguistic features of sustainability reports of three leading Chinese oil and gas companies and explores the ecological image that these companies construct in addressing climate change. It aims to answer the following three questions: (1) What lexicogrammatical features are highlighted through distribution and collocations of the terms 'climate change', 'global warming', and 'climate-related risk(s)' in Chinese oil and gas companies' reports? (2) What environmental behaviors, stances, and measures are realized by these linguistic features? What ecological image is constructed? (3) What ideological factors are embedded in the ecological image constructed by Chinese companies?

9.3 Theoretical Framework

9.3.1 Language, Society, and Context

Both theories of CDA and SFL emphasize the interrelationship between language, society, and context in language studies. CDA seeks to reveal the interaction between discourse, society, and power relations. Fairclough (1989) argued that language is a social practice determined by social structures. Linguistic activities take place in a social context, and they not only reflect but also involve social processes and practices. Thus, language shapes social structure, which in turn, is shaped by language. Their interaction drives the continuity and evolution of society.

Based on the dialectical relationship between language and society, Fairclough (1995: 97–98) proposed the three-dimensional discourse analysis model, in which he viewed discourse as oral or written texts, or discursive practice as well as sociocultural practice. The analysis of texts follows three stages: (1) description of the formal structural features of the texts (such as those of lexicogrammar and speech acts), (2) interpretation of the processes of discourse production, dissemination, and reception, and illustration of the relationship between text and discursive practices, and (3) explanation of the relationship between discursive processes and social processes. Processes of explanation need to be associated with the situational, institutional, and societal context in which discourse occurs. It is evident that context plays a particularly important role in CDA.

SFL also emphasizes the dialectical relationship between language and society. According to Halliday (1978), language actively constructs social systems and is, in turn, constructed by social systems. Halliday (1971) also pointed out that as social beings, people's behavior in the social environment is mostly linguistic behavior. Language, as a form of behavioral potential, is the speaker's capability to act. The behavioral potential is realized through the meaning potential, which is the ability to mean. The meaning potential, in turn, is realized through the lexicogrammatical

potential of the language system, which is the ability to say. These three potential systems are realized within the language stratum, corresponding to the contextual, semantic, and lexicogrammatical levels of language. The relationship between context, semantics, and the lexicogrammar is one of activation and construction. From a top-down view, context activates semantic choices, which then activates lexicogrammatical choices; from a bottom-up view, lexicogrammatical choices construe semantics, which in turn construes context (Hasan 2009: 170). Therefore, understanding language use is closely tied to context, which includes both the situational and cultural contexts.

9.3.2 Ideational Metafunction in SFL

In systemic functional linguistics, language serves three metafunctions: the ideational, interpersonal, and textual functions. The ideational metafunction is divided into the experiential and logical metafunctions. According to Halliday (1994; Halliday & Matthiessen 2004), the experiential metafunction refers to the use of language to represent our understanding and reactions to both the subjective and objective worlds, encompassing the transitive and ergative modes. The transitivity model identifies six types of processes for different functional configurations, such as material, mental, and relational processes. Each process type consists of three semantic components: process, participants, and circumstantial elements, which are realized by lower-level components in the clause. The process is realized by a verb (or verbal group), the participants by a noun (or nominal group), and the circumstantial elements by adverbs (or adverbial groups) or prepositional phrases.

Logical metafunction refers to the indirect representation of experience through logical relations in language. Logical-semantic relationships operate in clauses, groups, and phrase complexes. It can be further classified into parataxis and hypotaxis based on the interdependency between elements, and expansion and projection in light of logical semantics, A clause (or group or phrase) can be expanded in three ways: by elaborating, extending, or enhancing it.

In summary, the discussion on the relationship between language, society, and context provides an analytical framework for the study of ecological image construction in this article. Additionally, the ideational metafunction of systemic functional linguistics can serve as the primary theoretical framework for linguistic analysis.

Table 9.1 The sustainability report corpus

	Subcorpora	Reports	Tokens
1	CNPC	10	171,473
2	Sinopec	8	275,671
3	CNOOC	9	208,724
4	Total	27	655,868

9.4 Corpus Data and Methods

9.4.1 The Sustainability Report Corpus

A corpus of Chinese oil and gas companies' sustainability reports was constructed (see Table 9.1). The corpus was composed of 27 reports from three leading Chinese oil companies in the Fortune 500: PetroChina (CNPC), Sinopec, and China National Offshore Oil Corporation (CNOOC). These reports were released from 2012 to 2023.

It should be noted that CNPC and CNOOC replaced their *Sustainability Reports* with *ESG Reports* since 2018 and 2016 respectively. Given their shared origins and the consistency in environmental disclosure content, both types of reports have been included in the corpus. All these reports can be downloaded from the companies' websites in PDF form, and then were converted into plain text documents. After text preprocessing, the total number of tokens in the corpus is 655,868 words.

9.4.2 Analytic Procedure

This study, based on the theoretical framework of CDA and SFL, employs a corpus-based approach to explore the corporate ecological image shaped by Chinese oil and gas companies in response to climate change and the sociolcultural factors behind it.

First, based on the existing discursive analysis of climate change (c.f. Jaworska 2018; Pollach 2018) and the GRI Standards (2016, 2022), typical terms related to climate change, such as 'climate change', 'global warming', and 'climate-related risk(s)' were selected from the reports. Then we searched these terms by the software WordSmith and analyzed their annual distribution in the corpus to explore the general trend of Chinese oil and gas companies regarding climate change and risk mitigation, offering a macro-level view of the general characteristics of Chinese petroleum industry's ecological image.

Furthermore, we used the Word Sketch module of the Sketch Engine tool to examine the verbal and nominal groups that collocate with the above three terms. We then analyzed the process types and participants that constitute the experiential meaning, as well as the related topics represented by the nominal groups, investigating how these linguistic configurations reflect companies' perceptions, measures, and concerns in response to climate change.

Finally, we discussed the ecological image shaped by the companies' overall stances and measures in addressing climate change, and interpreted the creation, distribution, and consumption of the sustainability reports. We further explained the sociocultural factors that contribute to the formation of ecological image.

9.5 Results and Discussion

9.5.1 Trend of Climate-Related Terms and Ecological Image

Using WordSmith tool, we examined the annual frequencies of climate-related terms 'climate change', 'global warming', and 'climate-related risk(s)' of the reports to see the overall trend of Chinese petroleum companies' focus on climate change and risk mitigation, providing a macro view of the key features of their ecological image.

Figure 9.1 shows that the frequencies of climate change-related terms in the reports increased from 12 times in 2012 to a maximum of 116 times in 2023. Specifically, the frequency of these terms increased from 43 times in 2016 to 75 in 2020 and further to 116 in 2023. Among the terms analyzed, 'climate change' appears most frequently (336 occurrences), followed by 'climate-related risk(s)' (85) and 'global warming' (12). In general, a clear upward trend in climate change engagement is emerging among China's petroleum companies. These companies have not only recognized the importance of climate change but also actively responded to potential climate risks in recent years. The corporate attention to climate change may be attributed to various factors, including international and domestic environmental policies, an aspect to be addressed in subsequent discussion.

In the following section, we will further analyze the collocations of these terms to explore the ecological image of Chinese oil and gas companies in relation to climate change and risk management.

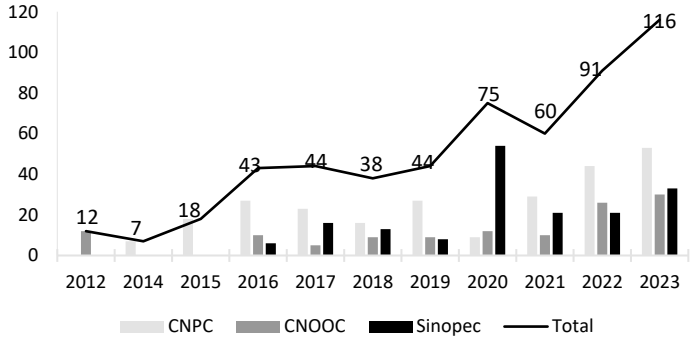


Fig. 9.1 Trend in Chinese oil and gas companies' focus on climate change

9.5.2 *Construction and Representation of Climate Change and Corporate Ecological Image*

According to Halliday & Matthiessen (2004: 175), the process is the most central element in the experiential function, followed by participants. Both, as the obligatory semantic components of a clause, construe the core experiential meaning of the clause. Based on this, we utilized the Sketch Engine tool to examine the verbs that collocate with 'climate change' and 'global warming', as well as their co-occurring nominal groups. Through analyzing the corporate environmental behavior and climate-related issues, we discussed the construction of the corporate ecological image.

9.5.2.1 Analysis of the Verbs Collocating with 'Climate Change' or 'Global Warming'

Using the Word Sketch tool, we searched the terms 'climate change' or 'global warming' in the corpus and extracted a list of verbs that co-occur with these terms when they serve as either the subject or the object within a clause. Table 9.2 indicates that the process types of the collocating verbs are mainly material clauses (including 75% of transformative types and 14% creative types) and relational clauses.

The analysis of the process types of verbs, their semantic features and the configuration of participants indicates that Chinese oil and gas companies construct a specific ecological image from their recognition of and response to climate change.

Table 9.2 Verbs collocating with 'climate change' or 'global warming'

Functions of the terms	Process types of the collocating verbs		Semantic set	Collocating verbs	Freq.	Pct.
climate change as subject	verbs in relational clauses	intensive	recognition	become, be, mean, represent	15	11%
climate change/global warming/ climate-related risk(s) as object	verbs in material clauses	creative		cause, bring, pose, trigger, create, affect	16	11.8%
		transformative	response	drive, promote, gain	3	2.2%
				address, tackle, combat, integrate, limit, monitor, help manage, keep	102	75%

Particularly, the latter is highlighted by verbs like 'address', 'tackle', and 'combat', co-occurring 102 times with the above key terms.

Moreover, through detailed analysis of the verbs collocating with 'climate change' and 'global warming', combined with the clause semantics and collocating groups, we found that the companies' perception of climate change can be identified in three aspects: climate change as a challenge, and an opportunity; climate change as a crisis; the importance of climate change issue (see Table 9.3).

Climate Change as a Challenge and an Opportunity

The construction of companies' image in the reports primarily manifests in the dynamic recognition of climate change. According to Tables 9.2 and 9.3, 'climate change' as the identified is described as 'a common challenge to the global energy industry', 'a common challenge for humankind', or 'more than risks and challenges' when it collocates with the verbs of the relational clauses 'become', 'mean', and 'be'. This pattern indicates that companies are more inclined to view it as a challenge, specifically a challenge to the global energy industry and humanity during 2012 to 2019.

Table 9.3 Semantic classification of collocating verbs with 'climate change' in clauses

Verbs	Semantic set	Collocating groups
become, bring, pose, mean, drive, create, increase, promote, be	challenge and Opportunities	a common challenge to the global energy industry(1)/the risks(2)(2012–2018) a common challenge for humankind(1)/ more than risks and challenges (1)/low-carbon development (1)(2019–2023) not only risks and challenges, but also opportunities for transformation and development(1)/the risks and opportunities(2)/ new opportunities(1)/the development Opportunities(1)/demand for low-carbon energy(1)/a faster reform in energy(1)
become, be, gain, require	significance	a global concern(1)/a noticeable issue in society(1)/a major issue that affects the future of the planet(1)/our future(1)/an important task of global energy development(1)/more weight in the international community(1)/a global issue for all humanity(2)/social attention and participation(1)
cause, trigger, represent, bring	crisis	a universal crisis for mankind(1)/extreme weather(1)hurricanes or flood(1) the increase of extreme weather phenomena(1)/ natural disasters(1)/storm surges and floods(2)/supply chain disruptions(1)

Note The numbers in parentheses in the table indicate the frequency and corresponding year of each group. Only years with discernible trends are presented

Since 2019, however, climate change has gradually been reframed in reports from a challenge to an opportunity. For example, climate change is defined as an opportunity for development and transformation in several identifying clauses. Likewise, the reports reinforce this presentation through the use of creative and transformative material clauses.

In a creative clause, the unfolding of the process has the sense of 'come into existence' of the Goal, while in a transformative clause, the outcome is the change of some aspect of an already existing Actor or Goal (Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 184). Therefore, the Actor 'climate change' and the creative verbs 'bring' and 'pose' configure the Goal 'the development opportunities', 'the risks and opportunities', which shows that climate change creates unprecedented opportunities for development. Furthermore, the Goal 'low-carbon development' and 'a faster reform in energy' is followed by transformative verbs 'drive' and 'promote'. This illustrates the driving role of climate change in current low-carbon development and energy reform transformation.

Climate Change as a Crisis

Climate change is also regarded as a crisis. In Table 9.3, verbs such as 'represent' in relational clauses and transformative verbs 'bring' in material clauses collocate with 'a universal crisis for mankind' and 'the risks', indicating that climate change poses a global crisis that affects all human beings.

The crisis is gradually specified as extreme weather and other negative impacts. Creative verb 'cause' frequently co-occurs with nominal groups representing extreme weather 'hurricanes or flood', 'the increase of extreme weather phenomena', 'natural disasters'. It demonstrates that enterprises acknowledge that climate change leads to extreme weather and natural disasters, such as hurricanes and floods. In addition, climate change also disrupts supply chain, as evidenced by the co-occurrence of the verb 'trigger' and the Goal 'supply chain disruptions'.

It is worth noting that the above material clauses all use the passive voice, introducing the Actor 'climate change' with the preposition *by*. This pattern occurs frequently, not only placing the Goal at the beginning of the clause as the theme or point of departure, highlighting crises such as extreme weather and supply chain disruptions, but also emphasizing climate change as the Actor, thereby obscuring the real cause of these crises: human activities.

Importance of Climate Change Issue

Tables 9.2 and 9.3 show that Chinese oil and gas companies' emphasis on climate change issue is primarily expressed through identifying clauses, typically featuring verbs like 'has become' collocating with the nominal groups 'a noticeable issue in society', 'a global concern', 'a major issue'. Modifiers 'noticeable', 'global', and 'major' in nominal groups highlight 'climate change' as a major issue of social and global concern.

As illustrated by the concordance lines in Table 9.4, 'a major issue' is modified by the embedded clause 'that affects the future of the planet and humankind', suggesting that climate change also affects the future of the Earth and humanity. This

representation highlights the significance of climate change issue, as evidenced by its far-reaching impact. Additionally, the verb 'gain' co-occurs with 'more weight' and 'in the international community', further indicating that the increasing importance of climate change issue on the global stage. Overall, through specific lexical-grammatical configurations, Chinese oil and gas companies frame climate change as a critical issue in both social and global contexts.

Response to Climate Change

Chinese companies' reports place special emphasis on measures to combat climate change (see Table 9.2). They mainly use transformative verbs like 'address', 'tackle', and 'combat', which collocate with the Goal 'climate change' (see Table 9.5), reflecting the resolution of Chinese companies to address this pressing issue. A closer analysis of the concordance lines reveals that the above configuration elaborates on the companies' climate change mitigation strategies by expanding or enhancing logico-semantic relations.

As demonstrated in Table 9.5, non-finite verbal groups 'to tackle climate change', 'to combat climate change', serve to extend the first verbal groups 'took various measures', 'made proactive efforts', 'integrate energy conservation, emissions reduction, and carbon reduction management systems' and 'is required to'. With 'we' and 'robust international cooperation' as the actors, these clauses construct a corporate image actively engaged in responding to climate change, through both implemented and ongoing initiatives such as energy conservation and emissions reduction. Moreover, they emphasize that climate action is not merely a corporate commitment but

Table 9.4 Sample of concordances of the importance of 'climate change' issue

1	**Climate change**	*has become a major issue* that affects the future of the planet and humankind.
2	As the issue of **climate change**	*gains more weight* in the international community, the influence of the Paris Agreement will gradually expand.

Table 9.5 Sample of concordances of the response to climate change

1	We took various measures to *tackle*	**climate change** and control greenhouse gas emissions.
2	In 2010, we made proactive efforts to *combat*	**climate change**,
3	We *integrate* energy conservation, emissions reduction and carbon reduction management systems to *tackle*	**climate change.**
4	Robust international cooperation is required to *combat*	**climate change.**
5	We support the goal of *limiting/keeping*	**global warming** (to) less than 2 degrees Celsius by the end of this century.

a global obligation that demands international collaboration. The use of the transformative verb 'integrate' further reflects an institutional effort to embed 'climate change' within comprehensive policy-making and risk governance frameworks.

Global warming, as a component of climate change, is also emphasized in the reports. The specific mitigation measures are presented through non-finite transformative verbs, such as 'limiting' and 'keeping', along with 'to less than 2 degrees Celsius by the end of this century'. This configuration reflects the enterprises' efforts to reduce greenhouse gas emissions and meet emission targets, specifically limiting global warming to below 2 degrees Celsius by the end of the century. Evidently, Chinese oil companies prioritize specific actions in addressing climate change.

9.5.2.2 Analysis of the Nominal Groups Extending 'Climate Change' or 'Global Warming'

In SFL, participants are generally realized by nominal groups. Drawing on the collocations retrieved via the Word Sketch, we find that the nominal groups co-occur with 'climate change' (or 'global warming') in a paratactic relation in the clauses, forming an extension relation to provide additional information.

According to Table 9.6, the nominal groups that extend 'climate change' or 'global warming' primarily cover topics such as energy utilization and environmental protection.

Table 9.6 Classification of collocating nominal groups of 'climate change' or 'global warming'

Paratactic nominal groups	Related topics	Head/ superordinate terms in the nominal groups
enhancement of energy efficiency (1), energy efficiency improvement(1), energy conservation (8), energy security (2)/energy transformation (1),energy transition (1), low-carbon transition (2), development of new technology (1), technological transformation (1)	energy utilization	risk/challenge response/action/ discussion/ disclosure/ consumers' attention
environment protection (5), ecological protection (1)/the Paris Agreement (1), the control of greenhouse gas (1), emissions (1),emission (1), air pollution(1)/ sustainability(1),sustainable development(1)	environmental protection	importance/ESG indicators impact/ environmental problems//factors
COVID-19(1), COVID-19 pandemic(1)/extreme weather(1)/shareholder returns(1)/quality management(1),finance(3)	other topics	

Note The above classification centers on the collocations of 'climate change', whereas 'global warming' appears rarely and is discussed only as a specific case

Climate Change and Energy Utilization

A detailed analysis of concordance lines (see Table 9.7) reveals that the nominal groups related to energy utilization including 'energy conservation', 'enhancement of energy efficiency', 'energy efficiency improvement', co-occur with 'climate change' to elaborate on the Head 'discussions', 'issues', or collocate with the verb 'address'. This collocation illustrates corporate efforts in actively addressing climate change, with a focus on energy conservation and efficient utilization.

Sustainability reports of Chinese oil and gas companies also demonstrate a discursive focus on the transformation of the energy structure in the context of climate change. Nominal groups pertaining to energy transition, such as 'energy transition', 'low-carbon transition', 'energy transformation', and 'development of new technology', frequently co-occur with 'climate change'. According to the concordance lines, these nominal groups either function to modify the Head 'discussion', 'disclosure', 'issues', and 'response' signaling the companies' emphasis on the energy transition in response to climate change or they modify 'factors', serving as the circumstantial element in clauses 'due to factors including', indicating the company's recognition of climate change, the COVID-19 pandemic, and technological innovation, all of which may have an impact on the future structure of energy use.

Table 9.7 Sample of concordances of 'climate change' (or 'global warming') and energy

1	Participate in discussions organized by the government on	**climate change**, energy conservation and emission reduction.
2	Petrochina achieved good performance in technical innovation, contributing effective solutions to issues, such as equal access to energy, response to	**climate change** and enhancement of energy efficiency.
3	We communicated the material issues including risks and opportunities in sustainable development, shareholder returns, addressing	**climate change** and energy efficiency improvement.
4	We have also made targeted enhancements to the disclosures on	**climate change** and energy transition, sustainable use of resources,
5	CNPC is deeply involved in international cooperation with other OGCI members to address issues on	**climate change** and low-carbon transition in the oil and gas industry.
6	Stakeholders pay closer attention to the Company's response to	**climate change** and energy transformation.
7	the future energy mix will change significantly due to factors including	**global climate change** and development of new technology.
8	However, inefficiencies in energy production and use lead to the depletion of precious energy resources and cause environmental problems, such as	**global warming**, extreme weather and air pollution.

Climate Change and Environmental Protection

Environmental protection emerges as another key category among nominal groups extending 'climate change', comprising three sub-topics: environmental conservation, emission reduction, and sustainable development. These topics, when combined with climate change, jointly shape companies' ecological image. Further examination of concordance lines (see Table 9.8) reveals three key patterns:

Firstly, climate change co-occurs with nominal groups like 'environmental protection', functioning as post-modifiers to the Head 'response', which indicates that companies perceive both climate change and environmental protection as significant issues warranting equal attention and response. Secondly, the co-occurrence of 'climate change' with emission reduction terms such as 'emission reduction', 'the control of greenhouse gas', 'the Paris Agreement' elaborate how companies prioritize emission control and air pollution mitigation, while actively addressing pollution management and complying with climate agreements. Finally, the collocation with 'sustainability' demonstrates that both climate change and sustainability have become key concerns for consumers.

It should be noted that in addressing climate change and environmental protection, distinct responsibilities are assigned to companies, governments, and consumers. In Table 9.8, the actors 'we', 'CNOOC', 'the government' introduced by 'by' and 'consumers' with verbal processes 'is deeply involved in', 'organized', and 'encourage' reflects the significant role of companies and governments in taking primary responsibility for climate action. Consumers' concern for climate change and sustainability also plays a crucial part in promoting the low-carbon transformation of products.

Table 9.8 Sample of concordances of 'climate change' and environment

1	We grant awards to the collectives and individuals of the Company with outstanding performance in response to	**climate change** and *environmental protection*
2	Participate in discussions organized by the government on	**climate change**, *energy conservation and emission reduction.*
3	CNOOC actively responds to the *Paris Agreement* and	**climate change.**
4	Consumers' attention to	**climate change** and *sustainability may encourage consumers to choose low-carbon products.*

Table 9.9 Sample of concordances of 'climate-related risk(s)'

1	*Describe the*	**climate-related risks** and opportunities the organisation has identified over the short, medium, and long term.
2	Disclose how the organisation identifies, *assesses and manages*	**climate-related risks.**
3	Describe the targets used by the organisation to *manage*	**climate-related risks** and opportunities and performance against targets.

9.5.2.3 Corporate Ecological Image in Response to Climate-Related Risks

In the above analysis, Chinese oil and gas companies have, to some extent, embraced the concept of climate change as a crisis. We further analyzed the collocations and concordance lines of the term 'climate-related risk(s)' (see Table 9.9).

As the Goal, 'climate-related risk' correlate with verbs 'identify', 'assess', 'manage', and 'integrate', and these verbs exhibit a semantic progression from risk identification to assessment and management. It is evident that these companies have implemented a series of well-structured and progressive measures to tackle the risks posed by climate change. A closer analysis of the related actors of these processes indicates a clear focus on 'the organization', which implicitly reinforces the notion that corporate responsibility is central to managing climate risks.

9.5.3 Discursive Interpretation in Sustainability Reporting by Chinese Oil and Gas Companies

Discourse practice focuses on the production, dissemination, and consumption of texts, serving as a mediating link between social-cultural practice and text (Fairclough 1995). In this study, the corpus consists of corporate non-financial reports—specifically, the sustainability reports—which primarily disclose the impact of corporate activities on the economy, society, and environment. The reports from CNPC, Sinopec, and CNOOC are compiled in accordance with the GRI Standards. Additionally, the reports reflect the environmental policies at the international, national, and corporate levels. Together, they constitute a form of discourse production. Regarding discourse dissemination, Chinese oil and gas companies have been releasing bilingual (Chinese-English) reports on their official websites since 2008. These reports integrate text, visual graphics, and data, with separate sections for detailed disclosures on social, economic, and environmental dimensions. All of the published reports are accessible for free downloading. Discourse consumption primarily involves policymakers, stakeholders, investors, and researchers who refer to, evaluate, or study the reports to understand corporate economic, social, and environmental performance.

9.5.4 Ecological Image and Possible Social Factors in Addressing Climate Change

The linguistic and discursive analysis reveals that Chinese oil and gas companies' reports construct a distinct ecological image through framing their environmental stance, actions, and related topics on climate change. For a long time, these companies have shown a growing focus on climate issues, not only acknowledging the problem but also actively addressing potential climate risks. They initially viewed climate change as a challenge, but in recent years, they have put a stronger emphasis on its opportunities, while still acknowledging its significance. They emphasize climate change mitigation, demonstrating a strong determination to address climate change through a series of well-structured and progressive measures to manage potential risks. Furthermore, they attach great importance to energy transition and environmental protection.

The construction of a corporate ecological image is inseparable from a broader sociocultural context. According to Fairclough (1995: 97), discourse is embedded in social practices at different levels. From this perspective, discourse analysis at the level of social practices requires investigating how immediate situational, institutional, and sociocultural contexts influence the production of discourse. Combining with the SFL view that context determines lexicogrammatical choices, it can be concluded that the ecological image of Chinese oil companies constructed in these reports is influenced by both international and domestic climate change policies, corporate strategies, as well as GRI disclosure standards.

International Policies in Response to Climate change

The construction of environmental issues such as climate change in Chinese oil and gas companies' reports reflects the measures and strategies of the international community in responding to climate change. Since the beginning of the twenty-first century, climate change has emerged as the most pressing global challenge. The United Nations Climate Change Conferences function as a critical barometer for international climate actions. The 2015 United Nations Climate Change Conference marked a new era in global climate governance, adopting the *Paris Agreement* as the first universal agreement on emissions reduction. The agreement commits to limiting global temperature rise to 'well below 2 °C' above pre-industrial levels while pursuing efforts to control it at 1.5 °C. This landmark means a global shift toward low-carbon, green economic development. Subsequently, annual climate summits have continued to negotiate reductions in greenhouse gas emissions, leading to agreements on the transition from fossil fuel-based economies to decarbonized green economies. Influenced by these international governance strategies, Chinese companies' reports have shown a significant increase in focus on climate change since 2016.

The lexicogrammatical features, such as the collocation of 'climate change' or 'global warming' with verbal groups in material and relational clauses serve to construct the ecological image of corporate actions aimed at advancing environmental protection and energy transition, reflecting their strong concern with climate change.

All of this can be viewed as a response to international environmental governance policies.

China's Actions in Addressing Climate Change

The ecological image that Chinese companies construct in response to climate change also reflects the pragmatic measures and actions taken by both the government and companies in climate governance. According to GRID-Arendal statistics, China has been the largest emitter of carbon dioxide since 2006. Compared to developed countries that achieved industrialization earlier, such as the United States and European countries, China's industrialization started later and is still going through a process of increasing energy consumption and carbon emissions. However, China has consistently played an active role in global climate governance. Between 2014 and 2015, China issued joint climate change statements with the United States, the European Union, and other countries, involving the governance framework for its subsequent participation in the *Paris Agreement*. In 2015, China submitted the *Enhanced Actions on Climate Change: China's Nationally Determined Contributions*, becoming the first developing country to autonomously propose a response plan. In the following year, China became one of the first countries to sign the *Paris Agreement*. In 2020, during the United Nations General Assembly, China announced its goal to reach peak carbon emissions by 2030 and achieve carbon neutrality by 2060, thus striving to fulfill its emissions reduction commitments under the *Paris Agreement*. At the Climate Ambition Summit of the same year, China emphasized seeking opportunities in green development and presented specific plans for emission reductions and transition to green energy.

At the same time, China has integrated climate change mitigation strategies into its national policy framework. The 12th, 13th, and 14th Five-Year Plans all emphasize reducing dependence on fossil fuels, expanding clean energy development and utilization, establishing a low-carbon energy system, and increasing national forest coverage. The introduction of *National Climate Change Program* and *12/13th Five-Year greenhouse gas emission control program*, among other policy documents, further underscores this commitment. At the corporate level, Chinese oil and gas companies have actively embraced and implemented green and low-carbon development strategies (Tian 2019). CNPC, Sinopec, and CNOOC have all taken distinct measures to achieve low-carbon development and have accelerated energy transition initiatives in recent years. CNPC, for instance, issued its low-carbon development action plans in 2012 and 2018 and co-founded the Oil and Gas Climate Initiative, which seeks to guide the petroleum industry's response to climate change. CNOOC, following China's commitments under the *Paris Agreement*, established a development framework for emissions reduction and energy transition. Sinopec has remained steadfast in pursuing low-carbon development and advancing clean energy transformation.

All the domestic climate governance policies and corporate climate strategies mentioned above are reflected in Chinese oil and gas companies' sustainability reports. The significantly increasing focus on climate change in the 2016 and 2020 reports clearly mirrors the macro direction of national climate governance.

A close lexicogrammatical examination reveals how the collocation of terms like 'climate change' or 'global warming' with verbal and nominal groups constructs corporate ecological image: from initially perceiving climate change as challenges and crises to recently recognizing them as opportunities, from implementing low-carbon emission reduction measures and energy transition strategies to explicitly defining environmental responsibilities for all stakeholders. These linguistic patterns reflect both national and corporate climate governance policies.

Guidance from the GRI Standards

The guidance of the GRI Standards for environmental disclosure also influence the construction of the ecological image in Chinese companies' reports. The GRI Standards are the most widely used standards for enterprises' compiling sustainability reports. According to the standards, sustainability reports should place particular emphasis on climate change and climate-related risks in their energy and emissions disclosures. In 2021, the GRI released industry-specific standards, including those for the oil and gas sector, which outline detailed requirements in terms of the causes of climate change (such as greenhouse gas emissions), responses, mitigation, responsibilities, and the impacts of climate-related risks. Therefore, by analyzing the verbal processes collocating with 'climate change', 'global warming', and 'climate-related risk(s)' in the reports, the risks brought by climate change are specifically addressed, particularly in light of how extreme weather disrupts the supply chain, and all of these risks are mitigated by companies' effective measures.

9.6 Conclusion

This study draws upon integrated theories of language, society, and context in CDA and SFL, and examines the frequencies of key terms 'climate change', 'global warming', and 'climate-related risk(s)' as well as their verbal and nominal collocations by using corpus methodology. Findings reveal that the ecological image of Chinese oil and gas companies in climate response is characterized by: (1) an increase in climate awareness among petroleum companies, shifting from initially framing climate change as a challenge to recognizing its opportunities for development in recent years, while still acknowledging its risks and emphasizing its significance; (2) a focus on climate mitigation and risk management, with clear allocation of environmental responsibilities cross corporations, governments, and other stakeholders; and (3) active engagement in environmental protection and energy transition. The construction of this ecological image may be attributed to several social-cultural factors, such as international and domestic climate change policies, corporate measures, and GRI disclosure standards. This research not only explores how Chinese corporate reports frame climate change but also expands the dimensions of corporate image studies, offering practical ecological insights. Future studies could compare cross-national differences in oil companies' climate representation or

analyze modal resources to further explore ecological images in Chinese corporate reporting.

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Chapter 10
Sociality, Communicativeness, Functionality: The Consonance Between Systemic Functional Linguistics and Landsenses Ecology

Lan Zhang

Abstract Based on the sociality, communicativeness, and functionality of language and landsenses, this paper examines compatibilities between systemic functional linguistics (SFL) and landsenses ecology. Firstly, the core concepts and research status of the two theories are outlined, and the similarities between Halliday's interpretation of the relationship among language, the world, speech act, and cognition, and the elaboration of vision, landsense creation, and common behavioral norms from the perspective of landsenses ecology are analyzed based on existing literature. Secondly, the potential areas of contact between systemic functional linguistics and landsenses ecology are discussed. And finally, the paper examines the path of linguistic landsense creation in relation to systemic functional linguistics. The final section presents a collaborative view, suggesting that one of the goals of functionally oriented linguistics should be to attempt to enable people to appreciate the humanistic value and social significance of language, further explaining the significance of theoretical integration in the fields of systemic functional linguistics and landsenses ecology for the contemporary development of the practical functional perspective of language.

Keywords Systemic functional linguistics · Landsenses ecology · Landsense creation · Linguistic landsenses · Speech act

10.1 Introduction

Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL) and landsenses ecology, as two separate disciplines with cross-cutting potential, explore the interaction between humans and the environment from the perspectives of linguistics and ecology, respectively. SFL

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emphasizes the social function of language and its role in constructing reality, while landsenses ecology focuses on human perception of the environment and the formation of behavioral norms. Although SFL and landsenses ecology have their own theoretical characteristics, their theoretical mapping in concept, method, and application layer provides an operational framework for their interdisciplinary integration. The purpose of this paper is to analyze the social, communicative, and functional similarities between the two theories and to explore the possibility of their integration and the implications for contemporary linguistics and ecology.

10.2 Sociality in SFL and Landsenses Ecology

10.2.1 Sociality in SFL

SFL was proposed by M.A.K. Halliday, whose core view is that language is not only a tool for transmitting information but also a product and constructor of social realities. Halliday believed that language is a social semiotic system (Halliday 1978, 1994), whose essence lies in the production and reproduction of social meaning through choice. On the one hand, language reflects the social structure, and the use of language by different social groups (e.g., dialects, technical terms) reflects their cultural identity and power status (Zhang et al. 2021a). For example, the frequent use of the term "sustainable development" in environmental protection policies reflects the collective recognition of ecological responsibility in contemporary society. On the other hand, language constructs social reality, and through lexical and grammatical choices, language can shape a group's perception of reality (Zhang et al. 2021b). For example, the media reframes "climate warming" as a "climate crisis" and inspires a sense of public urgency through transitivity system (e.g., intensifier verbs "threaten", "destroy").

The three metafunctions of SFL (ideational, interpersonal, and textual) reflect the social attributes of language from different dimensions. (1) Ideational metafunction refers to the capacity of language to represent our experience, thoughts, and the world around us through transitivity, including material process, mental process, relational process, etc. Its sociality is reflected in the responsibility attribution code. For example, transitivity selection can hide or highlight the agent (e.g., passive sentences—"pollutants are discharged"—hide the agent while active sentences—"factories discharge pollutants"—clarify responsibility). (2) Interpersonal metafunction involves language adjusting social relationships through modality, appraisal, and other resources, and its sociality is reflected in power relationship negotiation. For example, low-carbon harmonious discourse constructs emotional community through appraisal theory (attitude, engagement, and graduation) and mobilizes environmental action through emotional resonance (Zhang et al. 2021c). (3) Textual metafunction concerns the way language is organized and structured to form coherent and meaningful information flow through Theme-Rheme thematic structure and

Given-New information structure. Its social performance is focusing guidance, which determines the starting point of information through theme choice and affects the audience's attention distribution. For example, "the government declares a climate emergency" (Theme: government) vs "the climate emergency is declared" (Theme: climate). In short, language can construct reality through ideational metafunction, regulate relationships through interpersonal metafunction and organize information through textual metafunction (Halliday 1994), which directly maps the interaction between language and social structures.

SFL is a socially accountable linguistics (Huang 2018), which emphasizes the co-evolution of language and society. On the one hand, social context drives language selection, and different registers (e.g., scientific and technological style, advertising style) are restricted by the types of social activities. For example, the passive voice is frequently used in academic papers, reflecting the objectivity norm. On the other hand, language choice reconstructs social norms, and discourse practice can challenge or consolidate the existing power structure. For example, feminist discourse promotes gender equality through degendered vocabulary (e.g., *chairperson* instead of *chairman*). The linguistic semiotic system and social semiotic system proposed by Halliday (1994) have enriched the study of the connotation and extension of symbols and their relations (Zhou and Yu 2022). By deconstructing the two-way constructive relationship between linguistic symbol and social structure, the sociality in SFL provides a core framework for understanding human symbolized existence. In the contemporary society where ecological crisis and cultural conflict coexist, this theory has important implications for the discourse practice of promoting sustainable development.

10.2.2 Sociality in Landsenses Ecology

Landsenses ecology was proposed by Chinese ecologist Zhao et al. (2016). According to Landsenses ecology, "In practice, people usually endow or integrate one or more of their visions into a carrier through appropriate manifestation forms, so that others (including themselves) can graft these visions from this carrier and associated manifestation forms. These visions can guide or regulate people's words and deeds, and further promote the realization of sustainable development" (Zhao et al. 2020:197). The carrier with these kinds of attributes is referred to as a landsense, and the whole process of conception and construction of the landsense is called landsense creation. As an emerging interdisciplinary field, landsenses ecology focuses on the process of human perceiving environment through landsenses and forming group behavior norms. Its sociality is reflected in how landsenses participate in the construction of social relations, the cohesion of group identity and the generation of behavioral norms. Through space design, material allocation, and cultural narration, landsenses convey values, historical memory and code of conduct, and become the materialized expression of social relations. For example, many ancient settlements contain Chinese philosophy and ecological wisdom in the process of site determination, planning and

development (Yan et al. 2020). Landsenses ecology emphasizes human's perception of the environment and the sociality of behavior norms, which is reflected in the attention of landscape architecture to the interaction between collective behavior and environment.

Landsense creation involves not only the individual's cognition of the environment, but also group vision for the environment and the formation of behavioral norms. The core mechanism of its sociality is the symbolic transformation from perception to behavior, and its action path is as follows: landsense design → perception sharing → vision resonance → common code of conduct. For example, the scenario-based design of ecological education, through cooperative design of birdwatching station (high symbol), ecological identity (knowledge symbol), wooden boardwalk (experience symbol), etc., transforms environmental concepts into tangible, participative behavior guidelines (Arslan & Kaymaz 2020; Tarsitano et al. 2020). The theoretical core of landsense sociality is to condense collective memory through vision symbols (e.g., landmark buildings, community totems), and guide group practice through code of conduct symbols (e.g., garbage classification signs). For example, the techniques of viewborrowing in Wangjiatan wetland park in Henan Province, China, encoded ecological principles and cultural memory through spatial symbols (Lu et al. 2020), or the landsense elements of park affect people's senses, and then their activity intention and way (Liu et al. 2020). The sociality of landsenses ecology reveals how human beings realize the leap from individual cognition to group norms through the perception and practice of landsenses. This symbolic social interaction mechanism not only provides a new perspective for understanding environmental behavior but also forms a theoretical resonance with SFL. The social integration path of the two theories is that both the language system and the landsense system use symbols as media and realize the reproduction of social order through hierarchical coding (lexicogrammar layer/spatial symbol layer). At a time of ecological crisis and civilization conflict, the deepening research of this proposition has urgent academic value and practical significance.

10.3 Communicativeness in SFL and Landsenses Ecology

10.3.1 Communicativeness in SFL

SFL regards communicativeness as one of the core attributes of language, emphasizing that language is not only a tool for transmitting information but also a dynamic process for regulating social relations, negotiating meaning, and constructing identity.

Interpersonal Metafunction proposed by Halliday is the theoretical basis of communicativeness, and its core lies in the following ways that language achieves social interaction. The first is role negotiation, in which the language establishes the role relationship between the speaker and the listener through the mood system (e.g.,

declarative, interrogative, and imperative). The second is the expression of attitude, which conveys emotion, judgment and appreciation through the appraisal system to build an emotional community. The third is the regulation of power relations, that is, modality systems (e.g., *must, may*) reflect authority and negotiation space.

SFL regards language as a tool of communication and emphasizes the role of language in information transmission, emotional expression, and the construction of social relations. Through transitivity analysis, voice analysis, and other methods, SFL reveals how language achieves communicative functions and provides a set of operational tools for deconstructing communicative behavior. The first is the tone system, which identifies role relationships (e.g., authoritative vs. egalitarian communication) through the choices of statements, questions, and commands. The second is modal system, which reveals the degree of power negotiation through the use of modal verbs or adverbs (high modality = strong control). The third is the evaluation system, which decodes emotional mobilization strategies (e.g., the crisis graduation intensifies the urgency) through the three-dimensional encoding of attitude—engagement—graduation. The fourth is discourse coherence, which tracks how information flow design serves communicative purposes through thematic advancement patterns. Communicativeness of SFL, by deconstructing the logic of social interaction behind language choice, provides a core framework for understanding how humans negotiate meanings and construct relationships through symbols. At a time when globalization and digitalization are intertwined, this theory not only helps cross-cultural communication and public discourse optimization but also forms interdisciplinary resonance with landsenses ecology, pointing to a core proposition that the essence of communication is to weave social networks through symbolic practice.

10.3.2 Communicativeness in Landsenses Ecology

Communicativeness of landsenses ecology focuses on how landsenses realize the meaning transmission and behavior coordination between people and environment through space design, material allocation, and cultural narration. Its core is that a landsense, as a medium of social interaction, regulates individual perception, group consensus, and social practice through the process of symbol encoding and decoding. Landsenses ecology emphasizes the dual orientation of communicativeness, including human–environment communication and human–human communication. The former involves how landsenses convey environmental information through sensory stimuli (e.g., vision and touch) and guide behavioral responses. For example, the wooden plank road (tactile symbols) in a wetland park suggests not trampling on vegetation. The latter involves landsense design that shapes social scenes and facilitates/inhibits group interaction, such as shared seating areas in community gardens (open symbols) that encourage neighborhood communication, while closed walls (isolated symbols) discourage it.

Communicativeness of landsenses ecology realizes meaning transmission and behavior guidance through a three-level mechanism. The first is symbol coding,

which involves the materialization of environmental significance. For example, a wetland walkway (natural base + artificial path design) harmonizes ecological and human needs (Wu et al. 2016), or a theme park enhances immersive experiences through dense symbolic stacking (e.g., architectural style, music, smell) (Zheng et al. 2020a, b). The second is meaning negotiation, which involves the dynamic adjustment of group perception, such as quantizing the attention-capturing efficiency of environmental symbols (e.g., the optimization of scenic landmarks) (Shao et al. 2020), or analyzing the relationship between the flow of people and the contact frequency of symbols using space syntax (Xiong et al. 2020). The third is behavior output, which involves the transformation from cognition to practice, such as reshaping ecological behavior patterns through environmental education camps (Tarsitano et al. 2021), or reserving "empathetic experience zones" for integrated landsense healing behaviors (e.g., dynamic landscape installation of floating lawn) (Yang & Hong 2021). This three-level mechanism reveals that the environment is not only a passive carrier of meaning but also continuously participates in the reproduction of social relations through a dynamic coding-negotiation-practice cycle. Future ecological design needs to maintain tension between symbolic controllability and cognitive openness, making the environment truly a "talking actor".

Landsenses ecology realizes the communication between human and environment through the transmission of environmental perception and behavioral norms. For example, the vision transmission in the landsense creation can realize the consensus and behavioral coordination among groups through symbolic means (e.g., landsense design, public art). Communicativeness of landsenses ecology reveals how human beings realize the leap from environmental perception to social behavior through the encoding, decoding, and re-encoding of landsenses. This kind of symbolic interaction with space as the medium expands the material dimension of traditional communication theory, which provides an innovative path for building inclusive public space to promote sustainable development.

10.4 Functionality in SFL and Landsenses Ecology

10.4.1 Functionality in SFL

Functionality in SFL is rooted in the nature of language as a social semiotic system, and its three metafunctions correspond to the three basic needs of human experience. Among them, ideational metafunction represents human experience of the world (including physical and psychological activities) through language. For example, material processes describe physical behavior; mental processes express perception and emotion; and relational processes define attributes and belonging. Interpersonal metafunction negotiates social relations through language to regulate emotion and power. For example, modality system (e.g., *may*/ *must*) expresses possibility or obligation, etc., reflecting authority and negotiation space (e.g., low modality

"may"—open negotiation, medium modality "should"—suggestion guidance, high modality "must"—mandatory constraints). Textual metafunction organizes the flow of information through language to ensure textual coherence and context adaptation, such as Given-New, which is based on given information and focuses on new information. The synergistic effect of the three metafunctions constitutes the social meaning generation mechanism of language. The functionality of SFL can be realized through dynamic language selection. For example, ecological coding of ideational metafunction can realize explicit or implicit attribution of responsibility (e.g., active voice highlights the agent, while passive voice obscures the subject of responsibility). Or the abstract problem can be concretized through conceptual metaphor, such as carbon footprint metaphor, which binds carbon emission behavior to individual responsibility.

SFL emphasizes that language is not only a tool for transmitting information but also a semiotic system for constructing reality, regulating relations, and organizing social activities. Functionality in SFL reveals the essence of language as the core medium of social practice by deconstructing the role of language in empirical representation, relationship regulation and information organization. This theory provides a methodological foundation for optimizing environmental communication and designing sustainable discourse practices, and forms interdisciplinary synergy with landsenses ecology to jointly promote the collaborative governance of symbol, society, and ecosystem.

10.4.2 Functionality in Landsenses Ecology

Functionality in landsenses ecology focuses on how landsenses achieve the comprehensive goal of ecological balance, cultural inheritance, and social behavior guidance through design, perception, and practice. Its functionality is embodied in the guiding role of landsenses to environmental perception and behavioral norms. Through the landsense creation, human beings can form a common cognition of the environment, and formulate corresponding norms of behavior, so as to realize the harmonious interaction between human and the environment. Its core is to regard a landsense as a functional symbol system, coordinating the interaction between human activities and the natural environment through spatial narration, material coding, and cultural metaphor.

Functionality in landsenses ecology emphasizes the core role of landsenses in terms of ecological function, cultural function, and social function. Among them, ecological function refers to the regulation of microclimate to maintain biodiversity through material allocation (e.g., vegetation, water system). For example, wetland park reeds (water purification) and artificial floating islands (bird habitat) cooperate to achieve ecological restoration (Nakagawa & Nakagawa 2020). Or vertical green walls improve air quality and rain gardens ease waterlogging (Ma and Shi 2020). Cultural function involves passing on collective memory and values through landsense design. For example, the landsense design in classical Chinese gardens has evolved from

ecological practical functions to harmonious cultural symbols (Zhang et al. 2017). Social function involves guiding norms of group behavior through spatial grammar. For example, the circular seating layout of the city square promotes equal social interaction, while the stepped audience seats strengthen the power relationship between viewing and performance. Or the addition of multi-functional green landscape and shared workshops promotes community interaction (Mao et al. 2021). Functionality in landsenses ecology presents multi-level characteristics, covering three dimensions: materiality, cognition, and practicality. Among them, material dimension involves the physical anchoring of environmental symbols. For example, Xiamen realizes the material inheritance of cultural heritage through the multi-dimensional integration of land and sea network (base layer), street structure (structural layer), etc. (Zheng et al. 2020a, b). Cognitive dimension involves the psychological construction of ecological meaning, which requires multi-sensory (touch, hearing, smell, etc.) coordination to enhance immersion experience. For example, the rustling sound of a bamboo path (auditory symbol) and the fragrance of vegetation (olfactory symbol) form a natural healing scene (Zheng et al. 2020). Practical dimension involves the spatial discipline of social behavior. For example, tourists trampling on the lawn (behavior) → laying plank road (response) → reconstructing path cognition (correction) → forming new guidelines (iteration). This three-dimensional functional framework shows that landsenses ecology has gone beyond mere environmental design and developed into an integrated discipline connecting ecological reality, human cognition, and social action. Functionality in landsenses ecology reveals the deep interaction logic between human and environment by deconstructing the multi-dimensional role of landsenses in ecological maintenance, cultural inheritance and social guidance (Zhang et al. 2022). In the current ecological crisis, its theoretical value is not only to explain the mechanism of environmental meaning generation, but also to provide a viable framework for the construction of understandable ecological environment, that is, making the material space a cognitive medium and practical field of ecological civilization.

10.5 Compatibility Between SFL and Landsenses Ecology

The theoretical mapping between SFL and landsenses ecology in concept, method, and application provides a viable framework for their interdisciplinary integration.

10.5.1 Conceptual Layer: Carrier and Meaning Generation View

Both SFL and landsenses ecology emphasize the role of the carrier (language or environment) in meaning generation, in which language generates meaning through lexicogrammatical selection, while environment transmits vision and behavioral norms

through symbolic means. Language, as a "soft carrier", has strong plasticity of symbols, while environment, as a "hard carrier", anchors meaning through materiality. But there are many possibilities for integration, such as material language research, examining how the geographical distribution of dialects is affected by topography, or symbolic environment design, analyzing the intertextuality between language signs and environmental signs in urban guidance systems. These integration paths can provide a new paradigm for ecological discourse analysis, incorporating environmental symbols into multi-modal discourse analysis, such as interpreting the cooperative expressive mechanism of interpretation boards (language), bird watching platforms (architecture), and ecological corridors (space) in wetland parks. They can also promote the innovation of spatial cognitive education, and construct a three-dimensional ecological cognitive system by complementing the abstract coding of language symbols (such as ecological textbooks) with the embodied experience of environmental symbols (such as nature education base). This interdisciplinary dialogue suggests that meaning generation is essentially a cognitive ecological process in which organisms interact with multiple realities through different symbolic carriers. Under this framework, language and environment are no longer separated carriers of meaning, but together constitute the complex social-economic-natural ecosystem.

10.5.2 Method Layer: Hierarchical Psychological Framework of Carrier and Meaning Generation

Although SFL and landsenses ecology have formed their own theoretical paths due to the differences of research objects, they show profound cognitive commonalities and cognitive interfaces in the hierarchical psychological framework of meaning generation.

Firstly, in terms of hierarchical structure, SFL analyzes the meaning generation of language through cultural context, register, and other levels, while landsenses ecology explores the meaning generation of environment through individual perception, group consensus and social norms, but both pay attention to the historical precipitation of symbol system. For example, SFL focuses on the negotiation of meaning (interpersonal functional realization) of language signs (lexicogrammatical system) within register constraints (field, tenor, or mode). Similarly, landsenses ecology focuses on the behavioral guidance (environmental narrative construction) of environmental signs (spatial-material signs) within place grammar (spatial accessibility/visual salience). The fusion interface of the two in the symbolic interaction layer (carrier dimension) can be the co-coding of cross-modal symbols to promote the formation of cognitive-behavior closed loop. Secondly, in terms of the direction of meaning generation, SFL realizes meaning control (e.g., high-frequency modal verbs in legal texts) through hierarchical instantiation of semantic systems (e.g., cultural context, situational context, contextual discourse) and probabilistic selection, while

landsenses ecology relies on hierarchical emergence (e.g., perceptual fragmentation, pattern recognition, symbolic systems) to achieve the dynamic coupling of body schema and environment (e.g., the zigzag of the forest path leads to the exploration narrative), but the perceptual pattern accumulated in the individual's environmental experience (e.g., the forest shelter image) will penetrate the metaphorical structure of the language system in reverse (e.g., the expression of knowledge forest), forming a cross-level cognitive transfer. Moreover, in terms of cognitive constraint mechanisms, linguistic systems reconstruct experience through grammatical metaphors (e.g., "*globalization impact*" materializes processes), while environmental systems regulate behavior through space syntax (such as circular layout to strengthen central authority), but language can form intertextuality through discourse genres (such as guidebooks) and spatial narratives of the environment (such as exhibition routes), and jointly construct a three-dimensional network of knowledge transfer in the scene (such as museums).

The situational use of language (such as speech accompanied by gestures) and the spatial cognition of the environment (such as body turning in wayfinding) together confirm that cognitive activities are essentially embodied symbolic operations. For example, in urban square design, social norms (such as the tradition of democratic assembly) correspond to cultural context; group consensus (such as the function of the square as a public forum) maps contextual parameters; and individual perception (such as the sense of solemnness induced by the scale of steps) is realized as a specific spatial register.

This cross-carrier mapping reveals the deep cognitive homology of symbolic system operation. The domain analysis of SFL (such as identifying the communicative purpose of user discourse) and the spatial semantic decoding of landsenses ecology (such as understanding the design norms of park layout) can be used to design language-environment dual intervention strategies through the corresponding analysis of hierarchical structure. For example, the narrative of nature unity is reconstructed at the cultural context level; participatory environmental governance discourse is cultivated at the group consensus level; and ecological warning space symbols are designed at the individual perception level. The comparative study of this hierarchical architecture can not only reveal the modular characteristics of human cognitive systems, but more importantly, the ecological mechanism of meaning generation can be reconstructed through the symbolic coupling of language and environment.

10.5.3 Application Layer: Exploring the Interaction of Carrier, Cognition, and Behavior Based on Interactivity

Both SFL and landsenses ecology emphasize interactivity. Language realizes social interaction through communication, while landsense creation realizes interaction

between human and environment through environmental perception and behavioral norms. This interaction provides the basis for the fusion of the two theories.

Based on the common concern of SFL and landsenses ecology on interaction, a triadic interaction model can be constructed. First, a theoretical mapping framework of interactivity is constructed to analyze the cooperative mechanism of carriers, cognition, and behavior from three dimensions (i.e., symbolic interaction, cognitive interaction, and behavioral interaction). A linguistic landsense is a theoretical branch of landsenses ecology in the study of the relationship between language and environment, and it is also a concrete representation of the theoretical mapping of interaction between SFL and landsenses ecology. "A linguistic landsense refers to a meaning carrier that contains one or more of speakers'/designers' visions through appropriate forms of manifestation, through which listeners/ readers can grasp and resonate with the visions, thus forming a common code of conduct" (Zhang et al. 2021c: 11). For example, in the park scene, the symbolic adjustment system of ecological behavior inspires ecological identity through linguistic landsenses (such as signs or slogans conveying ecological norms, i.e., symbolic interaction) combined with natural landsense image (such as listening to natural sounds or convenient path design, i.e., cognitive interaction), and guides sustainable behavior (such as protecting vegetation or garbage classification, i.e., behavioral interaction) to achieve a dynamic balance between human and nature. Linguistic landsenses and spatial layout are regarded as different modes of the same symbolic system, seeking a balance between poetic expression and scientific norms, and finally constructing a sustainable interaction between people, symbols, and nature. Secondly, a double-loop coupled interaction model is constructed. The outer loop (i.e., explicit interaction) is from symbol carrier to perception / understanding to behavioral feedback and finally to symbol reconstruction. For example, traffic lights (environmental symbols) and traffic police instructions (language symbols) jointly regulate driving behavior, and the violation data reversely optimizes the signal system. The inner loop (i.e., implicit interaction) involves cognitive schema, meaning expectation, attention focus and experience integration. For example, tourists are more likely to pay attention to the bluestone pavements (environmental symbols) and dialect signs (language symbols) based on the cognitive schema of ancient towns, forming a cognitive-enhancing experience loop. The critical point effect of double-loop coupling is manifested in that when there is a significant deviation between language description and environmental experience (such as the coexistence of ecological community propaganda and dirty environment), cognitive dissonance will be triggered, forcing the system to rebuild the interactive balance through symbol correction (e.g., updating slogans) or environmental transformation (e.g., cleaning sanitation). Third, interactive practical application strategies can be constructed to promote intelligent space design by using symbol cooperative coding and cognitive load balance. For example, the efficiency of spatial navigation is optimized by combining the abstract generalization of language symbols (such as "exit" signs) with the embodied guidance of environmental symbols (such as ground arrows). In addition, interactive design and cross-media narration can be used to realize ecological education innovation. For

example, ecological terms (language symbols) are transformed into operational environmental devices (e.g., "carbon footprint" concretized as treadle power generation floor) to realize cognitive-behavioral linkage, or in nature reserves, interpretation boards (language), observation decks (space), biological soundscapes (environment) constitute a multi-modal meaning network to guide the hierarchical construction of ecological cognition.

This theoretical integration with interaction as the link breaks the traditional dichotomy between language and environment, which not only provides an integrated framework for understanding human symbolic practice but more importantly, provides a critical reflection path for safeguarding the ecology of human cognition in the current era of deepening technological intervention, that is, real intelligent interaction should promote the symbiosis between language and environment.

10.6 Conclusion

As a people-oriented emerging research field, landsenses ecology has great vitality due to its interdisciplinary openness and compatibility (Zhang 2024). Under the guidance of the principles of landsense creation, landsenses ecology has great possibility and feasibility for extensive integration with other disciplines. As a comprehensive theory, SFL not only studies fundamental issues such as the nature of language, language process, and common characteristics of language but also discusses the application of linguistics, including discussion of basic social problems, as well as the exploration of the formation and evolution of social institutions and other collectives. The social, communicative and functional commonalities of the two theories provide the theoretical basis for their integration. The innovation of this research is reflected in the complementary integration of the two disciplines. On the one hand, the social semiotic tools of SFL (such as register theory or appraisal system) are introduced into the research of landsenses ecology to provide a micro-operational framework for the meaning analysis in the landsense creation. On the other hand, the perception-behavior model of landsenses ecology can be used for reference to promote SFL from text analysis to multi-modal ecological discourse research. By integrating the theoretical tools of linguistics and ecology, the collaborative mechanism of language and landsense symbols in environmental cognition and behavioral norms is revealed. Therefore, it is feasible and significant to integrate the theories of SFL and landsenses ecology, which can further promote the contemporary development of functional language view and provide a new perspective and method for the cross-study of linguistics and ecology.

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Part III
SFL: Applications

Chapter 11
The Court Interpreter's Impossible Task: From a Linguist's Perspective



Jonathan Webster

Abstract The original guilty verdict in HKSAR v. Moala Alipate (2019) was quashed on appeal before the High Court Justices in Hong Kong's Court of Appeal. The success of the appeal was largely due to doubts over the interpreter's inability to fully and accurately interpret the evidence to the Tongan defendant. In line with past precedents (Rex v Kwok Leung (1909), Rex v. Lee Kun (1961), Radhakrishnan Kunnath v The State (1993)), failure to provide adequate translation of the court proceedings provided sufficient grounds to invalidate the guilty verdict against Moala Alipate. While the linguistic and professional background of the particular interpreter in HKSAR v. Moala Alipate rendered him incapable of successfully carrying out the task at hand, nevertheless the excessive linguistic demands placed on the interpreter in this situation highlight significant issues which are bound to arise from an apparent disconnect between how language is actually used and the expectations for what language is to accomplish. The summary of evidence read by the judge in HKSAR v. Moala Alipate, given that he was reading from a written text, not unexpectedly carried a high information load (i.e. high lexical density), compounded not only by a substantial amount of technical jargon, but also complex grammatical constructions demanding considerable mental alertness and language proficiency in order to be processed and comprehended. Although informed by defendant's counsel on second day of the judge's summation of evidence that the interpreter was having difficulty keeping up with the judge's pace of delivery, the judge's delivery speed, instead of decreasing, became even faster. At one point, the court interpreter was being expected to perform at a rate 40 times faster than normal translating work. Moreover, the judge's summation was characterized by the same linguistic features as identified by Charrow and Charrow (1979) as causing comprehension problems, including

This paper honors the contribution of Professor Huang Guowen in both the fields of Interpretation & Translation, and Linguistics. I also would like to express gratitude to the late Dr Gerard McCoy SC, barrister and constitutional law expert, who provided helpful source material to me in preparation for writing this paper.

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the use of passive constructions in subordinate clauses; the combination of many clauses within one sentence; and "Whiz" deletion, i.e. omitting the relative pronoun. When summarizing the evidence given by the defense's expert witness concerning contamination of the evidence, the pace of delivery accelerated to 200 wpm, with several instances of lexical density exceeding 10 content/lexical (as opposed to grammatical) words per clause, or significantly higher than the usual lexical density for written language. Under such circumstances, even the performance of the best trained interpreter is likely to be diminished to the point where the defendant is no longer fully comprehending the proceedings. If a defendant needs an interpreter in order to understand the court proceedings, then it is imperative that not only a capable interpreter be provided, but also that the expectations for what the interpreter can feasibly provide should be given due consideration.

Keywords Court interpreter · Linguistic demands · Inadequate translation · Delivery speed · Lexical density

11.1 Introduction

At his trial on the indictment of unlawfully trafficking the drug Ice, the defendant, MA, was accused by the prosecution of knowingly concealing the drug Ice in a game console in his luggage for transporting from Hong Kong to Auckland. Pleading not guilty, MA denied knowledge of the dangerous drugs concealed the game console, claiming he had been tricked into carrying the drugs. However, MA was convicted by a jury on 26 April 2017, presided over by Deputy High Court Judge X, and sentenced to 23 years and 9 months imprisonment. A Notice of Application for Leave to Appeal against his conviction was filed on 10 May 2017. The hearing of the application for the appeal not only allowed the application, but also the appeal, quashed the conviction, set aside the sentence and ordered a retrial.

Seven grounds of appeal were filed by the applicant's counsel, Mr Gerard McCoy SC[1]:

(1) the judge erred in not providing copies to the trial counsel of the five notes he had received from jurors (Ground 1);
(2) the judge failed to maintain an adequate speed in his summing-up, as a consequence of which the interpreter was unable to fully interpret the summing-up to the applicant (Ground 2);
(3) the lack of experience of the court appointed interpreter to assist the applicant, resulted in the interpreter, *inter alia*:

    i. being unable to keep up with translation;

[1] Criminal Appeal No. 135 of 2017 heard in the High Court of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region Court of Appeal (on Appeal from HCCC No. 86/2016). Heard before Hon McWalters JA, Poon JA, and Zervos JA. 26 February 2019.

ii. mistranslating parts of the evidence;
iii. failing to translate or correctly translate the evidence;
iv. omitting evidence;

which led to an overall standard, accuracy and quality of interpretation that resulted in unfairness of an extent that the applicant was deprived of a fair trial (Ground 3);

(4) the judge failed to adequately sum up the evidence of the defense witness Mr. Rowton (Ground 4);
(5) the judge failed to provide a lies direction to the jury (Ground 5);
(6) the judge failed to properly direct the jury of the use of expert evidence (Ground 6); and
(7) the judge erred in rejecting the defense's request to adduce evidence from the Commissioner of the Customs and Excise Department and failed to provide reasons for so ruling (Ground 7).

The appeal was allowed in respect of Grounds 2 and 3, both of which called into question whether the judge's summing-up of the evidence had been adequately translated, arguing that failure to do so denied the defendant a fair trial. Although Ground 2 argued that the judge's summing-up exceeded the ability of the trial interpreter to adequately carry out his task, Ground 3 placed blame on the interpreter's lack of experience. In summing up the issue before them, the appeal court justices concluded that "the difficulties lay not with the language, but with the linguist."[2] In other words, the fault lay with the interpreter, Mr A, aka "the linguist," not with the judge's speed of delivery, "the language." In their judgment the high court justices hearing the appeal noted:

> [72] Before concluding this judgment we should emphasize that even though we allow this appeal on Grounds 2 and 3, we do not accept the assertion that the judge spoke at too rapid a pace. It was, of course, too rapid for Mr A but that was only because Mr A was not a professional interpreter and lacked the skills needed to provide a simultaneous interpretation. Although the judge was aware that Mr A was experiencing difficulties or the reason for it; namely the very significant limitations on Mr A's skills as a simultaneous interpreter.

While the linguistic and professional background of Mr A rendered him incapable of successfully carrying out the task at hand, nevertheless the excessive linguistic demands placed on the interpreter in this situation highlight significant issues which are bound to arise from an apparent disconnect between how language is used and the expectations for what language is to accomplish.

[2] Ibid., [68], p. 30. The number in square brackets corresponds to the numbering of paragraphs in the original text.

11.2 Some Background to the Case

In preparation for the appeal against MA's conviction, I was requested by the Legal Aid Department of the HKSAR Government to provide linguistic advice to the defendant's legal team. While the defendant's legal team asked me to specifically address the matter of the judge's speed of delivery, it became apparent from my analysis of the judge's speed of delivery in summing up the evidence that speed is only one factor among several—including grammatical complexity, lexical density, ambiguous reference—which can lead to comprehension difficulty, not only for the interpreter, but also for the members of the jury.[3]

Reporting on the outcome of the appeal for the New Zealand Herald, Jared Savage provides some helpful background[4]:

> Alipate Moala,[5] 51, was in Hong Kong International Airport to catch a flight to Auckland in September 2015 when 1kg of methamphetamine was found hidden inside his luggage.
>
> The former champion boxer and gospel singer says he thought he was carrying a chemical cleaning agent for which, on safe delivery to New Zealand, his church would receive a cash donation.
>
> Tonga-born Moala had been recruited by email and the "cleaning agent" deception is a scam commonly used by West African crime syndicates to target vulnerable individuals.
>
> Ten others arrested in Hong Kong in similar circumstances around the same time were acquitted at trial.
>
> But Moala was convicted of drug trafficking and sentenced to 23 years and 9 months in prison.
>
> …
>
> His legal team argued the translation at the original trial was "fundamentally flawed."
>
> A rugby player without any previous experience in translation was the only person who could be found in Hong Kong to interpret at the trial.
>
> The delay in finding a translator meant the trial, estimated to last 5 days, stretched to 13.
>
> An impatient jury said the majority would not sit after a particular day. So the judge sat for longer hours and in delivering his summary of the case, spoke at up to 197 words per minute.
>
> For Moala's hearing in the Hong Kong Court of Appeal, a professor in linguistics submitted a report on the complexity of the judge's summing-up.
>
> …
>
> The Hong Kong Court of Appeal quashed the conviction and sentence of Moala. He was remanded in custody ahead of the retrial, although a bail application will be made.
>
> The grooming of naive individuals as unwitting drug mules is a hallmark of West African crime syndicates and others have been caught in New Zealand.

[3] Some may question giving assistance to the legal team representing a suspected drug trafficker. However, as my services come at the request of the Legal Aid Department of the HKSAR Government, I see it as my civic duty. Moreover, as is noted in the postscript of this paper, at the defendant's re-trial, he was found innocent of the charges.

[4] Jared Savage, 'Duped Auckland drug mule Alipate Moala gets new Hong Kong trial after Tongan translation flaws', New Zealand Herald, 10 March 2019.

[5] I have not used the full names of those participating in the court proceedings. Moala Alipate is referred to throughout this paper as "MA."

11.3 Defendant's Right to Interpreter Assistance

A primary concern of the Court is that the defendant not be linguistically disadvantaged "by his inability to understand and speak the language of the court."[6] At the appeal hearing, arguing for the prosecution, Mr. Y challenged why it was not until the defendant began to testify that concerns were raised about the defendant's linguistic ability to follow the proceedings, in particular, his ability to understand his own counsel's questions. However, the trial judge himself had agreed on the need for the defendant to receive interpreter assistance, noting.

> COURT: …. I am in agreement about the observations concerning his English since I do try to take verbatim noted and at times it was difficult, not because of the speed but because of the use of language. I do not think it is something made up by – by the defence team.
>
> …
>
> COURT: So it's a real difficulty and it's a real risk that if the defendant is not properly expressing himself then he may not be having a fair trial or he may not eventually be regarded as having a fair trial.[7]

Case law supports the judge's decision to provide interpreter assistance where the need becomes evident.[8] Agreeing with the trial judge that the threshold of need

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[6] Criminal Appeal No. 135 of 2017 heard in the High Court of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region Court of Appeal (on Appeal from HCCC No. 86/2016). Heard before Hon McWalters JA, Poon JA, and Zervos JA. 26 February 2019. [50], p. 21.

[7] Ibid. [40], p. 17–18.

[8] In their Memorandum of Counsel, Gerard McCoy SC, Nisha Mohamed, Counsel for the Applicant, cited the following examples in support of defense's request for interpreter assistance:

(a) Rex v Kwok Leung [1909] 4 H.K.L.R. 161, 163, 171, per Piggott C.J.: A prisoner is always entitled to make a statement, whether is he represented by Counsel or not. Translation of evidence to a prisoner who does not understand it is contrary to those fundamental and elemental principles of justice. The fact of Counsel being retained by, or assigned to, the prisoner, makes no difference to the application of the principle of law.

(b) Rex v Lee Kun [1961] 1 K.B. 337, 343 per Lord Reading C.J.:

A safer and wiser course, when a foreign accused is defended by counsel, is that the evidence should be interpreted to him except when he or counsel on his behalf expresses a wish to dispense with the translation and the judge thinks fit to permit the omission. The judge should not permit it unless he is of the opinion that because of what has passed before the trial the accused substantially understands the evidence to be given and the case to be made against him at trial. To follow this practice may be inconvenient in some cases and may cause some further expenditure of time; but such a procedure is more in consonance with that scrupulous care of the interests of the accused which has distinguished the administration of justice in our criminal Courts, and therefore it is better to adopt it.

(c) Radhakrishnan Kunnath v The State [1993] 1 WLR 1315, 1320D, where Lord Jauncey (speaking on behalf of the Privy Council) stated:

Their Lordships have no doubt that the course advocated by Lord Reading C.J. in Rex v Lee Kun [1916] 1 K.B. 337, 343, is a highly desirable one and should be followed whenever a foreign defendant, not fully conversant with the language of the proceedings, is represented by counsel. If it is not followed, the risk will be greater of a substantial miscarriage of justice occurring.

had been satisfied, the appeal court justices cited McGrath J from the New Zealand Supreme Court decision in *Abdula v Queen*[9]:

> 45 ….The threshold of need is not an onerous one. As a general rule, an interpreter should be appointed where an accused requests the services of an interpreter and the judge considers the request justified, or where it becomes apparent to the judge that an accused is having difficulty with the English language. Once an accused has asked for assistance, it ought not to be refused unless the request is not made in good faith or the assistance is otherwise unnecessary.[10]

The appeal judgment also notes that, as recognized in common law, the defendant's right to interpretation assistance is guaranteed in the Hong Kong Bill of Rights, specifically Article 11(2)(a) and (f)[11]:

> (2) In the determination of any criminal charge against him, everyone shall be entitled to the following minimum guarantees, in full equality:-
>
> (a) to be informed promptly and in detail in a language which he understands of the nature and cause of the charge against him;
>
> …
>
> (f) to have the free assistance of an interpreter if he cannot understand or speak the language in court;…

As noted by the appeal court judges in their *Reasons for Judgment,* "the provisions of Article 11(2)(a) and (f) are comparable to Article 14(3)(a) and (f) of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights which applies to Hong Kong by Article 39 of the Basic Law."[12] The defendant's right to interpreter assistance, based

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(d) Cuscani v The United Kingdom (2003) 36 EHRR 2, 17, 19 where the court reaffirmed the decisions of Rex v Lee Kun and Kunnath v The State, at para §[31]-[33], and held there was a violation of Article 6(1) of the Convention. The court stated at para §[39]:

> It is true that the conduct of the defence is essentially a matter between the defendant and his counsel, whether counsel be appointed under a legal aid scheme or privately finance. However, the ultimate guardian of the fairness of the trial proceeding was the trial judge. Domestic courts have taken the view that judges are required to treat an accused's interest with "scrupulous care".

(e) In re Applied Language Solutions Ltd [2013] 1 WLR 3820, 3824:

> It is clear that the provision of an interpreter for a witness or defendant in a criminal case is an obligation of the state which is regarded as an integral part of its obligations to provide a fair and just system of criminal justice. These common law principles have also been adopted under statute in article 6 of the European Convention for the Protection of Human Rights and Fundamental Freedoms.

[9] *Chala Sani Abdula v The Queen* SC 18/2010 [2011] NZSC 130.

[10] In the reasons for their judgment, the appeal judges also cited Lamer CJ from *R v Tran* [1994] 2 S.C.R., p. 984:
"…once claimed, the s14 *Charter* right to interpreter assistance should not be denied unless there is 'cogent and compelling evidence' that an accused's request for an interpreter is not made in good faith, but rather for an oblique motive." Ibid., note 6, p. 18.

[11] Ibid., [43] p. 18–19.

[12] Ibid., [46] p. 20.

on Article 11(2)(f), "extends to and encompasses all elements of the trial which affect the defendant's interests,"[13] assuring not only the defendant's comprehension, but also, more importantly, his meaningful participation in the trial, including "his ability to make decisions on trial issues and give instructions to his legal representative on such issues."[14]

11.4 Faulty Interpreter Assistance

According to Ground 3 of the appeal, the interpreter, Mr A, "did not possess the relevant skills and the necessary ability to perform the duties of an interpreter in a trial at the High Court before a jury, and his limited ability had compromised the fairness of the applicant's trial."[15] Of course, this prompts the question of how Mr. A came to be appointed as the interpreter. The defendant in the case, MA, is from the South Pacific group of islands, near Fiji and Samoa, called Tonga. When it became apparent during the trial that interpreter assistance would be required, the unavailability of a professionally trained Tongan interpreter prompted the Court to accept the services of the only available Tongan speaker, a rugby player and coach, who just happened to be in Hong Kong to play in the Hong Kong Sevens.[16] As apparent from his testimony during the appeal,[17] though aware of his own limitations as an interpreter, nevertheless, for the sake of a fellow Tongan whose incarceration would be prolonged pending the availability of interpreter assistance, Mr. A, agreed "to 'soldier on' and do his best to assist a fellow Tongan."[18]

Q	And would it be right to say that if you felt that you were not up to the job of being an interpreter, you would have said so?
A	Yes, and the fact that they said that there wasn't anybody else within the country and it was critical for somebody to be able to help to get the court proceedings under way because there had been—from what I was told, there had been a fair bit of time that he was already incarcerated
Q	But if you felt that, 'Actually, I'm not good enough to do this,' you would have said so?
A	At the start before I started, yes, I thought I was up for the job, but then obviously at the end of it there is a lot more to it than I—than I know

Counsel for the defense noted that "failure of the interpreter to use the appropriate words or to interpret to an extent that fully reflected the answers given by the applicant, could have conveyed the impression to the jury that the applicant was unresponsive,

[13] Ibid., [53] p. 23–24.
[14] Ibid., [51] p. 22.
[15] Ibid., [19], p. 7
[16] Ibid., [30], p. 10.
[17] Ibid., [34], p. 14.
[18] Ibid., [71], p. 30.

incoherent, inconsistent or even being evasive and this could have resulted in the jury making adverse findings against the applicant and ultimately influenced the outcome of the trial."[19]

Mr Y, for the prosecution, referenced the New Zealand Supreme Court's view in *Abdula,* and the Canadian Supreme Court's judgment in *R v Tran,* to make the point that no interpretation could be perfect. Thus, he argued that "any errors, mistranslations and omissions were of a minor nature and did not prevent the applicant from giving his answers or prevent the jury from understanding the applicant's answers."[20]

While what constitutes an acceptable standard of interpretation cannot be perfection, nevertheless "the court cannot allow the standard of interpretation to fall below a level where the right is so deprived of substance that it becomes illusory."[21] As for what does constitute an acceptable standard, in the reasons for judgment, the Court cited Lamer CJ in *Tran* (p. 990):

> … the question should always be whether there is a possibility that the accused may not have understood part of the proceedings by virtue of his or her difficulty with the language being used in court.

Citing McGrath J in *Abdula,* McWalter JA, Poon JA, and Zervos JA noted that,

> 43. … Trial judges should at all times be alert to the quality of interpretation; certain omissions and irregularities may thereby be sufficiently avoided or mitigated. Where compliance is challenged, the cumulative effect of deficiencies in the interpretation must be evaluated, in the overall context of the trial, to determine whether its standard was, nevertheless, such that there was compliance with the accused's rights. That is a matter for judicial assessment in every case.[22]

Giving evidence, Mr A was asked to estimate how much of the judge's summing-up he was able to exactly interpret, the interpreter admitted only 20 to 30 percent. He further acknowledged that his Tongan was not at the level of a native Tongan speaker in Tonga. Though born in Tonga, he was raised in Brisbane, Australia. Asked about his level of vocab in Tongan, Mr. A replied that while he can speak and write the Tongan language, "there are parts of the older Tongan language that I don't understand or I can't speak. That's sometimes probably directly linked to some of the words in law and stuff like that, but I'm not sure."[23] Asked to translate "DNA" into Tongan, he replied that he could not. Nor did he know the word in Tongan for "suspicion."[24] Noting that dockside interpretation is simultaneous, not consecutive, the Court realized that the defendant would have been listening to the interpreter not the person speaking, so that whatever was not communicated by the interpreter would have been lost on the defendant.[25]

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[19] Ibid. [19], p. 7.
[20] Ibid. [26], p. 9.
[21] Ibid. [58], p. 26.
[22] Ibid. [60], p. 27.
[23] Ibid. [32], p. 12.
[24] Ibid. [32], p. 12.
[25] Ibid. [63], p. 28.

After hearing the interpreter's testimony, which the justices hearing the appeal described as "credible and compelling,"[26] the justices decided that they did not need to hear further evidence in support of the two grounds for appeal, and instead were ready to conclude as follows[27]:

> [64] When an interpreter says that he was only able to interpret 20-30% of what had been spoken and was unfamiliar with key words and phrases which were frequently being used in the course of the proceedings, then we were compelled to conclude that the applicant had not been provided with constitutionally compliant standard of interpretation, i.e. one that met the purposes of the Article 11(2)(f) rights.

11.5 Delivery Speed of Summing-Up

Mr Y argued that "Anyone listening to the recording would conclude that the judge did not speak too quickly."[28] Rather he maintained that the trial judge "spoke articulately and clearly, and what he said was easy to comprehend."[29]

A linguistic analysis was conducted of the audio recording of the summing-up delivered by Deputy High Court Judge X over two days on 25 April (70 min 24 secs) and 26 April 2017 (115 min and 24 secs). The tables below show the speaking rate by section and by day for Judge X's summing-up. As can be observed from Table 11.1, the speaking rate for the opening remarks is the slowest section of the two-day summing-up at 137.86 wpm. The speed accelerates to 146.33 wpm as Judge X explains the elements of the offense. Once Judge X begins his summary of the evidence, the speed increases to 161.24 wpm during the first 16 min. During the additional 15 min requested by Judge X "so that I make sure you will all have enough time eventually to deliberate," the delivery rate increased to 176.05 wpm.

The audio from the second day begins with the defendant's counsel informing Judge X that the court interpreter reported having difficulty keeping up with the judge's speed of delivery. Judge X's speed of delivery of the summary of evidence on Day 2, however, continued to accelerate steadily as shown in Table 11.2, from 162.05 wpm in the first half hour (from 10:08 to 10:39 am), to 174.85 (between 10:39 and 11:09 am), then to 185.27 (between 11:09 and 11:39). In fact, just before the break at 11:40 am, the judge's delivery speed had reached 197.71 wpm. The concluding twenty minutes returned to approximately the same speed as Judge X began his summing-up earlier that same morning, 162.81 wpm, still faster, however, than the judge's average delivery speed on the first day. Table 11.3 shows Judge X's speaking rate during the summing-up in words per hour by day (Fig. 11.1).

While the normal delivery rate of extemporaneous speech is approximately 150 words per minute, speaking from a prepared text is likely to be more rapid, at around 200 words per minute. The Eleventh Judicial Circuit Court in Illinois, USA, estimates

[26] Ibid., [29], p. 10.
[27] Ibid., [64], p. 28.
[28] Ibid., [20], p. 8.
[29] Ibid., [20], p. 7–8.

Table 11.1 Speaking rate by section in words per minute

	Start	End	MINUTES.seconds = mins	Words	wpm = words/mins
Opening remarks	3:33.00	3:35.04	2.04 = 2.06 min	284	137.86
Direct on "some important principles of law"	3:35.06	3:40.17	5.11 = 5.18 min	748	146.33
Directions of law	3:40.20	3:46.36	6.16 = 6.26 min	943	150.63
The elements of the offense	3:46.39	4:11.54	25.15 = 25.25 min	3665	145.14
Summary of the evidence	4:11.57	4:28.00	16.03 = 16.05 min	2588	161.24
Summary of the evidence—additional 15 min **Day 1:** **Total:**	4:28.42	4:44.17	15.35 = 15.58 min **70 min & 24 secs = 70.4 min**	2743 **10,971**	176.05 **155.83 (10,971/70.4)**

Table 11.2 Speaking rate on second day of summing-up

Start	End	minutes.seconds = mins	words	wpm = words/mins
10:08.27	10:39.06	30.39 = 30.65 min	4967	162.05
10:39.07	11:09.04	29.57 = 29.95 min	5237	174.85
11:09.05	11:39.02	29.57 = 29.95 min	5549	185.27
11:39.03	11:40.48	1.45 = 1.75 min	346	197.71
12:00.51	12:23.57	23.06 = 23.1 min	3761	162.81
Day 2: **Total:**		**115 min & 24 secs = 115.4 min**	**19,860 words**	**172.09 (19,860/115.4)**

Table 11.3 Speaking rate: words per hour by day

Day	Total number of words	Total number of hours	Words per hour (wph)
1	10,971	1.17 h	9,376.92
2	19,860	1.92 h	10,343.75

the average rate of speech during court proceedings at 150–160 words per minute.[30] This expectation is reflected in the simultaneous portion of the California court interpreter certification examination, which is reported to include a three-minute

[30] This statistic is reported in the context of stating what a Court Reporter should expect. *Eleventh Judicial Circuit Court Organization, Court Offices and Programs* https://www.mcleancountyil.gov/DocumentCenter/Home/View/228

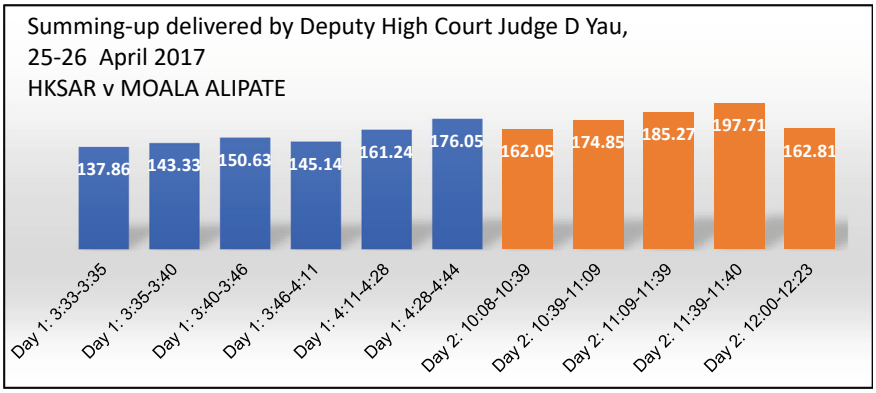


Fig. 11.1 Delivery speed in words per minute

tape recorded at a speed of 140 words per minute.[31] Court proceedings, however, include various kinds of exchange, some extemporaneous, others scripted. Speakers reading from a prepared text tend to deliver faster, with "none of the pauses, changes of pace or repetitions which normally help to convey meaning and which give the spoken language its immediate intelligibility."[32] Differences in mode of delivery, whether spoken or written, scripted or free, have consequences for the form that language takes.

11.6 Grammatical Features of Script-Based Speech

Script-based speech is characterized by those grammatical features of written language that may not only affect comprehension by jurors but also seriously impede the ability of court interpreters to meet their responsibility. Charrow and Charrow's ground-breaking empirical study of the comprehensibility of jury instructions[33] identified a number of linguistic features that cause comprehension problems. Certain of those linguistic features occur repeatedly in Judge Yao's summing-up. These include, for example,

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[31] R.D. Gonzalez, V. Vasquez and H. Mikkelson. *Fundamentals of Court Interpretation.* Carolina Academic Press. North Carolina. 1991, p. 542. The National Centre for State Courts, Language Access Division describes the court interpreter oral examination for simultaneous interpreting as follows: "This part of the exam consists of a CD recording of a simulated attorney's opening or closing statement to a judge or jury. It is 800 to 850 words in length, is recorded at an approximate speed of 120 words per minute, and is about seven minutes long. One hundred and twenty words per minute is *much slower* than most ordinary courtroom speech." http://www.ncsc.org/Education-and-Careers/State-Interpreter-Certification.aspx July 2012

[32] Ibid. p. 116.

[33] Robert P. Charrow & Veda R. Charrow, Making Legal Language Understandable: A Psycholinguistic Study of Jury Instructions, 79 COLUM. L. REV. 1306 (1979).

- the use of passive constructions in subordinate clauses[34];

  <c 2a> In the case of the DNA material **[<c 2b> found on the wrapping of lump, Pl — Exhibit P1]**, there are at least—at least three possible points **[<c 2c> where the defendant's DNA could have been transferred to the wrapping indirectly.]**
- the combination of many clauses within one sentence[35];

  <c 23a> The third possible point of transference … would have taken place inside Room 1740 <c 23b> according to Dr Z <c 23c> after the video recorded interview of the defendant had concluded <c 23d> and Officer Mak, 8195, entered the room <c 23e> to perform the task of putting the exhibits, especially the drug exhibits, into the tamperproof envelopes.
- "Whiz" deletion, i.e. omitting the relative pronoun.

  <c 43a> You will also remember <c 43b> Dr Z using the graphics on page 33 of the first defense bundle <c 43c> to explain to us the research **[<c 43d> conducted on transference by way of an investigator's glove onto another surface].**

11.7 Lexical Density

The lexical density or information load is also typically greater for script-based as opposed to free speech. Lexical density is calculated on the basis of how many content/lexical words there are in a clause. A clause in extemporaneous speech typically contains about two content/lexical words. On the other hand, written language, including what is written to be spoken, is more likely to contain between four to six content/lexical words per clause. As M.A.K. Halliday points out, the lexical density in scientific writing may go much higher, but when the lexical density gets to around 13 or greater, the text becomes difficult to comprehend.[36] Figure 11.2 shows the lexical density (i.e. number of content/lexical words per clause) and grammatical complexity (see above discussion) for Judge X's summary of the evidence given by the defense's expert witness, Dr Z. In addition to the fact that it was delivered by 200 wpm, there are several instances where the lexical density scored 10 or greater, at one point reaching 19 (See also Appendix 1—Calculation of Lexical Density and Grammatical Complexity for six minutes during which Judge X summarized the evidence given by the defense's expert witness, Dr. Z.) The coincidence of heightened lexical density with the complex grammatical structure, particularly if received in speech

[34] Key for clause analysis notation: <c 1 > indicates clause #1; […] indicates rank-shifted/embedded clause;

[35] Or what Charrow & Charrow refer to as "embedding." For my analysis here I have included both independent and dependent clauses, either finite or non-finite (e.g. "V-ing," "to inf-V"), and also what Halliday refers to as rank-shifted clauses (e.g. defining relative clauses). In other words, where there is a verb, there is a clause. A sentence can consist of more than one clause.

[36] M.A.K. Halliday. 1989/2004. 'Some Grammatical Problems in Scientific English' originally presented at the Symposium in Education, Society of Pakistani English Language Teachers, Karachi: SPELT. In J Webster (Ed.) The Language of Science. Volume Five, The Collected Works of M.A.K. Halliday. Bloomsbury, p. 169.

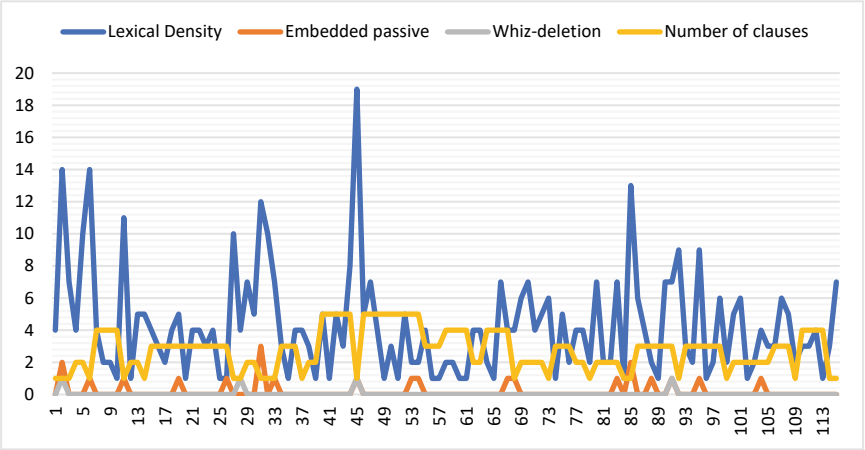


Fig. 11.2 Lexical density and grammatical complexity for the period between 10:24 and 10:30 am

over a period of hours, would certainly tax the ability of anyone to comprehend, regardless of whether English was their first or second language.

11.8 Court Interpreter's Impossible Task

In the reasons for their judgment, the appeal court justices noted that the observation of McGrath J in his judgment in *Abudal* that unlike "the translator who can reflect on how best to render the meaning of the source language into the target language," the interpreter must perform his task spontaneously.[37]

Because Judge X's summing-up, for the most part, involved the judge reading from a prepared written text, the court interpreter had to perform essentially the same task as a translator of a written text but at a speed which reached 200 wpm,[38] or "40 times faster than normal translating work."[39] As Seleskovitch notes, "This absurd pace quickly reduces the interpreter to a state of mental and physical exhaustion, and his usefulness to the listener is practically nil, when compared to the service he is able to render when dealing with free speech."[40] Although informed by defendant's counsel

[37] Criminal Appeal No. 135 of 2017 heard in the High Court of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region Court of Appeal (on Appeal from HCCC No. 86/2016). Heard before Hon McWalters JA, Poon JA, and Zervos JA. 26 February 2019, [54], p. 24.

[38] Judge X's summary of the evidence given by the defense's expert witness, Dr. Z on Day 2, 10:24.04 – 10:30.30 am, 1291 words in 6 mins and 26 secs. (6.43 mins) = 200.77 wpm.

[39] Danica Seleskovitch *Interpreting for international conferences* 2nd Edition. 1994. Washington DC: Pen and Booth, p. 118. The basis for this calculation is the fact the United Nations stipulates a requirement for translators of 6 and 8 pages, or 2,000 to 3,000 words per day.

[40] Ibid. p. 118.

on Day 2 that the interpreter was having difficulty keeping up with the judge's pace of delivery, the judge's delivery speed, instead of decreasing, became even faster.

11.9 Misuse of Indefinite Article

In the judge's discussion of the elements of the offense, he repeatedly refers to "an only reasonable inference." The judge is intending to explain what he later also refers to as "the only reasonable inference." Instead, however, his use of the indefinite article with the phrase "only ADJ N" (i.e. "an only reasonable inference") leads to the unintended meaning that there can be several "inferences," all with the quality that each is "only reasonable," and without any other quality. (E.g. *Tom is an only tall boy* (= "a boy who is only tall")[41] v. *Tom is the only tall boy*.) The listener could become confused over whether the judge is intending to suggest that there are multiple inferences, each "only reasonable" and that they are to decide between them, or whether they are to determine one in particular as being "***the*** only reasonable inference." (In the examples from the judge's summing-up, **bold underline** has been added.)

> What the prosecution seek to do is to ask you, the jury, to look at the surrounding circumstances - we call them "circumstantial evidence" - and then based on the evidence that you find are true, to draw **an only reasonable inference**. To draw **an only reasonable inference** to find that the defendant knew that the lumps of drugs were inside the consoles, that the defendant knew that it was some kind of dangerous drugs and that he was going to export to Auckland.[42]
>
> Mr Y also says that based on the contents of all the emails retrieved from the phone of the defendant, that is at the end of the jury bundle from AE -- page AE477 onwards,
>
> **Mr Y says it is an only - based on those emails - it is an only reasonable inference** that the defendant knew that he was going to come to Hong Kong to collect an item and that he must have known that the item was drugs, whether you are so able to infer from those matters is entirely for you to decide based on the direction I had given you.[43]

11.10 Ambiguous Use of Definite Articles

In the following exchange from the judge's summary of the evidence, reference is made to an exchange between Mr. B and Officer G concerning the defendant's having "touch[ed] one of the plastic bags containing the lumps of dangerous drugs." The first use of the definite article "These" (as below in "These are all the things that…") clearly refers to what has just been mentioned by Mr. B concerning the defendant having "coughed and cleared his throat…."

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[41] Admittedly this use of the indefinite article "a[n]" with "only ADJ N" sounds odd.

[42] The audio recording of the summing-up delivered by Deputy High Court Judge X over two days on 25 April (70 min 24 secs) and 26 April 2017 (115 min and 24 secs), p. 23.T-24.B.

[43] Ibid., p. 27.E

> Mr B mentioned to Officer G that the defendant seemed to have coughed and cleared his throat, exhaled strongly, tapped the table, tapped the telephones, stretched and leaned forward, rubbed, wiped his eyes, lips and nose a few times, rubbed or scratched his face, head and his neck a few times.
>
> **These are all things that, members of the jury, you can see for yourself in the video recorded interview and for you to decide if they happened or did not happen.**
>
> It was specifically pointed out to Officer G that at counter 992 or 01:20:05 hours of the video recorded interview; the defendant had reached out to touch one of the plastic bags containing one of the lumps of dangerous drugs.
>
> Officer G agreed but stressed that the defendant did not directly touch the lump, just the surface of the transparent plastic bag.
>
> **Again, this is recorded on a disc and it is for you to see for yourself and make a finding of fact on what had happened.**[44]

However, subsequently, the definite article "this" (as in "Again, this is recorded on a disc…") is ambiguous and may have been considered by the jurors to either refer simply to the defendant having reached out to touch one of the plastic bags, or to mean that the judge was confirming what Officer G had just stressed: "that the defendant did not directly touch the lump, just the surface of the transparent plastic bag." In other words, the judge's ambiguous reference may have been understood by the jurors to have been simply telling the jurors that they can see for themselves what happened or prejudicing the juror's perception of the event by saying that they can see for themselves and make a finding of fact concerning what Officer G just stressed.

11.11 Conclusion

For over an hour on the first day (= 1.17 h, interrupted by a brief break of 42 secs. during which Judge X requested an additional 15 min), and nearly two hours on the second day (= 1.92 h, interrupted by a break of 20 min), the court interpreter was required to mentally process and interpret the judge's summing-up into Tongan, which has "the rarest major type of word order: verb-initial (or predicate-initial)."[45] The court interpreter needed to carry out his task at 40 times the speed of that required of United Nations translators of written documents. Judge X read his summation. So as with other written texts, his summary carried a high information load (i.e. high lexical density), compounded not only by a substantial amount of technical jargon, but also complex grammatical constructions demanding considerable mental alertness and language proficiency in order to be processed and comprehended. In other words, the judge's summing-up delivered at a rather fast pace for over an hour must have taxed the mental processing of the court interpreter to such an extent that his performance would have been significantly diminished.

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[44] Ibid., p. 33.A-I.

[45] Douglas Ball. *Clause Structure and Argument Realization in Tongan*. PhD dissertation. Stanford University. 2008, p. 2.

The question remains whether the defendant can be considered to have had a fair trial if only the trial judge's summing-up has been called into question. Mr Y argued that since the judge's summing-up is primarily addressed to the jury, not the defendant, whatever deficiency existed in the interpretation of the summing-up for the defendant should not call into question the verdict rendered by the jury.[46] Countering that the English Court of Appeal in *Gjejlal Recica* was "not in any way devaluing the importance of summing-up, or suggesting that a defendant did not have a right to have the summing-up interpreted to him,"[47] the appeal court justices noted that the trial judge in *Gjejlal Recica* "had handed to counsel prior to his summing-up a substantial document which contained not only his proposed legal directions but also 'quite a good deal of factual material anticipating in summary form some aspects of what the Recorder would say in greater detail when he came to deal with evidence. So this was a substantial section of the summing-up.'".[48]

The appeal court justices did not hear the linguistic evidence since the evidence provided in the interpreter's testimony had already convinced them that the defendant did not receive a fair trial. The linguistic evidence, however, conclusively explains not only the interpreter's inability to provide adequate interpretation assistance, but also establishes the excessive linguistic demands placed on the interpreter, as well as members of the jury who were required to follow the summing-up without the benefit of a written document such as was produced in *Gjejlal Recica.*

Postscript

At the defendant's retrial which was held on 6 September 2021,[49] having been delayed due to the pandemic, it was reported that the defendant was stunned when the judge suddenly ruled that he was free.

The judge concluded his ruling by stating the following:

> 39. It is the finding of the Court that the emails between the defendant and Antony were capable of being regarded by a reasonable jury as allowing of only one possible inference, namely the defendant being innocent in that he was deceived by the 2 drug traffickers to unwittingly transport dangerous drugs for them and there is no evidence capable of excluding such an inference.

After the judge left the courtroom, the defendant, now a free man, sang a verse of *Amazing Grace* in the courtroom. MA later returned to Tonga, but in bad health. He passed away in January 2024.

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[46] Criminal Appeal No. 135 of 2017 heard in the High Court of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region Court of Appeal (on Appeal from HCCC No. 86/2016). Heard before Hon McWalters JA, Poon JA, and Zervos JA. 26 February 2019, [52], p. 22–23.

[47] Ibid. [52], p. 23.

[48] *R v Gjejlel Recica & anor* [2007] EWCA 2471 at [14], cited in Ibid. [52], p. 23.

[49] HKSAR v MOALA ALIPATE, HCCC 76/2019 [2021] HKCFI 2611, 6 September 2021.

Appendix 1

Calculation of Lexical Density and Grammatical Complexity for six minutes during which Judge X summarized the evidence given by the defense's expert witness, Dr. Z.

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 1a> Now, [<c 1b> what I understand Dr Z to be saying in his evidence] is this	4	(i) [<c 1b> what I understand Dr Z to be saying in his evidence]			1
<c 2a> In the case of the DNA material [<c 2b> found on the wrapping of lump, Pl—Exhibit P1], there are at least—at least three possible points [<c 2c> where the defendant's DNA could have been transferred to the wrapping indirectly.]	14		(i) [<c 2b> found on the wrapping of lump, Pl—Exhibit P1] (ii) [<c 2c> where the defendant's DNA could have been transferred to the wrapping indirectly.]	(i) [<c 2b> found on the wrapping of lump, Pl—Exhibit P1]	1
The first possible transference					
<c 3> The first point of transfer is at the interview room at the police post at the airport	7				1
<c 4a> There, Officer 8195 was wearing the same pair of gloves	4				2
<c 4b> when he searched the contents of the green floral bag and the green jacket in the black travel bag	10				

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 5a> With the support of the research [<c 5b> that Dr Z cited in his report], Dr Z is of the opinion [<c 5c> that it was possible [<c 5d> that some DNA material originally on the jacket could have transferred to the gloves of 8195.]]	14		(i) [<c 5d> that some DNA material originally on the jacket could have transferred to the gloves of 8195.]		1
<c 6a> That material could then have been transferred onto the wrapping of P1	4				4
<c 6b> when 8195 used his finger	2				
<c 6c> to open the wrapping a little bit	2				
<c 6d> to see [<c 6d> what was inside]	1				
The second possible transference					
<c 7a> The second point of possible transference, according to Dr Z, would have taken place in the display room [<c 7b> where exhibits were photographed]	11		(i) [<c 7b> where exhibits were photographed]		1
<c 8a> You will remember	1				2
<c 8b> that officer 8195 was a person [<c 8c> who had positioned the exhibits for photos]	5				
<c 9> Officer Mak wore a new pair of gloves	5				1

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 10a> He wore the same pair of gloves	4				3
<c 10b> when he took out the contents from the green floral bag	3				
<c 10c> to have photos 1 to 4 taken	2				
<c 11a> He wore the same pair of gloves	4				3
<c 11b> when he positioned the black travel bag and its contents	5				
<c 11c> to be photographed	1		(i) <c 11c> to be photographed		
<c 12a> He wore the same pair of gloves	4				3
<c 12b> when he opened up the two game consoles	4				
<c 12c> and found the third lump inside each of them	3				
<c 13a> He wore the same pair of gloves	4				3
<c 13b> when he positioned those	1				
<c 13c> to be photographed	1		(i) <c 13c> to be photographed		

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 14a> Dr Z is of the opinion [<c 14b> that there were two possible routes for the defendant's DNA <c 14c> to find its way onto the wrapping of the P1 lump.]	10				1
<c 15a> The first route was similar to the one [<c 15b> we mentioned above.]	4			(i) [<c 15b> we mentioned above.]	1
<c 16a> That is to say from the defendant's property, … to the gloves of 8195 and then onto the wrapping of P1	7				2
<c 16b> including his green jacket and two pairs of shoes,	5				
<c 17a> The second route is for the DNA material on the defendant's personal belongings [<c 17b> to be left on the green mat [<c 17c> on which all the exhibits were placed <c 17d> when they were photographed]]	12		(i-iii) [<c 17b> to be left on the green mat [<c 17c> on which all the exhibits were placed <c 17d> when they were photographed]]		1

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 18a> There is no evidence [<c 18b> that Officer Mak had cleaned the mat properly, or at all, <c 18c> before he placed the lump in question onto the green mat].	10				1
<c 19a> There is no evidence [<c 19b> that the arrangement of the photos in the photo album is in the same sequence [<c 19c> as the photos were taken]]	7		(i) [<c 19c> as the photos were taken]		
<c 20a> Mr Y did suggest to Dr Z	3				3
<c 20b> that such was the case,	1				
<c 20c> but Dr Z simply could not answer that question	4				
<c 21a> And [<c 21b> what Mr Y suggested] is not evidence, merely a suggestion	4	(i) [<c 21b> what Mr Y suggested]			1
<c 22a> That evidence should have come from Officer Mak,	3				2
<c 22b> but there is no such evidence	1				
The third possible point of transference					

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 23a> The third possible point of transference … would have taken place inside Room 1740	5				5
<c 23b> according to Dr Z	1				
<c 23c> after the video recorded interview of the defendant had concluded	5				
<c 23d> and Officer Mak, 8195, entered the room	3				
<c 23e> to perform the task of putting the exhibits, especially the drug exhibits, into the tamperproof envelopes	8				
<c 24a> Dr Z's opinion is [<c 24b> that as a result of the defendant's coughing and speaking during the video recorded interview, <c 24c> DNA materials could have been deposited onto the surface of the table and the transparent plastic bags [<c 24d> containing the exhibits]]	19		(i) [… <c 24c> DNA materials could have been deposited onto the surface of the table and the transparent plastic bags …]	(i) [<c 24d> containing the exhibits]	1
<c 25a> When Officer Mak took up the transparent plastic bags,	5				5

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 25b> the DNA material could have been transferred onto his gloves and then onto the wrapping of the P1 lump	7				
<c 25c> when he reached into the transparent plastic bag	4				
<c 25d> to take it out	1				
<c 25e> and place it into the tamperproof envelope	3				
<c 26a> You will remember	1				5
<c 26b> that there is a discrepancy between Officer G, 58,500, and Officer Mak's evidence	5				
<c 26c> as to how much time is required	2		(i) <c 26c> as to how much time is required		
<c 26d> for one lump to be transferred	2		(i) <c 26d> for one lump to be transferred		
<c 27a> Officer G said about one second,	4				3
<c 27b> whereas Officer Mak said	1				
<c 27c> it was 10 to 20, seconds each	1				
<c 28a> Whether this difference is material,	2				4

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 28b> and if so how it might affect the transference,	2				
<c 28c> it is for you, the jury,	1				
<c 28d> to decide	1				
<c 29a> In addition to the evidence on transference, Dr Z also said	4				2
<c 29b> that clothing is a recognized source of DNA	4				
<c 30a> Dr Z pointed out	2				4
<c 30b> that having seen	1				
<c 30c> the recorded interview, point 6 on page 10 of the first defense bundle is obsolete,	7				
<c 30d> to be replaced by his supplemental report at page 15	4		(i) <c 30d> to be replaced by his supplemental report at page 15		

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 31a> It is Dr Z's opinion [<c 31b> that the following step should have been taken <c31c> to prevent the occurrence of transference in this particular case]	4		(i) [<c 31b> that the following step should have been taken …]		1
<c 32a> He said 8195 should have used a new pair of gloves	6				2
<c 32b> after he had finished searching the defendant's personal items and green jacket	7				
<c 33a> If he had changed his gloves after contact with each item,	4				
<c 33b> the possibility of transference via the gloves would be entirely eliminated	5				
<c 34> Dr Z said the wrapping of the P1 lump should not have been opened by Officer Mak the way he did	6				1
<c 35a> That is to say	1				3
<c 35b> using his gloved fingers to pry open	5				
<c 35c> to see inside	2				
<c 36a> A clean and sterilized instrument should have been used	4				2

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 36b> so that there would not be contact between the gloves and the wrapping,	4				
<c 37> Thus avoiding transference	2				1
<c 38a> Dr Z agreed with Officer Mak's decision [<c 38b> to put the lump back into the console]	7				2
<c 38c> because that would minimize manipulation	2				
<c 39a> But Dr Z thinks	2				2
<c 39b> that the whole game console should then immediately be sealed inside a plastic bag	7		(i) <c 39b> that the whole game console should then immediately be sealed inside a plastic bag		
<c 40> That, however, was not done	1				
<c 41a> In relation to the taking of photos in the display room, Dr Z's opinion is [<c 41b> that each of the exhibits should be placed inside a plastic bag <c 41c> immediately after photos had been taken.]	13		(i-ii) [<c 41b> that each of the exhibits should be placed inside a plastic bag <c 41c> immediately after photos had been taken.]		1

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 42a> The exhibit should have been placed on a disposable plastic sheet just for the photo—taking	6				3
<c 42b> and then the plastic sheet should be replaced by a new one	4				
<c 42c> for the next item to be photographed	2		(i) <c 42c> for the next item to be photographed		
<c 43a> You will also remember	1				3
<c 43b> Dr Z using the graphics on page 33 of the first defense bundle	7				
<c 43c> to explain to us the research [<c 43d> conducted on transference by way of an investigator's glove onto another surface]	7		(i) [<c 43d> conducted on transference by way of an investigator's glove onto another surface]	(i) [<c 43d> conducted on transference by way of an investigator's glove onto another surface]	

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 44a> [<c 44b> What Dr Z is suggesting] is [<c 44c> that the indirect transfer of DNA [<c 44d> that he is suggesting <c 44e> could have happened in our present case]]	9	(i) [<c 44b> What Dr Z is suggesting]			1
<c 45a> To be fair to Dr Z,	3				3
<c 45b> even Dr Ip had agreed	2				
<c 45c> that it is possible [<c 45d> for DNA on the green jacket, if any, to be transferred onto the gloves of Officer Mak during his search of the jacket]	9		(i) [<c 45d> for DNA on the green jacket, if any, to be transferred onto the gloves of Officer Mak during his search of the jacket]		
<c 46a> As I said before,	1				3
<c 46b> Dr Ip had also agreed	2				
<c 46c> that transfer of DNA material from gloves onto another surface is a possibility	6				
<c 47> During cross-examination, Mr Y asked this	2				1

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 48a> If Officer Mak's gloves had the defendant's DNA material,	5				2
<c 48b> why would only one of the packet of drugs be tested positive for his DNA?	6				
<c 49a> Dr Z explained	1				2
<c 49b> that there are two reasons for that	2				
<c 50a> First would be [<c 50b> that there was not enough DNA material <c 50c> to be transferred to more than one surface];	4		(i) <c 50c> to be transferred to more than one surface		2
<c 50d> the material was removed in the first touch	3				
<c 51a> The second reason is [<c 51b> that there might have been transference to more than one of the wrappings],	3				3
<c 51c> but the condition was such [<c 51d> that the DNA material became unstable by way of attack by enzymes],	6				
<c 51e> which is a recognized problem of the stability of the post-DNA material	5				

(continued)

(continued)

	Number of content words per clause (including content words in embedded/ rankshifted clauses)	Rankshifted nominalization as Subject	Passive voice in subordinate or rankshifted clause	Whiz-deletion	Number of non-rankshifted clauses
<c 52> In other words, it would have been degraded by the enzymes	2				
<c 53a> It was suggested to Dr Z by Mr Y	3				4
<c 53b> that although what Dr Z said is theoretically possible,	3				
<c 53c> the chances of transference happening are negligible	4				
<c 53d> and can be disregarded	1				
<c 54> Dr Z disagreed with that proposition	3				1
<c 55a> The above is a summary of [<c 55b> what [<c 55c> I think] are the most relevant points of Dr Z's evidence]]	7				1

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Chapter 12
A Genre-Based Approach to Academic Literacy in an EFL Context



Hui Yu

Abstract The concept of genre-based pedagogy, deeply rooted in Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), has been widely investigated and applied within primary and secondary educational settings. Despite its prevalent use, there remains a noticeable gap in its application at the tertiary level, particularly in an English as a Foreign Language (EFL) context. This study applies the principles of genre-based pedagogy as articulated by SFL to develop a robust teaching model tailored for university environments. Our primary goal is to integrate academic literacy into both teaching and learning dynamics. By incorporating academic articles from key textbooks, this research aims to construct a foreign language teaching model that is intricately guided by principles of academic literacy. Through this model, it is anticipated that educators will be better equipped to enhance and nurture students' academic literacy, thereby enriching their educational journey and academic success in higher education settings.

Keywords Academic literacy · Systemic Functional Linguistics · Genre-based pedagogy · EFL

12.1 Introduction

Literacy refers to "language use as something people *do* when they interact with one another" (Hyland 2009: 9). In higher education, such perception reframes academic literacy as social practice rather than a universal set of skills usable in any situation. That is, academic literacy refers to academic practice associated with contextual factors including student's identities, purposes, disciplines, etc. This perception is echoed by Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), which regards language as a social semiotic resource for making meaning in social contexts. Viewed this way, the genre-based pedagogy of the Sydney School, deeply rooted in SFL, might be

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suitably applied to the study of academic literacy. However, SFL-informed studies of academic literacy so far have been limited to academic literacy in primary or secondary education contexts (Brisk 2015) or evaluations in academic writing (Hood 2010).

In the increasingly competitive landscape of education, developing students' academic literacy is crucial to their success in both academic and professional spheres. Academic literacy extends beyond the mere ability to read and write; it involves understanding genres of texts they encounter in academic contexts. In view of this, the current study aims to apply the genre-based pedagogy of the Sydney School to academic literacy instruction in an EFL context at the tertiary level.

12.2 Origin and Development of SFL-Informed Genre-Based Pedagogy

The genre-based pedagogy of the Sydney School, originated in the late 1970s and early 1980s, developed primarily by educators and linguists in Australia, notably by Jim Martin and Joan Rothery (Martin 1985, 1990; Rothery 1994, 1996), who were closely associated with the University of Sydney. The initial aim of the Sydney School genre-based pedagogy was to address the educational challenges faced by socially disadvantaged groups in Australia. It was noticed that learners from different social-economic backgrounds achieved different academic outcomes in school due to their different access to language patterns important in their educational context. This educational inequality led scholars of the Sydney School to develop a more structured approach to teaching language that focused on explicit teaching of genres. Their approach came to be known as "genre-based pedagogy," or simply genre pedagogy in brief.

The Sydney School pedagogy had its roots in Systemic Functional Linguistics, as learning is a linguistic process. As Halliday (1993: 97) states, "When children learn language, they are not simply engaging in one kind of learning among many; rather, they are learning the foundation of learning itself." Learning is not simply learning the knowledge of the subject. Rather, it is more about learning how the knowledge of the subject is codified and transmitted via language. It is therefore important for a linguist to explain how language functions in the process of education. To answer that, at least three questions should be asked: (1) How is knowledge organized through language? (2) How does language help students to learn? (3) What does the teacher need to know about language in order to help students along their learning process?

Apart from SFL, the genre-based pedagogy was also inspired by Bernstein's theory of education. Central to the pedagogy is Bernstein's conception of the pedagogic device, which forms an important theoretical foundation for the Sydney School's research project on discourse genre pedagogy (Rose and Martin 2012: 4). In Bernstein's sociological theory of education, the entire educational system of a

society is a pedagogic device, regulated by distributive rules, recontextualizing rules, and evaluative rules (Bernstein 1996).

Distributive rules control the distribution of knowledge. The social division of labor determines the different functions people must perform in society. These rules decide what type of knowledge is allotted to which specific social groups. Recontextualizing rules are a key concept in Bernstein's educational theory, maintaining that teaching itself is a process of recontextualization. As discourse moves from one domain to another, it undergoes changes in time and space, influenced by context, culture, ideology, and other factors, leading to relative changes of the text. Evaluative rules are also an indispensable element in Bernstein's educational theory. They are the implicit or explicit criteria used by the community to judge whether a student is successful or not. Evaluation determines the quality of students' academic performance and is also a process of social stratification, where inherently unfair knowledge distribution can be rationalized. This is because through evaluation, differences in students' performance can be simply attributed to their innate intelligence or effort, while the crucial role the educational system plays in maintaining and transmitting social relations is often overlooked.

Influenced by Bernstein's theory of education, the initial intent of genre pedagogy was to ensure a fair and reasonable distribution of knowledge. That is, children from different social classes can have equal educational opportunities. Learners, by mastering specific genres, can actively participate in various social communicative activities. Furthermore, genre pedagogy, being functionally oriented, helps students master different types of genre through contextual and linguistic aspects. Genre pedagogy is an integrative effort of Systemic Functional Linguistics and Bernstein's sociology of education. On the one hand, educational sociological theory provides a theoretical lens through which to view education; on the other hand, Systemic Functional Linguistics provides an applicable linguistic theoretical framework for educational sociological theories, enabling the verification of related hypotheses.

The genre-based pedagogy has gone through three phases. The first phase began in the 1980s with the *Language and Social Power* Project. The project at this phase focused on writing in infants and primary school education. The kinds of genres found in Australian primary school were outlined, including stories, factual texts, and arguments. Models of genres were then developed. The pedagogy was designed to enable students' genre mastery. Teacher-student interaction was investigated and analyzed to illustrate how meanings are negotiated. The teaching/learning cycle (TLC) at this phase consists of Deconstruction, Joint Construction, Independent Construction of Text and Negotiating Field (Rose and Martin 2012: 65). The TLC was later refined in the second phase.

The second phase of the genre-based pedagogy focused on genres that students are expected to read and write in secondary school, including stories, histories, explanations, procedures, reports, arguments and text responses, known as the *Write it Right* project. As children move on to secondary school, they begin to work with different school subjects. The task of educational linguistics is not just to describe the language of subject learning, but also to explain it regarding the way language is used. Language is described in terms of classification (things), cause-and-effect

(activity sequence), and evaluation (opinions) to account for the knowledge-building process. One crucial resource for building uncommon sense knowledge, grammatical metaphor, is also explored at this stage.

The third phase of the pedagogy was initially designed to meet the needs of indigenous education in Australia, known as the *Reading to Learn* project. Teaching design at this stage focused on two major components: classroom interaction and the model of reading. Three levels of reading were designed: preparing for reading, reading in detail, and using what has been learned from reading to write new texts. Strategies for each level were investigated.

As the name itself suggests, the genre-based pedagogy features the **explicit teaching of genres** with a clear focus on the communicative purpose, as genre is defined as "a staged, goal-oriented social process" (Martin and Rose 2007: 8). The approach stresses the importance of explicitly teaching the structural and functional aspects of various genres. This means helping students to identify the linguistic and structural elements typical of different genres, such as the typical elements in a story or in an argumentative essay. Take the narrative for instance, teachers might help students to identify generic elements including abstract, orientation, complication, evaluation, resolution, and coda. By teaching these elements, the approach enables students to use similar structures in their own writing.

The genre-based pedagogy, as advocated by Systemic Functional Linguistics, emphasizes the role of context in shaping the language and structure of texts. Understanding the communicative purpose of a genre is then crucial to effective reading and writing. For example, the purpose of a procedure is to explain how to do experiments and observations and will be very different from an argument, the aim of which is to argue for a point of view. One task of the teacher is then to help students to understand the purpose for each type of genre, guiding them to use specific language that characterize certain genres.

One key aspect of the pedagogy is its focus on the specific linguistic choices that characterize different genres. For example, academic and scientific writing might feature the use of grammatical metaphors, which increases the semantic density and technicality of the text. Teachers' guidance would help students to be more conscious of such language use and hence contribute to their effective writing. Teachers' help and support in this context should be provided through carefully structured stages. That is, scaffolding plays a crucial role in genre-based pedagogy.

In genre-based pedagogy, **scaffolding** means the teacher provides high levels of support initially, guiding students through the steps, but over time, gradually withdraws the support. The aim is for students to eventually be able to produce the genre independently. Specifically, at the initial stage, the "deconstruction stage," the teacher provides direct support by dissecting and breaking down the features of the genre. This may involve in-depth analysis of the text. Throughout the process, teachers should observe students' progress and adjust their support accordingly. As the learning process goes on, students become more familiar with the genre. The responsibility of the teacher can be gradually reduced. In the next stage, the "joint construction" stage, students begin to take more responsibility in learning and

writing. Students and the teacher work jointly to craft texts. Writing becomes a collaborative effort. In the final stage, the "independent construction" stage, students will produce their writing independently by applying the genre knowledge and linguistic resources they have learnt previously. This phase might involve peer review sessions, where students critique each other's work and offer constructive feedback. The deconstruction—joint construction—independent construction stages make up the learning cycle in the genre pedagogy of Sydney School.

Research indicates that genre-based pedagogy effectively improves students' writing and reading comprehension across various age groups and curricula. Studies by Macken-Horarik (2002) demonstrate significant improvements in students' ability to structure their writing according to the demands of different academic and social contexts. Further, this approach has been shown to particularly benefit students from linguistically diverse backgrounds, enabling them to access and succeed in mainstream educational settings (Gibbons 2006).

12.3 A Teaching Model

In this part, we will propose a pedagogical design, the purpose of which is to improve the academic literacy of students in an ELT context. The design is inspired by the genre-based pedagogy of Sydney School, particularly the learning cycle discussed previously. The deconstruction—joint construction—independent construction learning cycle in Sydney School is designed to help students develop the required skills in a stepwise approach. The learning is a gradual process from teacher-guided detailed reading and analyzing to independent writing. The aim is to enable students to be proficient in reading and writing about academic subjects and to engage in academic interaction and negotiation. See Fig. 12.1 for an illustration of the design (Rose 2014).

Deconstruction, Joint Construction, and Independent Construction are distinct genres, which may occur in separate lessons, and consist of their own staging. Each individual curriculum genre unfolds through a sequence of lesson stages.

Deconstruction

In the Deconstruction phase, students begin by analyzing and deconstructing authentic texts from the target academic genre. The aim of this phase is to help students understand how knowledge is built by analyzing the generic structure, lexicogrammatical resources, the communicative purpose, etc., of the genre. This phase is primarily teacher-guided and can be divided into two steps: generic deconstruction and the analysis of academic resources. The first step primarily helps students to identify and understand the basic generic structure and prepare them for further reading. The second step requires teachers to elaborate on the identified lexicogrammatical resources.

The first step involves learning about the communicative purpose of the text: why the text is written and who the intended audience is. For example, the primary

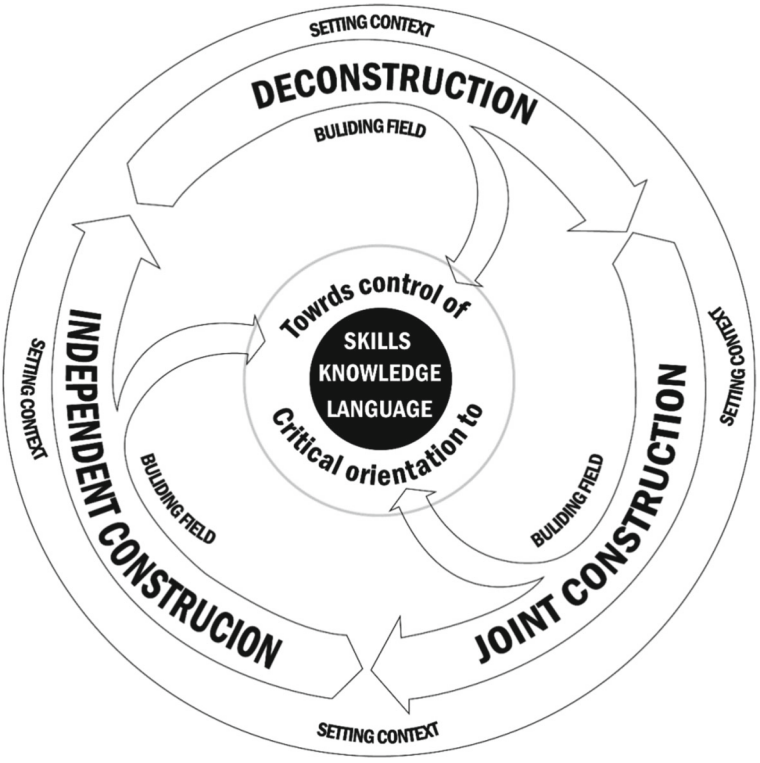


Fig. 12.1 The learning cycle

purpose of literature review is to critically review and evaluate existing research. The purpose can be further divided into several specific aims including (i) providing a foundation for current research; (ii) defining key concepts and theories; (iii) showing how research and methodologies have evolved; (iv) identifying research gaps in existing research; (v) providing support for your research questions and hypothesis. Leaning about the communicative purpose also means understanding how the context of production influences the linguistic choices made in the text. For example, the context of production of academic writing determines its linguistic features such as formality and objectivity.

The second step involves showing students how knowledge is built through lexicogrammatical resources. This can be broken down into understanding things (classification and composition), understanding processes (activity sequencing), and expressing opinions. Another important resource is the use of grammatical metaphor, which leads to the packaging of information and abstraction. It is such features that set apart academic or technical discourse from everyday, commonsense discourse.

In this phase, the teacher's role is instructive and deconstructive at the same time, guiding students to understand both the structure and the lexicogrammatical choices typical of academic genre.

Joint Construction

After deconstructing the text, students move into joint construction phase, which serves as a transitional stage. The aim of this stage is for students to apply resources they have learned in the initial stage to their writing. The stage features high teacher-student or student–student collaboration and interaction. At this stage, students work closely with the teacher and peer students to co-create a text. This may involve students' jointly writing sections of a text, exploring lexicogrammatical choices or discussing the structure of the genre.

The role of the teacher in this phase is to provide scaffolding by giving suggestions and comments on students' linguistic choices, guiding them toward a better understanding of conventions of academic writing. For instance, the teacher may point out how the use of grammatical metaphor may increase the semantic density of the text or how the use of passive voice increases the objectivity of academic writing.

In this phase, teachers should gradually reduce their responsibility and transfer it to students, but students are still supported. The focus, however, is on enabling students to experiment with features of academic writing and learn from joint endeavor, eventually leading to the internalization of knowledge for students.

Independent Construction

In the final phase, students are expected to engage in independent writing without the guidance of the teacher. The teacher may provide prompts or a specific task, but the students are now fully independent in creating their own text. Students should be able to use linguistic resources they have learned in previous phases and apply them to their own writing. This phase may also involve students making self-assessment of their writing or peer review sessions, where students assess each other's work and offer constructive suggestions. Teachers may provide rubrics for students to evaluate their work. In this phase, the teacher's role shifts to monitoring and providing feedback if necessary, but the focus is on fostering independence and self-reliance.

In the pedagogical practice, pedagogical activities, pedagogical relations, and pedagogical modalities should be designed to ensure that all students can successfully engage in interaction and have equal access to knowledge, which is one of the primary aims of genre-based pedagogy. In the pedagogy, learning activities position the learner's task as the central element, initiated by task focus and followed by evaluation. The task focus may not give students enough support to succeed with the task. For example, students may be asked to write on a certain topic, but not all students have sufficient experience with the target genre. In order to prepare all students for the task, the "prepare" phase should be brought in to reduce potential inequality. With all students being better prepared for the task, an "elaborate" step can be added to enhance knowledge. See Fig. 12.2 for such a nuclear model of learning task.

As can be seen in Fig. 12.2, a learning activity consists of three core phases: Focus, Task, and Evaluate, along with two peripheral phases: Prepare and Elaborate. The three core phases roughly correspond to the IRF (Initiation-Response-Feedback) interaction pattern of classroom discourse as proposed by Sinclair and Coulthard (1975). However, unlike the IRF model, this framework emphasizes that teachers

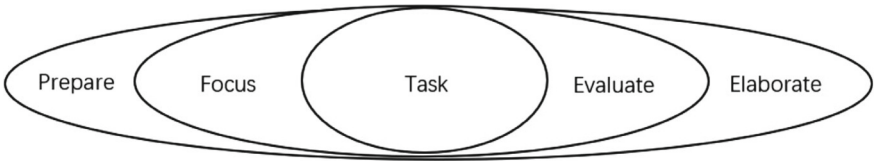


Fig. 12.2 Five phases of a learning activity (Rose and Martin 2012: 306)

should prepare students before starting the task to help them successfully complete it. After evaluating students' performance on the task, teachers may choose to expand on the knowledge to strengthen understanding. In the teacher-student interaction, tasks are often focused through teacher questioning, and teachers need to provide explanations after evaluation, which sets up the necessary foundation for the next task. Therefore, this teaching activity structure is also referred to as the learning cycle.

12.4 An Illustrative Case

In this part, we are going to show how we can apply the above-mentioned pedagogical design to enhance academic writing skills among graduate students in the Chinese context. The participants are students enrolled in a program of Masters of Education at a prestigious university in Beijing. As these students are working professionals, their study is part-time and restricted to the summer vacation period. Due to their limited exposure to academic writing, students often struggle with their academic writing tasks. The instructor of an academic writing course employs this pedagogical approach to improve students' academic writing skills. Given that the students are all primary and secondary school teachers, the reading materials for the course are primarily selected from English academic journals related to English language teaching. Through collaborative analysis and interpretation with the students, followed by practical application, this approach aims to enhance their academic writing proficiency. In the following, we will illustrate how the class is designed with an abstract selected from *Journal of English for Academic Purposes*[1]. Scaffolding plays a crucial role throughout the whole process. The objective of the teaching is to enable students to write abstracts for academic articles.

Deconstruction

In this phase, the teacher demonstrates how knowledge is built by dissecting the features of the genre, i.e. abstract. The teacher begins by explicating the purpose of

[1] The text is the abstract of the following article: Michelle Bedeker, & Sulushash Kerimkulova, 2024. "I notice I'm getting more involved, interested, and excited about my future topic." Action research as a transition from research steps to navigating graduate students' scholarly dispositions, *Journal of English for Academic Purposes*, Volume 68, 2024, 101,365.

an abstract, which is to provide a concise and accurate description of the study, thus allowing readers to quickly understand the main points without having to read the entire article. The purpose of an abstract requires that abstracts generally include the elements of research background, research purpose, research method, findings, and conclusion. The teacher organizes group discussion on the structure of the given text by giving the following instructions: *Find out what elements are included in the abstract. Discuss how the purpose of an abstract influences its structure*. The purposes of the discussion are twofold: understanding the generic structure of abstracts and understanding the contextual conditioning on the text. After group discussion, students are generally able to suggest an analysis of the generic structure of the abstract, as shown below.

[**Research Background**]

Graduate students often approach research with predefined steps emphasizing procedural aspects that occasionally expose their inadequate preparation for research as social practice.

[**Research Purpose**]

The purpose of this paper is to show how an action research (AR) methodology, in conjunction with English for Specific Purposes (ESP) and Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), has facilitated the scaffolding of explicit formal, rhetorical, procedural, and strategic knowledge in research discourse.

[**Research Method**]

We followed a cyclical action research model consisting of 1) recognizing students' limited understanding of research as a social practice, 2) developing interventions to promote understanding of how language is structured, represented, and negotiated in scientific discourse, 3) results of the intervention, and 4) reflection.

[**Findings**]

Thematic analysis of six participants' data, including their tasks, reflections, and draft proposals, revealed a discernible progression toward scholarly thinking, transformative learning, and the embodiment of scholarly identity.

[**Conclusion**]

Integrating ESP and SFL frameworks enhanced our ability to guide students through research-specific discourses, moving beyond a purely theoretical understanding to engage in authentic practices. This approach contributed to the cultivation of Communities of Practice (CoP) in which student-faculty collaboration fostered a shared scholarly mindset and facilitated the gradual integration of students into these academic communities.

Genre is "a staged, goal-oriented social process" (Martin and Rose 2007: 8). In this case, abstracts are social in the sense that by writing an abstract, students are engaged in academic interaction with scholars and researchers in the same field. It is staged because an abstract typically unfolds in certain steps with consistent patterns of meaning. It is goal-oriented because an abstract is generally considered a concise summary of a larger academic text and helps potential readers to determine the relevance of the current paper for their own research. The purpose of the teaching activities at this stage is to help students understand the social cultural context of the text production and how the context influences the way a text unfolds. By unpacking more lexicogrammatical resources, the teacher can help students better

understand how the resources contribute to knowledge building in the text and how the communicative purpose is achieved.

As Martin and Rose (2007) point out, the field of the text can be construed in terms of three sets of lexical relations. The first is taxonomic relations, including relations such as repetition, synonymy and antonymy. The second is the nuclear relation, the configuration of elements within a clause. This is about relations between people and things and the process they are involved in. The third is the sequence of activities as the text unfolds.

For the first type of lexical relations, the teacher can ask students to list the keywords in the abstract and draw up lexical strings to demonstrate the relations (Fig. 12.3).

Each lexical item in a text expects subsequent lexical items to be related to it in one way or another. In this abstract, the word *research* initiates the field. Other related lexical items are added to expand on the field of the text, including *academic*, *social practice*, *scholarly*, etc. Such analysis of taxonomic relations helps students to understand how to build up specialized classifications of uncommonsense experience in the academic field.

Another language resource in the abstract is the use of grammatical metaphor, a crucial feature of academic writing. Grammatical metaphor is essential in academic discourse because it enables abstraction, objectification, and logical structuring of knowledge. It transforms language from a commonsense, everyday mode into a specialized, theoretical mode suited for constructing and communicating disciplinary knowledge. This linguistic resource helps academic texts achieve the precision, and depersonalized tone characteristic of scholarly communication.

The most common type of grammatical metaphor is nominalization, where actions are reconstructed as things, for example, *preparation*, *interventions*, *reflection*, *progression*, *embodiment*, *cultivation*, *collaboration*, *integration*, etc. It is the teacher's task to explain the functions of grammatical metaphor in the academic writing. The use of grammatical metaphor increases abstraction and semantic density of the text. For example, for the metaphorical expression *their inadequate preparation for research as social practice*, a more congruent form would have been "they are not adequately prepared for research as social practice." By transforming the dynamic process of "prepare for" into an abstract entity "preparation," grammatical metaphor allows for a more compact and abstract formulation. It also enables academic discourse to construct knowledge as a system of related concepts rather than a sequence of events. For example, in the sentence "*Thematic analysis of six participants' data, including their tasks, reflections, and draft proposals, revealed a discernible progression towards scholarly thinking, transformative learning, and the embodiment of scholarly identity*", quite a few processes are involved, but the use of grammatical metaphor transforms processes into entities so that what should have been a sequence of events are now represented as individual entities in certain relations, thus making the information more condensed and compact. Below is a learning task, the purpose of which is to guide students toward a better understanding of grammatical metaphors in academic writing.

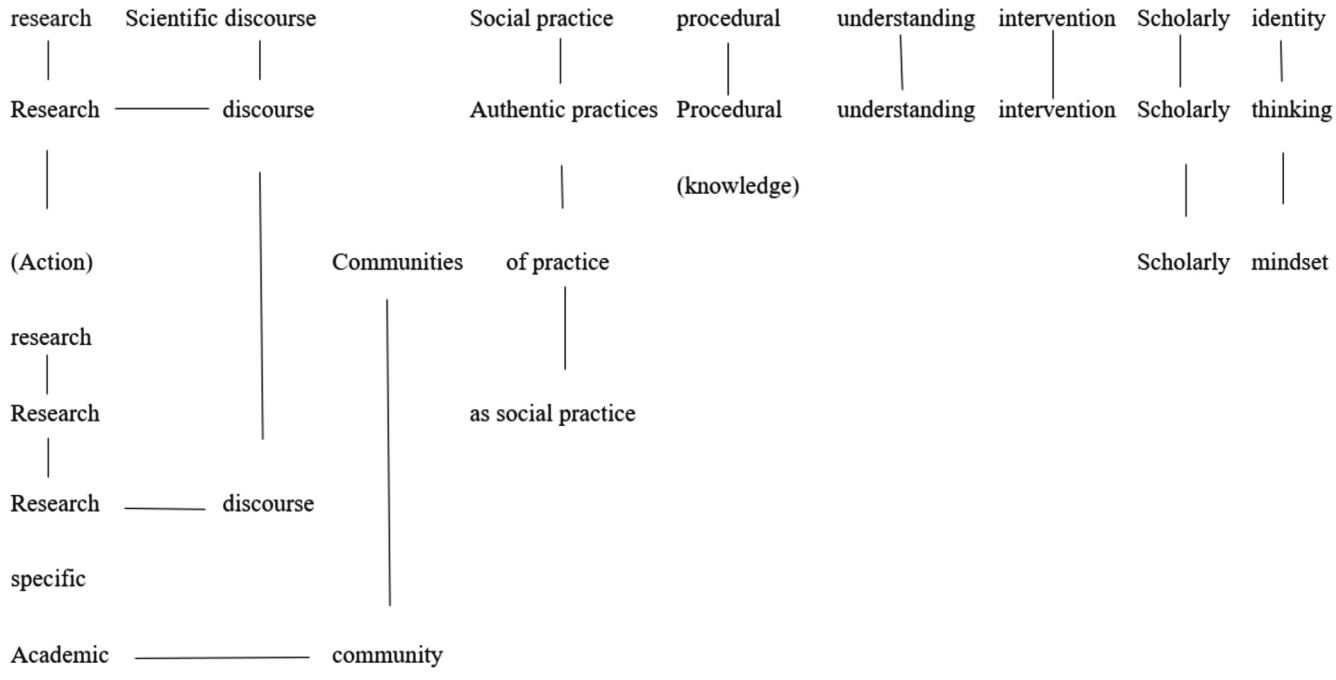


Fig. 12.3 Lexical relations in the text

[Prepare]	[Focus]	Teacher:	Can anyone tell me how you understand the term "*metaphor*" in general?
	[Task]	Student 1:	It is like using a word or phrase that usually means one thing to mean something else. Something literary?
	[Evaluate]	Teacher:	Exactly, that's a common usage in literary works.
	[Elaborate]		But in grammar, it takes a different form. Grammatical metaphor is about using a grammatical form to express a concept that is usually expressed by a different grammatical form. Nominalization is the most common form of grammatical metaphor, i.e. using a noun to replace a verb in a sentence. Examples of nominalization include turning "*express*" into "*expression*," "*argue*" into "*argument.*" Grammatical metaphors allow us to pack more information into fewer words. For example, "*I express my ideas in detail to effectively clarify the point*," can become, "*Detailed expression effectively clarifies the point*." This is crucial in academic writing for clarity and density of information.
[Focus]	[Focus]	Teacher:	Now if you paraphrase the sentence "*Thematic analysis of six participants' data, including their tasks, reflections, and draft proposals, revealed a discernible progression towards scholarly thinking, transformative learning, and the embodiment of scholarly identity,*" what do we get?
[Task]	[Task]	Student 2:	We could perhaps say: "*By looking at the work of six participants, including their tasks, reflections, and draft proposals, we found that they are learning to think more like scholars. They are also changing how they understand things and are starting to feel like scholars themselves*".
[Evaluate]	[Evaluate]	Teacher:	That's right.
	[Focus]		How are they different then?
	[Task]	Student 3:	The original sentence is shorter and the paraphrase longer. What's more, the original sentence sounds more formal and condensed, and the paraphrase is more direct and easier to understand
	[Evaluate]	Teacher:	Right.
[Elaborate]	[Prepare]		When we turn actions into things, the tone of the text changes from a more direct to a formal version. This function allows us to shift the focus and also pack the information more densely. This is useful in academic contexts where the emphasis is often on the results or concepts rather than the actions.
	[Focus]		How can using grammatical metaphor improve the readability and professionalism of academic texts?
	[Task]	Student 5:	By using these structures, we can make our writing more concise and emphasize what's important in the discourse, right?

(continued)

(continued)

	[Evaluate]	Teacher:	Correct!
	[Elaborate]		It also meets the requirements of the formal tone expected in academic articles. By mastering grammatical metaphors, you can enhance both the precision and persuasiveness of your academic arguments.

The **Prepare–Focus–Task–Evaluate–Elaborate** learning cycle provides a structured way to scaffold students' understanding. The above conversation shows how the teacher in the conversation supports students' learning about **grammatical metaphor in academic writing** using this framework.

In the **Prepare** stage, the teacher begins by activating students' prior knowledge of the term "metaphor." The teacher begins by activating students' prior knowledge of the term **"metaphor"**: "*Can anyone tell me how you understand the term 'metaphor' in general?*" Students respond with their existing understanding (literary metaphor), which the teacher acknowledges and builds upon: "*Exactly, that's a common usage in literary works. But in grammar, it takes a different form…*" Here, the teacher bridges students' prior knowledge with the new concept of grammatical metaphor, preparing them for deeper engagement.

In the **Focus** and **Task** stage, the teacher focuses students' attention in an active task by asking them to paraphrase a sentence: "*Now if you paraphrase the sentence… what do we get?*" Students attempt a more spoken, explicit version, shifting away from grammatical metaphor: "*…We found that they are learning to think more like scholars. They are also changing how they understand things…*" By engaging in such comparison, students experience the differences in language formality and information density, reinforcing their understanding of the function of grammatical metaphor.

In the **Evaluate** stage, the teacher encourages students to compare the two versions and reflect on their differences: *"How are they different then?"* Students identify key differences: "*The original sentence is shorter and the paraphrase longer. What's more, the original sentence sounds more formal and condensed, and the paraphrase is more direct and easier to understand*." This evaluative step helps them recognize the role of grammatical metaphor in making academic texts more concise and professional.

In the **Elaborate** stage, the teacher generalizes the concept to a broader academic writing context: "*How can using grammatical metaphor improve the readability and professionalism of academic texts?*" Students apply their understanding to explain the advantages: "*By using these structures, we can make our writing more concise and emphasize what's important in the discourse, right?*" The teacher further extends this idea: "*It also meets the requirements of the formal tone expected in academic articles. By mastering grammatical metaphors, you can enhance both the precision and persuasiveness of your academic arguments.*" This ensures that students understand not just how grammatical metaphor works, but why it is important in academic writing.



Fig. 12.4 Learning activity as a cycle (Rose and Martin 2012: 307)

In this learning cycle, the purpose of Prepare is to activate students' existing knowledge. The phase of Focus is to direct students' attention to the current Task, which is to paraphrase the sentence featuring grammatical metaphor. The phase of Evaluate is to compare different versions and helps students to identify distinctive patterns. The final phase of Elaborate is to generalize the function of grammatical metaphor in academic writing. It is through such design that the teacher provides careful scaffolding for students' learning.

As we can see, each phase is made up of a learning cycle. The five phases can also be interpreted as a cycle, in which each phase provides a basis for preparing the next task, as show in Fig. 12.4.

The teaching sequence takes the form of a spiral curriculum as each learning activity builds on preceding cycles. Each task becomes more challenging than the previous one. In this way, students gradually accumulate their knowledge and skills. In order to prepare students for each learning task, the teaching design should be about "guidance through interaction in the context of shared experience" (Rose and Martin 2012: 307). If students are guided through interaction based on existing experiences, they may be able to complete tasks that are beyond their competence. Such guided practice of high-level tasks helps learners to develop skills more effectively than individual practice of lower-level tasks.

In the Deconstruction stage, the teacher explicitly demonstrates how to approach an academic text, modeling analytical processes. Such instruction enables students to tackle difficult problems, which could not have been solved on their own. In the process, teachers scaffold learning by breaking down complex skills into manageable parts and guiding students through each stage. This scaffolding is tailored to the students' current level of understanding, promoting gradual and supported development. This is especially important in settings where complex academic skills are being developed, making it an essential strategy in educational contexts.

Joint Construction

The joint construction is designed as a transition stage, during which the level of teacher guidance gradually decreases. The aim is to help students employ resources

analyzed in the previous stage and develop their ability to apply genre knowledge in a supportive environment. Through such training, students progress from recognition to application, deepening their understanding of the text structure and language features of academic abstracts.

In this stage, the first task is to work on an abstract for an academic article given to the students. The teacher and students collaboratively work on the abstract. The process may involve group work. The teacher works with the class to jointly organize the ideas. Below is the first draft of the abstract.

During the last 10 years, studies on the stance markers in academic texts has increased rapidly. The aim of this study was therefore to investigate the main features as well as similarities and differences of the use of stance markers between student writers and expert writers.

Two corpora were established. This study selected forty academic texts, twenty papers from graduate student who major in foreign linguistics and applied linguistics, twenty papers from the journal in SSCI, Applied Linguistics. The study takes Hyland' theory (2005) as the theoretical basis, which divides stance markers into four categories: hedges, boosters, attitude markers and self-mentions. The author of this study tags stance markers manually and present the results as the tables of data with the help of statistical tool. Results of the study showed that the frequency of the use of stance marker of Chinese student writer is lower than expert writers. Hedges are the most frequently used stance markers. This suggests that student writers should learn the theory of stance markers and recognize the functions of them. Then they need to apply stance markers into their academic texts to express their views and communicate with readers.

The teacher guides students in structuring the abstract in a way that adheres to the academic standards and generic conventions of an abstract. This includes providing the research background, stating the research purpose, outlining research method, presenting results, and concluding with implications or recommendations. The teacher initiates the interaction as follows:

Teacher	Let's analyze the structure of the abstract and identify areas where it can be improved. Your task is to evaluate whether the abstract effectively achieves its intended purpose. Remember a well-structured abstract should briefly present the research background, purpose, methodology, findings and conclusions of the study.

Then the teacher proceeds with a step-by-step analysis:

Teacher	The abstract begins by talking about the rapid increase of studies on stance markers in academic texts over the last decade. Does this set the background for the current study? As the author says, the current research aims "to investigate the main features as well as similarities and differences of the use of stance markers between student writers and expert writers." Do you think the purpose of the research is clearly and adequately addressed?

Such instructions guide students toward discovering problems with the structure of the abstract. This can be seen in students' responses: "*No, the rapid increase does*

not tell us why we have to carry out the current research" or "*If there is rapid increase in the area, it does not tell us what gaps the current research can fill.*"

After a few rounds of negotiations, students may come up with statements like *While previous studies have focused on the use of stance markers in thesis of college students, very few studies have compared Chinese master students who major in linguistics and applied linguistics with expert writers who publish their papers on international journals.* Compared to the first version, students have shown better knowledge of how to indicate a research gap, hence justifying the current study.

Such negotiations can be guided with a list of instructions below:

- Does the abstract provide a complete overview of the study, including its significance, methodology, findings, and conclusions?
- Are there any key elements missing or any unnecessary details?
- Does the abstract maintain a balance between providing enough information to understand the research and remaining concise?
- Is the methodology clearly described? As readers, do we understand how the research was carried out? Is it detailed enough for an abstract?
- Are the results clearly and concisely presented? Do they directly relate to the research purpose stated earlier in the abstract?
- Do the conclusions and recommendations logically follow from the results presented?

The teacher should also guide students' attention to the language features typical of academic abstracts, such as nominalization, passive voice, and special lexis. The teacher helps students understand how these features function within the text to meet the expectations of academic writing. Throughout the process, the teacher engages the students in a dialogue about the choices they are making. This might include discussing why certain phrases are preferred over others, how to effectively introduce the main argument or findings, and how to make the text concise yet informative. Throughout, the teacher provides immediate feedback on the appropriateness and effectiveness of the language and content. Such dynamic teacher-student interaction helps students see how revisions should be made.

The teacher takes a text segment as an example and ask students to revise it. The teacher gives the following instruction:

Teacher	Let's see if we can make the text more academic and condensed. Here are a few guidelines to follow: Try integrating messages where possible. Use Nominalizations by changing verbs or adjectives into nouns or noun phrases. This helps create a more formal tone and makes the text shorter. Eliminate any unnecessary or wordy expressions. Let's try revising "*The study takes Hyland' theory (2005) as the theoretical basis, which divides stance markers into four categories: hedges, boosters, attitude markers and self-mentions. The author of this study tags stance markers manually and present the results as the tables of data with the help of statistical tool.*" with the above guidelines.

In the following, the teacher guides students step by step toward a revision of the segment. The negotiations are presented as follows:

Teacher	Do you find any unnecessary repetitions in the part?
S	It mentions "Hyland's theory (2005)" and "the theoretical basis," which kind of say the same thing.
T	Yes indeed! In academic writing, it's important to avoid such repetitions because you want to make your text appear concise and compact. How can we revise it then?
S	Perhaps we could simply say "draw on Hyland's (2005) theory"?
T	That sounds much better. In fact, we could even delete the words "theory" because "Hyland (2005)" itself could stand for the theory as advocated in the literature.
	Another question is, the clause *which divides stance markers into four categories: hedges, boosters, attitude markers and self-mentions* seems to sound a bit wordy, as "divide" and "categories" are sort of synonymous. Can we do anything to improve it?
S	Can we perhaps change the actions into things, like grammatical metaphor we discussed previously?
T	Great idea. Turning action into things makes the text more formal and academic. What can we do then?
S	Perhaps we could change this into "categorization of stance markers"?
T	Sounds good. Now that nominalization changes the sentence into a segment, maybe we need to combine messages into one sentence. Any suggestions?
S	We could combine this with the following sentence. We may also change the following sentence into passive voice. So we could delete the subject "the author." That makes the text sound more impersonal. Perhaps "stance markers are manually annotated…"?
T	Great idea. Such transformations make the text more academic. Remember, the purpose is to make your writing concise, clear, and appropriate for the purpose of an academic abstract

After several rounds of negotiations, the original sentence is changed into "*Drawing on Hyland's (2005) categorization, stance markers in the data are manually annotated in terms of hedges, boosters, attitude markers, and self-mentions, and are subjected to statistical treatment*." Compared to the original version, the revised version has improved in terms of its formality, objectivity and density.

Having jointly constructed an academic abstract, students are now better prepared to carry out their own writing tasks independently. They can draw on the experiences and insights gained during joint construction to produce well-structured, genre-appropriate academic texts.

Independent Construction

The independent construction phase is the final part in cultivating and assessing students' abilities to write an academic abstract. In the first two phases of scaffolded teaching, linguistic knowledge is deconstructed and gradually introduced into teaching activities, allowing students to consciously identify and use linguistic resources to construct an academic writing under the guidance of teachers, thereby developing their ability to describe key linguistic phenomena (Schleppegrell 2004). However, at the current stage, the scaffolding role of teachers is greatly reduced, and

tasks should be designed for students' independent practice. The main responsibilities of teachers are to evaluate. In this phase, teachers can first provide an academic article of a certain field, guiding students to use the learned linguistic resources for the abstract writing. Once familiar with a certain field, students can then engage in more "open-ended" writing, i.e. writing in more diverse fields, to examine their academic literacy. The purpose is to assess whether students, given an academic article, can generally write an abstract on their own. This is also the ultimate goal of cultivating academic literacy.

This structured progression from guided to independent practice is fundamental to the Sydney School's approach, ensuring that students are not just passive recipients of knowledge but active participants in their learning journey.

12.5 Conclusion

The genre-based pedagogy of the Sydney School has proved to be useful in enhancing students' literacy. The current study applied genre-based pedagogy in an ELT context to improve students' academic literacy. It has been shown how a genre-based pedagogy enhances students' understanding of text structures and linguistic features of academic abstracts. By equipping students with the ability to decode and produce genre-specific texts, this pedagogical approach directly addresses the challenges of academic literacy.

The progression from guided interactions to independent text construction has enabled students to not only master the forms and functions of academic texts but also to apply these skills in diverse and dynamic contexts. This shift from passive learning to active engagement has fostered greater confidence and competence among learners, essential for their academic success.

Furthermore, the critical and reflective aspects of genre-based pedagogy have empowered students to become self-regulated learners, capable of assessing and adapting their language use for different academic purposes. The positive outcomes of this study underscore the transformative power of integrating a genre-focused approach in ELT settings, suggesting that such a framework is not only beneficial but necessary for developing proficient and autonomous academic communicators.

As academic literacy continues to be a cornerstone of educational success in higher education and beyond, adopting genre-based pedagogy in ELT programs worldwide can provide learners with the tools they need to navigate the complexities of academic communication effectively. This study advocates for a broader implementation of this approach, urging educational stakeholders to consider its benefits and adapt it to their specific linguistic and cultural contexts to optimize learning outcomes.

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Chapter 13
Storytelling, Cohesion and EFL Teaching



Fan Dai

Abstract This paper examines the role of cohesive devices in storytelling. It argues that the use of cohesion is an indicator of the proficiency of a foreign language writer. One of the challenges of writing, when the writer doesn't use the natural temporal order, is what structure to give to the story and how to make the characters and happenings in the story coherent. Adopting Halliday and Hasan's definition for types of cohesive devices, this paper first discusses how some published writers take advantage of cohesion to make their writing work toward theme and characterization. Then analyses will focus on various extracts by EFL students in creative writing courses. The extracts either demonstrate good use or misuse of cohesive devices. They reveal that potentially, creative writing is an effective platform to showcase the writer's language proficiency, as well as an effective approach to EFL teaching.

Keywords Storytelling · EFL teaching · Cohesion · Creative writing

13.1 Introduction

Writing has always been an important course for teaching English as a foreign language (EFL hereafter) in the traditional classroom. Textbooks for writing tends to focus on grammar, and the writing is usually for specific purposes. In contrast, creative writing is often deemed as something done in one's mother tongue. Teaching creative writing as a means to teach English as a foreign language/second language is a recent phenomenon. Guidebooks for creative writing lean toward craft, its linguistic aspects usually to be dealt with in the revision and editing stage.

One common exercise of creative writing is for all students in the class to come up with one word each, which would result in a group of random words. For example: *rose*, *chicken*, *horror*, *swimming pool*, *birthday*, *bankrupt*, *London*, *seeds*, etc. Then

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every student, using all words in the list, would produce a sentence or a short paragraph to make reasonable sense. Such exercise opens up the participant's imagination, and the key is to build connection with the words that are seemingly not related. Even though students would produce different sentences and paragraphs, the common feature of their work would be cohesive devices that make the sentences and paragraphs coherent. Such exercise is the inspiration behind the current study.

Cohesion is part of the textual metafunction in Systemic Functional Linguistics (hereafter SFL). They include reference, substitution, ellipsis, conjunction and lexical cohesion (Halliday and Hasan 1976/2001). These cohesive ties create the surface level connection that gives overall coherence to the texts, which are made meaningful and easy to follow.

SFL has been very influential in linguistics, education and discourse analysis. With the aim of explaining how and why the text conveys its meaning, it has been widely applied to discourse analysis. In addition to their international counterparts' work, Chinese scholars have done extensive work in the area (e.g. Huang 1988, 2001, 2009; Hu 1994, 2018; Xin 2009; Miao 2020; Zhang and Liu 2021; Zhu 2023). In terms of language teaching, in which McCarthy (1991) took the lead, a lot of research has been done, some focusing particularly on cohesion and coherence (Lee 2002; Li et al. 2014; Chen and Cui 2022; Tabari and Wind 2023; Cui 2024; Tso 2024). Yet not much work has been done to explore the relationship between cohesion and creative writing. In other words, the attention paid to cohesive devices in language teaching tends to be limited to non-literary texts, leaving a gap in creative writing.

The author of the present paper has been a bilingual creative writer. Having come from a linguistics background, she saw the potential of creative writing in EFL teaching. Based on the author's experience as a teacher and writer, this paper will use examples of writing from published writers as well as students to demonstrate how the given stories are woven together by cohesive devices, and how such devices enhance the power in creative work. Accordingly, this paper will argue that creative writing has the potential to become an effective approach to teaching EFL.

13.2 Existing Research in Creative Writing in EFL

The teaching of creative writing has taken place in China (Dai 2010), in the United States (Hanauer 2010), in India, the Philippines and Sweden (Whetter 2021), South Africa (Law-Viljoen and Vaadevillier 2021), Brazil (Bueno 2021) and Japan (Thompson 2021). Such teaching has given rise to corresponding research. As Zyngier observes, second/foreign language creative writing makes students aware of how language works formally and functionally, and enables them to feel the subtleties of linguistic choices in a text and the effects such choices produce (Zyngier 2006).

Hanauer points out that creative writing in EFL allows students to reflect on their life experience and turn it into "authentic, meaningful, personal expression" (Hanauer 2012: 110). Dai finds that English creative writing enables EFL students to

improve English writing proficiency, develop critical thinking and share experiences (Dai 2015b, 2017a).

Evangelista (2013) holds that differences between cultures give EFL writers double perspectives in decoding life experiences. Chin (2014) argues that the EFL creative writing classroom gives students the space to interact and construct knowledge and identity as foreign language writers. Disney (2014: 2) observes that in writing in a foreign language, one "… aims for dialogical cross-cultural creative literacies, and strives to facilitate modes of meaning production inscribed with particular cultural grammars".

Both Spiro (2014) and Zhao (2015) research into the unique voices in students' EFL writing. Sui (2015) finds mixed cultural features through probing into the bilingual poems by Chinese students. You (2016) argues that students' writing in a foreign language should incorporate differences in language and culture into their work. Dai (2010, 2011, 2012, 2015a, 2015b) and Dai and Li (2021) maintain that writing in EFL trains students' critical thinking; Chinese writing in EFL, which often features culture-loaded expressions, is an irreplaceable perspective. Dai and Zheng (2019) regard writing in EFL as one kind of self-translation that gives the writer freedom in writing culture-specific element. Dai and Zheng (2023) contend that learning to write through EFL would lead to better writing in one's mother tongue, as crafting is largely the same no matter what language one writes in.

Furthermore, creative writing in EFL is a platform to showcase the achievement of the writer in language proficiency, literary studies, translation studies and cultural awareness, as well as a platform to demonstrate a writer's weakness in the above areas. This makes EFL creative writing a good medium for teaching EFL (Dai and Li 2019).

Creative writing features creativity, including the structure of the story. The chronological order, as a logical order for things to happen, is frequently replaced by more sophisticated structures. As Dai points out, writers can "… prefabricate different scenes/sections of a story and put them together to serve the purpose of storytelling" (Dai 2023: 30). The putting-together is done through cohesive devices. In other words, cohesive devices play an important role for meaning-making. Obviously, they can help produce texts that would otherwise be less effective.

13.3 Use of Cohesive Devices in Published Works

Creative writing is a practice-based activity that takes advantage of the craft that contributes to the power of the work. There have been many guidebooks on craft for fiction, nonfiction, all of which would discuss elements such as perspective, narrative voice, dialogues and thought, characters, details, which usually does not involve linguistic elements. On the other hand, the crafting of a story is materialized by how words are put together, which would eventually become an important concern at the editing stage, where accuracy of expressions including cohesive devices, as well as punctuation are given close attention.

Leech and Short hold "…the great novelists of the English language have been, arguably without exception, also great artists in the use of words, and the challenge remains of trying to explain the nature of that artistry, and how it integrates with the larger artistic achievement of the writer" (Leech and Short 1981/2001: 2). It follows that part of the artistry lies in the choice of cohesive devices, among many concerns of a linguist.

Take "Stories Matter" by Jacqui Banaszynski (2007) as an example. It is a short essay about the importance of storytelling. The essay is divided into two parts. The first part is a narrative about a famine camp in Sudan by the reporter who is the narrator of both parts. In addition to hunger, there was a severe shortage of water. Thousands of refugees walked for a long time to "a well of mud in a dry riverbed" in search of water. Among the details used to describe the situation are expressions such as "… moisture that they wring, drop by drop into their plastic jugs" (Banaszynski 2007: 3). In the face of such grave situation, the narrator heard *singing* (Italic from the writer) at night, which surprised and overwhelmed her, as singing is the last thing one would expect from such circumstances.

Obviously, the first part serves as the fact and basis for the second part of the essay, where the narrator argues for the important role of storytelling in human history. As she later found out, the singing was the *storytelling* (Italic from the writer) in the refugees' culture, which is "their version of school" (Banaszynski 2007: 4). So the words "*singing*" and "*storytelling*" serve as lexical cohesion to build connection between the two parts. The "*singing*" is the popular term for the phenomenon in the first part, while "*storytelling*" is its counterpart or synonym in the second part where the importance of storytelling in the cultural context is reflected on. Furthermore, stories are understood as "carried as much care as those precious jugs of water" (Banaszynski 2007: 4), which becomes the lexical cohesion of the previously quoted line "… moisture that they wring, drop by drop into their plastic jugs" (Banaszynski 2007: 4), thus strengthening the link between the two parts that belong to different genres, the former a narrative, the latter an argumentative.

Take Dai's "Saturday Evenings" (2017b) as another example. It is a story about a friendship that lasted for almost 30 years before the two friends lost touch for no obvious reason. It is told from the perspective of the "I" narrator who traced the relationship from its beginning to its end, reflecting on the impact her friend Huan has had on her. Huan is portrayed as someone of cheerful personality, in spite of the misfortunes in her life. She has a good laugh that goes like "hahahahaha", which is used 12 times in the story.

In fact, "hahahahaha" is not just an onomatopoeia, as in the lines "I've got a boyfriend! …. He speaks so little that I've already nicknamed him 'dead clam'! Hahahahaha …", but also other parts of speech, as is shown in the following:

> "Huan would *hahahahaha* every time I came up with something mean and funny". (verb)
>
> "Huan *hahahahaha*'ed and declared me a linguistic genius, begging for more parallel expressions." (verb)
>
> "I tried hard to imagine, shaken by the complexity of life, shaken that Huan seemed so different from her *hahahahaha* self." (adjective)

In terms of crafting, the use of "hahahahaha" is understood as Huan's characterization. In the meantime, it can also be regarded as creative use of cohesion throughout the story, as it marks and intensifies the presence of Huan every time it is used, bringing together a character that started as a cheerful teenager to a middle-aged woman who no longer had many reasons to laugh so heartily. As a cohesive device, "hahahahaha" weaves Huan's images from different periods into a fully developed character, contributing to a narrative where Huan eventually lost her innocence in the observant eye of the narrator.

The two examples above are among numerous cases of crafting through which writers build coherence throughout their stories. Such coherence requires that the writers have a very clear sense of what they want to deliver and how they want to deliver it. It follows that the ability to adopt cohesive devices effectively reflects a writer's language proficiency.

The following section will examine how EFL students who are learners of creative writing use cohesive devices. Extracts are mostly from undergraduate students at Sun Yat-sen University, China.

13.4 Writing from EFL Learners

One undergraduate student wrote about her experiences of teaching Chinese to primary school pupils in Nepal in one summer program. One of the pupils became interested in America as follows:

> "My uncle in America brings me a bag of chocolate". "My uncle in America tells me about the Grammies", "My uncle in America writes me letter with this eagle stamp"… It was mostly under these circumstances, when Swashani was mentioning her uncle, that she would talk too carelessly to mind her irregular teeth.

The obvious repetition of "my uncle in America" serves as the cohesive device whenever Swashani referred to her uncle, to show her fascination for America. Instead of "My uncle in America brings …", "he tells me …", "he writes me …", which is the more commonly used anaphoric reference in such context, the writer uses lexical cohesion "my uncle in America" three times, making "in America" an indispensable identity of the uncle. As a result, Swashani's keen interest for America is reinforced. Such lexical cohesion demonstrates the student writer's grasp of its function.

In the meantime, the "uncle" in "It was under these circumstances, when Swashani was mentioning her uncle …" isn't presented as "uncle in America" further demonstrates the writer's understanding of the difference between "My uncle in America" and "uncle": the former is Swanshani's perspective; the latter is the narrator's perspective which does not share Swanshani's fascination for America. Here, not repeating "my uncle in America" further demonstrates the writer's good understanding of the uncle's image in Swashani's eyes.

One other undergraduate student wrote a piece of nonfiction called "Miss Nightmare", telling the story of the time when she suffered from anxiety in high school. She

was in a half-dream, half-awake state for days in a row, which eventually exhausted her to the point of passing out in the classroom. The writer wrote about the third of such days, "May I call you Miss Nightmare? Since you wear red high heels, I assume you are a woman".

Once it was named, "Miss Nightmare" appeared 9 times in the story, symbolizing the pressure from teachers, including the math teacher in whose course the narrator did not perform well. A close examination of reference reveals that the anaphoric references of "Miss Nightmare" are all capitalized as in:

> SHE was alive.
>
> SHE must have heard it.

Meanwhile, the corresponding possessive pronoun "her" is also capitalized as in:

> HER brain wriggled.
>
> HER brain was wriggling.

The above expressions reveal the student writer's good understanding of cohesion and its effective use in the story. The student also wrote about her recovery, after which she no longer dreamed: "I haven't seen Miss Nightmare for a long time. Maybe it's a good thing not to see her. I wish her all the best".

It is worth noting that "Miss Nightmare" was no longer referred as "HER" but the lowercase "her", indicating that "Miss Nightmare" has no more power over her.

In addition, the narrator uses "spider's web" 7 times to describe her physical state in her continuous nightmare, which is first used in "my body seemed to be under an invisible control, as if a bug trapped in a spider's web".[1] With more underlined expressions, "nobody would care whether something was stuck on a spider's web or not" and "Day three, on the spider's web. Time for sleep paralysis and nightmare", the writer establishes a lexical set around "spider's web", an important syndrome of her nightmare, where she is suffocated and demobilized by the pressure from school.

Besides, before the narrator finds the name "Miss Nightmare", she describes the mysterious being as "it", which produced "crisp sound, the sound of someone walking in high heels". She continues to describe the horror of the nightmare below:

> Danger approaching. Who is it? Is it the spider coming to enjoy its prey? Help.
>
> Let me go! Move! Why can't I move?!
>
> Da, da, da. **IT** got closer and closer, as if stepping on my heart, with each step **IT** took, my heart ached as if pricked by a needle. The sound stopped at the edge of the bed. **IT WAS RIGHT BEHIND ME**. I was about to vomit all my internal organs out in the next second. **IT** sat down, on my bed. I wanted to run. I couldn't move. I'm going crazy.

As shown in the underlined "it" in the two-line paragraph, the mysterious being comes to the narrator in her dream from the distance and therefore not so terrifying, and so it is referred to as "it". As it comes nearer, and has the effect of stepping on the dreamer's heart, it becomes capitalized "IT", which obviously poses a threat.

[1] Quotes from students' work are all in their original states.

Such uses of "it" and "IT" are consistent with the effect produced by "SHE", "HER", "spider's web" and "her", etc., working toward the overall coherence which shows the state of the narrator under the pressure from school and ultimately coming out of it.

The following is from a graduate student's work, which is about her effort to get to a good graduate school:

> It comes out, finally.
>
> English major, f(F)rench major...translation major, yes, here *it* is.
>
> Yu, yes, number one in our major. **The next** is....
>
> **It**'s me!
>
> My name appeared in the postgraduate recommendation list just as I dreamed for three years.

There are 3 sets of the reference "it" and its corresponding expressions. The underlined set refers to the "the postgraduate recommendation list". The italic set refers to the name list for recommended translation majors, which is part of the "the postgraduate recommendation list". The set in bold refers to the individual name of the recommended translation majors. Therefore, all the "it's" are related. It is evident that the writer is very familiar with the use of cataphoric and anaphoric references. The first cataphoric "it" in particular, is used to captivate the reader's curiosity.

Three pages later in the story, the writer wrote "Finally, now, in my fourth year of college, I saw my name in the list. My dream list", where "the list", "my dream list" refer to "the postgraduate recommendation list". In spite of the fact that... it is very far away from the first time it was mentioned, it is almost treated as a proper noun. This highlights the importance of entering the graduate school of a prestigious university for the narrator, which is further revealed in the following:

> Entering a prestigious university has been my dream since my first day in middle school—a decade-long aspiration ending in my last year in undergraduate college.
>
> Therefore, I *dedicated* myself to mastering the subjects required for exams, *disregarding* **my interests** and life outside of school. After all, securing a place at an excellent university is considered the most crucial step in one's life, worth *sacrificing* everything, let alone **one's hobbies**.

In the above paragraph, there are three sets of cohesive devices that are underlined, italicized and in bold, respectively. "Entering a prestigious university", "a decade-long aspiration" and "securing a place at an excellent university" are synonyms that refer to the dream of the narrator. In the meantime, the narrator uses "dedicated" vs. "disregarding" and "sacrificing", which are antonyms to refer to what she had to do in order to fulfill her dream, while "my interests" and "one's hobbies" are synonyms for what she needed to sacrifice for her dream.

All of the above lexical cohesion work together to weave the story of a college student whose only purpose in that period of time was to go to a good graduate school. The lexical sets produce an emphatic narrative that is saddening to read. The following dialogue shows how the narrator stuck to her determination:

> "Do you want to have a dinner at the new restaurant near our college?"
>
> "I'd love to, but I have homework, so..."
>
> "Do you want to hang out with us?"
>
> "Definitely! But...maybe next time?"
>
> "How about watching a talk show?"
>
> "Sure, but when? I'm busy this week..." There is a pattern of the narrator expressing willingness to do what her classmates/friends invited her to do, followed by the adversative conjunction that negates it. Such pattern corresponds to the earlier example and provides instances of how the narrator disregarded her longing for some fun yet chose to sacrifice her interests.
>
> Before long, the narrator realizes the following:
>
> But my obsession with it didn't nurture me; it consumed me.

Eventually, she had the presence of mind to call her way of life as "obsession", and used "nurture" and "consume" that are antonyms in the context. The following lines are further evidence of the harm done to the narrator:

> … visiting high school teachers who held strong belief towards me was a shame for me, so was meeting a high school classmate who witnessed my pride and failure.

This example, containing the underlined clausal substitution, demonstrates that the writer is good at yet another kind of cohesion.

It was not until after the narrator knew that she was in the recommendation list that she began to reflect on the way she had led her life, and she saw things in different light:

> I discovered that the trees behind our classrooms had grown from seeds planted when I was a freshman. I noticed that the sky above was always blue and clear, turning yellow instead of dark when it rained. I recognized the scent that had tantalized me was from blooming osmanthus. I found that some white birds with black backs always sang at 10 o'clock in the morning on the balcony. I realized that walking from my dorm to college wasn't as time-consuming as I had imagined; it turned out that I could totally walk myself everywhere.

The underlined words, obviously, are synonyms in the context. The resulting lexical cohesion gives the narrator a perspective that she had chosen not to adopt, presenting a world in which she is likely to be "nurtured".

As the above analyses show, the writer demonstrates the ability of using cohesive devices that include references, substitution, lexical cohesion and conjunction, to put coherence in the narrative about a student who made it her only purpose to enter a graduate program of a prestigious university, at the cost of ignoring all other aspects of her life, and then came to realize that she has missed many good things in life.

At the end of the story, the writer, having recognized the same desire for going to a good university in one student, manages to compensate her regret by giving advice to the student in the high school where she was doing an internship, ending the story as follows:

> I believe there will be a day when she can escape from the idea of "topping the list to live."
>
> I know she will.

Although "the list" here refers to the ranking list in the class where the high school was, which is different from the narrator's list in the earlier part of the story, the urge for being on top of the class in order to get to a good university is the same like the narrator's desire for graduate school. The "will" in "she will" is a case of verbal ellipsis, cutting the clause short, producing the effect of the narrator being very confident of her passing on her lesson to the younger student.

In short, the above examples are illustration of the writer's good grasp of cohesion and her ability to use it effectively.

The qualitative studies of the work of creative writing in this section provides a platform to showcase students' performance in EFL studies, with particular focus on their achievements in using cohesive devices. Arguably, it is the result of craft taught in the creative writing course.

13.5 Error Detection Through Cohesive Devices in EFL Writing

Following the above statement about students' creative work showcasing their achievements in EFL creative writing, this section focuses on how such a platform can also serve as one where students' lack of effective use of cohesion can be detected and improved.

Going back to the "Miss Nightmare" story, the narrator described the nightmare dream on one of the days when she suffered from the pressure of school:

> Miss Nightmare stood in front of me. Her brain was wriggling. SHE was alive.
>
> SHE must have heard it.

This part of narrative is where Miss Nightmare exerts power over the narrator. As discussed in the last section, the anaphoric reference "SHE" is capitalized as indication of how fearful the image "Miss Nightmare" was for the narrator. And earlier in the narrative, the narrative goes like below:

> Day four on the spider's web. Miss Nightmare stood in front of me. What's coming today? I asked.
>
> HER brain was wriggling.

The use of "HER" in the above two examples is consistent with "SHE" in the earlier example, which is evidence of the writer's awareness and intention of the capitalization being part of the function of the lexical cohesion. Therefore, it is more than likely that "Her brain was wriggling" is an oversight of the writer. Given the function of capitalization as coherence that features Miss Nightmare's power over the narrator, such oversight does lessen the effect. Pointing this out in such context can easily convince the writer that changing "Her" to "HER" would work better for this part of the narration.

Apparently, both writers of "Miss Nightmare" and "The Road Taken" are fully aware of the role of cohesion and coherence in the story. They have built their stories

through cohesive devices that play an important role to make the stories coherent, consistent and effective. However, many student writers do not use cohesive devices as consciously for intended effect, as the following examples will demonstrate.

> Without doubt, scores are all Chinese parents' bottom line on the *Zao Lian* problem, as well as teachers.

If one is not careful, these clauses would appear to be fine with "as well as" as the additive conjunction emphasizing similarity between the bottom line of the Chinese parents and that of the teachers on the *Zao Lian* (falling in love at too early an age) problem. However, when "as well as teachers" are used, the corresponding grammatical counterpart becomes "scores" instead of "Chinese parents". It is only when "teachers" are written as "teacher's" that the right coherence is achieved.

Again, this particular example shows the learner writer the importance of getting the cohesion right. It also strengthens the writer's grammatical sense.

The following example is not a case of wrong grammar, but one of less desired anaphoric reference:

> She was completely weighed down by the stress of examinations. There were always a million of homework and tests waiting for you on the road. No way out. She wanted to sleep, she was dying for sleep...

In the above paragraph, the "you" can serve as anaphoric reference for "she" in "she was completely weighed down …", and a cataphoric one for the "she" in "she wanted to sleep …", if "there were always a million of homework …" is considered the free direct thought of "she" as the narrator in the third-person point of view. But in fact, it works better if it is turned into free indirect thought in which case the clause would become "… waiting for her on the road", as the reference "her" would not be foregrounded as "you", since there is no particular reason to make "you" stand out, making the narrative voice louder than usual.

Given the above analysis, there is no absolute right or wrong in using "you" or "her" as the reference. But the student writer can see the different effect to the paragraph and can decide for herself which effect serves better.

The following is from one student writer's work (Dai 2023: 195) in terms of consistency:

> Nov 7, 1997. In a village.
>
> …
>
> Year 2000. In a wet and messy room.
>
> …
>
> Year 2001. On a rusty 28 bicycle.
>
> …
>
> Year 2003. On the weedy road leading to a messy complex of buildings.
>
> …
>
> Year 2005. On the weedy road leading to a messy complex of buildings.
>
> …

Year 2009. On a cold, dark, rainy day in fall.

…

Year 2009. In a junior high school.

…

It can also be discussed from the perspective of coherence. The above times and locations are the beginnings of corresponding paragraphs in the story. There is an obvious different expression in both time and location patterns: the year 1997 stands out with the exact date, while the rest of the time indicators are the year; in the meantime, the location for it is "In a village" while the other locations are very specific. It turned out that November 7, 1997, was the narrator's birthday. Given the time indicator pattern in the text, one would expect the location to be a specific house instead of a village.

Furthermore, "On a cold, dark, rainy day in fall" in year 2009 has the only time reference while all others following the time indicator are location references. And what happened on the rainy day in the story does not justify the foregrounding put on the day.

Therefore, the above discrepancies in location and time can be reminders for relevant writer to consider whether it is necessary to give better coherence in the forms of expressions. Although there is no need to label what is right or wrong in storytelling, this case reveals that writers can put more thought to the use of cohesive device if it serves their purposes better.

The discussion in the above two sections, through examples of the work by published writers and students, argues for the indispensable role that cohesion plays in the writing of stories. Cohesive devices can enhance the effectiveness of the story, and are indications of the writers' understanding and mastery of the cohesive devices. In the context of EFL teaching, analysis of the use or inappropriate use of cohesive devices allows students to see the different effects brought about by the use or change of cohesive devices, and enables them to fully understand cohesion.

13.6 Summary

Creative writing in English as a foreign language offers a new perspective to EFL teaching. It provides a self-made text by student writers to demonstrate what they can achieve with the language. This paper, guided by the cohesion theory, examines extracts by published writers as well as student writers to show how cohesive devices can contribute to the power of a story, and how the analysis of cohesive devices can enhance EFL teaching. Arguably, teaching through student's own writing would yield better outcome.

It is hoped that, given more teaching and research, EFL creative writing, through which students write with personal interest, feelings and creativity, will prove to be a promising approach to let students learn how to mean more effectively and efficiently.

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Chapter 14
Communicating Crises During the Pandemic: A Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study of CSR Reports by Top Corporations of China and the US



Ming Liu and Yang Yang

Abstract This study integrates text mining into discourse analysis to provide a corpus-assisted discourse investigation of crisis communication during the pandemic in the CSR reports of leading corporations in China and the US. Drawing on the theories and methods of text mining, corpus linguistics, and systemic functional linguistics, this research reveals not only the foregrounding of danger as a prominent theme in Chinese and American CSR reports but also their distinct preferences in representing these dangers. The findings highlight not only cultural differences in crisis communication during the pandemic but, more importantly, the potential for a balanced integration, or "synergy", of systemic functional linguistics and text mining in corpus-assisted discourse studies.

Keywords Corporate social responsibility · CSR report · Corporations · Text mining · Corpus linguistics · Systemic functional linguistics · Corpus-assisted discourse study

14.1 Introduction

In an era of heightened global risks, such as environmental disasters, public health emergencies, social unrest, and corporate scandals, organizations are increasingly vulnerable to crises. These crises can damage stakeholder relationships, erode trust, disrupt operations, and harm reputations (Coombs and Holladay 2015; Coombs

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2022; Fehre and Weber 2016). Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) communication has emerged as a critical tool for managing such crises, enabling organizations to demonstrate accountability, empathy, and a commitment to societal well-being (Brennan et al. 2013; Coombs 2022). Understanding how CSR messages can be tailored to specific crises provides valuable insights into how organizations can respond effectively and minimize harm.

The COVID-19 pandemic created a unique crisis context that disrupted business operations, supply chains, and social norms, forcing companies to adapt their CSR strategies. Studying CSR communication during the pandemic provides an opportunity to analyse how organizations used language, narratives, and discursive strategies to maintain or restore legitimacy (Bondi and Nocella 2023; Giacomini et al. 2021; Poppi 2022; Uysal and Aksak 2022). The global nature of the pandemic exposed significant cross-cultural and industry-specific differences in CSR communication. Cultural dimensions such as power distance, collectivism, and regulatory environments influenced how companies in different regions framed their CSR narratives (Bondi and Nocella 2023; Hofstede et al. 2010; Zhang and Chen 2024). Examining these variations helps illuminate how cultural and contextual factors shape CSR strategies during crises, offering practical lessons for organizations operating in diverse environments.

Therefore, this study gives a corpus-assisted discourse study of the CSR reports of 30 top corporations in China and the US. The primary purpose is to examine how the crises are represented in Chinese and American CSR reports to construct a positive image of those corporations and how these representations vary with different cultures. It aims to answer three research questions: (1) How do Chinese and American corporations vary in their CSR reports? (2) How do Chinese and American corporations vary in their ways of representing the crises caused by the pandemic? (3) What are the socio-cultural factors behind their ways of representing the crises?

14.2 Previous Studies on CSR Communication During Crises

Crises, as both threats and opportunities, provide a unique context for CSR communication and have significantly shaped how corporations communicate with stakeholders (Giacomini et al. 2021; Park et al. 2024). During such challenging times, businesses are expected to actively respond to societal needs and demonstrate their role as "good corporate citizens", thereby maintaining or restoring public trust and legitimacy (Fuoli and Paradis 2014; Lin 2019). While companies often excel in showcasing their CSR performance during stable periods, their ability to sustain a sound reputation during crises remains less understood despite the fact that their long-term success is often defined by these moments (Poole 2016). Therefore, CSR communication during crises offers unique opportunities to examine how crises shape the communication strategies of CSR reports.

Previous studies have extensively examined corporate communication during crises across various genres, including written reports (Beelitz and Merkl-Davies 2012; Zhang and Chen 2024), CEO letters and speeches (Fuoli and Paradis 2014; Poole 2016, 2017), corporate websites (Bondi and Nocella 2023; Poppi 2022), newspapers (Herzig and Moon 2013; Joutsenvirta and Vaara 2015), and social media platforms (Dong et al. 2023; Giacomini et al. 2021). These studies have explored both endogenous crises, such as corporate scandals and stakeholder conflicts, and exogenous crises, including natural disasters, health emergencies, economic downturns, and political shocks crisis (O'Connor 2022; Torreggiani and De Giacomo 2022). Across these contexts, linguistic resources and discursive strategies have emerged as critical tools to repair trust and legitimacy.

Previous studies have also revealed some typical strategies used in CSR communication during crises. For instance, Fuoli and Paradis (2014) analysed CEO letters from oil firms following an oil spill and identified two primary strategies: avoiding or mitigating blame through negation, epistemic modals, and evidential markers, and enhancing positive narratives through evaluative language and affective appeals. Similarly, Breeze (2012) highlighted how oil companies used survivor narratives and hybrid discourses, blending financial, scientific, and environmental themes, to legitimize their actions and position themselves as responsible actors during crises. Other studies, such as Valdebenito (2013), have shown how companies employ linguistic mechanisms like passive voice, grammatical metaphors, and first-person plural pronouns to construct a positive corporate image while distancing themselves from blame.

Some other studies have also drawn attention to the narrative and stylistic shifts in crisis-related CSR communication and found that companies often balance dynamic, empathy-driven language with impersonal and distanced tones to manage public perception. For example, Corciolani et al. (2019) noted that corporations use dynamic language (e.g., personal pronouns, emotion-laden adjectives) to foster stakeholder empathy while relying on abstract and vague language (e.g., nominalization, impersonal nouns) to avoid direct accountability. Additionally, futurity-oriented discourse is a common strategy during crises, particularly among poorly performing firms. Such discourse emphasizes forward-looking strategies, vision, and plans, projecting optimism to reassure stakeholders (Poole 2017).

The COVID-19 pandemic has further redefined CSR communication, offering unique insights into how companies adapt their narratives in unprecedented crises. Some studies have revealed that corporations increasingly rely on rhetorical appeals, i.e., logos (logic), ethos (credibility), and pathos (emotion), to shape their responses. For instance, Poppi (2022) found that CEO letters from the airline and tourism sectors used emotional appeals to seek empathy, rational appeals to emphasize credibility, and assertive language to mitigate failures. Similarly, Uysal and Aksak (2022) highlighted philanthropic narratives and war metaphors in Fortune 500 companies' pandemic responses, portraying businesses as leaders in the global fight against COVID-19. These studies reflect a shift towards empathetic, people-centric CSR communication, emphasizing shared experiences and adaptability.

Furthermore, previous studies have also revealed cross-cultural differences in CSR communication. Chinese companies, for example, adopt a **mandatory approach** to CSR, aligning their communication with government regulations and socio-political agendas, while Anglo-American firms emphasize voluntary, market-driven CSR (Bhatia 2012). Linguistically, Chinese firms often use formal, distant tones and direct quotations referencing government policies, whereas Western firms favour informal, self-referential styles, and business-specific terminology (Lin 2021; Ngai et al. 2020). During crises, Chinese companies tend to focus on deflection and mitigation strategies, while their Anglo-American counterparts employ a broader range of rhetorical resources, including admissions and apologies. These differences reflect deeper cultural dimensions, such as China's collectivism and high power-distance versus Western individualism and low power-distance. However, few studies have given a cross-cultural examination of CSR communication by Chinese and American corporations during the pandemic.

14.3 Corpus-Assisted Discourse Studies

Corpus-assisted discourse studies (CADS) is an approach that underlines the balanced combination or "synergy" of corpus linguistics and (critical) discourse analysis (Baker et al. 2008; Partington et al. 2004). Corpus linguistics offers tools to systematically analyse linguistic patterns in large textual datasets, while discourse analysis situates these patterns within broader social, cultural, and ideological contexts (Baker and McEnery 2015; Liu 2024; Liu et al. 2022). This dual approach makes CADS particularly effective for examining large samples of data on media and political discourses, such as media discourses on immigrants (Baker et al. 2008), Muslims (Baker et al. 2013), and climate change (Liu and Huang 2024), as well as different types of political discourses (Liu 2022). Recently, with advancements in computational linguistics and text mining, CADS has sought to integrate more sophisticated computer-assisted analytical methods into (critical) discourse analysis (Liu 2024; Poole 2022). However, there is no established framework for combining the methods and theories of corpus linguistics with (critical) discourse analysis. Analysts must test the data and determine the most suitable toolkits for integrating corpus linguistics with critical discourse analysis. In other words, during the analysis, analysts must continuously move between findings generated by corpus-analytic tools and the examination of language patterns within their specific contexts of use. This iterative process helps to formulate the most relevant questions for the data and to identify the most appropriate analytical methods (Morley and Bayley 2009).

While earlier studies primarily relied on manual qualitative analysis to examine corporate communication during crises (Beelitz and Merkl-Davies 2012; Lin 2019, 2021), more recent research has increasingly adopted quantitative corpus linguistic methods, such as word frequency analysis (Park et al. 2024), keyness, collocation, and concordance (Bondi and Nocella 2023; Poole 2016, 2017). Additionally, some recent studies have turned to innovative computational linguistic approaches,

including topic modelling (Jaworska and Nanda 2018; Torreggiani and De Giacomo 2022), natural language processing (NLP) (Giacomini et al. 2021), and semantic network analysis (Park et al. 2024). However, these studies often feature an imbalanced integration of computational linguistic methods and discourse analysis theories. They tend to excel in automated corpus analysis but fall short in linguistic analysis, resulting in findings that are effective at identifying general language patterns but lacking in deeper linguistic insights. To address this gap, this study advocates for a "synergy" between text mining and discourse analysis (Liu 2024), drawing on the insights from text mining and systemic functional linguistics (SFL).

14.4 Data and Methodology

14.4.1 Data Collection and Corpus Building

The analysis in this study focuses on two large self-built corpora, namely the China Corpus (hereafter CC) and the US Corpus (hereafter UC). Each corpus consists of 30 CSR reports published in 2020 by 30 top corporations in China and the US. Table 14.1 shows the list of 30 corporations in China and the US. They are selected because they rank among the top 100 corporations in China and the US, respectively, by the Fortune magazine published in 2020 (Fortune, 2020). Since not all corporations published CSR reports, the top 30 corporations with CSR reports were selected. The year 2020 was selected because it represents the starting year of the pandemic. All the CSR reports were downloaded from each corporation's official website and converted from the PDF version into the plain text version. They were further built into two large corpora, namely, the US corpus (UC) and the China corpus (CC). The former consists of 837,388 tokens (28,555 types), the latter 842,036 tokens (24,992 types).

14.4.2 Analytic Methods and Procedure

This study utilizes the online corpus-analytic tool Wmatrix 5.0 and the text-mining tool KH Coder. Unlike traditional corpus analysis tools that primarily focus on word frequencies and collocations, Wmatrix enables users to analyse texts at a deeper level by classifying words into semantic domains and grammatical categories (Rayson 2008). This allows researchers to uncover not only surface-level language patterns but also the underlying meanings and functions of words in context (Huang and Liu 2025; Liu and Huang 2022; Liu and Wu 2015). KH Coder is an open-source software tool designed for quantitative content analysis and text mining, widely applied in fields such as linguistics, social sciences, business, and health research (Higuchi

Table 14.1 Top 100 corporations in China and the US (30 selected)

Number	US		China	
	Company	Link	Company	Link
1	Walmart	https://corporate.walmart.com/	Sinopec	http://www.sinopec.com/listco/en/
2	Amazon	https://www.aboutamazon.com/	China National Petroleum	https://www.cnpc.com.cn/en/index.shtml
3	Exxon Mobile	https://www.exxonmobil.com	ICBC (Industrial & Commercial Bank of China)	https://www.icbc.com.cn/ICBCLtd/en/default.htm
4	UnitedHealth	https://www.unitedhealthgroup.com	CCB (China Construction Bank)	https://ccb.com/eng/home/index.shtml
5	McKesson	https://www.mckesson.com	ABC (Agricultural Bank of China)	https://www.abchina.com/en
6	AT&T	https://about.att.com/	BOC (Bank of China)	https://www.boc.cn/en
7	AmerisourceBergen	https://www.amerisourcebergen.com	China Life Insurance	https://www.chinalife.com.hk/
8	Ford Motor	https://www.ford.com	Huawei Investment & Holding	https://www.huawei.com/en
9	CIGNA	https://www.thecignagroup.com/	SAIC Motor	https://www.saicmotor.com/english/index.shtml
10	Chevron	https://www.chevron.com	China Railway Construction	https://english.crcc.cn/col/col21575/index.html
11	Cardinal Health	https://www.cardinalhealth.com	China Mobile Communications	https://www.chinamobileltd.com/en/global/home.php
12	JPMorganChase	https://www.jpmorganchase.com	China Resources	https://en.crc.com.cn/companyataglance/index.html
13	General Motors	https://www.gm.com	China Minmetals	http://www.minmetals.com/english/

(continued)

Table 14.1 (continued)

Number	US		China	
	Company	Link	Company	Link
14	Walgreens Boots Alliance	https://www.walgreensbootsalliance.com	JD.com	https://corporate.jd.com/
15	Verizon	https://www.verizon.com/about	Sinochem	https://www.sinochem.com/zhjten/index.html
16	Microsoft	https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/about?msockid=0036c031c4aa6b282559d406c5586ad3	China Baowu Steel Group	https://www.baowugroup.com/en
17	Marathon Petroleum	https://www.marathonpetroleum.com	PICC (People's Insurance Co. of China)	https://picc.e-ciie.com/
18	Kroger	https://www.thekrogerco.com/	CITIC (China International Trust Investment Corporation)	https://www.citic.com/en
19	Home Depot	https://corporate.homedepot.com/	COFCO (China Oil and Foodstuffs Corporation)	https://www.cofco.com/en
20	Phillips 66	https://www.phillips66.com	Sinopharm	http://en.sinopharm.com/
21	Anthem	https://www.anthem.com/	Country Garden	https://www.countrygarden.com.cn/en/home
22	Wells Fargo	https://www.wellsfargo.com	China Evergrande	https://www.evergrande.com/en/Home/index
23	Citi	https://www.citigroup.com	PowerChina	https://en.powerchina.cn/
24	Valero Energy	https://www.valero.com	China Telecommunications	https://www.chinatelecom-h.com/en/global/home.php/

(continued)

Table 14.1 (continued)

Number	US		China	
	Company	Link	Company	Link
25	General Electric	https://www.ge.com	CNBM (China National Building Mate	https://www.cnbm.com.cn/EN/
26	Dell Technologies	https://www.dell.com/en-us	CMB (China Merchants Bank)	https://english.cmbchina.com/Corporate/
27	Johnson & Johnson	https://www.jnj.com	CPIC (China Pacific Insurance)	https://en.cpic.com.cn/
28	Target	https://corporate.target.com/	GAC (Guangzhou Automobile Com)	https://www.gac.com.cn/en/?ref=cybrhome
29	IBM (International Business Machines)	https://www.ibm.com	China Vanke	https://www.vanke.com/en/home
30	BOEING	https://www.boeing.com	IB (Industrial Bank)	https://www.cib.com.cn/en/

2016, 2017). KH Coder can help perform such tasks as word frequency analysis, co-occurrence analysis, topic modelling, cluster analysis, and correspondence analysis.

This study begins by comparing the two corpora with the BNC Sampler Written Corpus to identify their key Semantic Categories (SMCs). Key SMCs refer to those semantic categories that are statistically significant in the subject corpus when compared with the general reference corpus (Rayson 2008). These categories can suggest the topics and themes prevalent in the subject corpus (Liu and Wu 2015). The analysis focuses on the top 20 key SMCs for each corpus to identify their preferences for these semantic categories.

Subsequently, the study narrows its focus to one particular key SMC, i.e., A15- ("Danger"), which may reflect the influence of the pandemic. The analysis examines the different strategies used to represent dangers in the two corpora. Using KH Coder, the study identifies words that co-occur with representative terms of "Danger" (e.g., *risk*, *danger*, *hazard*). Furthermore, KH Coder allows filtering of strong co-occurring words based on their parts-of-speech (POS). This study examines the strong co-occurring adjectives, verbs, adverbs, and nouns separately to determine their respective ways of conceptualizing dangers in terms of the categories, qualities, and measures taken to address these dangers. Particular insights will be drawn from SFL (Halliday 1994) to categorize these adjectives, verbs, adverbs, and nouns in order to reveal their respective ways of representing dangers in their respective socio-cultural contexts.

14.5 Findings

14.5.1 Analysis of Key Semantic Categories

Among the top 20 key semantic categories (see Table 14.2), 12 are the same, including "Helping" (S8+), "Business: Generally" (I2.1), "Unmatched" (Z99), "Green issues" (W5), "General actions/making" (A1.1.1), "Belonging to a group" (S5+), "Work and employment: Generally" (I3.1), "Business: Selling" (I2.2), "Danger" (A15-), "Science and technology in general" (Y1), "Information and technology and computing" (Y2), and "Safe" (A15+). Their typical tokens are as follows:

- **I2.1**: *company*, *business*, *enterprises*, *economy*, *enterprise*
- **I2.2**: *customers*, *customer*, *suppliers*, *sales*, *market*, supply chain
- **W5**: *environmental*, *environment*, *ecological*, *energy conservation*
- **I3.1**: *employees*, *work*, *employee*, *working*, *staff*, *workers*
- **Y1**: *technology*, *technologies*, *technological*, *technical*, *scientific*, *science*
- **Y2**: *online*, *digital*, *internet*, *offline*, *website*, *information technology*
- **S5+**: *institutions*, *network*, *chain*, *communities*, *members*, *branches*, *units*
- **S8+**: *protection*, *services*, *support*, *promote*, *help*, *promoted*
- **A1.1.1**: *project*, *projects*, *production*, *operation*, *activities*, *process*
- **A15+**: *safety*, *safe*, *safely*, *safety work*, *safeguard*, *safety department*
- **A15-**: *risk*, *risks*, *hazardous*, *hazards*, *hazard*, *exposure*, *high-risk*

These categories align with Moon's (2002) three waves of social responsibility reporting: (a) social responsible production and process (I2.1, I2.2, A1.1.1, Y1, and Y2), (b) employee relations (I3.1, A15+), and (c) community involvement (W5) (Liu and Wu 2015). According to Strafella (2011), wave (a) focuses on shareholders, business partners, and customer relations; wave (b) emphasizes employee relations, such as health, safety, and training; wave (c) addresses community issues, environment, and philanthropy. However, both China and the US underline "Danger" (A15-). This can be attributed to the crises triggered by the pandemic.

However, CC shows the preferences for "Government" (G1.1), "In power" (S7.1+), "Evaluation: Good" (A5.1+), "Money: Lack" (I1.1-), "Industry" (I4), "Change" (A2.1+), "Evaluation: Good/bad" (A5.1), "Places" (M7). Their typical tokens are as follows:

- **G1.1**: *system*, *governance*, *country*, *government*, *welfare*, *state*, *governments*, *state-owned*
- **S7.1+**: *management*, *control*, *committee*, *power*, *supervision*, *organized*, *leading*
- **A5.1+**: *improve*, *improved*, *improving*, *high-quality*, *enhance*, *great*, *improvement*
- **I1.**1-: *poverty*, *poor*, *impoverished*, *in need*, *low-income*, *needy*, *poverty line*
- **I4**: *industrial*, *industry*, *industries*, *mining*, *factory*, *mine*, *production line*, *industrialization*
- **A2.1+:** *development*, *transformation*, *developed*, *change*, *reform*, *develop*, *become*
- **A5.1**: *quality*, *standards*, *evaluation*, *standard*, *rating*, *appraisal*, *ranked*, *evaluate*

Table 14.2 Top 20 key SMCs of the two corpora

	CN			US		
Rank	Tagset	LL	SMC	Tagset	LL	SMC
1	S8+	7405.73	Helping	Z99	8003.34	Unmatched
2	I2.1	6651.79	Business: generally	S8+	7119.19	Helping
3	Z99	5091.62	Unmatched	I3.1	4981.25	Work and employment: generally
4	W5	5045.28	Green issues	S5+	4613.42	Belonging to a group
5	G1.1	4166.73	Government	I2.2	4516.56	Business: selling
6	A1.1.1	3939.94	General actions / making	I2.1	3750.11	Business: generally
7	S5+	3933.36	Belonging to a group	A1.8+	3150.74	Inclusion
8	S7.1+	3793.37	In power	Y2	3102.85	Information technology and computing
9	A5.1+	3582.41	Evaluation: good	W5	2694.02	Green issues
10	I3.1	3514.15	Work and employment: generally	B2	2381.1	Health and disease
11	I2.2	3438.55	Business: selling	A9-	2298.51	Giving
12	I1.1-	2738.6	Money: lack	A15-	2149.23	Danger
13	A15-	2549.23	Danger	A15+	1950.74	Safe
14	I4	2476.32	Industry	A1.1.1	1870.07	General actions / making
15	A2.1+	2302.02	Change	Y1	1770.25	Science and technology in general
16	A5.1	2258.94	Evaluation: good/bad	X2.2	1671.56	Knowledge
17	Y1	2211.76	Science and technology in general	T2++	1613.17	Time: beginning
18	Y2	2181.46	Information technology and computing	B3	1407.7	Medicines and medical treatment
19	M7	1985.27	Places	X2.2+	1321.65	Knowledgeable
20	A15+	1898.66	Safe	N5++	1273.61	Quantities: many/much

- **M7**: *areas*, *local*, *international*, *national*, *area*, *province*, *regions*, *counties*

The prominence of I1.1- reflects those corporations' alignment with the Chinese government's poverty elimination initiative. Categories such as "Government" (G1.1) and "In Power" (S7.1+) highlight the involvement of state institutions and hierarchical leadership in shaping CSR priorities. Additionally, a strong focus on positive evaluation (A5.1+, A5.1) and industrial development (I4 and A2.1+) underscores China's emphasis on measurable progress, national stability, and economic growth. Therefore, China's CSR reports underline government alignment, control mechanisms, and industrial progress, reflecting the nation's collectivist culture and state-driven development agenda (Bhatia 2012; Dong et al. 2023; Lin 2021).

UC shows the preferences for "Inclusion" (A1.8+), "Health and disease" (B2), "Giving" (A9-), "Knowledge" (X2.2), "Time: Beginning" (T2++), "Medicine and medical treatment" (B3), "Knowledgeable" (X2.2+), "Quantities: Many/much" (N5++). Their typical tokens are as follows:

- **A1.8+:** *including*, *inclusion*, *include*, *inclusive*, *includes*, *included*, *comprehensive*
- **B2**: *health*, *mental health*, *tuberculosis*, *health professionals*, *infected*, *endemic*
- **A9-**: *provide*, *provides*, *providing*, *supply*, *provided*, *offer*, *distribution*
- **X2.2**: *data*, *database*, *databases*, *informative*, *data classification*, *reflecting back*
- **T2+**: *continue*, *continued*, *ongoing*, *continues*, *continuous*, *continually*
- **B3**: *healthcare*, *medical*, *health care*, *treatment*, *vaccine*, *pharmacy*, *clinical*
- **X2.2+**: *information*, *identify*, *experience*, *awareness*, *identified*, *expertise*
- **N5++**: *also*, *more*, *as well*, *additional*, *further*, *in addition*, *in addition to*, *additionally*

Categories like "Health and disease" (B2) and "Medicine and medical treatment" (B3) demonstrate a strong focus on public health and well-being, which gained prominence during the pandemic. Similarly, the emphasis on "Giving" (A9-) and "knowledge" (X2.2, X2.2+) reflects philanthropy, knowledge-sharing, and the dissemination of expertise as key components of US CSR practices. The U.S. corpus reflects an individualistic culture and market-driven economy, with CSR reports emphasizing stakeholder engagement, community needs, and innovation (Capaldi and Nedzel 2021).

These differences highlight how cultural, political, and economic systems shape the priorities and strategies of CSR communication in different regions. Both corpora, however, put an emphasis on "Danger" (A15-). It sheds light on the global impact of the pandemic and its role in shaping CSR communication (Bondi and Nocella 2023). The following sections examine how dangers are represented in both corpora.

14.5.2 Analysis of Strong Co-occurring Adjectives of "Danger" (A15-)

Table 14.3 highlights the top 20 strong co-occurring adjectives associated with "danger". They help to categorize the various types of dangers mentioned in CSR reports. They reveal significant differences in the ways dangers are framed and prioritized in Chinese and American CSR reports. According to Halliday (1994), these adjectives can be divided into two types: **epithets** and **classifiers**. The former focuses on the quality of the noun and add descriptive and evaluative meanings to it, whereas the latter narrows the scope of the noun by placing it into a class or category (Halliday 1994).

For CC, the strong co-occurring classifiers include *environmental*, *climate-related*, *social*, *occupational*, *operational*, *legal*, and *financial*. This indicates a strong focus on collective and systemic dangers that affect society at large, such as environmental

Table 14.3 Top 20 strong co-occurring adjectives of "Danger" (A15-)

	China			US		
Rank	Words	Freq.	LL	Words	Freq.	LL
1	*potential*	69	288.1	*climate-related*	95	488.2
2	*environmental*	160	209.7	*potential*	80	152.0
3	*internal*	95	207.4	*environmental*	138	146.2
4	*climate-related*	36	186.4	*physical*	48	111.5
5	*major*	95	136.4	*human*	89	97.7
6	*hidden*	23	119.3	*due*	51	68.7
7	*social*	105	96.1	*financial*	69	65.5
8	*occupational*	38	90.3	*salient*	22	63.4
9	*such*	137	87.6	*strategic*	40	56.8
10	*operational*	34	79.7	*such*	87	55.0
11	*key*	84	75.4	*reputational*	12	54.3
12	*legal*	30	74.6	*internal*	48	53.8
13	*timely*	43	66.3	*regulatory*	33	52.0
14	*comprehensive*	67	65.7	*high*	34	50.9
15	*relevant*	64	64.3	*appropriate*	31	47.9
16	*early*	26	55.4	*enterprise-level*	9	47.3
17	*extreme*	20	49.8	*inherent*	12	47.2
18	*controllable*	11	44.2	*operational*	34	43.2
19	*financial*	91	43.2	*corporate*	67	42.2
20	*solid*	33	42.6	*key*	55	41.9

sustainability (e.g., *environmental*, *climate-related*), workplace safety (e.g., *occupational*, *operational*), and regulatory compliance (e.g., *legal*). In contrast, for the US, the strong co-occurring classifiers include *climate-related*, *environmental*, *physical*, *human*, *financial*, *reputational*, *regulatory*, *enterprise-level*, *operational*, and *corporate*. This demonstrates a greater focus on risks at both the individual (e.g., *physical*, *human*) and organizational (e.g., *reputational*, *enterprise-level*) levels. The emphasis on "physical" and "human" dangers points to concerns about the direct impact on individuals, such as health, safety, and human rights. This aligns with the American emphasis on individual responsibility and ethical labour practices. However, the inclusion of "reputational" dangers emphasizes the high priority placed on corporate image and public perception. This is critical in maintaining a competitive advantage in the US business environment (Capaldi and Nedzel 2021). Therefore, the strong classifiers of dangers in both corpora suggest that the US is more concerned with dangers that directly affect the company's operations, employees, and public image, whereas China takes a broader view, addressing dangers that impact the wider society and its regulatory obligations (Bhatia 2012; Capaldi and Nedzel 2021; Hofman et al. 2015).

For China, the strongest epithets include such adjectives as *potential*, *internal*, *major*, *hidden*, and *key*. They suggest an emphasis on identifying dangers that are significant and potentially obscured or latent. This suggests a tendency to emphasize the seriousness of dangers that may not be immediately visible but could have substantial consequences if not addressed. By contrast, the strongest epithets in the US include *potential*, *internal*, *key*, *due*, *high*, and *inherent*, which reflect a slightly different emphasis. Terms like *high* and *inherent* suggest a stronger focus on the likelihood and inevitability of dangers. They indicate an acceptance of certain dangers as intrinsic to a given situation. The differences in the use of epithet adjectives suggest cultural and contextual variations in danger perception: while China focuses more on uncovering and addressing hidden or strategically significant dangers, the US puts more emphasis on the immediacy, inevitability, and causality of dangers.

14.5.3 Analysis of Strong Co-Occurring Verbs of "Danger" (A15-)

Table 14.4 presents the top 20 strong co-occurring verbs of "danger" (A15-). They also demonstrate important differences in how China and the US approach the concept of danger in their CSR reports. While both countries show preferences for verbs like *identify*, *manage*, *assess*, *evaluate*, and *review*, their preferences for some other verbs show different ways of danger evaluation.

China shows preferences for such verbs as *prevent*, *control*, *avoid*, and *eliminate*. While *prevent* and *avoid* suggest a focus on foreseeing potential dangers and taking steps to neutralize them before they can cause harm, *control* and *eliminate* underscore a desire to exert authority over dangers and remove them entirely. These action-oriented verbs reflect a proactive and decisive approach to danger management, emphasizing the importance of pre-emptive measures to stop dangers from arising or escalating (Dong et al. 2023; Liu and Wu 2015; Strafella 2011).

In contrast, the US demonstrates preferences for verbs such as *mitigate*, *oversee*, *monitor*, and *quantify*. *Mitigate* emphasizes reducing the severity or impact of dangers rather than eliminating them entirely, and *oversee* and *monitor* highlight a focus on continuous observation and oversight so that dangers can be carefully tracked and managed over time. *Quantify* reflects a strong emphasis on measurement and data-driven decision-making, prioritizing the ability to assess dangers in tangible, numerical terms. Therefore, these verbs reflect a more flexible and analytical approach to danger (Liu and Almor 2016; Wu et al. 2024).

Table 14.4 Top 20 strong co-occurring verbs of "Danger" (A15-)

	China			US		
Rank	Words	Freq.	LL	Words	Freq.	LL
1	*identify*	128	436.2	*manage*	191	519.5
2	*prevent*	87	267.1	*identify*	212	502.0
3	*manage*	73	192.0	*assess*	117	356.9
4	*improve*	202	184.5	*mitigate*	75	277.8
5	*control*	67	182.9	*relate*	95	199.1
6	*strengthen*	146	178.2	*include*	269	185.3
7	*establish*	131	128.6	*oversee*	51	124.3
8	*assess*	40	128.2	*associate*	48	118.5
9	*relate*	62	120.2	*evaluate*	50	101.5
10	*avoid*	35	95.7	*emerge*	41	84.2
11	*formulate*	73	91.6	*integrate*	41	65.9
12	*evaluate*	36	90.6	*review*	43	57.3
13	*conduct*	76	84.9	*address*	71	56.8
14	*hide*	14	76.4	*pose*	16	55.6
15	*ensure*	105	75.7	*monitor*	33	47.4
16	*enhance*	77	64.2	*conduct*	47	46.7
17	*carry*	100	60.7	*understand*	50	46.5
18	*review*	32	59.2	*expose*	11	39.5
19	*eliminate*	28	58.1	*consider*	31	37.7
20	*report*	37	57.9	*quantify*	10	37.0

14.5.4 Analysis of Strong Co-occurring Adverbs of "Danger" (A15-)

Table 14.5 highlights the strong co-occurring adverbs of dangers, revealing how dangers are framed and managed in China and the US. According to Halliday (1994), these adverbs can be classified into two types: **Manner**, concerning *how* dangers are addressed, and **Extent**, concerning *how frequently or consistently* danger-related actions are undertaken.

Manner adverbs emphasize the quality, style, or approach to danger management (Halliday 1994). Both China and the US share a preference for adverbs like *effectively* and *accurately*, reflecting a shared commitment to achieving concrete results and precision in addressing dangers. However, China shows preferences for such manner adverbs as *strictly*, *actively*, *fully*, *thoroughly*, and *dynamically*. *Strictly* reflects a disciplined and highly rigid approach, emphasizing adherence to rules and standards. Adverbs like *thoroughly* and *fully* highlight the importance of completeness in addressing dangers, suggesting that danger management efforts are exhaustive

Table 14.5 Top 20 strong co-occurring adverbs of "Danger" (A15-)

	China			US		
Rank	Words	Freq.	LL	Words	Freq.	LL
1	*effectively*	71	125.8	*effectively*	19	32.1
2	*continuously*	63	70.7	*regularly*	22	27.5
3	*regularly*	30	50	*materially*	8	22.7
4	*strictly*	45	34.6	*proactively*	12	21
5	*well*	56	33.2	*most*	43	18.1
6	*as*	53	28.8	*well*	51	16.1
7	*constantly*	20	21.3	*generally*	7	15
8	*so*	47	20.7	*adequately*	3	11.1
9	*also*	77	20.4	*prior*	8	10.7
10	*gradually*	16	20	*forth*	7	10.4
11	*mainly*	17	18.9	*appropriately*	6	10.3
12	*thereby*	11	13.9	*periodically*	5	9
13	*thereof*	4	12.3	*continually*	11	8.7
14	*actively*	56	12.1	*annually*	16	8.3
15	*initially*	5	12	*transparently*	3	8.2
16	*fully*	31	11.7	*as*	44	7.5
17	*accurately*	6	11	*accurately*	3	6
18	*dynamically*	4	9.9	*considerably*	2	5.5
19	*thoroughly*	8	9.9	*systematically*	2	5.5
20	*relatively*	5	9.4	*predominantly*	2	4.8

and leave no aspect unaddressed. Similarly, *actively* and *dynamically* emphasize a proactive stance, where dangers are not only identified but also continuously monitored and adjusted to respond to changing conditions. Therefore, they emphasize a rigorous, comprehensive, and adaptable approach to danger management.

In contrast, the US demonstrates preferences for adverbs such as *proactively*, *generally*, *adequately*, *appropriately*, *transparently*, *systematically*, and *predominantly*. *Proactively* underscores the importance of anticipating dangers before they materialize, emphasizing forward-looking strategies. Adverbs like *adequately* and *appropriately* suggest a balanced approach to danger management, addressing dangers to the extent necessary without overextending resources. Meanwhile, *transparently* reflects a focus on openness and accountability, ensuring that danger management practices are visible and trustworthy to stakeholders. The inclusion of *systematically* highlights the reliance on organized frameworks and processes to ensure dangers are addressed logically and efficiently, while *predominantly* suggests a prioritization of the most critical risks. They reflect a pragmatic, structured, and transparent approach to danger management (Rim et al. 2019).

Extent adverbs describe how often or consistently risk management actions are carried out. The preference for adverbs like *regularly* and *effectively* in both China and the US implies a shared emphasis on structured and results-oriented communication. These adverbs suggest a focus on consistency (*regularly*) and achieving desired outcomes (*effectively*), which may reflect common values in professional or organizational contexts, such as efficiency, reliability, and goal-driven practices. It also indicates a mutual interest in highlighting actions that are systematic and productive.

China shows preferences for adverbs such as *continuously*, *constantly*, and *gradually*. *Continuously* and *constantly* emphasize uninterrupted efforts to monitor, control, and address dangers. They suggest that danger management in China is not seen as a periodic task but rather as an ongoing process that requires sustained attention. The adverb *gradually* highlights an incremental approach to improvement, where dangers are managed and refined over time through steady progress. Therefore, these adverbs underline a persistent and progressive approach to danger management. It aligns with China's emphasis on long-term planning and persistence, ensuring that dangers are addressed in a manner that promotes stability and sustainable development (Zhang and Chen 2024).

In contrast, the US demonstrates a preference for adverbs such as *periodically* and *annually*. *Periodically* suggests that risks are reviewed and addressed at regular intervals, allowing for flexibility while maintaining a structured process. *Annually* indicates the importance of formal, yearly evaluations, which align with corporate reporting cycles and compliance requirements. They reflect a cyclical and formalized approach to danger management. It suggests that danger management in the US is tied to formal schedules and structured assessments, emphasizing accountability and adherence to regulatory and operational timelines (Wu et al. 2024).

14.5.5 Analysis of Strong Co-occurring Nouns of "Danger" (A15-)

Table 14.6 presents the top 20 strong co-occurring nouns with "dangers", illustrating significant differences in how China and the US conceptualize and address dangers in their CSR discourse.

China's preferred nouns, such as *safety*, *system*, *prevention*, *measure*, *warning*, *monitoring*, *impact*, and *mechanism*, highlight a structured and systematic approach to handling risks. The frequent use of *safety* underscores the priority placed on preventing harm and ensuring the well-being of individuals, communities, and the environment. The preference for nouns such as *prevention*, *measure*, and *warning* further reinforces China's proactive stance on risk management. These terms suggest that dangers are addressed through early detection and tangible actions to minimize potential harm (Sharma et al. 2020; Yang et al. 2022). Additionally, the inclusion of *impact* highlights the importance of assessing the consequences of risks to manage their effects on stakeholders effectively. Lastly, the frequent use of *mechanism* reflects

Table 14.6 Top 20 strong co-occurring nouns of "Danger" (A15-)

	China			US		
Rank	Words	Freq.	LL	Words	Freq.	LL
1	*management*	547	983.0	*management*	292	760.0
2	*control*	337	865.2	*climate*	201	459.3
3	*climate*	113	292.7	*assessment*	124	340.3
4	*system*	271	266.0	*oversight*	89	296.4
5	*assessment*	102	252.0	*mitigation*	42	161.7
6	*safety*	171	243.5	*process*	132	153.2
7	*change*	95	232.9	*change*	109	151.3
8	*compliance*	107	217.4	*enterprise*	67	149.9
9	*prevention*	117	176.1	*framework*	67	147.3
10	*identification*	46	171.3	*scenario*	42	143.2
11	*opportunity*	79	157.1	*control*	63	141.6
12	*business*	184	147.0	*compliance*	84	128.1
13	*measure*	125	133.6	*analysis*	55	126.2
14	*warning*	39	125.6	*opportunity*	124	116.7
15	*monitoring*	63	125.0	*client*	70	114.9
16	*impact*	67	116.7	*factor*	47	111.0
17	*process*	105	113.5	*business*	210	109.2
18	*mechanism*	99	112.4	*strategy*	99	107.5
19	*waste*	74	104.9	*identification*	27	107.3
20	*company*	204	100.9	*committee*	48	92.8

a reliance on institutional tools and processes to ensure that risks are addressed in a controlled and organized manner. Collectively, these nouns illustrate China's emphasis on stability, control, and institutionalized prevention, consistent with its regulatory-driven and collectivist approach to managing dangers (Dong et al. 2023; Wu et al. 2024; Zhang and Chen 2024).

In contrast, the US demonstrates a preference for nouns such as *oversight*, *mitigation*, *enterprise*, *scenario*, *analysis*, *client*, *factor*, *strategy*, and *committee*, which reflect a governance-oriented, strategic, and stakeholder-focused approach to addressing dangers. The prominence of *oversight* highlights the importance of governance and accountability in managing dangers. Similarly, *mitigation* underscores the focus on reducing the severity or impact of risks rather than solely preventing them, suggesting a more flexible and adaptive approach to managing dangers. The preference for nouns such as *scenario*, *analysis*, and *strategy* reflects the US's reliance on planning and analytical frameworks for addressing dangers. The inclusion of *strategy* emphasizes long-term vision and structured planning in managing risks, highlighting the importance of aligning danger management with organizational

goals. These terms collectively reflect a forward-looking approach that prioritizes flexibility, innovation, and strategic preparedness (Liu and Almor 2016; Poole 2016).

Therefore, the co-occurring nouns with dangers reveal stark contrasts in how China and the US approach danger management in CSR discourse. China prioritizes safety, prevention, and systematic frameworks to ensure stability and control, reflecting its collectivist culture and regulatory-driven mindset. In contrast, the US emphasizes governance, analysis, and stakeholder engagement, focusing on strategy, accountability, and flexibility in managing risks. These differences highlight how cultural, institutional, and economic factors shape the framing and management of dangers in CSR practices, offering valuable insight into the distinctive priorities and philosophies of each country.

14.6 Discussion and Conclusion

In summary, a key SMC analysis of CSR reports from Chinese and American corporations highlights "danger" as a prominent theme, reflecting the challenges posed by the pandemic. However, a co-occurrence network analysis of "danger" reveals distinct representational preferences between the two. Chinese corporations tend to emphasize dangers at the societal level, whereas American corporations focus more on dangers at the individual and corporate levels. Chinese corporations perceive dangers as hidden threats that must be identified and proactively eliminated. In contrast, American corporations view dangers as inherent risks that cannot be entirely eradicated. As a result, Chinese corporations prioritize the complete and thorough elimination of dangers, while American corporations focus on monitoring and mitigating risks. Additionally, for Chinese corporations, this process is ongoing and continuous, whereas for American corporations, it is conducted on a more periodic basis.

These systematic differences in conceptualizing dangers can only be explained in terms of the different cultures of China and the US. China is a highly collectivist society, where the well-being of the group (e.g., society, community) is prioritized over individual interests (Dong et al. 2023; Hofman et al. 2015; Zhang and Chen 2024). That explains why Chinese corporations tends to emphasize dangers at the societal level. By contrast, the U.S. is a highly individualistic society, where personal freedom and individual responsibility are prioritized (Capaldi and Nedzel 2021; Dong et al. 2023; Zhang and Chen 2024). This cultural focus on the individual explains why American corporations are more concerned with dangers at the individual and corporate levels, aligning with their emphasis on protecting personal rights and organizational interests.

Chinese culture is characterized by a long-term orientation, which emphasizes planning for the future, persistence, and sustained efforts to address challenges (Hofstede et al. 2010; Venaik and Brewer 2016; Zhang and Chen 2024). This long-term perspective explains why Chinese corporations focus on the complete and thorough elimination of dangers and view the process as ongoing and continuous. They

aim for lasting solutions to ensure long-term stability and prosperity. On the other hand, American culture tends to have a more short-term orientation, focusing on immediate results and efficiency (Hofstede et al. 2010; Wu et al. 2024; Zhang and Chen 2024). This explains why American corporations prefer to monitor and mitigate risks periodically rather than continuously, reflecting a pragmatic approach to dealing with dangers.

China's cultural values often reflect a higher level of uncertainty avoidance, where hidden dangers are perceived as threats that must be proactively identified and eliminated to maintain control and stability (Hofstede et al. 2010; House et al. 2004). This aligns with the Chinese corporations' approach of perceiving dangers as hidden risks that require thorough elimination. In contrast, American culture is more accepting of uncertainty and views risks as inherent and unavoidable (Hofstede et al. 2010; Li et al. 2013). This cultural trait explains why American corporations see dangers as inherent risks to be managed rather than fully eliminated, reflecting a more flexible and adaptive approach to handling uncertainties.

Therefore, the employment of the methods of corpus linguistics and text mining can provide different ways of processing the data at different levels, while the theories of SFL and discourse analysis can help reveal important linguistic meanings which cannot be acquired otherwise. Therefore, a balanced combination of the methods and theories of discourse analysis and text mining can contribute to an efficient analysis of large data at both macro and micro levels. This study demonstrates not only the cultural differences in crisis communication during the pandemic but, more importantly, the potential for a balanced combination or "synergy" of systemic functional linguistics and text mining in corpus-assisted discourse studies. It is hoped that this study can inspire more studies towards this endeavour (Liu 2024).

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Chapter 15
An Ideational Analysis of Different Versions of *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*



Zhenzhen Zhang

Abstract There have been a number of linguistic studies of Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* from various linguistic perspectives, and quite a few of them take a systemic functional approach, some of which explored the text from the metafunctional perspectives. Following Huang and Liu (2015) and Huang and Chen (2018), this study will investigate the text and some of its simplified versions in more detail. The present chapter attempts to follow up the study conducted by Huang and Chen (2018), and the purpose of this research is to explore the ideational (in the SFL sense, experiential and logical) analysis of the original version and four of its corresponding simplified versions. This study is different from the research of Huang and Chen (2018) in that their focus is on the grammatical complexity in relation to lexis and grammar, while the present study mainly focuses on the ideational analysis of the original versions and four of their simplified versions.

Keywords Text simplification · *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* · Systemic functional linguistics · Ideational function

15.1 Introduction

Although Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (henceforth AAW) (Carroll 1865/2009) appears to be a children's book, it is not a typical one. Many scholars argue that the book was written with an adult audience in mind, as it contains puns, riddles, poems, and humor that often exceed the comprehension of young readers. To make the book more accessible to children, various simplified versions have been created at different levels of difficulty to cater to readers of varying ages (e.g., Green 2003; Williams 2004; Tomalin 2006; Swan 2007).

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In recent years, studies on AAW and its various simplified versions have increasingly adopted a Systemic Functional Linguistics (henceforth SFL) (Halliday 1985, 1994; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004, 2014) perspective. For example, Huang and Chen (2018) conducted a comparative analysis of the opening paragraphs of AAW and some of its simplified versions. The purpose of their study was to show how a functional linguistic analysis of text can illustrate the relationship between the text and its variations. Their study shows that simplification does not necessarily lead to a reduction in text length or word count. Instead, simplification often changes the language used to convey meaning, which in turn reduces the informational content. Their study illustrates how linguistic analysis can help reveal the underlying intentions behind various adaptations, demonstrating that simplification is not merely about shortening the text but also about illustrating how meaning is expressed.

The present chapter is a follow-up investigation of the study of Huang and Chen (2018), and the purpose is to focus on the ideational analysis of the original version (henceforth OV) and its corresponding simplified versions (henceforth SV). While the main focus of the study of Huang and Chen (2018) is on the grammatical complexity in relation to the number of words in each sentence, the present research is mainly concerned with the ideational (in the SFL sense) analysis of the original version and four of its simplified versions.

15.2 Previous Studies

In the literature to date, there are quite a number of linguistic analyses of AAW, and recent years have witnessed a few more (e.g., Háhn 2009; Sholihah 2020; Sari et al. 2021; Suwannapracha & Pisitsenakul 2023). However, as the present study is an SFL study of AAW, only those that take a clear SFL orientation will be reviewed.

This section consists of two parts, the first of which is the review of systemic functional studies of AAW in general, and the second is specifically on the study of Huang and Chen (2018).

15.2.1 SFL Studies in General

The investigations of AAW and its various simplified versions have offered valuable qualitative insights into aspects such as narrative structure, attitudinal expressions, grammatical complexity, and textual cohesion. This body of research has laid a solid theoretical foundation for further explorations of the linguistic features present in both the original and simplified texts. Below are several examples that highlight these efforts.

Chen and Zhang (2015) utilized the SFL's appraisal framework (e.g., Martin and White 2005) to examine how attitudinal meanings are constructed in the original text and six simplified versions of AAW. Their findings indicate that advanced-level

adaptations align more closely with the original in terms of implicit versus explicit expressions, types of attitudes conveyed, and linguistic structures used. In contrast, lower-level versions tend to rely on more explicit expressions. They concluded that the processes of rewriting and simplification significantly influence both the type and degree of attitudinal expressions, which in turn may alter the narrative tone.

Huang and Liu (2015) focused on the lexical density and grammatical intricacy of AAW's original version and eight simplified versions, using Halliday's framework for linguistic complexity. Their mixed-methods study found that both the original text and one specific simplified version exhibited the highest levels of complexity. According to their study, variations in lexical density and grammatical intricacy reflect the different decisions made by rewriters to align with the needs and characteristics of their intended audience.

Liu (2016) explored the readability of AAW's original and simplified versions through the lens of SFL theory. Liu conceptualized readability as the ease of comprehension, the presence of certain linguistic features, and the suitability for specific readerships. His analysis included dimensions such as syntagmatic, paradigmatic, stratificational, and realizational complexity, as well as the role of grammatical metaphors and cohesion in enhancing text comprehension.

Gan (2017) examined cohesion as a critical factor in readability in her PhD thesis. Drawing on SFL principles, her study analyzed the meaning relations between sentences and the role of inter-semiotic meaning-making in text comprehension. Following Halliday and Hasan's (1976) theory of cohesion, Gan argued that without cohesion, the overall semantic system of a text cannot function effectively. Her research underscored the importance of cohesion in shaping and creating the meaning of a text and suggested that an SFL approach can provide deeper insights into readability studies.

Overall, these studies highlight the value of applying an SFL approach to examining the linguistic features of AAW and its adaptations. By exploring aspects such as attitudinal meanings, clause structures, lexical density, cohesion, and readability, researchers can gain a deeper understanding of how simplification strategies influence the language and narrative elements of children's literature. This body of research not only contributes to theoretical knowledge but also provides practical insights for developing effective simplification strategies.

15.2.2 The Study of Huang and Chen (2018)

Working within the framework of SFL, Huang and Chen (2018) conducted a comparative analysis of the opening paragraphs of AAW and its simplified versions. They discovered that simplification does not necessarily lead to a reduction in text length or word count. Instead, simplification often changes the language structure and words used by rewriters with the aim of conveying meanings that are easy to be accepted by children or language learners, which in turn reduces the informational content. This study illustrates how linguistic analysis can help reveal the underlying or hidden

intentions behind various simplified versions, demonstrating that simplification is not merely about shortening the text but also about expressing how meaning is conveyed. They argue that:

> By looking at the linguistic choices of the beginning paragraphs of the simplified versions, we can see how the change, simplification and/or adaptation convey meanings that are different from the original and how the rewriters express the underlying meanings.
>
> (Huang and Chen 2018: 236–237)

What is stated here is that because of the modification, adaptation, or simplification of a text, the meaning of the text will change as well and that the rewriter of the text will use the language that can, in his/her opinion, re-express as far as possible the meaning in the original text.

In order to discuss the similarities and differences between the original version of AAW and its simplified versions, Huang and Chen (2018) used the beginning paragraphs of AAW as an example (see the original passage in Sect. 15.4.1). They used four corresponding simplified versions (i.e., Green 2003; Bassett 2006; Swan 2007; Maghidson-Stepanova 1962) to compare the original version with the simplified versions, and they came to the conclusion that "the simplification of the original text results in the changes in its experiential meaning and information flow" (Huang and Chen 2018: 244), which was supported by the following four observations.

Firstly, there are a number of instances that are concerned with the deletion of information in the simplified versions, as the information is of no major importance for the development of the storyline. This is generally one of the characteristics of any simplified version.

Secondly, the simplification of concepts and linguistic expressions is another example of the characteristics of simplified versions. For example, in Bassett's (2006) simplified version, the original sentence "she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could) whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies" was changed into "She tried to think of something to do". As it is obvious, Bassett's (2006) simplified version is not just concerned with the simplification of the ideational meaning; it is also concerned with the language form; the original 31-word passage which consists of five processes (i.e. "was considering", "making", "would be", "getting up", and "picking") was changed into an 8-word structure. And the sophisticated idea expressed by "getting up and picking the daisies" was changed into a simple nominal group "something to do".

Thirdly, the motivation of choosing different but simple words and expressions to replace the original and difficult ones serves the aim of simplifying the understanding and interpretation of the original text. A typical example is that "on the bank" in the original text was changed into "under the trees" (Bassett 2006: 2), "on the grass" (Swan 2007: 8), or "on the grassy bank" (Green 2003: 1), which makes the meaning of the word "bank" clearer, in that the primary meaning of the word "bank" is "an institution where people or businesses can keep their money", rather than "the raised ground along the edge of a river or lake".

Fourthly, in some simplified versions, additional information was given so that the meaning of certain expressions was made more explicit. For example, in the

simplified version by Swan (2007: 8), the sentence "She saw a leaf falling from a tree, but she was too sleepy to look at it." was added so that the meaning of the original "the hot day made her feel very sleepy" was supplemented.

The study by Huang and Chen (2018) is significant in that it illustrates "how the functional linguistics analysis of the text can tell us something about the text and its variations" (p. 236) and "how functional linguistic analysis may help the reader better understand the underlying meaning of the text, and how the linguistic approach to text analysis can contribute to the interpretation and evaluation of texts in different communicative settings" (p. 248). They conclude that "the grammatical structure and the sequence of the events in the original story may undergo remarkable changes, which results in the reconstruction in the experiential meaning and information flow in the simplified texts" (p. 248). Following Huang and Chen (2018), the present chapter attempts to investigate the experiential and logical aspects of the original text and its simplified versions, to demonstrate how an SFL approach to text analysis can contribute to our understanding and interpretation of the ideational aspect of the original text and its simplified versions.

15.3 Theoretical Preliminaries

The theoretical support of the present study is SFL (Halliday 1985, 1994; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004, 2014), which is a problem-oriented theory of language (Halliday 2009: 61). This theory emphasizes "comprehensive, text-based descriptions—descriptions that can be used in text analysis" (Halliday & Matthiessen 2014: 56). The method of text analysis is adopted to examine the use of language and the choice of words and expressions, and the focus is the experiential and logical systems realized in the text. Thus, we follow Halliday and Matthiessen (2014: 54) in believing that "text analysis is a very rigorous way of testing, and thus improving, existing descriptions because everything in a given text has to be accounted for in the description".

SFL has always been closely associated with text analysis, and Halliday's *Introduction to Functional Grammar* (Halliday 1985, 1994) was written for the purpose of text analysis. In the latest edition, it is stated that the aim of the book is "to describe and explain the meaning-making resources of modern English, going as far in detail as is possible within one medium-size volume" (Halliday & Matthiessen 2014: 4). In the description of the content of the book, it is said that:

> In deciding what parts of the grammar to cover, and how far to go in discussion of theory, we have had in mind those who want to use their understanding of grammar in analysing and interpreting texts. This in turn means recognizing that the contexts for analysis of discourse are numerous and varied – educational, social, literary, political, legal, clinical and so on; and in all these the text may be being analysed as specimen or as artefact, or both (specimen here might mean specimen of a particular functional variety, or register, such as 'legal English').
>
> (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 4)

Within the general theoretical framework of SFL, the focus of this chapter is on the analysis of the two components of the Ideational Metafunction: the experiential function and the logical function.

15.3.1 Metafunction

SFL is a meaning-oriented theory of language, which focuses on the functions of language. In terms of the functions of a clause, there are three distinct ways of examining the function of the first element (e.g., "Sunny") in clauses such as "Sunny has bought two cats". It can be the Theme, the Subject, or the Actor. Each of the three elements refers to a different functional configuration, making up an important strand of meaning in the overall meaning of the clause (Halliday & Matthiessen 2014: 83). In order to illustrate how the three functions operate in a clause, Halliday (1985, 1994) proposed the concepts of metafunctions, which consist of the ideational metafunction, the interpersonal metafunction and the textual metafunction; and the ideational metafunction is further differentiated into the experiential and the logical subtypes. Thus, in some SFL writings (e.g., Thompson 1996, 2004, 2014), the experiential and the logical are treated as separate metafunctions.

As Matthiessen et al. (2010: 138) point out, the metafunctions are distinguished from macrofunctions and microfunctions: the former can be identified in children's transition between their protolanguage and adult language (cf. Halliday 1975) while the latter is the first functions/uses of children's protolanguage.

The identification of the different metafunctions in a clause helps to distinguish the different roles a clause can play, which enables researchers to regard "clause as message", "clause as exchange", and "clause as representation". However, as Halliday and Matthiessen (2014: 84) state, "the three-fold pattern of meaning is not simply characteristic of the clause; these three kinds of meaning run throughout the whole of language, and in a fundamental respect they determine the way that language has evolved".

The three metafunctions reflect the three strands of meaning in a clause, which enables researchers to look at the meaning and function in the clause from three different but related perspectives. Therefore, with a simple clause such as "Sunny has bought two cats", "Sunny" is the Theme if looked at from the textual perspective, the Subject if looked at from the interpersonal perspective, and the Actor if looked at from the experiential perspective.

15.3.2 The Experiential Metafunction

In SFL, it is assumed that the ideational metafunction provides two modes of construing experience; one is the experiential mode and the other the logical mode. As Matthiessen et al. (2010: 92) explain, "the ideational metafunction provides the

resource for construing our experience of the world around us and inside us as meaning".

In the experiential model, experience is construed organically as configurations (as in the transitivity structure of the clause). That is, this is done by modelling experience as configurations of phenomena: reality is reflected and created by processes. Thus, six process types are identified: the Material Process, the Mental Process, the Relational Process, the Verbal Process, the Behavioural Process, and the Existential Process. These process types operate in the Transitivity system, in which a process type expects its participant roles and circumstantial elements. For example, most material processes expect the participants of Actor and Goal, while most mental processes expect the participants of Senser and Phenomenon.

15.3.3 The Logical Metafunction

In SFL, the other mode of construing experience within the ideational metafunction is the logical mode, and this is the logical function, which refers to systems "which set up logical-semantic relationships between one clausal unit and another" (Halliday 2003: 17). The major systems within the logical function are "taxis" (hypotaxis vs parataxis) and "logico-semantic relations" (expansion vs projection).

When two simple clauses are combined into a clause complex, in terms of taxis, the two clauses can be given an equal status (i.e., parataxis, coordination) or a dependent status, which means that one clause is dependent on the other. In terms of logico-semantic relations, the relationship between the two clauses can be of expansion (i.e., one clause expands the meaning of the other by elaboration, extension or enhancement) and projection (i.e., whether we choose to "quote" more or less the same wording of the other language event or whether we project the meaning but not the wording of the original language event). Since the meaning relations within the systems that go under the logical function are closely related to the experiential meaning, Halliday (1985, 1994, 2003) put the experiential function and the logical function together to form the ideational metafunction.

15.4 Data and Data Analysis

The data used in this study are the beginning paragraphs of the original AAW and four of its simplified versions (e.g., Green 2003; Williams 2004; Tomalin 2006; Swan 2007), and the analysis is concerned with the experiential meaning and the logical meaning.

15.4.1 Data

The data for the present study consist of five passages, all of which are the beginning paragraphs of AAW. The first passage is taken from the original version of AAW (Carroll 1865/2009), and the remaining passages are different simplified versions of AAW. In order to make it easy for comparison, the sentences in the following passages are marked and numbered, with OV = original version, 1 = sentence one, S = simplified, and A = version A; thus, OV1 refers to sentence 1 of the original text and SB3 means sentence 3 of the simplified version B.

15.4.1.1 Original Version (OV)

OV1: Alice was beginning to get very tired of sitting by her sister on the bank, and of having nothing to do: once or twice she had peeped into the book her sister was reading, but it had no pictures or conversation in it, "and what is the use of a book," thought Alice, "without pictures or conversation?"

OV2: So she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could, for the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid), whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies, when suddenly a White Rabbit with pink eyes ran close by her.

(Carroll 1865/2009: 9)

15.4.1.2 Simplified Version A (SVA)

SVA1: Alice was beginning to get very tired of sitting by her sister on the grassy bank, and of having nothing to do. SVA2: Once or twice she had peeped into the book her sister was reading, but it had no pictures or conversation in it. SVA3: "What is the use of a book," Alice thought, "without pictures or conversation?"

SVA4: She was considering as well as she could (for the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid) whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of picking the daisies, when suddenly a white rabbit with pink eyes ran close by.

(Green 2003: 1)

15.4.1.3 Simplified Version B (SVB)

SVB1: Alice and her big sister were sitting on the grass. SVB2: Her sister was reading a book, but Alice had nothing to read. SVB3: She looked at her sister's book again. SVB4: There were no pictures in it.

SVB5: "What good is a book without pictures?" she wondered.

SVB6: It was a very hot day, and Alice wondered what to do.SVB7: "I'm so sleepy," she said to herself. SVB8: "Shall I look for some flowers, or is it too hot?"

SVB9: She saw a leaf falling from a tree, but she was too sleepy to look at it.

SVB10: Just then, a white rabbit ran by, very near to her.

(Swan 2007: 8)

15.4.1.4 Simplified Version C (SVC)

SVC1: It was the middle of the day one summer when Alice, sitting lazily at the edge of the river bank with her sister, became very tired. SVC2: There was nothing happening and nothing to do. SVC3: A couple of times she stole a quick look at the book her sister was reading, but it wasn't very interesting, as it had no pictures to look at or interesting conversations to follow. SVC4: "And what's the use of a book," thought Alice, "without pictures? What's a book if there's no conversation?"

SVC5: She was trying to decide (it was difficult for her because the hot summer day was not making her feel like making a decision but very sleepy instead) if she wanted to get up and pick some small wildflowers to make a necklace, when all of a sudden a White Rabbit with pink eyes quickly ran past her.

(Williams 2004: 1)

15.4.1.5 Simplified Version D (SVD)

SVD1: Alice and her big sister sat under a tree one sunny day.

SVD2: Alice's sister had a book, but Alice had nothing with her.

SVD3: She looked at her sister's book.

SVD4: There were no pictures or conversations in it.

SVD5: "Why is she reading a book without pictures or conversations?" she thought.

SVD6: "I'm bored. I know! I'll look for some flowers."

SVD7: Then she thought, "No, it's too hot for that and I feel sleepy."

SVD8: Suddenly, a white rabbit ran past her.

(Tomalin 2006: 1)

It should be pointed out that there are quite a number of simplified versions of AAW, but only four of them were selected as samples for the present analysis. As this study is qualitative rather than quantitative, the selection of data for analysis is basically subjective, which does not mean that it is not "scientific" as text analysis is qualitative and subjective in nature.

15.4.2 Experiential Analysis

In terms of the Transitivity analysis, the different process types illustrate the semantic situation of the passage, which expresses the meaning communicated by the writer.

15.4.2.1 Analysis of OV

In the original passage, there are 19 process types realized by 19 verbs (verb groups):

OV1: was beginning, to get (very tired), sitting, having, to do, had peeped, was reading, had, is, thought
OV2: was considering, could (consider), made, feel, making, would be, getting up, picking, ran

Of the 19 processes in the original version, there are 9 Material Processes (realized respectively by "was beginning", "sitting", "to do", "was reading", "made", "making", "getting up", "picking", "ran"), 5 Relational Processes (realized by "to get very tired", "having", "had", "is", "would be"), 4 Mental Processes (realized by "thought", "was considering", "could consider", "feel"), and 1 Behavioral Process (realized by "had peeped").

15.4.2.2 Analysis of SVA

In the Simplified Version A (SVA), there are 18 processes realized by 18 verbs (verb groups):

SVA1: was beginning, to get (very tired), sitting, having, to do
SVA2: had peeped, was reading, had
SVA3: is, thought
SVA4: was considering, could (consider), made, feel, making, would be, picking, ran

Of the 18 processes in SVA, there are 8 Material Processes (realized by "was beginning", "sitting", "to do", "was reading", "made", "making", "picking", "ran"), 5 Relational Processes (realized by "to get very tired", "having", "had", "is", "would be"), 4 Mental Processes (realized by "thought", "was considering", "could consider", "feel"), and 1 Behavioral Process (realized by "had peeped").

15.4.2.3 Analysis of SVB

In the Simplified Version B (SVB), there are 20 processes realized by 20 verbs (verb groups):

SVB1: were sitting
SVB2: was reading, had, read
SVB3: looked at
SVB4: were
SVB5: is, wondered
SVB6: was, wondered, to do
SVB7: am, said

SVB8: shall look for, is
SVB9: saw, falling, was, to look at
SVB10: ran

Of the 20 processes in SVB, there are 6 Material Processes (realized by "were sitting", "was reading", "read", "to do", "falling", "ran"), 7 Relational Processes (realized by "had", "were", "is", "was", "am", "is", "was"), 3 Mental Processes (realized by "wondered", "wondered", "saw"), 3 Behavioral Processes (realized by "looked at", "shall look for", "to look at"), 1 Verbal Process (realized by "said").

15.4.2.4 Analysis of SVC

In the Simplified Version C (SVC), there are 27 processes realized by 27 verbs (verb groups):

SVC1: was, sitting, became
SVC2: was, happening, to do
SVC3: stole, was reading, was, had, to look at, to follow
SVC4: is, thought, is, is
SVC5: was trying, to decide, was, was making, feel, making, wanted, to get up, pick, to make, ran

Of the 27 processes in SVC, there are 11 Material Processes (realized by "sitting", "happening", "to do", "was reading", "was trying", "was making", "making", "to get up", "pick", "to make", "ran"), 7 Relational Processes (realized by "was", "became", "was", "had", "is", "is", "was"), 4 Mental Processes (realized by "thought", "to decide", "feel", "wanted"), 3 Behavioural Processes (realized by "stole", "to look at", "to follow") and 2 Existential Processes (realized by "was", "is").

15.4.2.5 Analysis of SVD

In the Simplified Version D (SVD), there are 14 processes realized by 14 verbs (verb groups):

SVD1: sat
SVD2: had, had
SVD3: looked at
SVD4: were
SVD5: is reading, thought
SVD6: am, know, will look for
SVD7: thought, is, feel
SVD8: ran

Of the 14 processes in SVD, there are 3 Material Processes (realized by "sat", "is reading", "ran"), 5 Relational Processes (realized by "had", "had", "am", "is",

"feel"), 3 Mental Processes (realized by "thought", "know", "thought"), 2 Behavioral Processes (realized by "looked at", "will look for"), and 1 Existential Process (realized by "were").

15.4.3 Logical Analysis

The following is the logical analysis of the clause complexes in the sentences in different versions. This will be done passage by passage.

15.4.3.1 The Sentences in OV

In terms of the logical dependency relations, the first sentence (OV1) is a clause complex, which has four clauses that are in the parataxis relationship. From the perspective of logico-semantic relations, with OV1, the second clause (i.e., "once or twice she had peeped into the book her sister was reading") and the third clause (i.e., "but it had no pictures or conversation in it") extend the meaning of the first clause (i.e., "Alice was beginning to get very tired of sitting by her sister on the bank, and of having nothing to do"). Here, the second clause and the third clause form a parataxis complex, which is followed by the fourth clause (i.e., "and what is the use of a book", thought Alice, "without pictures or conversation"?), which extends the meaning of the second and the third clauses.

With OV2, the sentence is a clause complex with three clauses; the relationships between them are complicated. With the first clause complex "she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could, for the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid), whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies", the primary clause is broken into two parts, with the continuing clause ("for the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid") giving reasons for the process of "considering". The primary clause of this first clause complex is itself a clause complex with two clauses in a paratactic relationship, and their logico-semantic relation is projection, "she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could)" being the projecting clause and "whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies" the projected clause. The dependent clause "when suddenly a White Rabbit with pink eyes ran close by her" and its dominant clause are in a hypotactic relationship and the subordinate clause functions as an enhancement in terms of expansion of logico-semantic relation. The complex relationships between the clauses in OV2 can be illustrated from different levels:

Table 15.1 tells us that OV2 is a clause complex with the α clause as the dominant clause and the ß clause as the dependent clause and that they are in a relationship of expansion in terms of logico-semantic relation, with the ß clause functioning as an enhancement of time.

Table 15.1 Level 1 analysis

α clause	ß clause
So she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could, for the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid), whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies	When suddenly a White Rabbit with pink eyes ran close by her

On the second level, the α clause in Table 15.1 is a clause complex in paratactic relationship, with "she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could), whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies" as the primary clause and "for the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid" as the continuing clause, as Table 15.2 illustrated:

From Table 15.2, we can see that when the two clauses are in a paratactic relationship, the clause that comes first is labelled "clause1" and the one that follows is "clause 2", and this is in contrast with clauses in a hypotactic relationship (as Table 15.1 above shows), where the dominant clause is always the "α clause" and the dependent clause the "ß clause". It should be pointed out that the clauses in Table 15.2 are not in a hypotactic relationship because the word introducing the clause is "for", which is a linker, not a binder (Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 75).

As Clause 1 in Table 15.2 is itself a clause complex in a paratactic relationship, the primary clause is "she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could)", and the continuing clause is a projected clause, as can be seen in Table 15.3:

In traditional grammars, the two clauses in Table 15.3 are generally treated as a "complex sentence" (with subordination, not coordination) in which "whether the pleasure…the daisies" is said to be an "object clause"; thus, the two clauses are in a hypotactic relationship. In systemic functional analysis, the relationship between Clause 1 and Clause 2 in Table 15.3 is also regarded as hypotactic (subordination), because Clause 2 is the projected clause, which serves as the reported clause in the

Table 15.2 Level 2 analysis

Clause 1	Clause 2
She was considering in her own mind (as well as she could), whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies	For the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid

Table 15.3 Level 3 analysis

Clause 1	Clause 2
She was considering in her own mind (as well as she could)	Whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies

Mental Process of "considering" (see Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 515–518). This is consistent with the practice in systemic functional literature (see Halliday 1994: 252–253).

The discussion above is only concerned with the internal logico-semantic relation of the two sentences of the original passage. If we look at the relationship between OV1 and OV2, the logico-semantic marker "so" at the beginning of OV2 will show that the two sentences are in a paratactic enhancing relationship, expressing cause-effect meaning (see Thompson 1996: 204–205; Halliday and Matthiessen 2014: 477–485).

15.4.3.2 The Sentences in SVA

The simplified version A (SVA) is more or less the same as the original version (O) in terms of the dependency relations and the logico-semantic relations.

The main differences between OV and SVA lie in two aspects. The first is that OV1 was rewritten into three sentences (i.e., SVA1, SVA2, SVA3). The second point is the omission of some minor groups (i.e., "so", "in her own mind", "getting up" in OV2). Of the four simplified versions discussed in this chapter, SVA is the closest to the original in terms of both the grammatical organization and the dependency relations as well as the logico-semantic relations. From the perspective of the number of words, SVA is the closest to the original (SVA 103 words vs. OV 112 words).

15.4.3.3 The Sentences in SVB

Compared with SVA, SVB is more worth analyzing. There are four instances of clause complexes in SVB, in which all the instances show a paratactic relationship, with SVB2 and SVB9 showing contrast:

SVB2: Her sister was reading a book, but Alice had nothing to read.
SVB6: It was a very hot day, and Alice wondered what to do.
SVB8: "Shall I look for some flowers, or is it too hot?"
SVB9: She saw a leaf falling from a tree, but she was too sleepy to look at it.

Here, SVB2 and SVB9 each have two simple clauses in the clause complex, with the continuing clause introduced by the linker "but", while in SVB6 the continuing clause expresses extension of meaning. SVB8 is a quote, in which the continuing clause expresses an alternation with two different choices. In terms of complexity, SVB is simpler than the original version, as there is no example of hypotactic relations.

15.4.3.4 The Sentences in SVC

In SVC, there are a number of examples that illustrate the hypotactic and paratactic relationships between clauses in the clause complex.

> SVC1: It was the middle of the day one summer when Alice, sitting lazily at the edge of the river bank with her sister, became very tired.
> SVC3: A couple of times, she stole a quick look at the book her sister was reading, but it wasn't very interesting, as it had no pictures to look at or interesting conversations to follow.
> SVC4: "And what's the use of a book", thought Alice, "without pictures? What's a book if there's no conversation?"
> SVC5: She was trying to decide (it was difficult for her because the hot summer day was not making her feel like making a decision but very sleepy instead) if she wanted to get up and pick some small wildflowers to make a necklace, when all of a sudden a White Rabbit with pink eyes quickly ran past her.

In terms of the general organization of the SVC passage, there are obvious differences from the original passage and other simplified versions cited as examples in this chapter. Unlike OV, SVA, SVB, and SVD, the starting point of this version is not the main character of the story "Alice"; instead it is a circumstantial element of time, and the main point was introduced in a dependent clause ("when Alice … very tired"). In SVC3, the starting point is another circumstantial element "a couple of times" instead of "Alice". There are four finite clauses in SVC3, which forms the clause complex in terms of dependency relations and logico-semantic relations as is illustrated in Table 15.4:

Clause 1 in SVC3 has an embedded clause ("her sister was reading") restricting the meaning of "the book", and Clause 2 itself is a clause complex with the two clauses in a hypotactic relationship: the ß clause expresses the reason why the main character Alice was not interested in the book her sister was reading, and it also led to the utterance in SVC4.

SVC4 is a clause complex with two clauses in a paratactic relationship, and in terms of the logico-semantic relation it is of the projection category, with the projecting clause and the projected clause, which is a quote:

As Table 15.5 shows, the projected clauses (paratactic clauses) are broken into two parts by the projecting clause. Within the projected clause, there is a clause complex in which there is a dependent clause expressing condition ("if there's no

Table 15.4 Analysis of SVC3

Clause 1	Clause 2
A couple of times she stole a quick look at the book her sister was reading	But it wasn't very interesting, as it had no pictures to look at or interesting conversations to follow

Table 15.5 Analysis of SVC4

Projected–	Projecting clause	–clause
And what's the use of a book	Thought Alice	Without pictures? What's a book if there's no conversation?

conversation"), with the dominant clause (i.e., "what's a book") with the dependent clause showing a hypotactic relationship.

The logical analysis of SVC5 is similar to that of OV2 above, as OV2 and SVC5 have more or less the same lexicogrammatical structure.

15.4.3.5 The Sentences in SVD

Of the four simplified versions, SVD is the simplest one in terms of syntactic structures. But this version has its own characteristics.

SVD2: Alice's sister had a book, but Alice had nothing with her.
SVD5: "Why is she reading a book without pictures or conversations?" she thought.
SVD7: Then she thought, "No, it's too hot for that and I feel sleepy."
SVD2 is made up of two clauses in a paratactic relation, with the continuing clause expressing the meaning of contrast. The logico-semantic relation between them is an extension of expansion. SVD5 is supposed to be the simplified version of the original "'and what is the use of a book,' thought Alice, 'without pictures or conversation?'". The original question is concerned with the value or usefulness of the book, while SVD5 is concerned with the reason why "her sister" was reading a book without pictures or conversations. By looking at the dependency relation, SVD5 is a paratactic structure, with "why is she reading a book without pictures or conversations" as the primary clause and "she thought" as the continuing clause. In terms of the logico-semantic relation, it is projection, with "why is she reading a book without pictures or conversations" being the projected clause and "she thought" the projecting clause. Since the projected clause is direct speech, it is a quote, not report.
SVD7 is an interesting example worth discussing. In the original version, the writer's description of the situation ("the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid") was changed into the character's utterance "it's too hot for that and I feel sleepy", which is a quote; the writer's experience was transformed into the character's experience. In terms of dependency relation, the two clauses are in a paratactic relationship, and the continuing clause ("and I feel sleepy") expresses the meaning of extension.

15.5 Discussion

This section will first discuss the transitivity analysis, and this will be followed by the logical analysis, as they are the core elements in the ideational metafunction of SFL. And the implications and further studies will also be examined.

15.5.1 Transitivity Analysis

In the experiential mode, there are transitivity systems that play the key role in construing experience. According to Halliday (1966/2005: 7), "the transitivity systems are concerned with the type of process expressed in the clause, with the participants in this process, animate and inanimate, and with various attributes and circumstances of the process and the participants". Halliday (e.g., 1985, 1994) identifies six process types in the analysis of English, as was reported earlier. As our analysis presented in Sect. 15.4.2 above shows, all six process types occur in our data.

In the original passage, there are 19 processes realized by 19 verbs (verbal groups), with 9 Material Processes, 5 Relational Processes, 4 Mental Processes, and 1 Behavioral Process. The description here can serve as a checklist when we compare the simplified versions with the original version.

In the SVA, there are 18 processes realized by 18 verbs (verbal groups). As can be seen from Sects. 15.4.1.1 and 15.4.1.2, the only difference between the OV (the original passage) and the SVA in terms of process types is that SVA deleted one process (i.e., "getting up"), with the other process remaining unchanged; thus, "…worth the trouble of getting up and picking…" in the OV becomes "…worth the trouble of picking…" in SVA. It is very clear that SVA is more or less the same as OV, the former having 103 words and the latter 112 words. But in terms of the number of sentences, the OV has 2 but SVA has 4, as is shown in Sect. 15.4.1. The differences shown here suggest that the characteristics of simplification in SVA is expressed by the number of sentences and the complexity of sentences, as is shown in Sect. 15.4.3 above.

In the SVB, there are 20 processes realized by 20 verbs (verbal groups), consisting of 6 Material Processes, 7 Relational Processes, 3 Mental Processes, 3 Behavioral Processes, and 1 Verbal Process (see Sect. 15.4.2.3). Compared with the OV (Sect. 15.4.1.1), there are a number of important changes that contribute to the simplification of the rewritten passage. For example, the first sentence (i.e., OV1) was segmented into five sentences (SVB1, SVB2, SVB3, SVB4, SVB5), and complicated situations were simplified into simple situations. For example, "Alice was beginning to get very tired of sitting by her sister on the bank, and of having nothing to do" in OV1 has become "Alice and her big sister were sitting on the grass" in SVB1. Therefore, the processes of "was beginning", "to get very tired" and "having nothing to do" were deleted, and only "sitting" was kept. On the other hand, extra

information was added to make meanings more explicit. For example, the nominal group "the hot day" in OV1 was rewritten as a clause (i.e., SVB6: it was a very hot day), and description (e.g., "the hot day made her feel very sleepy" in OV1) has become verbiage (i.e., SVB7: "I'm so sleepy). Therefore, the SVB has a Verbal Process, which has no corresponding counterpart in the original version. Similarly, "whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies" in OV2 was rewritten as verbiage: "Shall I look for some flowers, or is it too hot?". The information in the clause complex in SVB9 has no corresponding counterpart in the original version. The information concerning the "rabbit" (OV2: "when suddenly a White Rabbit with pink eyes ran close by her") was given in OV2 as a dependent clause; but in SVB10, this information is encoded as an independent clause (i.e., "Just then, a white rabbit ran by, very near to her"). In terms of the logico-semantic relation, expansion has become projection, and in terms of dependency relation, hypotactic clause complexes have become paratactic clause complexes. Because the rewritten version not only simplifies the structure of the original sentences but also changes and/or adds information, it has become simple in terms of both meaning and structure.

Although SVC is a simplified version of OV, the number of words in SVC is 144 words, which is more than the original version, which has 112 words. As was reported earlier, the original version has 19 processes; SVC has 27 processes: 11 Material Processes, 7 Relational Processes, 4 Mental Processes, 3 Behavioral Processes, and 2 Existential Processes (see Sect. 15.4.2.4). The lexicogrammatical structures and the process types in SVC are obviously different from the OV, as was discussed earlier. Of all the four simplified versions, this SVC is the most deviant one.

In the Simplified Version D (SVD), there are 14 processes that were realized by 14 verbs (verb groups); thus, there are 3 Material Processes, 5 Relational Processes, 3 Mental Processes, 2 Behavioral Processes, and 1 Existential Process (see Sect. 15.4.2.5). Of all the four simplified versions, SVD has the least number of words: SVA, 103; SVB, 102; SVC, 144; SVD 78. Except for SVC, the other three simplified versions are shorter than the original one, which has 122 words. In the original passage, there are 9 Material Processes, but in SVD, there are only 3 Material Processes. If we compare these two passages, we can see where the difference lies (Table 15.6):

The other processes involved with action in the original passage (i.e., *was beginning*, *to do*, *made*, *making*, *getting up*, *picking*) were deleted in the SVD, which makes SVD short and simple. And this in turn illustrates the major difference between the two versions.

Table 15.6 Differences in the number of material process

O: 9 Material Processes	SVD: 3 Material Processes
Was beginning, sitting, to do, was reading, made, making, getting up, picking, ran	Sat, is reading, ran

15.5.2 Logical Semantic Analysis

As can be seen in Sect. 15.4.3.1 above, dependency relations in OV1 and OV2 are of two types, the hypotactic and the paratactic, and the logico-semantic relations in OV1 and O2 are rather complex, especially those in OV2. By contrast, the dependency relation in the SVA is only of the paratactic type, which shows that the flow of information is straightforward, thus making the text reader-friendly.

As was shown in Sect. 15.4.3.2 above, of all the four simplified versions, SVA is the closest to the original in both the dependency relations and the logico-semantic relations, and these relations are not changed for the purpose of text simplification. Besides this, the general organization of OV and SVA is more or less the same.

The dependency relations and the logico-semantic relations in SVB are different from those in OV in two ways: (a) The dependency relations of the clause complexes in SVB are of the paratactic type, which shows that SVB is an obvious simplified version of the original. (b) The continuing clause in SVB2 is introduced by the linker "but", and the continuing clause in SVB6 is introduced by the linker "and", and both express the meaning of extension (in terms of expansion).

SVB8 is interesting in that the original thought of the character has become a quote, with the continuing clause expressing an alternation with two different choices (i.e., "Shall I look for some flowers, or is it too hot?"). As SVB is rewritten to be a simplified version, it is simpler than the original version.

As the analysis in Sect. 15.4.3.4 shows, the organization and complexity of SVC are quite different from those in the original version. In OV1, the dependency relations are of the paratactic type, but the logico-semantic relations in SVC1, SVC2, SVC3, and SVC4 are of two types: hypotaxis and parataxis, as was shown in Sect. 15.4.3.4. This means that SVC is more complex than the original version in terms of the dependency relation. In OV1, the starting point (i.e., Theme in SFL terms) is "Alice" whereas in SVC1, it is the formal and empty impersonal pronoun "it" which refers to time. In this SVC, additional information is provided, for example, "lazily" and "at the edge of the river" in SVC1, "nothing happening" in SVC2, and "it wasn't very interesting" in SVC3.

In the original version, "and what is the use of a book without pictures or conversation?" (OV1) is a simple clause, but it was rewritten into two sentences—"And what's the use of a book without pictures? What's a book if there's no conversation?", the second sentence (i.e., "What's a book if there's no conversation?") itself being a clause complex with hypotactic relation in terms of dependency relation and being an enhancement of expansion.

The dependency relations and the logicosemantic relations in SVB are different from those in OV in two ways: (a) The dependency relations of the clause complexes in SVB are of the paratactic type, which shows that SVB is an obvious simplified version of the original. (b) The continuing clause in SVB2 is introduced by the linker "but", and the continuing clause in SVB6 is introduced by the linker "and", and both express the meaning of extension (in terms of expansion). SVB8 is interesting in that the original thought of the character has become a quote, with the continuing

clause expressing an alternation with two different choices (i.e., "Shall I look for some flowers, or is it too hot?"). As SVB is rewritten to be a simplified version, it is simpler than the original version.

15.5.3 Summary

The analysis so far indicates that there are a number of tentative conclusions that can be made. Firstly, different simplified versions have different characteristics in expressing the dependency relations and logico-semantic relations. Secondly, some simplified versions may be of little difference from the original version, and SVA can serve as an example. Thirdly, the simplification occurs at different levels, from lexicogrammatical structures (clause complexity) to choices of lexical words and expressions and the number of words. Fourthly, a simplified version does not mean that it has fewer words than the original version, and the comparison of SVC and the original version can support this; this point is similar to one of the findings in the study of Huang and Chen (2018: 236), which is "the simplified versions are not necessarily shorter than the original in terms of the length of the passage and the number of words".

If we consider the simplicity/complexity of the four rewritten versions in relation to the original version, we can have the following tentative conclusions: 1. There is not much difference between SVA and the original version in terms of lexicogrammatical structure; 2. SVC seems to be more complex than the original version; 3. SVD is simple but it does not accurately convey the information in the original passage; 4. Simplified versions tend to alter the meaning in the original passage, some versions being obvious in this respect; and 5. A lexicogrammatical analysis of the original version and its corresponding versions can help the analyst to see how far the semantic retention is possible.

15.5.4 Implications and Futher Studies

The present study is an ideational analysis of the beginning paragraphs of AAW and four of its corresponding simplified versions produced by four different rewriters. This study is concerned with text simplification, which involves simplifying complex texts while preserving the original meaning and content (Siddharthan 2014: 259). Text simplification is recognized for playing various roles in both educational and entertainment contexts. For instance, it can help children and language learners to better understand complex materials through simplified language, thereby enhancing language acquisition and cognitive development. Additionally, text simplification benefits a wider range of individuals, including those with intellectual and learning disabilities, the deaf and blind, older adults, people with limited literacy skills, and

immigrants whose first language differs from the text language (Alarcon et al. 2021: 58755).

Siddharthan (2014) points out that many experimental studies have shown that simplified language input significantly improves the reading comprehension of foreign language learners (e.g., Tweissi 1998; Gardner and Hansen 2007). Based on this evidence, simplified materials are equally essential for young foreign language learners. Standardized systems and principles for graded reading materials designed for children (e.g., Lexile) further demonstrate the necessity of matching simplified texts to the cognitive and linguistic levels of young readers. Therefore, foreign language learners, like native-speaking children, benefit from appropriately leveled and simplified texts.

As was indicated earlier, there are numerous studies comparing the linguistic features of the original and simplified versions of literary works to explore different strategies of simplification (e.g., Chen and Zhang 2015; Huang and Liu 2015; Liu 2016; Gan 2017; Huang and Chen 2018). These studies use the SFL framework (Halliday 1985, 1994; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004, 2014) to provide detailed analyses of language characteristics.

With the advancement of technology, automatic text simplification has developed alongside traditional approaches. In the era of artificial intelligence, the text generation capabilities of large language models have garnered widespread attention. Researchers are increasingly interested in whether these models can effectively simplify texts to support teaching and learning, making their capabilities in text simplification a significant area of research. In particular, the potential of large language models to simplify children's literature deserves our attention.

One of the possible directions of research on text simplification in general and the simplified versions of AAW in particular is the appropriate use of artificial intelligence, which will expect more use of the automatic machine analysis of text, and this will demonstrate a quantitative approach to the study, supplementing the qualitative approach in relation to text analysis, as is exemplified in this study.

15.6 Concluding Remarks

This paper is intended to be a chapter in the festschrift in honor of Professor Huang Guowen, who has taught language and linguistics in a number of universities, including Guangzhou Institute of Foreign Languages (now Guangdong University of Foreign Studies), University of Wales, College of Cardiff (now Cardiff University), Sun Yat-sen University, South China Agricultural University, and City University of Macau. For the past three decades, Professor Huang's academic studies have focused on SFL in general and SFL as an appliable linguistics in particular, and text analysis has been one of his main research interests, as can be seen from his numerous publications, including a number of monographs. The present chapter is a study inspired by Professor Huang's research, especially the study of Huang and Chen (2018).

The analysis and discussion in Huang and Chen (2018) and the present study follow the qualitative approach to text analysis, and this clearly reflects the tradition of text studies in the SFL community. However, as we are now in the era of AI technology, one possible direction of future text studies can be AI-empowered with automatic analysis of text together with manual analysis.

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Part IV
SFL and Translation

Chapter 16
Systemic Functional Linguistics in Translation Studies: From Linguistic Shifts to Social Accountability



Meifang Zhang and Hanting Pan

Abstract Translation Studies (TS), which is an interdisciplinary subject of study, often draw on findings and theories of other related disciplines in order to develop and formalize its own methods. Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), as an appliable linguistics, has a great deal to offer to the area of TS. This article discusses the relationship between SFL and TS via an investigation of major applications of SFL in TS in the past decades and their influences on TS from linguistic shifts to social accountability. First, we revisit some of the major works by translation scholars who have brought in relevant linguistic theories to construct some methodological models for investigating translation issues. Then we identify some of the influences/results from previous research work, such as diachronic changes in research themes and focuses from linguistic shift to context of situation, context of culture, the translator's attitudes and then to the creation of knowledge in social practice. Next, the paper highlights some of the major contributions of appliable linguistics to TS and their implications for future studies. It is hoped that this will help to enhance researchers' interests in adopting the discourse analysis approaches to TS.

Keywords Systemic functional linguistics · Translation studies · Research themes and methods · Linguistic shifts · Social accountability

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16.1 Introduction

Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), as an appliable linguistics, has a great deal to offer to the area of Translation Studies (TS), which is a comparatively young discipline and has to "draw on the findings and theories of numerous related disciplines to develop and formalize its own methods" (Baker 1992/2018: 4). Over the past decades, TS has developed to such an extent that it is a fast-growing interdisciplinary subject, interfacing with numerous other fields.

Of the numerous related disciplines, TS are naturally and fruitfully interfaced with, SFL is on the top list as the two are closely related subjects of study, the relationship of which is both profound and multifaceted. According to Matthiessen (2012: 436–437), "from the beginning, SFL was designed to be a holistic theory of language in context, with comprehensive descriptions of the systems of particular languages that could support text analysis", and "to solve problems that arise in communities around the world, involving both reflection and action" (Halliday 1985, 2002, quoted in Matthiessen 2012: 436). Halliday's SFL discourse analysis model is indeed useful to translation analysis in TS, "a discipline which has to concern itself with how meaning is generated within and between various groups of people in various cultural settings, and with what impact on society" (Baker 1992/2018: 4). Munday also pointed out that Halliday's "systemic functional grammar is geared to the study of language as communication" and "sees meaning in the writer's linguistic choices and systematically relates these choices to a wider sociocultural framework" (2012:137).

In the following sections, we will first review some of the outstanding applications of SFL in translation studies, which include: (1) shift theory (Catford 1965) and the translation methods; (2) contextual factors in translation; and (3) the translator's attitudinal positioning in translational operation. It is hoped that this study will give some implications for future research and help to enhance translation researchers' interests in adopting discourse analysis approaches based on SFL to TS.

16.2 Previous Research with Halliday's Discourse Analysis Model

From the early 1990s to the present day, many TS scholars have applied Discourse Analysis theory and methodology in their research. The "discourse analysis that has had the greatest influence is Michael Halliday's systemic functional model" (Munday 2012: 137). Munday illustrated Halliday's model in his influential book *Introducing Translation Studies: Theories and Applications* (2001, 2008, 2012), and his introduction has largely aroused TS researchers' interest in SFL. As a result, a large number of scholarly articles and books on discourse and translation have been published, with many conferences/symposiums on Discourse and Translation have been held across the globe.

Due to space limitation, we identify several key publications that have employed the Hallidayan model in translation research. Major reasons for selecting these items include that most of the works have been very popular among translation researchers, and all selected works represent the trend of discourse analysis-oriented Translation Studies. Table 16.1 shows the titles of the works, key theoretical concepts employed, and possible influences.

The selected publications in Table 16.1 demonstrate the developmental line of TS with the applications of theoretical concepts and models from SFL, i.e., from lexico-grammar analysis (Catford 1965) to text/discourse analysis (Hatim and Mason 1990, 1997; Baker 1992), from evaluating translation quality (House 1997) and examining

Table 16.1 Selected key publications employing the Hallidayan model in translation research

Scholar/year	Book title	Theoretical concept raised	Influence in TS
Catford (1965)	*A Linguistic Theory of Translation*	Translation shift	Translation methods
Hatim and Mason (1990)	*Discourse and the Translator*	Levels of context and discourse	Register and discourse analyses
Hatim and Mason (1997)	*The Translator as Communicator*	Providing bottom-up and top-down text/discourse analysis models	Broadening the research scope from language/text to sociocultural factors and power relations
Baker (1992)	*In Other Words: A Coursebook on Translation*	Level analysis: lexical, thematic/information structures, cohesion and coherence	Setting up an example for textual and translation analysis
House (1997)	*Translation Quality Assessment: A Model Revisited*	Applying genre and register theories of SFL in building up a model for translation quality assessment	Bringing a systematic theory in assessing the quality of translation
Munday (2012)	*Evaluation in Translation: Critical Points in Translator Decision Making*	Applying appraisal framework in evaluating the translator's attitude	Extending evaluation focus from text to the translator's role and attitudes
Zhang and Feng (2020)	*Multimodel Approaches to Chinese-English Translation and Interpreting*	Introducing theories and models of multimodal discourse analysis to the study of various texts in translation	Setting the agenda and serving as a resource for researchers in multimodal discourse analysis and translation studies
Pan et al. (2024)	*Multimodality in Translation Studies: Media, Models, and Trends in China*		

language of evaluation (Munday 2012) to exploring multimodality in translation and interpreting (Zhang and Feng 2020; Pan et al. 2024).

From Table 16.1, we can easily spot several places of expansion of SFL in TS. For example, in Catford's works, the focus of attention is on different levels of language (e.g., phonology, graphology, grammar, lexis) and ranks (sentence, clause, group, word, morpheme, etc.). Then in the 1990s, researchers' interest extended from thematic and information structure, transitivity, modality, and cohesion to sociocultural elements of the genre. Entering the twenty-first century, the scope of text investigation has been expanded to embrace other developments in SFL, in particular, the Appraisal Theory by Martin and White (2005/2008), which derives from the interpersonal metafunction of SFG (Halliday 1978, 1994), and the socio-semiotic approach of multimodality in the new media era (Kress 2010).

Although SFL has made great contributions to the study of translation, many people still think that Halliday's grammar is too complicated to be applied in daily research work. In fact, the works mentioned earlier in this section do not apply all the theoretical concepts of SFL, but only select relevant elements for their purpose and simplify the analysis where necessary. The next section demonstrates how we apply theories and methods from SFL in translation teaching and research.

16.3 Applications of SFL in TS with Case Analysis

In translation, the first and fundamental issue is what translation methods can be used to translate a source text into an appropriate target text. Secondly, the study of language and translation inevitably involves the study of the contexts in which they are used and expected to function. Thirdly, while *faithfulness* or *fidelity* may still be a yardstick to measure translation quality, the translator's attitudinal positioning is also an important factor in translation decision-making. Taking these three significant issues, we will look at three aspects with the application of relevant theoretical concepts from SFL:

a. *The shift theory and translation methods*
b. *Context analysis in translation*
c. *The translator's attitudinal positioning*

16.3.1 The Shift Theory and Translation Methods

Although the "shift" theory in TS is not a technical term or theoretical concept in SFL, it is indeed generated from Halliday's linguistic theory. Munday (2012: 92) observes that the term in question likely emerged from Catford's *A Linguistic Theory of Translation* (1965), which dedicates an entire chapter to its examination. Drawing upon the Firthian and Hallidayan linguistic framework, Catford (1965) conceptualizes language as a communicative system functioning contextually and

dynamically across multiple strata. This model emphasizes the interplay of structural levels—such as phonology, graphology, grammar, and lexis—as well as hierarchical units, including clauses, groups, words, and morphemes.

Catford also acknowledges Michael Halliday with whom he "discussed many parts of the work while it was in preparation" (1965: viii). At that time, Catford regarded Halliday's linguistic theory as general linguistic theory that provides categories and draws from generalizations based on observation of languages and language events. He confirms that "the general linguistic theory made use of in this book is essentially that developed at the University of Edinburgh, in particular by M.A.K. Halliday and influenced to a large extent by the work of the late J.R. Firth" (1965: 1). However, Catford did not employ Halliday's full model in his study. Instead, he acknowledges in the book that he would take "full responsibility of the brief and over simplified sketch of linguistic theory given here, which differs from that of Halliday chiefly in its treatment of *levels*" (1965: 1). And the way to simplify complicated theoretical concepts in TS has set an example for later researchers including the present authors and our colleagues.

We have done some research on translation shift, especially in relation to Chinese-English translation methods (Zhang and Pan 2009), and found that the linguistic shift theory is useful for organizing the Chinese-English translation methods in order and in proper linguistic framework. Traditional Chinese discourse, as critics have sometimes criticized, is impressionistic, unscientific, anecdotal, and unsystematic. However, when we examine the most popular translation textbook in China, namely, Zhang et al.'s *A Textbook of English-Chinese Translation* (1980), we find Catford's model useful because it provides, in a detailed and fairly systematic manner, a classification of translation shifts involving various classes and types of words and expressions. The translation methods listed in Table 16.2 are collected from Zhang et al. (1980).

Zhang Peiji et al.'s textbook was recommended by the Chinese Ministry of Education for use in colleges and universities in the Chinese mainland, and it has been very popular among translation students since the early 1980s to the beginning of the twenty-first century. Even up to the present day, the translation methods described in this book are still being used and referred to in translation teaching in universities and colleges in the Greater China Area. Illustrated below are some examples from our teaching materials.

a. **Level shifts**

(1) They are fighting for a ***better*** life.
他们为改善生活而斗争。(Back translation: They are fighting to **improve** their life.)(adj.→V.)

(2) The ***mastery*** of a foreign language is not easy.
掌握一门技术外语是不容易的。(Back translation: To **master** a foreign language is not easy.)((N→V.)

b. **Category shifts**

(3) The professor spoke to him ***with brutal frankness***.

Table 16.2 Summary of Zhang Peiji et al.'s Model (1980)

Translation methods	
Category 1: Shifts at lexical-semantic level	*Choosing the right word*
	Conversion of parts of speech
	Amplification
	Omission
	Repetition
	Negation
Category 2: Shifts at structural level	*Division*
	Combination
	Voices
	Restructuring
Category 3: Shifts at cultural level	*Transliteration*
	Replacement/substitution
	Semantic translation
	Transliteration plus semantic translation
	Transliteration plus explanation

那位教授跟他说的话虽然逆耳,却是忠言。(Back translation: Though the professor's words were harsh to his ears, they were sincere advice.) (phrase→sentence)

(4) ***Among the Blind the One-Eyed Man is King.***
山中无老虎,猴子称大王。(Back translation: When there are no tigers in the mountains, the monkey proclaims himself king.) (substitution)

By ***level shifts*** Catford means "a shift that an SL item at one linguistic level has a TL translation equivalent at a different level". Examples (1) and (2) are such cases, with shifts from an adjective to a verb and from a noun to a verb. In terms of translation method, it is called "conversion of parts of speech" (see Table 16.2). Such shifts are, of course, quite common in English-Chinese translation.

By ***category shifts***, Catford refers to "*unbounded* and *rank-bound* translation: the first being approximately 'normal' or 'free' translation in which SL-TL equivalences are set up at whatever rank is appropriate" (1965: 75). Example (3) and (4) are the cases in point. Example (3) transforms a prepositional phrase into a clause, while Example (4) uses a completely different saying in the target language to replace that in the source text. This is common in translating metaphors and cultural concepts.

When we focus on equivalence or translatability, we will find Catford's model useful because it provides, in a detailed and fairly systematic manner, a classification of translation shifts involving various classes and types of words and expressions. Munday praises Catford's book as "an important attempt to systematically apply advances in linguistics to translation" (2012: 94). The advances in linguistics

mentioned by Munday refer to those from the Firthian and Hallidayan linguistic model.

16.3.2 Context Analysis in Translation

When approaching language in a social-semiotic perspective, Halliday defines TEXT as "language that is functional" (Halliday and Hasan 1989: 10). By functional, he means that language "is doing some job in some context" (ibid). In dealing with the text, the translator has to deal with other text that accompanies it, namely, the con-text. Con-text can be decoded as "context" and "co-text", which are essential constituents of a text and are indispensable factors in determining its purpose.

All language use has a context. According to Halliday (ibid), the notion "context" refers to what is said and written: it includes other non-verbal goings-on—the total environment in which a text unfolds. The textual features enable the discourse to cohere not only with itself but also with its context of situation. Halliday and Hasan (1989: 12) analyzes the context of situation into the following three components:

> *Field of discourse*: the "play"—the kind of activity going on; the social action that is taking place.
>
> *Tenor of discourse*: the "player"—the interacting roles, that are involved in the creation of the text.
>
> *Mode of discourse*: the "parts"—the particular functions that are assigned to language in this situation.

The translator at work is a discourse analyst throughout the whole process of translating. When the translator tries to analyze a text, he/she has to understand its context first because "in real life, contexts precede texts. The situation is prior to the discourse that relates to it" (Halliday and Hasan 1989: 5). Without any knowledge of the context of situation, it's hard for one to get the right meaning of the discourse being translated. A Chinese dialogue as simple as "上课了?" "是" may cause mis-translations because the first speaker's words can be translated into different versions according to different context of situation:

> A: 上课了?
>
> T1. Have you just finished your class?
>
> T2. Has the bell gone?
>
> T3. Am I late for class?

> Situation 1: The interlocutors are students of different classes. A runs into B who is just coming out from a class.
>
> Situation 2: They are fellow students. A just comes back to school.
>
> Situation 3: They are fellow students. A is hurrying to the classroom.

	Welcome Thank you for showing respect in this place of worship **欢迎参观　在圣堂内　请勿喧哗** **出入关门　多谢合作** (Literal translation: *Welcome to visit. Inside the holy hall, please don't make loud noises. Close the door upon entry and exit. Thank you for cooperation.*)

Fig. 16.1 Bilingual public notice in use

Co-text is "the parts of a piece of writing, a speech, etc. which surround a word or passage and which influence or help to explain its meaning".[1] Co-texts assume great importance for the translator, especially when contextual details concerning time, place or purpose are not available. From the co-text the translator may be able to reconstruct some part of the original context. All of the sentences below contain the clause "it's out", but it has different meanings in different co-texts.

1. How's your new book? *Is it out?* (书出版了吗?)
2. I don't like this skirt. *It's out*. (这条裙子过时了。)
3. Look at the cherry tree in my garden. *It's out!* (樱桃树开花了。)
4. *It's out!* You've lost the game. (球出界了!)

When the co-texts of the above sentences are analyzed, the words "book", "skirt", "cherry tree" and "game", respectively, reveal what the speakers are talking about (field of the discourse). These co-texts help the translator to reconstruct parts of the context of situations: the first speaker is talking about "publication"; the second one about "clothing", the third one about "plants"; and the fourth about "sports". Only after these parts of context of situations are reconstructed, could the translator/interpreter be able to interpret the right meanings of "it" and "out" in different sentences.

Another example is a public notice in use. It is posted at the entrance of St Francis Xavier Catholic Church on Coloane Island, Macao. When collecting this public notice, we asked the church people which language version is the source text, and which is the translation. We were told that the English version was produced based on the Chinese text (Fig. 16.1).

A quick comparison of the two language versions shows that the Chinese and the English texts are very different in terms of content and style. In the Chinese text,

[1] This definition is from *Longman Dictionary of English Language and Culture*. Longman, 1993.

there are four clauses which are written in formal style, two of which are declarative and two imperative clauses. The first declarative clause "欢迎参观" (Welcome to visit) and the last one "多谢合作" (Thank you for your cooperation) are expressing the host's friendly attitude, while the imperative clauses, "Inside the holy hall, please don't make loud noises", "Close the door upon entry and exit", demand cooperation from the visitors (Table 16.3).

The English version, however, contains only two clauses: "Welcome" and "Thank you for showing respect in this place of worship". The former expresses a friendly attitude of the church people, and the latter expresses their gratitude for the visitors' good behavior in the church. The imperative clauses in the Chinese version (请勿喧哗; 出入关门) are omitted in translation, although the second clause could be understood as inviting cooperation rather than simply offering a thank-you note.

When the ST and TT are so different, can we say the translation is an appropriate one?

Halliday (1994/2000: 41) pointed out that "the linguistic analysis may enable one to say why the text is, or is not, an effective text for its own purposes—in what respect it succeeds and in what respects it fails, or is less successful".

A brief analysis of the public notice shows that the field of the discourse of both the ST and TT is the same: the message sender (the church management) expresses a welcome note and expects the message receiver (the visitors) to cooperate and behave well inside the church. But the tenor of the discourse is different, *i.e.,* the Chinese version (ST) is addressed to the Chinese tourists while the English version (TT) to the English-speaking tourists. Among the Chinese visitors to the church, very few have the knowledge of Roman Catholics or Christians, so they might not know the manners expected in Catholic churches; on the other hand, the Chinese people, especially when they are happy, tend to speak in loud voices. Therefore, the church finds it necessary to post a public notice advising the visitor "not to make loud noises" (请勿喧哗) and "Close the door upon entry and exit" (出入关门). In the Chinese language culture, it is not abnormal to demand participants or even strangers in certain social context to cooperate by using imperative clauses such as "please keep quiet", "Close the door please". As long as the courteous wording such as "Please…" (请), and "Thank you" (谢谢) are used, the demand would not be considered offensive.

However, if the Chinese text is literally translated into English: "Welcome to visit. Inside the holy hall, please don't make loud noises. Close the door upon entry and exit.

Table 16.3 A comparison of the differences between ST and TT

ST (Chinese)	Literal translation	TT (English)
欢迎参观	Welcome	Welcome
在圣堂内	Inside the holy hall	in this place of worship
请勿喧哗	Please don't make loud noises	(Omission)
出入关门	Close the door upon entry and exit	(Omission)
多谢合作	Thank you for cooperation	thank you for showing respect

Thank you for your cooperation", it would be very wordy and sound rude because this is beyond the expectation of English readers. Catholic is very popular in the English-speaking world, so English-speaking tourists are supposed to have sufficient knowledge of proper behavior in places of worship. Hence, it is understandable why the English text omits the two imperative clauses.

16.3.3 The Translator's Attitudinal Positioning

Traditionally, faithfulness to the original text was the most important principle, and linguistic shifts as well as stylistic shifts were the major focus of attention in translation studies. Over the past few decades, the scope of translation studies has been broadened to various approaches and scopes, including the value-driven nature of the sociocultural framework.

Lawrence Venuti is one of the scholars to raise some new concepts in translation studies. He coined two concepts for describing two types of translation methods: foreignization and domestication (Venuti 1995), which are related to the norms of translation. "Norms may be in the first instance linguistic or literary, but they will also include a diverse range of domestic values, beliefs, and social representations which carry ideological force in serving the interests of specific groups" (Venuti 1998: 29). Mary Tymoczko also points out that when choosing a translation method or strategy, the translator must have his/her own stance and positioning, because "the ideology of a translation resides not simply in the text translated, but in the voicing and stance of the translator, and in the relevance to the receiving audience" (Tymoczko 2003: 183).

In this section, we are going to employ the appraisal framework to examine the translator's stance and attitudinal positioning in translation, which is related to social accountability of the translator.

Appraisal is a "model of evaluation within the general theoretical framework of SFL" (Martin and White 2005/2008: 7). It constitutes a methodological orientation focused on the systematic analysis of how linguistic practices articulate value judgments, negotiate subject positions, construct authorial identities within texts, and regulate relational dynamics between communicative participants (White 2002).

According to Martin and White (2005/2008: 34–35), appraisal "is one of three major discourse semantic resources construing interpersonal meaning" and "itself is regionalized as three interacting domains—'attitude', 'engagement', and 'graduation'". The three domains of attitude refer to the "three semantic regions covering what is traditionally referred to as emotion, ethics and aesthetics" (Martin and White 2005/2008: 42). Affect is concerned with registering positive or negative feelings concerning happiness, sadness, confidence, anxiety, interests, etc. Appreciation involves the evaluation of semiotic and natural phenomena according to the ways in which they are valued or not in a given field, and judgment deals with attitudes towards behavior, which we admire or criticize, praise or condemn. Martin and White also suggest that one way to think about the three categories of attitude is to

see them as "institutionalized feelings, which take us out of our everyday common sense world into the uncommon sense worlds of shared community values" (2005: 45). Out of the three categories of attitude, perhaps the categories of appreciation and judgement will be the most relevant.

It is understandable that evaluation often directly inscribed in discourse through the use of attitudinal lexis and different lexical choices in translation indicate different attitudes: positive or negative stance of appreciation or judgement. In English-Chinese translation, there is a method call "Choosing the right word (选词)" (see Table 16.2), in which the translator often has to choose a lexical item from a group of synonyms. In so doing, he/she would have taken position intentionally or unintentionally. Take "*He is a politician*" as an example. "Politician" in English is a noun with neutral meaning, but it has no exact equivalent in Chinese. In the Chinese language there are only near equivalents such as "政治家" (politician with positive connotation) and "政客" (politician with negative connotation). When reading the statement "*He is a politician.*", the translator has to ask: who is he? Is he a man popular among his own community? The translation could be "他是位政治家"; otherwise, it would be "他是个政客".

Let us look at two more examples from the media.

Example 1. News headlines about Nancy Pelosi's visit to Taiwan

a) House Speaker Nancy Pelosi ***travels to*** Taiwan (CNN)
b) Nancy Pelosi ***visits*** Taiwan, angers China (AP)
c) 南希• 佩洛西窜访台湾 (CCTV)

Different news agencies often use their own discourse to report or comment on the news stories. In news translation, we may regard the actual happening as the source object and different reports as interpretations/translations. In the case of the US House speaker Pelosi's visit to Taiwan, almost all western news reports on this event as "visit" or "travel", as that by CNN and AP. The English words visit and travel are neutral verbs without any attitude or opinion. The news headlines seem just to be reporting a happening or telling a story. However, the Chinese media viewed this event from a different perspective. CCTV was the first to use the verb "窜访"(cuàn fǎng), then almost all media in China use the verb cuàn fǎng to report, describe and comment on Pelosi's visit to Taiwan. Cuàn fǎng is a Chinese verb, which means a provocative, ill-intentioned visit.

In this example, we can see different media attitudes through an analysis of the lexical meaning construing in the discourse. And in this case, we judge Pelosi's behavior from the perspective of "social sanction" which is "more often codified in writings, as edicts, decrees, rules, regulations and laws about how to behave as surveilled by church and state—with penalties and punishments as levers against those not complying with the code" (Martin and White 2005/2008: 52).

In their appraisal framework, Martin and White also described an important subsystem of meanings, i.e. graduation**.** According to them, Graduation is "a general property of values of affect, judgement and appreciation that they construe greater

or lesser degrees of positivity or negativity" (2005/2008: 135). More specifically, "graduation operates across two axes of scalability—that of grading according to intensity or amount, and that of grading according to prototypicality and the preciseness by which category boundaries are drawn" (Martin and White 2005/2008: 137). The former type refers to the force—scale up or scale down; and the latter type refers to focus—sharpen or soften.

The semantics of graduation is a frequent phenomenon to be accounted for in translation, and the theory of graduation is very useful in translation studies. Example 2 is a literary translation, in which the source text is from the English novel *Vanity Fair*, and the Chinese translation is by Yang Bi, a famous translator in China.

Example 2.

ST. … yet, as it sometimes happens that a person departs his life, who is really deserving of the praises the stone-cutter carves over his bones; who is a **good** Christian, a **good** parent, child, wife or husband; who actually does have a disconsolate family to mourn his loss; …(Thackeray 1908: 7).

TT. 不过偶尔也有几个死人当得起石匠刻在他们朽骨上的好话。真的是虔诚的教徒,慈爱的父母,孝顺的儿女,贤良的妻子,尽职的丈夫,他们家里的人也的确哀思绵绵地追悼他们。(translated by Yang Bi 1957: 4)

Back translation: … yet, as it sometimes happens that a person departs his life, who is really deserving of the praises the stone-cutter carves over his bones; who is a **devout** Christian, a **loving** parent, an **obedient** child, a **virtuous** wife or a **responsible** husband; who actually does have a disconsolate family to mourn his loss; …

Example 2 shows that the writer of *Vanity Fair* used a general adjective "good" to regard the persons deserving the praises the stone-cutter carves over their gravestones. But what does "good" mean? "Good" is a general appraisal word, we can easily find dozens of words that people often use to refer to good deeds or qualities. For example, *honest, fair, just, helpful, kind, friendly, responsible, virtuous* etc. The author of the book probably had more detailed words to evaluate the five different roles he was mentioning, but he decided to choose a more general word "good", letting the reader to interpret the possible substitutions by themselves.

In Chinese translation, however, there are at least two factors the translator would take into consideration. On the one hand, if the phrase "who is a **good** Christian, a **good** parent, child, wife or husband" be translated literally into "他们是好教徒,好父母,儿女,妻子,丈夫", it may sound pretty awkward. On the other hand, if it is translated with the missing "goods" and also interpreted, "他们是好教徒,好父母,好儿女,好妻子,好丈夫", it would sound a little redundant.

Yang Bi has her own interpretations of the word "good", or more specifically of the social roles of different people. She does not simply convey "good" into "好" (hǎo); instead, she assigns five specific values to judge the different roles: 虔诚的教徒,慈爱的父母,孝顺的儿女,贤良的妻子,尽职的丈夫 (a **devout** Christian, a **loving** parent, an **obedient** child, a **virtuous** wife or a **responsible** husband). Yang's translation has been well received and this paragraph has been widely used in translation teaching and praised as "an artistic, creative translation which distinguished itself from other

good works of translation" (Luo 1984: 849). Using evaluative words such as "artistic" and "creative" to evaluate a translation is a common and traditional way of judgment in which the appraiser looks at linguistic features and style of the translated text rather than looking at the translator's attitude, or relating the linguistic choices to social values.

Using the appraisal framework to analyze this translation, we could say that the translator uses more specific adjectives to achieve the preciseness in identifying the different social roles, sharpening the focus of attention to the reader.

Let us look at another example which indicates the translator "scaling up the force" of language in translation.

Example 3.

ST. BYD: The top electric car maker that is not Tesla (BBC News)

LT. 比亚迪:顶级汽车制造商不再是特斯拉 (by the present authors)

TT. 中国汽车巨头比亚迪已成特斯拉劲敌

(https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/662510070)

BT. Chinese automotive giant BYD has become Tesla's strong enemy.

In Example 3, the English version sounds much more mild with the news title "BYD: The top electric car maker that is not Tesla"; whereas, the Chinese version has turned the mild statement into a more forceful one:中国汽车巨头比亚迪已成特斯拉劲敌 (Back Translation: Chinese automotive giant BYD has become Tesla's strong enemy).

Putting the translation in appraisal framework for analysis, it is easy to understand that the translator adds a more specific image 劲敌 (strong enemy) to scale up the force of the news headline. The philosophy behind this shift is most possibly to please the target language readers in Chinese.

16.4 Implications for Translation Teaching and Translation Practice

Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL) and Translation Studies (TS) are two closely related subjects of study, the relationship of which is both profound and multifaceted. This article gives a brief review of some previous research achievements in applying SFL in TS, which also shows the development trend in the field, namely the focus of research goes from linguistic shifts and situational contexts to the value-driven nature of the sociocultural framework. We have discussed the application of SFL in TS in three aspects. Firstly, SFL can help to build up a model to systematically categorize translation methods and explain the philosophy behind them from a linguistic perspective. Secondly, SFL emphasizes the importance of context—both the broader cultural context and the immediate situational context. This is crucial for translation,

as understanding the context is essential for producing a translation that is appropriate and accurate. Thirdly, the appraisal framework developed upon SFL is useful in examining the translator's attitudinal positioning in relation to social and cultural environments.

Catford's model of translation shift is actually a meaning-oriented approach based on the Firthian and Hallidayan linguistic model, analyzing language as communication, operating functionally in context, and on a range of different levels useful for research and teaching because it provides, in a detailed and fairly systematic manner, a classification of translation shifts involving various classes and types of words and expressions. Researchers can also employ such logical classification in building corpus and in quantitatively investigating large amounts of literature.

SFL emphasizes the importance of context—both the broader cultural context and the immediate situational context. This is crucial for translation as well, as understanding the context is essential for producing a translation that is appropriate and accurate. In traditional translation studies, the major criteria for translation quality were faithfulness to the source text. Now, with the application of SFL, the contextual factors are included in evaluating the translation. With considerations of the contextual factors such as the "activity going on; the social action that is taking place", "the interacting roles" and "the particular functions that are assigned to language in this situation", the criteria for translation quality has become broader and more practicable. Indeed, Halliday's model of linguistic analysis can render valuable help in translation research and translation teaching.

Thirdly, we have discussed the translator's operation from linguistic shifts to social accountability. Matthiessen (2012: 436) states that "Social accountability thus includes the notion of a critical stance (as opposed to an uncritical one), but it is much broader: importantly, it also includes programmes for community-oriented action". He also quotes from Halliday (1975/2003: 89) in the footnote: "Social accountability is a complex notion which cannot be taken in from one angle alone. … There is an ideological component to it" (ibid).

The Appraisal framework developed upon SFL is useful in examining the translator's attitudinal positioning, which is usually shaped by the particular cultural and ideological situations in which the translator lives. Consider the words used by Yang Bi (see Example 2) to judge the five roles she viewed as "good": a ***devout*** Christian, a ***loving*** parent, an ***obedient*** child, a ***virtuous*** wife or a ***responsible*** husband. Here good qualities of human beings are positively assessed by reference to some sets of social norms. All these evaluative words lead to the system of morality that governs the behavior in the culture in which the translation is produced. The translator's attitudinal positioning implies that the negative values of human behavior, i.e. a ***lapsed*** Christian, a ***cruel*** parent, a ***disobedient*** child, an ***immoral*** wife and an ***irresponsible*** husband breach the norm of the society. Similarly, even a simple lexical choice of 政客 or 政治家for a *politician* indicates the translator's attitude. Likewise, the way particular words in a text will be interpreted may also depend on the social and ideological position of the reader/translator.

16.5 Concluding Remarks

This article provides a review and analysis of the application of SFL in TS, revealing how SFL has expanded from language-level translational research to the broad field of social responsibility. SFL provides a rich theoretical framework and methodological support for translation research, from early language conversion theories to considerations of context and cultural backgrounds, to translators' attitude positioning and knowledge creation in social practice. These studies not only deepen our understanding of the translation process but also provide new perspectives and tools for translation teaching and practice. In the future, with the continuous deepening of interdisciplinary research, the application of SFL in TS will continue to promote the development of this field and facilitate a wider integration of translation studies from linguistics to social sciences. We hope this article can inspire more researchers to adopt discourse analysis methods based on SFL and further explore the multidimensional and complex aspects of translation studies.

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Chapter 17
Researching Translation Quality Assessment: A Systemic-Functional Linguistics Perspective



Xianzhu Si

Abstract This paper reviews the ideas, procedures, and parameters of translation quality assessment from a systemic-functional linguistics perspective and discusses the revisions and developments in this line.

Keywords Translation quality assessment · House's model · Systemic functional linguistics · Revisions

17.1 Introduction

Systemic-functional linguistics has proved itself to be an applicable linguistic theory for translation studies. We believe that it can contribute to the improvement of translation quality in no small way. On the other hand, systemic-functional linguistics has provided a powerful tool for the evaluation of translation quality as well. To be specific, it offers theoretical foundations for constructing models of translation quality assessment as well as helpful instruments for evaluating particular translation works.

17.2 Review of Translation Quality Model by Juliane House

A scientific, objective, and systematic evaluation of the quality of any translation calls for an effective, comprehensive model of assessment. However, the construction of a powerful translation quality assessment model cannot be done without the guidance of a proper linguistic theory. Over the decades, systemic functional linguistics, among many others, has been favored by many translation theorists and critics. Among

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them, Juliane House is probably the first scholar who has made great contributions to translation quality assessment heavily based on systemic-functional linguistics (House 1977, 1997, 2001, 2014). In 1977, House published her monograph *A Model for Translation Quality Assessment*, which is based on her doctoral thesis finished in 1976. The second edition of the book appeared in 1981. In 1997, a newly revised edition got published under the title of *Translation Quality Assessment: A Model Revisited*. Just as she says, any translation quality assessment presupposes a theory of translation. She herself clearly acknowledges that one of the theoretical sources of her translation quality assessment model is systemic-functional linguistics (House 1997: 118).

In general, House's linguistics-based model of translation quality assessment draws upon the systemic-functional linguistic theories of textual analysis, especially the theory of register. Specifically, based on the three components of verbal behavior (i.e. form, function, and context of situation) and their interactions, systematic analyses and comparisons are made between the situational and formal (linguistic) features of source and target texts to find out the equivalence and deviation. The function of a text, both ideational and interpersonal, is defined as the application of the text in a particular context of situation. The context of situation is broken down into particular features, or situational dimensions. House's (1977) original model of translation quality assessment employs "three dimensions characterizing the text's author according to his temporal, geographical and social provenance and five dimensions of language use elaborating on the text's topic and on the interaction of, and relationship between, author and recipients in terms of their social role relationship, the social attitude obtaining, the degree of participant involvement and of writtenness or orality" (House 2014: 249).

Consequently, the analysis and comparison are conducted along the above eight situational dimensions. The degree to which the textual profile and function of the translated text match the profile and function of the original text is taken as the degree to which the translation is adequate in quality. That is to say, the higher the relative match is, the better the translation quality will be. It should be noted that a distinction is made between dimensional mismatches and non-dimensional mismatches in valuating the relative match between the original text and its translation. Dimensional mismatches are pragmatic errors while non-dimensional mismatches are errors in rendering denotative meanings in the translated text or breaches of target language norms. The final qualitative judgement of the translation consists of both types of errors and of a statement of the relative match of the ideational and interpersonal functions. In House's (1997) revised model, the Hallidayan notions of register (i.e. field, tenor, and mode) and genre are introduced. Here we will not go into any further details for the sake of space.

There are some problems with House's model. Firstly, the set of parameters (i.e. situational dimensions) is not adequate enough. They are mainly concerned with the author and language use itself. There are no parameters concerning the impact of the translator on the translation works. Secondly, the results of translation quality assessment can be influenced by the evaluator himself, say, his linguistic competence, individual style, aesthetics, values, and social ideologies. Thirdly, the specific

procedures of analysis and comparison also need to be optimized (Si 2005b: 83). In addition, some cases of non-equivalence in translation cannot be taken as errors, which may be due to the translator's purposeful translation strategies such as elaboration and compensation (Gutt 1991: 46–49). Despite these, House's linguistics-based model of translation quality assessment remains influential as one of the classic models of translation.

17.3 Construction and Revision of Translation Quality Assessment Model

17.3.1 Construction of the Original Translation Quality Assessment Model: Concepts, Procedures, and Parameters

People's understanding and judgment of translation quality is closely related to the translation standards they adhere to, and translation standards are closely related to people's understanding of the essence of translation. Therefore, when discussing translation quality, it is necessary to first clarify the essence of translation.

What is the essence of translation? Based on the differences in researchers' cognition and perspectives, the answer to this question varies from person to person. From the perspective of systemic-functional linguistics, language has three meta-functions: ideational function, interpersonal function, and textual function. Correspondingly, the form of language use—discourse, parole, or text—displays three meanings: ideational, interpersonal, and textual. Therefore, the essence of translation lies in the fact that "meanings" remain unchanged when transferred from one language to another.

"Translation is the use of semantic and pragmatic equivalence in the target language to replace the source text" (House 1977: 30). "Translation generally seeks equivalence in meaning between the source text and the translated text. Translation should seek to have the same meaning and function in discourses of two languages within the same overall situational context". "The equivalence relationship in translation cannot be based solely on one meaning (usually ideational meaning); while seeking ideational equivalence in discourse between two languages, it is also necessary to seek equivalence in interpersonal meanings such as the speaker's attitude, motivation, judgment and role, as well as in discourse meanings such as medium, channel and rhetorical device. In general, a good translation needs to be equivalent to the source text in all three senses" (Hu et al. 1989: 188).

Therefore, based on the explanation of the essence and standards of translation in systemic-functional linguistics, assessing the quality of translated discourse is to examine whether the translation is equivalent to the source text in the three meanings or functions mentioned above.

However, from the perspective of constructing translation quality assessment models, this does not necessarily mean that the three classifications of language function in Systemic-functional linguistics and the three segmentations of meaning carried by language (represented by discourse) should be listed in parallel as the three parameters for examining translation quality. This is because, although the meanings (ideational and interpersonal) that people use language to express cannot be separated from the "intermediary" of textual meaning, the latter's role is after all to organize the ideational and interpersonal meanings, and its role is to assist in the realization of the first two meanings, and it does not itself represent "content", so not at the same level as the first two meanings. From the perspective of expressing non-linguistic content, any discourse (parole, text) and its components, such as clauses, only express two functions/meanings. In view of this, the judgment of the translation quality depends only on whether the ideational meaning/function and interpersonal meaning/function of the translated text are equivalent to the source text. In other words, in terms of setting parameters for the evaluation model, only two items are needed: ideational and interpersonal meaning (House 1977, 1997; Si 2007, 2008).

However, it must be emphasized that it is impossible for the translated text to achieve equivalence in both the ideational and interpersonal meanings with the source text without the simultaneous equivalence at the organizational level, namely, the equivalence in the textual meaning.

Based on this, conducting translation discourse quality assessment is to explore the ideational and interpersonal meanings of the source text and translated text by analyzing the transitivity and mood (including modality) systems that respectively realize ideational and interpersonal meanings, as well as the lexical-grammar (such as themes) that realize textual function and assist in the realization of ideational and interpersonal meanings.

That is to say, to construct a translation quality assessment model, on the one hand, only two parameters of ideational meaning and interpersonal meaning need to be established. On the other hand, when examining whether the translation is equivalent to the source text in these two parameters, it is necessary to examine whether the textual function enabling ideational meaning and interpersonal meaning is appropriately replanted in the translation, because the textual function that realizes information organization, whether at the micro or macro level, has an impact on the expression of ideational and interpersonal meanings.

Specifically, the procedure and parameters on which a translation quality assessment model is based are as follows:

According to the speech act framework of systemic-functional linguistics on language use and its interaction among form, function, and context (Si 2005a), the first step starts from the cognition of the overall meaning/function of a discourse as the result of organic combination of its basic constituent units—the meaning/function of clauses. At the micro-clause level, the three meanings of the clause—ideational, interpersonal, and textual—are directly influenced by the register reflecting the situational context—field, tenor, and mode. Then, starting from the corresponding lexicogrammar system in the language that realizes these three meanings, this step analyzes the transitivity, mood (including modality), and theme of clauses in the

source and translated texts to reveal and describe their ideational and interpersonal meanings, thus determining whether or where the translation has "deviated" from the source text.

The second step, from a macro perspective, is to re-examine the various "deviated" cases discovered and described at the micro level, as well as the features of the target language, translation scenarios and requirements, and purposes, with the aim to eliminate the "deviations" that do not damage the overall quality of the translation.

Next, in the third step, based on the value judgment in the second step, the statistical quantities in the first step are revised. Thus, by adjusting the "deviated" cases, we are capable of judging on to what extent the translation is "equivalent" or "faithful" to the source text.

Finally, when evaluating the overall quality of the translation, it is also necessary to consider the type of text being translated, and determine the corresponding impact weights of different types of meaning deviations—ideational, interpersonal, on the quality of the translation. This model is illustrated as follows (Fig. 17.1):

For this model, we have conducted an actual assessment of the translation quality of popular science papers, novels, and advertisements representing three types of discourse: information, expression, and operation (Si 2007). We have found that in the actual translation quality assessment, we can emphasize certain steps based on different discourse types, and weaken or even omit other steps. For the assessment of operative texts such as advertising translations, the second step in the assessment model needs to be emphasized; on the other hand, the assessment of information texts such as popular science is the opposite, emphasizing the first step and weakening the second step.

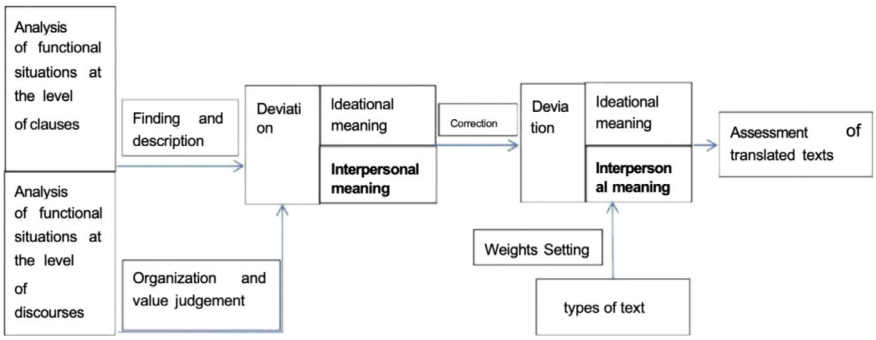


Fig. 17.1 Translation quality assessment model

17.3.2 Revision of the Model

Judging the quality of a translation based on the aforementioned model is both descriptive—where the translation deviates from the source text, and illustrative—why some parts of the translation do not correspond to the source text, which is deviation. In the second and third steps of this model, the deviations described at the micro level are sorted out from the perspective of the relationship between the whole and the parts, as well as the impact of internal and external factors on the discourse (wording). In this way, the "deviations" (referred to as positive deviations) that do not have a negative impact on the overall quality of the translation are eliminated, thus breaking away from the static perspective of the text. However, due to the fact that the assessment of translation quality is entirely based on the statistical analysis of "deviation" cases, for emoticons and operative translations whose dominant function belongs to the interpersonal function/meaning category, the quality assessment of the translation thus made according to the above model is often difficult to be convincing.

This is because translation deals with specific discourses, and as an actual discourse, it must belong to a certain type and play either an ideational or interpersonal dominant function. Therefore, from the perspective of successful translation, the translation naturally requires the transmission of the dominant function of the source text.

The aforementioned translation standards based on systemic-functional linguistics require the translation to be "equivalent" to the source text. For the translation of different types of discourse, there are often quite different situations in terms of the relationship between the micro level (meaning of the constituent parts of the discourse, such as clauses) and the macro level (dominant meaning of the discourse). For informational discourse, generally speaking, as long as the equivalent transformation of the aforementioned three language functions is achieved in the micro part of the constituent discourse, the entire translated discourse basically achieves equivalence of the dominant function/meaning of the source discourse, that is, the micro and macro aspects are basically unified. However, for the translation of vocative texts, in order to achieve equivalence in the dominant function of the source text—the same or similar discourse effects—what House calls "cultural filtering" is often implemented, adjustments in the translation—addition, deletion, combination, and change of expression are more often than not are applied.

This is also known as genre-level adaptation and adjustment. As a result, the translation often fails to maintain consistency with the source text at the micro level, such as the function/meaning level of phrases and clauses (Si 2007). Therefore, from the perspective of translation quality assessment, if the equivalence requirements of the translated text can be unified at both the micro level (ideational and interpersonal function of phrases and clauses) and the macro level (dominant function of the text), such as the translation of some informational texts, then translation quality assessment is relatively simple in using the procedures and parameters of the original assessment model to examine whether there are or how many "deviation" cases in the translation.

However, for the evaluation of translation quality of some operative and vocative texts, simply using "deviation" as the observation point is not enough. The original assessment model uses statistical analysis of the types and quantities of deviations from the source text as the sole basis for determining the quality of the translation, the design of which is severely flawed. In other words, a value judgment should be made based on the positive and negative correlation between "equivalence" and the transmission of the entire discourse. As the above discussion already shows, when discussing the situation of "deviation", not all "deviations" have a negative impact on the translation, and not all "equivalence" helps to achieve the equivalent transmission of the original function in the translation. For translated texts, including some vocative ones, there are indeed some translations that are "equivalent" to the source text at the micro level, such as clauses. However, at the macro level, it often means that the dominant function of the translated text is "not equivalent" to the source text, which is known as "equivalence in small areas and inequality in large areas". Therefore, in order to evaluate the quality of translations more comprehensively and scientifically, it is necessary to make revisions to the original assessment model both in terms of procedures and parameters.

In terms of procedure, it needs to be revised to add a link where the translation is functionally/meaningfully equivalent to the source text at the micro level, such as the clause level, but the main function of the text is considered to be contrary to the original function. In terms of parameters, it is to add "negative equivalence", which refers to the aforementioned "equivalent at micro level but not at macro level", or "false equivalence". (As for the cases of "equivalence" at the discourse level and "deviation" at the micro level, it has already been reflected and resolved in the "deviation" link of the original model—not recorded as deviation cases that affect the quality of the translation.) Due to our perspective on assessing translation quality model from negative impacts, we only need to pay attention to the cases of "deviation" and "negative equivalence". In this way, the modified evaluation model process is as follows (Si 2008) (Fig. 17.2):

17.4 Development of the Model

In spite of due attention paid to the text type and thus reflected in the design of the model, which still suffers from a serious defect: lack of genre analysis, because text type does not amount to the genre. Therefore, in order to improve and develop the assessment model, it is necessary to incorporate genre concepts into the assessment model parameters. Specifically, when assessing a translation, genre analysis should be conducted on the translation and its source text.

Genre analysis involves both stylistic analysis and discourse analysis. Its purpose is to study the communicative purposes and language use strategies. The purpose of genre analysis is to answer why people tend to organize their discourses and choose words and sentences in this way rather than that one when constructing a certain discourse. The organization here refers to the schematic structure, generic structure

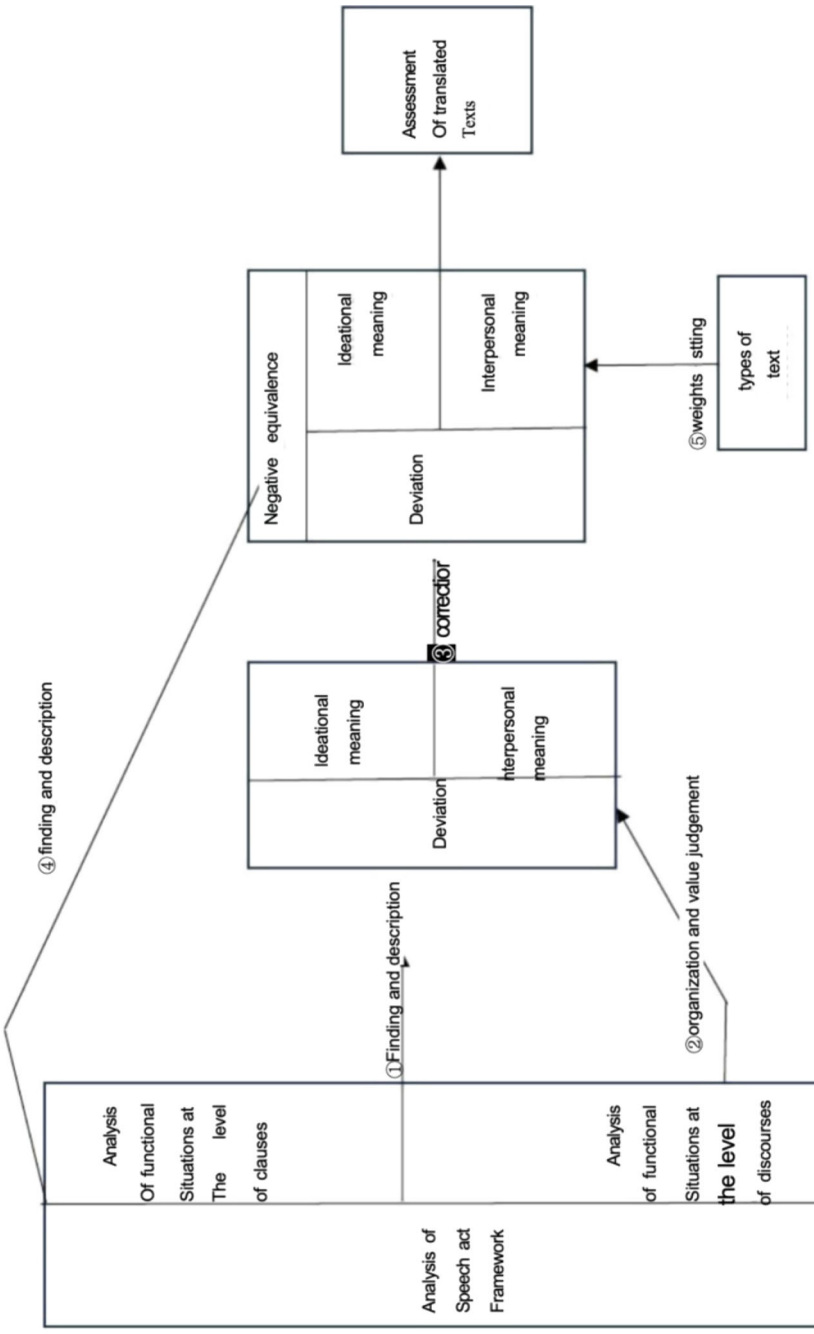


Fig. 17.2 Revised translation quality assessment model

potential (GSP), and move-step, while the choice of words and sentences belongs to the same category as the aforementioned stylistic and linguistic features, and stylistic markers. Given this, we believe that to determine the quality of a translation regarding to whether excellent or inferior, apart from the extent to match with the source text in terms with the ideational and interpersonal meaning, it also depends on whether the translation is equivalent or similar in the cultural context—genre, namely, to what extent the dimensions of the genre schematic structure and realization pattern are equivalent or similar, that is, genre equivalence.

How to achieve genre equivalence between the translation and the source text? We believe that to achieve the communicative purpose of the translation and achieve genre equivalence between the translation and the source text, this goal can be realized at two levels. At the level of genre planning and organization, translators are required to identify the discourse structure of the target language by analyzing parallel texts of the same genre as the source text, clarify the differences between the source text and the translation in this regard, and make corresponding adjustments to the translated text. At the level of linguistic style, translators set to analyze target language texts of the same genre as the source text to identify the language features and matching methods of this genre in the target language, thus to guide the choice of words and sentences in the construction of the translated text. Thus, it is a top-down translation perspective and strategy based on the overall discourse. As for constructing a translation quality assessment model, it is also geared at the overall discourse level, examining whether the textual organization of the translation is equivalent to or deviated from the same type of text in the target language from the perspective of genre structure, whether the linguistic features of the translation are similar to or deviated from the text of the same genre in the target language.

The setting of genre analysis parameters (schematic structure and realization pattern) has solved the expressiveness and beautifulness of translated text in the target language not only in terms of genre structure but also in terms of linguistic features. From the perspective of translation quality assessment, it examines the issue of "expressiveness and elegance" required by traditional translation standards to measure translation quality. From the traditional translation standard of "faithfulness, expressiveness, and elegance" required of translation, it is obvious that the original assessment model only focuses on the "faithfulness" of the translated text relative to the source text, while the requirements for "expressiveness, and elegance" of the translated work are missing, a serious defect. In other words, the setting of genre analysis parameters addresses the aforementioned defect of the original model.

Of course, it should be affirmed that the original model has given sufficient attention to whether or to what extent the translated text is "equivalent" and "faithful" in terms of ideational and interpersonal meaning compared to the source text. For 'meaning-based' translation, the success of the translation quality assessment model largely depends on whether and to what extent the parameters set in the model can actually be evaluated. It is gratifying that the original model has effectively solved this problem.

What needs to be added to the original model is the parameter to assess the expressiveness or elegance. But to perfect the model, it is found necessary to clarify the

expressions used in the original model. The expression of “false equivalence” in the original assessment model, the so-called “equivalence at the micro level but not the macro level”, is not proper, because “equivalence” mainly refers to the faithfulness of the translation relative to the source text at the semantic and functional levels. However, the phenomenon of “false equivalence” used in the original assessment model refers to the issue of whether the meaning carried by the source text is sufficiently and appropriately expressed in the translation. So, it does not mainly focus on “faithfulness”, but rather belongs to the categories of “expressiveness” and “elegance”. For instance:

> 八月一日第AG-3号合同项下的10万吨小麦，原定于十月底以前交货。你方在合同中保证提前交货，并且以此作为签订合同的条件。但是，这批小麦迄今尚未装运。对此，我们深表遗憾。

If translated directly into Chinese, the translated text may look like this:

> The 100,000 tons of wheat under Contract No. AG-3 of August 1 is scheduled to be delivered by the end of October. You have guaranteed an early delivery in the Contract and it is on this understanding that we signed the contract. Up to now, however, the shipment has not yet been made. We very much regret for that.

This kind of translation, due to its complete adherence to the original structure, can be said to be “faithful” or “equivalent” at the micro clause level. However, from the perspective of the entire English writing, there is a loose structure, weak logic, and a lack of prominent semantics, which makes people feel confused and not be able to get the point. Therefore, although the translated text can safely be said to be faithful to the source text in terms of meaning transmission, the problem is that the translated text shows a strong translationese due to being too limited to the original structure, as of a consequence of not being smooth, let alone beautiful, that is, the so-called “faithful but not beautiful”. However, if translated as:

> We very much regret that the 100,000 tons of wheat under Contract No. AG-3 of August 1, scheduled to be delivered by the end of October, is up to this moment not dispatched, in spite of fact that you have guaranteed an early delivery in the Contract, which was actually signed on this understanding.

This translation is both faithful and smooth. Therefore, we believe that the “negative equivalence” or “false equivalence” that reflects the phenomenon of “equivalence at the micro level but not the macro level” in the original assessment model parameters should be modified to “mechanically corresponding, stiff and rough”, that is, “not smooth”.

Whether the original wording “equivalence at the micro level but not the macro level”, or the modified expression of “not smooth”, it must be operative first before it becomes an effective parameter in the model. We believe the evaluation of whether a translation is “mechanically corresponding, stiff or rough” or “not smooth” can be fully grasped by analyzing and summarizing the schematic structure and linguistic features of similar genre texts in the target language.

In addition, the original model’s elaboration on the speech act framework is basically limited to the situational context, that is, the register level, concerning the equivalence and appropriateness of the translation to the source text. This is necessary, but

it ignores the cultural context, that is, the equivalence and appropriateness of the translation to the original at the genre level. According to our research (Xiao and Si 2014), genre is an independent symbolic layer that transcends register and language. The three major meta-functions in systemic functional linguistics are the organizational levels of language, while the three variables of register are the organizational levels of situational context. The three variables of register closely correspond to three major metafunctions, namely, field corresponds to ideational function, tenor corresponds to interpersonal function, and mode corresponds to textual function. However, none of these meta-functions can cover the intention of a particular discourse. Genre has intentions, but cannot generate a one-to-one correspondence with meta-functions. It focuses on the overall effects of the three variables of register. That is to say, the implementation of genre is spread among the three major meta-functions. So, from the perspective of translation, if the translated work is not equivalent or similar in genre to the source text, its quality cannot be satisfactory. Therefore, from the perspective of improving the original model and enhancing operability, it is necessary to change "the situational, functional and formal expressions at the micro level of clauses" to "register analysis", and modify the "situational, functional and formal analysis at the macro level" to "genre analysis", which not only focuses on the impact of situational and cultural context on the meaning and language form of the translation, but also makes it more accessible and understandable. Of course, both "register analysis" and "genre analysis" are essentially included in speech act frameworks.

In this way, the assessment of the translation quality model can be divided into two stages:

In the first stage, assessing the function and meaning of the translated work relative to the source work, which is related to "faithfulness" and "equivalence", as shown in Fig. 17.3:

That is, the first step is to start from the cognition of the organic combination of the overall meaning/function of the discourse composed of its basic constituent unit—the meaning/function of the clause. At the clause level, from the perspective of context, function and formal interaction, starting the one-to-one correspondence between field, tenor, mode of the register, and the three meanings of the clause—ideational, interpersonal and textual, and the lexicogrammar system of the language that realizes these three meanings—transitivity, mood (including modality) and theme, the source and translated texts are analyzed, their ideational and interpersonal meanings are revealed and described, and whether or where the translation has deviated from the source text is determined.

The second step is to re-examine the various "deviation" cases discovered and described in the first step from the perspective of genre, standing at the height of the entire discourse, as well as from the interaction among form, function, and context, to exclude "deviation" cases that do not harm the overall quality of the translation from this perspective. As mentioned earlier, the role of genre in discourse is generally mediated through register, so dashed lines are used here to connect: on the one hand, it indicates that genre functions through register; on the other hand, unlike the first step, the second step mainly assesses deviations at the genre level beyond the register.

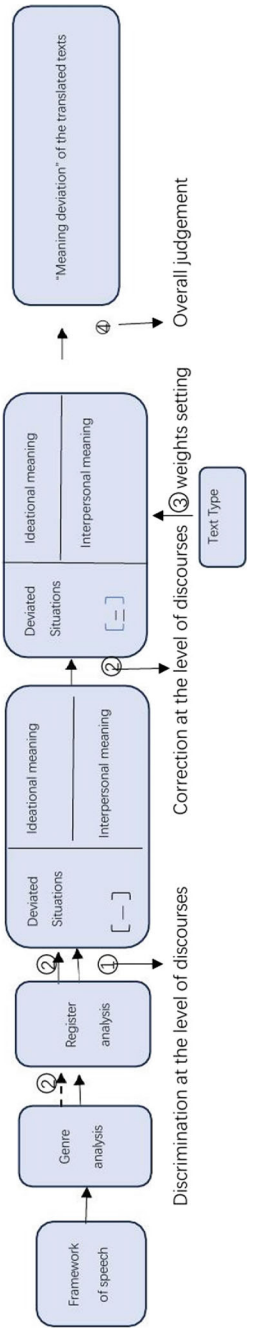


Fig. 17.3 Translation quality assessment model

The third step is to determine the corresponding weights of different types of meaning deviations—ideational and interpersonal—on the quality of the translated text based on the type of text being translated.

Finally, the fourth step is to complete the quality evaluation of the first stage of the translation: that is, to what extent the translation is faithful to the original text in terms of ideational and interpersonal meanings.

In the second stage, evaluating the language of the translated work itself for smoothness and elegance, focusing on "expressiveness and elegance" (Fig. 17.4).

That is, under the guidance of the speech act framework, it starts from the schematic structure and realization pattern of the two dimensions of genre analysis.

The first step is to identify the GSP patterns and linguistic features of the translated (target) language) of the same genre. Then, the second step is to analyze the GSP patterns and linguistic features of the translated text proper. On this basis, the third step is to compare the translation with similar genres of the target language in terms of schematic structure and linguistic features. The fourth step is to evaluate whether the translated text is "smooth" based on the schematic structure and linguistic features of similar genres of the target language. Finally, the fifth step is to make an evaluation judgment of the overall degree of "accessibility" and "smoothness" of the translation.

In this way, by combining the first and second stages, the overall evaluation of the translation quality can be finished from two aspects: "faithfulness" and "smoothness", as shown in Fig. 17.5.

Compared to the original model, this translation quality assessment model possesses two advantages: (a) inclusion of genre parameters and (b) the evaluation of expressiveness or elegance of the translated.

That is to say, guided by systemic-functional linguistics and genre analysis theory, the new model has overcome the shortcomings inherent of the original, thus a great leap forward to the researching translation quality assessment model. However, it must be pointed out that the revised new model mentioned above, like the original model, is a translation quality assessment model developed based on the translation perspective of systemic functional linguistics, which inevitably presupposes a "bystander" or "blind eye" to some factors and is therefore descriptive rather than prescriptive. This kind of assessment is just the author's viewpoint, which is not exclusive and does not exclude translation assessment from other perspectives. It is complementary to the assessments from other perspectives.

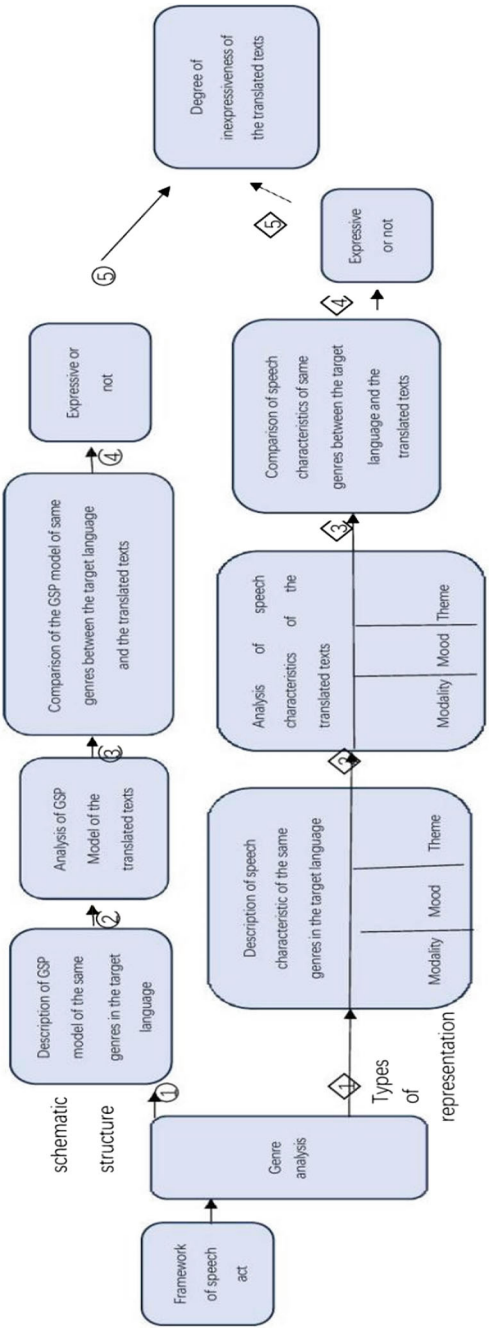


Fig. 17.4 Translation quality assessment model

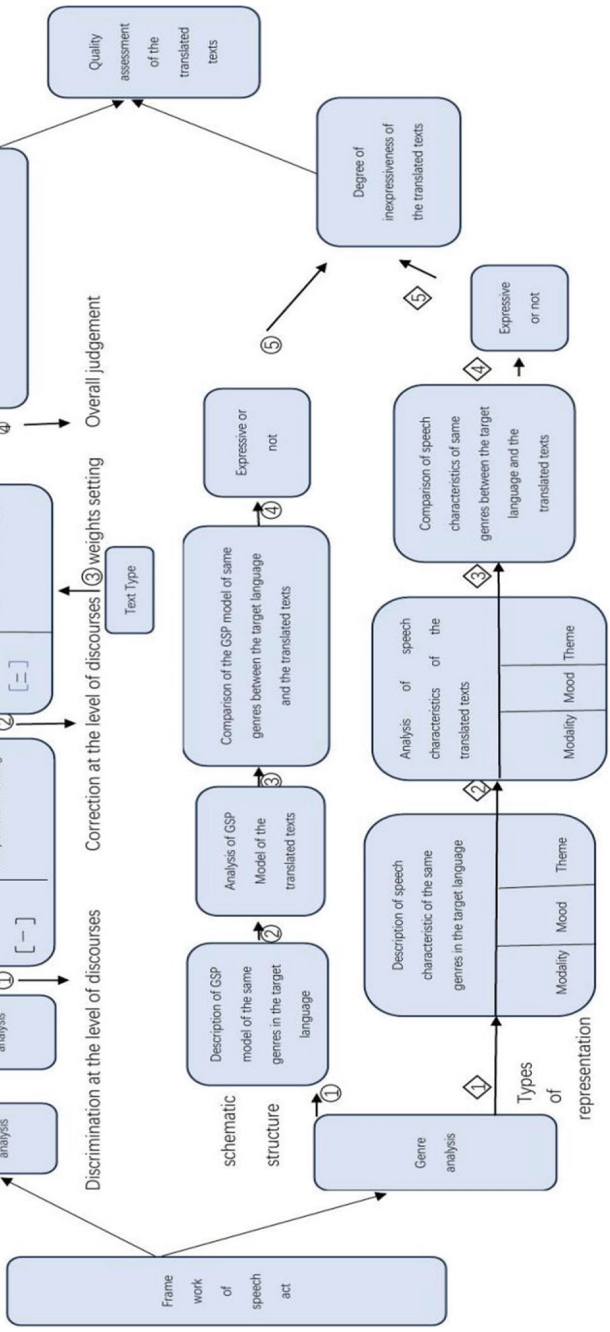


Fig. 17.5 Overview of translation quality assessment model process

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Xianzhu Si Ph.D., is a renowned scholar in contemporary China's linguistics circle. His main researches include Translation Studies, Systemic Functional Linguistics, and foreign language education. He has published widely in the aforementioned domains and related fields, including more than 135 research articles, 12 monographs, and over 30 other academic writings.

Chapter 18
A Systemic Functional Study of the AI-Aided English Translation of a Significant Concept in the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture



Manliang Li

Abstract This paper attempts to conduct a detailed study of the AI-aided English translation of a seemingly simple but very familiar and significant concept, *cǎoyuán míngzhū* ["grassland pearl", 草原明珠], in the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture. To do so, we use systemic functional linguistics as the theoretical framework, and the study is based on the systemic functional syntactic analysis and language comparison between the Chinese and English nominal groups by which the concept is realized. Besides, AI tools such as ChatGPT and DeepSeek are utilized to offer preliminary translations which form word and structure systems to be selected in the delicacy analysis that follows. The findings show that the AI-aided translation of the Chinese nominal groups ought not to be carried out in the way that the nominal group is translated as an independent grammatical unit isolated from the clause in which it appears. Rather, the factors of context are to be taken into consideration as the context plays a crucial role in helping to seek the right word and syntactic structure in inter-lingual translation. In addition, although the AI tools can provide various candidate words and structures, the selection of the options from the word and structure systems still has to be based on the functional syntactic analysis. It is hoped that this study may promote further research on the English translation of the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture, contribute to the localization of systemic functional approach to translation studies, and provide insights into AI-assisted translation studies, especially into the English translation studies of the Chinese nominal groups.

Keywords The Chinese Northern Borderland Culture · AI-aided English translation · Language comparison · Systemic functional linguistics

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18.1 Introduction

Since the beginning of the twenty-first century, China has further integrated into the world, gaining more and more international attention. There is an increasing need for the international community to get to know this rapidly developing country. Accordingly, when we translate the world, we must also focus on understanding and translating contemporary China to the world, allowing contemporary Chinese culture to reach a global audience (Huang 2022). The Chinese Northern Borderland is a term referring to the vast border region in the northern part of China with Inner Mongolia Autonomous Region as its core. The Chinese Northern Borderland Culture is an organic part of Chinese culture, and its English translation is of practical and theoretical importance for its global attention.

As the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture is such a broad concept with vast range of topics, it would be impossible to cover too much in a short paper. Instead, this paper focuses on a very specific topic, the English translation of a seemingly simple and familiar but a very significant concept, *cǎoyuán míngzhū*, ["grassland pearl", 草原明珠] in the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture. As is known to many people in China or even in the world, Inner Mongolia Autonomous Region is famous for its *cǎoyuán* (grassland) and its grassland culture. When people mention Inner Mongolia Autonomous Region, they would immediately think of its grassland and its grassland culture. As a result, *cǎoyuán míngzhū* is widely used to refer to the most precious and valuable things in their hearts. However, the literature to date as well as the materials about travel or public communications shows that there is no satisfying English translation of this expression. Just as McDonough and McDonough (1997/2000: 59) point out, originality may reside in "a new question", "new data", "a combination of data", "a new theory or modification of theory", "a new analysis of previously obtained data", or even "replicating a previous study to compare the results and thus establish its generalizability". A new study can either "solve an old problem with a new method" (Schiffrin et al. 2001: 4), or "describe something that had [has] not yet been described" (ibid.). *Cǎoyuán míngzhū* is an old topic but its AI-aided English translation has not been attempted, which is the motivation for the present research.

This study aims to answer this question: What is the best English translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū*, and why is it translated this way? To do so, we use systemic functional linguistics as the theoretical framework, and the study is based on the systemic functional syntactic analysis and language comparison between Chinese and English nominal groups by which this key concept is realized.

In this research, some AI tools such as ChatGPT Sider Fusion, ChatGPT 4.0mini, DeepSeek V3, and DeepSeek R170B are applied to provide basic and preliminary translations first. This is then followed by the systemic functional syntactic analysis of these different optional translations, which form the word systems and the structure system for the corresponding English nominal group. Next, the analysis is done through the selection of words, groups, phrases as well as the internal syntactic structures from the system networks.

18.2 Theoretical Framework

As was mentioned above, this research is based on the systemic functional syntactic analysis and language comparison between the English and Chinese nominal groups. It is widely acknowledged that syntactic analysis is as important as word recognition in comprehending the source language in translation. In other words, if we want to accurately understand a clause or a clause complex, we need to understand not only every word but also the whole syntactic structure of the clause or the clause complex. Fawcett (2008: 72) points out that "the main problem for a syntax analyst who is analyzing the sentences of a natural text is usually this: which words go with which to form a unit WITHIN a clause". Furthermore, the translation of a linguistic unit higher on the rank scale than a word into the target language cannot be done without the appropriate arrangement of the syntactic structure along with the selection of proper words. Systemic functional syntactic analysis is the combination of analysis of both syntactic structure and the functions of the elements in the construction. Naturally enough, grammatical categories are quite necessary in describing and analyzing the grammatical constructions both in Chinese and in English. As such, this section will give a brief introduction to grammatical categories and language comparison between the Chinese and English nominal groups in the framework of systemic functional linguistics.

18.2.1 Grammatical Categories

Halliday (1961/2007) clarifies the four basic grammatical categories, *unit*, *class*, *structure*, and *system*, and the three interrelationships among them, which are scales including *rank*, *exponence*, and *delicacy*. These are the core concepts of Scale and Category Grammar. As far as English grammar is concerned, the grammatical **units** include *sentence, clause*, *group* or *phrase*, *word,* and *morpheme*. *Unit* has a close connection with *rank scale* in that these units are placed in a certain order based on the rank. The *group* or *phrase* is an intermediate unit between the clause and the word. Halliday (1985, 1994/2000) later discards *sentence* but uses *clause complex* to refer to *sentence* in the former sense. Most systemic functional studies (e.g. Halliday and Matthiessen 2004, 2014; Bloor and Bloor 1995/2001, 2004, 2013; Thompson 1996/2000, 2004/2008, 2014) apply this principle.

Halliday (1994/2000) features eight-word **classes**, *noun*, *adjective, numeral*, *determiner*, *verb*, *preposition*, *adverb*, and *conjunction*. As to the class of group and phrase, Halliday (1994/2000: 179–214) classifies group and phrase in English as five groups and one phrase: *nominal group*, *verbal group*, *adverbial group*, *conjunction group*, *preposition group*, and *prepositional phrase*. **Structure** has a close association with unit and class in that every class of unit has its own unique structure, and the structure of both the English and Chinese nominal groups will be illustrated in the next subsection below.

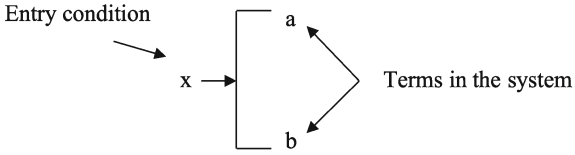


Fig. 18.1 Basic system (Eggins 2004: 194)

Besides the concept of *unit*, *class*, and *structure*, another significant concept of the grammatical category, *system*, is also applied in the present study. According to Halliday (1961/2007) and Eggins (2004: 194), "the basic system consists of an entry condition and a set of two or more signs in opposition, of which one and only one must be chosen". In other words, a basic *system* (Fig. 18.1) is made up of an entry condition and many options, and many *systems* form *system networks*.

The translation may concern the choices of grammatical units as well as the syntactic structures of various kinds, and it can be argued that these options form the system networks for the English translation of the specific Chinese text. As for the translation of the nominal group, the main choice resides in the selection of words and the specific nominal group structure. Meanwhile, these above-mentioned terms and concepts of grammatical categories are not only applicable in describing, explaining, and analyzing the English but also in the Chinese nominal group.

18.2.2 Comparison Between the Chinese and English Nominal Group

The present research is revolved around the English translation of a specific Chinese nominal group. This part will firstly offer a brief comparative overview of the internal functional structure of both English and Chinese nominal groups, since key technical terms are usually realized by nouns or more often nominal groups with complex internal structure. There follows a discussion of the principles relevant to the English translation of the Chinese nominal groups in general.

The basic internal structure of the English nominal group, however complicated it is, can be summarized as this: Premodifier^ (followed by) Head^Postmodifier. From the experiential perspective, the Premodifier includes Deictic, Numerative, Epithet, Classifier, or combinations of any of these elements. The Postmodifier is called Qualifier, and it is usually rank-shifted because the Qualifiers are often realized by groups, phrases, clauses or any combination of these grammatical units, which are either at the same level as the group or at the level higher than the group on the rank scale. Moreover, the Head and the Thing coincide with each other although there are some exceptions according to Halliday (1994/2000: 195–196). Besides, the order of these elements is relatively fixed or constant although there may be some exceptions occasionally, and the change of the usual order may mean differently or be considered a grammatical error.

Li (2007: 25) argues that the Chinese nominal group may include these elements: determiner^ numeral^ measure word^ classifier^ head. Table 18.1 is a simple illustration of systemic functional analysis of a Chinese nominal group.

Example 1: 那 两间 漂亮的 红色 木头 房子

In terms of the internal construction, the biggest difference between the English nominal group and the Chinese nominal group lies in the Postmodifier, as most of the latter is congruently comprised of only the Premodifier and the Head which is located at the end of the group.

Once in a while, there are a few Chinese nominal groups that do have the Postmodifier. In particular, the Numerative in the Chinese nominal group can either be a Premodifier or a Postmodifier. For example, *liǎngwǎn mǐfàn* (two bowls of rice), and *mǐfàn liǎngwǎn* (rice of two bowls) are both Chinese nominal groups with *mǐfàn* as the Head/the Thing and *liǎngwǎn* as the Numerative but acting as the Premodifier and the Postmodifier, respectively. The two constructions have the identical experiential meaning, although the thematic meaning is a bit different (see Li 2013, 2023). From the perspective of grammatical metaphor, the two different structures can be seen as the incongruent or metaphorical way of expressing the same propositional meaning. Furthermore, the order of the Premodifiers in the Chinese nominal group is a little bit more flexible than that of the English ones. All these factors and distinctions between the English and Chinese nominal groups need to be taken into consideration when we translate Chinese nominal groups into English.

18.3 AI Translations of *Cǎoyuán míngzhū*

In the section that follows, we are to give a detailed analysis of the translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* as an example of translating a Chinese nominal group into English.

Example 2:内蒙古大学被誉为草原明珠。

Nèiměnggǔ dàxué bèi yùwéi cǎoyuán míngzhū.

Inner Mongolia University is hailed as grassland bright pearl.

The following are cited from the AI translations, and they are translated in two separate ways, translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* in the whole clause and that of as an independent nominal group isolated from the clause in which it occurs.

Translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* as it appears in the clause:

(1) Inner Mongolia University is hailed as the pearl of the grasslands.
(2) Inner Mongolia University is known as the pearl of the grasslands.
(3) Inner Mongolia University is known as the pearl of the prairie.
(4) Inner Mongolia University is fondly called the pearl of the grasslands.
(5) Inner Mongolia University is hailed as the jewel of the grasslands.

Table 18.1 Systemic functional analysis of a Chinese nominal group

Nominal group	那	两间	漂亮的	红色	木头	房子
	nà	liǎngjiān	piàoglàng de	**hó**ngsè	mù**tó**u	fángzi
	those	two	beautiful	red	wooden	houses
Lexicogrammar	determiner	numeral measure word	adjective	adjective	noun	noun
Experiential structure	Deictic	Numerative	Epithet: Interpersonal	Epithet: Experiential	Classifier	Thing
Logical structure	Premodifier					Head
	ζ	ε	δ	γ	β	α

Translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* as an independent nominal group isolated from the clause in which it occurs:

(6) pearl of the grassland(s)
(7) pearl of the prairie
(8) prairie pearl
(9) grassland pearl
(10) prairie gem
(11) jewel of the grassland

The apparent distinction between these two ways of translation is manifested in that some nominal groups bear no Postmodifiers by the translation in the latter way. Another point that needs to be noted is that either the original Chinese nominal group or the translation of it only as an independent unit contains no determiner or Deictic, which the English nominal group usually does under normal conditions. Thus, it can be seen that context, even the context of co-text, is a crucial factor in translation. This may explain why *běijiāng* is translated by AI into *Northern Xinjiang* if it is translated in isolation but *Northern Borderland* in clauses or texts. The distinction results from the different language systems between English and Chinese, and also from the different contexts.

18.4 Systemic Functional Analysis of the Translations

Nèiměnggǔ dàxué (Inner Mongolia University) in this clause is a proper name, and *bèi yùwéi* is translated into *is hailed as* or *is known as*, or *is fondly called*. Translation of this proper name and this verbal group is simple and even obvious, so it is not the focus of our discussion in this study. What we focus on here is the translation of the nominal group *cǎoyuán míngzhū* in this clause or in any other contexts. Halliday (1994/2000: F39) argues that "language has evolved to satisfy human needs; and the way it is organized is functional with respect to these needs—it is not arbitrary". Similarly, the way it is translated is not arbitrary but to satisfy various needs in various situations.

The main investigation lies in the following aspects: the selection of the appropriate word from the English word system for *cǎoyuán*, the selection of the appropriate word from the English word system for *míngzhū*, the selection of appropriate syntactic structure from the structure system for the corresponding English nominal group, and the selection of an appropriate determiner from the word system for the Deictic. Figure 18.2 is the word system networks for the English translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū.*

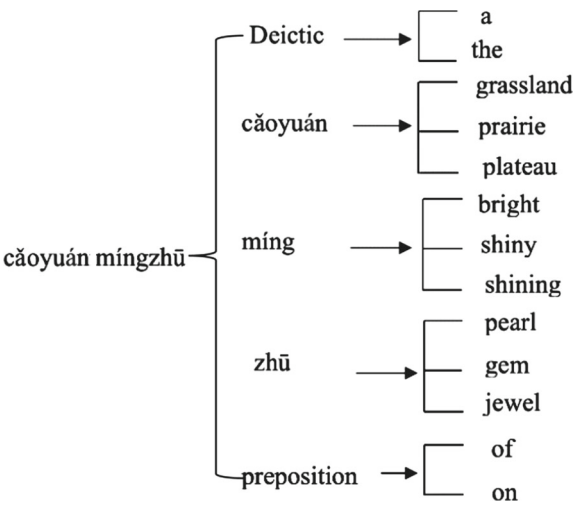


Fig. 18.2 Word system networks for the English translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū*

18.4.1 The Selection from the English Word System for Cǎoyuán

Cǎoyuán is a compound noun which is composed of two morphemes *cǎo* (grass) and *yuán* (land), although it may be seen as an endocentric construction, just as *píngyuán* (plains) or *gāoyuán* (plateau), with *yuán* as the Head morpheme. Thus, *cǎoyuán* is not a nominal group and is usually translated into *grassland*, *prairie*, or *plateau.* According to *Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English* (*LDOCE* hereafter), the three words are explained as these:

> *grassland*: a large area of land covered with wild grass. (*LDOCE* 2018)
>
> *prairie:* a wide open area of fairly flat land in North America which is covered in grass or wheat. (*LDOCE* 2018)
>
> *plateau:* a large area of flat that is higher than the land around it. (*LDOCE* 2018)

From the above explanations of the three words, we can conclude that the most proper choice of *cǎoyuán* is *grassland* simply because *prairie* particularly refers to a land in North America, and *plateau* stresses the height of the land. Although Inner Mongolia Plateau is one of the many plateaus in China, only *grassland* emphasizes a land covered with wild *grass*. *Grassland* is also a compound noun consisting of two free morphemes.

18.4.2 *The Selection from the English Word System for* Míngzhū

The translations provided above show that *míngzhū* has three possible English counterparts, *pearl*, *jewel*, and *gem*. These three words are defined as follows in *LDOCE* (2018):

> *pearl:* [C] a small round white object that forms inside an OYSTER, and is a valuable jewel.
>
> [U] a hard shiny substance of various colors formed inside some SHELLFISH, which is used for making buttons or to make objects look attractive. (*LDOCE* 2018)

jewel: a valuable stone, such as a diamond. (*LDOCE* 2018)

gem: a beautiful stone that has been cut into a special shape. (*LDOCE* 2018)

Jewel and *gem* are both stones, and the nuance is that the former seems to refer to an original stone while the latter means a stone "that has been cut into a special shape" and thus has a man-made trace. In this sense, these two words correspond to the Chinese noun *bǎoshí* (宝石) whose concept bears a small difference from that of *míngzhū*. *Míngzhū* is actually the short form for *míngliàng de zhēnzhū* (明亮的珍珠). The concept of *pearl* is closer to *zhēnzhū*, and therefore *pearl* is the right word in this context. In Chinese, *míngzhū* is a compound noun with endocentric construction rather than a nominal group, and *míng* serves as the Modifier morpheme and *zhū* is the Head morpheme.

However, *míngzhū* is not a common *zhēnzhū* but a pearl with special features. Consequently, the concept of *míng* has to be demonstrated, and the candidate words may be *bright*, *shiny*, or *shining*. All these three words are correct in terms of the experiential meaning. The first two words are themselves adjectives depicting a static state, while *shining* is either an adjective or a non-finite verb or even a non-finite clause, which indicates a dynamic state. Comparatively speaking, considering the context of the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture, a dynamic state can more vividly describe the position of this special pearl in the mind of the people in this region. In other words, *bright* and *shiny* are more like experiential Epithet while *shining* is more like an interpersonal Epithet. Thus, *míngzhū* is better translated into *a shining pearl* if it exists itself. Nevertheless, the translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* is another story. This is to be analyzed in the following part, which is concerned with the selection of the concrete satisfying syntactic structure of the nominal group.

18.4.3 *The Selection from the Structure System for the English Nominal Group*

Based on the translation and the analysis above, *cǎoyuán míngzhū* may be translated into any of the following. There must be a determiner or a Deictic at the beginning of the English nominal group and *grassland* ought to be in singular form just because the *grassland* here refers to the grassland locating in Inner Mongolia Autonomous

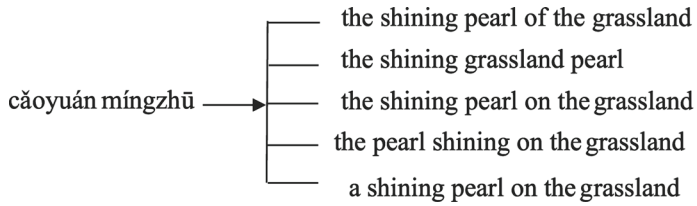


Fig. 18.3 Structure system of the English translation of cǎoyuán míngzhū

Region only. Figure 18.3 is the structure system of the English translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū.*

(12) the shining pearl of the grassland
(13) the shining grassland pearl

In both of these two nominal groups, *pearl* serves as the Head, and *shining* as the Epithet. The difference is that in (12) *grassland* is a part of the Qualifier, but in (13) *grassland* functions as the Classifier. As far as Classifier is concerned, it is used to classify the object that the Head refers to. This suggests that this pearl is a grassland pearl, not an ocean pearl nor a desert pearl. In fact, *grassland* does not perform as a Classifier to classify pearls but a location where the pearl is situated. Consequently, in the original Chinese nominal group, *grassland* is not a Classifier, but a Circumstantial Element. In this sense, *the shining grassland pearl* is not a good translation, and thus we may have the following two options:

(14) the shining pearl on the grassland
(15) the pearl shining on the grassland

The only difference between (12) and (14) is the use of the different preposition *of* and *on*. Halliday (1994/2000: 212–213) holds that the preposition is a mini-verb which can realize mini-process from the experiential view. The Complement of the preposition is the Participant of the mini-process. The prepositional phrases *of the grassland* and *on the grassland* in (12) and (14) both act as the Qualifier of the nominal group. Basically, the preposition *of* indicates belonging, meaning that the pearl belongs to the grassland wherever it is placed even if it is buried in the earth or hidden in a secret place. On the contrary, the preposition *on* emphasizes touching the surface, indicating the pearl is in a place that people can easily see if it is *on the grassland*. We do not have to hide this shining pearl but display it in a conspicuous position. In consequence, *on* seems more proper than *of* to illustrate the position of this pearl in the mind of people on the grassland. Once more, this consideration results from the context of Chinese Northern Borderland Culture.

Nonetheless, in (15), *shining on the grassland* itself is a non-finite clause with *on the grassland* performing as the Circumstantial Element of the Process *shining.* Then, when we compare *the shining pearl on the grassland* and *the pearl shining on the grassland*, we find that the slight difference exists in the stress, the former being on *pearl* while the latter being on *shining*. The fact is that our attention is actually

on the *pearl*, and *shining* is just its property. So, *the shining pearl on the grassland* is supposed to be a better translation than *the pearl shining on the grassland*.

18.4.4 The Selection from the Word System for the Deictic

Last but not the least, the selection of an appropriate determiner from the word system for the Deictic in the corresponding English nominal group cannot be ignored. Different from Chinese, even an independent English nominal group must contain a Deictic unless the Head word is in plural form. Hence, there is a great necessity to select the article, either definite article or determiner *the* or the indefinite article or determiner *a*, as both of them can serve as the Deictic here. The item *the* indicates the uniqueness, suggesting that the pearl is the only pearl on the grassland, while the word *a* indicates that this pearl is only one of many such pearls on the grassland. As a matter of fact, however significant it is, Inner Mongolia University is just one of many shining pearls on the grassland. There are many other institutions, scenic spots, and even cities that claim to be shining pearls on the grassland. As a consequence, the item *a* is a better option than*the* in functioning as the Deictic here in this nominal group.

Till now, we have found the satisfying translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* in this clause into *a shining pearl on the grassland*. The analysis by delicacy is displayed in Table 18.2. For the sake of convenience, we add some small items for the Chinese nominal group, and the resultant nominal group would be *(yīkē) cǎoyuán (shàng de) míngzhū*, *cǎoyuán (shàng de)(yīkē) míngzhū*, or *cǎoyuán (shàng de) míngzhū (yīkē)*. Whatever order it has, the function of each element remains unchanged.

This section has provided a detailed analysis of the English translations of *cǎoyuán míngzhū*, and the discussion is carried out from the perspective of selecting every word from the word systems in the construction together with the selection from the structure system of the overall structure for the corresponding English nominal group. The exploration process once again verifies the fact that both language comparison and context are equally significant in inter-lingual translation. We then settle on the translation of *cǎoyuán míngzhū* into *a shining pearl on the grassland* and offer a systemic functional analysis by delicacy of both the Chinese and the English nominal group as is demonstrated in Table 18.2.

18.5 Conclusion

This paper has conducted a detailed study of the AI-aided English translation of a seemingly simple and familiar but very significant concept in the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture, *cǎoyuán míngzhū*. Systemic functional linguistics is employed as the theoretical framework, and the research is based on the systemic functional syntactic analysis and language comparison between Chinese and English nominal

Table 18.2 Systemic functional analysis of *cǎoyuán míngzhū and its English translation*

Chinese nominal group	(一颗)	草原(上的)		明珠				
	(yīkē)	cǎoyuán (shàng de)		míngzhū				
	a/one	grassland on		shining pearl				
Lexicogrammar	(numeral measure word)	noun (location)		noun				
Experiential structure	Numerative	Deictic		Thing				
Logical structure	Premodifier			Head				
	β			α				
English nominal group	a	shining	pearl	on	the	grassland		
Lexicogrammar	determiner	adjective	noun	prepositional phrase				
				preposition	nominal group			
					determiner	noun		
Experiential structure	Deictic	Epithet: interpersonal	Thing	Mini-Process	Range			
				Qualifier				
Logical structure	Premodifier		Head	Predicator	Complement			
				Postmodifier				
	← →							

(continued)

Table 18.2 (continued)

Chinese nominal group	(一颗)	草原(上的)		明珠
	(yīkē)	cǎoyuán (shàng de)		míngzhū
	a/one	grassland on		shining pearl
	γ	β	α	β

groups by which this concept is realized. Additionally, AI tools such as ChatGPT and DeepSeek are also utilized to offer preliminary translations, which form word and structure systems to be selected in the delicacy analysis that follows.

The findings and implications are as follows: (1) The translation of a Chinese nominal group as an independent group or that of in a clause would result in different outcomes. In other words, the AI-aided translation of the Chinese nominal groups ought not to be carried out in the way that the nominal group is translated without putting it into the clause in which it appears; (2) In addition, the selection of every word and group/phrase plays as crucial a role as that of the whole syntactic structure. Although the AI tools can provide various candidate words and structures, the selection of the options from the systems still has to be based on the functional syntactic analysis, and the comparison between two languages; (3) Context of culture, context of situation, and context of co-text all play significant roles in seeking and determining the right word and syntactic structure in inter-lingual translation.

This paper has only touched on one shining pearl on the grassland, a quite small and specific topic, but there are many other shining pearls on the grassland and in the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture, which are all good topics for investigation. It is hoped that this study may promote further research of the English translation of the Chinese Northern Borderland Culture, contribute to the localization of systemic functional approach to translation studies, and provide insights into the AI-assisted translation studies, especially into the studies of the English translation of the Chinese nominal groups.

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Chapter 19
Translation as Textual Titration: The Origin of Translation and a Typology of Titration Patterns

Guoxiang Wu

Abstract This paper regards translation as experiments in which two linguistic systems are titrated from their textual perspectives. First, textual titrations are quantified by the density rate (DR), which is defined as the dual rate between RWC (the ratio of English words to Chinese characters) and RCC (the ratio of English clauses to Chinese commas [and sentences]). Secondly, the DR equation and its 3-dimensional (3D) view are used to locate the origin of translation (OT). Starting from this original point, four curves are identified: the RWC interval curve, the RCC interval curve, the DR interval curve, and the DR average curve. Accordingly, eight directions and five curved surfaces are specified. Thirdly, these five curved surfaces define five types of titration patterns: Type I (T1), Type II (T2), Type III (T3), Type IV (T4), and Type V (T5). Finally, five typological transformations are identified, that is, the T1-to-T3 transformation, the T3-to-T2 transformation, the T2-to-T5 transformation, the T5-to-T4 transformation, and the T4-to-T1 transformation. The pentagonal typology and the typological transformation provide an analytical framework for translation practices and studies.

Keywords Textual titration · The origin of translation (OT) · Density rate (DR) · DR equation · Typological transformation

19.1 Introduction

Translation is the cross-linguistic comparison at the textual level. Textual comparison is restricted by various overt or covert factors and conducted in multiple functional orientations with an ultimate aim of sufficient equivalence (House 2015). The concept of equivalence, however, is dynamic (Emmerich 2017). Practically,

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dynamic equivalence is manifested in specific intervals of values within which relevant parameters fluctuate (Nida 2001; Wu 2020). The fluctuation actually achieves a transient balance. Theoretically, dynamic equivalence is manifested in constant shift from one paradigm to another, including: formal equivalence (Catford 1965), functional equivalence (Halliday 2009), purposive equivalence (Reiss and Vermeer 2013), equivalence of value (Blumczynski and Gillespie 2016), and stylistic equivalence (Boase-Beier 2020). The shift of theoretical paradigms achieves an ideal equilibrium, which in turn should adapt to the above-mentioned practical balance. The adaptation is centered somewhere around what can be referred to as the origin of translation (OT).

As Halliday (2008: 191) puts it, "[w]hereas typology is the comparative linguistics of the system, translation is the comparative linguistics of the instance: here one text is being brought into relation with another—because that is how the translated text is constructed". In this sense, translation can be regarded as experiments in which two texts are titrated. In chemistry, titration is an analytical method, in which the neutralization reaction between two solutions is used to determine the concentration of a substance. Needham (1969) introduces the concept of titration to analyze how the eastern civilization and the western civilization have exchanged and communicated through the history. He refers to the titration between these two civilizations as the "Grand Titration": An analogy is drawn between civilizations and solutions, and civilizations have cultural elements as their "solutes", including: scientific achievements, social structures, languages, and literatures. In a textual titration, texts are solutions, whereas their linguistic elements are solutes, so a variety of intertextual features are involved. The concept of textual titration implies insufficient or relative equivalence, because the neutralization between two texts is conditioned by the context.

Given various contextual factors in translation (Chang 2022; Halliday 2009; Huang 2015; Wu 2020; Zeng and Yu 2022), the specification and classification of parameters into constants or variants becomes a difficult problem. Even more complicated is the situation in which these parameters are corelated or entangled with each other. Accordingly, most existing studies regard translation as unidirectional: Source texts (ST) are inputs, contexts are variants, and target texts (TT) are outputs. This perspective, however, assumes that translation does not change ST or the ecology in which ST are located. Though facilitating translation studies to some extent, this unidirectional, monolingual perspective is inadequate to specify and classify various bilingual parameters and intertextual relations.

Drawing upon the notion of complementarities between lexis and grammar (Ure 1971; Halliday 2008; Halliday and Matthiessen 2004) and the functional approach to translation studies (Halliday 2009; Huang 2006), this paper proposes a pentagonal typology for textual titration in the context of Chinese-English translation. Waley's (1938) English translation of *The Analects of Confucius* (*AC*) is adopted as linguistic data to exemplify five types of titration patterns in a quantitative framework, that is, Type I (T1), Type II (T2), Type III (T3), Type IV (T4), and Type V (T5). The mechanism is also illustrated in which these titration patterns are transformed from

one type into another. The pentagonal typology and the typological transformation provide an analytical framework for translation practices and studies.

19.2 The Density Rate (DR): The Dual Rate Between RWC and RCC

Lexical density (LD) and grammatical intricacy (GI) are two indices for the analysis of texts and clause complexes in a monolingual context. Ure (1971) first defines LD as the percentage of content words among all words in a text. Text LD can be used to indicate whether a text is in a spoken or a written mode (O'Loughlin 1995). Halliday (2008: 158) later redefines LD as the average number of content word(s) that every clause contains. Both text LD and clause LD are indices of lexical features. For grammatical features, Halliday (1994: 350–351) turns to GI, which is defined as the average number of clause(s) that every clause complex contains.

The present study introduces LD and GI into the bilingual context of Chinese-English translation. Translation LD is defined as the number of English words that are used to translate every Chinese comma (or sentence) (Wu 2020, 2021: 175–176). The comma/sentence, or "jùdòu" in Chinese ("jù" means "sentence" and "dòu" is "comma"), includes various syntactical segments which are demarcated by punctuation marks, including: periods, commas, colons, semicolons, question marks, and exclamation marks (Ma 1898/2007: 385; Sun 1991). In this paper, "comma" is used as the cover term for these syntactical units. They are not necessarily clauses, since they may be words, phrases, clauses, or clause complexes. In contrast, the clause is usually defined as a subject-predicate construction.

Translation LD integrates the word number (WN) in the English text and the comma number (CoN) in the Chinese text. For example, the ST of *AC* contains 3,809 commas, and Waley's (1938) translation contains 27,720 words, so the value of translation LD is 7.28. Translation LD is a complex index, in which WN is a lexical parameter and CoN is a grammatical parameter.

19.2.1 The Ratio of Words to Characters (RWC)

RWC indicates the average number of English words that are used to translate every Chinese character, so the value of RWC is the quotient of the word number (WN) and the character number (CN) (Wu 2021: 160–177). Given that the ST of *AC* contains 15,807 characters and Waley's (1938) translation contains 27,720 words, the value of RWC is 1.75.

RWC and translation LD hold a direct proportion, and their coefficient is character density (CD). CD refers to the average number of characters that every comma contains in a Chinese text. Given that the ST of *AC* contains 15,807 characters and

3,809 commas, the value of CD is 4.15. The value of RWC can also be calculated as the quotient of translation LD and CD. Given that the value of translation LD is 7.28 and that of RWC is 4.15, the result is also 1.75.

The English translation of ancient Chinese and that of modern Chinese is different in terms of their RWC values. For example, 180 English words may have been used to translate 100 Chinese characters in the English translation of Chinese historical classics, that is, the value of RWC is 1.80. In contrast, only 75 English words may have been used to translate 100 Chinese characters in the Chinese-English bilingual abstracts of linguistic journal articles published in China, that is, the value of RWC is 0.75.

Significant fluctuations of RWC values can be easily observed in multiple translations of the same ST. For example, Ku's (1898), Waley's (1938), Legge's ([1893] 1971), and Pound's ([1950] 1969) English translations of *AC* have 2.10, 1.75, 1.73, and 1.36 as their RWC values, respectively. The values fluctuate in the interval of [1.36, 2.10] with a range of 0.74. Unlike the complex index of translation LD, RWC is a simple index, in which both WN and CN are lexical parameters.

19.2.2 The Ratio of Clauses to Commas (RCC)

Translation GI is defined as the number of English clauses that are used to translate every Chinese comma (Wu 2021: 178–192). In this definition, the ratio of (English) clauses to (Chinese) commas can be identified, shortened into RCC. The value of RCC is the quotient of the clause number (ClN) and the comma number (CoN). Given that *AC* contains 3,809 commas and Waley's (1938) translation contains 4,725 clauses, the value of RCC is 1.24.

To an extent, different domains and types of translations have different ranges of RCC values. In the English translation of Chinese historical classics, 130 English clauses may have been used to translate 100 Chinese commas, that is, the RCC value is 1.30. In the Chinese-English bilingual comments of world heritage sites in China, 80 English clauses may have been used to translate 100 Chinese commas, that is, the RCC value is 0.80. In the English translation of China's Constitution and laws, the RCC value is close to 1.00.

Multiple translations of the same text also indicate that there are significant fluctuations in RCC values. For example, Ku's, Waley's, Legge's, and Pound's translations of *AC* have 1.37, 1.24. 1.27, and 1.13 as their RCC values, respectively. The values fluctuate in the interval of [1.13, 1.37] with a range of 0.24. RCC is a simple index, in which both ClN and CoN are grammatical parameters.

19.2.3 The Density Rate (DR) and the DR Equation

The complex parameter of density rate (DR) is the dual rate between RWC and RCC. The value of DR is the quotient of RWC and RCC, that is, DR = RWC/RCC. Suppose RWC is x, RCC is y, and DR is z, the DR equation can be formulated as follows: $z = x/y$ ($y > 0$). Given the four RWC values (2.10, 1.75, 1.73, and 1.36) mentioned in Sect. 2.1 and the four corresponding RCC values (1.37, 1.24, 1.27, and 1.13) mentioned in Sect. 2.2, Ku's, Waley's, Legge's and Pound's DR values are 1.53, 1.41, 1.37, and 1.21, respectively. These DR values fluctuate in the interval of [1.21, 1.53] with a range of 0.32.

19.2.4 The DR Equation and Its 3D View

The DR equation provides a quantitative method to analyze textual titrations and compare multiple translations. It can be visualized into a 3D view in the form of a dot matrix, and the dot matrix represents how titration patterns are distributed in terms of their intertextual relations. For example, *AC* contains 499 sections in total, and each section in Waley's translation has a definite RWC value (x) and a definite RCC value (y), so its DR value (z) is also definite. These three values constitute a DR array (x, y, z) and hence 499 DR arrays in total. In Fig. 19.1a, these 499 DR arrays are visualized into a 3D view.

The dot matrix is composed of 500 single dots (Fig. 19.1a): 499 single dots correspond to 499 DR arrays, whereas the 500th dot represents Waley's DR average

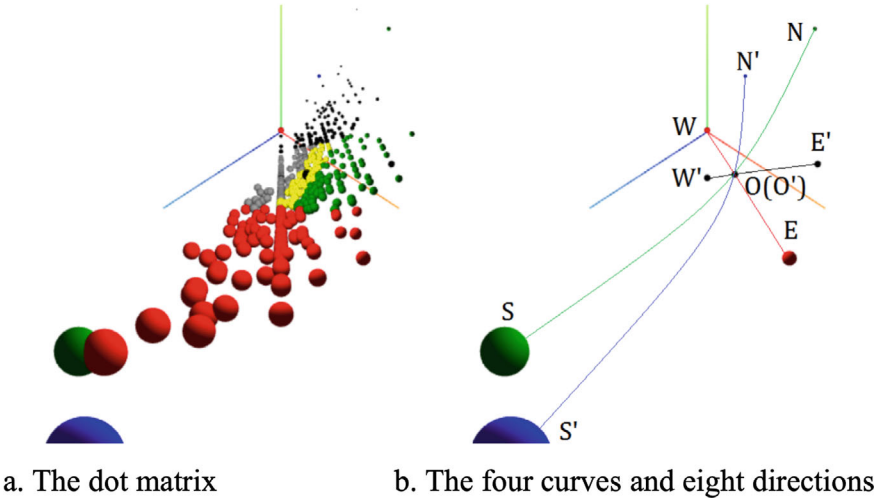


Fig. 19.1 A 3D view of the DR equation: The OT and the eight directions

array, that is, (1.75, 1.24, 1.41). The axis of *x*, *y*, and *z* represent RWC, RCC, and DR: the axis of *x*, which is largely covered by the dot matrix, represents RWC; the axis of *y*, which is vertical, represents RCC; the axis of *z*, which is other than *x*or*y*, represents DR. The size of each single dot symbolizes the size of each DR value.

Figure 19.1b extracts 10 special single dots from Fig. 19.1a (see Sect. 19.4). These 10 dots are grouped into 5 pairs, that is, N and S, E and W, N' and S', E' and W', O and O'. Four curves can be identified: (1) N and S are connected via O to form the RCC interval curve (NS); (2) E and W are connected via O to form the RWC interval curve (EW); (3) N' and S' are connected via O' to form the DR interval curve (N'S'); (4) E' and W' are connected via O' to form the DR average curve (E'W'). Starting from O or O', these four curves specify eight directions.

19.3 The Origin of Translation (OT)

The origin of the 3D axis ($x = 0$, $y = 0$, $z = 0$) is not the OT, but the zero point of reference for all parameters in the DR equation: $z = x/y$. For any effective textual titration, all parameters in the DR array are larger than 0, that is, $x > 0$, $y > 0$, $z > 0$. Theoretically, the OT is represented by another dot (O') in Fig. 19.1, that is, the 500th single dot, whose DR array is the average of all 499 arrays. This theoretical OT represents a "prototype of translation". Practically, the instance of textual titration whose DR array is the closest to the theoretical OT (O') is used instead as representative of the prototype. Accordingly, this DR array is used as a practical OT (O). The practical OT (O) is close to or overlaps with the theoretical OT (O') in Fig. 19.1b.

19.3.1 The OT of Multiple Translations

The practical OT of multiple translations virtually serves as the theoretical OT of individual titrations. For example, there are more than 70 English translations of *AC*, and the DR equation can be used to calculate their DR average array. The point specified by the DR average array can be used as the theoretical OT of individual translations. Among these translations, the one whose DR array is the closest to the theoretical OT can be sorted out to serve as the practical OT. Because of inadequate data, a limited number of textual titrations are often used to determine the theoretical OT. For example, Ku's, Waley's, Legge's, and Pound's DR arrays are (2.10, 1.37, 1.60), (1.76, 1.30, 1.36), (1.73, 1.27, 1.37), and (1.36, 1.13, 1.21), respectively. Their DR average array, that is, (1.75, 1.24, 1.41), locates a theoretical OT which applies to any of the above-mentioned four translated versions. Both Waley's and Legge's DR arrays are close to the theoretical OT, so either can serve as the practical OT. In this way, the DR equation and its 3D view locate a textual titration in the context of translation.

19.3.2 The OT of Chapters

The practical OT of the whole titration serves as the theoretical OT of the partial titration. For example, *AC* contains 20 chapters, and Waley's DR average array is (1.75, 1.24, 1.41). The point specified by the DR average array is the practical OT of the whole titration, which can in turn be used as the theoretical OT of any individual chapter. Given that the 13th chapter contains 1,035 characters and 256 commas and that Waley's translation uses 1,795 words and 321 clauses, the DR array of this chapter is calculated as follows: x = 1.73, y = 1.25, z = 1.38. Among all the 20 DR arrays, this is the closest to the theoretical OT, so it is used as the practical OT. In this way, the DR equation and its 3D view quantify the relation between the partial titration and the whole titration.

19.3.3 The OT of Sections

For any section, either the chapter or the whole book can serve as the frame of reference in which the theoretical OT is calculated. On the one hand, the 13th chapter contains 30 sections, and its practical OT is defined by the DR array (1.73, 1.25, 1.38). This practical OT can be used as the first theoretical OT for all 30 sections. The 11th section of the 13th chapter (Sect. 13-11), whose DR array is the closest to the first theoretical OT, can be used as the practical OT.

[13-11] Zǐ yuē: "Shàn rén wéi bāng bǎi nián, yì kě yǐ shèng cán qù shā yǐ. Chéng zāi shì yán yě!"

[13-11W] The Master said, "Only if the right sort of people had charge of a country for a hundred years would it become really possible to stop cruelty and do away with slaughter". How true the saying is! (Waley 1938: 174).

The Chinese version of Sect. 13-11 contains 21 characters and 4 commas, whereas the English version contains 37 words and 5 clauses, so the DR array is as follows: x = 1.76, y = 1.25, z = 1.41. The point specified by this DR array is the practical OT.

On the other hand, Waley's DR average array (1.75, 1.24, 1.41) specifies the practical OT of the whole titration (see Sect. 19.2.4). This practical OT can also be used as the second theoretical OT for individual sections. Among all 30 sections in the 13th chapter, the one, whose DR array (1.76, 1.25, 1.41) is the closest to the second theoretical OT, is still 13-11. The DR array of 13-11 still serves as the practical OT.

The first theoretical OT assumes the perspective of a local titration, whereas the second theoretical OT assumes the perspective of a global titration. This paper adopts the second theoretical OT as the frame of reference.

19.4 The OT and the Eight Directions

With the OT (O or O') as their common starting point, eight directions are specified by the four curves. On the one hand, the RCC interval curve (NS) and the RWC interval curve (EW) intersect at the practical OT (O). Given that O is taken as their common starting point, with the two ends of NS as targets, ON and OS specify two directions; similarly, with the two ends of EW as targets, OE and OW specify other two directions. On the other hand, the DR interval curve (N'S') and the DR average curve (E'W') intersect at the theoretical OT(O'). Given that O' is taken as their common starting point, with the two ends of N'S' as targets, O'N' and O'S' specify yet other two directions; similarly, with the two ends of E'W' as targets, O'E' and O'W' specify further two directions. These eight directions are adequate to explain translational "deviations" (Liu et al. 2016) in lexical, grammatical terms.

19.4.1 The RWC Interval Curve: Point E and Point W

The RWC interval curve (WE) in Fig. 19.1b represents the interval of [0.94, 3.14] within which 499 RWC values fluctuate. The 12th section of the 7th chapter (Sect. 7-12) has the largest RWC value of 3.14.

[7–12] Zǐ zhī suǒ shèn: zhāi, zhàn, jí.

[7-12W] The rites to which the Master gave the greatest attention were those connected with purification before sacrifice, with war, and with sickness (Waley 1938: 125).

The Chinese version [7-12] contains 7 characters and 2 commas, whereas Waley's English version [7-12W] contains 22 words and 3 clauses, so the DR array is: x = 3.14, y = 1.50, z = 2.10. The point specified by this DR array is Point E of the RWC interval curve. In contrast, Sect. 11-3 has the smallest RWC value of 0.94.

[11–3] Zǐ yuē: Huí yě, fēi zhù wǒ zhě yě, yú wú yán wú suǒ bú yuè.

[11-3W] The Master said, Hui was not any help to me; he accepted everything I said (Waley 1938: 153).

The Chinese version [11-3] contains 16 characters and 4 commas, whereas Waley's English version [11-3W] contains 15 words and 4 clauses, so the DR array is: x = 0.94, y = 1.00, z = 0.94. The point specified by this DR array is Point W of the RWC interval curve (EW).

The curve segment OE indicates a gradual increase in RWC, and OW shows a gradual decrease in RWC.

19.4.2 The RCC Interval Curve: Point N and Point S

The RCC interval curve (NS) in Fig. 19.1b represents the interval of [0.33, 2.80] within which 499 RCC values fluctuate. Section 19-10 has the largest RCC value of 2.80.

[19-10] Zǐ Xià yuē: Jūn zǐ xìn ér hòu láo qí mín. Wèi xìn zé yǐ wéi lì jǐ yě. Xìn ér hòu jiǎn. Wèi xìn zé yǐ wéi bàng jǐ yǐ.

[19-10W] Tzu-hsia said, A gentleman obtains the confidence of those under him, before putting burdens upon them. If he does so before he has obtained their confidence, they feel that they are being exploited. It is also true that he obtains the confidence (of those above him) before criticizing them. If he does so before he has obtained their confidence, they feel that they are being slandered (Waley 1938: 226).

The Chinese version [19–10] contains 31 characters and 5 commas, whereas the English version [19-10W] contains 66 words and 14 clauses, so the DR array is: x = 2.13, y = 2.80, z = 0.76. The point specified by this DR array is Point N of the RCC interval curve (NS). In contrast, Sect. 7-37 has the smallest RCC value of 0.33.

[7-37] Zǐ wēn ér lì, wēi ér bù měng, gōng ér ān.

[7-37W] The Master's manner was affable yet firm, commanding but not harsh, polite but easy (Waley 1938: 131).

The Chinese version [7-37] contains 11 characters and 3 commas, whereas the English version [7-37W] contains 14 words and 1 clause, so the DR array is: x = 1.27, y = 0.33, z = 3.82. The point specified by this DR array is Point S of the RCC interval curve (NS).

The curve segment ON indicates a gradual increase in RCC, and OS shows a gradual decrease in RCC.

19.4.3 The DR Interval Curve: Point N' and Point S'

The DR interval curve (N'S') in Fig. 19.1b represents the interval of [0.73, 5.00] within which 499 DR values fluctuate. Section 13-26 has the smallest DR value of 0.73.

[13-26] Zǐ yuē: Jūn zǐ tài ér bù jiāo, xiǎo rén jiāo ér bú tài.

[13-26W] The Master said, The gentleman is dignified, but never haughty; common people are haughty, but never dignified (Waley 1938: 178).

The Chinese version [13-26] contains 14 characters and 3 commas, whereas the English version contains 17 words and 5 clauses, so the DR array is: x = 1.21, y = 1.67, z = 0.73. The point specified by this DR array is Point N' of the DR interval curve (N'S'). In contrast, Sect. 7-24 has the largest DR value of 5.00.

[7-24] Zǐ yǐ sì jiào: wén, xíng, zhōng, xìn.

[7-24W] The Master took four subjects for his teaching: culture, conduct of affairs, loyalty to superiors and the keeping of promises (Waley 1938: 128).

The Chinese version [7.24] contains 8 characters and 2 commas, whereas the English version [7.24W] contains 20 words and 1 clause, so the DR array is: x = 2.50, y = 0.50,z = 5.00. The point specified by this DR array is Point S' of the DR interval curve (N'S').

The curve segment O'N' indicates a gradual increase in DR, and O'S' shows a gradual decrease in DR.

19.4.4 The DR Average Curve: Point E' and Point W'

The DR value of the theoretical OT (O') is 1.42, and that of the practical OT(O) is 1.41. The DR average curve (E'W') is drawn on the basis of the practical value (1.41). In total, 10 of Waley's 499 sections have 1.41 as their DR values. Points specified by these 10 corresponding DR arrays, that is, (x_n, y_n, 1.41) ($1 \leq n \leq 10$), are distributed on the DR average curve (W'E') with their RWC values (x_n) and RCC values (y_n) increasing or decreasing simultaneously. The DR value of Sect. 1-8 is balanced by the largest RWC value (x_{10}) and the largest RCC value (y_{10}).

[1-8] Zǐ yuē: Jūn zǐ bú zhòng zé bù wēi, xué zé bú gù. Zhǔ zhōng xìn, wú yǒu bù rú jǐ zhě, guò zé wù dàn gǎi.

[1-8W] The Master said, if a gentleman is frivolous, he will lose the respect of his inferiors and lack firm ground upon which to build up his education. First and foremost, he must learn to be faithful to his superiors, to keep promises, to refuse the friendship of all who are not like him. And if he finds he has made a mistake, then he must not be afraid of admitting the fact and amending his ways (Waley 1938: 85).

The Chinese version [1-8] contains 27 characters and 6 commas, whereas the English version [1-8W] contains 76 words and 12 clauses, so the DR array is: x = 2.81, y = 2.00, z = 1.41. The point specified by this DR array is Point E' of the DR average curve (E'W'). In contrast, the DR value of Sect. 20–3 is balanced by the smallest RWC value (x_1) and the smallest RCC value (y_1).

[20-3] Kǒng Zǐ yuē: bù zhī mìng, wú yǐ wéi jūn zǐ yě. Bù zhī lǐ, wú yǐ lì yě. Bù zhī yán, wú yǐ zhī rén yě.

[20-3W] The Master said, He who does not understand the will of Heaven cannot be regarded as a gentleman. He who does not know the rites cannot take his stand. He who does not understand words, cannot understand people (Waley 1938: 233).

The Chinese version [20-3] contains 27 characters and 7 commas, whereas the English version [20-3W] contains 38 words and 7 clauses, so the DR array is: x = 1.41, y = 1.00,z = 1.41. The point specified by this DR array is Point E' of the DR average curve (E'W').

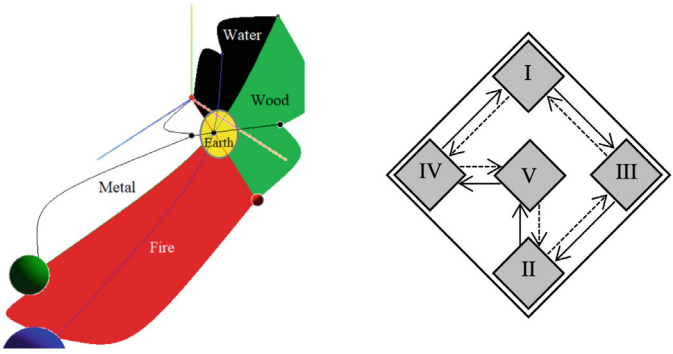
The curve segment O'E' and O'W' shows simultaneous changes in RWC and RCC: O'E' indicates a simultaneous increase in both RWC and RCC, and O'W' indicates a simultaneous decrease in both RWC and RCC.

19.5 The Five Curved Surfaces and Five Types of Titration Patterns

In Fig. 19.1a, the eight directions are identical with the eight curve segments: OE and OW of the RWC interval curve (EW); ON and OS of the RCC interval curve (NS); O'N' and O'S' of the DR interval curve (N'S'); O'E' and O'W' of the DR average curve (E'W'). These eight curve segments specify five curved surfaces: (1) the first surface is based on O'N' with OW and ON as boundaries; (2) the second surface is based on O'S' with OE and OS as boundaries; (3) the third surface is based on O'E' with ON and OS as boundaries; (4) the fourth surface is based on O'W' with OS and OW as boundaries; (5) the fifth surface is formed by the above-mentioned four curved surfaces clustering around the OT (O or O') (Fig. 19.2a).

Chinese-English textual titrations are distributed on these five curved surfaces and thus classified into five types of titration patterns: Type I (T1), Type II (T2), Type III (T3), Type IV (T4), and Type V (T5). These patterns are transformable from one into another and five typological transformations can be identified (Fig. 19.2b): (1) the T1-to-T3 transformation(T1-3), in which Type I is transformed into Type III; (2) the T3-to-T2 transformation (T3-2), in which Type III turns into Type II; (3) the T2-to-T5 transformation (T2-5), in which Type II turns into Type V; (4) the T5-to-T4 transformation (T5-4), in which Type V turns into Type IV; (5) the T4-to-T1 transformation (T4-1), in which Type IV is in turn transformed into Type I.

This pentagonal typology differs from most existing dichotomies, including: domestication vs. foreignization, communicative translation vs. semantic translation, and overt translation vs. covert translation (Venuti 1995; Chu 2006; House 2015). In Figs. 19.1 and 19.2, the DR arrays of Waley's 499 sections have been used



a. Five curved surfaces and their cluster b. Titration patterns and their transformations

I: Type I (of Water) II: Type II (of Fire) III: Type III (of Wood)

IV: Type IV (of Metal) V: Type V (of Earth)

Fig. 19.2 Four curved surfaces and five types of Chinese-English textual titrations

as benchmarks to specify five types of titration patterns according to the principle that each type be assigned with approximately 100 sections.

19.5.1 T1 Titration and the T1-to-T3 Transformation (T1-3)

A textual titration that is distributed on the first curved surface belongs to T1 titration. In Figs. 19.1 and 19.2, 96 sections adjust and confine T1 titration to the DR interval of [0.73, 1.17]. They are characterized with small RWC values and large RCC values. Accordingly, their DR values are relatively small. T1 titration is further divided by the baseline O'N' into the masculine and the feminine. The masculine is defined by O'N' and OW and the feminine is defined by O'N' and ON.

Waley's Sect. 13-26, located at Point N' of the DR interval curve, is representative of T1 titration. The English version [13-26W] (see Sect. 19.4.3) can be revised into [13-26W']:

[13-26W'] The Master said, the man of a superior mentality is dignified, so he will never be haughty; in contrast, the man in an inferior mentality is haughty, so he will never be dignified.

The word number has been increased from 17 to 33, and the clause number remains unchanged, that is, 5. The revised DR array (x = 2.36, y = 1.67, z = 1.41) falls within T3 titration. As a result, T1 has been transformed into T3. T1-3 takes ON as the boundary. Section 19-10, located at Point N, is a transient point of T1-3. It is itself a T1 titration.

As a matter of fact, T3 titration is rarely adopted in the translation of Sect. 13-26. Instead, a T4 titration can be found.

[13-26A&R] The Master said, "Exemplary persons are distinguished but not arrogant; petty persons are the opposite." (Ames and Rosemont 1998: 169).

With 15 words and 3 clauses, the DR array (1.07, 1.00, 1.07) of Ames and Rosemont's (1988) translation falls within T4 titration. As far as the transformational relation between [13-26A&R] and [13-26W] is concerned, T4-1 is involved (see Sect. 19.5.4).

19.5.2 T2 Titration and the T2-to-T5 Transformation (T2-5)

A textual titration that is distributed on the second curved surface belongs to T2 titration. In Figs. 19.1 and 19.2, 99 sections adjust and confine T2 titration to the DR interval of [1.73, 5.00]. They are characterized with large RWC values and small RCC values. Accordingly, their DR values are relatively large. T2 titration is further divided by the baseline O'S' into the masculine and the feminine. The masculine is defined by O'S' and OE, and the feminine is defined by O'S' and ON.

Waley's Sect. 7-24, located at Point S' of the DR interval curve, is representative of T2 titration. The English version [7-24W] (see Sect. 19.4.3) can be revised into [7-24W']:

[7-24W'] Subjects that the Master used in teaching are four, including: culture, conduct, loyalty, and sincerity.

The word number has been reduced from 20 to 15, and the clause number has been increased from 1 to 3. The revised DR array (1.88, 1.50, 1.25) falls within T5 titration. As a result, T2 has been transformed into T5.

T5 titration is rarely adopted in the translation of Sect. 7-24. Instead, a T3 titration can be found.

[7-24L] The Master instructs under four heads: culture, moral conducts, doing one's best, and being trustworthy in what one says (Lau 1979: 89).

With 19 words and 4 clauses, the DR array of Lau's (1979) translation (2.38, 2.00, 1.19) falls within T3 titration. As far as the transformational relation between [7-24L] and [7-24W] is concerned, T3-2 is involved (see Sect. 19.5.3).

19.5.3 T3 Titration and the T3-to-T2 Transformation (T3-2)

Textual titrations that are distributed on the third, the fourth, and the fifth curved surfaces belong to T3, T4, and T5 titrations, respectively. In Figs. 19.1 and 19.2, 304 sections adjust and confine these three types of titration patterns to the DR interval of [1.18, 1.72]. They are characterized with a balanced relation between their RWC values and RCC values. Accordingly, their DR values are of medium size. T3, T4, and T5 are further adjusted by their RWC values.

T3 titration is further adjusted and confined to the RWC interval of [1.88, 3.14] by 106 sections. They are characterized with a balance between large RWC values and large RCC values. T3 titration is divided by O'E' into the masculine and the feminine. The masculine is defined by O'E' and ON and the feminine is defined by O'E' and OE.

Waley's Sect. 1-8, located at Point E' of the DR average curve, is representative of T3 titration. The English version [1-8W] (see Sect. 19.4.4) can be revised into [1-8W']:

[1-8W'] The Master said, without dignity a gentleman will lose the respect of others and the foundation of his learning. He must first be loyal and sincere. None of his friends is not like him. He does not hesitate to correct any of his mistakes.

The word number has been reduced from 76 to 44, and the clause number has been reduced from 12 to 5. The revised DR array (1.63, 0.83, 1.96) falls within T2 titration. As a result, T3 has been transformed into T2. T3-2 takes OE as the boundary. Section 7-12, located at Point E, is a transient point of T3-2. It is itself a T2 titration.

T2 titration is rarely adopted in the translation of Sect. 1-8. Instead, a T1 titration can be found.

[1-8L] The Master said, "A gentleman who lacks gravity does not inspire awe. A gentleman who studies is unlikely to be inflexible. Make it your guiding principle to

do your best for others and to be trustworthy in what you say. Do not accept as friend anyone who is not as good as you. When you make a mistake, do not be afraid of mending your ways." (Lau 1979: 60).

With 66 words and 14 clauses, the DR array of Lau's (1979) translation (2.44, 2.33, 1.05) falls within T1 titration. As far as the transformational relation between [1-8L] and [1-8W] is concerned, T1-3 is involved (see Sect. 19.5.1).

19.5.4 T4 Titration and the T4-to-T1 Transformation (T4-1)

T4 titration is further adjusted and confined to the RWC interval of [0.94, 1.62] by 102 sections. They are characterized with a balance between small RWC values and small RCC values. T4 titration is divided by O'W' into the masculine and the feminine. The masculine is defined by O'W' and OS, and the feminine is defined by O'W' and OW.

Waley's Sect. 20-3, located at Point W' of the DR average curve, is representative of T4 titration. T4 titration can be transformed into T1. For example, Lau (1979) translates [20-3] into [20-3L]:

[20-3L] Confucius said, "A man has no way of becoming a gentleman unless he understands Destiny; he has no way of taking his stand unless he understands the rites; he has no way of judging men unless he understands words." (Lau 1979: 160).

With 38 words and 10 clauses, the DR array of Lau's translation (1.41, 1.43,0.99) falls within T1 titration. T4-1 takes OW as the boundary. Section 11-3, which is located at Point W, is a transient point of T4-1. It is itself a T1 titration.

By T4-1, it is not meant that [20-3L] has been practically transformed from [20-3W] (see Sect. 19.4.4), but that they can be theoretically explained to have a transformational relation in which T4 titration turns into T1 titration.

19.5.5 T5 Titration and the T5-to-T4 Transformation (T5-4)

With the above-mentioned four types of titration patterns, T5 titration is eventually adjusted and confined to the RWC interval of [1.62, 1.88] by the rest 96 sections, which cluster around the OT. They are characterized with a balance between medium-sized RWC values and medium-sized RCC values. T5 titration is divided by N'S' into the masculine and the feminine. The masculine is based on O'E' and the feminine is based on O'W'.

Waley's Sect. 13-11, located at the practical OT, is representative of T5 titration. T5 titration can be transformed into T4. For example, Xu (2002) translates [13-11] into [13-11X]:

[13-11X] If good men, said the Master, were to rule the state for a hundred years, violence and slaughter would be done away with. But how could it come true? (Xu 2005: 64).

With 29 words and 4 clauses, the DR array of Xu's (2005) translation (1.38, 1.00, 1.38) falls within T4 titration. In this case, T5-4 is involved. By T5-4, [13-11W] (see Sect. 19.3.3) and [13-11X] are explained to be a transformational relation in which T5 turns into T4.

19.6 Conclusion

Every instance of translation is a textual titration, and the concept of equivalence is equal to the neutralization of ST and TT. To some extent, the neutralization is subject to the context or environment in which the textual titration takes place, so different types of titration patterns are produced even when the same translator does the same piece of work. Textual titrations differ from each other in terms of their context of culture, context of situation, or context of co-text. The notion of neutralization transforms equivalence into a dynamic concept.

The DR equation integrates RWC and RCC. These three parameters quantify the extent to which ST and TT are titrated to achieve dynamic equivalence in both theoretical and practical terms. As far as Chinese-English translation is concerned, RWC further integrates the number of Chinese characters and that of English words, representing lexical relations between ST and TT. Similarly, RCC further integrates the number of Chinese commas and that of English clauses, representing intertextual grammatical relations. The DR equation and its 3D view serve as an analytical method to locate the OT.

Dynamic equivalence is manifested in fluctuations of the OT as translation practices and studies unfold and extend. The OT is distinguished between the practical and the theoretical. In general, a whole practice serves as the context of a partial practice, or a global domain as the environment of a local domain. Accordingly, the practical OT of the whole practice or the global domain serves as the theoretical OT of the partial practice or the local domain. Therefore, the practical OT indefinitely approaches the theoretical OT, and the theoretical OT varies as the practical OT changes. In nature, the theoretical OT is a practical OT in a wider context.

The values of RWC, RCC, and DR and the average of DR values define the RWC interval curve, the RCC interval curve, the DR interval curve, and the DR average curve. These four curves and the OT define five curved surfaces. The distribution of textual titrations on these five curved surfaces specifies five types of titration patterns, that is, Type I (T1), Type II (T2), Type III (T3), Type IV (T4), and Type V (T5). This pentagonal typology of textual titrations provides a framework in which intertextual relations can be quantified and analyzed.

The analysis of intertextual features can be conducted either from the perspective of ST or from the TT. In general, T1 and T2 titrations have incompatible features. The English text of the former is lexically shrunken, but grammatically expanded. In contrast, the English text of the latter is lexically expanded, but grammatically shrunken. Similarly, T3 and T4 titrations have incompatible features. The English text of the former is expanded simultaneously in lexical and grammatical terms, while that

of the latter is shrunken simultaneously. T5 titration is lexically and grammatically neutral and harmonious. It balances the intertextual relation either between T1 and T2 or between T3 and T4.

From the perspective of TT in Chinese-English translation, T1 titration is transformed into T3 titration if the number of English clauses is properly decreased and the number of English words is properly increased; T3 titration is transformed into T2 titration if clauses are decreased and words are increased properly; T2 titration is transformed into T5 titration if clauses are increased and words are decreased properly; T5 titration is transformed into T4 titration if both clauses and words are decreased; T4 titration is transformed into T1 titration if clauses are increased and words are decreased properly. The transformation among the five titration patterns constitutes a closed-loop mechanism.

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Guoxiang Wu is Associate Professor at the College of Foreign Languages of Huaqiao University, Quanzhou, China. He obtained his PhD degree from Sun Yat-sen University in 2013 and completed a post-doctoral program at Peking University in 2015. His research interests include: (1) lexical semantics; (2) functional approaches to translation studies; (3) English for overseas Chinese affairs. He is the translator of *Cognition-Based Studies on Chinese Grammar* (2017), a co-author of *Lexical Ontological Semantics* (2019) and the author of *Intertextual Features and International Functions of the Chinese-English Text* (2025). The present study further develops the quantitative framework proposed in his Ph.D. thesis—*On the Grammatical Complexity of the Translated* Confucian Analects.

Appendix I
Students supervised by Professor Huang Guowen

For the past thirty years, Professor Huang Guowen has been supervising Ph.D. students, MA and MTI students as well as BA students, apart from serving as a postdoctoral advisor, in the fields of English studies, systemic functional linguistics (SFL), applied linguistics (AL), ecolinguistics, and translation studies (TS).

1.1. Students who completed their Ph.D. degrees at Sun Yat-sen University (SYSU) and South China Agricultural University (SCAU) under the supervision of Professor Huang Guowen

Name	Year of		Research area	University
	Admission	Graduation		
LI Guoqing 李国庆	1988	2002	SFL, genre analysis of style	SYSU
YU Hui 于晖	1988	2001	SFL, genre analysis of abstracts	SYSU
ZENG Lei 曾蕾	1988	2001	SFL, projection	SYSU
DING Jianxin 丁建新	1999	2002	SFL, prefabricated language	SYSU
YANG Bingjun 杨炳钧	1999	2002	SFL, nonfinite clauses	SYSU
CHANG Chenguang 常晨光	2000	2003	SFL, English idioms	SYSU
HE Wei 何伟	2000	2003	SFL, verb tenses	SYSU
SHANG Yuanyuan 尚媛媛	2000	2003	SFL, translation shifts	SYSU
ZHU Shan 朱珊	2000	2007	SFL, intonation	SYSU

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(continued)

Name	Year of		Research area	University
	Admission	Graduation		
DAI Fan 戴凡	2001	2004	SFL, speech and thought presentation	SYSU
HE Hengxing 何恒幸	2001	2004	SFL, lexicogrammar	SYSU
WANG Peng 王鹏	2001	2004	SFL, translation	SYSU
ZHANG Peiwen 张佩雯	2001	2008	SFL, genre-based writing	SYSU
LI Fagen 李发根	2002	2005	SFL, poem translation	SYSU
WANG Jin 王瑾	2002	2005	SFL, code-switching	SYSU
DENG Renhua 邓仁华	2003	2006	SFL, Cardiff Grammar	SYSU
LIAO Haiqing 廖海青	2003	2008	SFL, interview	SYSU
Lü Dairong 吕黛蓉	2003	2008	SFL, online e-discourse	SYSU
QI Xi 齐曦	2003	2006	SFL, causative construction	SYSU
SI Xianzhu 司显柱	2003	2006	SFL, translation quality assessment	SYSU
WANG Yong 王勇	2003	2006	SFL, evaluative enhanced theme	SYSU
WU Kerong 吴克蓉	2003	2007	SFL, discourse analysis of aphasics	SYSU
HUANG Zhiying 黄志英	2004	2011	SFL, hypotactic verbal group complex	SYSU
LIAO Yiqing 廖益清	2004	2007	SFL, gender studies	SYSU
YANG Ruifu 杨汝福	2004	2007	SFL, intertextuality	SYSU
CHEN Xiaoyan 陈晓燕	2005	2009	SFL, instant messaging discourse	SYSU
LONG Minghui 龙明慧*	2005	2008	TS, translation prototype	SYSU
XIONG Xiyuan 熊锡源*	2005	2011	TS, intertextuality	SYSU
CHEN Jing 陈静	2006	2010	SFL, genre-based teaching	SYSU

(continued)

(continued)

Name	Year of		Research area	University
	Admission	Graduation		
CHEN Yumin 陈瑜敏	2006	2009	SFL, multimodality	SYSU
LIU Yi 刘毅	2006	2013	SFL, genre-based teaching	SYSU
WANG Hongyang 王红阳	2006	2009	SFL, SFL in China	SYSU
CHEN Yang 陈旸	2007	2014	SFL, translating the Analects	SYSU
LI Manliang 李满亮	2007	2010	SFL, nominal nominal groups in English	SYSU
XIAO Haozhang 肖好章	2007	2010	SFL, role-based interactions	SYSU
BI Xuefei 毕雪飞	2008	2013	AL, learning environments	SYSU
ZENG Jiongwei 曾炯巍	2008	2015	SFL, e-discourse	SYSU
LUO Xuejuan 骆雪娟	2009	2012	AL, problem-based learning	SYSU
ZHANG Chunyan 张春燕	2009	2014	SFL, clause complex in Chinese	SYSU
WU Guoxiang 吴国向	2010	2013	SFL, grammatical complexity in translated text	SYSU
ZHAO Ruihua 赵蕊华	2010	2013	SFL, transitivity	SYSU
CHEN Ying 陈莹	2011	2014	SFL, variation in translation	SYSU
GAO Shengwen 高生文	2011	2014	SFL, register analysis in translation	SYSU
YU Changli 于昌利	2012	2015	SFL, lexicogrammar	SYSU
YU Juan 余娟	2012	2015	SFL, translation	SYSU
GAN Lili 干丽丽	2013	2017	SFL, readability	SYSU
LIU Yan 刘衍	2013	2016	SFL, readability	SYSU
XIAO Juanjuan 肖娟娟	2014	2019	SFL, prosodic realizations of written texts	SYSU
TAN Xin 谭欣	2014	2020	SFL, Chinese intonation	SYSU

(continued)

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Name	Year of		Research area	University
	Admission	Graduation		
LI Jia 李佳	2015	2020	Ecolinguistics, text analysis	SYSU
ZHANG Lin 张琳	2015	2019	Ecolinguistics, text analysis	SYSU
WEI Zhouping 韦周平	2016	2022	Ecolinguistics, harmonious discourse analysis	SYSU
LI Wenbei 李文蓓	2018	2022	Ecolinguistics, greenwashing	SCAU
TAN Xiaochun 谭晓春	2018	2021	Ecolinguistics, ecosophy, and harmonious discourse	SCAU
HA Chuangchen 哈长辰	2019	2022	Ecolinguistics, ecological literacy	SCAU
ZHANG Danqing 张丹清	2019	2024	Ecolinguistics, sustainability in text analysis	SCAU
ZHANG Lan 张兰	2020	2023	Ecolinguistics, linguistic landsenses	SCAU

Notes (1) Students are listed chronologically by enrollment year, then alphabetically by surname within the same year

(2) * LONG Minghui and XIONG Xiyuan were primarily supervised by Professor TAN Zaixi at the Hong Kong Baptist University, and Professor Huang Guowen served as the back-up supervisor

2. Students who studied/are studying in the PhD programs of Systemic Functional Linguistics or Applied Linguistics at SYSU and City University of Macau (CityU) under the supervision of Professor Huang Guowen

Name	Year of admission	Research area	University
XU Yi 许伊	2007	SFL, text analysis	SYSU
WENG Jinghua 翁靖华	2008	AL, reading strategies	SYSU
ZHOU Jinying 周晋英	2009	SFL, lexicogrammar	SYSU
LIANG Shuwen 梁淑雯	2009	SFL	SYSU
Mohammad Al TOWAIM	2011	AL, language testing	SYSU
SHANG Yanyan 尚延延	2013	TS	SYSU
QIAO Yanru 乔彦茹	2016	SFL, text analysis	SYSU

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Name	Year of admission	Research area	University
CHEN Sihui 陈思卉	2023	AL, textbook development	CityU
LI Jie 李洁	2023	AL, linguistic landscape	CityU
LI Shaoting 李劭婷	2023	AL, textbook evaluation	CityU
ZHANG Zhenzhen 张珍真	2023	AL, text analysis	CityU
KANG Zhiyang 康之洋	2024	AL, textbook analysis	CityU
YANG Bingkun 杨炳坤	2024	AL, discourse analysis	CityU
YANG Ningwei 杨宁伟	2024	AL, translation studies	CityU

3. Researchers who completed their Ph.D. degrees and then worked as post-doctoral fellows under the supervision of Professor Huang Guowen at Sun Yat-sen University

Name	University awarding the degree	Research area	Year of collaboration
YANG Caiying 杨才英	Shandong University	SFL, interpersonal function	2008–2010
LIU Chengyu 刘承宇	Xiamen University	SFL, code-switching	2008–2011
XIN Zhiying 辛志英	Xiamen University	SFL, language as social semiotic	2009–2011
PAN Hanting* 潘韩婷	University of Macau	TS	2015–2018

* Dr. Pan Hanting worked with Professor Huang at the initial stage of her research at Sun Yat-sen University and then worked with another professor after Professor Huang moved to SCAU

4. Visiting Ph.D. student under the supervision of Professor Huang Guowen at Sun Yat-sen University

Name	University awarding the degree	Research area	Year of collaboration
XIN Zhiying 辛志英	Xiamen University	SFL	2008–2009

5. MA and MTI students under the supervision of Professor Huang Guowen at Sun Yat-sen University and South China Agricultural University

(1) MA and MTI students at the School of Foreign Languages and the School of International Studies, SYSU

1997:
ZHENG Xiaodong (郑小冬)
1998:
LI Yan (李艳)
1999:
KAN Zhehua (阚哲华)
2000:
QI Xi (齐曦)
2001:
CHEN Shuiling (陈水玲)
2002:
JIAN Ge (剑歌), JIN Xiaohui (金晓晖), ZHENG Shaoen (郑少恩)
2003:
PAN Xiaoyan (潘小燕), TAN Weiqing (谭伟清)
2004:
CHEN Jiansheng (陈建生), HU Wenwen (胡文雯)
2005:
CHEN Xiaozong (陈孝宗), FU Yao (符瑶), JIANG Yonghong (江永红), LI Manliang (李满亮), TENG Chen (滕琛), XIANG Boyang (向波阳), YAO Yinyan (姚银燕)
2006:
LIAO Chuyan (廖楚燕)
2007: (with members of the supervisory committee for master's dissertation)
CHEN Haiyan (陈海燕), DENG Liping (邓利萍), GUO Li (郭莉), HOU Ruijing (厚瑞婧), HUANG Minjuan (黄敏娟) HUANG Shuping (黄淑萍), HUANG Xue'e (黄雪娥), LI Qiaolian (李巧莲), LI Qiong (李琼), LI Xiaoying (李小英), TAN Lin (谭琳), WU Fanghong (伍芳红), WU Zhuodan (吴卓丹), ZHONG Wen (钟雯), ZHOU Qiang (周强), ZHOU Yingshao (周影韶)
2008: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)
CHEN Ying (陈莹), DAI Shunmei (戴顺梅), HAN Ying (韩颖), HUANG Weixuan (黄蔚璇), JING Xiaofang (景小芳), LI Hui (李晖), LIANG Jiehong (梁洁红), MIAO Qing (苗青), SHI Peng (石蓬), WANG Fang (王芳), WU Guoxiang (吴国向), XIAO Lei (肖蕾), XIE Li (谢丽), YANG Yingli (杨颖荔), YE Ruijuan (叶瑞娟), YI Yong (易勇), YU Guofang (于国芳), ZHENG Huaijie (郑怀洁), ZHOU Xiao'e (周肖儿)
2009: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

GUO Man (郭曼), HU Yu (胡瑜), HUANG Xugang (黄绪钢), LIU Ming (刘明), TANG Wenshao (汤文绍), WANG Song (王松), WU Jie (吴洁), XIAO Sishi (肖思诗), YAN Hongzi (闫宏兹), YU Weiqiong (余伟琼), ZHOU Hanqi (周涵琪)

2010: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

CHEN Shaoxin (陈绍新), CHEN Yuexia (陈月霞), DIAO Tingting (刁婷婷), HUA Haiyan (华海燕), LIU Xiaomei (刘小梅), HE Jianmin (何健敏), LIAO Xuan (廖璇), LIU Li (刘丽), QI Shuqin (漆舒琴), WANG Liya (王沥涯), WEN Weiqiong (温伟强), CAI Shanni (蔡珊妮), FU Zhihuan (付志环), HONG Dan (洪丹), PAN Shourong (潘孝荣), WANG Xiaomin (王晓敏), WANG Zhihui (王志慧), WU Yafei (吴雅菲), XIAO Zhaowei (肖肇威), XU Chaoli (许超丽), ZHOU Ying (周颖)

2011: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

CHEN Wenchao (陈文超), HE Xiaolin (何晓琳), HE Hongbing (贺江兵), HU Ying (胡英), HUA Yi (华毅), HUANG Fang (黄芳), LAI Haiyan (赖海燕), LI Enyao (李恩耀), LI Jianwei (栗建伟), LIANG Shanshan (梁珊珊), LIANG Yuhang (梁宇航), LIU Shuxin (刘姝昕), LIU Xun (刘珣), TIAN Fei (田菲), WANG Jue (王珏),WANG Xuan (王璇), XIA Jingping (夏锦萍), YE Lu (叶露), ZHOU Jiajia (周佳佳)

2012: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

CHANG Jie (常婕), CHEN Liru (陈丽如), GONG Die (龚叠), GUO Yi (郭怡), HE Ziyan (何梓燕), JIA Xiaodan (贾晓丹), WANG Yizi (王怡子), YANG Hanjie (杨汉杰), ZHANG Jing (张婧), ZHANG Yanan (张亚楠), ZHENG Yajing (郑雅婧), ZHONG Minjun (钟敏珺)

2013:(with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

CAI Xiaman (蔡夏曼), CHEN Jiahui (陈家慧), HUANG Yishu (刘奕舒), LIU Quanying (刘全颖), MA Yingxin (马颖新), MIN Jie (闵婕), SHAO Xiaonan (邵晓楠), WANG Zhongliang (王仲良), WU Wenyan (吴文燕)

2014: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

CHEN Shujun (陈淑君), GAO Ge (高歌), HU Xiaochan (胡晓婵), LIANG Gaorong (梁高荣), TANG Biaofeng (汤彪凤), WANG Le (王乐), ZHAO Mengmeng (赵萌萌)

2015: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

GAO Chuanlong (高传龙), LAN Yuhui (蓝育惠), LI Jia (李佳), LIANG Wenjie (梁文洁), QIU Huanhuan (邱欢欢), PENG Pengyan (彭鹏燕), SUN Caihong (孙彩红), TIAN Shaoping (田邵平), WANG Dingjia (王汀葭), XU Shuting (许姝婷), ZHU Hua (朱婳)

2016: (with members of the Supervisory Committee for Master's dissertation)

GUO Yueqing (郭月晴), HE Liangwei (何良伟), HE Yankee(何琰),LI Chen (李臣), LI Yaping (李亚萍), LIU Jiao (刘娇), MAO Jiaxin (毛嘉欣), MO Hongru (莫鸿儒), QIAO Yanru (乔彦茹), MU Xiaolu (穆小路), WEN Xing (文杏)

(2) MTI students at the School of Foreign Languages, SCAU

2018:
LI Dongwei (李东卫), XIAO Chunmei (肖春媚)
2019:
LING Guihua (凌桂花), XU Jiayun (许嘉芸), XU Yashi (徐雅诗), ZHANG Yihao (张毅豪), ZHENG Dan (郑丹)
2020:
LIN Xue (林雪), WU Yingxin (伍颖欣), XIA Tingfen (夏婷芬), ZHUANG Ruhui (庄茹慧),
2021:
WEN Weijie (文伟杰), XIE Jianxin (谢健欣)
2022:
DU Jiahui (杜嘉慧), OU Baoling (欧宝玲), WANG Junyao (王君瑶), WANG Peilin (王培霖), XIE Kaijie (谢开杰)
2023:
LIANG Minqin (梁敏卿), YANG Jiachao (杨嘉超)

6. BA students supervised by Professor Huang Guowen at the School of Foreign Languages and the School of International Studies, SYSU include the following:

2001: MA Da (马达); 2002: LIN Luwei (林露薇); 2003: CHEN Xiaoyan (陈晓燕), FU Yao (符瑶); 2004: CHEN Yumin (陈瑜敏), LIAO Chuyan (廖楚燕); 2006: LUO Jianfeng (罗剑锋), WANG Yong (汪勇), YAO Min (姚敏); 2007: CAI Jiali (蔡佳丽), FAN Surong (范苏蓉), FAN Mengning (樊梦宁), QIU Yanni (丘苑妮), ZHU Minhua (李旻桦); 2008: LIANG Lina (梁丽娜), WANG Wen (王雯), XU Chaoli (许超丽), XU Yiying (徐毅荧); 2009: CAI Menghong (蔡梦虹), CAI Xiaochun (蔡孝纯), HAN Xiao (韩霄); 2010: CAI Jiaji (蔡家吉), WEI Yu (韦宇); 2011: LIAO Yunfei (廖韵斐), WU Wenyan (吴文燕); 2012: CHEN Yutong (陈雨童), TAN Xin (谭欣); 2013: HE Huizhen (何慧贞), LUO Zhenjing (罗阵靖); 2014: HE Liangwei (何良伟), ZHUANG Chulin (庄楚林); 2015: HUANG Yingtong (黄影彤), TANG Chushan (汤楚珊).

7. Visiting scholars under the supervision of Professor Huang Guowen at Sun Yat-sen University

1997–1998	XIONG Kun (熊锟, 河南师范学院)
1998–1999	WANG Yunyan (王云燕, 楚雄师范学院)
1998–1999	TAO Yang (陶炀, 辽宁师范大学)
1999–2000	WANG Tianming (王天明, 广东技术师范学院)
2000–2001	ZOU Dongqi (邹东旗, 广东技术师范学院)

2002–2003	XIAO Jiayan (肖家燕, 襄樊学院)
2002–2003	HUANG Xianfang (黄宪芳, 广东经济干部管理学院)
2006 (Feb.–July)	QIN Xiaoyi (秦小怡, 海南师范大学)
2006 (Feb.–July)	FENG Guibing (冯桂冰, 广州中医药大学)
2006–2007	YANG Jian (杨健, 海南师范大学)
2007 (Mar.–July)	LING Zhenghua (凌征华, 江西理工大学)
2007–2008	WANG Fulan (王馥兰, 吉首大学)
	ZHI Jufang (支菊芳, 南昌大学)
	DU Guojuan (杜国鹃, 江西师范大学)
	CUI Xuexin (崔学新, 湖州师范学院)
	CHEN Caifen (陈彩芬, 东华理工大学)
	XIA Hong (夏虹, 广东技术师范学院)
2008–2009	LI Weiqing (李委清, 东华理工大学)
	LI Haoping (李昊平, 天津外国语学院)
2009–2010	XIE Fen (谢芬,韶关学院)
	JIANG Mingfang (江茗芳, 韶关学院)
	WANG Jiali (王佳莉, 四川师范大学)
	PENG Yaolan (彭耀兰, 玉林师范学院)
	ZHAO Yueping (赵玥萍, 南昌航空大学)
2010–2011	LIN Yaoqun (林耀群,广东工业大学)
	GUI Yongxia (桂永霞, 广东女子职业技术学院)
	YANG Xiaohua (阳小华, 五邑大学)
	WANG Wenqiu (汪文秋, 三峡大学)
	HU Honghui (胡红辉, 广东商学院)
	KANG Leiming (康雷鸣, 合肥工业大学)
	WANG Zelong (王泽龙, 鞍山师范学院)
2011–2012	WU Caixia (吴彩霞, 肇庆学院)
	HU Wenwen (胡文雯,广州中医药大学)
	HUANG Jin (黄谨, 梧州学院)
2012–2013	SI Jitao (司继涛, 钦州学院)
	WU Hong (吴虹, 广西大学)
	JI Chun (纪春, 海南职业技术学院)
	ZHENG Yaofei (郑瑶菲, 广东药学院)
2013 (Mar. –Jun.)	YU Jie (俞婕, 江西理工大学)

2013–2014	HUANG Huixian (黄惠娴, 肇庆学院)
	DING Ling (丁聆, 成都理工大学)
	WANG Genlian (王根莲,浙江越秀外国语学院)
	LIU Shaoying (刘少英, 平顶山学院)
	ZHU Yanmin (朱艳敏, 增城学院)
	YANG Yang (杨洋, 玉林师范学院)
	ZHANG Lingli (张伶俐, 广东商学院)
	WEN Xingyuan (闻兴媛, 广东警官学院)
	WANG Hui (王惠, 南海东软信息技术职业学院)
	ZHANG Xiaolan (张小兰, 广东培正学院)

	LI Qing (黎晴, 韶关学院)
	ZHANG Lin (张琳, 兰州城市学院)
2014–2015	LI Jie (李捷, 仲恺农业工程学院)
	PAN Wenhan (潘文晗, 广州商学院)
	HAN Ying (韩颖, 广州医科大学)
	CAO Guangtao (曹广涛, 韶关学院)
	YE Ruijuan (叶瑞娟, 广东药学院)
	FENG Wenlin (冯文林, 南方医科大学)
	YI Yong (易勇, 广州科技贸易职业学院)
	YANG Yong (杨勇, 广东白云学院)
	XIE Miaoying (谢妙英, 培正商学院)
2015–2016	JING Xiaofang (景小芳, 广州现代信息工程职业技术学院)
	CHEN Qian (陈倩, 广东技术师范学院)

Appendix II
List of Publications by Professor Huang Guowen

A: Monographs/专著

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2. 黄国文、肖俊洪,《英语复合句——从句子到语篇》。厦门:厦门大学出版社, 1996。
3. 黄国文,《英语语言问题研究》。广州:中山大学出版社, 1999。
4. 黄国文,《语篇分析的理论与实践》。上海:上海外语教育出版社, 2001。
5. 黄国文, Enhanced Theme in English: Its Structures and Functions. 太原:山西教育出版社, 2003。
6. 黄国文,《翻译研究的语言学探索》。上海:上海外语教育出版社, 2006。
7. 黄国文、葛达西,《功能语篇分析》。上海:上海外语教育出版社, 2006。
8. 黄国文、何伟、廖楚燕等《系统功能语法入门:加的夫模式》。北京:北京大学出版社, 2008。
9. 黄国文、辛志英,《什么是功能语法》。上海:上海外语教育出版社, 2014。
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14. 黄国文,《黄国文自选集》。广州:中山大学出版社, 2024。
15. Huang Guowen, Linguistic Explorations in Translation Studies—Analyses of English Translations of Ancient Chinese Poems and Lyrics (translation of《翻译研究的语言学探索》,by Wang Bo and Ma Yuanyi). Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
16. 赵蕊华、黄国文《生态语言学100　核心概念与关键术语》。北京:清华大学出版社, 2025。
17. 黄国文、辛志英、梁雅梦《系统功能语言学史》北京:外语教学与研究出版社, 2026。

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C. Chang and H. Yu (eds.), *Explorations in Systemic Functional Linguistics*, The M.A.K. Halliday Library Functional Linguistics Series,
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3. 黄国文、肖俊洪　编《大中学生简明英语语法词典》。广州:广东教育出版社, 1999。
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5. 黄国文、王宗炎 编,*Discourse and Language Functions.* 北京:外语教学与研究出版社, 2002。
6. 黄国文 编,《功能语言学与语篇分析》(专号)(广东外语艺术职业学院《外语艺术教育研究》2004年第3期特邀主编)。
7. 黄国文 编,《功能语言学与语言研究》(专号)(广东外语艺术职业学院《外语艺术教育研究》2005年第3期特邀主编)。
8. 黄国文、常晨光、丁建新编,《功能语言学的理论与应用》。北京:高等教育出版社, 2005。
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10. 黄国文　编,《语篇分析研究》(专辑)(四川外语学院《英语研究》2006年第4期特邀主编)。
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14. 黄国文　编,《功能语言学与语篇分析研究》(第2辑)。北京:高等教育出版社, 2010。
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16. 黄国文、常晨光　编,《功能语言学年度评论》(第2卷)。北京:高等教育出版社, 2010。
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18. 黄国文、辛志英　　编,《功能语言学通论》。北京:外语教学与研究出版社, 2011。

19. 黄国文、常晨光　编,《功能语言学年度评论》(第3卷)。北京:高等教育出版社, 2011。
20. 黄国文、常晨光、廖海青　编,《系统功能语言学研究群言集》(第二辑)。北京:高等教育出版社, 2011。
21. 黄国文　编,《功能语言学与语篇分析研究》(第3辑)。北京:高等教育出版社, 2011。
22. 黄国文　编,《功能语言学与语篇分析研究》(第4辑)。北京:高等教育出版社, 2012。
23. 黄国文、辛志英　编,《系统功能语言学研究现状和发展趋势》。北京:外语教学与研究出版社, 2012。
24. 黄国文　编,《功能语言学与语篇分析研究》(第5辑)(主编)北京:高等教育出版社, 2013。
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27. 黄国文、常晨光　编,《功能语言学年度评论》(第5卷)。北京:高等教育出版社, 2014。
28. 黄国文、王宾、许东黎　编,《从这里走向世界——中山大学翻译学院建院10周年回眸》,中山大学出版社, 2015。
29. 黄国文、王宾、许东黎　编,《岁月湖畔——中山大学翻院人的回忆》,中山大学出版社, 2015。
30. Alexandra Assis Rosa and Huang Guowen. *Journal of World Languages*, Vol.3, No. 1, 2016. Special Issue: East and West Encounters: Translation across Time. (Routledge)
31. 黄国文、陈新仁、冉永平、李捷 编,《语用人生——何自然教授八十华诞庆贺文集》,高等教育出版社, 2016。
32. 黄国文　编,《功能语言学与语篇分析研究》(第6辑)(主编)北京:高等教育出版社, 2017。
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34. 黄国文　编,《功能语言学与语篇分析研究》(第7辑)(主编)北京:高等教育出版社, 2019。
35. G. Tucker, Guowen Huang, L. Fontaine & E. McDonald. *Approaches to Systemic Functional Grammar: Convergence and Divergence*. Sheffield: Equinox, 2020.

C: Textbooks/教材

1. 黄国文、葛达西、张美芳,《英语学术论文写作》。重庆:重庆大学出版社,2014。
2. 黄国文、葛达西,《英语学位论文写作教程》。北京:高等教育出版社,　2008。(“普通高等教育‘十一五’国家级规划教材”)。
3. 黄国文 编,《MTI毕业论文写作指南》北京:外语教学与研究出版社, 2012。
4. 黄国文、王宾、林裕音　编,《英语专业学位论文写作手册》。上海:上海外语教育出版社, 2012。(“普通高等教育‘十一五’国家级规划教材”)

5. 王守仁、黄国文 (总主编),《新时代明德大学英语》(综合教程)(1-3册),高等教育出版社, 2021-2022。
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1. As if从句的时态形式。《上海外语教学》1979(4), pp. 28–31。
2. 也谈谈it is/was…that/who…结构。《中小学外语教学》1980(12), pp. 33–34。
3. insist后面的宾语从句中谓语动词该用什么形式?《中小学外语教学》1981(5), pp. 22–23。
4. 略谈英语的静态动词和动态动词。《现代外语》1981(4), pp. 16–19。(王湛法、黄国文)
5. As if 和 as though。《教学研究》(洛外学报)1982(4), pp. 32–33。
6. 交际教学语法。《现代外语》1982(4), pp. 1–7。(何恩光、杨殿蓉、黄国文)
7. 评《英语结构》。《现代外语》1982(4), pp. 53–57。
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10. 关于It is three years since he lived there表达的意义问题。《英语辅导》1983(6), pp. 17–19。
11. 英语状语从句的位置。《现代外语》1984(1), pp. 24–30,17。
12. 英语答问。《现代外语》1984(1), p.71。
13. 英语答问。《现代外语》1984(2), pp. 72–73。
14. 英语状语从句的若干问题。《现代外语》1984(3), pp. 27–34。
15. 英语被动结构选择的若干问题。《外国语》1985(2), pp. 41–47。(徐盛桓、黄国文)
16. 中国英语教学界规模空前的盛会。《外语教学与研究》1985(4), pp. 49–50。
17. 著名语言学家斯瓦特维克教授来华讲学。《外语界》,1985(4), pp. 49–50。
18. 读《新编英语语法概要》。《现代外语》1986(2), pp. 52–57。
19. 句型转换的意义分析。《教学研究》1986(2), pp. 32–34。
20. 英语限制性与非限制性状语从句。《现代外语》1987(1), pp. 35–40。
21. 论英语的名词性从句(上)。《教学研究》1987(1), pp. 22–30。
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25. 语言学系列教材新书预告。《现代外语》1987(4), p. 71。
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30. 论英语语法的意义和种类。《解放军外国语学院学报》1991(6), pp. 17–22。

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36. Identifying the matrix language in Cantonese/English code-switching: A two-level analysis. *Newcastle University Studies in Language and Speech*, Series A, 1994, No. 6, pp. 1–37. (Huang Guowen, Lesley Milroy and Li Wei)
37. The structure of code-switching: An analytical framework for the study of alternational and insertional code-switching with Cantonese/English examples. *Newcastle University Studies in Language and Speech*, Series A, 1994, No. 7, pp. 1–56. (Huang Guowen, Lesley Milroy and Li Wei)
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